Hidden Kingdom

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28530699.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Catra/OC (past), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Canon until 3.3 'Once upon a time in the Waste', Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, 12 years after the start of the show, Bored Adora, Adora is adrift in a world that has grown up and left her behind, can't put much more or the cat (wink) will be out of the bag.

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Part 1 of Hidden Kingdom

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by limey_limey

Summary

Adora was She-ra and She-ra was a weapon; where does that leave her in a world at peace? 12 years after joining the Rebellion, 10 after she last saw Catra and 7 since the Horde revolted and destroyed themselves peace fills Etheria. The world has been healed and the people around her are building families while she simply feels lost.

Something flying over the skies of the abandoned Crimson Waste calls the Princess Alliance back into action and Adora could not be more relieved to investigate. Nothing could prepare her for what she finds there.

COMPLETE

Notes

My contribution to both the 'What if Catra stayed in the Crimson Waste' and 'What happened to the Magicats' head canons.
We are 12 years from the start of the show and everybody has accomplished a lot, some more than others.

This is planned and I will be writing weekly alongside Wild.

Chapter 1

Adora was lost. Not physically; she was in her room in Brightmoon, her's now for the last twelve years. That was part of the problem. She paced agitatedly around the airy space and out to the balcony, fingers drumming discordantly on her thigh, coming to a stop at the railing. Her hands rested on the balustrade and started to drum as she peered out over the landscape. All of the old scars left on the Whispering Woods had long since faded, grown over by the passing of time. It was the same with the people out there living their lives, a gradual process or repair and reconciliation with their past and present. She strained her eyes, looking beyond the woods and trying to catch a glimpse of a past she had left behind but could not let go of. The Fright Zone had once poisoned the sky on that horizon, turning blue to orange and angry grey; silhouetted towers reaching their gnarled fingers into the sky. Gone now.

The problem was, peace was, well, peaceful. Days no longer filled with fighting and scrambling to stay alive. That had ended with the destruction of the Fright Zone from the most unexpected quarter. Seven years on and no-one was any the wiser as to what prompted the Horde to rise up against their leader and raise the Fright Zone to the ground. Nor did they know where the troops had disappeared to, for disappear they had down to a man. It was as though the Horde had never been. Shadow Weaver, still a 'captive' of Brightmoon, the only proof that it ever was.

In the intervening years they had searched the wreckage, finding no evidence of bodies in the rubble. Whatever had happened it appeared as though the soldiers had somewhere to run to. The Black Garnet was also missing. Though the Princess Alliance had cast their net wide, hunted for survivors, wanting somebody to blame for all the ills of a war fought over generations, they had been left with nothing. Time had marched on, looking for lost enemies put aside in favour of rebuilding a world no longer fighting against itself.

That had been the work of years, no quick fixes to put together what decades had torn asunder. The princesses had returned to their lands, bringing back their scattered peoples and channelling there magic into building a better world. There were still the abandoned places, inhospitable and abandoned; the Crimson Waste (which now lay as desolate and abandoned as the Fright Zone), Beast Island (though, on one of a very few missions to look at it's viability for life, the discovery of King Micah had proved yet one more joy to add to their victory) but little else. Even that hell hole where she had been raised had been cleared and rebuilt with a thriving city carved out of shining steel and under the purview of Glimmer as Queen's Regent to the place.

Now though, it had been years since there was anything left to do but govern and monitor. No more mountains to climb or monsters to slay and Adora didn't have a place here. She had watched, filled with brimming joy, as her friends had grown up alongside her. First there had been Mermista, finally succumbing to Sea Hawk's quirky charms and wedding in the first royal wedding in a generation. The whole of Etheria had celebrated and Adora had been there, resplendent as She-ra, stood with the happy couple at the isle. There was a joyful small boy that had been born not long after who was every bit his mother's son.

Close on their heels had come Glimmer and Bow. She had had front row seats to the shy dance of their courtship as they moved from kids running to keep up with a war, to grown ups who worked side by side to rebuild. It had taken them longer than she had expected, both of them afraid about what would happen if they crossed a line. But the heart wants what it wants and soon she had been standing up with her friends, this time as just Adora, as they too exchanged vows of love. She was still waiting to hear the pitter patter of tiny sparkly feet along the hallways of Brightmoon though. She knew one day it would come.

Netossa and Spinerella had finally taken their leave and returned to their own home, settling in and taking in any number of war orphans, choosing to foster those who had no home rather than bringing new life into the world. Adora thought that, were she

ever to find her ‘one’, she would like to do the same. Offer children like her a place to be happy and learn to be loved. It was a distance dream. Unlike her friends, Adora was single and lost. She was not the only single one, Perfuma had dedicated herself to rejuvenating the land all over the world which was still ongoing in the places that had been the most poisoned, leaving her little time to craft a family and Frosta was still so young, she was enjoying her freedom. Yet she felt like the only one who didn’t really have a place, She-ra was a weapon and those fighting days were gone.

Adora had tried to find her puzzle piece, she was a woman nearing thirty and no blushing virgin, after all. She had dated a few of the palace guards, had a long affair with a noble woman from the Kingdom of Snows - distance and lack of effort had made it fizzle out. Truthfully that had happened with most of her relationships, she just couldn’t motivate herself to put the effort in. She was still looking for wrongs to right and people to help, dating and settling down didn’t fill that gaping void inside herself where She-ra sat and screamed for action.

Her blue eyes continued to stare at the nothing in the distance, one hand moving to touch the sword turned braced on her forearm, caressing it like an old friend. Wanting it to be an anchor.

But she was adrift.

She had been in the library when she received the call on her tracker pad. Curled up into one of the big, plush chairs in an almost hidden alcove, a book of Etherian history on her lap, she was startled at the sudden beeping noise. Reading about the history of the world that she had grown up in but had little knowledge of, was one of the things that she enjoyed to pass the time. She had almost exhausted the stocks of Brightmoon, sometimes straying to Selineas and the Kingdom of Snows to raid their stacks. It had taken a long time but she had eventually acclimatised to the comforts of the castle, and now embraced it, snuggling into the soft depths with her legs drawn up beneath her

and the book resting on the chair arm as she engrossed herself in thousands of years of history.

She had spent some time with Lance and George, looking for information on the First Ones, but found that just made her angry and frustrated. Sometimes the anger was directed at Shadow Weaver and Hordak for taking her away from her people, others it was at her people for how they had used Etheria. The revelations that Mara's hologram and the ship itself had given to her still made her shudder, though none of it had come to pass. She had grown increasingly frustrated at Light Hope over the years, realising from the books in the hidden library that she had kept so much from her during her training at the beginning of her time as She-ra. She had stopped visiting the Crystal Castle many years before after reading one tome in particular.

Todays book was one that she had found in a dusty and forgotten part of Frosta's library. The younger princess was always pleased to see her when she would take Swift Wind for a visit. The sight of the looming ice castle was always breathtaking and spending time among the ice princesses people was fascinating, a far cry from their warmer climate counterparts. The library there was based in a large warren of catacombs under the castle, able to be kept at a warmer temperature than the rest of the palace, meaning that the oldest of the books were preserved. Over the last decade she had worked her way through there. On the day that she picked up this book, she had felt drawn to go deeper into the more forgotten areas of the miles of tunnels. It had been dark and grimy, the books looking like they hadn't been touched in generations.

She had run her fingers down the regimented spines, standing in the dark like soldiers awaiting commands, her hand coming away smeared with dusty neglect. It had been hard to make out the titles of the books in the dim light, but a few had caught her eye. One in particular, it's gold binding managing to catch what little light there was drew her hand. It lay in front of her now, as she pawed over the information that she had been curious about since she was a child, laying bare the details of a dead civilisation that

had been all but forgotten. Forgotten if not for one, young, angry girl all alone in the Fright Zone.

The page open in front of her showed a detailed diagram of some of the technology that they had built. For a society that had died off just after the First Ones departed, they had been incredibly advanced. Adora wondered if they had worked with her people or fought against their plunder of Etheria's magic. It made her feel sick to the stomach to consider that, perhaps, her people were the reason for their extinction.

She was so fixed on the information on the page that when the alarm of the tracker pad had sounded she had almost jumped out of her skin, sending the book tumbling to the ground and releasing a few pages across the floor, detached from their brittle spine. Scrambling to her feet she had carefully scooped the pages up, reverently finding where they belonged inside and slipping them in, a picture of a large eared child, looking out with wide eyes caught her attention and made her heart squeeze before she closed the book on it and held the tome to her chest. She would have to take another trip out to Bow's dads to get help to repair the damage.

Hearing the shrill chirp for the second time as it rang out trough the empty library, she reached out to answer the call, the screen suddenly filled with Glimmer's pinched, worried face. Adora felt a shover of anticipation crawl up her spine, this was clearly not a social call.

"Adora, thank goodness you picked up. We were worried you were off spelunking again or something." Glimmer's words came out in a rush, and as Adora looked more closely at the screen, she could make out other people moving in the background of what was clearly the former war room.

"Glimmer, what's going on?" She started to move out of the library and down the hallway on the familiar rout to the war room.

"I've called the Alliance together, there's been activity in the Waste." Her words were curt, commanding in a way she had learned over the years.

"I'll be right there." The pad went dark and she marched to the meeting, on the other Sid of the castle.

By the time Adora pushed open the doors, sending a nod to each often guards that flanked it, everybody else was already seated at the table in their familiar positions. It warmed her to look at the head and see Angella flanked by Micah, something she could never have imagined as a teen when she had made the error of sitting in his chair during her very first briefing. Spinerella and Netossa sat as they always did, with chairs pulled close so that they were always touching, facing the royal couple. Arrayed around were the others, all looking much as they ever had.

Perfuma had changed the least, still willowy and etherial, clothes more green than pink these days. Sea Hawk had grown a beard, equally as impressive as his moustache had always been and dressed more like a king than a pirate these days while Mermista had got more beautiful over the years, still wearing her teal coloured clothes, softened a little by motherhood. Frosta had surprised them all with a sudden growth spurt when she had been sixteen, going from Glimmer's little shadow to a statuesque woman who towered over everyone save Angella, she grinned over at Adora showing that the spunky little girl was still tucked away inside the twenty-something. Adora sat and smiled over at Bow and Glimmer, the former with his own cropped beard and hair tied in a bun, the latter looking more like her mother with every passing year. Just shorter. Which she still griped about. Adora glanced down at her own being pants and white top, again feeling a pang at the notion that she was still exactly where she had been a decade ago. She was brought back to the moment when Angella's cut glass voice began the meeting.

"Thank you all for leaving your kingdoms. We have received intelligence from the villages that neighbour the Crimson Waste of some troubling activity. Glimmer, if you would."

Glimmer took the stage, bringing up the holographic display at the centre of the table, showing the edges of the Crimson Waste, the vantage point clearly from a village. The camera had been angled to look as deeply into the desert as possible, where usually it would monitor the border. These cameras had been one of the post war measures designed to stop the looting that they had anticipated at the start of peace from rampaging bands of ex-Horde. The danger had never materialised but the monitoring technology had stayed. On first glance it was just a static image of sand. They all knew there was more so watched attentively as seconds ticked by until, almost as though materialising from the air, a black figure began to move across the sky. It could have been mistaken for a bird at this distance if not for the fact that the wings never moved and that it left a feint trail in the air. It hovered and then dived towards the ground before pulling up and climbing fast. It stopped and pivoted back to the height as which it started, catching the sun as it moved, which gleamed off of what could only be metal, temporarily dazzling the camera, and the watchers. When the camera cleared of the flare, it was gone.

"As you can see, a flying machine has been seen hovering somewhere close to the centre of the waste. It is hard to tell how large it is from this angle, though our best guess is that it is at least as large as a skiff, if not larger. This is the only time it has been caught on camera but we have reports of similar sightings from four different villages that border the area." She brought up a map of the area and highlighted the villages which had reported the sightings.

"Yeah, ok, but, like, haven't they sent scouts in to take a look or whatever?" Mermista's bored tones rolled through the room, voicing what they were all thinking.

"In fact they all have and there is nothing out there. They have come at it from different angles and saw no sign of life of any kind, certainly not a large, metal, flying machine." Glimmer waited for more questions.

“So what are we doing?” Frosta had a brow cocked and her arms crossed over her chest.

Glimmer sat down again and reached over for Bow’s hand, interlacing their fingers, Adora felt her eyes drawn down to them as a frown tugged at her lips. She almost missed when Angella started to speak again, wrapped up in the melancholy that had recently been bringing her down.

“Clearly this needs to be further investigated. We have decided that sending the Princess Alliance is our best option here. What the locals can’t detect we can use main to explore.” Angella cut her eyes towards her daughter who had the grace to look bashful and colour with a pretty blush at her mothers smile. “Not to mention that if you’re all as antsy as my daughter, I am sure a little mission will air out all the cobwebs.” There was a ripple of laughter around the table and several nodded heads.

“We understand that you all have many more affairs to get in order before a mission than you did when you were younger, so we would ask that you be prepared in two days.” Micah’s voice still felt odd to hear at this table.

The meeting broke up soon after, with promises of rendezvousing at the Waste. Mermista and Sea Hawk would leave their son with Spinerella and Netossa, the older members of the Alliance electing to stay behind and act as communication relays and do any intelligence gathering as necessary. They had a brood of children to look after themselves. Soon they were all gone to organise their realms.

Adora ate a pleasant dinner with the royal family, long since adopted as another daughter of the house. They talked and traded nostalgic stories about the first time they went to the Crimson Waste. The Best Friend Squad, as Bow still insisted they call themselves, were able to share the more juicy details of their youthful adventures these days. No chance of Angella grounding them any more. The talk of going into a bar and meeting Huntara made Adora wonder what had ever happened to the Horde

deserter, they had thought that she would become a resource but after they had recovered the First Ones ship she had disappeared, or so it seemed.

That made her mind turn towards other people who had vanished over the years. It was a path she didn't want to go down. She excused herself after dinner, not feeling sociable enough to hand out with the others and made her way back to her room. As she walked, she couldn't stop herself from wondering what had happened to her old squad mates. Had Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio survived whatever had happened to the Fright Zone? She hoped so.

She reached her room and sat heavily on the edge of her bed, next to the book that she had dropped there earlier. He fingers itched as she tentatively opened the pages and pulled out the picture of a child that had caught her eye before. All the thoughts of times passed and people lost, she couldn't help but think of the person lost that had meant the most to her.

Catra hadn't been seen since she took her newly acquired gang and left Adora, standing alone, inside the old spaceship. She had untied her captive, thrown the sword at her feet in dismissal and walked away without a backward glance. The blond had expected to see her, taunting and full of bitterness, at the next clash with the Horde, and the next, and the next, but she never arrived. A year after that encounter and Adora had realised that Catra was gone. A deserter. And then the Horde was gone.

The child in the picture looked so much like Catra when she was a cub. Adora couldn't help but trace her fingers over the shaggy mane and giant ears in the image and think about a wide eyed child siting on her bed and crying, pressed into a blue blanket.

She closed the book again, picture safely ensconced between the covers and traced a long finger across the words embossed there; 'History of the Migicats'.

Chapter 2

The Crimson Waste was beautiful in its emptiness and ferocity. The sand stretched for miles in all directions, shimmering under the sun's heat as it bounced from grain to grain. The sparse cacti that popped up here and there looked like emeralds on a gold band. Gorse bushes also clung to the ridges and ravines. The red and yellows all around blending like a living fire as buzzards circled overhead, embers of the living earth.

Adora raised her hand to shield her eyes from the glare as she took it in. Was it always this beautiful? She thought back to when she was last here as a teen and realised that all she had seen then had been a difficult obstacle filled with harsh people that she had to overcome to achieve her goals. The war had raged and she had needed answers, blind and blinkered to anything else but proving her worthiness to carry the mantle of She-ra. Those intrusive thoughts still crawled under her skin sometimes, if she was still for too long, of whether she was worthy of still being the warrior princess - especially when there was little for her to do.

Sometimes, as she grew older and her responsibilities less, it felt as though her Adora-self was a cage that She-ra stalked inside, pacing and growling to be set free. There would be an itch under her skin and she would want to rip the bracer off, throw the sword, just to be free of it. Then the guilt would kick in, she knew the she only had the opportunities she did because she had been She-ra when she joined the Rebellion, her story would have been much different if she had arrived without her; to resent her now seemed churlish. But she wondered if she would be happier without her? It was easier to blame her discontent on the supernatural entity, otherwise the problem was with her.

Shaking off the dark thoughts that had cast a shadow over the heated sand, she turned to look at her team. It was like old times, each of them ready to take on an adventure and uncover secrets - maybe fight a bad guy or two. Blue eyes watched as Glimmer stomped her way over to Frosta, grabbing the younger woman by

the arm and pulling her down to eye level. It was comical to watch as Frosta had to stoop, which always made a frown crinkle Glimmer's face. She had been devastated when she realised she would always be the short one.

"Are you honestly wearing that?" Her voice held an edge, as it often did when she fell into her role as defect big sister to the other woman.

Frosta had arrived in a swirl of magic with one of the Mysticore mage's that had been assigned to each realm to enable quick transfer of the princesses when necessary. They had vanished as soon as they had disappeared, leaving behind a young woman decked out in a bandeau top and short shorts, stylish hiking boots with a hint of fur on the edge to fit her brand and a large brimmed hat to finish the ensemble. She looked like she was heading on a vacation more than hunting for possible danger. She looked down at herself, then back up to meet Glimmers eyes, quirking a cheeky eyebrow.

"What? I've put on sunscreen." Glimmer's face began to harden with annoyance. "Don't give me that look, how often do I get to go somewhere and get some sun? Let a girl live a little!"

"And what about when we encounter some dangerous menace? Can you fight in that?" Smirking now, folding her arms she thought that she had won this round.

"Then I'll ice blast them and dazzle them with my feminine wiles!" Like Adora the others had been eavesdropping on the conversation and Mermista let out a short bark of laughter as the others all tried to hide their smiles from the speechless glitter-bomb.

"Fine!" Glimmer threw her hands up in surrender. "Have it your way, but when you get stabbed in the stomach don't come crying to me."

“You’ve seen Bow, right?” Frosta was trying hard not to laugh outright in Glimmers face when the truth of the matter finally dawned on her and she blushed and stomped over to stand with her husband, who’s mid-drift was noticeable bare.

Adora felt warmth in her heart for these people who had been her family for so long. They were funny and ridiculous, loved and fought and bickered. There was a comfort in the familiar as they stood on the precipice of something new and potentially dangerous.

It felt just like old times.

They split into teams to cover the desert from every angle. They broke up the area and Glimmer deposited each group at their starting village before materialising back with her group. Over the years Bow had become a technological marvel, working tirelessly to improve their communications technology, meaning that there was little chance of them losing signal on their tracker pads this time round. They would alert each other where to meet if they found anything.

Adora was working with Mermista, while Sea Hawk was with Perfuma and Frosta and Bow and Glimmer stayed in their usual duo. Adora had shot Mermista a curious glance when she had sidled up beside her when they were pairing up, only to receive an evil smirk in return as Mermista lifted her chin in the direction of the mismatched group of three. Adora had to hold back a snort when she realised that Mermista was messing with everyone over there.

It wasn’t long before Glimmer had deposited them in the furthest village in a blast of sparkles and then whisking herself away. They wasted no time walking out onto the hot sand, and making for the depths of the Waste. Adora looked over at Mermista who still wore a smirk on her usually impassive face. Shen noticed Adora’s glance and scowled.

“What?”

“You know somebody’s going to die in this desert, right?” If Perfuma didn’t blow up a cacti, Sea Hawk would grate on one often other women until they threw him through a dune.

“Oh, I know.” Mermista let the mischief back into her voice. “I do love Sea Hawk but he would have already started singing. Let Perfuma see if she can zen her way through that.”

“And Frosta?” Adora knew that the odd rivalry between the water and plant princesses was friendly but it had lasted for over a decade.

“I just thought she’d be the most likely to be driven up the wall.”

“You’re a mean one, 'Mista.” The couple laughed before falling into companionable silence as they kept their eyes peeled for any signs of life.

Time drifted by in silence until Mermista’s voice broke it, almost drawing Adora to a standstill. “So, like, why’d you break up with Zildari? I thought you two were good together.”

It was strange to hear Mermista ask her about her personal life. She was usually the least likely to share her emotions, the picture of stoicism. Except she wasn’t, Mermista wore her bored, sarcastic persona like armour and they all knew it though none of them dared ever bring it up.

“We were, but with her wanting to stay close to her family and me wanting to stay in Brightmoon, it was never going to work. We had a good time together and then it was time for it to be over.” Even to her own ears Adora realised how detached that sound, as though they had a contract that ended and then they decided not to renew it.

“Adora, you were together for three years, wasn’t there anything worth holding on to?” Mermista might have always been exasperated with her husband and occasionally outraged, but they

had always shared passion. It was hard for her to understand that Adora, or all people, wouldn't feel that way about somebody she had been with for so long.

… Adora had met the trade envoy for the Kingdom of Snow's Fur Guild, four years ago, she had been twenty-five and convinced by herself, and all of the people around her who were settling down, that it was time for her to look for 'the one'. Adora wasn't sure she even believed in the concept herself, she didn't think she'd ever felt that rush that the others talked about. Well, maybe during the war, when she first joined the rebellion. But even that had fizzled out after a couple of years. And she wasn't sure that was the feeling that they were talking about. So, she had been surprised when the dark haired woman had caught her eye.

Adora had walked into the meeting room, it was a luxurious space further down the hall than the war room. Strangers had been milling about at the table of food that had been pushed to one side, chatting and laughing. Only one of the chairs at the table had been filled, the woman sprawled out with the chair pushed back so that she could lean and cross her legs at the ankles in a posture of complete languid ease. The plate on the table in front of her was bare and she already looked utterly bored.

Adora had felt a pull towards her at once, moving into the room, bypassing the food completely, to sit at the table beside the mystery woman. Closer she as able to take in the long, wild, chestnut hair that curled around her face and the slight hint of pointed ears that peeked out. Her eyes were large and so pale that the green almost looked yellow, the colour vibrant against her darkly tan skin. Adora was captivated by the woman and blushed scarlet when she realised that she was being appraised back with a quirked eyebrow and sardonic curve of the lips.

"Hi," she said with an embarrassed wave of her hand. Where was the woman who managed to flirt shamelessly with the palace guards now? She felt like a teenager with a crush. She knew that feeling well.

“Hi, I’m Zildari. I’m going to take a shot in the dark and assume you’re She-ra?” Adora’s face, alongside her superhuman alter ego were well known all across Etheria.

“It’s Adora, actually. I’m much more glowy when I’m She-ra.” This was better, she was starting to feel far less flustered. She could talk to girls.

“I don’t know, looks like you’re glowing quite a lot right now.” The voice was low and teasing with a hint of bite and Adora felt her blush flare up even more. Maybe she couldn’t talk to girls?

She was saved from further embarrassing herself when Queen Angella walked in and the meeting came to order. People took seats all around her and she caught a saucy wink thrown her way from the brunette who had straightedge herself in her chair. Had she slid her chair a little closer to Adora’s?

As the meeting went on, with various representatives of the kingdoms discussing how best to organise trade and set a fair system of pricing, Adora felt eyes on her more and more. When she chanced a glance to her right, she was not surprised to see this enigmatic woman gazing at her blatantly. She smiled hoping that nobody else was looking at them, and got another wink in response.

During a recess, where more refreshments were brought in, Adora found herself leaning in a corner with a small plate of sandwiches watching the people. She kind of wished that Glimmer was here, but she was working in the former Fright Zone for a few weeks. She was distracted by thoughts of her friend, so when a hand snaked around her bicep she almost dropped her plate. She scrambled to gab it out of the air, failing to save the sandwiched but at least avoiding the plate shattering on the floor and becoming the centre of attention.

“I guess that’s those reflexes that saved us all during the war,” the voice was teasing and very close to her ear.

“Um…yeah…I guess?”

“You’re not much of a talker, are you?” A finger moved to her chin, crossing so many boundaries that Adora found she didn’t mind, and turned her face to look at the other woman.

“Actually, I usually am.” And she usually was.

“Must be me then.” And it was, something about the chaotic and mischievous energy of this woman, as well as her looks, made Adora feel compelled to be near her.

“Must be.” She realised her blush was gone. She could flirt.

“You doing anything after this snoozfest ends?” Zildari didn’t lower her voice as she said it, gaining them some several disapproving looks that just made her let out a high pitched laugh. Adora shook her head, captivated. “I could use a tour guide, I’ve never been to Brightmoon before.”

It had been Zil’s first visit to Brightmoon but certainly not her last…

“We were never in love, Mermista. She’s beautiful and fun and neither of us made too many demands on each other. I liked being with her but not being with her hasn’t left me with a void or anything. Honestly I’m just as happy by myself.” She wasn’t, but telling any of her friends would lead to even more uncomfortable conversations.

“You know you can’t just keep screwing your way around the palace guards, right?” The accusation made her blush, everybody knew that she let off steam with the guards. Everybody knew it was just fun and none of the other women had ever tried to push for more than a one or two night stand. She might not be Etherian but she was only human.

“I’m not hurting anyone, we’re all adults.” Mermista was surprised by the edge to the blond’s voice and dropped it, silence falling between them again, not quite as comfortable this time.

That was the end of talking for a little while, a tension around them that as thick as the heat that enveloped their bodies. It was approaching noon, and they still had seen not sign of life other than the myriad of different cacti and the occasional small lizard skitter across their path. Something in the air felt wrong; Adora could feel a strange tingling under her skin, almost like a sunburn but she was lathered in sunscreen so she knew it couldn't be that. She looked over at Mermista who also seemed to be shifting uncomfortably in her own skin. Maybe it was just the midday heat getting to them both.

"How far before we reach this bar?" Mermista had never been to the Waste before so, with her limited experience, Adora got to be the guide.

"Honestly, I thought we would have hit it by now," it was a relief that the water princess had broken the silence. She held up her tracker pad and looked at the map that was following their movements. They were far in now and still nothing. She watched Mermista give a little shiver, strange in this heat. "Do you feel it to?"

Mermista looked at her strangely for a moment before noticing the constant twitch of the skin on the blond's forearms, revealed by her short sleeved t-shirt. "Yeah, it's weird. Feels like tiny bugs crawling all over me."

"That's it exactly. It wasn't like that last time, maybe it's because we've been using our magic longer now?" What other reason could their be?

They continued to puzzle over the strange, unnerving feeling when finally they crested a dune and ahead of them, a few hundred metres away, stood the cantina. The two women came to a stop and just stared for a moment. It was still a striking sight, the giant animal bones stretched taught with canvas looking like skin. The colourful flags hanging listlessly on top, looked far more faded than Adora remembered. In fact, the longer she looked, the more she started to notice differences about it.

Sand was piled up to one side, almost burying the back of the building in another dune. There seemed to be large tears in the canvas roof and some of the rib bones that gave it support had started to list precariously outwards, seeming to only be held upright by the toughness of the canvass.

"This it?" Mermista's voice came from her side and was softer than she had expected, as though she was worried to break the stillness.

"Yeah." Adora's voice was equally soft. Something felt very wrong here. At her side Mermista started to step forward, only to be stopped by Adora's outstretch arm and a shake of her head. "I think we should call the others. There's something wrong here, I can feel it. We don't want to be ambushed."

Mermista agreed and they used the tracker pad to alert the others to their location. While they waited for Glimmer to retrieve the other group and bring them to their location, the pair sat down in the sand to wait.

"Hey, isn't this where you got caught by that cat-girl during the war?" Mermista's drawl was curious.

"Oh, Catra? Yeah… yeah… well not exactly here, it was deeper in." She pointed vaguely off into the distance, uncomfortable at the sound of her childhood friend's name.

"How come you didn't end up back at the Horde then? She'd done it before, right?" Mermista hadn't had a lot of interaction with the Force Captain during the war and when she had vanished their had been no opportunity for future confrontations.

"Well, she did kidnap Glimmer and Bow. I don't know why she let me go. Glimmer and Bow managed to get away with the guide we had, but she caught me. Something happened out here and she'd managed to get a gang of mercenary goons and drugged me. When I woke up, I had no sword, so no She-ra, and I was bound and gagged to a pole and I could hear them celebrating in the

other room of the ship we'd found." When she thought back to that moment, she had been certain that she was a goner, that Catra was going to deliver her and the sword to Hordak, yet something else had happened. "Catra walked in a while later, she looked totally blank. She came up to me and crouched down, lifted my chin with the pommel of the sword and then just stared at me. I'd never seen her so focused or still before. I couldn't look away. Then, suddenly, she threw the sword at my feet, cut the ties with her claws and walked out. She never said a word or looked back. I still don't know why." And she'd never had a chance to ask, as Catra had seemingly vanished. Her and Scorpia aspirating into the air and never appearing among the Horde forces again, and then the war was over. The war was over, and Adora never knew what became of her childhood friend.

"Weird." Mermista had a gift for understatement.

The soft tinkling of bells caught their attention and they pulled themselves from their seated position as Glimmer and the four others appeared below them, between their vantage point and the dilapidated building. They made their way to join them and as a group they warily made their way to the entrance. Well, six of them moved warily while Sea Hawk looked positively overjoyed at the prospect of walking into a place that looked very much like one of his old, youthful port-side haunts. In fact, he was so excited that he drew in a breath, prepared to launch into a shanty, only to be stymied by Frosta's hand clamped over his mouth and Perfuma glaring daggers at him. Thank god there were no roses nearby or Sea Hawk would be barraged with thorns. Clearly the two other women had had quite enough of his singing.

Adora took the lead, invoking the power of the sword, feeling She-ra burst through and consume her form, leaving her taller and stronger but still strangely empty. She pushed back the cloth that covered the entrance and walked into the dingy interior, light cast inside in shafts through the tears in the roof. The place was unnervingly silent, save for the buzzing of flies. There was not a soul to be seen. It looked like there hadn't been for years. She called the others in, convinced that they were in no danger.

Glimmer was the first to walk in and her eyes widened in surprise and apprehension at the sight. Bow looked equally shocked. The others bustled in, almost knocking over the royal couple who had hesitated to move any further.

"What happened here?" It was Glimmer's voice that broke the stillness as they looked around the abandoned building. Sand covered every surface, warring with dust to see what could cover the most. Cups and plates lay broken on the floor behind the bar and several of the tables were on their sides. Yet, although the inside looked ravaged their was no food or drink anywhere, no sign that there had been a sudden exodus. It looked as though the vagabonds of the Waste had just disappeared.

"Maybe they just found a better spot?" Bow's relentless optimism came out high pitched, belying the fact that he was clearly worried.

"Did anyone else see any signs of life?" The crawling feeling under Adora's skin had increased tenfold when she transformed, she could barely stand it.

"Nothing," reported back Perfuma. Glimmer muttered the same.

"Do we think this could be the Horde? They took the Fright Zone out and then moved out here, took the people and have made a secret base? That could be where the flying machine came from." Frosta voiced what they had all been fearing since seeing the recording.

"I don't…" She-ra was finding it hard to focus now. The magic seeped out of her and she was Adora again. "Can the rest of you feel that?"

"That buzzing feeling?" Perfuma was the first to speak as the rest of the princesses boded. Sea Hawk and Bow shared a confused look, not understanding what they were talking about.

"What buzzing?" Bow was a scientist, his curiosity piqued and he drew out his tracker pad to put in the data.

The group of women began to describe it, how it had become more intense as they had walked further into the dessert. Hiring the others articulate it made Adora more and more worried. What could possibly be out here, doing this? Was it what was responsible for the desertion of this place?

"Have we heard anything from Huntara?" Her voice cut over the rest, where they had all gathered by Bow at the bar.

"We haven't heard from her in around five years, I think. I have tried since we arrived but there's been nothing." Bow's response was muted.

"Lets eat and then get out of here, keep going. There's nothing to find. I think we should stay together this time. I don't like this, there's definitely something going on." Adora's voice was commanding, as she had been taught all those decades ago at the Horde, broaching no room for question.

Afternoon was fast moving into evening and the group were no further along in their search. They walked in a bunch, talking and exchanging stories as they did, partially out of boredom but mostly out or a perverse sense of dread. If they didn't find something soon, Bow would set out a locator beacon and Glimmer would have to take them back to one of the villages and they would be able to start again in the morning. Adora did not want to be out here once the day moon faded.

Frosta was getting antsy, still full of youthful energy that the rest of them seemed to have moved beyond and sick of the tension in the air, she spotted a fairly large slope leading away to the left, and broke out in a run, whooping as she went. She hit the crest of the dune and then slid down the sand, impressively keeping her feet as she did. Frosta felt the sand shifting under her feet and she moved downwards, it was almost like snow how it flowed and lowered her down. She was almost at the bottom when she noticed a strange grove just ahead. Sand seemed to be resting

against nothing, and as her eyes widened she lost her footing, flailing as she flew the last few feet to smack into that same nothingness. Her startled squark brought the others running.

When they reached the snow princess, they found her propped up against nothing, cheek squished where it rested, almost as though she was pushed up against a window. Sea Hawk tried to move beyond her but bounced back off of the invisible barrier. After checking that Frosta was non the worse for wear, they fanned out into a line, prodding and probing at the barrier. It seemed to carry on and on. They kept moving, following it for hundreds of metres and still no end in sight.

They couldn't be certain what it was, Glimmer's magic just fizzled out when it reached it, not even illuminating the obstacle. Mermista used her canteen to try to funnel water at it, which only made it ricochet back and hit Perfuma square in the face, making her huff with agitation. Adora didn't bother trying to hit it with the sword, whatever this was magic didn't seem to bother it. What she was certain of was that this was the source of the terrible feeling as it was so strong now that she had to grit her teeth against it.

"All right, I'm going to say it. This is bad, right? Like, really bad. Like, 'secret hidden military base in the desert plotting our destruction bad'," Perfuma's voice was reedy as it cut through what they were all thinking.

Without discussion they stepped away from the barrier, never taking their eyes off if it as though it would reach out to grab them. The question was, what now? This was clearly where the flying craft had come from, hidden away behind the invisible wall. If not a military base then what? Why would anybody need to hide it they meant no harm?

Bow patched in a call back to Brightmoon, Juliet's face appearing on the screen and getting a few words out before the power was suddenly gone and the screen black. Somebody had pulled the plug on the device. Adora drew out her own only to find that too

dead, as did Sea Hawk. Somebody knew they were here and didn't want them to call in reinforcements.

"What's that?" They all looked up from the dead tech to where Perfuma was pointing with a long, trembling finger.

The barrier had begun to shimmer and melt.

Six uniformed figures stepped out onto the desert sand, weapons raised.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> This one finally takes us to our Hidden Kingdom and some familiar faces make an appearance.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mirrored lenses reflected back their shocked expressions to them as the six soldiers stood impassively, blocking them from approaching the barrier, faces obscured by scarves wrapped around nose and mouth to keep sand out. The six newcomers fanned out, silently taking up positions to surround the princesses, on three sides. Their weapons were trained on the ground, grasped tightly, revealing that they were ready to raise them at any moment. Nobody moved.

Adora felt Glimmer's magic begin to bubble up from where she stood at her side. She locked eyes with her and subtly shook her head. It was clear to her that throwing all that magic at the barrier had down these soldiers out. Casting her eyes around the group she was relieved to see that the others had obviously seen her cue and remained impassive. The former Horde soldier turned her full attention back to assess their captors.

She had been immediately struck by their appearance, they were like no soldiers she had seen before. Each figure was adorned with the same sand coloured uniform and helmet, mottled in various hues of yellow and orange to enable them to merge with the desert and surprise attack their foes. It was a far cry from the vibrant colours of the Alliance or the muted greys of the Horde. Some of the soldiers had their arms bared beneath their padded jerkins and shirts.

Adora quickly took an inventory of what species they may be facing off against. Two of their observers were obviously Lizard-

kin, their thick tails giving them away as much as the scales on their arms gleaming in the sunlight. It was harder to determine with the others, a couple were human or human-like, while the other two were beast-men, one with sleek fur revealed on their arms, looking almost like velvet under the sun while the last had thick, bushy brown fur that sprouted, almost comically, out of the arm holes of his shirt and cascaded over brawny biceps.

The stand-off between the two groups ended when one of the human figures stepped forward, pulling their mask down and removing their sunglasses hooking them into the v of their jerkin. The face looking appraisingly at them from beneath the brim of their helmet was a familiar one to Adora, who felt her breath catch at the sight.

"Lonnie?" Against protocol, Glimmer should have been the first to speak as Princess of Brightmoon, the words spilled out before she could catch them.

Lonnie briefly met her eyes, nodding minutely in acknowledgement, but quickly turning her whole focus on Glimmer. She broke the line of her squad and took three steps forward to ensure that all eyes were on her as she holstered her weapon and pulled a small, flat device from her trouser pocket. A few muted beeps could be heard as she ran her thumb over its surface.

"Greetings, Princess Glimmer," the formality of the words in Lonnie's older, mellower, voice made Glimmer stand up more regally by instinct. Lonnie moved her eyes over the surface of the device in her hand, making Bow realise that it was some kind of miniature tracker pad and piquing his curiosity even more. "We welcome you to Oasis. We extend the offer of diplomatic relations. You may enter our city walls if you agree to abide by our rules and laws." The words were staid and stilted, revealing that, though they may be rehearsed, they had rarely been used.

"We wish to speak directly to your Queen," Glimmer's voice carried power and authority that that she had developed over the last

decade as her mother had entrusted her with the reclamation of the Former Fright Zone.

"I'm afraid that will be impossible." Though her expression remained stoic, Adora could see mirth sparkling in her eyes.

"And why not? You say we are welcome, yet your leader will not deign to meet with us?" Glimmer drew herself up to her full height. "I would expect as much from Horde scum." She spat the words as though they burned in her mouth.

Lonnie could no longer hold back her laughter, and the princesses noticed that the shoulders of some of the other soldiers were also shaking in obvious mirth. Glimmer was beginning to growl and Adora found herself watching the shorter woman's hands to make sure that she wasn't going to destroy their chance of getting through that barrier before they had a chance to find out more. Lonnie reached up and wiped tears out of her eye and finally spoke up, "Horde scum… haven't heard that in a while." The dark skinned woman trailed off into rueful laughter that left her breathless, before seeming to realise that she may have caused a political faux pa, Lonnie squared her jaw again. "You can't meet out queen because we do not have one, nor a king. We decided that we wanted to be a society of equals. We vote for officials and are ruled by a council of five. You may meet representatives of the council."

"That would be acceptable to us!" Frosta's imperious voice rose and cut off whatever the leader of the group would say. Her years as a young princess regent and now the only queen among their group meant that when she wanted them to her words held a lot of weight.

"There is no magic allowed inside city walls and your weapons will need to be left in the hotel rooms that we will assign to you. We are the law and order of the city, not an army, and are responsible for upholding the law and delivering people who defy it to the law. We are not an army and this is not a military base, so please respect the people and families that you will find within." As

Lonnie spoke all of the others in her group holstered their weapons and pulled down their face coverings. Adora scanned the crowd but found nobody else that she recognised.

Adora walked a little way away from the desert dwellers and the others followed, knowing that it was time to strategies before they followed these people into the unknown.

"We need to go along with their instructions, we don't know what we're walking into. Bow, you need to send a message to Brightmoon now, let them know that if they have not heard from us in 48 hours to send reinforcements. Better to be safe than sorry." Bow was already tapping away at his pad that had come to life when Lonnie had used her own smaller one. "Let's try to give all this the benefit of the doubt. We don't want to pick a fight here, we're vastly outnumbered if the Horde really is here."

They talked back and forth for several minutes, planning quick strategies and arranging themselves into groups that would be able to have each others backs should danger arise. Meanwhile Lonnie and her squad waited patiently, some with their heads bowed towards each other as they talked to pass the time.

"So, are you coming?" Finally out of patience, Lonnie called out to the group that had drawn away. Adora called out an affirmative, and soon they were following Lonnie and the five strangers towards the invisible barrier.

One of the Lizard-kin held up his hands and pressed his open palm, covered in a metallic glove, to the air and shimmer began to surround it. The shimmer soon turned to a strange rippling as though they were looking at the surface of a pond that had been turned on its side until, like water, the barrier crashed down and disappeared in one perfect rectangle ten feet high. Beyond, cutting through desert that they could still see on either side of the aperture, was a city of gleaming steel spires, clean white lines and plants. So many plants thriving in tehe heart of the desert.

They walked through and the barrier fell at once behind them. From this side it was simply a clear surface, lightly distorting the sand where they had just been. Captivated they follow their guides down the paved road and towards a pair of vehicles that were waiting not far ahead. Lonnie gathered her people together speaking a few words before sending them to continue monitoring the perimeter.

"I'll take you to the council. They're expecting us." The group piled into one of the large transporters and drove towards the city that became more and more amazing the closer that they got.

"How did you do all this in seven years?" Perfuma was captivated by the array of coloured grasses and flowers that lined the roads, impossible in the heart of this desert but here nonetheless.

"Entrapta, of course."
Of course.

Lonnie had stopped the transporter at the city limits, explaining that large vehicles like it were banned from the centre of the city to avoid accidents and pollution, though they were allowed in the suburbs (though the visiting princesses wasn't entirely sure what a suburb was). Walking though the city, it was clear that it was different from anywhere they had ever been. The buildings shared more in common with the Fright Zone than any of the princesses' domains and yet the place was bright and clean. The metallic buildings were full of windows and often decorated with vines climbing them, softening the edges. The streets were wide and paved, with small market stalls here and there for a splash of colour.

The place felt alive, people of every species imaginable going about their business. Parents with small children wheeled them around, heading to one of the parks that they saw tucked away here and their on their journey. Workers from the various buildings gathered to buy food from kiosks. There was not a

Horde insignia in sight. People were dressed in their own unique styles, adding more colour to the metal, plants and sand.

Lonnie was quiet, answering questions when she was asked, but mostly happy to let them take the place in rather than giving away too much, letting them draw their own conclusions. This was her home and she was proud of what they had achieved as a community in so little time. So many broken people coming together to make something whole and beautiful. It wasn't perfect, ex-mercenaries, ne'er-do-wells and soldier's were not easy people, but it had turned out that so many of them just wanted a new life that even the worst of them had played along. This part of Oasis, Central as they called it, was the most highly organised and sterile. The further you moved from the centre the more organic it began to feel, Lonnie's own home being in a much more relaxed area close to one of the schools. She was sure that somebody would give the snooty princesses a real tour if this meeting went well.

Soon she was leading them through the doors of one of the more imposing buildings that dominated Central. The doors parted with a gentle whoosh as they entered into a bright and airy reception. Lonnie approached the young man behind the counter and he pointed for them to go directly through another set of looming doors to his right, a bright smile on his face and wishing them a 'merry day' as they passed him.

"Where is he from?" Mermista was the one to ask, her brows drawn as she tried to think how old he may be.

"I think he was one of the Horde cadets, but he would only have been 12 or 13 when everything happened. He turned 20 a few weeks ago, there was a big celebration." Lonnie didn't elaborate on why she, a guard would be partying with a twenty-something administrator.

Lonnie ushered them through the doors, but did not join them this time. She looked towards the front of the room and bowed her head in respect, before turning and leaving them to their meeting

with the council. Her shift was not yet over and she had squad to rejoin, perhaps after a small detour to get some lunch.

Looking down at the seven members of the Princess Alliance from a raised platform were five men and women. Two faces were instantly familiar. Huntara scowled down at them, looking exactly as Adora remembered, even down to her clothing, though perhaps there was a little less definition to her arm muscles and a few more creases on her face to show the passing of years. Beside her sat Scorpia, who beamed at them and clacked her claws together with glee. Huntara caste her a reproving look which deterred her not one bit.

At the sight of Scorpia the one time Force Captain looked around the room for Catra, unaccountably disappointed to see no sign of the feline. Instead, the members of the council were rounded out by a scrawny male canid, a human man who was sweaty and balding and at the very end of the table was a lizard-kin of a type none of them had seen before, skin smooth and features softly androgynous.

"Welcome to Oasis. The elected council are pleased to receive you. We had hoped that this meeting would come a few years down the road when we approached you, but you seem to have stumbled upon us." The words came from the balding man, sweet and syrupy as honey but with a wheedling tone that revealed that he was no fool.

"How did you 'stumble upon us'?" Huntara's voice was loud and hard and brokered no dissembling.

"There was a sighting of a flying machine out here and we were investigating it when we hit your wall." Glimmer saw no reason to lie.

"Entrapta," the word was soft and exasperated. "This seems like rather a small mission for you all to be on. Do you expect us to believe that you just 'stumbled' on the shield?" Huntara was still an intimidating woman.

“What could we gain from lying to you?” Glimmer’s voice was just as firm.

“Taking out the last of the Horde.” This came from further up the table.

“If you are what Lonnie claimed, then there isn’t a need for that.” Glimmer cocked her hip and crossed her arms over her chest, waiting.

“We do not want another war, we are tired of war. If you agree to our terms you may stay here for as long as you need to decide either to make a treaty with us or vow to leave us in peace and never return.” This time it was the canid who spoke. “We will provide you accommodation in the hotel in Central and you will be shown all we have to offer. You are not prisoners, we will treat you as envoys. Please respect our rules against carrying weapons and absolute prohibition on the use of magic inside the city shield.”

This was not what they had been expecting. Quite what they had been expecting, Adora was unsure, but it surely wasn’t this gruff but welcoming approach from these people. They would have to make a plan about who would be looking for what information in this place to uncover secrets that this seeming civility may cover.

“I’ll give you a little tour this afternoon, I can talk you through all the most important developments in Oasis.” Scorpia’s jolly voice was at least something familiar to all of the visitors, Sea Hawk smiled remembering his own snowy adventure with the big scorpion.

Adora found herself alone in a sparsely decorated room at the inn that they had been taken to. No, not an inn, they had called it something else and truthfully the word that created visions of quaint villages was wrong for this place. Hotel, Lonnie had called it as they’d travelled together earlier. The word felt at once more fitting and alien. She looked around at the plain white walls, one

holding a large painting of what she thought was supposed to be a bright blue dragon, a large bed dominating the space and a cupboard to the side of a desk. There was no clutter and nothing out of place. Everything in the room was clean and new but functional; only enough pillows for you to sleep on, running water only in the attached bathroom with its sharp chrome and no frills.

Whatever this city was, it felt to her as though this building, and these rooms, were what they were trying to achieve. Something clean and new with a purpose in the heart of the rugged and dirty desert. Drawing together the best of what the Horde had on offer and infusing it with the life and vitality of the rugged people of the waste and the civilized sensibilities of the displaced villagers who had also help to found the place. Adora felt drawn to it, the almost bare room calling out to some part of her that was still a child running around metal corridors hand in hand with her best friend, giggling in spite of the dark surrounding them.

She could breath for the first time in what felt like too long. This secret place had been made by people like her, for people like all of them.

Knocking on the door startled her out of the cloud of thoughts that were whirling around her head. This was not the time to be getting lost in thoughts of the past and who she would have been if not for all the things she had done. They still didn't know if this place was to be trusted as Glimmer had rightly pointed out in her Glimmer way, though the part of her that was She-ra lay sleeping, signalling that there was nothing to fear around them, yet.

"Coming," Adora shucked her top coat and rolled up her sleeve, remembering that she had come in to do just that before she became distracted by the decor.

Walking to the door, she took a deep breath, squared her shoulders and pulled open the door. She had been expecting to see one of the Alliance, gathering her for the tour that they were about to be taken on. She was stunned, therefore, to see Lonnie standing in front of her, no longer wearing her uniform and

smiling uncertainly at her from a face ten years removed from the one she remembered.

"Lonnie?" She didn't mean for it to come to so uncertainly, they had grown up as friends and though they had fought there had never been the bad blood between them that there had been with Ca… she didn't let herself finish that thought. "Hi?" She hoped that Lonnie couldn't hear the question in her voice.

"Hi Adora," it was reassuring that Lonnie sounded as uncertain as she was.

Silence fell between them as they each studied the other, stood in the open doorway. Lonnie was a little taller than she remembered, all grown up now as was she. The dark skinned girl…Adora corrected her thoughts, none of them were girls any more, the other woman had grown her hair down to the small of her back and now it coiled in thick braids augmented with gold cuffs down their length that caught the light and gleamed like jewels. He eyes were warmer than she ever remembered, Lonnie had always been so angry at the world and held it back, channelling it into getting the job done and protecting Rogelio and Kyle, but that was gone now. The thing that was the most startling about her appearance were the loose flow pants and shirt she wore in muted greens which picked out the colour in her eyes. Her feet showed though sandals and one of her shoulders was bared by the large neck of her shirt which was tied together with pretty laces in a vibrant red. It was soft and showed a confidence and vulnerability in herself that they could never have in the Horde.

"I've never seen you in civilian clothes before." It was blurted out thoughtlessly.

"Yeah, not much rec time back then," a little chuckle followed her words. "Not sure I can say the same to you though, 'Dora. Still looking kinda uniformy there." She gestured at the blond's clothes and Adora found herself self-consciously pull at the hem of her light coloured t-shirt. Sure, it was no longer the white long sleeve and red jacket of the war but it was awfully similar. The others

often ribbed her about it but she needed something that she could always rely on and refused to feel bad about it.

"What can I say, I found my style, why change." The two women laughed, like strangers meeting for the first time but a tension was broken.

"Thought I would come and get you for the tour, Scorpia asked me if I'd like to join you guys as I'm off duty now. I thought it was probably a good idea not to just get her point of view, she's still so upbeat I'm not sure your queen would believe she wasn't just sugar coating everything." That was a good point, if anyone was likely to give you the unvarnished truth it was Lonnie.

"That's actually a really good idea," Lonnie quirked her eyebrow and smirked. "God that sounded so much more patronising than it was meant to!"

"Nah, don't worry about it. It's not the first time you've talked to me like that." Adora felt worse at those words though she was sure they weren't supposed to be a barb. "Let's meet your friends and get this show on the road."

Lonnie led the way down the long hallway littered with doors to left and right and down a set of stairs. As they hit the foyer of the building she saw that the rest of the group were already there, all looking much as they had that morning, except Frosta. Somehow the younger woman had managed to acquire herself a pair of calf length silk-type pants and a blouse similar to Lonnie's. Adora would have to ask her about that on their walk. Scorpia hovered close to the group but was obviously uncomfortable to be with them alone, although as they drew closer she notice that Perfuma was trying to engage the Scorpioni in conversation in her gently insistent way.

"Hey, Scorp, got our straggler. Let's get this show on the road." Lonnie's words were prompt enough to get Scorpia to take charge and lead the way out of the building.

"So I thought we would just walk around and I'll point out the important places and you can ask me about anything that catches your eye. There are a lot of really interesting stores and places to see and that way you can talk to people we bump into if you fancy it." Adora noticed that Scorpia's words were a little softer than they used to be, she hadn't been close to the other woman but she, like Lonnie, seemed a lot more relaxed.

There was a mumble of assent from the group as they followed, eyes roaming the streets around them. Glimmer's eyes remained cold and flinty, even while Bow tried to draw her attention to some cute shop here or bakery there. She was not sold and it was clear that she still believed that this was all some extremely elaborate trick designed to take them down. Adora thought she was wrong, but more than once Glimmer's sceptical nature had kept them all safe so she would let her keep hold of that paranoia so long as she didn't alienate their hosts.

Hours passed in easily, Frosta and Perfuma doing the lion's share of the talking, asking about the various buildings that they passed. Scorpia had walked them passed the ravine that used to house the majority of the inhabitants of the Crimson Waste. Now the vertical walls were covered in flowering cacti and other climbing green plants and the caves that had housed people seemed to be teaming with wildlife, many of the people having moved up to the surface. It really was incredible what Entrapta had managed to do to the desert in a scant few years, each time Adora looked at Bow she could see him jotting down what were undoubtedly questions for the tech princess.

"So, we only have two schools at the moment, although there are plans to build more on the other side of the city. It was one of the first things that we did, after the hospital." Scorpia was beaming as she talked about the work that had been done to make this place a home. She was still wearing her sand coloured uniform but like Lonnie there was something much softer about how she carried herself now.

“Why schools before houses?” Perfuma had been asking a lot of questions, keeping their tour guide disarmed and chatty.

“It’s what the Horde was. It was those of us who grew up there and became the soldier’s and the children that would grow up and repack us. I never knew how many children there were in the Fright Zone. We were kept in our units and grew up together and there was never a reason to go to the lower years of the creche. When we brought it all down their were hundred of children, most of them under twelve and all they knew was war. It was important that we started off by trying to give them the normal life they deserved.” It was all said with a deep sorrow in her voice for all the lost innocence.

The princesses looked among themselves and then looked at Lonnie and Adora standing beside each other, as though realising for the first time that they would have been those children. Adora felt uncomfortable, though whether because she liked that they had forgotten her origins in the moment, or because they had been reminded she wasn’t sure.

“So who looked after all those kids?” Frosta remembered being a young child without parents and too many responsibilities and the words burst out of her almost like an accusation.

“Oh, oh, we didn’t give them their own houses and say ‘here you go’ or anything. There were a lot of ex-Horde adults too. Some people went and started their own homes but others stayed with the children. We have five or six big orphanages - I should take you to one next - where we live with the children. I’ll take you to the one me and… I’ll take you to the one I live in.” She was smiling as she spoke and it was possibly the softest expression that any of them had ever seen.

“So you live in an orphanage. What about her?” Glimmer asked as though she expected Lonnie to reveal that she ate the children.

“Might want to watch that tone there, Your Majesty.” Lonnie’s words were getting more clipped, more like Adora remembered,

and it was not a good sign. “My husbands and I have a very nice home over the bar that they run.”

“So you don’t help with the orphans?” Glimmer had turned to look at the taller woman with her arms crossed over her chest and her mouth pursed in a familiar pose that did not bode well. Bow reached out a hand and rested it at the small of her back, hoping to stop her saying something that would really offend because anything that happened now would be on them as Scorpia and Lonnie had been nothing but cordial.

“Actually, we adopted three children from one of the orphanages as soon as we thought that we were in a position to be able to take care of them, you know, after we had to learn to look after ourselves like normal people who weren’t just so much cannon fodder.” Her eyes were sharp, piercing through Glimmer, and Adora shuddered, glad that they were not locked on her. “How many war orphans have you taken in to your giant castle, Your Majesty?” And the title had never seemed so much like an insult as it did right now.

Glimmer was seething with anger and the tell-tale spark of magic was starting to wrap around her hands. Both women were staring at each other, neither backing down, and Adora felt She-ra wake inside her and the bracer around her wrist begin to itch at the impending confrontation. Mermista and Perfuma were looking between the two silent would be combatants, clearly torn about what they should do, though Frosta had moved to Glimmers side with no such qualms.

Before anyone could speak or make a move a small blur of fabric and fur sprinted around a corner, pursued by a larger group of children who were whooping and laughing. The cacophony of sound broke the tension as the gaggle of children thundered towards them. The child in the lead dodged to the side as one of the others got too close, and built speed as they headed towards the group of princess and Lonnie.

Glimmers hands were still sparking with magic when the same child collided with her at full speed, taking themselves and the Queen of Bright Moon down in a pile of limbs on the ground. Where there had been joyful noise there was now silence as they other half a dozen children stopped stick still, eyes wide, as they saw what had happened.

"Digs! Digs, dude! Get up." The tallest kid in the group, a shirtless orange lizard-kin hissed loudly in common tongue.

"Geez, ma'am I am sorry." The young ball of fur scrambled off of the woman and then used all their strength to help Glimmer to her feet.

Dazedly she looked down at the child who had knocked her off of her feet. He was probably around ten years old, all gangly limbs and slender almost to the point of skinny. His skin was covered in white fur with brown and orange patches where it wasn't covered by a brightly coloured red t-shirt and black shorts. His clawed feet were bare and he bounced nervously on them under the scrutiny of so many grown-ups and his large ears were almost lost in his wild mane of hair as they pinned to his head.

Before Glimmer could gather her thoughts enough to speak, Lonnie stepped forward and rested her hand on the boy's shoulder. "Digby," She looked up from his bowed head and caught the eye of the leader of the group and the little girl that was clearly trying to hide behind his larger bulk. "Fernando and Ellia you need to come here. The rest of you need to go back to school, because I know for a fact it doesn't get out for another thirty minutes. Now skedaddle!" There were a chorus of muted 'yes ma'ams' as the children fled towards the large building they had been approaching. They had got off lightly, it seemed, as Lonnie caste a disappointed eye on the three children of similar ages who now all stood in front of her. The princesses stood back and watched, wondering what they were about to see.

"Would you three like to tell me why you are out here, running around like a pack of dogs when you should be, if I'm not

mistaken, in math class right now?"

"It's my fault Mom," the lizard boy, Fernando, hissed shame faced. "Our teacher was sick today and I didn't think anyone would notice."

"So you organised the seven of you to run out?" He nodded dejectedly.

"Ellia, you have anything to add? Like why you were all chasing your little brother." Lonnie tilted the girl's chin up so she could look her in the eye.

"We were just playing Mommy, honest. Digs thought that we could catch him if we worked as a team and took a turn in the lead." Ellia's big brown eyes were starting to place with tears and Lonnie reached up to cup her cheek reassuringly.

"What about you Digby?" Her free hand ran through his bushy hair while his tail wound around Fernando's wrist, linking the four of them together in a loop.

"That's true, Mommy. I'm sorry I hurt the lady," he turned from his family and looked at Glimmer. "I am really sorry that I knocked you down." He smiled widely at her showing his small fangs and some deep dimples.

"That's ok, no harm done." Glimmer looked bemused by everything as she spoke, all the vinegar gone from her words.

"Well, you're lucky nobody got hurt today and I don't mean from knocking people over. If you're not in school and anything happens to you, how will anyone know?" Now there were tears of shame in all the children's eyes at Lonnie's soft words. "Scorpia, can you finish the tour without me? I think I need to take these three home and we all need to sit down with their fathers."

"Sure Lonnie, tell the boys I'll be at the bar later."

Scorpia waved as Lonnie led her brood away, her arm thrown around the lizard boys shoulder while her other hand was held by the little girl who in turn held her younger brothers.

Through it all Adora had not been able to tear her eyes away from the little boy who had started the kerfuffle.

“Scorpia,” her voice was low but the quiet among the group let it be heard. “Was that a magicat?”

Chapter End Notes

Oasis is Entrapta's baby. Think sci-fi Vegas but less gambling.

So here there be baby magicat's...

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Tours, bars and revelations.

Chapter Notes

Are you ready for....

Sexy Kyle? I want you to think Umbrella Academy season 2 Klaus but with LOTs of blond hair.

I was meant to be writing the update for Wild but 8k of this spilled out instead...whoops.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Gathered around Glimmer and Bow's room as the sun faded outside their window, the group of seven filled the room with chatter. Each of them was trying to make sense of this place that they had discovered. Only Adora was quiet and still, sat on the windowsill, back against the frame as she looked out at the city that was kissed by the amber light of the setting sun, giving it a jewel-like quality. She noticed, as she stared, a building situated far away from the rest of the city, sitting atop a stony ridge. It reached up like a spire silhouetted against the sky, with lights already blazing on its surface, revealing dozens of windows. She let herself ponder what it might be before her mind went back to the magicat boy who called Lonnie 'mommy'.

In nearly thirty years Adora had only ever seen one magicat; they'd all only seen one magicat. When they were children she and Catra would often sneak to their quiet places and wonder where they came from. Back then, Adora had assumed that she was a normal Etherian and had imagined that somewhere out in the world there were two people who had given her to the Horde

to look after because they knew that she would help to protect the world. She built them up in her head as people who had made a noble sacrifice. Catra, being the most alien looking creature living in the Fright Zone, had spun wild stories about crash landing from one of the moons, or being made by Hordak in his lab. She had always been joking, but now that Adora looked back she could remember the other girl's voice trembling under the laughter, eyes pained. Neither had ever had an answer to where Catra had come from. Ironic now, that it turned out to be Adora who was the stranger to the planet.

Briefly, Adora had wondered if that little boy was her childhood friend's. That perhaps Catra had a child, and that Lonnie had adopted it. The trouble was, that raised the nagging question that had been eating at the back of the blond's mind since they first saw Lonnie and then Scorpia; where was Catra? If that child was her's, what did it mean that she would not raise him herself? Something squeezed inside her chest at the implications of what that could mean. She couldn't imagine having the chance to have a child and not hold it close, after the childhood they had.

Adora was so lost in a tsunami morose contemplation that she missed someone calling her name. When a hand landed on her shoulder she spun, hands coming up defensively to strike out at an assailant. It too a moment before she realised that her fits was raised close to a wide eyed Perfuma's face. Adora lowered her hand and smiled apologetically at her friend, whose eyes shone with concern as she reached for the blond's clenched fist, smoothing her thumb over it until the tense woman relaxed and let herself be pulled over to join the rest of the group finding a place to perch on a pillow thrown from the bed to the floor.

"Sorry guys, I was miles away. Could you repeat that?" Adora hoped that she hadn't missed too much. Looking around at the others, casually sprawled on the bed or cross legged on the floor, they all looked fairly relaxed so obviously things weren't too bad.

"Fine!" Glimmer growled out the words as she pinched the bridge of her nose. Ok, so everyone looked relaxed except glimmer, who

sat ram rod straight on the small chair that finished the room. "We all agree that this place looks fantastic. I am not arguing with that. But, doesn't it seem a little suspicious to the rest of you that in less than a decade they have taken this place to barren desert to this? How, if not for magic? Not to mention that the Fright Zone obviously collapsed itself to come and hide here. How can we be sure they aren't just regrouping?" It might be mostly paranoia talking but Glimmer did have some good points.

"I was saying, like, we need to stay for a while to see if this is just a facade or whatever." Mermista was laying with her head in Sea Hawk's lap as she drawled out the good sense that she could always been relied on to supply.

"And I was saying, that we can't all just abandon our kingdoms to stay in a place that may actually be a trap." Glimmer eyeballed the other princess who just rolled her eyes in response.

"I think Mermista has a point, Glim. It's not like we haven't been away from home before and this time we're not at war. We all left people we trust in charge and the Tracker Pads are working now so we can check in." Frosta didn't often really disagree with Glimmer, but she had become more levelled headed over the years.

"What about you, Adora? You can't tell me that you're not waiting for there other shoe to drop. Where's Catra? You're telling me that the girl who almost took down Brightmoon: who kidnapped me and Bow: who was going to drag you back to the Fright Zone in chains?" How strange that Glimmers mind was on the same person as her own, just for very different reasons.

"Honestly, I am surprised she isn't on the council instead of Scorpia. You're right, it is odd, but I really don't think that this is some elaborate trap for us. I think it seems real. Lonnie is so different, and you saw the children everywhere." Happy children running wild and free, admonished by parents in the softy firm way that spoke of care and not disgust. "If this is a vote then I vote we stay."

Assent filled the room as the others agreed with her and Glimmer's eyes grew more and more stormy. It wasn't unusual for her, still standing in the shadow of her parents with no kingdom to run. With the war over, even rebuilding a whole new kingdom didn't satiate her need to lead. When that project was finished, who knew where she would channel her frustration.

"Fine. Just keep your guard up, we need to gather all the information we can."

The meeting broke up and the group left Glimmer and Bow to return to their own rooms. Thankfully they all had rooms on the same level. Adora was at the furthest end of the hallway, each of the other princesses disappearing into their own rooms until she was walking the last few feet alone. She lifted the flat key to the door and heard the tinny little beep tell her that it was unlocked and walked back into the sparse and comforting place.

Adora peeled her pants and shirt off and wandered to the bathroom where there was a wrapped toothbrush and paste waiting on the sink. Splashing water on her face, she tore open the brush and set about cleaning her teeth. The taste in her mouth was oddly metallic but not unpleasant. She spat, dried her face and wandered over to the bed, snapping off the lights as she went before she threw herself onto the bed and curled up in the crisp, clean linen.

As her eyes grew heavy, the events of the day catching up to her, she thought of Lonnie and her three chosen children.

It was decided, through a rather terse conversation via their tracker pads the next morning, that they would meet with the council again the following day. This would give them another day to explore the place and get a feel for it. How much longer than that they would stay was still up for debate. Bow had been the

one to contact Scorpia, who had given him her details the previous day, and she was to meet them in the restaurant of the hotel after breakfast. He voice over the tracker pad had been joyous at the thought that they would see more of this place that she had helped to build.

Breakfast was a less charged affair than the evening before had been. Glimmer seemed to have decided to give the place a chance and was sitting casually drinking a cup of herbal tea while chatting about the food with Perfuma and Sea Hawk. Adora found herself with Frosta this morning, the younger woman dressed in some of the clothing that had been provided to them the previous day when they arrived at their rooms. The simple blue peasant shirt and blousy pants were similar in style to what she wore in the Kingdom of Snows but light weight, as though they had been specifically selected for her. In fact, as Adora looked around, she realised that was true of the clothes all of the group were wearing. Glimmer was robed in a floaty purple tunic and leggings, Bow's clothes matching but, importantly, a crop top revealing his impressive abs. Mermista a Sea Hawk were in complimentary aqua, his a loose shirt and knee length shorts and hers a shift dress. If not for the changed colour of Perfuma's dress, it would have been hard to tell the difference, so similar was it to her usual fare, but rather than pink or green her dress was a sunshine yellow.

Looking down at her own attire, a plain white t-shirt and kaki shorts, she wondered at the care and generosity they were being shown by this young kingdom. Adora wasn't sure kingdom fit here, they didn't have a monarch, after all, but city didn't seem a big enough word to describe the busy centre and the sprawling homes she had seen in the distance from the window last night, or that spire on the distant horizon. How they had managed to achieve all this, and turn two groups of outcast and neglected people in a thriving home for them all was still something that they didn't have an answer for, and all of them were intrigued.

In the same time that it had taken these displaced people to build a home, Glimmer had been building a new city on the site of the

old Fright Zone. Buildings had needed to be torn down and the poisoned land healed. Perfuma and Mermista had worked tirelessly alongside the heir to Brightmoon to cleanse the earth and encourage plants to grow. It had taken three years before they could even think to start allowing people to begin building homes. They had reclaimed the ruins of the former Scorpion Kingdom and made them the centre of power for the area. Even with all that hard work, the place was still a work in progress and still looked like little more than a typical village. Nothing like this. If Oasis was all it seemed, perhaps they could lend their expertise to the outside world, as long as Glimmer could staunch her pride.

They talked back and forth, making a strategy for how they would use the day. With a meeting with the council looming the next day, they needed to gather as much information about the place as they could in a day. That would mean convincing Scorpia that they should be allowed to go on their own recognisance rather than staying as a large group with her. Somebody would have to stay with the ex-Force Captain, and surprisingly it was Perfuma who volunteered. During the war, the two had never really interacted but the flower princess was a calm personality who seemed like she would have a nice day out with the always pleasant, even when you were fighting her, council member.

Scorpia breezed in with a booming welcome and drew an empty chair from a nearby table after asking the patrons there for permission. It had surprised the outsiders that the hotel had other guests, assuming that they would be alone in the building. She slid the chair closer to the group and sit down so that she wasn't looming over them. It was a small change in her physicality, but another that shows dhow the passing of years had made her more perceptive of how other people would react to her.

"So, I hear that you will be meeting the council again tomorrow, I'm here to show you a little more of our city and answer your questions. What would you like to see first?" Her expression was soft as her dark eyes moved over their faces.

“Actually Scorpia, we would really like to be able to go out and look around by herself.” A look of consternation passed the white haired woman’s face as Perfuma took the lead.

“Well, I guess that would be fine, but what if you have questions?” She raised a large claw and tapped it to her dark lips thoughtfully.

“We thought of that, and Sea Hawk and I will come with you and if the others have any questions about where they are then they can just call us and speak to you.” They could see the tall woman thinking through this plan. She pulled out one of the small data pads and tapped it with her claw in a strange, disjointed pattern, receiving a beep in response and running her eyes over the lit up screen.

“That is acceptable. Huntara asked me to remind you that you cannot use magic here and that there are no weapons allowed.” She looked pointedly at Bow and Adora. Adora held up her arm to show that her bracer was absent while Bow nodded in acceptance.

They all rose from the table and set out for their day of exploration.

Mermista and Adora decided to pair up, while First latched herself onto Glimmer, meaning that Bow would be spending his day with Sea Hawk, Perfuma and Scorpia. He still had a boy crush on the sea captain and was happy to get to spend the day with him as well as with Scorpia who would be able to answer all of his questions.

Scorpia took her group back to the school that she had toured them past the day before, this time taking them in and allowing them to talk with some of the children and look at how they were taught. The day continued in the same vein with them walking around the hospital, Bow's eyes lighting up as he saw some of the intricate machinery that he had seen nowhere else. Perfuma asked lots of questions about the role of plants and herbs in

medicine in here and Sea Hawk regaled some patients with a song.

The most illuminating part of the tour for the guided group was when Scorpia led them to the orphanage that she lived in. She explained that it was one of five across the city. None of the group of three had been sure what to expect from the building. Having heard Adora's tales of being brought up as an infant in the Horde's 'creche' they were expecting a utilitarian building lacking warmth. What they saw as they turned the corner was the antithesis of their expectations.

The building was four stories high and completely square, but that was where the utilitarian feeling ended. The outside, rather than being the shiny metal of the rest of Capital, was painted in a rainbow of bright colours and peppered with pictures clearly painted by the children who lived there. Sitting in front was a playground full of play equipment, they noticed that a lot of it was for climbing and some of it seemed terrifying tall. Walking through the toys, feet feeling springy as they walked across the ground, Bow remarked on the lack of children and Scorpia laughed a little but said nothing more as she pushed open the door and led them inside.

Walking through the doors they expected to be bombard by children but the place was eerily quiet. They found themselves in a large room with a very high ceiling and more climbing equipment against the walls, in fact one wall seemed to have been turned into a climbing wall leading to the next level. Bow and Sea Hawk looked at it with barely concealed excitement, their inner children desperate to climb it. Perfuma felt no such compunction, but was taken with the plethora of comfy looking sofas and cushions that were scattered around the room and clearly well used. There were baskets of toys and bookcases dotted around. Hanging down from the balcony rail of the upper walls was a curtain of vines that cascaded down and leant more colour to the area.

“So, fair lady, where are all these orphans?” Sea Hawk, now a father, was keen to see that the children were treated well.

“Oh, you really meant that outside?” Scorpia looked genuinely apologetic. “Sorry, I thought you were teasing. They’re all at school right now, of course. We want them all to have the opportunity to try everything and make their own choices about what they’ll do as adults.” She started to lead them further into the building when a long fingered hand grasped her elbow gently and brought her to a stop. She turned and looked questioning at Perfuma.

“That’s really wonderful, Scorpia. I think what’re wondering is, where are the babies and children too small to attend schooling?” Scorpia eyes widened and her mouth formed into a perfect ‘o’ as she seemed to realise something.

“We don’t have any babies or small children here. The youngest orphan in Oasis is eight years old. They’re all the children from the Horde creches and other foundlings. There are babies here, I’m sure you’ve seen people out with them, but they all live with their families. I mean, sure, one day there might be new orphans, but for now just children from 7 to 18. Obviously some of them were babies when they came but they, you know, grow.” Scorpia used her claws to illustrate her words as she put them close together and then gradually separated them.

“Let me show you my favourite part of this place!” She turned and started to lead the way again as the other three followed behind, falling in love with this strange community more and more as they went…

Not everyone was enjoying Capital quite as much. Glimmer was still wary of the intentions of this place and found it hard to believe that if they looked more closely they wouldn’t find a military base hidden away. Every person that walked passed and got too close, or nudged into her, received a suspicious glare and retreated quickly from the angry little woman. Frosta was more open minded and was enjoying sampling food from vendors along

the way, though it was hard not to be infected with Glimmer's paranoia as the day went on.

They started by going to the small library that was still sparsely filled but was obviously doing its best and allowed people access to an array of computer interfaces. There were a handful of people there, alongside the librarian, who were pawing over various tombs.

Glimmer had to hold Frosta back from launching herself at a young magicat woman who walked in, looking so similar to their old foe that it had taken Glimmer a moment to register that it couldn't be the force captain who had almost destroyed her home. Frosta wasn't so quick to release and already had her fist encased in ice before her elbow was grabbed and she received a firm shake of Glimmers head. The ice retreated and they were thankful to note that nobody seemed to have registered what had happened.

The girl who had walked in was already seated at a monitor and pressed buttons, the light of the screen illuminating her face and revealing that, actually, other than the wild hair, large ears and tail, she didn't look much like Catra at all. Her fur was dark brown and her arms, revealed by a floaty white dress, were dappled with white and orange speckles and covered a form that was slender but clearly well fed. She was young, perhaps not yet twenty, and her youthfulness was accentuated when her tongue poked out of the corner of her moth as she concentrated. Frosta took a shuddering breath as she realised that she had very nearly done something terrible to an innocent because of her own (and her friend's) fears.

They left the library cowed and walked the streets quietly, not really paying attention to where they were headed. Glimmer may not trust this place bu the last thing she wanted to do was hurt innocent people. Before she could ponder too much though they reached a less populated area. They walked down a street that was windowless and found themselves spilling out into an area that looked more industrial. There were machines whirring and

signs on various walls directing people where to head. Frosta took out her tracker pad and started to take pictures of what they could see. This place could be what it seemed, any place as big as this would need a power plant and manufacturing area, but something about it struck the two women as wrong.

They walked farther, encountering no resistance, or sign of life at all, until they got to a tall sign on a corner. This contained a map of the whole of Oasis. It showed them that they had stumbled out of Central and were now in Industry. They obviously didn't believe in fancy names here. On the map they could see a large building further up the path they were currently on. It looked like it dominated the place, although they couldn't see it from there. Prison Block. It was simply labelled but revealed that this little utopia clearly had problems under its surface.

Who was held in this prison that they hadn't been invited to view? Scorpia had made no mention of this area which simply raised more concerns. The two women looked at each other and turned tail, heading back to the hotel to wait for the others to return. They didn't go to the prison, knowing the folly of that without backup, but they were sure to take more pictures…

Elsewhere, Mermista looked with bewilderment at the tall blond woman who had run off to a stall filled with fried pastries. Her face crinkled in disgust as she saw Adora stuff one of the doughy confections into her mouth whole and chew enthusiastically as her cheeks bulged like a chipmunk. Walking over warily Mermista ordered one for herself and ate it in sensible bites and had to agree that it was delicious. As she finished, Adora was ordering one of everything to be put into a paper bag to share with the others, so she said, though the sea princess was unsure how many of them would survive the trip back to the hotel.

"Hey," Mermista's voice caught the woman behind the counter off guard and she flinched at being addressed. Mermista and Adora shared a look, not sure to make of that. "So, can you tell us where the water comes from?" Because of course she was curious about

her element, she could use her magic to find the source but it was banned and she at least was trying not to start an incident.

“Of course, of course.” The woman spoke fast and nervously. “The purple haired princess found something out here that she worked on and,” she clicked her fingers, “we had water for crops and to drink. I don’t really understand it but it’s got something to do with the ruins and the spire.” The woman shrugged and went to serve a new customer.

“What ruins do you think they found?” Mermista asked as they walked away.

“Must be more First Ones tech that Entrapta got her hands on. I wonder when we’ll get to see her?” It did seem odd that they hadn’t seen the Dryl princess yet.

“We should ask the council tomorrow.”

The pair turned the corner, Adora’s bag of treats swinging from her hand, when a sudden clamouring filled the air. Where there had been the quiet voices of pedestrians going about their business, now the air was filled with the sound of run-ing feet and excited shouting and laughing. Quickly stepping out of the way, they barely missed being bowled over by dozens of children spilling down the alleyways and into the market square that they had just left. As fast as the stampeded had come it was over and now the various food vendors were swarmed with delighted children getting after school snacks.

Adora suddenly felt compelled to stay and observe these youngsters. Mermista didn’t have a reason to leave, so they snuck over to a bench and sat down to observe. Adora reached into her bag and pulled out a white dusted pastry and this time nibbled it while they people watched.

What was immediately obviously was that the children were from a wide range of species and ages. The youngest in the square seemed to be seven or eight, while the largest were in their mid

teens. Adora thought that it would be easy to tell which of the children were Horde raised, but as she watched them laugh and jostle it was impossible to see anything other than children who were having a good childhood. Mixed among the lizard-kin, humans and assorted beast-men, something else caught her eye.

First she noticed Lonnie's gaggle of children were part of the group at the stall that she had just vacated, and then she noticed something else. Crowded close to Digby were four other children with large furred ears moving expressively among their wild hair, their tails lashing together messily behind them in excitement to get a cake. Each of them had fur in a different hews, from Digby's patchy white, to unbroken grey to two who shared strikingly red fur with stripes of lighter fur littering them. Digby seemed to be the youngest, he was definitely the smallest, while one of the two ginger boys looked to be in his early teens.

Part of Adora had hoped that Digby was somehow Catra's child, raised by her friends because she couldn't do it herself. Although that thought had left a sour taste. Yet here were four more kittens, half of them too old to be anything related to Catra. On one hadn't it made her happy that her former best friend hadn't had to part with her child, while on the other Adora continued to be left without answers about her fate.

"You ok there, Adora?" Mermista leaned forward to catch her eye, clearly concerned.

"Yeah, just surprised to see so many magicats, you know. Growing up, we thought Catra was the only one."

"Yeah, it is kinda weird, I've never seen another one either. It's like they're all here or something."

Adora decided that she would have to find a way to talk to Lonnie again and get some answers to the questions swimming around her mind. She wanted to ask Scorpia about Catra but asking in front of Glimmer would just cause the shorter woman to get more belligerent and that was the last thing she wanted. Maybe she

could get Scorpia on her on later, at the bar they'd agreed to go to as part of their taste of life in Oasis.

Evening in Oasis was truly beautiful. Sunset over the desert was unencumbered by anything that could mask the pristine beauty of the sun setting the sky alight. The group of outsiders had taken Scorpia up on her invitation to join her at a bar on the edge of Central that night. Having seen what the place was like when people were working, they were curios to see if things became more rowdy at night, especially on the outskirts of the most sophisticated area. Would they finally see the true face of the mercenaries, cut-throats and ex-soldiers come out? Certainly that was what some of the small group were hoping, if only to vindicate their initial impression.

Scorpia walked them through some darker, narrower, streets that they had been on in the day, even during their own investigations into the city. It was big and their time had been spent dividing it and finding out what technology they had, where the military infrastructure must be hiding (though they had yet to locate it) and being regaled with information about how the social support infrastructure worked. They had not even made it to the outskirts until now. The tall woman led them with ease along meandering walkways, sharing waves and greetings with many of the people that they passed. It was curious to not that nobody called her councillor or any type of title aside from her name.

Before long they burst into a large square with brightly coloured buildings on every side and banners hanging down from street lights emblazoned with images of food and entertainment. This was more like what the Best Friend Squad would have anticipated from the little they had seen from the people of the Waste. Intriguing smells drifted around them, making their mouths water as they caught hints of roasted fish, friend meat and all matter of sweet goodness. Then, in perfect counterpoint to the clouds of smells bleeding out all around them came music that floated out from the largest building in the square. That also seemed to be

where Scorpia was leading them, weaving them through the growing gaggle of people starting their evening.

As they got closer they realised that the buildings front walls were made of woven fabric which Scorpia swept back with a large claw and beckoned the others to head in. Adora ducked her head as she walked in and when she stood tall her breath was taken away by the vibrant colours of the inside of the bar. There was no roof to speak of. Instead criss-crossing metal beams held up different sheets of brightly died fabrics which allowed wide gaps for the moonlight to filter through. It was the softest part of Oasis that they had seen yet, though they had been promised a tour of the farms and houses on the outskirts later.

Sea Hawk strode forward like a man who had spend a large portion of his life in bars and taverns, choosing one of the empty tables and staking claim to it. He may be loud and a little silly, but he was no fool and selected a table that they could secure on two sides while facing towards both the bar and the large stage the stretched along one wall and was dotted with a variety of instruments. Two elfin women sat centre stage playing a box-like drum and a flute, accounting for the soothing melody that they had heard from outside. They all joined him and watched as more and more people of all types wondered in.

A waiter was soon at their side, offering them a pitcher of some bright coloured fruit drink 'on the house' and sharing a gentle few words with Scorpia. This was all a stark contrast to Central but seemed to compliment it, enhancing both areas and showing that what had made the people of this place unique still lived on.

"Who owns this place?" Sea Hawk was the first to break the spell the bar seemed to have placed on them.

"What? Oh, this is Lonnie's place…well I say Lonnie's, she works the border so really it's Kyle and Rogelio's place. But they're a family and they all live upstairs," 'upstairs' seemed to be the sky, Adora was confused and from the looks of the others not the only one. Scorpia noticed. "Oh, the kitchen and the bar are actually

inside a building, if you look you can see they are darker? That's where their apartment is."

"Kyle runs a bar?" Adora was incredulous. She could see Rogelio maybe acting as a bouncer but surely klutzy Kyle would spill more drinks than he would pour.

"I'll let you see for yourself," there was a chuckle in her words and she didn't elaborate more. The drinks were poured and proved to be delightfully cold and tangy rather than sweet, quenching their thirst.

"So, what's good here, Scorpia?" And it was like a night out with old friends (which for the most part it was), ordering more drinks, eating some deep friend goodness knew what and chatting as the place got busier and busier around them. They could almost forget that they were surrounded by people who used to be their enemies.

As the light further dimmed from outside, dozens of lights flickered to life inside, making it seem more etherial by the minute. They noticed that the stage began to fill with a larger group, led by a tall, lithe figure In black, long blond hair bouncing around their shoulders. Black pants clung to narrow hips and a vest clung to lean muscles. Something about them seemed familiar to Adora, but she couldn't place it.

New music filled the air, more complex and deeper this time. People were playing a range of instruments and creating a complex sound that was nothing like the orchestral arrangements that were so often heard in Brightmoon. As the music began to build and swell, people in the crowd began to cheer and clap, turning their attention to the musicians.

It was then that a deep, smooth voice began to ooz into the room, carrying words of happiness and friendship into the air and other voices joined it as the bar patrons sang along. Adora found herself staring fixedly at the singer. The more she looked the more she recognised the tilt of his head, the ungainly way that he

danced, though now it seemed purposeful. Blond hair that had always been too unruly for a boy in the army, shone gold in the light and for the first time since they were children, she could understand why so many of their instructors had thought they were brother and sister when they were small.

Adora found herself rising to her feet and moving towards the entertainer before she knew what she was doing. The closer she got the more clearly she could see the changes that a decade had wrought on him. His jaw was more square, even though he had filled out, and accentuated by a tightly trimmed beard, as golden as his hair. She was only a few feet away when his name fell from her lips.

"Kyle?" His name spilled from her lips as a dazed whisper. It was one thing to see Scorpia, another to see somebody she had spent every day with until she was seventeen.

A hiss to her right made Adora spin in shock, another familiar face filling her vision and for a moment she was twelve again and in the canteen of the Fright Zone. The big lizard at her side wrapped and arm around her shoulder, which sat far below his own, and looked down at her with soft eyes and he hissed and clicked at her excitedly.

"Yeah, I guess he has changed. You too. You look very relaxed." It was true, the very large Rogelio had an apron wrapped around him and a chefs hat at a jaunty angle atop the crests on his head, a sign that he was a mature male.

Before Rogelio could say any more, a dark skinned hand wrapped around his other bicep and Lonnie rested her head against his arm. Adora smiled across the male's body, and received a tired smile in reply.

"I see you found our bar." The pride in her voice was obvious as Adora watched Rogelio bow his head to receive a kiss that spoke of love and reconnection after a day apart. The blond felt something twist inside her, different from when she saw Bow and

Glimmer of Mermista and Sea Hawk share affection. “What do you think?”

“It’s beautiful. Really. And the food is top notch.” She saw the other two share a look and roll their eyes before she found herself laughing with them at her still predictable appetite. “Um, when did Kyle get sexy?”

Rogelio’s jaw dropped in surprise as Lonnie let out a shocked snort. They both looked at the stage, then each other, before finally meeting the gaze of the other woman. “You think he’s sexy, huh?” Adora felt her face burning with a blush as she tried to stutter out something that down’t quit come out.

Rogelio saved her from her embarrassment as he gently chastised Lonnie before excusing himself to head back to his work in the kitchen. Left alone together, Lonnie and Adora turned to watch Kyle as he started singing a softer, more melancholy song . “He is sexy isn’t he?” Her voice was soft but carried to Adora’s ears. “It’s amazing what not living in fear of discipline and death will do for you. Once we knew we were really free, he just blossomed. He took to this better than me and Rogelio, truthfully. As for the singing? We were all shocked about that; he was putting the kids to bed a few weeks after we brought them home and started to sing to them and,” she waved her hand as if the music in the air was visible. “That came out. The rest is history.”

“How come you’re still a soldier then?” It had placed Adora that her old friend was still trapped in their old way of life, the irony that she was doing the exact same lost on her.

“Is that what you think I am?” Lonnie had turned fully to face her. Before Adora could respond to the disquieting question, a commotion on the far side of the bar drew her attention and caused a face splitting smile to cover her companion’s face. “See you later ‘Dora.” With that Lonnie was gone, heading to whatever was happing close to the bar. Adora craned her neck to see what was causing so many people to be shouting happily and moving towards the same area of the bar, but her view was blocked.

She found herself not wanting to go back to the table, so at a far slower rate followed Lonnie towards the bar, sitting at the end closest to the stage and far from the excitement at the other end of the long stretch of metal. Adora watched as Lonnie disappeared into the sea of bodies, and as they separated to let her through Adora caught a glimpse of a furred forearm reaching out to her before the gap was closed by more people coming to see the newcomer.

Requesting another drink from the bar, she turned her back and leaned against the bar to continue to watch the band. From time to time she found her gaze wandering back to the big group that was starting to thin now the initial excitement of the new arrival had waned. Adora wondered if, perhaps, it was one of the council members. That would account for the excitement, although nobody had reacted to Scorpia's presence that effusively. Thinking of the scorpioni, she looked over at her table of friends.

Frosta was no longer with the others, blue eyes searched for her until she was located dancing closely with a tall canid wearing some very bright colours. The younger woman was laughing and chattering excitedly. It was cute to see her acting like a kid. The others were still at the table, both the couples cuddling and sharing occasional kisses while Perfuma and Scorpia were learning close together, heads almost touching as they talked animatedly.

A burst of laughter, Lonnie's, pulled her attention back along the bar where she caught a glimpse of a fur covered calf and a dark tail disappearing through a door to the side of the bar, followed by Lonnie. They must have been heading to her apartment. Adora couldn't lie to herself, that tail looked awfully familiar but, having seen a few more magicat children during the day on the streets of Central, she didn't want to make assumptions.

Their parents must be somewhere, right?

There were more people filling the council building than on their first visit, men and women moving around with practiced ease with files and papers in hand. The same young man who had greeted them before was there again, still smiling benignly and making pleasantries. Unlike the first time, he ushered them into a small room to the side of the main council chamber.

"The Council will be with you shortly, they're just waiting for one of the attendees to arrive.Please help yourself to some refreshments." He backed out of the room and closed the doors.

"What do you think this is about?" Frosta's words filled the room and none of them had an answer.

Scorpia hadn't been at the hotel to gather them this morning, replaced by a dour faced Lonnie who was once again dressed in her uniform, sans the helmet and face covering. She had been polite but there had been a detachment that she had learned in long years in the Horde, and Adora realised that this was her profession demeanour. It was odd to think that Lonnie was two people now, maybe three (soldier, wife, mother); while Adora felt like she was barely one. They had been escorted to the council building where Lonnie had left them and how they had found themselves in this room.

"Maybe they're just discussing other business before they meet with us." Bow shrugged as he spoke and Adora was thankful for his level head.

He was right of course, there wasn't necessarily anything nefarious about putting them in a waiting room. These were the people who ran the city, of course they would have other business to attend to that they wouldn't want outsiders to be privy to. Glimmer, of course, was chaffed by having to take her turn. She and Frosta had shared the information that they had believed would be a bombshell the night before.

Glimmer had called them all back to her room when they returned in the afternoon and with a flourish revealed that she and the

youngest princess had found an industrial area and evidence of a prison. The reaction she had received had ben mostly raised eyebrows and a low ‘duh’ from Mermista. Glimmer had tried to emphasise how suspicious it was that Scorpia had not mentioned it either day, though Perfuma had interjected that it was only natural for them to want to put their best face forward.

Together they had decided that it would be something that they would ask about during the meeting. It had defused things in the moment and then, once they had been out on the town with Scorpia, it really hadn’t seemed so important. That morning they had all had to agree that the night before had been fun and that Kyle was a very good entertainer.

They didn’t have long to wait before their merry escort returned and took them to the doors of the council chamber. He pushed open the doors and they realised that this was an open council session, as they noticed a selection of other people gathered in the rooms gallery. They walked down the aisle and found a cluster of seats had been set out for them. They took their seats and saw that all of the council members were seated in the same positions as during their previous encounter. Scorpia discretely, or as delicately as she could, raised a claw in a tiny wave.

Greetings were made, and the council reiterated their intentions, then opening the floor to the princesses. It had been agreed that Perfuma would be the one to speak for the group, and she smoothly thanked them for their hospitality so far and laid out that they would be delighted to accept the offer of a longer stay in order to see where they could work together. There were pleased sounds from the people on the dais and in the gallery.

As Perfuma opened her mouth to continue, ready to ask about the prison, the doors to the chamber could be heard opening and two sets of feet could be heard walking into the room. One pair of heavy boots made dull thudding steps while the other steps were whisper soft on the ground. The princesses turned, and then all hell broke out.

Glimmer's hands were sparking with magic even before her eyes finished registering what they were seeing, Frosta and Mermista not far behind. Perfuma kept a cool head, staying back, while Adora, Bow and Sea Hawk stepped up in front of the primed princesses, trying to stop them doing anything rash.

A long, sharp laugh echoed around the room, followed by the sound of somebody getting hit in the shoulder accompanied by a chastising hiss, and Adora found herself turning her head to lock her gaze with the mismatched eyes of the one person she had expected to see this whole time, but dreaded seeing at the same time.

Lonnie and Catra continued walking through the room and came to rest standing in front of the council, ignoring the princesses behind them. Catra shared some muted words with Huntara and the sweaty human man whose name Adora could not recall. He was annotated as he spoke, and blue eyes watched as the other woman shook her head firmly. Eventually some kind of consensus was reached and Catra joined Lonnie standing to one side of the councillors at parade rest.

"Enough!" The voice that cut through the room came from the androgynous lizard who seemed to observe everything and catalogue it with their uncanny eyes. "As entertaining as this is ladies, you need put the magic away and sit down. You have broke one of our fundamental principles, but this once we shall overlook it as you were obviously shocked to see out police chief. We deal with our problems like grown ups here, which means you will sit down and you will use your words." Their brow lifted as they spoke, the rhythm and timbre of their voice a smooth blend of command and condescension.

Feeling like children under the weight of every eye in the room, they all retook their seats. Glimmer kept her violet eyes trained on the cat woman whose tail lazily waved behind her, revealing no concern. A voice called her name and she was given the opportunity to raise their grievance.

"Council member," she poured ever ounce of her mother into her words. "You must realise how provocative it is for us to see Force Captain Catra here. She was responsible for almost destroying Brightmoon, during the war, as well as the kidnap of myself and several other princesses. She attacked both The Kingdom of Snows and Salineas. She was second in command of the Horde!" Her voice remained level, even as her hands fisted at her sides.

While Glimmer spoke, Adora couldn't tear her eyes away from the pair of uniformed women. If Lonnie had changed with the passing of years, Catra had gone through a full metamorphosis. She stood taller than when the blond had last seen her, having a few inches on Lonnie even though her feet were bare. Her greater height was accompanied by more well developed musculature, she was still slighter than Adora or Lonnie, but Catra's muscles were much better defined and her frame, though still lithe, was no longer skinny. The fur that covered her seemed longer too, giving her a shaggy, soft look and Adora felt her fingers itch to pet her as she had when they were children. It shone with health and at least the markings on her upper arms were how she remembered. As were her mesmerising amber and blue eyes.

What was less familiar was the way her hair was cut close to her head on either side, while the centre was long and swept to one side, a few tiny braids falling in front of the opposite ear and the rest cascading down her back, ending below her shoulder-blades. She looked like a desert barbarian version of herself.

"We understand your concerns. What you must acknowledge is that all of the events of which you speak occurred over a decade ago. We were all much younger then, I believe the chief was only sixteen during the events at Brightmoon." There were more gasps around the room at this revelation, than there hand been upon hearing she had invaded the kingdom. "Much has changed and we believe that everybody in Oasis should have the chance at a fresh start. Without Catra, none of this would have been possible. We have her to thank for everything."

Adora snuck another glance at the magicat and saw her duck her head and move uncomfortably at the words. It was not something she would have expected from the woman who had always wanted adulation.

“You may not have reparation, she owes you nothing after all this time. We will arrange a meeting for you so that you can talk through this grievance. We hope that this will not hurt our chances at a peaceful working relationship.”

The meeting carried on in a much less charged way, though none of the Alliance could stop sneaking glances as the magicat in the corner. She stood tall and still, eyes locked with the wall until she and Lonnie were dismissed. Adora was the one who could’t look away as the two women walked passed. She attempted to make eye contact with her old friend, but couldn’t catch her eye, finding herself left watching her back as they got further away until the doors closed on them, hiding Catra from view, leaving Adora behind.

Chapter End Notes

Come back for a switch into Catra's POV next time.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

The last three days but its Catra.

Chapter Notes

Some questions are answered in this part and a lot more are posed, I hope.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Pain shot through her nose, starling her out of her slumber. Blearily, she looked around for an assailant, barely managing to dodge the elbow that was heading back to her face for a second blow. The tension in her body eased as she glanced down her body and saw the gaggle of small, furred body piled up around and beside her, pinning her to the floor in a warm bundle. It wasn't the first time she woke up that way, but it was still hard to get used to. Their hands, arms and feet all around, her touching her, still made her uncomfortable even after all these years.

She knew the kittens needed the attention; she was one of the few adults among them, but she's never been comfortable with being touched. Well, that wasn't strictly true, but none of the people laying on her were the people whose touches she had craved. She pushed that thought away as she carefully extracted her body from the heavy breathing, purring pile. It took a little finesse but she was soon crouched over them and not pinned below. There were a few groans at the absence of her body heat, and bodies twisted and turned to fill the void she had left, rearranging themselves by instinct until they were all peacefully sleeping once again on the cushioned floor. She made her way out of the large dormitory and headed towards her own room.

Reaching the blue painted door, her ears twitched as they caught the tiny sounds of mewling coming from the small bed in the corner. She walked in on soft feet, eyes well accustomed to the

dark, and made her way to the curled up ball of fluff. The sheets had fallen down to reveal a bushy tail wound around a pudgy arm and clasped tightly in a fist. For a moment Catra just watched the kitten breath, before moving to rest her hand lightly on the exposed back, feeling the ribcage expand and contract under her hand. A wash of relief always coursed through her when she felt the soft fur under har hand.

The toddler never moved, so deeply asleep that nothing short of an explosion would wake her. Catra often wondered if she had ever slept so soundly, all of the kittens in the orphanage slept soundly, even after all that had happened to them. Even the adults claimed to sleep through the night. It never seemed to have been a reality for her, all she could ever remember was nights plagued with bad dreams and fear; even now, she woke almost every night, heart pounding and unable to get back to sleep. It was part of the reason she was first to volunteer for night and evening shifts, at least then she was exhausted enough to rest.

Pulling the blankets back up to cover the fragile form, she walked over to the bathroom and closed the door behind her. Stretching to get out the kinks from sleeping among the kittens, she drew her uniform shirt over her head and threw it with negligent grace to land in the hamper by the door. It was soon followed by her pants and underwear, leaving her standing, naked, in the dark. She reached up and turned on the soft light over the sink, blinking against the intrusion as she made her way to turn on the shower.

Waiting for the water to heat up, she went through the ritual of cleaning her teeth, grinning broadly at herself in the mirror as she checked her sharp fangs. She studied her own face for a moment, thinking back to the child that she had been and the woman that she was. The eyes that looked back at her were still mismatched, but no longer haunted as they used to be. There was still a sadness, from new losses and old, hiding in their depths though, that only a few would see. She ran her hands over her face, chin and cheekbones just as sharp as ever and pushed her hair out of

her face, enjoying how the shaved sides prickled at her palms in a way her fur never did.

Finally the water was hot enough and she walked under the spray, rinsing away the day. Tomorrow was an off day and she would get to spend it with the children, forgetting her colossal responsibilities to this place that she had helped build. Washing quickly, she cut the water, shaking the bulk of the water out of her thick fur before she grabbed a towel and rubbed it vigorously over her body. Re-entering the bedroom, she threw on a pair of loose shorts and a crop top. She walked passed her bed without stopping, instead crawling on top of the comforter on the small bed in the corner.

Catra rested her head on the pillow beside the tousled one that already resided there, and curled her own body around the ball of child. Her arms pulled the little one towards her body and the two melted together on the cramped bed, Catra's back hanging off the edge of the bed. Purring deep in her chest, there was nowhere else she'd rather be. A tear broke free from her eye as she thought about who was missing from this little tableau, as it often did in the dark, and she let it fall as she pressed a kiss to the fragile ear beside her lips.

Yarsha ran through the halls squealing in delight as her pursuer got closer and closer. Her tiny claws clacked against the floor, helping her to find purchase as she threw her diminutive frame around corners. A bushy tail waved out behind her, flapping back and forth to keep her balance on her pudgy little legs.

"I'm gonna get you!" The voice echoed towards her and made the child scream with laughter as she saw the shadow of her chaser getting closer.

The little girl was so excited, that she wasn't paying attention as she hit the top of the stairs. Still too young to be in complete control of her body, she was soon airborne, limbs scrabbling,

grasping at air. Laughter turned to screaming as the floor flew towards her.

Big furry arms scooped her out of the air, and she was spinning, little claws digging into flesh as she hung on for all she was worth. It was all over in a moment, from her fall to her rescue. Catra landed silently on the ground, the kitten held close to her body, fear coursing though both of them. Thankfully all of the other inhabitants of the orphanage were in school and at work, meaning that there was no-one to see her sag into a nearby chair, shaking.

"You're ok, sweet girl, you're ok." The two cats rocked together, both pulling reassurance out of each other. The little one sniffled and rubbed her head under her protectors chin. "You gotta be more careful Yar-Yar." Catra pulled back so that she could lock eyes with the yellow ones of the child.

"I'mma sowwy." Her chubby little face was solemn even as her words, still hard to understand around her sharp little teeth, spilled out.

"Hey, you don't need to be sorry. It was an accident. Just remember, we might be smart and quick and really, really bendy, but we can still fall and hurt ourselves." No longer full of adrenaline, she sat the toddler back on her knees and took her hands, dwarfed in her own much bigger ones, and pulled them to her lips to kiss the pads. It made the child giggle for the first time since falling.

"Hey, shall we get some flowers and go visit Zu?" They always enjoyed the walk to the flower shop and then out to Freedom.

"Yay! See Zu!" Yarsha clapped her hands excitedly, almost slapping Catra in the process and making her laugh.

"Come on then Yar-Yar, let's go potty and then we'll go for a walk."

It was surprisingly easy to get out of the orphanage in the next ten minutes. When you didn't have to wrestle children into coats or shoes, things were really easy. Catra slung a backpack over her

shoulder with everything they would need for their excursion and then held out her hand to the buzzing ball of fluff to take. They made a comical sight, the two year olds arm upraised to keep it nestled in the much larger hand, tail wound around the tall feline's thigh.

Wondering though Capital was always exciting for the small child. There were colours and smells and people everywhere. Sometimes they would go to visit the council and she would be allowed to sit at the big table and play with Huntara's little hammer; or Double Trouble would turn into funny characters and make her laugh and tickle her tummy. That was always when Ra had things to do there.

Catra loved Capital, hell she loved all the parts of this patchwork city that they had made. Capital was the jewel at its heart, clean and bright and made to show that they could be peaceful. Bazaar was for pleasure and Market for commerce. Industry was a necessary blot on the landscape that kept the place going, and Freedom, the large sprawling suburb of farms and houses was more than its counterpart. If sixteen year old Force Captain Catra could see what she had accomplished a scant few years she wouldn't believe it.

She led the child through the streets of Capital, waving to familiar faces here and there. It was a long walk to Market, so after a while she put the packs straps over both shoulders and hoisted the toddler onto her shoulders. Gleeful little hands grabbed at the long hair that grew along the middle of her head and pulled like the reins of a horse, heels kicking back and forth and making the woman wince just a little.

Market was the most exciting place for a kitten. It was filled with people, and colours and smells. Their very discrete trade rout brought in spices and other things they were not set up for yet. Yarsha wriggled where she was sitting until Catra placed her back on the ground, watching her run off to the price market, walking quickly to keep her in sight. She came to a stop and watched the confident little one reach up and pat the stall holder on the leg

before starting to babble excitedly at them. Green eyes looked up and met hers as the adult magicat crouched down to look at the child as she chattered to them.

Catra watched for while before scooping up her companion and promising her fellow cat that they would come back another day and buy some herbs. They were waved away and finally found themselves at the flower shop. This was the kitten's other favourite place, the bright colours and smells always making her purr like an engine. They grew the flowers that were sold here in Freedom, so there wasn't much variety, but it was a symbol of the success of their agriculture and the freedom they had to just enjoy pretty things. It was a small things but it always made Catra proud of what she had helped to achieve.

"What shall we get for Zu today, sweet girl?" Catra trailed around the shop behind the child who was sniffing each blossom.

"Um…" Pudgy little face crinkling in thought, she took a sniff at a purple flower that had strange, spikes leaves. Then sneezed adorably. "That ones no good. Up Ra!"

Catra obeyed the little dictator and lifted her into her arms, carrying her over to a stand of pink flowers with softly rounded petals. Delicate hands reached out and stroked the satiny surface before pulling one out of the display and waving it towards the pixie-like woman who ran the place.

"This peas." The proprietor looked to the adult and received a smile in confirmation.

"Of course little lady," she was used to this pair coming and rooting through the flowers so knew how big a bunch to prepare. Soon they were furnished with a big bunch of flowers and the florist received a kiss on the cheek along with her payment from the child.

Waving goodbye, they were off again, Yarsha once again sitting astride Catra's shoulder with her tail wrapped around the woman's

neck so that the older magicat could carry the flowers. Sometimes, when the heat was too much, they would take a cart out to Freedom, but today there was a breeze so Catra set out on the forty minute trek to their destination.

After a while, Catra felt a weight fall heavily onto the top of her head, a sure sign that the kitten had dozed off and coiled her body over. The woman reached up her free hand and grasped one little bare foot to further secure her cargo. The walk was long but filled with marvels to take in. From the towering building s they had left behind to the incomprehensible expanses of grass and crop that they walked through, farm houses dotted here and there, to the clutch of quant little cottages with well kept gardens that made up a lot of Freedom. They weren't going that far though, turning off the main road and heading out through the track in the field.

Soon they were walking through a large grassed area, stony edifices jutting out of the ground here and there. It was sparsely filled as yet, but with the passing of time would become thick with them as they city grew with the years. Catra trod a well worn path, placing the flowers onto a bench before lifting the child down from her shoulders and snuggling her until she was fully awake again. Setting her alongside the flowers, Catra also removed her pack and pulled a sheet of paper.

"Time to see Zu, Yar-Yar." She took the little hand in hers again and they walked towards a tall column that stood a few feet away.

As they got closer, the little girl dropped the larger hand so that they could both reached out and lay their hand against the cool stone before leaning forward and resting their foreheads against it. Silence fell between them before the child broke the stillness.

"Hi, Zu." Catra placed the flowers into the vase that jutted out of the stone. She handed the piece of paper to the child, who unfolded it to show the incomprehensible drawing to the stone.

Catra sank to the grass, resting her back against the sturdy stone, feeling the cold soak into her back through her shirt. Soon the little ones chatter started to fade and she crawled onto the lap of the seated woman, curling up and purring to herself until she was napping once again. Catra raised her hand and starts to run it through her hair soothingly, feeling the toddler fall into a deeper sleep. One of the joys of having a kitten was their predilection for napping.

Wind rustling through the grass and the soft purrs were all there was to hear for a while. Catra relaxed in this place they had visited at every opportunity over the last eighteen months. Looking down at the innocent face of a child who didn't really remember the woman memorialised by the stone, she felt a wash of loss mix with affection.

"Tace, you'd be so proud of our baby. She's the cutest damn thing I've ever seen." She moved her head to be able to press her cheek against the cool stone. "I think you'd be proud of me too, you know. All those times you told me I could be softer with the kittens. They slept in a pile on top of me last night. I'm not going to tell you I liked it, because you know damn well I didn't, but they did." Her free hand started to pull up individual blades of grass and watch them float away in the breeze. "I'm trying to give them all what you did." She let out a soft, melancholy laugh. "I still wanna be like you when I grow up." She sighed heavily. "I wish you and I could have finished growing up together."

Silence fell again. Catra sat almost content, beside the memorial of the woman taken away from them too soon. Magicat's didn't bury their dead, believing the spirit needed to be set free from the prison of the body for it to be reborn. It had all seemed very odd to Catra when she first heard about it years before while learning the traditions of her people, but now she hoped that Tace had been released, this stone being enough of an anchor for her and Yarsha.

She knew that lunchtime had passed, but they could eat on the bench when their daughter woke up. She let herself begin to drift,

feeling safe in this place that she knew no-one would dare desecrate. The peace was shattered when a high pitched beep started emanating from the pack on sitting on the bench. Catra jerked awake, smacking her head on the stone and jolted the little one awake too harshly, making her start to cry in bewilderment. Catra hoisted them both up, shushing the little one, as she huffed her way to their things. Her subordinates knew better than to interrupt her on her rare days off, so this better be good.

Setting the now calmed child on the bench, she rummaged inside and pulled out her coms, pressing the answer button and wedging it between her shoulder and cheek. She barked out a 'what?' As she fished out a bottle of juice and a box of meat and rice for the child. She popped open the box, set it in the girl's lap and pushed a spoon into her hand. Seeing her start to tuck in, she walked back towards Tace's grave.

"Say that again, Lonnie!" Truthfully all she had registered was that it was Lonnie on the line.

"Chief, I know you're off today but you need to hear this. The Princesses found us this morning. I was patrolling and I brought them to the council, I just left them."

"Shit," this was not what they had planned for. They would reveal themselves to the outside world in a decade or so, not while things were still being built. "How?"

"Entrapta, I think. They said that a flying machine was seen in the sky." Lonnie's sigh was louder than the breeze.

"Damn it, I told her not to test it yet." Catra had known what the scientist was working on, and really she kicked herself for not seeing this coming.

She looked over, pleased to see Yarsha was still munching away contentedly. " Which Princesses?" She feared she knew.

"All of them…well not that net one. I don't think." There was silence for a moment and she listened to Lonnie's heavy footfalls,

clearly walking on a street and not the border sand. “Adora is here.” There it was.

“Of course she is.” She no longer hated the blond, she was too old for that childish grudge, but the rebel fighter always managed to derail her plans and she couldn’t see why that would be different now. “Are you heading back to the border?”

“Yeah, my shift isn’t over.”

“Don’t. Call your second and let them know. If I know my bureaucrats, they’ll tour them round the place. I’ll make sure it’s Scorpia. Go change and tag along. Let’s see what their agenda is.”

Lonnie muttered her assent and closed the call. Catra walked back to the bench, picking up a napkin and wiping some of the source off of the Childs chin before handing her a biscuit as she started to eat her own sandwich, while sending a message to Scorpia.

She refused to let the Alliance ruin her day with Yarsha, she would meet with them tomorrow when she was back on duty. She wasn’t a member of the council for a reason.

Fastening the buttons on her sand coloured shirt, before tucking the tails into her knee length pants, Catra turned her head to laugh at the sight of Yarsha hopping around trying to put her foot wraps on. She was at that age where she was adamant that she could dress herself, no matter what the reality might be, and Catra was so amused by it that she didn’t have the heart to stop her. Shaking her head, tail coiling merrily, she pulled her padded jerkin over her head and snapped the buckles together. It wasn’t particularly comfortable, and chaffed at her fur, but she liked to look as much like her team as she could to promote solidarity.

“Come on Fuzz-ball, let’s get out of here.” Yarsha mewled indignantly but let herself be lifted up and carried out of the room.

Catra launched herself over the second floor balcony, arms full, and landed in a crouch on the floor, suddenly swarmed by older magicat children as well as a few scopioni, lizard and human children of various ages. Yarsha shouted excitedly as she was lifted from Catra's arms and passed among the older teens for kisses and tickles.

"Alright, you little monsters, time for breakfast. Some of us have places to be." She looked pointedly at two of the younger children who looked down at the floor, chagrinned. Lonnie had called the previous evening, filling her in on the princesses and also the truancy of some of the children. She knew instantly who would have been with Lonnie's brood and made sure they knew, that she knew.

Breakfast in the orphanage was loud and boisterous. The kitchen staff laid out trestles of food and the children and adults who lived one site helped themselves. Aside from Catra and Scorpia, ten other ex-Horde adults lived in the orphanage, some working there while others had jobs that took them elsewhere in the day. It made for a sense of community in the place rather than just obligation.

Catra set Yarsha in her high chair at Scorpia's table, getting a happy wave from the woman whose mouth was full, before she loaded up a plate for her and the child. Some mornings, like today, she was still in awe at the spread of food to choose from. Grains and cereals, cured meats and slabs of bread and cheese were like nothings could ever have imagined as a child. She watched the older children, many former Horde, who would have known nothing but ration bars and now were able to make choices that at their age she never had.

"There you go Yar-Yar, eat up." She placed a warm bowl of oatmeal dusted with cinnamon in front of the toddler, who grabbed her spoon and began to tuck in enthusiastically.

"Hey, Wildcat!" Scorpia's voice was warm and effusive, but a little calmer than it used to be.

“Morning Scorp.” Catra began to shovel folk-fulls of egg into her mouth. Some habits were hard to break, and when eating among others she still felt compelled to eat fast lest somebody take it away. “What’s today looking like?” They tried not to talk shop in front of the children, but today time was short.

“I’m going to take them on a proper tour today. Yesterday I just gave them the highlights. They seemed pretty receptive…well that sparkly one was not very happy but I think the others listened. Thought I’d show them places like the hospital, school, here.” It was a good strategy to show them the things they had achieved to improve people’s lives.

“Sounds like a plan. When?” Salty bacon hit her tongue as she took another bite.

“I’m heading to the hotel now, actually.” Scorpia’s plate was empty, Catra noticed.

“Great, me and Fuzzy-butt can walk with you until we get to Rogelio’s place.” Cleaning up the little girl, the three headed out, calling goodbyes to the room and receiving an ear splitting chorus of replies that left all three of them laughing.

Scorpia hoisted the tiny girl onto her shoulders, careful of the spikes, and strolled down the street waving at everyone they passed. They didn’t talk about the possible repercussions of the interlopers, instead chatting about nothing to pass the time. There would be enough of the day spent on them.

They separated so that Catra could take Yashra to Lonnie’s place. Walking through Bazaar in the morning was like walking through a ghost town. It was a part of this young city that was alive at night, whee many of those who found it hard to integrate had found a place. All the shutters were closed and the stalls closed up. Yashra ran ahead, straight to the biggest building in the square and passed it to the almost hidden side door. At night this was inside the curtained seating area, but with it all shut up it was

the only way in and out. She stood beside the closed door, bouncing on her bare feet.

Catra fished out her key and let herself into the building, bustling the pair of them up the stairs to the main living area. Thankfully everyone inside was already awake, thanks to the presence of three children, or the little girls shouted hello would have drawn them from their beds.

"Morning kitten," Kyle walked out from the kitchen and scooped the toddler into his arms and received a sloppy kiss on his cheek fo this trouble. The tall, slender man sidled up to Catra and pressed his forehead to hers briefly, in greeting. "Lonnie's already gone. As you can see, the kids aren't quite ready for school yet."

"Thanks Kyle, I'm sure she filled you in on what's going on." She leaned forward and kissed the child before ruffling her hair, then cheekily ruffling Kyle's luxurious main and hastening out before he could catch her. Heading down the stairs she heard "Rogely!" Screamed at the top of powerful lungs as the kitten saw her favourite person.

Marching into the council building, Catra was no longer a carer and a parent, she was the police chief of the city. It's protector and guardian. When she and Scorpia had started to cut a swathe through the Crimson Waste, absorbing gang after gang into her own, she could never have imagined this. It was Huntara who had been the catalyst for more, in the end. She wasn't willing to be absorbed, but she was willing to join forces, creating a power vortex that pulled all of the Waste together. All they had needed was a goal to consolidate them and taking the Fright Zone had provided it. In less than two years they were ready.

Catra, with the help of Double Trouble and those like them, had infiltrated their way into the Fright Zone and started to plant

seeds of dissent. It had been surprisingly easy to get people to question their way of life and look for a change. It was like they had spread a disease until all of the soldiers, and most of the Force Captains were infected. Without Shadow Weaver there to intimidate people into capitulation and Hordak still locked away in his lab, the coup had been more of a mass discretion than an assault.

With the Fright Zone emptied, the people of the Waste had wasted no time in raising it to the ground. It was a catharsis for all and brought the two sides together in solidarity. A solidarity that had led to Capital.

Catra walked into the council chamber, looking around and noticing that only two of the council were present. Back, in the beginning, people had wanted to vote for her to represent the Horde here. She had rejected it out of hand, knowing that, in the end , it would be more of a detriment to the burgeoning city than a help.

"Take a seat, Chief." Huntara's gruff voice filled the room. Catra pulled out a seat and slumped into it bonelessly. Waiting.

"Hello Kitten, I'm sure Scorpia and Lonnie had told you all about our visitors." Double Trouble's perma-smirk stretched wide across their face as they spoke.

"Of course they did, I am the chief of police. They pose no immediate danger, if they haven't called in the cavalry yet then they won't. We need to find out their angle, obviously, but this is what we wanted eventually." Catra wasn't worried about invasion just yet.

"Scorpia said as much." As though speaking her name had invoked her, Huntara's com lit up on the desk. The ex-mercenary picked up the device and scanned the message there. "Scorpia says that the princesses want to split up. Some will go with her and the others want to explore on their own. She's asking if she should allow it."

"We have nothing to hide, the place is fabulous and none of our people are stupid enough to reveal too much to strangers." Double Trouble waved a dismissive hand.

"DT's right. Let them. I'll make sure we have eyes on them so that they don't do anything stupid." Catra was already running a mental catalogue of who was already stationed where.

Huntara typed a quick missive back and turned back to their conversation. It took an hour for them to run through their plans for the following day. There was no doubt that seeing her was going to be like a red rag to the Alliance, so she would need to keep a firm hold on her temper and snark. Time might have passed, and she might have grown up, but she was still a snarky, short tempered little shit at her core. She just had a better hold on it.

Seldom had a day seemed to last so long. What with monitoring the movements of the Alliance, dealing with two fights in Market and just the reams of paperwork that her position accrued, it seemed like she had barely sat down in her office before the sun was setting. Scorpia had kept a close eyes on the people with her, while Adora and the water one had mainly stayed in public areas and enjoyed the food. Sparkles, on the other hand, had been harder to keep tabs on, which had proved to be a headache all on its own.

Rubbing at tired eyes she turned off the computer screen in front of her and stood up from her desk. Her spine popped as she straightened. Somewhere along the line she had missed lunch and her stomach growled angrily.

Casting a final glance around her office, she walked through the bull pen bidding farewell to the night shift. Stepping out onto the street, the air was warm with a gentle breeze that ruffled her hair. Walking briskly, she pulled out her com to let the boy's know that

she was on her way. The reply was almost instantaneous and she rolled her eyes, of course the Alliance would be there.

The sun was down by the time she got there, she hated days when she missed dinner with Yarsha, the little one was probably already asleep. It was the price of building the place.

Pulling the curtain back close to the door, she stepped inside only to be engulfed in a crowd of ex-Horde, all whooping at seeing her. It was unusual, in fact it was a daily event. Put a little grog into the young men and women who grew up with her and suddenly she was a star when they saw her. She was surrounded and a dozen people were talking at her at once as she stood bemused at the end of the bar. The noise was deafening and she felt her ears flattening to her head to protect her. People were offering her drinks and asking her about the strangers. It was strange to think that many of these people didn't remember who the strangers were. She would never be able to forget.

It wasn't long before she smelt Lonnie's familiar scent, reaching out to break the crowd and pull her friend to her side. The dark skinned woman crashed into her side and wrapped her arm around her waist to steady herself. Both of them were laughing. Catra felt her fur start to stand on end, knowing who was watching the crowd from the end of the bar. It was a familiar sensation she had known since they were small. She just hoped that Adora could not see her through the throng.

Soon she was trailing Lonnie up into the apartment, waving a lazy greeting to the children sprawled on the floor, doing their homework on the coffee table. Digby leapt up and threw himself at her, and she let the momentum propel her into one of the overstuffed shares, hugging the little boy back. He had spent only a handful of weeks at the orphanage before he had become a part of this family, but all of the magicat's shared a bond so they were always happy to reconnect.

She nudged Ellia with her foot and the girl giggled while Fernando just snorted and got back to work, as though he wasn't the

biggest hooligan of them all. Digby slid back to the floor and Catra found a cup pushed into her hand by Lonnie. Looking down she saw it was a big mug of the hearty soup that Rogelio had become expert at. She smiled gratefully and brought the food to her lips. The delicious flavour filled her mouth and her empty stomach settled.

"So," she said after a while. "Why are they all here?"

"Scorpia invited them. So far, they're just hanging out. Filling my pockets with cash." Lonnie took a sip of tea. "Adora told me she thought that Kyle was 'sexy'." The two of the locked eyes, and then burst out laughing.

"Hey, that's my husband you're laughing at!" Lonnie tried for indignant through her laughter.

Setting her empty mug down, Catra lent forward and rested her elbows on her knees. She looked at Lonnie, studying her across from her. When they were young they had clashed, often fighting like, well, cat and dog. It wasn't that Catra had hated Lonnie, she had been afraid of her. Afraid that Lonnie would get between her and Adora, and when Adora was gone that Lonnie would find a way to step over her. It had all been senseless in the end. Now they were a family; Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio like her brothers and sister, helping her to care for Yarsha and look after herself.

"Who'd have ever though that we'd be here, like this, and Adora would be the stranger?" The words were low but they carried to the other woman.

"Hey, no melancholy here. Adora doesn't matter. You have us, we're not going to change sides and go chasing after She-ra. You gave us this life. You, the council, Tace and the pride. We know that." Catra felt tears in her eyes at Lonnie's words and covered her face with her hands to hide them.

It must have been a longer day than she thought.

“What are you doing?” Lonnie hissed at her as they stood outside the council chamber.

Lonnie had noticed something different about the magicat as soon as she saw her approach her in the halls after she had deposited the princesses. The chief was always neatly in uniform, but today her uniform was more pristine than ever, the button on her shirt fully closed to the neck and every buckle on her jerkin shone in the bright light of the hall. Both those things could be ignored, if not for the fact the Catra’s hair had been groomed to perfection, sides shaved as short as her face fur and the top long and swept to one side. A series of small braids with gold cuffs fell in front of her uncovered ear. She looked fierce, like a tamed wild animal.

“What?” Catra had been fidgeting with the buttoned down collar and snatched her hand back as though she had been caught ding something wrong.

“Fidgeting like a first year cadet. Are you nervous?”

“No!” The word was undermined by the squeak at the end.

“You know they have nothing to judge you on, right? They’ve been working on the Fright Zone for years and still only have a little village and you’ve done this.” Lonnie reached out and nudged her shoulder encouraging.

“I didn’t do this, we all did.” It was something that Lonnie had noticed about the feline over the years, that she was unwilling to stand up for how much she was responsible for everything; the city, the city, the uprising, the other magicats. She had always been so eager to seek even the smallest amount of praise when they were children and now she shied from it. It was obvious to everyone but the former Force Captain, that she should be on the council, if not its leader but instead she had chosen a background role keeping law and order.

Catra looked down at her watch so that she didn't have to look her friend in the eye and saw that it was time to make their grand entrance. "Come on, time to show our hand."

The pair of them walked, shoulder to shoulder, through the double doors and started to make their way down the aisle. They knew they had been noticed almost as soon as they took their first step, seeing the women at the front of the room swivel to look at them and then they did exactly what Catra had anticipated. It made Catra let out an involuntary peel of laughter at their predictability, and received a sharp smack in admonishment from Lonnie, throwing her a sheepish look at her presumption.
The sparkle princess got all glitter bomb, while the ice one (who had got big, Catra noticed) and the water one also got into a battle stance. She was curious to note that Adora simply got between the magic and the new arrivals.

As if she knew she was being watched, Adora was suddenly looking right at her. Catra met her eyes without faltering. This had been a moment she had felt apprehensive about. The other may be predictable, but you could always count on Adora to ruin your plans, even by intent or misadventure. Catra didn't want their plans crushed, this time they were working for good. As she stared into blue eyes that used to be as familiar to her as the ones that looked back at her in the mirror, she expected to feel that old twist in her heart and the accompanying emptiness she used to feel at being left by the person she cared for the most. It wasn't there. Instead it felt like looking into the eyes of a stranger, and she broke her gaze away as she and Lonnie moved to play their part in this council meeting.

There would be time to think about Adora later. Maybe Lonnie was right, though, and Adora didn't matter anymore.

Chapter End Notes

You ever wonder what happened to Shadow Weaver...

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Angry glitter bomb rages at a baby.

Chapter Notes

I'm not super happy with this chapter - but it needed to be there to get us to some funky flash-backs in the next section.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora made it back from the meeting in a daze. She could not pull her mind away from what she had witnessed in the large hall. Catra had seemed at once so familiar and yet so different. Her posture had been relaxed, even when Glimmer and the others had taken up a fighting stance, she hadn't bristled, just that laugh that seemed to have escaped her without intent. A far cry from her gremlin-laugh that she had always used to rile up an opponent even when they were children. Hearing that laugh had made Adora's heart beat faster, reminding her of the happy, honest laughter that she had heard so much when they were children running and hiding together in the dark, and which had started to die even before she ran from the Horde to join the rebellion.

Alone in her room, she went to the window and slumped onto the sill, once again looking down at the city that Catra built. It felt different now. Yesterday she had marvelled at how much had been achieved in so little time, but had chalked it up to so many people working together. Now, as she looked at sleek houses, and further the Bazaar and then fields beyond, she saw a testament to Catra's grit and determination. Was Glimmer right, was Catra really the secret queen of this place? Were they being duped to believe she was just a cog in the administrative machine?

Adora realised that it didn't seem like the Catra that they had fought, who had been hell bent on proving herself and moving up the ranks to all but take over the Horde. Growing up they had

both always talked about ruling the world. Sitting alone on top of the world, as they knew it, talking about being free and having power over their lives, Catra had always seemed so invested in their collective future as Force Captains and then running the Horde. Adora didn't know if she believed that the younger woman could work happily for a government without running it. There had to be a reason why, another shoe to drop. She couldn't have changed that much, could she?

Sighing, she leaned her forehead against the cool glass. It felt like she had conjured this place up, filled with all the ghosts of her past, with all her melancholy thoughts of being left behind. Of course, not all of her past had been left behind in the Fright Zone, some of it had followed her to Brightmoon but she had spent a third of her life trying to avoid it in the pristine halls.

Breath steaming up the window, which felt odd in the desert, she reached out a finger and swiped it through the fog. A knock sounded on the door and she jumped, banging her forehead into the glass and cursing under her breath as she rubbed at the reddening mark.

"It's open!" She called out, pretty sure the person outside would be one of their number.

Sure enough, Bow peeked his head around the door, beaming at her as he revealed two cups held in his right hand. "Want some company?" Glimmer had asked him to get her a drink, but they had known each other long enough that he knew when she needed some space. He figured he could spend some time with the clearly troubled Adora, and then return to his wife.

"Of course," Adora smiled back but it looked tired. She moved from the window and sat, cross legged, on the floor. Bow joined her and passed the cup full of steaming purple liquid to her. She raised her eyebrow at the sweet smelling concoction.

"Apparently it's what's popular here. Some sort of heated fruit juice, I figured we may as well give it a try." They clinked cups

together before both taking a sip. It was surprisingly delicious, tasting vaguely like berries and some spices they couldn't quite place. "Not bad."

They didn't talk for a while, just sipping their drinks. It was Bow who broke the silence. "So, how you feeling about seeing all these people you grew up with?"

"Don't you mean fought against?"

"Adora, I know that it's been a long time, but I remember that you lived a life before us and those people were all a part of that. The people from the bar, Catra, they all mean something to you. It would be like me denying the fact I have brothers. I don't see them for years at a time but growing up with them helped me become who I am." His big, brown eyes looked at her with such care that Adora worried she might cry.

"It's just…I don't know. Confusing, I guess? The last time I saw any for them we were enemies, and now they're all here together and I don't know them any more. All the hate, and the violence should be what I think of when I look at Catra but that was such a small part of our lives, and mostly I just want to know what happened to my best friend in all this time." She looked at him and chewed her lip, as though he would chastise her. "I shouldn't feel that way. She hurt us all, I still have the scars to prove it."

"I don't think that there's a right way to feel about this." He was pretty sure that Glimmer would say the opposite, which was why he had come by himself.

He loved his wife, but over the years he had noted that she had become less warm, less forgiving of people's mistakes. She was still very much the girl he had married, but with a harder, harsher edge. The rest of them had mellowed in peace and he couldn't pin point the reason why she hadn't. Sometimes they talked about it, as gently as possible, and Glimmer would reveal her frustrations with still working for her mother and her desire to learn more magic that her father wouldn't show her (for her own good he

said, but Glimmer had never liked to be coddled). Once, she had suggested going straight to Shadow Weaver if her father would not show her what she wanted to know, but he had talked her out of it. It was bad enough that the old crone still haunted the hall's of the southern annex of the palace, they didn't need to be bringing her further into their lives.

Thoughts of Shadow Weaver only deepened his concerns about Adora. He knew that she kept a careful distance from her old guardian, but as big as Brightmoon was, their paths sometimes crossed, and it seemed to him that no matter the passage of time, the sorceress was still far too interested in her former ward. He never raised the issue, but was careful to keep watch over the other woman after any such encounters. Shadow Weaver was a cancer that Brightmoon kept contained, but she was all too eager to spread her poison if people got too close. Thankfully, Glimmer had been keeping away from her for the last few years, allowing him to become less vigilant.

"I know you're right. It's just…seeing Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio was a big shock. They all look so happy and relaxed, and they have a business and children." Her voice disappeared for a moment and he thought she had simply run out of steam. He was surprised when she continued, albeit in a much quieter voice. "We all thought Kyle would die in the war, you know? He was always so small and weak; afraid of everything. He could barely fight. I still don't know why Shadow Weaver left him on my team, to teach me humility I guess." Her eyes were very far away and he reached out a hand and took one of hers.

"I know we were all child soldiers, but it wasn't the same there as it was for all of you. Even as young as she was Frosta had a choice. You all had a choice, and you got to grow up with people who cared. Imagine what it must be like to grow up and think you will die as soon as you step out into battle, because that's what everybody tells you. Now, seeing him looking healthy and cared about and so very alive, I just feel like I helped hurt him when we were kids." Bow couldn't help but notice that though she had mentioned Catra, she was not talking about her and it was equally

clear that she was at the heart of Adora's tumultuous emotional state.

"I'm sure none of them feel that way Adora, if they ever really did." He released her hand and started to stand, they were meeting with Catra and some of the council this afternoon and he would need to return to Glimmer. "Maybe you can ask them later, at the meeting?"

"Maybe." Maybe not.

Blood boiling, Glimmer paced around the room she shared with Bow. She had asked him to go and get her a hot drink and was using his absence to let out all of the frustration she felt at what had happened in the council meeting earlier. Sparks flew around her, almost shattering the mirror on the small desk in the corner. She pulled back, taking a deep breath, before she destroyed anything and made it obvious that she had contravened one of the 'laws' of this place.

Laws! She let out a growl and slumped onto the bed, pounding the mattress with her fist. Laws, what a ludicrous thing to suggest that this place had laws; upheld by a war criminal no less. Oh, so they couldn't use magic but that animal could walk free? Regardless of what she had done to her, or Bow or the whole of Brightmoon? This was all clearly the smoke screen she had suspected all along! Why couldn't the others see that?

Sure, the others had been shocked when Catra had walked into the room, and Glimmer had been reassured to feel the others pull up their magic at her back, but after the meeting ended, the others had seemed content to wait for more information. They had been promised a meeting with the former second in command of the Horde, under the supervision of the council, but how could any of them be trusted if they were working with Catra? Hell, they were probably all working for her, the council nothing but an elaborate ruse to cover the fact that they were living in a dictatorship.

Thoughts rolling through her head, she was spiralling and knew that she would get short shrift from any of the others if she tried to talk about this. They would just tell her to be patient; that they should wait to see what pack of lies they were told late today by the Horde scum. She loved the other members of the Alliance like family, but they were all bleeding hearts. Even Adora, who had been raised in the crucible of a war machine, was too willing to trust things on face value.

She reached for her tracker pad, casting her eyes to the door just to be sire that Bow was nowhere to be seen, and typed in an access code that only she knew. The screen lit up, searching for a signal before connected to the person still residing in Brightmoon. Connection came swiftly, a dark face filling the screen and Glimmer walked into the bathroom and locked the door, keeping her voice low.

The group found themselves taken back to the bar of the former Horde cadets, apparently called Liberty, by a much quieter Scorpia. Double Trouble, the pale green skinned lizard from the council was also accompanying them, to act as mediator, though Glimmer was unconvinced that they weren't just there to build numbers against the Alliance. Double Trouble did intrigue her though, they were clearly a lizard but their skin seemed smooth, lacking scales, and their features were softer and more human than many of the lizard-kin she had seen before. Perhaps they were indigenous to the desert and didn't leave it? It was certainly something to ponder, but right now her mind was fixed on the debacle that was about to take place.

Violet eyes moved over to the other princesses, all of whom wore pensive expressions. It was rare that they were not all talking, sharing their thoughts, even in the height of battle. Today though, there was a definite pall over them. It reflected her own mood and reassured her that they did understand the seriousness and danger inherent in meeting with the Horde scum. She had initially been reticent to meet at the bar, assuming it would be a trap. It had been Double Trouble who had reassured her that it was

because the bar was essentially an open space that they would allow all parties to feel like they could leave at any time. She wasn't sure she bought that, but at least they were not flanked by soldiers. Between this mornings meeting and now, just a handful of hours later, Glimmer had gone from rage to grim determination as they finally reached their destination.

Unlike the previous night, the large curtains that enclosed the bar had been tied back, making the bar a collection of tables exposed to the square. It was open and airy, the square devoid of any other life. It was clearly an area of the city that was largely nocturnal, which was another justification for meeting here. The council chambers had felt too confined, any chance at an attack and they would be caught. Glimmer looked around for any possible hidden attackers, noticing that Adora was doing the same, but there was nothing to see. Ideally she would have transported herself to each rooftop just to be sure but this ridiculous 'law' against magic meant she couldn't without dooming this already cursed meeting and she was sure that they were not going to be the ones to make this meeting a disaster. Give Catra enough rope, Shadow Weaver had said, and she always hangs herself.

As though thinking of her conjured the cat woman, she walked into the square from another walkway and made her way towards the large table that had been formed in the middle of the space from pushing a few smaller ones together, and throwing a cloth of bright colours over them. All eyes watched the figure of the former Force Captain swagger her way to the table. Her movements were self assured, as they had always been, but the way she held her shoulders and kept her head high spoke of age and strength that had been absent from her adolescent self. Glimmer stared down a rival, an enemy, while Adora found herself devouring more information about her oldest friend.

Adora had seen Catra march into the council room, now she watched her movements which were more fluid, not relaxed but more akin to how she had flowed around the Fright Zone when they were small. Her changed body, broader shouldered, longer

limbed and carrying more muscle seemed more purposeful, almost dangerous with the ease that she moved through the space and poured into one of the chairs on the side closest to the stage. Adora noticed Scorpia perk up and a small smile bloom on her face as she too watched Catra move to the table. A strange, calcified shard of jealousy pricked the blond's heart at the soft look.

During the war she had seen the giant scorpion woman constantly at Catra's side, dwarfing her and offering protection and friendship. Her belief in the magicat had been unwavering then and clearly still was. Often, alone in her room in Brightmoon during the war, she would find herself replaying their interactions. It was not unusual for her to daydream about Catra turning to her and laying down her weapons, agreeing to finally join the rebellion. Those 'what ifs' had been a torture, and faded as their conflict had gone on. Sometimes, she would fantasise about what was going on between Scorpia and Catra and she would hate them, and herself, and feel dirty, pushing those thoughts away. Now, confronted by them as grown women, she found herself searching for any sign that they were together now. Scorpia's reaction certainly suggested it.

Why did she still care? The past was another country that she should have moved on from years ago.

Getting to the table, Double Trouble and Scorpia moved to flank Catra, who had stood to greet them. This small respect was enough to leave Glimmer taken aback. It lacked the distain she remembered. Glimmer had already told the others to spread themselves around when they got here. Adora and Mermista sat on either side of her, while the others fanned out behind, not far from the table but enough to make sure that they would be able to stamp down any danger.

"Attendees, we are here in order to clear the air between the Alliance and the former second in command of the Horde forces, and current chief of Oasis police, Catra. Princess Glimmer is to act as the nominated spokesperson for the Alliance, while Catra will

speak for herself. Councillor Scorpia and myself will stop in as necessary, as Princess Glimmer may also call others to ask pertinent questions." Double Trouble, it seemed, was a confident orator who oozed confidence.

"We agree to talk." Glimmer made sure her voice was authoritative, though it was starkly clear that they had not agreed to listen. Catra only nodded in confirmation, it seemed she would not volunteer anything she wasn't asked for.

"We would ask that all sides attempt to remain civil, and remember that this is not a witch hunt." Double Trouble could already sense the bottled up hostility in the pink haired Princess.

Glimmer sat tall in her seat, well as tall as she could. She refused fold her arms, instead resting her hands on the table top, fists clenched in a sign of dominance. Just a reminder that these were her weapons and that she could call up magic whenever she wanted if things went sideways. She was surprised that Catra sat with her arms hanging by her sides behind the table, her own weapons out of sight.

"Let's get this over with then. We don't believe that she," I finger was jabbed in Catra's direction. "Isn't running the council. We know her, we fought her and there is no way she is simply looking after law and order in the city. She was power mad!" Glimmers voice rose steadily until it sat just below a shout.

"You don't know me, Princess." Catra's words were low and measured, surprising everyone that she had spoken and that she had not called Glimmer 'Sparkles' as she always had to ignite her ire. "You haven't seen me in a decade. I don't know about you, but I grew up in that time." Though soft there was an edge to the words.

"You're a snake, there is no way you 'changed'. Adora told us what happened in the First Ones ship. You expect us to believe that you took over a gang, grew it until you were almost running this place and then…what…decided that wasn't for you?" If looks could kill,

Glimmer's would have melted though the table as she spat the words.

"You can believe what you want. I came here today to answer questions. All you seem to be here to do is spout accusation. If you're mind is already made up, why waste my time? I have work to do." Catra splayed her hands on the table and started to push herself away. DT stayed her movement by placing their hand on her thigh. She lowered herself back into the seat and clasped one hand over her arm in a pose Adora recognised as comforting herself.

Realising that the meeting would end before it started, Glimmer started to fire questions about the last ten years at the other woman. They were delivered with accusations and mostly just wanted her to accept culpability for all of the things she had done during the war. It was curious to Adora that Glimmer still carried so much anger towards Catra after all these years, but in the absence of Hordak or a real defeat of the Fright Zone, perhaps this was a sore that had been festering for her over the years.

Voices rose, Catra trying to explain herself but being cut off or called a liar. Bow rested his hand on Glimmer's shoulder to try to calm her and she shrugged him off dismissively, never taking her eyes off of Catra. A half hour passed with nothing getting resolved or explained; simply Glimmer getting more frustrated and Catra visibly tamping down her own growing rage.

Backing out of the kitchen, Kyle manoeuvred the heavily laden tray of refreshments out to the main floor. He didn't often have to wait tables in the bar anymore, people came to hear him sing and eat Rogelio's food, they had enough customers to be able to employ other people for that. The slim man took great care not to let the bowls and plates clatter as he moved, conscious of the seriousness of the meeting being held here. It was why he had been pressed into service, in order to keep this between people who knew the situation and could be trusted.

As he got closer he could hear the angry words move from barely controlled shouts, to hissed words and then petter out at his presence. By the time he was laying the platter on the table, there was a tense silence around him that made the hair on the back of his neck rise and reminded him too much of growing up always surrounded by danger and hostility. He had always bee too fragile for the world he grew up in, and even now his hand began to tremble as he unloaded the tray. The soothing touch of a furred tail came up and stroked along his wrist, letting him know that even though she may not have taken her glowering eyes off of the pink haired woman in front of her, Catra was aware of his distress. The touch was fleeting but he felt calmed by it.

As he looked up from placing down the last plate, ready to head back and collect another, he caught Adora watching him and knew that she had seen the brief act of affection. He smiled shyly at this woman who had once been his idol and was now looking at him with a mystified expression. She smiled back, clearly uncertain if she should, while everybody else was so stern.

Kyle hustled back to the kitchen, where he sidled up to Rogelio and rose onto tip-toe to press a kiss against a scaly cheek. Rogelio made a low rumble in his chest and continued to load the last of the food onto the second tray. Kyle didn't flinch when a hand settled on the back of his neck, slipping through his hair and he leaned into the touch. Lonnie rested her forehead against his shoulder and the three of them just existed in that moment.

In the kitchen the children were making themselves snacks, keeping their fathers company while Lonnie was supposed to be overseeing proceedings, having only snuck away for a moment after seeing Kyle was riled up. The sound of giggling coming from across the kitchen new all three adults eyes, seeing Digby trying to wipe source on his sister who was making a disgusted face. Somewhere in the kitchen Yarsha was napping, Rogelio had last seen her curled up by a bag of potatoes.

Kyle bent to pick up the now finished tray, but a pair of warm hands pulled his away. He looked up and Lonnie gave him a

cheeky wink as she whisked the tray away from him and made for the door. Shaking his head, feeling very cared for, he moved front of her to hold open the door; he didn't need to, but he wanted to. She thanked him softly and started to walk back to the odd group who had spread out in the room to eat, far away from Catra, Scorpia and Double Trouble who all remained at the meeting table. Kyle held the door for a moment longer, enjoying the view of Lonnie walking away in her uniform, almost missing when a small, dark blur whizzed passed his knees and out into the room. By the time he registered what happened it was too late to grab the kitten who was already half way across the room and streaking ahead of Lonnie.

Kyle stood, paralysed, he didn't know whether to run out and grab her, or hang back fo fear of causing more chaos. His mind whirling, the decision was taken out of his hands as he watched her careen into Catra's chair, as the rest of the room noticed her presence mere moments before. Not waiting to see what would happen, now that she was safe with Catra, he sloped back into the kitchen and cast a guilty look at Rogelio, who just shrugged and grumbled noncommittally. It'd be fine.

Catra was the first one to realise something was wrong. She hated that Kyle had been so distressed by the situation, in truth she had taken Glimmer's bait and hated herself for it. She had promised herself that she wouldn't be drawn into an argument, that she would be able to keep her cool and stay calm. She had worked so hard over the last eight years to manage her temper and not lash out, and it felt like with a few well placed jobs the sparkly monster had managed to bring her right back to that wicked little animal she had been. When he had dashed back to the kitchen, she had given Lonnie a nod to make sure he was ok.

When the door to the kitchen squeaked open, she shot a quick look and wasn't surprised to see Lonnie bringing back the rest of the food while Kyle hung back. When they were kids she would have perceived his actions to be weak and hated him for it, now she knew that it was alright to feel vulnerable. She turned her attention back to Scorpia and DT, speaking in low voices about

where this was going when her ears shot up. Lonnie hadn't reached the table yet but something was moving towards them with tremendous speed.

Reaching down, she caught the fast little blur, and leaned over the edge of her chair to look down at the kitten. A loud sigh left her lips as she realised that all the sound in the room had died, save for Lonnie putting the tray down. The Alliance members had all moved away to the far side of the room with their refreshments and been talking quietly, but animatedly, while shooting glances towards her. Now there was only silence. This was the very last thing she had wanted!

"Ra, up! I tireded." Small hands reached up, and any annoyance she felt at the child running out disappeared in the face of her big, drooping eyes and grabby little fingers.

"Fuzzy-butt," she reached down and drew the small body onto her lap, where Yarsha began to nuzzle her throat trying to get comfortable for a nap. "Hey, you can't stay here. Ra is working." She ran a hand across the child's back to sooth her.

Big, tired eyes, gazed up as her and began to fill with tears as her lower lip trembled. They were on the precipice of a full out toddler meltdown, it seemed. When she had gone to work that morning, Yarsha had been more clingy than usual, and now this, made Catra think that perhaps she was coming down with something. How could she send her way when she was looking at that face? She looked over to DT, she knew Scorpia would already be cooing at the sight of the kid, and got an approving nod.

"Shush, everything's ok. You can stay. You gonna take a nap with me, huh?" Just like that the tears tapered off and the little ball of fur went limp against her chest, trying to get comfortable.

Double Trouble leaned closer in their chair, "Having the little one here might help them to calm down and actually listen…"

“Children are not pawns!” The words left her mouth as a growl that was far louder than she intended and carried across the room, she was sure. She looked down and saw disapproving eyes and a pout directed at her. “Sorry, Yar-Yar.” The words were whispered and accompanied by a kiss to a nearby ear.

The princesses had slowly begun to move back to the large table, moving gingerly like Catra was holding an explosive and not a two and a half year old child. She heard the scrape of chairs moving, but made a point not to look up at the sound, instead keeping her gaze on Yarsha as she fought against sleep.

“What’s wrong?” She spoke too low for any of the humans to hear but twitchy ears let her know the kitten had.

“Dis is ouchy, Ra. I wanna go sleep.” Claws jabbed at her padded jerkin, really more of a tactical vest, and started to pick at the buckles. Catra didn’t even need to think about it as she unhooked the vest and drew it over her head careful not to jostle Yarsha. She discarded it on the floor beside her, and drew the little girl closer.

Yarsha purred delightedly and nestled her face into Catra’s throat, as she melted into her. One small hand came up to grasp the collar of her shirt, while the other wrapped around her neck. Yarsha curled her legs into the bigger cat’s body and finally her tail coiled around her Ra’s forearm as her eyes got to heavy to hold open. She had never once even glanced at the half dozen or so new people. Catra felt her completely relax and lowly purred to send her over the edge, keeping her tail wrapped arm firmly pressed to her back to stop her from falling.

Only once tiny snores began to emerge from below her chin, did Catra look up and stare down the group across the table. Perfuma, Catra knew all their names she just chose never to use them, was looking at the two of them the same way that Scorpia did, as was Bow. If their eyes were any wider they would be heart shaped. The other two princesses just seemed bewildered and she was’t sure that the pirate was even aware of the small child.

Adora couldn't pull her eyes away from the kitten, she looked… lost was the only word that Catra could think of.

But Glimmer? Glimmer was still glowering at them both, her hands still twitching in that way they had since the meeting started. Like she wanted to reach out and choke the magicat, child be damned. There was no softening around her eyes, and if Catra strained her ears enough she was pretty sure that she would be able to hear the sound of her teeth grinding.

"So, meetings over then, just like that? You wheel in an infant and we go without our questions answered? I thought you were low…" Thankfully Glimmers voice though harsh, was not a shout, and Yarsha never stirred.

"I may be low, but I would never use a child for that! All of the children here are loved, orphans or otherwise. We all know what it's like to be used by adults, why would I even consider it?" She'd thought her words would come out angry, but instead she just felt sad.

"The meeting can certainly continue," DT slot into the conversation smooth as silk. "The child is asleep, and as long as we can keep a civil tongue in our heads and an appropriate volume to our words, then why should we stop?" Thus far things had been very far from civil or quiet. "Perhaps I should take over answering your questions? Catra, or course, will contribute as necessary. Might I suggest that Princess Glimmer also take a break and allow somebody else to take the lead, just to allow cooler heads to prevail?" Double Trouble's word's were too smooth, too polite, to possibly be able to say no to.

Mermista raised her hand, taking control of their side, as Glimmer sat back in her chair with her arms folded and her knee jumping under the desk. Catra couldn't relax either but that was more a survival instinct than fear, at least that's what she told herself as she unconsciously took a sniff at the top of the little ones head.

“So, like, are you going to tell us why she,” Mermista might be sardonic, but she was always able to cut to the chase. “Should be trusted? Because right now, we think that she’s running the show and all this is just a front.” Glimmers eyes swivelled to her right and she fixed Mermista with a look that screamed ‘don’t tell them that!’ And, truthfully, it was all Catra could do not to snigger at her. It was about time somebody put their cards on the table.

“How much do you want to tell them?” Double Trouble turned to her, waiting for her reply. They weren’t the most tactful person but they cared about her enough to ask.

“Everything relevant.” Because Tace wasn’t relevant for them, though she was vital to her, and DT knew that.

“Everything it is…”

_____

Kyle had looked so worried. It reminded Adora of when Shadow Weaver used to walk into their bunk when they were small, although Kyle had never been the focus of her ire he had often cried and more than once wet himself in fear. He was sensitive then and clearly even as this much more self assured seeming man, he still was. She had always thought that Bow and Kyle would have been friends in other circumstances. It didn’t escape her notice that Catra stroked out her tail to him, and the little girl that lived in her bristled. Catra had never reached out to anyone but her.

What was wrong with her? She needed to focus on the meeting, she was a grown woman. Of course Catra had changed, they were all almost thirty. With Kyle gone, the Alliance members grabbed some food and moved to the far side of the bar to talk over events. They were clearly getting nowhere and Adora sat with a plate full of small pastries and sandwiches, thinking forlornly of Entrapta, the princess they had all let down. Groaning softly, she stuffed foot into her mouth and kept quiet while the others shouted at each other in whispers. Glimmer was getting nowhere and they were all getting frustrated with the stalemate.

As she ate, Adora kept casting glances back towards the meeting table, noticing that Catra did not eat though she did sip from a mug that had been placed in front of her. It was then that her attention was drawn to Lonnie emerging from the Kitchen, holding a tray while Kyle watched her come back to the table. Were they all so unbearable that he needed to hide from them?

Just as Adora turned back to her team, ready to try to step in and rally them, a dark blur caught the corner of her eye and she was once again staring at Catra. The small, fast moving thing, was at her side in a moment, rushing passed Lonnie. Adora felt herself tense at the intrusion, hand moving to where her bracer should be and coming away empty. Nobody else had noticed so far, still too caught up in what they should do to get the confession that they demanded. She was able to watch as Catra leant down to the small creature and pulled it into her lap.

It was a kitten. It took her mind a minute to process what she was seeing. A small, tortoiseshell kitten was now held in Catra's arms and marking under her jaw with intent. Her dark brown, almost black, base fur was highlighted with large patches of the red-brown fur of the older magicat. The little one had one had a particularly large pair of lighter patches on her face, one around her right eye and the other her nose and mouth, though the blond couldn't see the colour of her eyes. She saw Catra bring her hand up into the girls jet black hair and them exchange soft words.

The chatter around Adora started to fade, but all her attention was on the kitten. Hadn't Scorpia said that there weren't any orphans younger than seven? Wasn't that what Perfuma had said? What did that mean for this tiny ball of fur that sent pangs of longing through her chest as she thought of the kitten she had found in a box twenty-five years ago? She saw Double Trouble say something to the older woman and then everyone heard her response.

"Children are not pawns!" It was a growl that was much more familiar than her attempt at civility. The child tensed and Catra was once again shushing with soft words.

Adora couldn't stop her feet from taking her back to the meeting table, vaguely registering that the others were also walking back with her. She only had eyes for the two magicats. Catra never looked up, just trading words too quiet to hear with the child. It was a shock when Catra loosened her uniform and pulled the larger piece over her head and to see the kitten take its place snuggled up to her chest with her tail wrapped around a furry forearm. It was another reminder of how baby Catra would curl up with her in their bunk when they were small and lonely.

Everybody was quiet, watching the odd spectacle of this woman they thought of as a war criminal, cradle a very small child. Large and small purrs twined together to fill the space until the latter morphed into small snores and Catra finally deigned to look at them. Adora was mesmerised, feeling as though she was under an enchantment. If she had needed any confirmation that Catra was changed, this was it. She had always been the first to be mean to the younger cadets and sworn that only fools would have children.

"So, meetings over then, just like that? You wheel in an infant and we go without our questions answered? I thought you were low…" Adora' eyes snapped away from the soft sight in front of her to the seething woman at her side, feeling shocked by her attitude to the sight of a child.

"I may be low, but I would never use a child for that! All of the children here are loved, orphans or otherwise. We all know what it's like to be used by adults, why would I even consider it?" Adora felt a lump form at the back of her throat at the melancholy sound of the Catra's voice, and the truth of her words.

Around her the other members of the Alliance agreed with Double Trouble's assessment that the show could go on with some adjustments, like Glimmer piping down. Adora was relieved, the idea of raised voices waking that baby up made her chest hurt. She knew what a frightened kitten sounded like first hand and never wanted to hear it again. Mermista did what Glimmer should have, cut to the point of the meeting and stayed calm.

“How much do you want to tell them?” It was interesting to watch how Double Trouble interacted with Catra, they were clearly in command but still deferred to her under the circumstances. Adora couldn’t understand how the others hadn’t noticed that both Scorpia and Double Trouble were clearly in control of this meeting, and not the former Force Captain. It seemed obvious to her, even before the child arrived.

“Everything relevant.” There was a flintiness in Catra’s mismatched eyes as she spoke, clear and concise. Double Trouble obviously knew what that meant, and Adora found herself leaning forward din her seat as they began to speak.

“Everything it is…”

Chapter End Notes

Who's ready to travel back in time?

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Let's go back 8 years and have our hearts ripped out, shall we?

Chapter Notes

information between **** are flashback scenes.

I hadn't planned to post this, or even write it this weekend, but Tace wanted to come out so 7K+ later here we are. Hope it lives up to expectation.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“How much do you want to tell them?” Double Trouble turned to her, waiting for her reply. They weren’t the most tactful person but they cared about her enough to ask.

“Everything relevant.” Because Tace wasn’t relevant for them, though she was vital to her, and DT knew that.

“Everything it is…”

While DT started talking, Catra buried her nose in Yarsha’s sweet smelling hair and let her mind drift back to that day eight years ago.

*****

If the heat didn’t kill her then the itchiness might, sharp claws frantically scratched at her side where the sand had managed to get beneath her fur. The young magicat looked at her team who all seemed perfectly at ease as they walked deeper and deeper into the heart of the desert. They were a long way from the market now, all loaded with plenty of water and food in case they were to get stuck out here in the heat. Catra grumbled profanities

under her breath about each of them. Double Trouble, the newest member of their group, laughed uproariously when they heard, making her glower even more.

Huntara had been out in the desert for almost a decade and was well used to the extreme temperatures and the sand. A large brimmed brown hat, which had been the subject of a lot of teasing from the young feline, protected her head, ears and neck from the beating sun and she pulled a travois behind her laden with supplies. Looking between the hulking purple skinned woman and Scorpia, walking jauntily, smile spread across her face and humming, Catra felt envious of their strength. Sure she'd shot up a few inches in the last couple of years, a growth spurt that had taken her by surprise, considering she had been the same small stature since she turned fourteen. She was still a ways off of Scorpia's height, but a good head taller than she had been.

When it had started to happen, she had chalked up her clothes getting too tight to her more active life as a gang master and eating anything she could get her hands on. That had explained her thicker biceps and legs, but not the broadening of her shoulders or the way her leggings covered less and less of her calves. She soon realised that she was, indeed, growing. And not just taller. Her body was changing in other ways.

When she had been in the Horde with Adora and Lonnie, she had watched as the human girls' bodies changed. They had got taller, curvier and grown breasts and started to get their own fur. She had been admonished, more than once, for looking at the other girls in the showers, but it had been fascinating and as a child she had wondered if they would become as furry as her. She had grown too, and her chest had grown a little but she didn't look like Adora. She was always very conscious of the fact that she could never measure up to Adora in anything she did, even her body was defective. Or so it seemed.

Yet, in the desert and turning nineteen her body had decided to metamorphose. She still didn't have particularly large breasts, apparently that was not a cat thing. What she did have, was

greater musculature, still wiry but much more defined, broader shoulders and her torso also lengthened, increasing her already impressive agility. The fur across her body also grew, at first she was disgusted. Throughout her childhood Shadow Weaver had made sure to tell her she was nothing but a mongrel, a filthy animal she had to put up with, and the longer, thicker fur reminded her of those words. Thinking about her fur brought her back to the present as she continued to scratch.

"You doing all right there, Wildcat?" Scorpia had sidled over to her, large pack perched on her shoulders and long braid hanging over her shoulder.

Scorpia had also changed while they had been out here. She dressed similarly to Catra and Huntara, in short pants, sleeveless shirts and a vest but all of hers were in bright, pastel colours and her hair had been allowed to grow and soften her face. Catra reached up and tucked a stray strand of white hair behind the scorpioni's ear, getting a soft smile in response.

In the early days, and it was still hard to believe that they had lived in the Waste for almost two years and gone from Horde deserters to gang lords to co-leaders of a united town, Catra and Scorpia had tried to be together. Catra wasn't sure, even now, if she would call it dating. Scorpia had been caring and supportive and her love had shone out with every word or action, once Catra let herself see it. But Catra had still been too jagged and broken to build anything permanent or that could last. They'd exchanged kisses and slept together, both having their first time with somebody they at least trusted, but after just three months they both realised that they weren't what each other needed. Scorpia was too soft, Catra too harsh in return.

It had ended on surprisingly good terms, Scorpia had been sweet and accepting while Catra…Catra had been kind. It meant that now they were still close, but Scorpia no longer looked at her like she hung the moon, and Catra could be pretty sure that she wasn't going to have her personal space invaded at any given opportunity.

“Yeah, I’m fine. Just sand in my fur itches like a bitch. I hope we find something out here soon.” Mismatched eyes scanned the barren landscape, looking for any trace of where the peculiar signal that they had received could have come from.

A week earlier some of the more tech savvy Horde deserters, who had been peppered throughout the Crimson Waste and were now together under her banner, had picked up a feint signal coming from deep in the desert. It was intermittent, stopping for days at a time only to return in long, low pulses. They had been searching for a signal to hack into the Fright Zone, a way to piggy-back into the fortress and sow dissent a little at a time.

With news of the signal, old rumours of abandoned ruins way out in the desert sand began to spread. Only old timers seemed to have any veracity to their words. Huntara had heard about them before, but chalked them up to heat visions (mirages, Catra had learned they were called). Catra had seen a lot of weird alien things while scavenging First Ones tech for Hordak, and also while hunting She-ra. Rumours of ruins, strange signals and isolated places all screamed First Ones to her. After all, that ship she’d abandoned Adora in had been one of their’s.

It had been decided that it was worth taking a look. As they had brought the various factions of the Waste together, sheer violence and force of will was not enough to keep it running. Bartering with the outside world was becoming a fact of life - new (old) technology could bring a pretty penny with intermediaries who might be willing to deal with the Horde. It wasn’t ideal, but making a new society was a messy affair where sometimes principles had to be put aside for practicality.

The group had already spent two nights in the desert, bundled together in one small tent. As hot and arid as the Waste was in the day, the nights were glacial. Conserving body heat was imperative, no matter how uncomfortable it made Catra. There was only ever one person she had felt comfortable sleeping beside, and Adora was a million miles away and a hundred years in the past. So, as well as the discomfort of itchy sand, cloying

heat and bitter cold, Catra was more tired than she'd like as they trekked through the emptiness.

Double Trouble held the small, boxy device that periodically emitted a beep as it caught the signal. They were heading in the right direction, if the increase in the strength and regularity of the beacon was anything to go by. The device had a small screen with an illuminated dot that gave them an indication of which direction to head but no more. The slick lizard had been a fairly new addition to their group. They had appeared one day in the shanty town, disguised as a Horde soldier - only to try to pick the wrong pocket and het caught by Catra. It's hard to trick a trickster. Their ability to shape shift had proved invaluable since, allowing them to take the characters of merchants and traders to be their link with the outside world. Without them, things would not run almost as smoothly. Within months they had become part of the team running the place. It would be easy to distrust them, that ability to be anyone and hear anything making many people uneasy in their presence.

Catra had felt that way only briefly, finding in DT a kindred spirit. As caustic and mean as herself and able to give as good as they got. They were a necessary foil for her, a living scratching post who could endure her barbs, whether them with barely a reaction, meaning she could be cordial more easily to others, like Scorpia. It was shocking how easy diplomacy was, when you didn't scream at the other side because you'd already run through that scenario with the best actor you know.

"Yo! DT! Any clue if we're getting close or not?" She raised her voice and called out to them clearly frustrated.

"No more than every other time you've bellowed at me, oh fearless leader." Mockery dripped from the words as a wide, toothy mouth formed into a smirk.

"Grrrr!" Catra kicked at the sand, needing to distract herself, suddenly breaking into a sprint. Pounding across the sand on all

fours, shocking Scorpia with the suddenness of her actions and moving passed Double Trouble in a blur.

She had always been fast, but her longer frame ate up the sand at lighting speed; arms stretching out and body coiling only to spring forward on her powerful legs. Sand spat out behind her, displaced by her movements as she got further and further away from the others until she could just make them out when she turned her head. She kept moving as she glanced behind and then the ground was no longer under her feet. The bottom dropped out of her world and she was falling, twisting her body in the air by instinct, spend bringing arms and legs together as her eyes met the ground and processed how long till she would hit. Just in time it all came together letting her hit the rocky ground in a crouch, absorbing the worst of the impact. Her feet ached, and her palms were scraped across the tender pads there, but she was fine.

Catra stood and stretched out her back, loosening the tenseness brought on by the threat of danger. She looked up, and up, seeing the cliff face that she had toppled down. It was sheer and at least two hundred feet, almost certainly a near fatal injury for anyone else who toppled over the edge. Still looking up she pulled out a communicator and called Scorpia, warning the others to be on their guard and that they would need the rope that Huntara had packed. Getting confirmation that she had been heard, she turned to survey her surroundings.

The area was vast, surrounding her on all sides. The cliffs around her had a gentle curve and every wall was tall and smooth. It was almost as though a giant had stamped down a foot in the desert and left an impression. There was sand on the ground, but it was sparse and interspersed with large, exposed rocks and gravel. Catra felt herself drawn over to the far side, where a pile of jagged boulders seemed to be stacked up against one of the cliffs. Catra’s mind whirled as she realised that they would make for a far easier escape out of the place. She pulled out the coms again and instructed them to make their way around the edge of the crater.

After walking for long enough that she could now make out the sound of the others up top, she reached the boulder wall. Now, on closer inspection, it wasn't a pile of rocks. It was clearly a landslide. These rocks had fallen haphazardly from higher on the rock wall to cover something. The smell of the desert as dry and earthy, the scent coming from around the rocks was metallic and mechanical. Something was being concealed. Her gaze sharpened, even as Huntara began to lower a rope, to something glinting close to the landslide.

Walking away from there the others had started to climb down, she crouched in the dirt and reached out a hand to dust away the sand t hat concealed the glinting object. Claws extended, she slid them beneath the edge of the metal sheet and flicked it up into her hand. Her eyes grew hard as she saw the familiar red, double wings of the Horde. The metal was tarnished and worn, clearly old and the metal had lost its colour in the sun but the symbol was unmistakable. Once upon a time, the Horde had been in this place.

Several hours passed as the group pitched their tent and set out camp in the centre of the crater where the ground was at its flattest. It was clear that this was the origin of the signal as the beeps on DT's device were going crazy, to a point that they turned it off to save their sanity. Catra had shown them the scrap she had found and explained the scent change coming from the landslide. DT had been charged with camp, while the three women began to try to remove the large rocks, hoping to locate some kind of cave or craft.

Progress was slow, for each rock removed another was revealed. They took care not to move any rock that looked like it would cause a further landslide and crush them. Finally, sweat pouring off of them, the three diggers dragged themselves over to Double Trouble where they collapsed onto the ground and gratefully took a pull of water and a bag of rations. Catra's claws ached from scrambling to gain purchase on the stones and her frustration was

mounting again. She chewed silently at the sawdust-like food in her mouth and forced it down, taking another draw on her canteen.

Catra was the first to spring to her feet and move back to the wall, hauling almost frantically at stone after stone, looking for that one which would allow a glimpse at what lay beneath. This time it was DT who joined her, shifting their body into Huntara's form and hauling rocks. They lacked the stamina of the actual Huntara, but could sustain a brisk pace for a little while as their own body was tricked into believing the muscle was real.

They traded barbs at each other as they worked, falling into the rapport that they had developed. Catra was almost certain that the flamboyant shifter was interested in her, they were caustic and scathing towards her, as they were to everyone, but there was always a flirtatious edge in their interactions that she never noticed with the others. It was flattering to be desired, different to what Scorpia's moon eyed devotion had been, and she flirted back but it meant nothing. Sure, Double Trouble was sexy and alluring, but Catra felt nothing real towards them beyond friendship. A part of her had started to wonder if perhaps she just wasn't meant for love or relationships. Things hadn't worked with Scorpia, and she couldn't see feeling that way about anyone else. Anyone, except HER. But she couldn't think about that.

A big haul sent her reeling back, boulder in her arms. She landed on her back and the rock hit her stomach, causing all the air to leave her lungs in a 'oof' of air. Double Trouble pulled the rock off of her and dragged her to her feet, now back in their familiar black clad form.

"Look what you did, Kitten." How she hated that nickname, and anyone else she would claw the tongue out of their mouth, but DT got away with a look.

Look Catra did. A large, dark, hole had been revealed. The boulder that had pinned her had dislodged others and rather than causing a further collapsed it had revealed only darkness. The

aperture was still small, far too small for Huntara or Scorpia to enter, but Catra and DT were both lithe and wiry enough to fit through small spaces. Scorpia tried to dissuade them, siting the danger of further collapse and what could be lurking inside.

"Scorp, we have to investigate. DT and I will take comms, rope and torches down there. You and Huntara wait up here, you can figure some way to keep the rocks from shifting." She laid a reassuring hand on Scorpia's shoulder. She didn't have a death wish, not anymore, and needed her friend to know that. She noticed that DT looked apprehensive, but made no attempt to get out of going into the dark.

Equipped with water, torches and rope, they eased into the hole. Catra took the lead, her eyes able to adjust to the darkness almost instantly and letting her assess the area for any sign of danger. There was a small drop, just a couple of metres, but could have caused a nasty spill if they didn't realise. She jumped down and then reached up to guide Double Trouble down with care. The tall blond flicked on a torch and illuminate a vast expanse of low ceilings and shimmering ground. Beginning to walk, the roof skimming across the top of Catra's head, while Double trouble had to stoop, their feet clanged metallically and they shared a look.

Whatever they were walking on was a continuous sheet of metal. Not rock. Both lowered to their knees and ran their hands over the surface under the torchlight. It was cool to the touch and etched with razor thin grooves. They moved further into the darkness, dropping down at intervals to look for a way in. There was no way to even get a claw tip in any of the groves.

"What is this?" Double Troubles voice echoed around them eerily.

"I have no idea." Mechanical, no doubt, but too huge to be anything she had ever seen before. "But I can smell something weird, well, weirder, this way." She led the way, DT at her heels.

They moved cautiously, the acrid smell of melted, scorched metal becoming more and more distinct. It was something she had

smelt a lot in the Fight Zone when she and the others would sneak out to the foundry and watch the liquid metal be poured. Down here, in the narrow dark, it couldn't mean anything good.

Double Trouble moved the torch to their other hand and momentarily lit up the roof, revealing deep, thick gauges there. They cut trenches everywhere. Something else had been here.

"Stay behind me." Catra's skin was prickly, her fur lifting.

"I had no intention to be anywhere else." They tried for haughty but still sounded as shaken as she felt.

Clanging echoing around them was disorienting and she almost missed the twisted metal. She stopped just in time to prevent them from toppling downwards, reaching out her arm to stop DT, one fall a day was enough. She lay on her belly and took out her own torch, shuffling to the rolled and deformed edge, and peered down and down. The torchlight bounced off the interior, showing that the same irregular hole had been cut through another floor, and another, and another. Whatever this thing was it was big, going deep into the earth. It was reminiscent of the holding cells of the Horde, which Catra knew too well.

"We're going to need that rope." Catra took the coil that was held out and cinched it securely around one of the smooth imperfections that had been created by the intrusion.

The feline swung down, swiftly moving to the bottom of the borehole. She tugged the line and DT slid down the cord that she pull taught. When their feet hit the ground, both torches were switched on as they looked around the place. It was devastated. The walls were covered in protruding wires where panels had been ripped off the walls and then roughly discarded on the floor. A pair of doors to their right had been brutally forced open, the corners peeled back like paper, allowing enough room for them to crawl through. On the other side they wished they hadn't.

Row after row of coffin shaped boxed lined the large, hanger sized area. There were too many to count, reaching into the darkness beyond the reach of therein torches. Some had their covers pried off and discarded into the walkway, forcing them to step gingerly over them. Catra shone her torch into one of those and found a desiccated corpse, throat slit and the ancient remnants of rusty brown blood covering the insides of the metal box. The flesh had shrunk to the bones, mummifying the person inside. DT turned their face away, walking further into the dark and noting that the further they went, fewer of the boxed were missing lids, instead having the window at the top over the face of the inhabitant shattered and the faces if those inside bashed in leaving watered, obliterated faced.

Catra was rooted to the spot at the first box. They may not have been built as coffins, but that was what they had become. The petrified body in front of her had sharp teeth showing from receded gums and fur that still clung to every inch of the shrivelled flesh. Large ears, now leathery bracketed the face. Without conscious thought her hand reached out and softly touched the long claws that tipped the hand.

"Kitten, they're all dead. Whoever broke in here didn't want to leave any survivors." DT could see how shaken Catra was and didn't elaborate on how the others had died.

"They're magicats, DT. I thought they were just a legend and I was some kind of throwback freak!" She punched her hand into the side of the pod, feeling instantly bad to have desecrated this place. "What did the Horde do?"

Double trouble rested their hand on her shoulder and squeezed. Nobody had ever seen a magicat, the name a think of folklore of a group of creatures who had been around with the first ones and disappeared around the same time. To be in the presence of so many bodies was humbling. Catra had her head in her hands, DT scanned their torch around the edge of the room.

Was that another door?

The shifter moved away, heading towards the newly revealed door. The area around it was blackened and gauged but the door was still intact. “Kitten, I think you should get over here!” Their call reverberated around the tomb.”

Catra’s head shot up and she pulled herself together, stalking over to where the tall form of the lizard was cast into silhouette. She saw the signs of the aggression that had been levelled at the wall around the door. It was impressive that this door had held, she wondered what was behind it.

She raised her hand to trace come symbols that had evaded the blasts and cuts. She wanted to know what they meant but they were as alien to her as the rest of the ship. Her palm rested against the cool metal, trailing down when a light blazed to life under her hand. She jerked away, looking at the rectangular panel fade and go dead again, looking like the rest of the wall around her. DT tried, placing their hand over the same spot and nothing happened, they even tried shifting into Catra’s form but the panel remained dark. They grasped Catra’s wrist and placed her hand back onto the panel which once again came to life.

This time, Catra did not pull away and a whirring noise began softly beside the door. The light changed from white to green and with a beep the doors began to pull apart. Catra took her hand away now, eyes wide and fixed on the space between. The doors continue to move sluggishly before a squealing grinding sound happened and they stopped. The gap between them was big enough to walk through and as they did, cool white lights flickered, obviously motion activated, around them. Both of them froze.

This room was smaller, filled with more of the boxes but there was little sign of disturbance here. There were, perhaps, a two hundred or so boxes here, nothing like the volume in the outer room. The biggest difference that they noticed from the doorway was that these were a range of sizes. Larger ones, like the ones in the main chamber, were arranged around the edge in a circular

configuration, surrounding smaller and smaller ones. Neither of them wanted to move for fear of what they might find.

Slowly, as though she were afraid that her very presence would turn everything in the room to dust, she walked to the first box and peered inside. She fell to her knees and DT looked into the same window. Inside, sleeping peacefully, was a youthful figure. They looked like Catra, just as young and cat-like and the movement of their chest showing they were very much alive.

Catra crawled on her knees into the inner circle and moved to look into the window of a smaller box and a strangled sound escaped her throat as she looked into the face of a sleeping kitten. She had never seen another face that looked like her own, and within the space of minutes she had seen a corpse, a youth and now a child. It was almost more than her mind could take. The smallest containers were beside her, a dozen crib sized pods that held babies. Babies.

"Kitten, there's something wrong here." What wasn't wrong? Catra looked up and saw that DT was standing over one of the smaller pods and looking down with an inscrutable look on their face.

She joined them and saw that one of the pods was empty, its cover loosened and leaning against the side. There was no sign of the toddler that must have been inside, given the size. One of the kittens had been taken. Somebody had gotten into the room after all.

"How old were you when the Horde got you?" It was rare to hear anything like sympathy in the shifters voice.

"Really, really young." Adora had found her in a box about to be discarded by Shadow Weaver.

"I think this might belong to you, kitten."

It took days to get more people to the crater. They had managed to scrape together a handful of vehicles that could manage the terrain and ferry more than a hundred children and youths back to the town. It had been surprising how keen the former gang members had been to lend a hand to save the children. Whether it was loyalty to Catra or just a need to help children, it was appreciated.

Only Catra and Double Trouble had spent any time in the mysterious subterranean place. When the time came to start waking the children, they led a few more of the smaller mercenaries down and started with the infants. The babies were removed from the pods and strapped to the torsos of the rescuers, most being removed two at a time. It took little time and then they moved on to the toddlers. What was clear was that, on removal, the children were still mostly asleep and easily manoeuvred without a fuss. By the afternoon of the first day, all of the youngest children had been ferried back to the town. While the others took a break up top, Catra stayed behind.

The magicat had not emerged from the chamber since she and DT discovered it four days before. She couldn't drag herself away from these young people. Each time she had been left alone she had walked up to one box or another and just watched the sleeping faces of these orphans. Her kin. Some were light in colour, others mottled a handful of colours. She wished she could see their eyes. None of the younger children had woken enough to open their eyes and she wished she could see if any of them shared her heterochromia.

It was the older youths that she spent most of her time watching. She was barely twenty, at least that's what she thought, and it was clear that most of them were around her age. There weren't many of these older youths, perhaps twenty older teens but at least they might have some answers. She'd found herself drawn to one girl in particular, who seemed to be the oldest. Her fur was black, shining purple when the light hit and her hair was woven into a myriad of tiny braids. Something about the sleeping girl

called to her. Maybe it was the hope of meeting somebody who was old enough to give her some answers?

It took another half a day to clear out the under tens and then all that was left were forty-five boxes containing the teens of various ages. It was decided that they would begin the last part of the evacuation in the morning. The older the child, the more they seemed to wake up when taken out of the pod, still confused and easily handle, but it had got progressively more difficult to them back to the surface. The hope was that the adolescents would be awake enough to give them some answers about this place, whatever it was.

Scorpia had tried to cajole her out of the hole over the com, worry evident in her voice but she had refused. There was obviously something very wrong with sleeping beside a graveyard, but she just couldn't leave these children unprotected. It was clear that it had happened once, and she had been taken - that wouldn't happen again. The first night she hadn't slept, just haunting the room and looking in on every sleeping face, wondering who they were to her. Were any of these her brothers? Sisters? Cousins? Had her parents been out in that room? On the second night those questions had brought her to her knees and brought tears to her eyes that had run down her face in salty tracks, but at least she managed to sleep.

This was the last night she would spend down here, and sleep was again out of her grasp. There were fewer people to check on, so she found herself looking at the walls. She had seen that there was a black screen, almost blending with the wall, on the first day but had been too preoccupied to explore. Now she approached and ran her hands over the area that jutted out underneath, light coming to life under them as they had with the door. She looked at all the button sized lights, seeing writing that she couldn't decipher. She growled and punched down onto the board, jumping back when the screen flashed brightly.

Her eyes were transfixed to the scene playing over and over on the screen…

…Hooks grasped onto the join of the doors and they were pulled apart, the whining of motors like a defiant scream against the intrusion. They were no match for the hydraulics that cracked them apart. A helmeted Horde soldier walked through the opening and scanned the room, seeing children. They sheathed the knife that they held in their hand, even in the old footage clearly stained with blood spilled in the other room. The clank of their footsteps filled the audio as they walked between the pods, looking into smaller and smaller windows in a parody of her actions just days before.

"Commander, we have found a room full of children. Shall we dispatch them like the adults before we start to bring up the tech?" The gruff voice was unfamiliar as it spoke into the communicator with somebody at the Horde.

"Kittens, not children, Force Captain. These are animals, invaders too stupid to wake when they landed here." The voice was a boogeyman, the sound of terror that crawled up her spine as Shadow Weaver pondered the fate of innocents. Catra's ears flattened to her head as she watched. "Bring me a small one. Let's see if they have any worth, they could be useful attack animals with the claws and teeth. A small one, mind you Force Captain. Not an infant though, I have no time for mewling babies, now that Adora has grown." There was nothing but raw loathing in that voice.

Catra watched with wide eyes as another soldier can in and together they walked to a small pod and tore the cover off, lifting out a small bundle of fur by the scruff of its neck and carrying it out as though it was something contaminated - far from their bodies and with little care.

The time code on the footage continued to count down as she heard the sounds of metal being torn and plundered and the ominous sound of glass shattering in the adjoining room, It made Catra, far in the future, flinch with every sound. She sat for hours watching the screen as nothing happened. The sound had died a long time ago. The Horde soldiers had left a lamp in the room

which remained illuminated after the motion sensor went dead. Our after hour she waited. They would not have left all of this behind. There was far more tech that they could plunder and all these other potential soldiers.

A cacophony of sound hit the speakers so unexpectedly that Catra flinched and threw up her arms to protect herself from the phantom threat. On the screen the there were some screams which quickly died and a plume of dust puffed through the open doors. The camera shook and then the doors slowly crept closed from the vibration…

Catra woke up the next morning having fallen asleep on the floor with her back against the dark girl's pod, eyes fixed on the screen only to see the screen had gone black. All she could assume was that the landslide they had cleared had been caused by the Horde's heavy handed actions and then this mission had been abandoned. Maybe they had had no use for this technology.

Maybe she had been so much of a disappointment that Shadow Weaver had decided not to waste any more effort on children like her. Maybe her shortcomings had saved them all from suffering the same fate as her.

Maybe it was ok that she had endured so much, for them.

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"…After we relocated the children to the town, as it was then, it was like a fire had been lit under us all . We may have been a crowd of criminals, mercenaries and deserters but what we saw down in that pit was genocide. No one could condone that.

There hadn't been children in the Waste before. Now there were almost two hundred. None of us were so low that we would murder children, but it seemed as though the Horde had intended to and be stymied by circumstance. It was then that we all made the decision that the Horde had to be stopped. That all of the children who were there, or who had grown there, needed a

chance.” Double Trouble paused, taking note of Catra’s far away expression and the horror on the faces opposite. Horror and incredulity from some. That troubled them, how could you hear about that and feel anything but horror?

“That’s…just…disgusting.” Mermista’s usually blasé tone was shaken.

“Yes.” Scorpia spoke now, voice gravelly with tears even now, so many years later. “Catra and I made a plan to take down the Horde right then. We found a lot of amazing technology down there and suddenly we were a force to be reckoned with, galvanised by loathing.”

Catra noticed that along with Bow, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma, Adora was weeping as she kept her eyes fixed on her and the sleeping kitten.

“We can tell you more. But I think that’s enough for today.” Catra’s voice was low but carried through them all and this time there was no defiance.

They all started stood, readying to leave, when Frosta spoke. “What was that place?”

“The last hope of the magicat’s, the Halfmoon. It was an ark full of the last of my people and it crashed here, in the desert, a thousand years ago.”

“The last…”

“There are more of us now than there were seven years ago.” Catra kissed Yarsha’s head as she spoke, she wasn’t the only new kitten born since then. Just one of the first.

There was a pained silence as they left with a promise to come back and hear more the next day. Catra walked home with Yarsha in her arms and Scorpia by her side, into the orphanage. Yarsha stirred as they walked through the door and the trio were

swarmed by a gaggle of excited kittens, hatchlings and children. Catra sank to her knees and let herself be engulfed by them all.

The rest of the day was spent playing games that the other magicats had taught her over the years. The building was filled with shouting and laughter, sometimes on the run and others while sitting around in a group. Many of the other adults joined in as they returned from work and dinner time was spent with children and adults alike sharing their day with the people that they loved. It was cathartic after the painful memories of the afternoon.

Yarsha's bedtime came too soon. She carried the kitten up through the throngs of other children wishing her goodnight, and got to their room. She left Yarsha pulling off her clothes, while she went to fill the bath with a shallow amount of warm water. Before she could go and fetch the little ball of fur, she was attacked from behind by a naked laughing ball. The two of them tumbled playfully, and eventually the little girl was doubled over laughing as she was gently tickled before being placed into the water. It barely covered her legs, but she splashed happily anyway.

Catra washed the little one efficiently, not wanting her to get too cold, before pulling her out and wrapping her in a huge, fluffy towel so that only her face was peeking out. She pressed their foreheads together and chuffed which got her a bop on the nose in returned. She placed the wrapped bundle on the sink counter and efficiently cleaned needle sharp little teeth before vigorously rubbing every bit of water out of tortoiseshell fur.

By the time Yarsha was dressed in her pyjamas, she was yawning and snuggling. "I sleep in da big bed, Ra?" He voice was foggy and her eyes were drooping closed.

"Of course you can, sweet girl." A happy little 'mrrp' left the toddler who was almost asleep already. Catra pulled down the blankets and placed her in the centre, carefully tucking her in before she laid, still clothed beside Yarsha, on top of the linens and remembered.

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With few kittens left, it had been decided that they would wake the oldest looking kittens first, hoping that they would be able to explain the situation to them and then get their help with the others. There was no way to manhandle them out of the pit as they had with the more portable inhabitants for the room. Catra had felt compelled to be the one to wake the ebony furred girl. The lid came open with surprising ease and she reached in, hand hovering over a furred cheek, before detouring to land on her shoulder and gently squeeze.

"Hey, you need to wake up. We're here to help." Catra's voice was soft, the tone the same that she had used with the smaller children that she had tried to rouse.

The body under her hands began to tremble, fingers beginning to flex as she woke slowly. Catra watched as her throat bobbed as she swallowed and a big yawn broke out, revealing her long canines that seemed startlingly white against the darkness of her fur. If that was stark, when her eyes fluttered open, revealing eyes so green that they seemed to glow was mesmerising, and Catra found herself unable to look away, nearly resulting in her getting headset as the other girl began to sit up. Finding her wits just in time, Catra jerked back and helped the girl to sit up. She noticed, vaguely, that several of the other teens were also now sitting.

"Hey, you feel all right?" Catra kept her voice low, almost reverent as she spoke to this hypnotic girl.

"What…". The girl's voice was gravelly and Catra passed her a canteen that she accepted gratefully. "What's going on? This wasn't the protocol?"

Those words let Catra know that she had been right, that this girl would be of use to them in figuring out everything that this place alluded to. Without waiting for a response, the other girl crawled out of the pod and shakily found her feet. Without thinking, Catra

moved forward and steadied her, noting that the darker girl had a couple of inches on her own increased height.

"Steady there, you need to give your body a minute. You've been down here for a really long time."

"Down?" There was a slither of panic in her voice now.

"We found you all in a cavern in the desert." Her words seemed to do nothing to ease the panic.

"We're supposed to be in space. We're supposed to be on our way to a new home planet." Her hand came up to grasp the necklace that lay at her throat, holding it like a lifeline.

"Whatever your people had planned, that was a long time ago. You and the other children are all that are left." There was no gentle way to drop that bombshell, and they needed somebody who knew what was going on to help them.

Green eyes grew wider as she finally seemed to see Catra, scanning her face and reaching out to run a dark finger along the stripes on her arm. Her eyes roamed her features before locking with her eyes and a devastating realisation filled them.

"Alcea…are you Alcea?" Catra swallowed, momentarily lost for words. Had that been her name?

"I don't know. I was taken from here when I was very small. I didn't even remember this existed until a few days ago when we found you." She gestured to the motley crew of other species who were talking softly to the other teens. Green eyes followed and looked startled at these clearly alien faces.

"You can only be little Alcea. There were no other younglings with eyes like yours. I used to sit you on my knee and read you stories when I looked after you for your parents." Her eyes looked glassy now and Catra felt like if she moved she would shatter. "You said we are all that's left? Where are the elders?" It was clear that she had already guessed the answer.

“They were murdered when I was taken. They were still asleep. It would have been swift.” It was no reassurance at all. “I think you might be one of the oldest. I was hoping you could help us figure out your technology, get a manifest of the children?” She didn’t say that she wanted to know about herself, in that moment it barely seemed important as she watched this strong girl gather herself as best she could.

“Of course. If the adults are gone, Phibin,” She indicated a stout white young male with a large bullseye of red around one eye, “and I are the oldest. Though I guess you might be the eldest now, Alcea.”

“Catra. My name is Catra. How old are the pair of you, what’s your name?” A long fingered hand settled her check as the former cadet had to hold in the urge to purr at the softness of the gesture.

“They really took everything from you, didn’t they?” Then the taller girl was moving forward and resting her forehead against Catra’s ruddy brown one. It was something she used to do to Adora when she felt a well of sadness or affection, never knowing why she felt compelled to do it. It seemed it was something she had known as an infant. “I’m Tace, you used to call me Tree because of my eyes and because you couldn’t say my name.” She pulled away with sad eyes that looked older than her age. “Phibin and I are nineteen. We were instructed in how to access everything on the ship, some of the others too, in case of a worst case scenario.”

‘I’m twenty.” It seemed important that this girl, this Tace, should know that.

“Twenty.” A black furred hand reached for her own at her side, a fluffy and luxurious tail twining with her wrist, and led her towards the monitor where she had seen her own kidnapping. “Let’s get that information then.”

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Catra rolled over and pulled Yarsha to her, sighing deeply as she thought about the girl who had once, a thousand years ago, cared for a tiny version of her, and the woman who had been so brave in the face of near annihilation that she could love the broken thing Catra had become.

Chapter End Notes

> This is the first of many trips to the past that will intercut the present - and don't worry Catradora content is coming.

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

A pinch of Adora-trauma and more Tace.

Curled up into a ball on her bed, covers pulled up to her chin, Adora tried to shut out the noise in her head. Hearing how Double Trouble and Catra had found the last of the magicats had been harrowing, even in their bare-bones retelling of it. Though the shape shifter had clearly been sticking to the facts - at times almost clinical in their explanation - they had not been able to soften the blow of murdered innocents and orphaned children. When they had come to Catra, and her kidnapping from the place, the others only saved from Shadow Weaver's wrath by a freak landslide, Adora hadn't been able to stop the tears that had scolded a path down her face.

One of her most treasured childhood memories had been finding Catra. She's been around four at the time and already in the same bunk room as Rogelio, Kyle and Lonnie. The big lizard man had been nothing but a tiny crawling lizard, barely looking any different to the little animals that they sometimes found scuttling around the shower block, except for his little uniform bib. They had gone to lessons in classrooms where they had been taught how to handle weapons and the basics of reading and writing. Most of their time had been spent playing, or what passed for playing in the Horde. They had played 'hide from the princess' and target practice, all the while Shadow Weaver looming over them to heap praise on her shoulders or gentle admonition when she wasn't prefect.

She had snuck out one night, hungry and knowing that she was unlikely to be caught creeping into the mess hall, and even if she was Shadow Weaver would stroke her head and tell her she was a good girl for using her skills. She had been in the deserted kitchen area, climbing up on the counter to fetch a grey ration bar when she had heard a whimpering sound. She had jumped and

squeaked herself, at first, worried that it was a mouse, but when the sound had come again, followed by some feint rustling, she jumped down from the counter and scampered to the door on socked feet.

She remembered pushing the creaky door open just enough to get out, pulling a stool over to hold it open and then she had been outside. It was dark and murky out there in the night, scarier than a place you grew up in should be. When her eyes adjusted she had seen a pile of garbage sitting beside the door. There were flies buzzing around bags and boxes and a rancid, decaying smell that made her curl her button nose. Seeing nothing, she had turned to go back, her feet were cold though her socks and starting to feel a little damp, when one of the boxes shuddered and toppled off of the pile.

Adora stepped back warily, ready to run in case an evil princess came out to get her. She was brave though, so she stood her ground, little fists balled, eyes glaring at the twitching box. That's when the box had tumbled a second time, and two huge ears had peeked out of the opening. As though drawn by a siren song, young Adora had found herself moving forward until she was looking over the edge of the big box. Inside was a trembling ball of dirty fur. Other than the ears it was hard to tell what the little thing looked like. It was so tightly coiled and the fur dirty and matted.

Cautiously the little blond reached out a hand and touched one of the ears, it felt like velvet. Then two enormous eyes were glowing up at her, bright in the darkness, one blue and the other yellow. They blinked up at her fearfully and she gave them a big, gap-toothed grin.

"Hello." Adora's voice was loud in the night and the thing cowered way into the corner of the large box. "Oh, don't be scared. I'm a good guy. I'll protect you!" Because that's who she had believed they were, the good guys, saving the world from the tyranny of the princesses. It made her adult incarnation sick to think of it.

A tail had uncoiled and the ball of dirty fur had turned out to be a child, much smaller than her with cat-like features. It was a little girl, she could see, because it was naked and she realised that the reason it was shaking was from the cold. With all her four year old strength, she had put her arms underneath the toddler's armpits and hoisted her up before clumsily stagger-carrying her into the kitchen and down the hall to a supply room. She found a blanket and wrapped the silent form in a blanket and gave her a ration bar she had stuffed in her pocket. Sharp little teeth nibbled it and then the face creased in disgust and spat it out.

"Yucky." It was the first thing it had said.

"Hey, you can talk! I'm Adora, what's your name?"

"You not cat." The mismatched eyes looked wary.

"No, I'm a human. Is your name Cat?" The smaller girl just pouted and shrugged. "How about I call you Catra, like I'm Adora. We can be the same and then you won't be on your own."

She had thought that the toddler had made an affirmative sound, little face drooping as she had fallen asleep leant up against the wall.

That had been how they had met and become fast friends. She had never really thought about the implications of finding Catra naked and filthy in the garbage. Now, after having heard what Double Trouble had told them about how they had found the children and what they had seen on the security footage, she just felt sick. No wonder Shadow Weaver had always treated the magicat like dirt, she had intended to throw the little girl away.

Adora had no love lost between her and her former mentor. She gave her a wide birth in the halls of Brightmoon. She was horrified by the things that she had seen Shadow Weaver do during the war. Sometimes she thought about what had been intended for her, and she would have to do all she could not to fall victim to a panic attack. Thinking about how Shadow Weaver had lived in the

relative luxury of her ‘cell’ in the palace, while Scorpia and Catra escaped to an existence out in the desert made her feel more guilty than ever. Without even a trial, the former second in command of the Horde had become just a part of the daily life of the castle, kept away from King Micah and Adora but still allowed to be a part of life there, even if she could never leave the grounds.

Adora often wondered what the red robed woman had done to deserve such kind treatment when she had never offered the same, and she was still wondering.

Thinking about the murder of people sleeping peacefully in their pods, of the way that the children had been left behind with every intention of killing them if they proved not to be useful, and how Catra had been destined for the incinerator all those years ago left her feeling sick and tired to her bones. She pulled the comforter over her head and pressed her eyes tightly closed against the pounding in her head as she let herself be drawn down into the undertow of sleep…

….fire lapped at her legs, searing pains running along the nerves as her pants melted into her skin. She tried to scream but heat raced down her throat, burning away her vocal cords and making her lungs explode in her chest. Tears tried to escape her eyes - turning to ash before they could ever touch her cheeks…

…she watched from a million miles away. Blackness all around as she surged towards a nebulous vortex of pinks and golds, hurtling towards a planet far below. The air was sucked out of her lungs and her skin turned cold and hard as diamond. The surface of the planet surged closer and closer, everything blurring around her. She tried to bring her arms up to shield her face. She struck the stoney ground and shattered into a million diamond-bright pieces…

…white and red and gold and black bodies pressed against her. Warm and furred, gentle purrs lulling her deeper and deeper into sleep. A long tail curled around her hand and she felt herself

tugged along as her eyes opened and she found herself on an empty street. He feet stumbled as she was pulled along behind a chestnut coloured kitten, moving so fast that she was almost a blur. She lurched forwards as the kitten released her hand and disappeared into a crowd of other small magicats.

She peered closely at each one. Desperately seeking a face that was familiar, she rushed to first, then another, spinning them to face her. Finding herself looking into nothing but a blank mask of nothingness….

…Catra was nothing more than a kitten, throat held tightly in Shadow Weaver's long fingered hand. Adora watched, helpless and unable to move, as the little magicat was brought up to eye level with her assailant, feet and tail hanging limply. All the fight in her was gone. Adora tried to beg for her little friend but no words came, as though her voice had been stolen.

Shadow Weaver turned the kitten to face her friend, pulling her into her body in a parody of a hug as her other hand came up, a long wicked blade glinting in the light. As it came to the kitten's neck, moving across fur and flesh. Adora screamed…

…Adora screamed and jerked up in bed, throwing the comforter off and clutching at her chest where her heart pounded so hard she feared it would break free. She was dizzy and disorientated. So lost in the haze of her whirling nightmares she didn't hear the person walk up to the bed, softly saying her name. Was unaware that she wasn't alone until she was pulled into the comfortingly real form of a warm body, a hand cupping the back of her head as she broke down in tears that soaked into her companions' shoulder.

Glimmer looked up at Bow, still frozen in the doorway. They had been heading to the blond's room, not having seen her since they returned to the hotel, and wanted to make sure she would come down for dinner. They had heard the scream from a little way down the hall and run to her aid. The Princess had feared there

was an attack, and been taken aback by the sight of nothing but Adora wearing an expression of defeated terror.

"Adora," Glimmer whispered, sounding much more like the young girl who had taken in a Horde cadet. "Hey, everything's ok. We're here."

Catra strolled from Bazaar with purpose, all the commotion of the day before meant that she was looking at a big pile of unfinished work. Being the chief of the police force was interesting and challenging, something that she needed less she get bored and get into trouble. It had actually been Tace who suggested that this should be the role she take in the new world they were building together. The wiser, more level headed woman (and how she missed that foil for her own hot tempered nature) had found her reticence to represent the former Horde on the council, after the collapse of the Fright Zone, puzzling but never challenged it. Eventually she had understood. She couldn't let all of Catra's skills be wasted though and once a system of law and order was established she had put Catra forward to run it. They had been a powerful pair, Tace taking the reins as chief of the magicats while Catra kept the peace.

Passing Phibin in his boutique, she detoured in. The younger man, though not by much, had changed a lot over the years. When she first found them he had been selfish and youthfully arrogant. His sense of self importance had grated on her and his attitude to Tace had earned him a set of claw marks and several black eyes along the way. The Phibin of eight years before and the twenty-seven year old man before her were as different as a person could be. He was now a pudgy, finely groom cat with a passion for fashion and a confusing relationship with Double Trouble that more often than not left Catra scratching her head.

"Morning Phibs, got anything pretty in for my girl?" She ran her fingers over some of the fine silk he always seem to have, how

even she wasn't sure. It wasn't her speed, but Yar-Yar loved the frilly dresses he sold for children.

"Nothing new at the mo, Chief. How is the cutest kitty in Oasis?" All of the orphans of the Halfmoon had a soft spot for Tace's child.

"She's great, spending the day with Rogelio and Kyle." It sometimes felt strange to share such mundane conversation, as a brash youth she would have turned her nose up at small talk bit a lot of water had flowed under that bridge and now banal normality was a comfort.

"Well, you know if you ever need me to, she could spend the day here with me. I'm sure she'd like to play with the scraps in the fabric room." The mental image of Yarsha rolling around and batting at ribbons popped into her head and made her smile.

"I'm sure when she's a little bigger I won't be able to keep her out of here Phibs."

"How are you? I heard that the people who you used to be at war with are here," there was no need to ask how he knew, the gossip spread faster than the heat in Oasis.

"It's nothing to worry about, just moving up our timetable for reintegration a little sooner that we'd planned." She wasn't quite so confident that all was well, but no point spreading panic.

Phibs got closer to her and raised his hand to her cheeks, she let him, holding back her instinct to flinch away. Some habits were hard to break. He brought her forehead to his and gave her a slow blink. "I know that you're strong, but if you need to talk, cat-to-cat, I know I'm not Tace, but I'm here."

Catra had to leave, lest she end up blubbering. They had all come so far, so fast. Phibin watched her leave as though he had scared her, and maybe he had, he knew she struggled with affection. He turned back to his little slice of the world and walked into the making room, maybe he had enough of that gorgeous red taffeta to knock out a tiny dress.

Catra quickened her pace, finally seeing the office ahead, she couldn't help but think of Tace, Phibs kind words taking her back to when they were all so young.

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Catra had planned to head back to the ship alone. And hadn't that been a brain bender, to learn that she was not from here. One thing to be a sacrifice that helped protect the others from the clutches of a personal monster, another to learn they should never have been there at all. When confronted by Scorpia, worry etched across her open face, about why she was going back, she had claimed it was for the tech. That was part of it, but certainly not the real reason. That was obvious to everyone. Catra, having been tantalised with a hint of the past, couldn't resist the allure of finding out more.

Throwing together the supplies she'd need for several days in the desert, and in the pit, on a sled that she had borrowed from a gruffly sympathetic Tung Lashor (and hadn't him turning out to be a reliable guy, after all the resentment petered out, been a surprise?) She'd started out of the door of her tiny alcove. It was a small, cramped space barely big enough for her narrow cot, foot locker and desk, but it was all she needed. Bizarrely it reminded her of all the tiny, cramped spaces she'd found comfort and solace in as a small child growing up in fear; the small places of safety. Picking up her mask from the bed and placing it on like the armour it was, she made for the door.

A figure was there, blocking the light streaming in from outside, pushing back the thin threadbare curtain that acted as a door. Catra tensed at the intrusion. Nobody was foolish enough to invade her space, door or no door, yet here stood somebody who had done just that. Claws extended, she refrained from lashing out when it registered who this intruder was. Silhouetted by the bright sunlight outside, Tace was little more than a silhouette. The only part of her providing any colour, her startling green eyes.

“What are you doing here? Get out!” She bit the words our harshly, angry at somebody invading her sanctuary and regretted it as soon as she noticed the younger girl flinch and begin to pull back as she spoke. Tace was almost gone before Catra found her wits and called to her.

“Wait! Wait. I’m sorry I got angry… I’m not used to people coming in here…It’s something I’m working on.” Her arm was outstretched in supplication to the taller girl who had stopped walking away but had yet to turn around.

They stayed that way for a while, until Tace’s shoulder’s dropped and she turned around, eyes downcast as she bowed her head, not making eye contact with Catra. The former cadet felt a pang in her chest at the display of submission. Once, not long ago, she would have revelled in the feeling of power and domination over somebody else; all she had ever wanted since she was a child, beaten down by almost everyone around her, now it just felt hollow. The young woman in front of her had lost everything and to delight in her felling small brought bile to her throat.

“Hey, Tace, look at me.” Big green eyes met her own and the black furred woman chewed on her lip. “How can I help you?” That was what a normal person would say, she was pretty sure, if somebody came to their door.

“Oh, I heard that you were heading back to Halfmoon.” Her eyes darted away, and then she firmed her jaw and her resolve. Catra couldn’t help but notice how the light shimmered across her glossy fur with the movement. “I wanted to come with you. I know the layout and how the technology works. There is a lot of stuff there that could help you make this place better for all of us.”

How could she say no? Catra was returning from a morbid sense of curiosity, and Tace surely felt the same. Maybe she wanted to find her people among the dead? Maybe she really wanted to help? Whichever was true, Catra made a quick calculation in her mind and realised that she had more than enough supplies for the two of them packed already.

“Fine.” The word escaped softly, but alert, tufted ears picked up as easily as a shout. “I hope you’re ready to go because I’m leaving now.”

“Sure am.” Tace pointed to the bulging pack on her back, tone flat. It wasn’t what Catra had come to expect from the self assured young woman, and it was her fault.

Tace turned and left the doorway, Catra trailing behind. They climbed to the top of the crevice, not too far from her home. Catra may be wild and free now, but a very big part of her wanted to know that she could escape at any time and being at the bottom of what was essentially a large pit had made her heckles rise. Her fully loaded sled was waiting close by and she put the harness over her shoulders ready to pull. She cast her mismatched eyes over to the girl glowing almost blue under the sun, and made a decision.

“Tace, tie your pack to the sled. We can take turns pulling it rather than both getting too tired to do much of anything.” Catra had hoped to only have to make camp once on the way to the crash site, unencumbered by the bigger, slower Huntara and Scorpia, and it looked like Tace would be able to match her.

“Thanks.” Again there was no eye contact as she retied ropes around the full pack and then moved to Catra’s side.

Catra shot her a reassuring look, which she wasn’t sure that her companion saw, and then they were striking out into the desert. The first couple of hours flew by quickly, though not a word was spoken between them and the tense silence was making both girls increasingly uncomfortable. It was Tace who finally broke it when they sat down to eat some lunch in the shade of a small overhang.

“Thank you for letting me tag along.” Her fingers toyed with the food pouch rather than eating it.

During the month since the magicats had be brought back to the town, Tace had spent a lot of time with the other woman, as had all of the oldest of the kittens. There had been logistical issues to deal with, of course; where could the almost two hundred children live in a town made of thrown together buildings and dug outs in the wall, built by people as necessary? Who would care for them? It was unreasonable to think that the small group of teens could take on that responsibility. Catra, Tace and the other leaders of this wild place had been shocked when more than one member of the mercenary community had come forward to offer their help. It seemed that, just because you were a thug didn't mean that you couldn't have a soft spot for children.

Things were still being worked on, certainly nothing was perfect, but it was good enough. The dark magicat knew that there was a plan going on behind the scenes to take down some military organisation, the ones who had murdered all of the adults, but she had not been made privy to that or why so many of the gang members were invested in it. She was pretty sure that the contents of Halfmoon could help them, though, and was determined to make herself and her people essential parts of this world.

All that time spent working with the other woman had brought a cavalcade of conflicting emotions for Tace. It was hard to look at the wild mane, reddish-brown fur with those cute stripes and distinctive eyes and not think of picking up a miniature version of her. Remember tickling her fuzzy belly and hearing bell like laughter as she sat her down and made her snacks, or drew pictures. That two year old Alcea that lived in her head was always transposed over this sharp and sometimes acerbic Catra who seemed to inspire loyalty in people even while she was pushing them away half the time. The fact that Catra was tall and strong, with her chiselled jaw and ever present physicality made looking at her doubly difficult. Tace felt uncomfortable with her as much as she was drawn to seek her out.

"There's a lot of equipment on the ship that I have, some idea how to use. It could help you with the town, maybe with the…

other thing?" Why did she sound so uncertain? Tace's Zu had always said she was the most confident cub they had ever known, where was that woman now?

"What kind of stuff?" Catra spoke around a mouth full of dried meat that she dared not consider the origins of.

"We were looking for a habitable planet. Ours had been destroyed by an invasion force but we managed to get a few ark ships away. We were all looking for somewhere new to live. There was terraforming equipment in the ships."

"What's that?" Catra had lowered her lunch and was studying her intently.

"Terraforming? Its scientific equipment that can make an inhospitable place liveable. Like it could make this desert green so you could make crops." The other cat's eyes had lit up and become the size of dinner plates. It was ludicrously endearing to Tace. "Don't get too excited. I don't really know much abut how that works but I'm sure we could figure it out."

"Good job you turned up at my door then, huh?" Catra had sidled closer on the sand and nudged her playfully with her shoulder. It was a simple gesture that made both young women relax.

The rest of the days journey was much easier, the magicats falling into an easy, if superficial, camaraderie. Tace spoke of the world that she remembered all too well to the clear delight of the other woman. In exchange, Catra told her a little of this Etheria that she had landed on. She noticed that there were no personal details from her travelling companion, and she didn't push. She could only imagine, and had, what kind of life the stolen kitten must have had.

It was a little before dusk when Catra noticed that the taller girl was starting to flag, dropping behind her on the sand. In the early part of the day they had traded off pulling the sled a few hours at a time but as the day moved into evening, Catra had taken over.

Her greater strength showing though as her stretched muscles told her that she could go for another few hours even with the added weight if she needed it too. She slowed to let Tace catch up and felt a hand rest briefly on her shoulder when the taller women reached her.

A big part of Catra wanted to keep going, but she could see the tiredness around the green eyes. They would still reach the ship tomorrow even if they set up camp now. Looking around, this was as good a place as any and she let the straps of the sled harness fall. Tace bent as though to put them on and Catra stayed her hand.

"We'll set up camp for the night. Set out at first light. I can pitch the tent, you can unpack the sleeping bags and food." It was a good feeling to be able to take control and be in charge of somebody else's well being. They had turned in as soon as it was dark, Catra strangely comfortable with the near stranger at her side as she fell into a relaxed sleep.

Canvas flapped overhead, the morning sun just rising, already heating the close confines. There was clearly a strong breeze today and Catra thanked the moons for it. The day before had been stifling and she had fought her base instinct to snipe when feeling discomfort, not wanting to be unkind to the young woman who laid, still purring, beside her.

Catra couldn't remember when she had last slept so well in the presence of another person. It had been a long time. She wasn't sure if it was the smell of warm fur, the purring of the snores that filled the tent or just the mellow aura of the other woman, but whatever it was she was glad that she had brought Tace along. Something itched at her hand and she realised a fluffy black tail was curled around her wrist and twitching now and again.

Rising, she used her other hand to lift herself into a seated position without waking the other woman and found herself just looking at her. Her eyes trailed over the sleeping face. Tace's features were rounder than her own, her nose aquiline and

matching her slightly jutting chin. Catra felt the urge to reach out and touch the ear that lay closest to her, but resisted. They looked much furrier than her own, as though they would be softer and less smooth then hers, they were also a little smaller. Then there was the hair in its tiny braids that in some ways reminded her of Lonnie, and in others were the most attractive thing she had ever seen. She was lost in her contemplation of the serene face and almost missed when green eyes opened and caught her.

Catra blushed under her fur and stammered something about breakfast as she scrambled out of the tent and into the daylight. Tace was left bemused. Had Catra been looking at her while she slept?

Neither of them talked about the morning, instead hustling to get there things back together and make it back to the crater. Tace began to absently sing a song from home, her voice high and willowy, floating away from them on the breeze. It was a song full of longing and hope, the words new to Catra but the melody familiar in the way that a nursery rhyme might be. Tace grew self conscious as she realised that the stronger woman was listening to her with rapt attention and trailed off.

“No, don’t stop. It was beautiful. Could you sing another?” Seeing nothing but sincerity on her face, Tace began another song, this one more upbeat and cheery. It was one that she used to sing to little Alcea as she would twirl the kitten around in her arms and hear giggles in reply. The grown version of her childhood charge seemed to appreciate it too but there was still no recognition there.

“Do you know any songs?” It was soon Tace’s turn to pull the sled, she was determined to pull her weight, in this case literally.

“Wasn’t a lot of that in the Horde.” A clawed hand scratched at the back of her neck. “I do know one, I think. Scorpia sung it a lot for a while, I think she heard it on a raid.” It was the most she had shared about her life as a child soldier.

Tace listened, ears attuned only to the low, gravelly sound of Catra voice as she sang a song about harvesting. The song itself was nothing special but the voice was spellbinding. It seemed like they got to the crater in no time, caught up as they were in getting more comfortable with each other. When the rescue mission had been mounted to bring the kittens back, a ramp had been thrown together into the crater meaning that the sled could be taken down. Efficiently they set up a camp and got all the equipment they would need to safely navigate the subterranean ruin.

"Where should we start?" Neither young woman was keen to head back to the death chamber.

"We should find the bridge. If the systems are still working we can activate them from there. It will mean we can check on supplies and equipment." Tace had spent a lot of time on the bridge of ships as she grew up and was confident that she would be able to navigate the systems.

They were grovelling along the hull of the ship, darkness around them and only the illumination of one torch. They reached the large, ugly hole, and flicked on the lights that had been left there. Catra uncoiled the rope that she had brought with her and then looked expectantly at her companion.

"It'll be easiest to access through the third level." She was surprised when, with a flourish the rope was secured and Catra was already disappearing down the hole with a graceful leap. Tace peered over the lip of the precipice apprehensively, pleased to see that the other cat was in complete control of her descent and using her momentum to swing one the jagged walkway that was exposed on the third level. She walked out of sight for a moment and the rope grew taught.

"Slide down, Tace. I'll grab you." Taking hold of the rope in both hands she lowered herself over the edge, bringing her legs up around the rope and letting herself slowly slide towards the

waiting hands. She felt Catra take her by the waist when she got close enough, and pull her into her own body.

Flustered, Tace pulled away. “This way.” She walked into the darkness, turning on her own torch to add to the illumination of Catra’s own.

Unlike the pod level, the walls here were perfect, showing no sign of looting. The dozens of doors that lined their path were all still sealed and nothing had disturbed the thick layer of sand and dust that covered the floor. The ship was huge and they walked for a long time before they reached the large circular door that barred entrance into the command area. It loomed above them, their torches casting strange shadows in the heavy metal disk that jutted from the surface.

“How do we get through that?” Catra was examining the cog-looking barrier that was twice as tall as she was.

“You need an access code.” Tace was already moving towards a sensor pad to the right of the wall. “I know it.” She placed her hand on the device, as Catra had down below, and it bloomed to life in the same way. Tace pulled back her and hit an assortment of buttons, each bleeping in a jolly rhythm. A beep of confirmation let them know that the code had been accepted.

Tace joined Catra and they watched as the door began to make a grinding sound before it rolled sideways, disappearing into the wall to the side of the hallway. Inside the aperture the lights flickered to life, clearly connected to the code to unlock the door. They both blinked against the sudden brightness in the gloom. They walked forward, Tace leading the way past a couple of glass walled rooms that looked like something Entrapta would enjoy. Everywhere was deserted.

Everywhere, except the bridge.

They stepped onto the large space dominated by a large display screen that covered the whole front of the room. There was no

time to take in anything about the room before they saw the bodies. Or rather, Tace saw the bodies and let out a stifled cry from behind her hand. Catra turned at the sound, registering the desiccated skeletal remains that lay slumped over equipment. There were ten in all. Most collapsed in pairs, entwined as though they had huddled together at the end. They were not mummified like those from below, these were bone an scraps of cloth, obviously having been dead for as long as the ship had been here.

Tace had fallen to her knees in front of the two figures in the command chair. Her shoulders were shaking but she was silent. Catra moved towards her but feared speaking in this place. When Tace moved, Catra was startled at the suddenness of the motion. She moved closer and reached out her hand to touch the uniform of the seated figure, just over the breast. Then she broke with a long, terrifying wail.

Catra was moving before the sound could stop, scooping up the other woman, bridal style, and rushing her out of the room and back down the corridor to the dark, abandoned area outside the large door. Not letting go, Catra set her back against the wall and slid down so that she was now cradling the sobbing figure in her lap. She felt out of her depth, but did what other had down for her. She pulled Tace's head under her chin and ran her hand up her back, under her hair, until she could cup the base of her skull and whispering soothing nothings to her.

It took a long time for the black cat to stop crying, her body eventually going limp in her arms from exhaustion, lingering hiccups occasionally shaking her frame. She never raised her head, and Catra rested her chin on the braids and waited. Finally Tace began to speak in low, lifeless tones.

"Those were my parents. My Zu was the pilot, my Ra the science officer. I was…I was…" She trailed off, Catra knowing better than to ask her questions about the unfamiliar words she had used just kept quiet, scratching soothingly at her scalp with her claws. "I was hoping they had been in the pods, at least. They look like

they were all afraid when they died. They must have known."
Tears started again and Catra just held her.

Tace watched the chestnut haired woman bent over the papers on the table, head held up on one hand as she glared at what was in front of her. Her jaw was clenching, bulging the muscles in her cheek and causing a big, black ears to twitch in agitation. Tace's fingers ached to go and smooth down the always wild hair, to soothe her, but the swelling emotions that filled her at the thought held her back. Her conflicting thoughts were getting ever more confusing as she spent more time with the de facto leader of this place. Bawling in her arms in the eery light of the Halfmoon after finding the corpse of her parents had felt like a homecoming of sorts and left her heart and mind in a whirl.

Catra had taken her up to the surface, gently wiped the salty tracks from her face with a cloth dampened with their precious water supply and made her stay in the tent that they had pitched in the crater. Then she had disappeared for several hours. Tace had insisted on joining her, but a steel had crept into the lighter cat's voice and she had told her to stay put. Tace had wanted to argue, to say that she could carry her weight, but was secretly relieved that she wouldn't have to go back right away. When Catra had returned, her shoulder's had been slumped and her eyes had a pinched quality that showed that she was exhausted. She had returned empty handed save for the supplies that she had taken with her.

She hadn't said much to the black furred girl on her return, but had sat beside her and leaned against her shoulder. The next day, when Tace was allowed to return to the ship, she found that the bridge had been cleared of the bodies and when she had asked, Catra had simply shrugged and replied that she had taken each of them down to the pod chamber and placed them in the bigger pods in the children's room. Tace had been so touched that tears had formed in her eyes again, but she had bitten them back, instead moving to embrace the other girl who had stiffened in her

arms but made no move to break away. She had gruffly said it was nothing and they had begun to inventory supplies.

In the months since she had been awakened on the Halfmoon, Tace had spent a lot of time with the now fully grown Alcea. Catra, her mind supplied. The tot she had spent so many days kitten sitting for her parents had grown into a strong, capable woman who seemed to carry the weight of the world on her shoulders and a host of demons in her heart. She was reticent to talk about how she had grown up, and Tace, along with the other teens, hadn't pushed it as they were still trying to process their own losses, along with taking care of the little kids. Though the elders had prepared them for disaster, none of them had ever thought it would come to pass.

The dark furred young magicat had taken charge of the few survivors, Phibin had griped but at heart he was a lazy oaf he would never take control. It meant that she spent a lot of time alone with the tactician. Tace and the others weren't entirely sure what was being planned around them, but between that and helping to integrate the magicats into this ramshackle society it seemed as though the younger/older girl barely slept. Finding the terraforming equipment along with a slew of drones, drills and other building equipment seemed to have turned a tide in terms of improving their way of life, though that wasn't what was on the minds of Catra, Scorpia and the others who were in charge here.

It hadn't taken long to discover that the whole the Waste was focused on taking down the Horde. Naturally, the magicat's old enough to understand that had been instantly on board. They had seen the security footage of the people who had torn Catra from her pod and slain their parents. They had expected the rough and ready people around them to be planning an assault through the front door with guns blazing. The raucous laughter that the suggestion had gotten from Huntara had been a surprise, but coupled with the revelation that the Horde had been holding it's own as a war machine for at least thirty years, meant that they had a military might that the former gangs of the desert could not take down. Instead their plan was to poison the place with

dissent. It had already been going on for several months, with coded messages being piped in. The step was to send in Double Trouble and the other shape shifters to further sow seeds of discontent.

Tace had suggested using the drones to deliver letters and items that might prove an incentive to the growing group of dissenters in the Horde ranks. They would also be able to bring back messages. It was an idea that had been met with universal approval, but seemed to be causing a problem.

"Damn it!" The outburst was startling after so much stillness and Tace jumped as a pencil sailed past her and embedded itself in the sandstone wall, point first. Low growling rumbled through the room. "Where's Entrapta when you need her?" A shaggy head thudded onto the table, the words muffled.

"What's an Entrapta?" She hadn't meant to blurt the words but the chuckle she received in response made her smile.

"Exactly." Catra still hadn't raised her head, but the tense line of her shoulders showed that she was not relaxed, just frustrated.

As though she was being pulled by an invisible thread Tace found herself pulled towards the desk. She walked around it until she was stood behind her new friend and reaching out. Her hands landed on the tense shoulders, which hunched even further at her touch though the woman did not pull away. Tace began to knead at them and gradually, bit by bit the young woman relaxed. Tace continued the massage even when Catra sat back up and turned her head to look at her with an inscrutable expression.

Tace found her hands moving up to burry themselves in the tangled mane, rubbing at the scalp beneath until an involuntary purr was pulled from the woman below her. The startling eyes were fluttering closed and Tace found herself leaning down, until her lips were millimetres from the other girl's. She hesitated to close the distance between them, Catra did not. She surged forward, sealing their lips together and rising from her seat to turn

their positions, hoisting Tace onto the desk, crinkling the papers that sat their and they melted together for the first time.

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Catra sat and stared at the mountain of papers on her desk and let out a sigh and she pushed her hair out of her eyes. How could one missed afternoon leave so much work? Administration was a nightmare but nobody else had the skill set she did, though she was working on that with her team. It was a slow process.

Picking up her pen, she resumed her analysis of recent trends when the door to her tiny cubby of an office banged open, hard, making her flinch. She looked up balefully, to see a younger male magicat looking at her with horror at the noise he had caused. He was a good guy so she couldn't stay mad for long.

"What is it, Jorth?"

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Adora's having a quarter life crisis all right.

And Perfuma hearts Scorpia!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Twirling around, Double Trouble caught sight of themselves in the mirror and admired the way the new purple outfit accentuated their lithe form. They hadn't been sure about the colour when Phibin had given it to them, but they should have known better, the magicat just had an eye for fashion. The chubby kitty had grown out of his hyper-masculine shell and blossomed into a sweet man whom Double Trouble spent entirely too much time, and too much money with.

Leaving their office they walked down the corridor, only to find themself face-to-face with a ball of simmering resentment and her entourage. Scanning all of their faces it was clear that most of them seemed uncomfortable to be here, it was good to know that they had been paying attention during their stay here, even if their leader had not. It was early, far too early for them to be here for an appointment they had not yet made and DT could tell that this was a day that was going to end in a headache and the need for copious amounts of alcohol.

The day before had been draining for all of the Oasis inhabitants, and they had just been pleased that Catra had mangled to hold her temper. It had been a stroke of luck that Yarsha had run out to her, and something they wished they had thought of, though Catra would never had stood for that. It was understandable but showed weakness in the magicat that the lithe lizard lacked. DT wasn't one for too much sentimentality when there was a goal to achieve. Fortunately, they were working towards the better of the

people. After seeing all those bodies on the Halfmoon, they knew that they would never be able to leave, move on and grift, when they could make a different here. It had been their watershed moment. They had hoped that hearing about it would have helped these people see the bigger picture, but clearly some (one) of them needed more.

"Princess, how can I help you this morning? I was't aware that we had an appointment. I thought we all agreed that after yesterday we would let things settle?" The pink eyes glowered and that headache was already starting at the base of their ears.

"Yes, the magicat sob story was very affecting," all of the other Alliance members winced at her choice of words, the Bow reaching out a hand as if to admonish Glimmer but held bad at the sight of her pursed lips. "But we still have questions that were not addressed. Nothing we were told yesterday explained why we should trust that Catra isn't tricking us into letting our guard down."

Double Trouble had to use all their acting muscle not to roll their eyes at the fiery woman. She clearly had an axe to grind with the oldest of the magicats and was not going to let it go without a full rundown of taking down the Fright Zone, and what Catra's duties actually entailed. The woman was going to be more than a little peeved to have to meet again, and Double Trouble did so hate to be on the receiving end of one of her tirades, they were very energetic.

"Of course. If you could give me thirty minutes, I will need to organise us a room and get Catra here. As we were not expecting this meeting, there isn't time to go back to the bar, I hope that one of our smaller meeting rooms will suit?" A large, hopefully earnest, smile played on their lips as they spoke disarmingly.

"That is acceptable. We will return in thirty minutes." Glimmer was walking away, the others trailing. The sardonic water princess shot a mouthed 'sorry' while the plant one just shook her head and

looked more troubled than the rest. DT filed that away for later, maybe they could be allies along the way.

Walking into the lobby, thankful that the princesses had already cleared out, the council member walked purposefully towards a magicat male who was stationed by the door as security. It was one of the many roles that Catra's people played in the city along with patrolling the shield, ensuring that people had anything they needed to start new lives as they came in, watching over the day-to-day management of parks and farmland as well as the tedium of breaking up bar fights. There were some more heinous crimes, you can't build perfection from debris in less than a decade, but it was rare.

"Jorth!" The magicat jumped to sloppy attention. "I need you to hurry back to the office and tell Catra she needs to get herself here in the next twenty minutes. The Alliance have demanded another meeting." Not waiting for the young man to respond, they shooed him away and watched as he started to run to head quarters.

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"What is it, Jorth?" She didn't mean to snarl at him, but from the way his ears pressed close to his head and his shoulders hunched, she had.

"Chief, Councillor Double Trouble sent me to get you. Seems that the Alliance want another meeting today. They told me that you

needed to be there in the next twenty minutes." The words tumbled out of his mouth in a breathless rush and she was sure that if she didn't know him as well as she did, she would have missed half of it.

Catra felt her blood boil at the audacity of these interlopers, pulling her away from her life to satisfy some ancient revenge that would be left forgotten. She must have growled, because she noticed Jorth take a step back and saw how her claws had extended and ripped deeply into the wood of the table, thankfully missing the papers she had been working on. Forcing herself to close her eyes and take a deep breath, something Tace had encouraged her to do after one too many violent outbursts, she stood and started to gather the most pressing paperwork.

She saw Jorth edging his way out of the door and signalled for him to wait. He stood to attention and watched her with wary eyes. She grabbed a seldom used messenger bag from the corner and slid a large pile of papers into it, along with pens, a stapler and other things she would need. She would go to the meeting but she would be damned if she was going to lose another days work for the sparkle princess.

"Come on Jorth, you can help me get this stuff done today. I might need you to fetch and carry things back and forth today." Jorth puffed up his chest and his ears went from limp and wary to perked alertly. It was a real honour to be picked by the chief to do something. Doubly so for the magicat's on the team, for whom she was doubly chief.

A soft knock on the door brought Adora out of her troubled thoughts. The chaotic and revealing meeting today, coupled with the bombshells of the previous day not letting her mind rest. It was one thing to learn about the Horde committing near genocide twenty-five years ago, and another to hear how easy it had been to take the Fright Zone apart with just words and promises of hope. The insidious hope that they had inserted throughout the

Horde had spread faster than a wildfire, the men and women all too ready to turn their backs on a war that had no end in sight and leaders that they had long since realised didn't care about anyone but themselves. Yes, there had been hold outs, but you can't lead an army if the army has walked away. Adora had been impressed with the explanation, hoping that she would be able to find out more from her old team.

Glimmer had been less impressed, believing that it was obvious that the people had turned from one dictator to another who had made them whatever promises they needed to, to build a whole new army. Through it all, Catra had been in the room, but preoccupied with a mountain of paperwork that made her brow furrow and her jaw clench. Every now and again she would thrust a document into the hands of a nervous looking male and send him away. Her lack of focus had only increased Glimmers ire, as she screamed at her several times. Catra's composure held up for the most part, though she had thrown a few pointed barbs herself about the Rebellion's lack of success and intelligence about what had happened in the Horde. Each pointed word had landed and, after three hours, Double Trouble had called a halt to proceedings which had given them the information they needed but done nothing to improve relations between the two groups. It had left Adora with a throbbing head.

The soft knocking left her know that her visit was neither Glimmer nor Bow, they still just burst in as they had when they were all teens. Cautiously, she opened the door, not sure if she wanted anybody to see her, and saw Perfuma looking at her with a warm expression. Adora moved aside and Perfuma took the invitation, moving into the room and perching on the edge of the bed.

Adora closed the door and briefly let her forehead rest against it, feeling exhausted to her bones. She had spent days rebuilding decimated towns, that had not left her as fatigued as she felt after just a few days in Oasis. It seemed like she was far more well equipped to deal with physical exertion, it seemed, than the emotional toll this place had wrought on her. Taking a breath she pulled away from the door and joined the plant princess on the

bed, noticing that the other woman was wearing her sandals, an unusual sight to see when they were inside, and was carrying a small hemp bag.

“Going somewhere?” She pushed out a smile as she spoke.

“I’m heading out to the orphanage where Scorpia lives. She invited me to go and see it in the afternoon, once the children were home . I wondered it you’d like to join me?” Perfuma had reached out and taken one of Adora’s hands in her long fingered grasp, soothingly running a thumb over the back.

“Oh, um, I’m not sure that’s a good idea.” Adora dropped her eyes from the sympathetic ones opposite.

“Adora, I think it’s just what you need to take your mind off of things. You’re living in you’re head. Scorpia asked me to invite you, she thought it would be good for the ex-Horde children to see you and that you might like to see them. You can show them how good you are at games.” She gave the hand in hers a gentle squeeze. “If t’s too much, you can always come back.”

Adora was quiet for a long time, torn between a desire for a distraction and not wanted to infect others with her sorrow. A finger came under her chin and lifted her face until she could see the compassion in dark eyes.

“Come on, I bet the kids will love you.” The few children that came and went from Brightmoon all adored the part-time goddess because of her childlike playfulness. Perfuma rose and held out her hand. Adora shook her head ruefully and let herself be pulled up before going over and slipping on her battered boots.

“Lead the way,” the First One hadn’t been to the orphanage and was curious.

“We’ll go together.” Perfuma linked their arms and they made their way down the hall, side by side.

The streets of Capital were bustling in the mid-afternoon. Though Adora had seen the chaos of children tumbling into the market when school let out, she hadn't really taken notice of the other hustle and bustle. There were people dressed in every style buzzing in and out of stores. Parents holding the hands of young and older children alike, towing them beside them. Whenever Adora saw parents and children she felt a pang of loss over the fact that she had never known that kind of care, no matter what Shadow Weaver tried to suggest.

Perfuma watched how blue eyes devoured the signs of family and domesticity around them and filed it away as something she would have to sit the other woman down and talk about when they got home. Today, though, was about getting Adora out of her head, not diving in deeper. She tugged on her arm and they made their way down an alleyway towards the orphanage. It was Perfuma's third visit to the orphanage.

She had taken a walk there by herself the night before, drawn to seek out the tall Scorpioni woman when she couldn't sleep. She had found her sitting on one of the swings out front of the building. It had been late and most of the lights inside the building had been out. Scorpia had been silhouetted by a streetlamp placed in the playground, her white hair seeming to glow and she gently swayed. The willowy woman had been drawn to take a seat on the empty swing to her side and for a time they had just drifted beside each other in silence. Scorpia had leant her head against a chain and looked at the blond though her hair.

They had't said a lot, it had just felt naturally to drift trough the air side by side exchanging occasional words in the stillness. By the time that Perfuma had felt centred enough to leave and head back to her hotel room, she hadn't wanted to leave. Being near the bigger woman was warm and comforting, her gentle aura soothing a part of Perfuma that she hadn't known needed to be soothed. When she had said a soft 'goodnight', Scorpia had surged to her feet and walked forward, stopping just shy of touching distance and rubbing a claw to the back of her neck, clearly fighting to maintain eye contact. When the former soldier

asked her to come back tomorrow she could do nothing else than agree.

Now, she and Adora were nearing the same playground, so different from her first two visits. Where previously it had been quiet and almost deserted, now noise screamed out of the place. As they turned the corner they were met with dozens of children laughing, shouting and screaming at each other as they poured themselves over and around the play equipment. The smaller children were darting around their bigger counterparts and the place felt full of life and hope. Older children were in the larger, empty area to the side of the building playing a team game with a ball and moving fast, while others sat and cheered them on. It was as alien an environment to Perfuma as to Adora.

Adora let her eyes scan the children wondering if all of the human and lizard-kin were former Horde, or whether they had just found and taken in orphans along the way. There were almost as many young magicats as non-magicats and they moved with all the grace of water among the others who looked lumbering by comparison. She wondered if she had looked like that beside Catra when they were children? She wondered what Catra's life would have been if that ship had never crashed…letting her mind go down that path was not what she was here for so she closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

With her eyes closed she was taken completely unaware as a ball sailed towards her face and ricocheted off of her forehead. Her eyes snapped open, fists coming up by instinct to protect herself as her eyes darted around looking for her attacker. All she saw in front of her was a sheepish looking red headed boy, toeing at the ground and not looking at her. A few inches in front of his feet sat a bright blue ball. It only took her a moment to realise what had happened.

"Hey, kid, it's ok. Come get your ball." She bent to retrieve it and held it out to him. He looked at her with caution as she moved forward and she could see an echo of herself in his alertness

around an adult. He looked to be around fourteen, so seven when the Horde fell. Old enough to know that adults were not safe.

"Thanks. Sorry it hit you." He grabbed the ball and held it to his chest as though afraid she would take it back. He started to run off towards his friends, who had all been watching the interaction, then came to a sudden halt before turning to give Adora a hard look, praising her dispassionately from head to toe. "Wanna play?"

Adora nodded mutely, taken aback at the offer. She looked over at Perfuma who was surrounded by little boys and girls who were touching the flowers that adorned her dress with wonder. She pointed in the direction of the waiting teens and Perfuma waved her off with a big smile. Adora ran to join the group of teen who ranged from thirteen to seventeen and after a very brief introduction found herself caught up in a fast game that involved kicking the ball to others in the group and dodging tackles around the waist.

Perfuma watched the other blond beaming as she was taken down at the knees by a stocky girl and had the ball stollen. She excused herself from the small children around her, laughing softly as they groaned and promising that she would back out as soon as she found Scorpia. At the mention of the large woman's name the children's eyes shone with happiness and Perfuma wondered if she looked the same when she thought of her.

Walking into the building, she saw more children sprawled out, playing on devices and reading books or talking. There were a smattering of adults here, and she caught the eye of a large, spike man with blue skin. He stood, dislodging the feet of a boy who had thrown them over him as he sprawled with a book open in front of him.

"Can I help you, Princess?" His voice was gruff and low, holding more than a hint of suspicion. He obviously knew who she was.

"Hello, I was invited by Scorpia. I was wondering if you could tell me where I can find her?" That seemed to allay his concerns and

he directed her where to go. “You should probably know that Adora is outside playing with the children.”

“Is she now.” His eyes were far away as he looked towards the door. She thanked him and went to find Scorpia.

By the time Adora had been trounced at several games, half of which she was sure the children were making the rules of as they went, she was breathing hard and had a fine sheen of seat on her face. Before she could be pulled into another game, she dropped to the floor beside the spectating kids and sprawled out. After a little good natured heckling they were soon preoccupied in a game that seemed to be a mix of wrestling and catch from what she could tell.

Watching them she let her mind drift before she flopped onto her back. There had never been play like this in the Horde. There had been very little down time at all. The best way to keep your child soldiers in check was to keep them too tired for teen rebellion. It wasn’t the first time she thought of all that she had missed out on, but surrounded by the happy sounds of children set free from her fate it didn’t seem so bad. She was almost dozing when a big shadow fell over her, causing her to jump up.

“Have the kids been treating you gently?” Scorpia was smiling widely, looking away and towards the boys and girls who obviously possessed super human stamina.

“Oh yeah, I could have kept going for hours but I wanted to give them a chance.” A teen girl to her right snorted loudly and rolled her eyes, Adora found herself a little offended.

“I’m sure that’s what happened.” She was obviously holding back laughter. “I left Perfuma in the library. I was wondering if you would like to stay for dinner?” She looked very hopeful.

“Is Perfuma staying?” Adora started to worry at her lip.

“Yes, I assured her we had plenty of veggies.”

“Great, sounds great.” They stood awkwardly, neither had been friends in the Horde and during the war their interactions had been clouded by a lot of things.

“Wanna come in and have a tour?” Scorpia was the first to break the silence.

“Sure.” Adora waved to the kids who were too occupied to notice and followed Scorpia inside.

By the time the two of them reached the library, Adora was certain that there was nothing going on in Oasis except people who were trying to build a better life. Nobody who could care for children so carefully could be doing anything bad. The children that ran around freely, the adults that interacted wit them with ease and all of the toys and amenities put in place all screamed love to her. She had been particularly impressed with all the climbing walls dotted inside and outside the building. She could imagine a very young Catra, more mane than child, throwing herself up them and laughing down at her for being too slow and too clumsy to keep up.

In the library Perfuma was sitting on a big, overstuffed couch with a tiny child leaning up against her and staring at the big book that she was holding on her lap. Perfuma’s voice was low and very animated as expressive ears twitched to acknowledge their entrance but the kitten stayed fixed on the story. She held her very fluffy tail in one pudgy fist running the tip of it rhythmically over her cheek while her other hand held a hand full of the woman’s dress.

Adora stood very still by the door as Scorpia walked in and sat on the other side of the child who leaned back and snuggled into her. It was the same very small magicat that she had seen in Catra’s arms when she had learned the terrible truth behind the other woman’s origins. Noticing that Scorpia was looking at her with a question in her eyes, Adora shuffled towards a battered looking armchair opposite the couch and lowered herself down, watching the child all the while.

Unlike the previous day, the little one was awake, her huge yellow eyes staring at Perfuma in wonder as her voice carried the story to her. Now that she wasn't tucked into Catra's chin, Adora could pick out more details. Her ears were a little smaller than she ever remembered her friend's being, and topped with long tufts of hair that were possibly the most adorable thing she had ever seen. The mottled colour of her fur, mostly so dark it was almost black and interspersed with large patches of ruddy brown, highlighted her small features. One eye surrounded by light fur and the other dark, imitating Catra's bi-coloured eyes. Adora wanted to ask about her, but the words stuck in her throat.

Yarsha had been so engrossed in the story that pretty new person was telling her that she barely registered Scorpia walk into the room. The comfortingly familiar presence that settled behind her all of a sudden was welcome and the kitten snuggled into the warmth, never taking her focus off of the story. She stroked her face with her tail, enjoying the feeling that reminded her of Ra. She hated when her Ra had to go to work before bedtime but Scorpia would put her to bed.

The lanky blond's voice stuttered out as the sound of a bell rang out loudly through the room, and the whole of the complex. It made the two visitors jump at its unexpected appearance. Scorpia laughed at their reaction, and Yarsha finally noticed the third adult in the room who had let out a gasp at the dinner bell. She scrutinised her with a glower on her adorable little face, not looking away even when Scorpia scooped her up and put her on her shoulders.

"Dinnertime everyone!" Scorpia's voice was cheerful as she playfully jostled the child who couldn't keep up her suspicious glaring through her giggles.

Scorpia led the way, Perfuma behind and Adora lagging at the back. She had noticed the odd look the little girl had given her and felt unreasonably deflated by it. In the halls children were streaming towards a large central room. Scorpia had shown her the dining hall on their brief tour, but now as she approached and

heard the cacophony of happy noises she realised that this wasn't a canteen for young cast offs, it was a dining room for children who were loved.

The men and women standing behind the every were already merely chatting to the children as they selected their food. Around big tables, children of all ages and races sat together, the few adults who also lived there scattered around the room. The delicious smells of the food filled the air and Adora felt her mouth water as she continued to play follow the leader. Scorpia stopped and lifted the kitten into her arms and they exchanged some quiet words until a little arm pointed at a particular table. Scorpia nodded and set her down, watching her run off towards the group that was already there.

"Hey, so Yarsha want's to go sit over there today, so I'm going to get her food and mine and sit with that group. You guys are welcome to sit there or you can join one of the groups of kids. When you're ready just go and get whatever you want." Scorpia was so at ease here, clearly beloved by all as she walked among youths who happily greeted her.

Adora was about to follow when a group of kids called out to her and she saw the teens she had been playing with earlier waving her over. Making her way over, the leader, a short girl with pigtails, blushed scarlet and asked if she would like to sit with them. She didn't have the heart to say no, so agreed before collecting herself a tray for food. While she waited in line, seeing that Perfuma had joined the toddler and the scorpioni, she wondered even more at the child. Her name was Yarsha. It was unusual, Adora wondered if it was a magicat name. She hadn't spoken to enough magicats to get a gage on how their names worked to be able to tell. She was becoming more and more certain that the little one was Catra's child. She wasn't sure how she felt about that, her feelings were too tumultuous to tell.

Finally seated with the big group of boisterous teens, Adora found herself talking and laughing as she absently ate the food. It was delicious, but the company had all of her attention. She asked

about their hobbies and school. A few shyly asked questions about how she had got away from the Horde and others about what it was like to be She-ra. She hadn't considered, outside on the court, that they knew who she was. She was surprised that they didn't seem to feel anything other than curiosity about her.

As the evening wore on, Adora found that she had no desire to leave this place. It was everything that she wished growing up in the Fright Zone had been. She had found herself whisked away by an ever growing group of children to a side room where there were cards and board games. She played game after game with different groups, laughing and hearing their stories, telling some of her own. At some point Scorpia and Perfuma had joined them, the toddler nowhere in sight.

Excusing herself, Adora made her way upstairs to use Scorpia's rest room. The bigger woman had told her not to use the kids bathrooms as they were always busy around mealtimes, so she followed the directions she had been given and ran up the stairs two at a time. She felt weird going into the other woman's room by herself, and she tried not to be nosy as she walked to the door in the back of the room and used the bathroom.

On her way back out, she wasn't looking as she entered the hallway and was taken completely off guard when a blur of fur leapt up at her and collided with her chest. She hit the floor with a thud as her butt connected with the polished wood. She looked down in confusion and found a pair of yellow eyes looking at her in confusion.

"You're not mine!" The little voice sounded sullen.

"No?" Adora was still trying to process how she had ended up on the floor. She was supposed to be a well trained soldier and been taken out by a toddler.

"Who are you?" Small, clawed hands came up and grasped her face, smooshing her cheeks and moving her head from side to

side as she examined the adult as she might a bug under a microscope.

“I’m Adora.” Her words came out muffled through her squeezed face.

“You have pretty eyes!” It was declared with finality, as though the little one had decided it was very important.

“Thank you?” The situation was feeling stranger by the minute.

“You’re a silly!” The words were shouted in her face as the kitten seemed to make a decision and jumpopff of her and started skipping back down the hall.

Adora rose to her feet and turned to go back down to the games room. She had barely taken a step when she hear the slap of bare feet getting closer and then a tiny hand was inserted into her own. Instinctively she closed her hand around it and looked down to meet toe big, sleepy eyes of the little girl.

“You come with me, silly Adora.” And then she was being pulled down the hallway, passing a couple of doors before she was led into a darkened room, lit softly purple by a nightlight.

“Hey, I don’t think I should be in here.” Her voice was a whisper and her eyes were flicking around the room, taking in the small bed pushed against the wall and the larger one in the middle of the room, almost certain now whose room this must be.

“Why not?” The girl had let go of her hand and was twirling around.

“Because I’m a stranger.”

“You isn’t. You know Scorpia and the thin lady. You must be nice.” She clearly hadn’t seen the blond at the meeting yesterday before she fell asleep. She took Adora’s hand again and walked over to her little bed. “I’m tireded. YOU tell me story now.”

Feeling helpless to resist, and having put more than one of the children of the castle to bed before, while babysitting, she followed and helped the child get under her covers. She pulled them up and made sure that she was all snuggled up. The bed was low, making it easy for a child to get in and out, and so Adora sat on the floor beside it and began to tell a story that she had read a few times about a girl and her pet lamb. It didn't take long before she could hear the tell-tale sounds of a kitten falling into a deep sleep. She kept speaking a little longer until she was sure the child wouldn't wake up, and then rose to her feet to leave. On her way to the door she passed a desk crowded with colouring books and papers. In the dim light she was able to make a photograph sitting in a frame on the one uncrowded part of the desk. Her fingers itched to pick It up and look closer, but she resisted, instead just squinting at it.

It was easy to make out Catra, her luminous eyes shining through the glass. Beside her was another magicat, hard to make out as they seemed to be much darker in colour, a pair of green eyes and dazzlingly white teeth all that she could really see. What did stand out was how closely the two were together, caught in an embrace it seemed.

Adora forced herself out of the room before she did something rash and ran down the stairs.

Seeing the picture of a happy couple, and meeting what was obviously their child, left Adora feeling dazed. It was hard to reconcile the angry, bitter woman that Catra had become during the war with somebody who was able to build a life where she seemed to be happy and embraced. Adora couldn't help but wonder who the magicat in the picture was, and whether she might run into her on her walk back to the hotel. Would it be awkward if she did? Would she be the one to stop the dark furred woman and say 'hello, I met your child and I know your partner?' Or would Adora just scuttle away like the snoop that she was?

Why could the other's move forward with her life and she couldn't? It was a question that had been plaguing her for months, maybe years, as she watched life move around her in Brightmoon. Here it seemed so much more magnified. Maybe there was something wrong with her, or maybe it was a price she paid for being She-ra?

She let out a gusty sigh as the hotel filled her vision. Rather than going inside, she found herself skirting the building and continuing her walk, mind drudging up moments where she could have been happy, but never quite content.

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"Morning pretty," a raspy voice burred in her ear as she drifted up from sleep. A fuzzy smile curled her lips as she buried her face in the rest of sleep mussed hair beside her and drew the smaller woman closer.

Soft kisses peppered along her neck and jaw, making her giggle and squirm as soft puffs of air were blown into her ear. She reached out and pulled the naked body closer to hers, feeling smooth skin slide against her own. She felt goosebumps pebble on the other woman's skin and felt a pang that she often felt when they were intimate. She enjoyed touching Zil, knowing that's she brought her pleasure and she took pleasure in return but there was always a little something missing. A little emptiness.

Zildari's hands began to wander across her abs, scraping her short nails along the lines of muscle. Adora squirmed, torn between giving in to the sweet morning seduction and pulling away as she had been more and more recently. She'd look into pale green eyes and see only the now, never a hint of the future in their depths.

She had thought, at the beginning, that those feelings would come. Desire and lust had been easy, Zildari was sexy and mean, a little dangerous to be around and the two of them had escaped

from trouble that the other caused more than once. It was maddening, and funny and familiar in a way that hurt her chest and more and more made it hard to breath.

Adora reached down a hand and drew Zil's away from where it had been creeping, drawing it up and placing a kiss in her palm and seeing a troubled look on the other woman's face. Adora pulled away a little so that she could sit up and draw her knees to her chest, sheet tucked around her as she made a barrier between the two of them. She hadn't known that today would be the day, but looking at the woman who was now tense beside her, it obviously was.

"Zil, where do you see us going?" Only blissful moments ago she had been sleeping and woken up gently and now she knew that she was about to break it. Maybe she should have done it a while ago, maybe it wouldn't be over now? She was pretty sure it would.

"I don't know what you're asking, Adora." Her tone was tight, pinched. The elfin woman had a way of becoming hard as diamond after being soft and pliable moments before. It was something the blond admired in her and knew that she lacked in herself.

"Do you think you'll ever be able to love me?" Would anybody? She knew she was lovable as a friend, but never anything more.

Zildari's hard stare suddenly broke and she looked away. It was answer enough, but the slender woman sighed and looked her in the eye as she answered truthfully, "No. I think you're really fun to be with, and great in bed," she smirked lasciviously to try to lighten her words, "but you're never really here with me. You're asking if I'll ever love you, when you should know, like I do, that you'll never love me. I realised it a while ago and made my peace with it. No use getting head over heels. I knew we were a passing fancy."

Adora felt like she had been slapped. Zildari's words were not harsh, but mostly cooly delivered and reflected back to her a part of herself that she feared. It would have been easier if Zildari had slapped her and called her an idiot. She watched, tongue tied, as Zil got up from the bed and pulled on her clothes. It was a rare stay at Brightmoon for the pair who spent most of their rendezvous at Zil's home.

"I'll see you around Adora." Zildari threw a smile at the woman still curled up on the bed, speechless and absurdly relieved.

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Adora sat on a bench, pulling her knees up to her chest as she thought about that day. Why could Catra move on and build life while she was left always searching and forever lost? Wasn't she supposed to be the hero? Shouldn't she get a happy ending?

After a week in Oasis it was almost time for the Alliance members to head back to Brightmoon and debrief Queen Angella. Some progress seemed to have been made between the two groups, with even Glimmer agreeing that the people of Oasis had technology and expertise to share. It had been agreed that Mermista and Perfuma would liaise with the desert civilisation, lending their magic on request in order to help with the agricultural needs of the city as it grew. That had been a concession that the council had agreed on, that the Princesses, if they came, would be allowed to use their magic as long as it was not against any of the people. That had made Glimmer baulk, but it had been agreed and a contact to that effect had been signed.

There had been some question of why they had not seen Entrapta on this visit, Bow particularly disappointed, and been told that she was working on a project in her spire on the on the far edge of the shield that she could not leave unattended. They were all welcome to return to visit the former princess of Dryl at any time.

One thing that had been negotiated between the two groups was that there would need to be transparency on both sides.

They would leave in the morning and Adora had gathered her things, what little there had been, and found herself itching with pent up energy. Taking a leaf out of Perfuma's book, she left the hotel and started to walk the streets of Capital. The day had faded into night almost without her noticing and the streets of the main area were almost eerily quiet with only the odd person walking passed on their way home. Many of the shops and buildings were closed up and she found her feet walking a now familiar path towards Lonnie and the boys' bar.

As she got closer the sights and sounds of people having a good time became intoxicating as moved past the smaller stalls and restaurants of the Bazaar area. Her stomach growled and her mouth watered at the smells around her as she watched people walking around with meat on sticks and bread wrapped parcels, juice running down their chins.

Getting to the cloth tented building, Adora walked in and made her way to take a seat at the bar. She had been so focused on getting in and taking a seat, eyes scanning the stage to see if Kyle was performing, that she hadn't noticed the person sitting two seats down.

A glass slid noisily across the bar, stopping when it hit Adora's folded hands, pulling her attention away from the stage and to her right where she found herself face-to-face with Catra who raised an eyebrow and shot her eyes towards the full glass of beer that she had send sliding towards the blond. Speechless, Adora took a hold of the beer, bringing it to her lips and taking a sip as a way to cover the fact that she had no words. Catra raised her own half empty class, full of a clear liquid, and took a drink herself.

Adora found herself just staring at the magicat as she put her drink down, licking foam from her lips as she let her eyes travel all over the form beside her. Catra endured her scrutiny, a smirk playing around her lips. This was the closest the two of them had

been to each other, no table to separate them, just a closely packed stool.

Instead of her sand coloured uniform, Catra was dressed in a cropped red shirt, arms bare and hem barely touching her loose fitting black shorts that draped over her thigh and ended just before her knee. Little tufts of fur stuck out haphazardly between the two items of clothing and the fur on her shoulders looked ruffled and carefree. It was a strange mixture of familiar and foreign that she realised the cat-woman was. The colours what she might have worn in the Fright Zone while the fit and the casual nature of them and her pose were something completely new.

The close cropped sides of her hair were less like Scorpia's undercut had been, and more like the short fur that covered her face, while the rest could have easily been tamed into a mohawk had she wanted, but instead flopped over to the side. Two small braids hung over one exposed ear and were adorned with small silver cuffs that she didn't remember seeing at their meetings. Noticing the other woman looking, Catra raised a hand and played with the cuffs almost self consciously.

Finally, seeming to grow tired at the stretch of silence between them, Catra took another drink, waving a bartender over and speaking lowly into his ear. He nodded and soon disappeared, Catra's dual coloured eyes finding her own blue again.

"Hey, Adora, how you been?" There was a strange, rye laugh in her voice that seemed more bemused than sarcastic.

"Hey, Catra. I've been good." Had she been? A part of her felt like she was lying, after having seen how much Catra had achieved during her journey into adulthood, and how little she had to show for the passage of years between them.

They were quiet again, letting the soft music from the stage and the low hum of people talking around them wash over them. The sharp sound of a bowl being placed on the bar startled Adora,

making her look down where she saw that the bartender had returned with a bowl of something deep fried.

“Thanks!” Catra’s voice piped up and Adora looked at her again. “What? Like I don’t know you’re probably starving. It might have been a long time, Adora, but I doubt you’ve change that much.” It felt like a punch in the gut to hear those words fall from the fanged mouth.

“You have.” The words were quiet as she reached out for the lightly battered vegetable and popped it in her mouth to save herself from saying anymore.

“Yeah, guess I have.” Catra’s voice had a far away quality.

“You have a daughter.” Adora wasn’t sure if she meant it as a statement or a question. She shoved some more of the delicious crispy veggies in her mouth to distract herself from saying more.

“I heard you met Yarsha properly. Cute little handful, isn’t she?” In fact the little kit had had a lot to say about the pretty eyed woman who had told her a bedtime story.

“How?” The older woman nearly choked as she asked it, turning scarlet.

“Did nobody at Brightmoon give you ‘the talk’?” Catra’s eyebrow was raised and a broad grin covered her face as she teased the woman beside her. It was the most familiar thing that had happened between them.

“You know that isn’t what I meant! You never wanted to be a mom when we were growing up. You hated the younger kids, and now you have one and live with dozens of them.” It really was the most puzzling thing.

“As you said, I’ve changed a lot. And I’m not a ‘mom’ I’m a Ra. It’s…different.” She wasn’t sure that she wanted to share any of that with Adora, a virtual stranger at this point.

“Oh,” it was more a puff of air than a sound. Sitting together it was hard to remember the angry enemy that Catra had been and all too easy to just desperately miss the girl who had been her best friend.

“No little She-ra’s running around then?” She took a drink and waited, noticing Adora colour again.

“No. Just me. Mermista has a child though, everybody else is still getting their act together I guess.” It did seem so odd that Catra and her other old squad mates were parents, while the Alliance members who had been raised in loving homes did not.

“Must be nice to live your life at a snails pace. One day maybe I’ll be able to slow down.” There was something sad in her eyes at the words and Adora felt the urge to reach out and cover her hand but held back.

“Do you have somebody?” She assumed the female magicat in the picture must be somewhere.

“I did. She’s gone now.” The words were soft, revealing how much she had cherished that person.

“Gone?” Catra shook her head even before the other woman had finished the word.

“Not today, Adora.” She stood from the bar, and Adora feared she had said the wrong thing. Catra unexpectedly patted in her firmly on the shoulder. “Maybe I’ll see you again before another decade goes by.”

She was through the door behind the bar and out of the blond’s sight before she could think to say a word.

Chapter End Notes

The fabulous candycornsnake has done some fanart for this fic. go take a look - her Tace is beautiful.

https://www.instagram.com/p/CK-ZbVqgCz3/?igshid=f1l77vnd1pkt

Interlude

Chapter Summary

Snap-shots of Tace and Catra's life together over a period of 5 years.

Chapter Notes

A little something soft for Valentine's Day (and it moves the story along too - so yay!)

No Adora though...that comes later, promise.

Oh, forgot to say when 'alpha' is used here it is NOT in an A/O/B way - just a dominant/leader animal way.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tired to her marrow, Catra dropped into the seat behind her desk and flopped over until her head was resting on the scattered paperwork there. Even her tail was limp and lifeless as she let out a groan into the empty tent. Her shoulder was throbbing viciously but she had too much to do to go to the infirmary. It would pass. She was used to working through pain, physical and mental. If she could do it for the good of the Horde then she could do it for this place, this oasis that they were building in the desert for the former Horde like her and the mercenaries who had followed her. The sooner it was finished the sooner they would all be able to move on.

Closing her eyes, and telling herself it was just for her to catch her breath, she was startled awake by the tent flap opening with a thwack. She jerked up in the seat, momentarily forgetting her shoulder until pain raced through it and down her arm. A roar, a honest to goodness roar, pulled from her chest and filled the tent. It had happened a couple of times in the last few months, the first time she had scared herself. She had never been able to do it

before and had put it down to the physical changes that came with her delayed development.

"Wow, easy there alpha." The voice that caused her ears to twitch was teasing, although laced with concern.

Tace had a habit of using terms that Catra didn't quite understand. It should have been frustrating, but the other woman was always kind and never patronising when she explained something or other about their shared heritage. Alpha though, was something that she had been called by others from the ship, and it made her uncomfortable once she had found out what it meant. Sometimes, when she didn't want to seem like a child to the girl who had looked after her as an infant, that level of vulnerability still made her uncomfortable, she would head out to the ship and search the data banks for information. Having been prepared to start over on a whole new world, the magicats had thought of everything to preserve their culture and all the answers were there. It had been easy to find what an 'alpha' was, and Catra was afraid of the implications.

"Don't call me that!" The words came out weary and lacking any bite but as she looked at Tace she saw her eyes crease with concern as she quickly moved through the space between them.

"Hey, I'm sorry. I was only teasing. You're roar is just so powerful." She reached out and ran a hand through the seated woman's short, dusty hair, causing a small shower of dust and stand to rain down on the desktop.

Catra reached up to take the hand from her hair, intending to bring it to her lips for a kiss, forgetting her injured shoulder. As she moved, the pain grew so intense that for a moment she saw white flashes dance across her vision and swayed dangerously on her chair. Tace reached out quickly, catching her by the front of her shirt, hearing it tear, as she was careful not to touch her arm as she kept her upright.

“Catra, did you go to see a medic?” Worry had replaced the light tone that she had had when she entered the room, and despite the pain Catra felt warmed by the evidence of her affection.

“It’s fine.” It would have sounded more convincing if her words weren’t slurred by pain.

“It is not ‘fine’. You almost passed out just then,” she saw the shorter woman open her mouth to refute her words and promptly glared down at her until her mouth snapped shut. “I saw you fall off of that ledge, I know you’re hurting.”

“We’re cat’s, Tace, we fall. We land on our feet. We start over.” She pulled her shirt out of the black furred girls grasp with her good hand and tried to straighten up and project strength.

“Did you land on your feet?” Tace pushed Catra’s chair away from the table and eased her way between her and it.

Catra tried to hold the fiery, concerned stare, but her eyes slid away to the side. Over the last year, so much had changed for the former cadet that she often felt overwhelmed by the genuine, caring emotions that came from others. It was all too easy for her to retreat back to being bitter and lash out to cover her weakness. She had tried to push Tace away more than once over the last few months. Better to be alone than open herself up to hurt, but after their first kiss she had stubbornly refused to let Catra sabotage their still young relationship.

“No.” Catra’s words were mumbled to the floor.

Tace sighed exasperatedly. She cared so much for the other woman. She was everything that Tace had ever imagined in a mate (not that she had told her that, if there was a sure way to make her run the other way it was to go too fast with the damaged woman) but never hoped to find. She could go slowly with her, they were both barely more than kits and had all the time in the world. It was simply vexing to watch her make so much progress with how she saw herself, only to run back to her

old self destructive ways when she was hurt or afraid. How she wanted Catra to know that she could be afraid with her!

Tace reached out and cupped the sharp chin, lifting those haunted eyes up to meet her own. Catra put up a token resistance but allowed herself to be moved and met the green eyes brimming with affection in front of her. Tace traced a thumb over the furred jaw, ruffling the soft hairs there, feeling the tense body begin to relax fractionally.

"I saw you fall four stories. I couldn't see how you fell from where I was but I heard the thud." She traced a gentle hand from jaw, down her neck, careful to keep her touches feather light. She extended a careful claw and slid it under the collar of the dirty grey shirt and sliced a clean line, letting the two sides of the fabric fall away revealing the quickly swelling joint.

It was hard to see the bruising through the thick fur, but the puffy quality was easy to see and as the skin stretched the furred pulled apart giving hints of angry pinkness. With the same tender care that she would use to pick up a butterfly, Tace set her hand over the wound and was shocked by the heat radiating from it. She was gratified that the other woman remained relaxed under her touch.

"Fine," it was as sigh of surrender. "I fell on my shoulder. I slipped, and before I could think what to do I was on the ground in pain." Catra moved forward, resting her head against the other woman's abdomen.

"Oh, my sweet, strong girl. You don't have to try to build every orphanage and home yourself. I know you know how to delegate, I've seen you do it. You don't have to keep proving that you're worth something to everyone. We all know." Tace was bent almost double to rest her head against the one nestling loser and closer to her stomach. She purred and pulled her hand away from the wound to rest both of them on the back of the bared neck and knead softly.

"I know." And she did. Intellectually. Catra knew that over the last three years she had more than made up for whatever atrocities she had performed in her time as an active soldier during the war. The nagging self loathing that had been beaten into her over seventeen years was harder to shake and made it hard to cast the guilt aside.

"Take me to the medical tent, wise one." They both laughed, Catra wincing a little as she moved stiffly out of the chair, relief flooding through them both for very different reasons.

After nine months, it was hard to imagine a time before Tace. After their first kiss, which had taken both girls by surprise, Catra had done the inevitable and run away. Not physically, she could never leave this place and the people that she had found, but emotionally she had withdrawn and thrown as much of herself into taking down the Horde as she could. She had worn herself down so far; planning, building and hiding from Tace's hurt and confused eyes, that eventually something had had to give.

She had found herself, late one night, standing outside the door of the room that used to be hers. Most of the young magicats were living in large tents and partially finished structures, but as Tace was acting as their leader it seemed only right that she had a little privacy. Or that's what Catra had told herself when she had offered the space to the younger woman. So what if a part of her felt warmed by the fact that Tace was sleeping in her bed? She knew that Tace would be asleep and almost left, but her traitorous hand was knocking on the beam that held up the entrance before she could.

Tace had called her in, as though she had been expecting her. She had been sitting up on the slim bed, sheets pooled around her waist and the weak light of a lamp glimmering off of her fur where it peeked out from her sleep shirt. Catra had walked to her, eyes never leaving the girl that she had been avoiding for days, drawn as though on a string until her knees hit the edge of the bed. She had felt very small, as she had muttered an apology more heartfelt than any she had ever given and yet much more

simple. Tace had gently chided in return, Catra deflating until her wrist had bee firmly grasped and she had been pulled onto the bed that was barely big enough for one, let alone two. Tace had pushed her onto her back, draping her body across her and planting a possessive kiss on her lips before pulling the covers over them. It had been their first night together, and they had just slept, but it had been perfect and after six months they had shared a lot more of themselves in that cramped, perfect bed.

As she settled the dirty hand of her uninjured arm into the black furred one, she squeezed just hard enough to make the other woman turn and look at her quizzically. Catra leant forward and took her lips in a tender kiss that made the taller woman catch her breath and almost forget how to respond before she moulded her lips to the demanding ones that covered them.

"I love you, you know?" The words passed between their barely separated lips.

Walking down one of the brightly lit corridors of the ship, hand clasped comfortingly in Tace's, Catra felt relaxed. Entrapta had called them here to see something 'really astounding!' That she had found in one of the secured areas. Even a year after finding the ship, there were still areas that they had not searched - between the pressure of causing the uprising, the need to build a city almost overnight and getting to grips with the amazing terraforming equipment the ship had been largely neglected for its other potential.

As soon as Entrapta had been brought here from the Fright Zone she had got straight to work with a feverish glee. Without her they would never have been able to bring up the terraforming equipment and get it to work with 150% efficiency. Entrapta had pawed over plans and schematics from the Halfmoon until she was expert - it hadn't taken long. That had led to the start of grass, and the hope of crops and weather systems hidden behind the shield.

The pre-fabricated buildings that had been stowed in a good half of the gargantuan vehicle had meant that with hard work and all hands at work, the centre of the new society had gone up easily, as had the small farm houses they had arranged far on the outskirts of where they hoped to have arable land. The magicats had really been prepared for almost anything.

They rounded the corner to Entrapta's purloined laboratory in the buried ship. She had picked the biggest one and had equipment brought in from all the others so that she could work on things without having to stop. They always made sure that she wasn't down there alone, a few ex-Horde would camp out in one of the empty cabins. The place looked chaotic but to Catra's Entrapta trained eye, she could see that there was an order to the madness. The purple haired princess was nowhere to be seen around the chunks of metal and coils of wire. The two women began to walk through it, careful not to scratch themselves on exposed wires or knock down any of the precarious piles.

"'Trapta!" Catra called out loudly, voice echoing around the metal walled room and making Tace flinch as it hit her sensitive ears.

"Are you sure she's here?" Tace was still scanning the room for any hint of movement with her predators eyes.

"Oh, she's around here somewhere, trust me. Eventually we'll have to prise her out of here with a crow bar to make sure she gets some air." There was affection in her voice as she spoke of the scientist.

"If you say so." Tace went to sit in the chair in front of the bank of monitors, only to scream as the chair flew out from under hear, clattering away on its casters as the impish woman shot out of the vents and crouched beside the prone woman.

"We have a chair, Tace, you don't have to sit on the floor." Entrapta was ever earnest and often oblivious; Catra let out a peel of delighted laughter as Tace looked at her, unamused. Catra mouthed 'what?' And went to help her up.

“Why are you guys here?” Entrapta’s voice was already muffled behind her welding mask as she moved behind sone metal sheeting.

“You asked us to come, ‘Trapta,” Catra gently reminded her. It was easily possible that between making the call for them and now the woman with the prehensile hair had completely forgotten, mind whizzing onto the next thing.

“Did I?” She popped up like a meerkat, flipping the mask up with a tendril of hair and rubbing her chin in thought with another as her hands remained preoccupied out of sight.

“Yes?” Tace was looking between the two women in confusion. She was used to Catra being decisive and more than a little impatient with people, especially when she was working on a project. She’d been trying to help her relax a little, yet here she was softly amused by the scatterbrained scientist.

With a ‘hmmmmm’ Entrapta ducked downed out of sight again. Catra dragged the chair back where it had come from and patted the seat for her puzzled paramour to sit down. Once she was seated, Catra stood behind her and started to massage her shoulders while they waited. It was relaxing and she let her head fall forward as she listened to the sounds of puttering. She was lightly dozing under the strong hands of the other woman when a sudden, incredibly shrill ‘Ah ha!’ Jerked her awake and out of the chair back onto the floor, Catra unable to grab her.

“Tace, you can sit on the chairs you know.” Entrapta’s voice lacked anything but sincerity.

“Yeah, thanks.” Tace winced as she stood again, knowing that she was going to have a lovely bruise on her butt. “Did you remember why you called us?”

“Hmmmm…What?” She was already drifting back to her work, “Oh, yes. There are schematics here to build a large spire. It seems to be very similar to the First Ones towers we have seen. I

believe it is a communication station, possibly intended to call the other Magicat arks to the location of the first group to find a home to settle on." Her eyes were alight with excitement.

Catra and Tace looked at each other, could they call for other magicat's? It was a hope that came and went quickly. It had been a thousand years, the chances of the other two arks still being out there were slim, they had either settled or been destroyed by the forces that they had run from.

"What would we use it for?" Catra was thinking of the practical application.

"We could use it to communicate in seconds all over the planet, it's such a big transmitter. There is also the possibility that we could use the technology to create transportation tech that could mean we go from here to, say, the Kingdom of Snows in an instant…Kinda like Glimmer's powers, actually." She threw the name of the princess out without batting an eye.

"That could be helpful when we get to the point that we need to trade with the outside." Tace could already see Catra ticking over plans.

"Of course, that is just theoretical right now. I wanted the green light." Had Entrapta ever asked for permission before? Maybe Catra wasn't the only one changing.

"Go for it Entrapta. Just no reaching out unless you've talked with the council."

"OK!" And that was that. The visor went down and Entrapta threw herself back into her work. It was a clear dismissal.

"Let's go home." Catra pulled Tace alone with her as they made their way back into the sun.

Catra splayed out her hand on the warm, rounded surface and purred in delight as she felt the tiny form inside kick out into her

hand. It was amazing to think that in just two more months, this little kitten would be in their arms. Her life was about to change for the third time in just a handful of years and she couldn't be happier. Almost seven years since defecting into the desert, five since finding the magicats and freeing her people, she was a long way away from the angry girl who, at sixteen, had wanted to rule the world with her best friend at her side.

She seldom thought of those days anymore, her life so full of people who cared for her and responsibilities that she chose, that she had no time to live in a past that had tried to break her down to nothing but a weapon. She had risen from those ashes as something tempered nut not hardened. Now, she was someone important, not because of fear, but out of respect for her hard work and care for all of those around her.

"Hey kitty, I'm you're Ra." The word still felt alien in her mouth but she loved it as much as she loved this tiny life and the woman who had helped to make it. In a low voice, full of wonder, she breathed, "Do you know me?" A flurry of wriggles and movements met her words and her heart swelled.

Catra looked at the darker furred magicat and they exchanged a giggle, both still so very young yet with an eternity of life experience behind them. Tace slipped her arm over Catra's shoulder's and drew her closer, feeling an answering arm wrap around her waist as their tails entwined. Tace reached out and placed her palm alongside her mate's on the artificial womb. The pliant, rubbery surface warm and smooth, flexible enough to let the feats inside reach out to it's parents outside.

"Of course she knows you, she is half of you." Tace pressed a kiss to Catra's cheek as she spoke softly to her.

"She's us." Catra pulled Tace so close that not a hair could pass between them. This, the three of them in this room, this was what had always been missing from her life. They were a perfect circle, the beginning and the end of everything she could want.

They had found the birth chambers in a rummaging expedition for Entrapta a couple of years ago. The manic princess had put together a few teams with schematics of the ship, and with more time on their hands than ever before, they had begun to search the unstarched to find anything that would help their little home grow. Tace and Catra had been sent to search for medical equipment or drugs. Building a medical facility had been one of their top priorities, alongside the orphanages, but fitting it out had proved to be more difficult that had imagined.

Going back to the Fright Zone to loot supplies was off the table, almost as soon as the princesses had realised that the deserted nature of the place wasn't a trap, they had moved in and started to dismantle the place. It was hard to trade for the equipment they needed in the smaller vials and towns and they dare not let people go too far afield for fear of detection. Entrapta had managed to jury rig things here or there, but the more they could locate on the civilisation shaped ship the better.

The sheer scale of the ship could be overwhelming. It was big enough that all of Oasis was going to sit on top of it. The shield generator and cloak, as Tace had told her the camouflage technology was called, had turned out to be too tied into the ship and its power source to be removed without compromising its effectiveness. Instead, Entrapta had managed to reroute it and now their whole city was enclosed in a protective bubble that hid them from prying eyes or unwanted visitors. Building almost on top of the ship had the added bonus allowing them to tap into the power and bring electricity to every home.

Getting to the lower level's med bay, the four on upper floors had already been cleared, took over an hour on foot. It wasn't helped by the two young women pulling each other into alcoves, making out and feeling each other up in the dim light. Their relationship had become more tactile and playful as they got more and more comfortable with each other. Years together had left them very much in love, mated not long after their first confessions of love. They both still feared that time would be snatched away for them even now, and lived as fully as they could.

Laughing they finally made it to a set of doors that spanned from wall to wall and blocked their path. Catra looked down at the tablet in her hadn't and saw that they were in the right place. Tace tried entering the standard access code that was usually successful, this time to no avail. The sensor panel bloomed to life, but died when the code was put in. Entrapta had thought of everything though, and a wire was pulled from the pad and inserted into a port at the side. Catra pressed a button and both the tablet in her hands and the panel light up and ran through a series of numbers at ludicrous speed before there was a metallic hiss and the door ground their way open.

On occasion, some of the old infrastructure of the thousand year old ship needed a little help and the two young women braced themselves in the narrow gap that had opened and pushed until the doors were hidden back in the walls. The lights burst to life and the sterile, shiny area was revealed to them. Each medical bay that they had discovered had been perfectly clean, no dust or sand having broken through the sterilisation seals. It was more disconcerting than the dust motes in the air.

Having seen four other medical units on the ship, Catra had been expecting to see the familiar site of rows of beds, a few closed cubicles and some operating rooms towards the back. Walls lined with cabinets full of medicines and equipment. When she turned away from the door, what she saw left her puzzled and confused. This place had tens of frames holding what looked like flaccid flesh coloured bags that hung limply from them. They were each set on a table with an intricate variety of wires, tubes and cables dangling from the sack. They were widely spaced with a trolley beside each table that seemed to have a long, clear tub on top and a blanket inside. The walls had the familiar cabinets, and she could tell that in the back there was another operating room.

Catra opened her mouth to ask Tace when she saw that her mate had already walked into the room and was looking around in wonder. Her delicate, long boned hands were hovering over one of the sacks, torn between wanting to touch and being afraid to break something. It was clear that she knew what this place was

for. Not wanting to spook the woman who was clearly lost in her own thoughts she moved deliberately, making enough noise that she wouldn't startle her. Getting behind her, she slipped her hands around the slim waste and placed her head on a convenient shoulder.

"Hey." It was the ghost of a whisper picked up by a large ear.

Tace's whole body relaxed into hers, Catra's hold tightening to show that she was there. "Hey." Tace's voice was like somebody who has stepped into a temple and is left in too much awe to speak.

"What is this place?" Catra peered over the shoulder in front of her and got a better look at the thing on the table. The sack almost looked like flesh and was clearly soft and pliable. There were no visible joins, just one seamless sack with no opening save for where the various tubes entered it. There was something off puttingly organic about it.

"It's a nursery." Tace turned in her arms so that they were facing each other. "People like my parents, who wanted to have a baby, would use these to gestate the foetus. The doctors would take material from both parents and join it together before letting it grow inside these. It's like a womb. Mates who were both male, or both female, could have children together."

Mates who were both male, or both female, could have children together. The words rung in Catra's head. She had never even considered having children, always having thought they were weak when she was one, and then too busy trying to take care of all of the orphans and displaced child soldiers to think of her own. Hearing those words fall from those lips though? That suddenly made things spark in her heart and her mind, swirling images of a tiny kitten with Tace's eyes running through them. She leaned forward and rested her head against Tace's neck, feeling both the other girls arms twine around her neck.

That was how they found themselves stood in front of an artificial womb, playing with their unborn daughter as she played tag with their hands. They could see her silhouetted form through the opaque surface of the sack, big ears and tail now easy to see at seven months.

Huge yellow eyes blinked up as a tiny mouth opened in a yawn exposing pink gums. Little mewls and the smacking of lips told the adults watching that she was ready to be fed. The room was filled with the sound of cooing as the adults who had come to see the new arrival fawned over her adorableness. Squeals and laughter filtered through the open doorways as the dozens of older boys and girls ran around and played in the hallways and rooms of the orphanage.

Catra smiled fondly at the group as she went to collect a bottle from the cupboard. She ran her hand across Tace's shoulders as she passed, finding her hand taken and a kiss pressed to her palm by her smiling mate before she moved away. Tace walked over and scooped the little ball of fur out of Scorpia's extremely careful claws, patting the big woman's cheek as she held very still so as not to hurt the new arrival as she was drawn into her Zu's embrace. Happy little squeaks left the kitten as she nuzzled into Tace's jaw recognising her scent.

Every one of the adults in the room gasped at the sound. It really was too adorable for words. Catra, bottle in hand, noticed that Kyle had cuddled closer to Rogelio, while Lonnie rested her head on his knee from where she sat on the floor, their own little magicat looking in wonder at the kitten from his seat on the lizard man's lap. Their other two children had rushed out to play with the orphans, but young Digby was too fascinated by the sight of a baby of his kind. Catra imagined she would have felt the same at his age, before everything got so dark.

Shaking off a momentary pang, a fleeting memory of blond hair and somebody from her life who was missing from her perfect family picture, she handed the bottle over to Tace who had

retaken her seat in an armchair, Yarsha cradled in the crook of her arm. Catra settled on the arm of the chair, cupping her hand to the kitten’s shaggy head. She watched lovingly as the smallest of all the magicat’s began to suckle. Yarsha was a new start for her, but more importantly she was a new dawn for the magicat’s. They had gone to space to try to save their species, and this little girl was the first born on an alien world, but she wouldn’t be the last.

Feeling a nudge from a large fluffy tail, she looked up and saw Tace smiling fondly at her. Catra felt her own face mirror the expression on her mate’s and leaned down to rest their foreheads together, letting the sounds of Scorpia and the other family fade into the background.

What their little cat would grow up to be was something that they both looked forward to finding out. Whatever it was, it would be perfect.

Chapter End Notes

Still a lot of mystery left in all this...
All will be revealed!

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Adora starts to make positive changes.
Perfuma and Scorpia get cute.
What is with Glimmer and Shadow Weaver?
Wasn't there a book...

Chapter Notes

Rating changing to mature as Adora may not have had a lot of meaningful relationships but she has had quite a lot of trysts.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Usually returning to Brightmoon was a relief. Whether it was coming back after a battle, returning from rebuilding or just slinking back exhausted from a party, there was always a feeling of peace that filled her when she walked into her room. This place, with its plump bed, large balcony and pristine surfaces was her space. This was the first place that she had ever had that she could call her own. She had experienced many firsts here in Brightmoon; first place that was hers, first midnight feast, first kiss, first time…

Arriving back, Adora walked into her room and pulled the door closed behind her, blocking out Glimmer and Bow who had turned to say something to her that she didn't want to hear. All the other princesses had headed back to their realms and Adora simply wanted to be alone to think. There had been precious little time for that since the night before. She clicked the lock on her door, seeing the blue shimmer move around the edge of the room and let her shoulders slump, finally letting down her guard.

Knowing that Glimmer couldn't just spark into the room had been something that she had come to appreciate more and more ever the passing of years. In the beginning it had been reassuring to

know that Glimmer would just suddenly pop into the room. The Horde orphan had hated being alone, never having slept by herself. Bow and Glimmer had been a constant presence that kept her from thinking too much about what she had lost by leaving her squad. As the years had passed though, Glimmer and Bow had taken to locking their own bedroom door, meaning that Adora could not burst in and ruin the moment. This change had not gone both ways,
unfortunately.

Glimmer had continued to pop in on a whim. As time passed this began to feel less comforting and more intrusive. They weren't teens anymore and yet Glimmer would still expect her to drop everything and listen to her rant about her parents stifling her, or how the rebuilding work wasn't going as planned.

Things had to come to a head eventually, and come to a head they had in the most embarrassing way that Adora could imagine. She had been pinning one of the palace guards to the wall, the other woman's naked legs wrapped around her hips as her own pants pooled around her knees and her shirt hung open. She was thrusting into her with three fingers as she sucked on the older woman's neck and revelled in her breathy grunts when the too familiar sound of tinkling bells caught the periphery of her mind. It wasn't enough to make her lose her rhythm as she toyed with the nipple in her other hand and pushed her willing victim more firmly into the wall.

"Adora you…" The loud voice that filled the room stopped everything.

Three things happened in rapid succession. Glimmer screamed in horror, Adora lurched backwards and the brunette who had been wedged between her body and the wall hit the floor with her ass, hard. The woman on the floor was crimson with embarrassment, curling up to try to shield her nudity from the princess. Gathering her wits, Adora had stood in front of her most recent paramour and demanded that the dumb struck Glimmer leave. Eventually, the pink haired woman had got her wits together enough to

disappear from the room in a cacophony of sparkles and Adora was able to turn to the woman on the floor who had moved rapidly from shame to anger.

Adora reached down a hand to her, letting go of her shirt which fell open and exposed her breasts again. The hand was slapped away harshly as the other woman scrambled to her feet with a glower on her face. Adora watched her stomp around the room, pulling her clothes on until she was standing beside the door. Her brown eyes fixed on Adora, judgment oozing from them.

"All you princesses really need to grow up!" She threw the door open and began to storm out, "don't call me again and when you see me in the corridors, don't talk to me!"

The words were harsher than she expected, punctuated with the loud slamming of the door making her wince. The shame that the other woman must have felt, naked and exposed on the floor as her boss just burst in had obviously shaken her. Adora would give her a few days and then try to talk with her. The last thing she wanted was another 'talk' from Juliet about her philandering with the security team. Once had been bad enough.

Adora had straightened her own clothes and gone in search of the mortified Glimmer. It had been easy to find her, she always ran back to her own room. Adora made a point of knocking loudly on her door and a muffled 'come in' met her ears.

Glimmer was perched on the edge of her bed, no longer suspended from the ceiling now that she shared it with Bow as a concession to him. As Adora walked in, she didn't look up at once, head held in her hands and shoulders quacking a little.

"See how easy that is?" Adora began, referring to asking permission to enter. At the words, Glimmer's shoulder's began to shake more, Adora becoming concerning and sitting beside her friend, putting an arm around her in comfort. "Hey, it's nothing we can't sort out."

Glimmer's face came up and with a start Adora realised that she hadn't been crying, but stifling laughter. "You should have seen your faces!"

Something snapped in Adora's as she saw the mirth in Glimmer. Adora had been embarrassed, her date mortified and Glimmer just thought it all a grand joke. As they had grown older, Adora had noticed Glimmer become increasingly self absorbed, focused on the importance of her own missions and desires. Usually those moments didn't last long, and the blond was able to push them aside, remembering how much the pink princess had done for her. But today, Adora was enraged in a way she seldom was.

"What is wrong with you?" She was on her feet now and looming over her friend.

"What? I'm sorry I interrupted. Honestly. I never needed to see… that!" Her glib words and dismissive gesture further enraged Adora.

"How would you feel if I just burst in on you and Bow?"

"Adora, why are you so mad? I said I'm sorry. I just forgot to knock. It's happened a million times." Glimmer rose to approach her and Adora reared back.

"She told me not to talk to her anymore."

"She'll get over it. Give it a week and she'll be back in your room." A smirk was playing around her lips as she spoke, making it clear what she really thought about Adora's promiscuity.

Adora had stormed out of the room, knowing that if she stayed they would end up fighting and nothing would be resolved. Glimmer was more stubborn than anyone she had ever met. Well, almost anyone.

That had led her to seek out Castaspella, thankfully in Brightmoon on one of her bi-monthly visits. The eccentric sorceress was more of a fixture in the castle than when Adora had arrived. She came

to spend time with her big brother and had struck up a relationship with Juliet that both women seemed to think was a secret.

Adora had managed not to reveal too much when asking Casta if she could put some sort of magic filter on her room to keep Glimmer from getting in on a whim. The older woman had cupped her cheek in an unexpectedly maternal gesture and told her it was about time. They had both returned to her room and it had been a shockingly easy process to cast a spell on the room that would activate to lock the entire room when she locked the door with a shimmer of blue.

Adora threw her bag onto the bed and flopped back beside it. That had all happened a few years ago, Glimmer had been huffy about it at first but seemed to get over it quickly. Now, Adora's room was reserved only for her and those people that she invited in. Though she hadn't invited anyone in for a while.

Taking a few deep breaths, she filled her lungs with the sweet smelling air that wafted in thrust the open balcony doors. The scent was made up of tree sap and flowers and just a hint of magic that was constantly suspended in the air. She couldn't help but compare it to the crisp, almost synthetic smelling air of Oasis as she let her eyes roam the ceiling with it's ornate light fixture. Everything just felt like too much. She pulled herself up into a sitting position, slowly, as though she was as old as time itself, then back to her feet.

Wandering listlessly to her desk, she ran her hand over the various souvenirs and moments that sat there. She pick them up one by one and ran her hands over each one. From above her desk the smiling faces of her friends looked over her work. She placed a small glass unicorn back in its place on her desk as she reached out and touched an image of a very young Best Friend Squad, faces smooshed together and mugging gleefully for a camera that she was pretty sure Sea Hawk had been holding.

She pulled it down, releasing the pin holding it here with a pop as it few out of the cork board to land somewhere out of sight. She stared at the girl in the middle. That younger her who had seen a world of possibilities in front of her as long as she had her friends by her side. She reached up and touched the hair poof that she still sported, just one more reminder that the girl in the picture hadn't become who she had hoped to be.

Catra's face swam in front of her eyes for a moment. Not the one that she had just met, but the skinny, sharp jawed girl who she had run simulations with and climbed to the highest, most dangerous spot in a dangerous place just to feel free. That image was replaced by the bigger, more intimidating version of that girl. All grown up with her harshly cool hair, filled out frame and thoughtfully deep eyes. For a moment, the two images of the other woman sat in her head, side-by-side, until with a grunt of frustration she realised she had screwed the photo up in her hand, leaving a crease down her own face.

Usually returning to Brightmoon was a relief.

Something had to change.

"…if the ship that they discovered had the technology to build that city, that quickly, and keep it hidden, who's to say what else they are hiding?" Glimmer folded her arms over her chest as she stood in the war room looking over at her parents where they sat side-by-side.

Angella's face was contemplative, eyes sharp as she considered her next words carefully. Glimmer was always a simmering powder keg when they were in this room, as though the place itself made her so tense that she could barely contain herself. Her mother had more than twenty-five years of experience in dealing with her hair trigger child, so knew to consider her words carefully. Micah, at her side, was staring at his only child incredulously. Her words held a little more venom than he was

comfortable with and he wondered, not for the first time, how much he had truly missed trapped on Beast Island.

"Was there anything concrete that you could point to as suspicious?" Angella measured her words, the last thing she wanted after seven years of peace was to be the one to start another war.

"Did you not hear when I said that Catra is there, with all of the Horde, and that they have a giant spaceship?" Glimmer's hands were one the edge of the table now as she leaned forward and glowered, voice rising in pitch but not volume.

"Yes, Glimmer, I understand that. What you must understand, is that the Alliance cannot be the aggressor here." The key was not to escalate; with her daughter, or a potential enemy.

Glimmer threw her hands up in frustration and flopped into her chair, almost balling herself up in her defensiveness. "You're always so keen to 'not be seen as the aggressor'! It's why we were losing the war! If we took the offensive for a change we could stop what is coming before it even started."

Angella stood now, her massive hight making Glimmer sink further into her chair. Micah looked up at his wife and then back to his daughter. He had not said a word. A big part of him thought that it was still not his place to intervene here, he had lost that right when he went against the Queen's orders and got himself banished to a death island. Sometimes it was hard though, as he moved his gaze between the two women that he loved dearly.

"We will not start a war, Glimmer. Bring me some proof of an impending threat. Show me these weapons, bring me a battle plan written by Catra. Something. Your groundless accusations are just that." She walked to her daughter and rested her hand on her shoulder, causing her to uncoil just a little and look up. "We need proof for action." It wasn't a complete denial and seemed to appease the younger woman somewhat.

"If you need proof I'll get it for you. They never showed us that ship. I just know they have weapons powerful enough to destroy us all. They brought water and farming to the centre of the desert, if they can do that they can do anything." Her voice was more measured now as she seemed to be considering her options. "They want to work with Perfuma and Mermista. They can get on their good side and then collect evidence for us."

"I'm not sure that Perfuma will be comfortable with acting as your spy, darling." Angella had moved back to her own chair, sitting and taking Micah's hand where it rested on the table.

"I'm sure I can get Mermista and Perfuma to see things my way." Already her mind was processing how to get Perfuma to be her unwitting spy. "I need to meet with them both before they head home, in that case. Preparation is important."

Glimmer rose without waiting for permission from her mother, blinking out of the room in a shower of sparkles, clearly intending to ambush her friends before they left. Angella sighed. She wished that Glimmer had been able to move on from the war as easily as the rest of her friends had. Finding this kingdom in the desert was the last thing that her daughter needed.

"Are you alright, my love?" The low burr of Micah's voice, still something that she couldn't quite believe she got to hear, came softly from her side.

"I wish they hadn't found this city." Angella's sounded tired to his ears as she tapped at the document in front of them.

Micah stood and pulled his much taller wife to her feet, drawing her into an embrace. She melted into him, and he gave her his strength to keep her grounded as he always had. He may be king, but she was the powerhouse of the two of them. He was happy to stay in her orbit and lend her his strength when she needed it. He hadn't always been as happy to do so, wanting to prove himself worthy of this immortal goddess who had the choice of anyone she wanted and picked him. That had led to disaster and losing

his child' s whole childhood, leaving Angella to fight a war that had clearly taken more of a toll on her than the younger people around her had seen.

"I know, my love. But perhaps this will be the catharsis we all need. I know you've all been waiting, wondering when the Horde would resurface. At least now you know. I hope that Glimmer is wrong, and that they are not a threat, but at least it isn't waiting over our heads anymore." He looked up into her lovely face and smiled. Angella smiled tiredly and leant down to kiss him, enjoying the tickle of his beard as she pulled away.

"You're right. It is a relief to know where they are. Why did Catra have to be there though?" Glimmer had never been able to get over her ire at the Force Captain who had led the assault on Brightmoon.

Angella wasn't certain why her daughter held such loathing of the cat woman. It was something she had not been able to get over. It was puzzling, given that although the other young woman was the one who had kidnapped Glimmer and Bow, delivering them into the Horde's clutches, it had been Shadow Weaver who had tortured her daughter. She may have forgiven the other woman, allowing her to live in house arrest in the castle to be able to keep watch on her, but she had not forgotten. Glimmer though, seemed to have unequivocally forgiven what the old sorceress had done to her and focused all her frustration on the soldier.

Now here was Catra, back again, and with her presence assuring that Glimmer would see nothing but danger lurking in the shadows of this place. Angella couldn't lie, she too harboured suspicions about the hidden kingdom that they had found purely by chance. It was hard not to. The place was made up of all their old enemies. She would like to know what more that buried ship had to offer.

She would have to debrief with both Adora and Bow to get a full picture of events, she was certain that Glimmer had held back

some information, she always did. Her daughter loved to keep control.

The bigger question that lingered in her mind as Micah led her out of the room and out for a stroll in the gardens, was what had become of Hordak?

Looking down at her sleeping husband, Glimmer admired his well sculpted torso. The sheet had ridden down to his hips as they slept and he was now splayed out, one arm flung over his head, resting on then pillow while the other rested on his abdomen. The moon shone brightly through their balcony window, almost making his skin shimmer as hers did in the light. A big part of Glimmer wanted to reach out and run her hand over his skin, spread her fingers above his heart and feel it beat at her pam in that reassuringly solid way that was so quintessentially Bow. Her anchor for as long as she could remember.

She moved quietly, not to touch her husband, but to ease her way off of the mattress. She picked up the robe that she had cast aside close to the mattress, slipped her feet into slippers, using her magic to vanish from her room and reappear in the empty corridor outside. She pulled on the robe, cinching it at her waist before starting to walk a familiar path along dimly lit corridors. The further she went, the darker the corridors became, shadows flickering on the walls, seeming to guide her path to her clandestine destination. She was long past being afraid of the shadow minions that crawled along the baseboards.

Nobody saw the princess, just as she had planned. This was the time of night where guards were changing and she was well used to making short work of the brief journey. Reaching the door, she inserted the key that she kept in her robe and let herself in, quickly closing and locking it behind her. The room she had entered was only lit by the moon, yet still bright enough to make out the woman in red sat on the chais lounge pouring two steaming cups of tea.

Not waiting to be invited, Glimmer moved forward, leaning close to press a kiss to the seated woman's cheek and receiving a smile in acknowledgement as she moved to sit opposite and accept a cup and saucer. They sipped their tea quietly for a moment before the older woman placed her cup back onto the small table that sat between them, folded her hands in her lap, and fixed the princess with a fondly appraising look.

"Welcome back Glimmer, I have missed you this last week." Shadow Weaver's voice was soft, gentler than it had ever been with anyone other than Adora. Without the mask covering her face her voice was less hollow and held a warmth that Glimmer had drawn comfort in over the years, especially when her parents would not listen to her.

"Me too. Your advice was welcome though. Sometimes the others just can't see clearly past all their emotions." Once upon a time, that would have been true of her too, but over the years she had learnt a thing or two from her secret mentor and how to look beyond sentimentality was one of those things.

"You know that you always have a sounding board in me, Princess." Another smile settled on her face, pulling at the thick bands of scarring that covered the left side of her face. Dark eyes twinkled and Glimmer felt the same pride that she always did when Shadow Weaver showed her what lay beneath the mask. It was something she knew that she had never trusted Adora with.

Glimmer never spoke about her relationship with the former Horde commander. The others in the palace knew that she would visit in the day from time-to-time, that was seen as acceptable by all concerned. Her father was less than pleased that she had any kind of relationship with his childhood mentor, but Angella had seen no danger in it, Shadow Weaver being largely powerless now and the Horde threat eliminated. Glimmer doubted she would have been so magnanimous were she to know about their almost nightly tête-à-têtes.

Shadow Weaver was a sounding board for the princess, for years she had gone to her for help and advice that she did not want to speak to the king and queen about. All too often Angella still saw her as a child, second guessing her choices or talking her into plans that were not her own when she sought advice. She had realised quickly, that the best way to make any progress with anything, like reconstructing the Fright Zone, was to go to them with a definitive idea and plan and leave no room for questions of doubt. That was where Shadow Weaver came in, she was Glimmer's personal advisor, albeit a secret one.

Shadow Weaver had also been invaluable in helping her build her sorcery skills. Castaspella and Micah were good teachers and she had learned much from both of them but Shadow Weaver simply knew more. Her knowledge of the craft was encyclopaedic and she had shown Glimmer how to harness both the light and dark spells. She had not yet had cause to unleash them, but were they ever to be under threat again, Glimmer would be as formidable as She-ra had ever been.

"So tell me about this Oasis." Shadow Weaver's dark eyes were trained on the younger woman as Glimmer took another sip of her herbal tea, a special blend made by the witch. Even in the moonlight she saw a red glow briefly shine in pink eyes, Glimmer blinked and it was gone. "Did you find the mongrel there?"

"We were right, Catra is there and so are lots more things like her. She even used a baby one to try to emotionally manipulate us. Can you believe it?" Of course she could, she well remembered the brat being brought to her. A rare error in judgement that had cost her dearly in the long run. She still rued not having the scolders simply euthanise all of the young as they had the adult beasts. She wouldn't make that mistake again.

Glimmer began to spell out everything that they had learned. Shadow Weaver watched her speak, nodding along and giving her all the attention that she was so desperate for. Glimmer was everything she had hoped that Adora would be for her. Without the pesky martyrdom that plagued the blond girl. Of course, if she

could get Adora back under her thumb along the way, then all the better.

In the days after they had returned from Oasis, after fond farewells to her friends who she had resolved to make more of an effort to visit and keep up with, Queen Angella and King Micah had pulled her aside. Rather than heading to the war room, they had taken her to their private parlour where cakes and fruit juice had been laid out.

Adora had never felt completely comfortable with Queen Angella, it was nothing that the woman did, its was more to do with Adora and her ongoing issues with powerful older women. Being raised by Shadow Weaver as her favourite had come with a lot of psychological damage. When Adora had first come to Brightmoon as a teen she had feared disappointing the austere, aloof woman. She had never felt good enough as herself, firmly believing for years that all Angella valued was her She-ra persona. She had tried so hard over the years to impress the woman, often ending in her own embarrassment and a mortifying sweet intervention.

The other princesses had set up a meeting that she thought was about more demolition at the Fright Zone. It had been some years after she joined the rebellion and after the fizzling end of the war. Adora had walked into the garden (she had thought it was a strange place for a strategy session but assumed Perfuma had needed to be near the trees or something) to find them all seated on garden chairs in a semi-circle with Angella at the centre. Adora had instantly tensed and stumbled on her own feet, falling in a heap at the angelic woman's feet. She had looked up, blushing furiously only to see Angella looking down at her with nothing but naked affection.

The group had each taken a turn, speaking about how much they loved her and valued what Adora did for them as a friend. There had been no talk of She-ra that day. They had all noticed that she had been working hard to rebuild war damage at the expense of

herself, and it had been heartwarming to realise that they cared enough to do this. After the princesses, Bow and even Sea Hawk (through a shanty about her, obviously) had showered her with love that had made her squirm under that spotlight, but built a warmth in her chest, they had all left, some leaving a kiss on her cheek as they walked passed. Frosta had punched her in the shoulder roughly and laughed at her startled face.

That had left her alone with the Queen. She had still felt tongue tied and started to lower her eyes. Log fingers had cupped her jaw and raised her face. A part of her had tensed, the gesture too much like how Shadow Weaver would show her affection only to remind her how conditional It truly was. Angella must have felt it, and moved her hand away to hold the top of her arm and rub reassuringly.

"Adora, I need you to know that you never have to try to impress. You are one of the most impressive young women I have ever known. You have overcome so much since you came here to be with us. Never think that I only value you for what you can do for Brightmoon. I value you because you are precious to me. I'm sad that I haven't shown you that enough for you to trust in it." Adora had felt tears start to track down her face at those words and Angella had brushed them away. "I love you Adora, you are a part of my family. If you never did anything except ride horses and eat cake for the rest of your life, it would be enough because you are enough."

They had not embraced, Adora had felt too overwhelmed, but from there things had been easier between them. Adora believed that Angella's words had been sincere, and she felt much happier with her now, but whenever they met formally even in a setting like the parlour, she still found herself reverting to the girl who had arrived with nothing but a red jacket and a magic sword.

Adora was still processing her own feelings about Oasis when the King and Queen had asked her for her thoughts on the place. They often consulted her about things, wanting a separate option from Glimmers. Her upbringing meaning that she could bring

some different, more strategic perspectives to things that the other princesses lacked. She was also just more hardened than they were. It was sometimes hard to see, her affable personality shielding it and making her seem much more like her peers, but the monarchs saw it and appreciated her ability to detach herself from a situation and look at it somewhat dispassionately.

That had not been the case that day though. Far from dispassionate, Oasis had started her on a tailspin that's he was yet to be able to pull herself out of. When they had asked her to debrief them on what she had learned, she had shared as much. She found that they both appreciated her being more bluntly honest. She was still able to give them the facts that they desired though.

"Though we were not given access to this downed spacecraft, their council member did give us enough detail and documentation to verify its existence. There was come indication that if a treaty were to be signed in the future then we may be granted limited access." That had surprised her on the last morning when a courier had brought some plans, images and schematics, clearly intended to entice them to think about forming an alliance rather than a rivalry.

"Oh, Glimmer must have forgotten to pass that on to us. I shall have to remind her." Adora noticed that the queen's eyes looked troubled. "Did you get any indication that they were an imminent threat?"

"Honestly, I think that they were more afraid of our intent. I saw no indication of weaponry, beyond what the border patrol had. From what I saw of the city it was built around the rehabilitation of the people and those we encountered were just concerned with living their lives and improving their lot." That was the truth as far as she had seen it.

"And this alleged ship they discovered. What do you believe their reasons for not taking you to see it?" It was Micah who spoke up this time. His attitude to the Horde was interesting. He had fought

them and lost, suffering consequences that were hard to imagine, yet when he had retried he had accepted that they had given up and left easier than any of them. Maybe he had realised the futility of fighting a war perpetually in stalemate.

"As soon as were told about the ship being full of bodies I knew they would not take us. It sounds more like the place is a graveyard." She shivered as she imagined the sight of thousands of mummified corpses.

"One last question and we'll let you get back to whatever you were doing. You know Catra better than any of us. Glimmer thinks that she is secretly the leader of this place and just building an army. What's your take?" Angella looked at her earnestly.

"I may have grown up with Catra, but the woman I met there wasn't the girl I grew up with or the woman I spent two years fighting. She seems to have changed a lot. All I witnessed was a woman doing her job and looking after her child. I saw no evidence of them plotting for war."

"What child? Glimmer mentioned them using a child to illicit sympathy when they told you about the magical orphans." Micah's voice was soft as he mentioned the orphans.

"I spent some time in one of the orphanages. The child from the meeting was there but not one of the orphans. It turned out that Catra has a daughter. I can't see her doing anything to put a child in danger. We had to much of that ourselves." Talking about Catra and her child made Adora feel sad, which must have been reflected in her eyes.

"Thank you Adora, we just wanted a full picture, you understand." Adora had left that meeting more galvanised than ever to move on.

Moving on became something of an obsession for Adora over the month since returning from Oasis. It had started with small things. She had gone to the palace tailor and tasked him with

creating her a new wardrobe, without the colours red or beige in them. Needless to say the wiry man had been taken aback. For years he had been trying to persuade the woman to change up her style, even a little, tired of making her the same red jacket and pants. He had managed to sneak in small alterations over time; getting rid of the ridiculous shoulders, streamlining the collar and getting some variety into her simple white shirts. This instruction? This was unprecedented!

Adora had spent hours with the tailor in nothing but her underwear, being measured from every angle. She had dressed and they had discussed ideas over tea and cookies. Yes to pants, and shirts, maybe to a dress or two, a hard no to skirts. She liked several of the colours that he showed her on swatches and had left feeling like she had made a first step in real, positive forward momentum.

After her trip to the tailor, feeling invigorated she had taken herself to the barber. She hadn't had a clue what she wanted, just that she wanted to shed another thing that was stopping her from growing. She had worn her hair the same way all her life. A ponytail, pulled tightly to the back of her head, that had been joined by the iconic pouffe at the front that had come after a rather disastrous attempt at letting Catra cut her hair when they were nine. She had like how it looked and kept it ever since no matter how silly her best friend had told her it looked, or how much the princesses had teased her. Now, it felt like changing it would be like shedding her skin.

Sitting in the chair, looking at herself in the mirror, she jumped a little when the woman behind her let down her ponytail and the hair cascaded around her face. Her eyes looked bluer somehow. She brought her hand up and touched her hair, winding a lock around her finder. Distantly she heard the barber ask what she wanted. She could hardly tell her that she just wanted to change, could she.

"Cut it short." The words blurted out of her mouth before she could stop them.

“How short?” Other hands were in her hair now, sifting through and examining the length. She could see the hair in the mirror falling from those hands and looking like golden wings.

“Short enough that it won’t fall into my face when I work, I guess. Other than that I don’t really know.” Did she sound childish, sitting there like that?

“Well, that’s a start. I won’t go mad, you tell me when you like the look of it in the mirror and I will stop and style it.” That made her relax her shoulders and nod with a smile.

As the hair rained down onto the floor, Adora felt lighter somehow. Maybe it was just not having the weight of the hair, or maybe it was more symbolic than that? Whatever it was, with every swish of the scissors through the golden strands Adora felt more and more relaxed.

After thirty minutes and much back and forth, Adora found herself sitting there with hair that barely brushed her collar. It was short at the nape of her neck and messily long on top, flopping onto her forehead but not into her eyes. Around her ears the hair curled and tickled a little but she had to admit that she looked all at once older, but more carefree. It softened her face and her blue eyes shone. It highlighted her jawline and made her feel just as confident as pulling the hair back and cinching it up always had.

“Do you like it?” The barber stood behind her, expectantly.

“I love it. Thank you so much.” Adora spun in her seat to give the woman a smile.

“You’ll need to come back every few months just to keep it looking like that, it’ll need more attention than your old style,” Adora laughed at the warning. That didn’t sound so bad. She said as much and the two women left each other with agreement that Adora would return.

Sporting new clothes and a new haircut, Adora started to feel like she was making positive changes. Granted they were superficial

ones, but it was more forward momentum than she had made in a decade. All her old fears about change had melted away. Now it was time to think about what bigger changes she could make. That was what led her to the coffee in the middle of Brightmoon, outside of the castle, where she waited, absently tapping her fingers on the wooden table top as she waited for company.

Taking a sip of her tea, she almost choked when a hand settled on her shoulder. Managing not to take a defence posture, she swallowed and gave the new arrival a smile. General Juliet was one of a very small group of people who had the skill to take her off guard. Even Glimmer's magic made enough of a disturbance for her to be able to spot her presence…well most of the time.

"Thank you for agreeing to come, Juliet." Adora seldom addressed her without her title, if the general wasn't curious already, she was now.

The dark haired woman had noticed the change in the younger woman. It was hard to miss. The closely cropped hair that was playfully tousled, the more casual clothes in a range of colours that flattered her frame and made her look more at ease and less like a girl who had just run away from a military dictatorship. It had all happened quickly, but Juliet though that it was about time.

"I was curious. You've never sought me out before. Truthfully, other than the war, I think you and I have only spoken privately regarding your use of my security team as a dating pool." She quirked an eyebrow and shot the other woman a smirk to show that she was teasing.

"Not some of my finest moments." Adora was proud of herself when she managed not to blush at the joke.

"So what can I help you with Adora?" Juliet gestured to a nearby waitress who scurried off to get her order. It looked like she was a regular here.

"I have decided that I need something to do, a job. I can't keep on waiting for the other shoe to drop. Most of the major reconstruction had ended, there are no more enemies left for me to fight and I can't bare sitting around. I know Glimmer wants more help with the village but I was wondering if you had anything?" Adora took a drink as she waited.

Though Juliet was based in the palace, her formal role was general of all of the Brightmoon troops. She looked at her companion, saying a distracted 'thanks' to the waiter who placed her drink down. Even though they may not be at war, the price of peace was eternal vigilance.

"I think I have a few things for you, especially with this Oasis situation. Your prior military training would make you idea for liaising with them, if things get that far. For now, I have some roles I think you would be perfect for. Several of my command team want to retire, so give me a few months and you'll have a role. I'll send you some documents and you can see if any of it suits." Adora smiled brightly, that had been easier than she had imagined.

She wondered why she had waited so long.

Standing in front of the shield, waiting for it to part and let her in, Perfuma felt a thrill of excitement run down her spine. It had been three weeks since they had found Oasis and already she was returning to work with the farmers on how to cultivate more crops. It was humbling to be invited back and to be told that they trusted her to use her magic with discretion. She had not come alone, bringing several of the best horticulturalists from Plumeria with her as well as wagons full of seeds and seedlings pulled by horses. All together there were ten people in the plumeria party and each was almost as excited as their leader.

Almost.

Perfuma was excited to help, of course, but she was just as excited at the thought of seeing Scorpia again. Though they had only spent a little time together, Perfuma could admit that she was smitten with the scorpioni woman. They had kept in contact through the tracker pads, speaking almost daily since she returned to Plumeria. It had been a shock when the device had chirruped one night as she prepared for bed. She had picked it up, assuming she would see Bow on the screen only to feel her face light up when the white haired woman appeared.

Scorpia had been almost giddy that she had answered, then quickly chagrinned that she had had disturbed her. Before Perfuma had managed to breath her name, the rambling woman had been about to end the call, apologising all the while. Perfuma had managed to stop her with a reassurance that she was just as pleased to see her. It had started a nightly routine. Perfuma would perform her duties as princess and before bed she and Scorpia would talk about their days.

Perfuma had never found anyone she could talk to as easily as Scorpia. Perfuma was naturally a listener, taking on other people problems and helping to relieve their burden but she knew that often the other princesses didn't understand her. The Plumerians around her understood more about her, but she was separated from them by the weight of her responsibilities. In Scorpia she had found a kindred spirit. Sometimes, after they spoke, Perfuma would find herself dreaming about a version of their lives where Scorpia had been raised as the princess she had been born to be and that the two of them had met at a ball.

It was a dream that she had often over the weeks and now, with the shield shimmering in front of her and the sound of excited voices behind, she felt her heart flutter. The shield dropped in a large archway, revealing a team of men and women who surveyed them before waving them through. Perfuma tried not to frown when she realised that none of them were Scorpia. Telling her people to go ahead and follow the road, she was just about to climb onto the back of a wagon when she heard heavy footfalls of someone running towards them.

She climbed down in time to see Scorpia come to a stop just feet away. Sending her people on, while Scorpia dismissed the guards now that the shield was back up, they just stood and looked at each other across the space. Perfuma noticed a pretty pink blush creeping up Scorpia neck as she fidgeted with her claws, screwing the tips of them together. Perfuma moved forward, reaching out her hand to rest it onto one of the large pincers, feeling the cool, smooth surface under her skin. Scorpia froze, eyes wide as she examined the fragile hand starkly pale against her red shell.

Perfuma felt soft, looking at this giant woman who was so very gentle. How the Horde could have taken someone so sweet and try to make them into a weapon was just one more thing for her to hate them fore and be thankful that they were gone. Though they had only seen each other though a screen for the last three weeks they had talked about everything. She had never felt closer to anyone. Never felt more attracted to anyone.

She reached out her other hand and cupped Scorpia's cheek, bringing those coal dark eyes up to meet hers. Scorpia blushed even harder, trying to lower her eyes again in embarrassment. Perfuma couldn't have that. She moved closer still, Scorpia's claws and her hand now trapped between their bodies. Scorpia may be a physical imposing woman, but Perfuma was just as tall, her willowy frame bowing forward to connect her lips with the startled ones in front of her. It was a soft kiss, little more than a press of lips, but she was sure that she was blushing now too. She pulled away a little.

"Was that ok? I should have asked first I'm…" Before she could say more Scorpia was initiating another kiss, deeper this time but still close lipped. She drew her claws from between then and drew Perfuma closer with as much care as she would hand glass. It was perfect.

Scorpia reluctantly pulled away, extending an elbow for Perfuma to take. The blond eschewed the elbow and took her claw carefully in her hand. Scorpia looked at once worried but very much warmed by the action.

They made their way back to Capital in Scorpia's transporter. It wasn't a long journey, but it gave them time to talk and laugh together like a pair of school girls. By the time they had drawn level with the Plumarian delegation, the centre of the city was towering overhead. Perfuma's eyes were on the woman beside her though, watching a host of expressions pass over her face as she clearly fought with something on her mind, eyes fixed on the path ahead.

"Scorpia, everything ok in there?" Perfuma stroked a finger along the white hair at her temple, careful not to distract her.

"Oh, yeah, everything is fine. Yep, nothing going on up there." She stopped for a moment and Perfuma watched her brow furrow. "I mean, something is going on up there, obviously, I have thoughts. Lots of thoughts." She was rambling endearingly, Perfuma decided to save her from it.

"Are any of those thoughts about me?"

"Lots of them!" Scorpia smiled hugely, not embarrassed to say that. Perfuma laughed. It seemed to give Scorpia a shot of courage. "I was wondering, well it's just an idea, but whether you would like to stay at the orphanage with me?" She looked over and saw the other woman eyes widen and rushed on, "You don't have to. There are rooms at the hotel for everyone. You probably want to stay with your team, you're in charge after all. It was a silly thing to ask. Forget I asked it. No questions here." She was steering the vehicle to a stop, they had slightly over taken the Plumerians, and Scorpia jumped out before Perfuma could say anything in response, to flag down the wagons as they too would be took cumbersome to navigate the narrow streets of the city.

Perfuma got out and directed her people to get their personal items from the wagon and that they would be safe left where they were. In the hum of activity she went back to Scorpia who was waiting to lead them all to the hotel, Perfuma had already pulled her large bag from a wagon and held it with both hands.

“Scorpia, I would love to come and stay with you at the orphanage. I think it sounds lovely. My people are capable of looking after their personal time. So, if the offer is still open, the answer is yes.” She gave Scorpia her most sincere smile, receiving a bashful one in return, accompanied by a nod and her bag being taken from her with ease as Scorpia slung it over her shoulder as though it weighed nothing. Perfuma’s heart may have fluttered at that, but she was almost certain that she did not swoon. No matter what any observers may have said.

The gaggle of Plumerians had been awed by the place as they approached it, seeing the lush grass that led up to the city, all too happy not to crush it with their wagons. Once inside the city their eyes had bugged at the sight of the pristine structures so alien from their own organic home. Scorpia took them to the hotel and they were given their rooms. Perfuma gathered them all together for a pep talk about respecting the rules of the city and the amenities of the hotel. There work would start tomorrow, so she told them to have a great time in the city. Each of them was provided with one of the small handheld tablets that Scorpia carried with a map and a quick link to their princess.

Explaining that she was going to stay at the orphanage, she left with Scorpia to a chorus of happy goodbyes. She was almost certain that her people would stay out of trouble. They would undoubtedly find Bazaar and, hopefully, charm the locals. She seemed to have charmed one already.

The walk to Scorpia’s home seemed to take an instant, both women just caught up in connecting with each other. Any worry either had harboured that their easy rapport over coms would not be replicated in reality had been dashed almost instantly. If anything, the pull to each other was stronger than ever before. Scorpia guided her into the orphanage, once again deserted with the children still in school, and up to her room.

Scorpia’s room was big enough to accommodate a double bed, a desk and a wardrobe. Everything was simple and functional, much like the hotel had been. In fact the room reminded Perfuma very

much of the space where she had spent her last stay. A few framed pictures adorned the desk, a tattered soft toy placed between them. Scorpia gently placed the bag on the bed before walking over and opening a door to reveal a small bathroom with a shower.

"So, ah, this is me." Scorpia stood beside that open doorway, claws outstretched, looking a little lost.

Perfuma walked to her and slotted herself into the other woman's personal space, wrapping her own arms around her neck, weaving her long fingers into white hair, she felt Scorpia bring her arms down to circle her waist. Smiling dopily, they leaned their foreheads together and sank into each others touch. It was safe to say both were very much smitten.

Before they could kiss again, the main door of the room was flung open with a bang and a screaming ball of fur rushed in. Perfuma jumped, ready to tackle an intruder, but Scorpia squeezed her waist reassuringly, laughing at what Perfuma now realised was a completely naked kitten.

"Scorpia! Save Yar-Yar!" The giggling child threw herself onto the bed and curled up in a tiny ball behind Perfuma's bag going eerily silent and still.

Before Perfuma could say anything, a soaking wet Catra stomped into the room, leaving wet footprints on the smooth floor. Her tail was limp and her ears were flattened against her head. Her shirt and pants were moulded to her skin by the weight of the water. She walked into the room without knocking or looking at Scorpia and her guest, making a beeline straight to the bed where the kitten was hiding.

"Yarsha, please get off of Scorpia's bed." Her voice was calm, if anything it was too calm. She waited, careful not to stand on the rug or touch the bed with her saturated form. Perfuma was surprised that Catra had been able to hear the child who had

seemed so silent to her human ears. She was also shocked by Catra's composure even though she was obviously annoyed.

"No!"

"Yarsha, you are naked and you smell. Please get off of Scorpia's clean bed." Catra's tried to appeal to the kitten. The child sat up, looked at her care giver, and promptly shook her head.

"No!"

"Please, Yarsha. Ra is getting cold, and you do smell my little fuzzy-butt. I know you love the bath. We can play with your ducky family." That seemed to get the child's attention and she started to edge towards the bigger cat.

"You do ducky voices." It seemed that Perfuma was witnessing one hell of a negotiation, she had turned in the circle of Scorpia's arms to face the bed and could feel the big scorpion shaking with mirth, her face pressed to Perfuma's neck to hide any sound she couldn't keep in. The princess wondered how often this scene had played out before.

"Yes, I'll do ducky voices. Come on." She held out her arms, expecting the little one to jump into them. Instead, Yarsha stayed just out of reach. "Come on."

"No! You do ducky voices now." Her little face was scrunched into a pout so adorable that Perfuma couldn't hold in the 'aww' and got thrown matching dirty looks from both cats.

"Yarsha!"

"NO! Ducky!" Catra sighed. Resigned…

"And then…

AND THEN…" Perfuma was giggling just thinking about it.

“Catra started to quack like a duck! It was honestly amazing, and she made the duck sound like it was talking. Yarsha jumped off the bed straight away and from what I could tell the next day, bath time was a great success.” Perfuma had come to tell Brightmoon about her first foray to work with Oasis. The other Alliance members had come together for the meeting, planning for the worst but hoping for the best. The formal report had detailed the agricultural work and how welcome her people had been. The best seemed to be all she had to share

The informal report began with her relaying the bath time incident, which got giggles from most of the people gathered around the table. Obviously she censored what she told them about her relationship with Scorpia, not out of shame but out of covetousness. That was for her. She shared more about her time spent with the former Horde Second in Command, out in the farm area and with the children. It painted a positive picture.

“That all sounds very sweet. A great act. Let’s see how long she can keep it up after repeated visits.” Glimmer was becoming exhausting, Perfuma thought. Her aura was just dark all the time lately.

“Did you ask to see the Halfmoon?” Angella took up from her daughter, keen not to derail the meeting into another diatribe about Catra.

“I did enquire and was told that it was not a place for outsiders. I asked the full council. There was a suggestion that in time it could be a possibility but it was a matter of trust.” It hadn’t been quite that diplomatic but Perfuma didn’t think they needed to hear that.

The meeting broke up soon after that, everybody heading home. Kingdoms didn’t run themselves. Adora declined lunch with the royal family and headed back to her room alone.

Back in her room, Adora threw herself into her chair at her desk. Why did hearing good things about Oasis make her feel like this? Was she still as angry as Glimmer? Was that what this was? With

a noise that was something close to a strangled scream she ran her fingers through her shorn hair, frustrated when there was far less to sooth herself with than before. She began to open and close drawers, searching for something to distract herself with.

Doors banged open and closed as she looked for a distraction. She would rummage through pencils and paperwork, riffling through notebooks, looking for some project or other than she could do. She got to one drawer, closer to the bottom and deeper than the others, pulling it and finding it stuck. In no mood to be stymied, she transformed into She-ra and tore the drawer out with such force that it flew out of her hand and landed with a bounce on the bed, the contents spilling out onto the comforter and the floor.

Back in her normal form, sighing gustily as she surveyed the mess, she walked forward and started collecting the things on the floor. At least cleaning would be a distraction, she supposed. Most of what was on the floor were old war plans, long since passed useless. Something darker caught her eye, having skittered under the bed. Bending down she pulled out the torn remnants of the book on magicats that she had been reading before the mission. Her blue eyes widened and she searched feverishly for the rest of it. The book must have been what was keeping the drawer stuck and been shredded when the drawer was opened.

Sitting on the floor, carefully patching the book back together, her mind began to whirl at a mile a minute. If the magicats had arrived, as Double Trouble had claimed, on a large space ship, and been in some kind of forever sleep, how was there a book about their history?

Pawing through the information, she found the book had been written five hundred years ago, long after the alleged crash. Adora had been drawn to the images of children and adult magicats, only skimming the information for clues about Catra. Now, looking more closely at the introduction, it became clear that much of the book had been written by collecting journals and the journals of witnesses. Very little was based on solid physical evidence. How

much of this was true and how much of what Catra's people claimed was lies?

Head spinning, she thought about George and Lance and their research into First Ones that had led George to get a tattoo that said 'lunch' not 'love' and how historians didn't always have the full picture. Maybe she should take a trip to the woods, with the remnants of the book, and see what they had to say? Settling on that as a plan she put the reconstructed book to the side and finished cleaning the mess. Thankfully the drawer itself had survived unscathed and slid back where it belonged.

Unable to stop herself, she found herself riffling through the pages of that old tome until she came to the picture of a child. She stared at it, taking in the details. It wasn't perfect, certainly it was what somebody who had read a description of what a magicat looked like might draw, but it was close enough. It was a child who looked like Catra. A child who looked like Yarsha.

If the magicat's had crash landed a thousand years ago and nobody woke up, how could this book from half as long ago have pictures that showed them so accurately?

Chapter End Notes

Short hair Adora and mohawk Catra? Yes, yes please.

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Water and sand.

Chapter Notes

Sorry this one is a little late. It's been written and deleted twice as I was not happy with it. Hopefully this is worth the wait - a little longer than usual.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Finding herself preening in front of her mirror, Scorpia blushed as she tugged on the hem of her blouse with her pincers, careful not to tear it. She didn't know why she felt so anxious. Perfuma's last visit had been a success, they had shared their first kiss and a bed, though things hadn't gone any further than that. It had been amazing just to sleep beside the younger woman. With all the work the Plumerian's had been doing each day in the fields , the willowy princess had been worn out at the end of each day. Scorpia had wanted to take her out and share Oasis with her, in a different way when she had just been giving a tour, but hadn't pushed when she had seen the fatigued in her eyes.

Instead, the two of them had spent four days eating with the children and hanging out with them in the common areas. Scorpia had been delighted by how open the other woman had been with them. The children had wanted to ask a million questions about being a princess, how she had helped in the war and why she used magic. It had been interesting to hear her answers, how the magic of the Heart Blossom made her feel. Scorpia had never felt connected to the Black Garnet, even now that it was in the spire and untouched by tech. She wondered what it would be like to feel that kind of connection to something, or somebody.

It had been puzzling to see Catra interact with the single princess, and the other Plumerians. The magicat was oddly still and

restrained, as though she was working hard not to make a bad impression. Scorpia couldn't blame her best friend, she may have been a sweetheart but the scorpioni wasn't naive enough to think that Perfuma would be compelled to tell the other Alliance members everything regarding the cat woman.

The first night shenanigans with Yarsha and the bath had gone a long was to disabuse the Plumarian of any preconceptions about the former invader. Scorpia was used to the slapstick antics of the cat family, often with some of the orphans pulled into it too. She had simply taken their boisterous entrance as an excuse to hold Perfuma class and muffle her giggle sin her sweet smelling hair.

It had turned out, after the strange noise that Catra made as a talking duck, and the laughter of everybody in the room, that Yarsha had managed to dodge Catra in the bathroom - tripping heron the progress and sending her head first into the full tub. Scorpia had watched Perfuma's face as Catra had told them how she got into that state. She had looked bemused and not a little charmed by the magicat. It had made Scorpia fall for her even harder than she already had.

A much drier Catra and fully dressed Yarsha, adorned in her little blue pyjamas, had joined them for dinner at the kittens insistence. She had clambered up onto the lanky woman's lap and promptly refused to budge, eating her dinner from there. Catra had been soft and quiet, not that she was usually particularly mean these days, but after more than a decade Scorpia could tell she was on her very best behaviour. It was strange to see Catra make herself smaller like this, all for the good of everyone around her.

Scorpia hoped she would relax; and after three days things had been more comfortable. She wanted the Alliance to be able to see the real Catra who had grown out of the adversity of her whole life and not some staid person who hid herself. That would just affirm all of their fears that the woman had something nefarious to hide. She had said as much. Catra had considered her words and agreed to try to be more 'real' in front of Perfuma.

Scorpia and Perfuma had cuddled together each night, the slighter woman held gently in front of her as they lay propped up in her bed, chest to back. In the twilight cast by the pale moonlight filtering through the open windows, they talked and talked as they did over coms, only now peppered with soft kisses and gentle touches until they fell asleep together.

That had been four weeks ago, it felt like longer but at least they could speak and see each others faces every day. Today was the day that she would see Perfuma again, accompanied by the Selinean princess on her first visit to work on the ever pressing issue of water, and she wanted to make a good impression. It was important to her that Perfuma's friends thought that she was worthy of her, that she could have been a princess just like them. Catra had told she was being ridiculous when she passed by her door on her way to work, that she was just as good as any princess, better even. Scorpia had felt touched by the gruff, almost harsh praise. Long ago she would have rushed over and pulled her friend into an uncomfortable hug. Nowadays she knew better and the two just exchanged a smile as Catra swung a giggling Yarsha onto her back and headed off with the little girl shouting about how pretty Scorpia looked.

Satisfied with her look and knowing that it was fast approaching time to meet the new delegation. A furred head poked into her room, bi-coloured eyes appraising her from top to toe and making Scorpia blush like a school girl. She and Catra may have had a fleeting romance and be best friends now, but she could still admit to herself just how attractive she found the magicat. The fact that she was giving her an approving smile made her confidence boost, as did her words.

"You ready?" Scorpia nodded and made her way to the door. "Perfuma's not going to know what hit her."

"Thanks," Scorpia felt bashful as she walked down the hall with her friend. "You sure you want to come to the shield? I can bring them both back."

“Nah, it’ll be fine. Figure I’ll take the water one with me to the crack. I need to do a tour and check the perimeter and the equipment. Entrapta told me there was a problem on the west side, something making her equipment go nuts.” It always surprised Scorpia how Catra downplayed her responsibilities. She may not be on the council, but she did far more for the community than anyone - taking too much on her shoulders, if you asked the scorpioni.

“Where’s Yarsha?” She peered around her friend seeing no sign of the tiny kitten.

“Kyle came to get her, he was doing a pastry delivery for the kids and saved me the trip into Bazaar.” It was good to hear her speak so fondly of the man who had often left them so exasperated when they were younger.

They walked though the orphanage, saying their hellos to children who were getting ready for school. Snagging a piece of toast each they made there way out to the street and headed to the edge of the city, shoulder to shoulder.

Mermista rolled her eyes at the woman next to her as she fidgeted with her hair for the millionth time since they arrived at the barrier that blocked the world from seeing Oasis. The water princess was a little excited herself, not that she would admit it of course. That just wasn’t her brand, even at thirty. The idea of finding water and bringing it to irrigate the desert was fascinating and a challenge that she was looking forward to. Since the war and the rebuilding of Selineas were over, she had been feeling a little stifled. Here she could do something that would challenge her.

Looking over at Perfuma again, she wondered what was going on with the other woman. She had never seen her behave this way. She had always assumed that the lanky woman wasn’t interested in romantic entanglements. She always seemed to be on a higher

path, thinking about how her actions affected the world around her and not herself. It was something that Mermista admired about her, though she would never tell the taller woman. It was just too much fun to tease her. The fact that her eye had been caught by a former soldier, and not just any soldier - a Force Captain that they had fought multiple times, was startling. Maybe she was hoping to change her or maybe they were always meant to have a chance and with the war taken out of the equation they had a chance. Mermista rolled her eyes at herself; when had she become such a sap?

Mermista turned her attention to the other, equally squirrelly blond standing behind her. Perfuma's first visit had been accompanied by ten of her people, though peaceful there was safety in numbers. Glimmer had been unwilling to let two princesses go without protection. She would have been happier to send a small army, but Queen Angella had simply cast her a look and agreed to Adora joining them. Naturally, Mermista had pointed out that Adora was also a princess, but she had seen how less and less of what others said had any impact on Glimmer these days. She had been all too keen for She-ra to be in the mix. The sea princess was ever grateful that Queen Angella wouldn't be standing down any time soon, her calm and measured presence was needed in the Alliance.

Adora had been unnaturally quiet on their brief, Glimmer assisted, journey. Mermista would have expected her to be chattering and goofing around, just as keen as the rest of them to see more of this unique and mysterious desert hideaway. Instead she had been somber, waking behind the other two women and largely out of sight. There was something pinched about her eyes and her shoulders were stiff. Maybe the idea of interacting with so many former members of the Horde without the safety net of Bow and Glimmer was a little daunting or perhaps it was to do with Catra. Everything seemed to back to the cat woman. Obviously, Mermista had no love lost with the other woman, she had tried to attack the Sea Gate after all, but that was in the past.

Shimmering in front of then brought the blue haired woman's attention back and there, instead of the vista of sand dunes, stood Scorpia and Catra. She wasn't surprised to see the pair, it was what had been agreed with the council, from the gasp at her side clearly Adora had not been anticipating seeing the magicat. Honestly, was she the only one that read the paperwork? Maybe Mermista wasn't as transgressive as she thought.

Shaking off that notion, because really she was surrounded by squares (maybe not Catra but, honestly, the jury was still very out on her) Mermista walked forward with Perfuma. She could feel the taller woman almost vibrating with happiness as she got closer and closer to the big scorpion who was blushing warmly and looking up through thick, dark lashes. It made her feel a little like she was an interloper, but it was cute to see.

"Welcome back to Oasis," Catra was the one who spoke up, greeting them with her rough lightly amused voice. It was a tone familiar from the battlefield, but as her startling eyes were also fixed on the women trying not to run into each others arms for proprieties sake, it didn't seem cruel.

It was because she was watching her friend that it took Catra a moment to notice that Mermista and Perfuma were not the only ones waiting at the shield. The tall blond shuffled uncomfortably and blue and yellow eyes shot towards her, widening almost in-perceptively before narrowing and pursing her lips. As fast as it came it passed as she turned her attention back to the white-haired woman at her side and gave her a non-too-gentle show towards the visitors.

"Give her a hug before you burst, will ya? I can feel you vibrating from here." Scorpia blushed almost as scarlet as her shell, but was suddenly moving forward and taking an equally blushing Perfuma into her arms for a hug.

Catra turned her attention away from the tender moment to look at the two other princesses. This time not changing her expression as she looked between them. Cocking her hip and

resting a hand there lazily, creepily reminiscent to both Mermista and Adora of her battlefield posse, she lazily waved a finger of her other hand between the two. “I thought the council agreed that you and Perfuma were allowed in this month?”

Mermista sighed, she should have known that nobody would have thought to actually tell the people they were, for all intents and purposes, spying on that they were bringing more people. No way that could cause an incident!

“Queen Angella thought it best that Adora accompany us this time, you know how it is.” She tilted her head and made a noncommittal gesture with her hand. Far more diplomatic than saying they didn’t trust them.

“Scorpia!” Catra’s slightly raised voice broke the two women out of their low conversation and made the scorpioni’s head swivel to her. “We have extra company.” She indicated Adora with her hand, “You represent the council. Is she permitted entry?”

“Oh, oh I see. That should be fine. I will speak to the rest of the council when we get back. I mean, it would have been nice to let us know beforehand…logistically.” A look of consternation passed over her face as she turned to look back in the direction of Capital. She looked back to Catra and jerked her head towards something which elicited an exasperated sigh from the furred woman as they both started to walk back inside the shield. “Please follow us.” Scorpia threw over her shoulder.

Perfuma was the first to walk in, clearly already feeling safe and at home within the shield, Mermista and Adora weren’t far behind but made sure to look for any potential ambush as they did. They saw nothing there except for two vehicles a small ways off. One was a transporter like the ones that had ferried then to the city on their first visit while the other had two far wheels and could clearly only accommodate two people. It was matt in colour and looked harsh and aggressive, it wasn’t a surprise to see Catra pick up a helmet that had cat ears protruding from it, to know that this

was hers. She looked from the helmet in her hand, to Adora and Mermista and sighed heavily, walking over to the larger vehicle.

"So, how do you want to do this? The plan was for Perfuma to head back to the city with Scorpia and I was going to take Mermista to look at the fissure where we suspect we could get another irrigation source. I guess it's up to Adora to where she wants to go." There was something steely in her words that made Adora have to fight against squirming.

Adora had known that coming to Oasis without notification was a bad idea, but she was desperate to com back to the place so didn't speak up. She had yet to be invited, having nothing to offer this burgeoning place or so it seemed. They didn't need a legendary warrior. Nobody did anymore… shaking off those morose thoughts, she made eye contact with her old friend, realising that she may have hesitated too long in responding as she notices a taught tail fighting against lashing.

"I should probably go with Mermista, take a look at this fissure?" She meant it as a statement but her voice rose at the end faltering and turning it into a question.

"Fine. Pretty much what I expected, can't let the evil beast take the princess down a big hole by herself," it sounded self deprecating and Scorpia laughed, but Adora noticed the cloudy look in her eyes as she spoke. "Scorp, you got a helmet in there? Mine'll probably fit Perfuma. You can take the sled back and I'll use the wagon." Both of the desert residents moved over to the large vehicle and Scorpia pulled out two helmets and stuffed some small items into her pocket.

"I have a helmet you can wear Perfuma, we keep spares for the patrols in the wagons. No cat ears I'm afraid." She was smiling, voice full of mirth and everyone relaxed. Scorpia took Perfuma's bag and put it in the wagon, Adora followed suit with hers and Mermista's, reaching passed Catra to put them in the bed of the truck and shivering as she felt fur brush against the skin of her arm.

"OK, so you two head back to town and we'll go to the crack. I'll keep in contact." Catra ushered her two charges to get in as the two taller women mounted the smaller vehicle with helmets firmly attached. Engines roared and the two groups headed their separate ways.

The fissure turned out to be an intimidatingly large tear in the ground that seemed to stretch for miles in a jagged curve. One side rose up above the crack while the other was rocky and prevented the transport from getting too close. The journey had been quiet, save for Catra filling the duo in on what they were about to approach.

"This area, that we call the fissure, is actually a deep gauge in the ground caused when the Halfmoon crashed. If you follow the curve you see here, the terrain alters and you will find the crater that I discovered when I found the ship. We're hoping that what we suspect is an underground reservoir is sitting just underneath it but we can't risk anyone mining lower and Entrapta can't make a bot small enough. Hence you. We're hoping you'll be able to find it, if it's there."

"Sounds like a challenge, but if you have water I will be able to find it."

"I…I got the impression from what Double Trouble told us, about the ship, that it was much further away from the city?" Adora's voice had been low but very curious. Mermista noticed that the blond was trying to make herself quite small as though she shouldn't be there.

"Hmm…" Catra's distracted hum made both passengers look out of the front window to see her manoeuvring around several rocks and heading towards a small group who were waving welcome. "It was days away from where the shanty town was. Capital as

you see it now is almost on top of the ship. It helped Entrapta rig the ships shield and cloak to hide Oasis." Neither princess knew what a cloak was but they could guess. What shocked them was the idea of how big this ship was. They had heard that thousands of people were on it, but the only space craft they had ever seen was Adora's First One ship and that was no bigger than a house. The idea of something as big as a city being able to fly at all was mind boggling. "We're here."

The wagon stopped and Catra was out without another word, heading towards the group of four magicats who were shouting and waving. Not knowing what else to do, they followed, picking their way carefully over the craggy ground. As they got closer they could make out the words that the young men and women were saying, there was nothing suspicious just the excited greetings of people happy to see one of their own.

"Chief! We thought you were only bringing one person?" A head popped up from the ground as a grey cat pulled themself over with bared claws and brute strength. They stood, head just reaching Catra's shoulder, and shook themself hard, a dust cloud puffing out from them. Adora coughed and waved a hand in front of herself to clear the air. When the dust settled, the new arrival was shown to be black, rather than grey.

"Kesh, why were you down the hole?" The older cat's eyebrow was cocked as she waited for a response.

"I was just fixing the climbing rigs, I checked all five. I must have known you were bringing more people." Bright, pale blue eyes turned to the two human women and appraised them. The eyes of all of the other magicats joined them and Adora found herself fighting not to squirm. Beside her Mermista seemed as cool as ever under the scrutiny. Catra was still staring fixedly at the younger female. "What?"

"You all know that you are not to go down there alone. It's too dangerous." This wasn't her command voice, but something more like Adora would have expected Catra to use with her child.

“We knew where she was, Chief.” A bulky calico furred man spoke up, his voice a low burr that could be felt as much as heard. He was clearly young, but had a serious demeanour. “We were all here waiting. If anything had happened we would have had her. You don’t need to worry about us out here. Nobody is risking themself. We were all just excited that you were bringing visitors from outside.”

“I just wanted to be ready, Chief!” Kesh’s voice was youthful and exuberant.

“You all need to stop calling me that.” Catra shook her head, affectionately exasperated. Adora understood, it was annoying to be called by your job title and not your name.

“We could all start calling you CC?” This came from another male, younger than the others, with pure white fur and a charming smile that bared his wicked teeth.

“You can try and see how far that gets you.” Looking around, she seemed pleased with what they had heard. “When do you guys rotate?”

“Three days. Then Jorth’s here with Midrall and some of the younger kids.” The deep voice was soothing and it was hard not to listen to him.

“Thanks Varga, you’ve been doing a great job!” The man almost giggled at the praise and it made Adora happy to know that Catra was gentle with her people. “These two are from the Alliance, they’ll need rigging up.”

Adora waved self consciously, making several of the onlookers tilt their heads to take her in and she wished that she could hide behind one of the boulders. Seeing so many adult magicats in one place was strange, the blond was trying not to get caught staring. It was one thing to see all the children together and the odd adult on the street of Capital, but six of them all at once was a lot to take in after a lifetime of thinking that Catra was the only one.

Adora didn't know what she expected, but like when she reached Brightmoon she saw individuals of all different shapes and sizes. Their was fur ranging from steely grey to almost luminous orange and some of the even had whiskers. They were all dressed similarly though, much like Catra was dressed today. She had foregone the sandy uniform in favour of shorts that clung down to the knee and a singlet with a close fitting tee underneath. Looking at the fissure, it was obvious that this was what they wore to climb to allow themselves freedom of movement. Adora looked down at herself and over to Mermista and was glad that at least they were both wearing pants to climb down.

While Catra pointed out equipment and explained it to Mermista, Adora examined the group while pulling on a climbing harness. Most of the magicats were around twenty, she guessed, and all were very focused on Catra. They nodded at her words, some chipping in to add information about climbing down. The small, energetic cat who had climbed up, Kesh, was helping Mermista to secure her climbing gear, softly pointing out how the ropes would work.

"I hope neither of you are afraid of heights or tight dark places." Catra stood on the edge of the ravine, looking down.

"You know I've never been afraid of heights." Adora smiled, voice light.

"People change, Adora. Can't take anything for granted." The words were flat as she walked to the edge of the cliff and let herself fall over the side, unharnessed.

Both Adora a Mermista dashed to the edge, breathlessly looking down to see what had become of the cat, only to see her hanging by her claws dug deep into the rock. The laughing at their backs as the other magicats saw their shock and worry. Kesh, who just come over the side of the ravine, rested a gentle hand on Adora's back and said, "She's a little bit prickly but she's okay."

“Yeah…” It was strange to have somebody take to her as though the hanging woman was a stranger to her.

“You two need to wait until she gets to the bottom, she’ll radio up so that she can monitor your descent. Do you both know how to abseil?” It had been a term that the cat creatures had learned, not needing the ropes themselves to climb, and they had been fascinated with how the humans dealt with their lack of claws.

“Yeah, it was something I was taught growing up.” Adora wasn’t sure why, but she didn’t want to tell these people that she had been Horde.

“Great, how bout you?” The eerily pale eyes turned to Mermista who shrugged, she had never down this before. “Ok, how about blondie goes down first and you can watch what she does and I’ll show you how the rig lets you belay?” It was clear that this small group were used to letting people down here.

Adora walked to the edge of the chasm, checking her ropes one more time, before she walked her body back into the abyss.

The bottom of the deep crevice was dull, twilight lit by small phosphorescent lamps attached to the walls at shoulder and ankle height. It was enough to be able to navigate without risk of a turned ankle or bashed head. As Adora shucked off her harness, she saw large torches waiting to be used by the climbing equipment. The wobbling of the rope to her right caught her attention and she watched as Catra reached up to steady it. The muscles in her arms were bunching under her fur and the dim light silhouetted them. Adora found it hard to look away, she had noticed the physical changes in the magicat on their first visit, but now she could look unabashedly while the other woman’s focus was on Mermista’s slow descent.

Catra was so much taller and broader than she remembered, her hands sure against the rope as they stretched up and held firm.

She watched biceps bulge as the rope started to wave and she pulled it harder to steady the woman that had let out an undignified scream from above. Her face broke into a small, familiar smirk at the sound as she ruefully shook her head and steadied her former foe. A pang of something familiar filled her chest, she had seen that look a hundred times in training when Lonnie would be losing or Kyle would fall. As much as she had changed, there was still a part of Catra that still seemed to be the girl she had known.

Adora fought her desire to let her eyes roam over the body of the woman in front of her further. It was one thing to watch her control the rope, she could convince herself that it was because she wanted to ensure Mermista's safety, another to think about the strength of her legs or the way that her toes flexed in the dirt. Even as children she had admired the wild physiology of the other girl, how differently her body moved and how her fur and claws made her seem dangerous. Adora had always found comfort in her differences, had studied her movements to try to be more graceful in her own; it was how she had learned to climb the rickety places of the Fright Zone adeptly enough not to fall to her death. Now her need to look was not about studying her form, if it ever had been, and she dragged her gaze away.

As the blond walked over to the neatly piled equipment that was kept down here, Catra guided Mermista the last of the way down and unhitched her harness. When the three of them were together by the lights and packs, Catra handed each of her companions a light the size of a brick and a small pack containing a couple of ration bars and canteen of water. Mermista looked at her as she slipped the strap of the bag over her head, Adora doing the same beside her. Catra was looping her pack around her waist so that it rested on her hip.

"Why the supplies?" Mermista's monotone fell flatly between the close, steep walls that enclosed them.

"We'll be down here a while and we never take chances. A cave-in isn't likely," her tone became weary at the words, "but if we were

to be trapped down here its better to be prepared."

Before they set off, Catra moved to the far wall, several feet away, and placed her hand against it and then her forehead. She stayed like that for several beats before pulling back and joining them again. There was something about the gesture that made Adora think of late nights, whispering to each other in the dark, heads pressed together for comfort. Whatever was behind that rock wall obviously had meaning.

"We need to follow the crack until it branches, we're pretty sure there's no water here, but it comes into three branches and from there its all you." She pointed her light at Mermista. "This is the widest point, it's why we put the comb here, it gets pretty tight up ahead. In some paces you might need to go sideways. You shouldn't get stuck, just don't panic when it gets small. You mind going up front, Princess?"

"Why?" Mermista's voice was suspicious and she seemed more than a little perturbed.

"It'll be hard to change positions up ahead and we're going to following your water sense." There was no sign of subterfuge in her voice so Mermista lit her torch and started to walk.

Adora was next, showing trust in their guide as she took the middle position in their little procession. Her boots crunched on the gravel under her feet and she wanted to ask if Catra was comfortable with her bare feet. There were a lot of things that she wanted to say, and if her last visit was anything to go by this might be one of the few chances she got to be close to the other woman. She opened her mouth, about to speak when a rough voice stopped her.

"I like your hair. Finally got rid of that pony and poof combo. There might be a chance for you not to be bald by forty." Her words were playful, and Adora tried not to read too much into them, just an observation from an old friend. But she did turn her

head, shooting a bright smile at the magicat and stumbling over a loose rock in the process.

She braced herself to hit the floor, but long arms wrapped around her waist, pulling her close to a warm body inches from the ground. Catra pulled her up, arms still holding her tight. She was sure that the feline could feel her heart pounding. She hoped that she would chalk it up to the adrenaline of the near fall rather than being held so close to her. It was the first time that she had touched Catra in a decade, after a lifetime of gentle tussling and not to gentle fights, giving each other comfort where there was nobody else. Even when they were at war, there was always touch.

"Still clumsy though," the words were soft in her ear, long strands of hair and fur tickling her cheek.

A disgruntled 'argh' broke the moment, Catra's arms loosening so quickly that Adora barely stopped herself from falling again. She smiled sheepishly as she turned on her own torch and Mermista resumed her trek through the claustrophobic place. Adora kept her gaze on the ground, not wanting to embarrass herself further, while Catra chuckled behind her, light bean directed higher than the ground.

It took some time, the aperture narrowing as she had said it would, but by the time that Adora's shoulders were brushing lose sand particles from the walls with every step, they were at three branching tunnels. Well, two were tunnels, completely enclosed and no longer lined by the small lights, while the third was a narrower part of the fissure. Catra shone a torch down each one, not revealing much but oppressive shadows.

"So, here's where you come in." Adora noticed that Catra was trying very hard not to call Mermista by a facetious nickname. "We found evidence of water in all three, but Entrapta was certain that one of these tunnels had to be the origin. She's been trying to make, her words, 'teeny tiny bots', to send down here and get into the smallest cracks. Nothing she can make is small enough or

could get the readings we need. As much as we hadn't intended to show ourselves to you, your arrival couldn't have come at a better time for our water supply."

"Well, wouldn't want anyone to die of thirst out here, would I?" Mermista set down her torch and took of her small pack.

"What're you going to do?" Catra's ears were pricked forward, all of her focus on the woman at the head of the group.

"I'll need a while, I will have to send my magic out and see if I get an echo from the water." She took a deep pull of water from her canteen, ensuring that she was hydrated enough to really feel the potential spin. "You aren't going to leave us down here if I come up empty handed, right?" Mermista looked wryly at the magicat.

"Ah, my nefarious plans foiled once again by the rebellion!" Catra looked serious for a moment before giving Mermista a big grin over Adora's shoulder. "Then there's no water here to find and we get you to look somewhere else."

"Good to know. You two need to back off, give me some space to focus. I'll call you when I get something." Nodding, Catra and Adora backed up in the tunnel, far enough away that they could keep an eye on her but not close enough to disturb her.

Catra sank down to the ground and pulled a ration bar from her pouch, tearing open the paper. The crinkling sound of the wrapper made Adora turn in the cramped pace, joining Catra on the ground. She glanced at the food that the other woman was eating, it was the same shape and size as the ratios they had eaten in the Horde but that was where things ended. Adora pulled out her own and opened it, taking a large bite and moaning in pleasure as she chewed. There were dried fruits and nuts in the snack, bound together with something sweet and light. She was so engaged with the food that she didn't notice that mismatched eyes were watching her fondly as she slowly ate her own ration.

Before they could do anything more than look abashedly at each other, a triumphant whoop echoed around the rock walls. It was a sound so unlike the usually droll woman that they were both on their feet instantly.

"You wanted to know which tunnel had water?" Her dark eyes were sparkling with glee. "They all do! There is a huge reservoir down here, so big that I couldn't feel it all. It's deep, the moisture up here is just condensation. It's going to take work to get it, but there is enough water there to last you years!" The whoop that filled the place this time came from Catra, and Adora couldn't help but smile.

Six months had passed quickly for the Oasis liaisons. After her visit, Adora had become a staple of both Perfuma and Mermista's visits. The two princesses tried to stagger their visits, so were seldom there at the same time, after Mermista's initial trip, it meant that she spent almost half of her time there. So much so, in fact, that Scorpia had gently suggested four months in, that she should get her own place there, rather than staying at the hotel. She had baulked at the idea. Adora may be making life changes, yet the idea of having a permanent place anywhere outside of Brightmoon was daunting.

Eventually she had agreed to keeping a room at the hotel, that she could leave some stuff there. It still didn't feel like home, but walking into a familiar room, bed made just as she as she left it with her own unique assortments of nicknacks picked up in the desert. The scents of clean linen washed in her favourite detergent, helped her to relax. The longer she spent there, the more she missed it when she was in Brightmoon. Just not enough to leave. Not yet, at least.

She knew, given the opportunity, that Perfuma would be here just as much as she was. Her blossoming romance with Scorpia was heartwarming to witness. The two of them were well matched, balancing each other in a way that she had never had with a lover.

Sometimes, she wondered if Scorpia would ever consider heading back to Plumeria with the princess? It was obvious that Perfuma could not, would not, leave her people and the Heart Blossom. Yet, she doubted that the ex-soldier would leave this place either, her devotion to the place that she had helped to build and the children that she cared for was palpable. Adora wondered if the relationship could possibly survive the distance.

One thing that had been surprising was how easy it had been to fall back into the friendship with her old squad. Spending time with Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio made her feel more normal than she had in a long time. When they looked at her, she felt like they were seeing her, Adora, and not looking for She-ra just below the surface and what she could do for them. It was funny, but in a lot of ways she would have expected them to see her only as the warrior she had become, rather than the awkward, cocky girl that they grew up with.

Kyle had been the one to sit her down and explain that she didn't need to make anything up to them or impress them. It had been her fourth trip in two months and she had found herself back at their bar night after night. She spent too much money and got too many drinks, sometimes sitting with Mermista and Sea Hawk or Perfuma, but more often than not coming alone and sitting at the bar. She didn't lie to herself, she knew she was always waiting to see a particular pair or unusual eyes but Catra never showed up.

Kyle had come to sit beside her after finishing up a set on stage. Rogelio had come out from the kitchen with a steaming bowl of something that smelt mouthwatering, place it down in front of the man and leaned over for a kiss before casting his eyes over to the woman who was unconsciously licking her lips and letting out a chuffing little laugh. Adora was left bemused as Kyle grinned through a mouthful of stew. Before she could think of what to say a matching bowl was placed in front of her and Rogelio was tousling her short hair affectionately before disappearing back to the kitchen.

“There’s no need to look so shocked, Adora, we know you’re always hungry.” Kyle’s voice didn’t break anymore but it was still high and light. He nudged her with his shoulder when he saw she hadn’t picked up her spoon and pointed with his own. “Dig in.”

They sat together, side by side, as they had a hundred times before and devoured the food that Rogelio had made them. It was several hundred steps up from what they had eaten in the Horde. Bowls half empty, Kyle balanced his spoon on the edge and took a swig of the water he always had with him, before turning sideways on his stool and looking softly at her. Adora’s cheeks were bulging as she crammed too much food in and chewed noisily, humming at the flavour until she realised she was being watched and self consciously slowed her chewing, swallowing and putting down her own spoon. She wiped her face with a napkin and tried not to blush.

“We’ve missed you, you know?” It wasn’t what she had expected him to say and she felt tears welling in her eyes.

“Why would you?” She was pleased when her voice didn’t crack and the tears stayed in place.

“Because you’re one of us, Adora. You were when we were five, you were when we were sixteen and you still are. We might have lost you for a while,” She opened her mouth to say…something, what she wasn’t sure, but Kyle pulse a hand on her arm and squeezed. “You should never feel guilty that you left us. It was the right thing to do, and maybe we should have come too. We just weren’t as brave as you. But we’re all here now. You’re here with us and we’re so glad.” He patted her arm again and sat back, picking up his own spoon. “You better eat up or Rogelio will have your head.”

It had been the first of many trips to see the trio and their children, she found herself eating with them a lot. They would laugh and reminisce and catch up. The children were funny and liked to ask her is she had embarrassing stories about their parents, and she was happy to tell them much to the chagrin of

all three other adults. As much as she wanted to know more about Catra, she never outright asked. Occasionally, Lonnie or Kyle would say something about her, but never more than just how busy she was or what her little girl had been up to.

It was the children who talked about the magicat the most. Digby was clearly much enamoured with the adult magicat and would happily talk about how smart and strong she was and how she had been found in the tube just beside his. That had cut to her quick, realising that this little boy could have been ripped from his sleep and brought to the Horde, not Catra, and how different their lives would have been. Each time she sat on the floor and played a board game with them, she found herself looking at his little face and remembering ten year old Catra, still all ears and giant mane, her face already pinched and taught with fear and bitterness.

It wasn't that Adora never saw Catra. In fact she saw her almost every day. The oldest of all the magicats seemed to work from dawn till dusk almost every day. Not always at her job, which seemed to encompass anything from building a wall to planting crops to breaking up a bar room brawl and a seemingly never ending pile of paperwork. Whenever their paths crossed Catra would smile or wave, the odd tension between them still there but the magicat seemed to have got over her discomfort with Adora. It was all the blond could do not to trail the other woman around like she would have when they were children.

More than once the two of them had worked together to divert the water that Mermista had managed to locate for them. The work to build the irrigation systems and the water towers was backbreaking but neither woman ever stopped or complained. In some ways it was like training, both of them doing their best to keep up with each other, except this time Catra was the stronger of the two. It was unexpected when the leaner woman could swing the sledge hammer over their head for longer, while she had to stop and take a drink, wiping sweat from her brow. Even as children, Adora had always been the physically stronger one while Catra was faster. Now it seemed, that if Adora wasn't She-ra

she couldn’t keep up with her. They would trade smiles and sometimes talk about nothing just to fill the time.

There was no talk of the lost love, but Catra would willingly share tales of Yarsha, smiling softly as she thought of the little girl. It was sweet to see and Adora found herself wishing that she had similar storied to tell. Instead she told anecdotes about her early days in Brightmoon and the misadventures she had along the way. Stories that would once have made the furred woman bristle now made her laugh and occasionally shove the human’s shoulder. The same as she did with anybody else she worked with. This adult Catra was more open, accessible to the people around her. She spoke and laughed with them, listened to their problems and tussled a little.

Adora wasn’t special anymore. Not the centre of Catra’s attention when they were together. It shouldn’t hurt. They hadn’t been close for far longer than they hadn’t seen each other. They had fought a war on opposite sides, but even then Adora had felt like the centre of the Horde soldier’s attention. Always the one she engaged, taunted and struggled against. Now she was just one of a crowd of people to share casual jokes and pass the time at work. It was never more than that though. They never spent time with each other outside of the work. It shouldn’t hurt, but it did.

What hurt even more was when she saw Catra and Mermista share a laugh as they watched their respective children play together during informal meetings about the projects that were being undertaken. After the first visit, Mermista had agreed that Sea Hawk could tag along and bring their four year old son, Sturgio. The boy was the spitting image of his rambunctious father with Mermista’s colouring and predilection for eye rolling. Watching the boy, who towered over the kitten who was eighteen months his junior, made memories of her and Catra spring to mind. She was about Sturgio’s age when she pulled a small, scared toddler from a box.

She would watch the two of them caper across the floor, or Sturgio fail to climb up a set of shelves and end up laughing as he

tumbled and was then pounced on by a chubby ball of fur. Their was only happiness in their play. They had no self consciousness, neither of them feeling like they had to watch out for adults who would tell them that their games were wrong or pull them apart. From time-to-time, Adora would join the children and crawl around the floor being a dragon (never a unicorn, she would never hear the end of it from Swift Wind if she did) and chase them until they screamed with laughter and jumped all over her. She was no stranger to children, Netossa and Spinerella had a herd of them now and she spent plenty of time with Mermista's boy, but she seldom felt the pull to engage in play with them. Maybe it was just a yearning for a childhood that she had missed that she could see in them, or maybe it was just a way to understand more about Catra.

Mermista, after some initial reticence had struck up a firm friendship with the magicat. They were both acerbic and wry, digging at each other with verbal blows designed to annoy not hurt. They were well matched and sought out each others company. Catra said it was because everybody around her was too soft, and had been looking pointedly at Scorpia at the time, while Mermista claimed that now that she had married Sea Hawk she needed some adult conversation that wasn't fawning all over her. Adora thought that they were just full of it. She wasn't jealous, she told herself. She shared the time together when they worked, but only then.

It hadn't taken long for her to start seeking out company, it was a coping mechanism that she wasn't proud of. Juliet would be bitterly disappointed in her. She was disappointed in herself, but the more time she spent in Oasis the more she needed something that was just out of reach. The first time it happened had been an unconscious thing brought about by too much alcohol…

Waking up came slowly. Heavy blue eyes fluttered open, the pounding in the back of her head making her feel weak and queasy. Quickly she pressed them together, hoping that the return of darkness would calm the nausea rising in her stomach. She tried never to get drunk enough for a hangover, especially in an

unfamiliar place. Clearly that rule had gone out of the window. Throwing an arm across her eyes to shield them even further from the light, she tried to puzzle together the night before. She had been at the bar, laughing and having fun with her old and new friends when she had seen Catra walk through the bar, hand in hand with the short, dark furred magicat she'd seen around. Kesh, she remembered her name was, probably three or four years younger than Catra.

The two magicats had been laughing, bodies close together as they walked into the curtained area and straight to the doorway behind the bar that she now knew led to Lonnie's home. They had disappeared up the stairs, the younger woman's tail brushing against Catra's hand and Adora had felt a pit open in her stomach. That's when she had started to drink.

At some point, she vaguely recalled leaving the safety of the bar she knew and, against the protest of the others, heading to one of the seedier bars that lined Bazaar. She had never been anywhere else, so she picked the closest place and headed straight to a corner table and a drink. Then another. Then another. She paid little mind to the colourful inhabitants of the place. It was on her third or fourth drink that things had become hazy around then edges. Vaguely she recalled standing and maybe...dancing? Things were a blur after that. She thought she had felt fur , heard purring but wasn't sure why.

Letting out a frustrated sign she flung out her arms across the bed. A loud yelp made her wince as he arm hit something very solid, very close to her on the bed. Mind working slower than normal it took her a moment to realise that the noise had been more than just something painfully loud. Recoiling so far back on the bed that she fell to the floor, she found herself looking up from a pile of sheets and into wide, confused yellow eyes.

"What're doin?" The voice was hazy from sleep and the lingering affects of alcohol. "Why'd you hit me?" There was high indignation mixed with the befuddlement.

Looking down at her was a magicat, fur rumpled and hair tousled. She was naked, her pale grey fur striped darker across her arms which were holding up her head, as she looked at her with open confusion and blatant interest. Adora looked down at herself and saw that she, too, was naked but thankfully covered by the dislodged sheets. She looked back at the other woman and felt her mouth go dry at the sight of her breasts pressed together against the mattress.

"Um...morning?" As much as Adora may have been notorious for sleeping around, she'd never woken up with a stranger in her bed.

"You don't remember any of last night do you?" Their was amusement in the sleep deepened voice.

"I mean... I ...you...we?" Somewhere, there was a sentence in Adora that was desperate to get out but couldn't.

The lithe, grey cat stood unselfconsciously from the bed and padded her way over to the open bathroom, making no effort to cover herself. Adora watched the sway of her hips as she moved, the way her fur moved across her skin and her nipples hardened in teh cool air. She was slight, little muscle or fat covering her frame. Stripes climbed all along her arms and across the small of her back and buttocks. She bent to pick up the clothes that were scattered around the room and Adora forced herself to look away from the swishing tail, face flushed. The woman noticed her discomfort and let out a giggle that seemed too shrill and walked into the bathroom, closing the door behind her.

Adora scrambled to her feet, opening a drawer and frantically pulling out her grey underwear. Standing in front of her desk she pulled in her shorts, catching a glimpse at herself in the mirror that sat there. She was brought up short, seeing that her back was littered with shallow scratches, reddened but not painful, none had broken the skin. Something felt very wrong, seeing those superficial marks crossing the two sets of parallels scars that she kept on her back, no matter how many times she

transformed. They had long since faded to pale white, thin and barely noticeable but always there.

Hearing movement in the adjoining room, she hurriedly pulled on her vest and moved to put the sheets back on the bed, resolving to strip it and ask for clean sheets as soon as her guest was gone. By the time that the grey magicat walked out, she looked much more awake, wearing the cropped top and harem pants that she must have been wearing the night before. She was certainly sexy as she walked straight to the door, but bile rose in the blond's throat as she realised why this girl. The stripes, the slender frame and the confident way that she carried herself.

"You outsiders really are quite odd, you know? But verry sexy!" She purred the last as she gave a lascivious wink that made Adora shiver before walking out of the room.

It was only as the door clicked shut that she realised that she hadn't even asked her name…

After that, every interaction with Catra was laced with guilt that Adora couldn't quite quell. The more she wanted to push for a meeting with the just the two of them, the more she found herself pulling in Mermista, Perfuma or Scorpia. Catra seemed more bemused than anything, nonplused by her odd behaviour and why would she be bothered? It was clear that although she was happy enough for them to be colleagues and acquaintances the magicat had too much going on in her life to think about anything more with Adora.

The council chamber had become a very familiar space to the Brightmoon delegates. With each visit they would have to check in with the council, at first all five members but as time progressed they met with Double Trouble in what had become, for all intents and purposes, a gossip session. Double Trouble was just too charismatic to resist and they had all come to like the slender lizard. Whether they trusted them was a different matter, there

was always something going on behind those slit pupil eyes, as though Double Trouble was filing away everything they did or said to be used against them, should the need arose. Thankfully it didn't seem like the need would.

Given how much they had helped to achieve in Oasis, Glimmer had been pushing for them to get more answers. She was still fixated on the mystery of the Halfmoon. No matter what they told her in meetings or reports she still believed that there was something being hidden in the community. They humoured her, but there was only so long they could go without bringing it up.

This meeting was to be more formal, they had requested all five members of the council be there so that, when they made their requests, it could be fully considered. At this point, with the three of them and their families, and lovers intertwined with Oasis, they couldn't conceive of any reason why the request would be rejected. Adora knew that Glimmer wanted to be the one to search the Halfmoon, but that was not something they were willing to ask. The citizens may be happy for one of the people they knew to go down there, but not a stranger who was antagonistic towards their way of life, at best.

Sea Hawk and Sturgio had walked them to the large building, the little boy talking a mile a minute about going to visit the other children at the playground. Mermista had watched Sea Hawk wander off down the street, their son's hand clasped in his as he pointed out bright colours that caught his attention. She had kissed them both goodbye after they delivered her to the meeting, Perfuma and Adora had waved, and she had been happy that these two bright, ridiculous people were hers. That Sturgio had fallen in love with the children of her former enemies seemed almost symbolic of what this place could be for all of Etheria, a fresh start and a sign that things could change for the better.

Due to the more bureaucratic nature of this meeting, they found themselves waiting in the foyer of the council building. The public waiting area was tucked in a corner, surrounded by potted plants and contained several soft chairs. Perfuma was delighted and

began to make the potted plants stronger and bloom. Other people who were waiting for their appointments 'oohed' and 'ahhed' at the spectacle. The general ban on magic was still curious to the visitors, nobody having an answer beyond the fact that they wanted to rely on it as little as possible. The people didn't seem to fear or hate it. It was a question that they hadn't asked for fear of the answer.

Waiting was not something that Adora was good at and after ten minutes she found herself searching for something to do. Mermista was dozing in the chair beside her, Perfuma talking with two other women as she made flowers bloom, so Adora began to people watch. It was something that she had picked up in her early days in Brightmoon, when she felt like a freak and an outsider, watching the people there to learn how to fit in better. Glimmer and Bow had helped with that, taking her in and making her feel loved and accepted, but she had worked on it on her own too.

Looking out into the main area she noticed a new receptionist, this one an older woman in a brightly coloured floral blouse. Her face was somber and she dealt with the people who approached the desk with curt efficiency. There was no small talk or laughter today, and Adora found she missed the young man that they usually dealt with. He seemed to love his work here, although she supposed this woman was much more efficient at getting through the lines of people with their requests for land, materials and all manner of other things that affected their lives here. Oasis may seem like a series of unrelated spaces, but she had quickly learned that everything was done with forethought and planning.

She looked away and saw a little boy run in, shouting incoherently before launching himself at the leg of a tall, thin man standing in line. The child had close cropped purple hair and a happy, high pitched voice. He was, perhaps, the same ager as Sturgio but seemed a little small for his age. The big man moved a broad hand to rest on top of the head by his thigh and the child preened, rubbing into the touch as though he were a kitten and

not a human child. It was adorable and showed how integrated the different species were here.

Adora stopped watching the boy and the man, worrying that she would seem creepy, and took note of how many people were coming and going from the council chamber. They had, perhaps, chosen a very bad day to need to see the council. Pulling her attention back to Mermista, she nudged her with an elbow as she noticed a little trail of saliva on her chin. She snorted and shot upright in her seat. Adora couldn't help but laugh, pointing at the other woman's chin and watching as she wiped away the offending drool. The two were just starting to talk when a raised voice pulled the attention of everyone in the foyer.

The tall man, back still towards them and small boy nowhere to be seen, was now in front of the receptionist, gesturing wildly as the woman sat impassively in front of him. There was something strangely familiar about the body language and deep burr of the voice. They were too far away to hear the words, but that tone sent a shiver down Adora's spine. She looked around and saw no recognition of her friends faces, so turned back to examine him more. His tone had quieted but he was still waving a piece of paper in a bone white hand.

He was dressed in dark blue overalls and heavy boots, a cap pulled down on his head. He was thin and lanky, nothing that seemed familiar to her but she couldn't stop looking at him. His broad shoulders were a little hunched and his stance was rigid. Why did she know this man? The receptionist finally seemed to relent and picked up a communicator before motioning for him to head towards some doors in the back. It seemed like she had been worried for nothing.

And then Hordak turned, red eyes shadowed under the brim of his hat, and marched deeper into the council building.

“Of course we have to tell Brightmoon! We have to pull out the tracker pad and tell them right now!” Mermista’s voice was loud in the small room, echoing around the place with anger and betrayal.

Sea Hawk had taken their son to Adora’s room, leaving the three women to decide how to deal with the bombshell that they had discovered. None of them were still, Perfuma was sitting cross legged on the floor trying to compose her breathing while Mermista a paced. Adora was at the window, looking out at the city and picking at the wood around it with jittery fingers. None of them could believe what they had seen was real. If he was here, everything was a lie!

“We should talk with the council first, or go to Scorpia and Cat…”. Perfuma’s voice was broken, soft and raw as she considered that the life she had started to build could have been an elaborate deception.

“You want to talk to Catra? She was his right hand! They’ve been hiding him, hiding the ship…what else haven’t they told us?” Adora’s voice was completely inflectionless. Dead. Her back still to them rigid and hand now still.

“She’s right. We need to tell Brightmoon that Hordak is here and walking around like nothing ever happened.” Mermista didn’t want to, she had liked this place, but the truth seemed to be staring them in the face. Month’s of Glimmer’s suspicions and vitriol seemed to have been manifest and made flesh.

“No. We can’t tell them over the tracker, what if they’ve been monitoring our communications all along? It’s what I would do if I was trying to get under the skin of an enemy.” All their training, shared under the iron fist of Shadow Weaver, she knew how Catra thought. “We head back to Brightmoon as we planned. We don’t say anything. When we get back we call a meeting and decide where we go from here.”

It made sense. They all hated it. What would happen to the families and children that they had got to know? Where would the orphans go if they had to take this place apart?

"We don't know that they're doing anything bad!" Perfuma was on her feet now, hands balled into fists at her side and body tense in a way that neither woman had seen from her before. "Scorpia wouldn't lie to me, we've never asked what happened to Hordak. I'm sure they would have told us if we had." She moved over to the window and made Adora turn to face her, "Do you honestly believe that Catra would use children as a shield? Would put all these people in danger?"

Adora roughly pushed her hand away, "I don't know anything. We leave here tomorrow, we alert Glimmer to get the Alliance together and we meet with them."

Perfuma pulled away, shaken by the coldness in those blue eyes. She looked to Mermista and saw the same edge in hers. Breathing out what sounded like a sob, she walked out of the room and down the hall. She didn't close the door behind her, and the occupants of the room watched her walk passed her own room and down the stairs. Their was no doubt where she was going. It might be the last time she saw Scorpia outside of a combat situation. There was no doubt in their minds that she would betray them, Perfuma was loyal to the Alliance, there was no harm in letting her have the night.

Adora had no words to share with Mermista. She left in Perfuma's wake, opening the door to her own room and seeing Sea Hawk, Sturgio cradled in his lap, singing softly to the sleeping boy. He looked up at her as she entered his bearded face as solemn as she had ever seen. For months he had been here with his whole family, making friends and letting his only child play with the children of those who might turn out to be their enemies all over again.

"Sea Haw…". Her voice was soft, but he shook his head, cutting her off. He rose with his child in his arms and made his way out of

the room.

Adora took the seat that he had left, curled up and wept.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter Glimmer gets WILD!

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Just when things were looking up.

Chapter Notes

You just need to imagine Entrapta saying the name 'Stanley' in the same way she says 'Darla' in that 50s sitcom voice.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Running a brush through Yarsha's hair was a soothing act for the pair of them. Catra hadn't thought that she could ever find solace in something so mundane and repetitive, but the simple motion of the brush through the dark mass was almost hypnotic as she watch it become shiny and sleek. Yarsha's hair was the same colour and texture as Tace's had been, and it was a gentle reminder that although the other woman may be gone, a part of her would always be with Catra in the form of their kitten.

Small, content purrs drifted to her ears from the little girl seated on the chair. She liked to look in the mirror as her hair was brushed. She felt like a big girl. In truth, Catra couldn't believe that her little one would be three very soon. It felt like only yesterday that one of the techs had unsealed the womb and placed a tiny, slimy bundle of fur into Tace's arms while she hovered over her shoulder, looking down at what the two of them had made. Yarsha's ears had been pinned back to her head and her eyes tightly shut, downy fur covering her whole body but nothing that resembled hair on her head. Catra had fallen in love with the little gremlin looking thing immediately. Now she was growing like a weed, already standing taller than her Ra's knee, with her mane long and wild even when tamed by the brush.

"Hey, Yarsha, would you like me to ask aunt Kesh to braid your hair?" Catra rested her head on top of the little ones and met her merry yellow eyes in the mirror.

“Like Zu had?” She reached out a chubby hand and tugged on the two thin braids that hung in front of Catra’s ear, a memory of her mate that she saw each time she looked in the mirror.

“Yeah, like Zu had. You’ll look just like her,” not quite true, Yarsha was every bit as much Catra as Tace, but the child always preened when told she looked like her lost parent.

“You can do it?” Big, trusting eyes looked up at the woman she thought hung the moon.

Catra sometimes wondered how her daughter would feel when she got older and inevitably learned about Catra’s past, would she still look at her with love or with contempt? She always tried to push those thoughts aside. Tace had told her, when she spoke those thoughts aloud when the baby was a few months old, that she was worrying at shadows that had never been cast. She was right, of course, but Catra didn’t have much luck with shadows.

“No, Yar-Yar, I can’t. I’m good at a lot of things but not that. Kesh can do it, you’ve seen her wear her hair like that.” She put the brush down and lifted Yarsha so now she was sitting in the seat and the kitten was sitting in her lap, looking up at her. “Aunt Kesh is Zu’s sister, remember? She can teach you things that Zu’s parents taught her, like how to do your hair. Won’t that be nice?” Fingers tickled at the plump little belly making the child giggle and squirm on her lap.

“Yep-Yep. I have pretty hair and then I can get clicky claws!” Sometimes, Yarsha didn’t quite get how Scorpia was a different kind of aunt to Kesh and it made the older magicat chuckle.

“No big red claws for you, I’m afraid. Scorpia is a different sort of creature to us. You get to grow up and be a big cat like me.” She cuddled her closer as she spoke, planting a kiss on top of her already messy hair.

“But Scorpia is our fambly!” It was hard not to coo over how sweetly the little one tried to say ‘family’.

“That’s right, she is. But not because we were born the same. We are family with Scorpia and Rogelio and Kyle and Lonnie and all their children because we chose each other. Families can be made all different ways.” She placed another kiss on her fuzzy forehead. Talking like this with Yarsha lately made her thoughts travel to the long absent blond who had become a fixture in her life again.

Meeting Adora again when the Alliance had stumbled on them had led to a lot of conflicting thoughts. She had moved on from her adolescent longing for a girl who couldn’t love her back, that had been left back in the war. Lost in the fog and adrenaline of building a life in the desert and then completely buried when she kissed Tace for the first time. But still, seeing someone who had been such a part of making her who she was, who had helped her learn what love could feel like, even if it had been only as a friend, in a place where she was so often treated like something that could only suffer wrath, it had still taken her back. Made her wonder if that love had been buried for good or just put into stasis.

Knowing that the blond was looking for her had eventually led her to the bar on that last night of their stay. Of course she had seen her in the council chambers and at the bar during the awkwardly invasive meetings. Adora had even seen Yarsha which had never been her intent, but she had learned to let go of the little grievances a long time ago. The big ones, the slights that had sliced into the fabric of her were harder to heal and though no longer open wounds were more scabs than scars. They had been easy to ignore for a long time, but that was before…

Shaking those melancholy thoughts away lest they drag her down a dark path of a different kind, she helped Yarsha pull on her dungarees and a tie-dyed t-shirt that Perfuma had given her on her third visit. She snapped the straps together, pulled a pouffy tail through the hole specially cut into the seat and tied the uncontrollable hair into a sloppy pony tail. That was something she hadn’t learned how to do from Adora. Yarsha, already bouncing on her bare feet, grasped her hand and pulled her down the hallway. The kitten was always excited when she got to go to

the Spire. It wasn't a place they went a lot and when they did she got to ride on the two wheel with her own special little helmet on.

On the walk to the edge of the city, Catra watched fondly as Yarsha ran ahead, always casting little glances over her shoulder to make sure Catra was there, skipping and twirling without a care in the world. It was a gift that Catra had promised herself she would give to every single child in Oasis, Horde or magicat. No child should have to grow up living in fear, thinking that they had to be of value or be discarded. It was something that she had pushed and pushed until the council were sick of her, but the children were as carefree and happy as it was possible to make them. Many of them, those old enough to really remember their lives before, were still troubled but their wounds were healing with time and affection.

Children on her mind brought her back to Adora again, as though the women was just ricocheting around in her head. To say that Catra had been surprised to see her arrive alongside the water and plan princesses that second time had bee an understatement. Really, she shouldn't have been, it was a very She-ra thing to do. Come to act as an entire army to protect the others from perceived danger. It had just been startling because in Oasis, there was peace, it had been a long time since she even thought of herself as a threat, let alone her world as one of war or menace.

Her changed appearance had also thrown Catra for a loop, if she was honest with herself. Adora had always been strictly uniformed, even when she left behind the place that the uniform belonged to. Yet, there she had been, stood out in the desert with her hair cut almost as short as Scorpia used to wear hers, artfully tousled and making her look so much younger than the tight, staid ponytail. Her clothes were lose and more appropriate for the climate in shades of orange. When she had walked through the shield the first time it was as though she had been preserved in amber. Now it was like she was a butterfly emerged from a long stay in a drab cocoon. Catra hadn't quite known what to do with that, so like the teen she had once been she had dealt with it

though passive aggression and snark. She had regretted it once they were down the hole.

Adora had blushed when she had told her that her hair looked nice, of course she hadn't been able to say it like that and instead had felt the need to tease. Finding her arms wrapped around the other woman in the confined space of the tunnel seconds later as she saved her from herself had not been something she meant to do, but when she had seen her trip she couldn't avoid the instinct to catch her. She had always caught her; when she fell over her own feet on the way to train, when she tried to climb too fast and lost her grip, when a box slid out from under her. Catra had always been fast and agile enough to catch her, not always strong enough to stop her fall, but they had always fallen together. Until Adora learnt to catch herself. The close contact had triggered something in her, something old and skittish. Something that made her withdraw.

"Hey, fuzzy-butt, come back here!" The little cat had almost disappeared around a corner but spun in a pirouette and dashed back to wrap herself around one of Catra's legs and got a stroke along her ear in return that made her wiggle. "Up-up." Then there was a purring bundle of love in her arms and they were leaving the city, on the path to the vehicle.

Putting a crash helmet onto a toddler is an interesting proposition. It's too tight. It's too itchy. It squishes their ears. They want to do the chin strap. After some coaxing, and promises that Yarsha could stick some pretty pictures onto it when they got home, the helmet was fixed securely and the girl was sitting astride the body of the sled. Catra pulled on her own helmet and acknowledged that it did, indeed, squish her ears, before throwing her leg over and sitting behind her daughter. She pulled the child into the curve of her body, and reached for the handlebars, surrounding Yarsha in a cage made of muscle. The little girl held on tight to the handle that sat in front of her as they moved off and made the several hour trip to the edge of the shield.

As they passed through the changing terrain, Yarsha was hypnotised by the scenery. Catra couldn't help but think of being out here with the various princesses. Perfuma had proved to be a hard worker, getting her hands dirty as much as she wove magic into the plants and the dirt. She had always seemed like the member of the Alliance least likely to be there, and now after interacting with her she saw that just like Scorpia she wasn't made for fighting. She was glad the two gentle women had found each other. They were going to make the loveliest parents to all of the children in the orphanage when they got their act together.

In those fields she had dug earth, lifted boulders and sewn seeds shoulder to shoulder with her old bunkmate. They had worked together with smooth efficiency, each tirelessly caring for the land while Perfuma infused the ground with her magic. They had already been able to grow some crops, but cereals had seemed impossible until the magic of the Heart Blossom was pushed into the ground. It had warmed her heart to see Adora help with such gusto, a place that had no meaning for her. They talked and joked about nothing at all, as Catra did with the other farmers and volunteers. She had learnt, over time, that you couldn't only focus your attention on one person if you want to keep your sanity. It had been nice, to integrate a lost part of her past into her present.

Working with Mermista had also been interesting. She had never really thought of the mermaid princess much beyond the fact that she controlled her least favourite element and had a boyfriend who was deeply annoying (even in the heat of battle talk of the crazy pirate and his singing was notorious). Yet, as they worked together to bring the water up from the large well that she had found, it seemed that they were very sill people. Neither were easily impressed or cared to suffer fools. They bickered back and forth, causing many of the Oasis citizens to look scandalised, but enjoyed every moment. Then, when Mermista began to bring her husband and son along with her, Catra had seen that the crazy pirate wasn't so bad.

In fact, once she introduced Sea Hawk to Kyle properly it was a bromance at second sight. The captain had hearts in his eyes as he watched Kyle sing and when the fair man pulled him up and let him take centre stage, their friendship had been sealed. Having a fellow parent to talk to who was just as jaded as her, who had changed as much as she had with the passing years and the mellowing influence of love and family had been comfortable in a way that she didn't feel with anyone else.

Adora had been a surprise too. Watching her play with Sturgio and Yarsha, crawling around the floor or spinning them around had made Catra feel soft. They had never really been around the smaller children in the Horde, and when they had been near the creche or the first years, Catra had always felt so bitter as she watched them run around, not afraid of every move they made, or injured, that she could only loath them. Now, it turned out, that Adora was just a big puppy as she let the kids crawl all over her. It was a shame that she had always been destined to be a soldier, Catra thought that she would have fit right in at the creche.

She'd expected the blond to seek her out more, maybe had wanted her to a little bit. She avoided the bar at night, she would rather be with the children when she wasn't working in the evening and she certainly wasn't looking for a hook-up. That held very little appeal. She needed to trust a person implicitly before she let them touch her like that, too many hands had taught her that touch was dangerous with the wrong person. In fact there were only two people that she had trusted that way, one was gone and one was spending a lot of time swooning over a certain tall blond. That warmed her heart too.

But Adora had never come to find her by herself. It just showed that, as well as changing her appearance the other woman had grown-up in other ways, and one of those was that she didn't need to live in Catra's pocket anymore. It should have been a relief to know that they had both moved forward, able to live happy and complete lives. Even if those lives contained their own losses and pain. Part of Catra wished that she would come to talk to her, that they could maybe reminisce on some of the good

times that they had shared, in amongst the bad. Not to say that Catra sought out the other woman either. She could have, she knew where she was, but it felt wrong. Like crossing a line.

The spire loomed closer and closer, filling the horizon and Catra increased the speed of the vehicle to get them there. It was a strange structure, smooth and knife like as it reached into the air. It had been found in a hanger of the ship, not with the equipment for colonisation. It didn't match the design or the technology of the rest of the magicat's equipment, so its origin was in question to start with but it contained a lot of very useful scientific equipment that Entrapta had jumped on. It was obvious why the magicat's had kept it in their already well stocked ship. It reminded Catra of the First Ones edifices scattered all over Etheria, but lacking the showy designs on the outside. Entrapta had been certain that it wasn't First Ones, which had made her even more excited.

Bringing the sled to a stop, waiting for the solar motor to still, she puled off her helmet. It was a tight fight and took more effort than she liked but eventually she managed to free it and place it on one of the handlebars. She reached down and did the same for Yarsha. Thankfully her helmet slipped off more easily and the little girl was leaping from her seat, hitting the sand and scrabbling to her feet as she made her mad dash for the imposing doors. Out this far, though still inside the shield, there was still only sand and heat. It had been decided that bringing the grass and crops out this far was not prudent yet, so it stood alone in the nothingness. Humming.

Catra's ears always twitched uncontrollably when she came out here, the sound wasn't unpleasant bu the frequency was constant and disorientated her a little. Yarsha didn't seem to feel the effects, probably too young to make out the frequency. Meeting the smaller cat at the door, she lifted her so that she could place her hands against the entry pad which bleeped merrily under her hand opened the doors for them. Entrapta hated to leave her lab, just like she always had in the Fright Zone, so anyone that was a regular visitor could let themselves right in. It seemed like that

trait had been passed to all the other inhabitants of the spire, nobody coming to check who had walked in.

Yarsha dashed down a sterile, white corridor, claws ticking against the shiny floor. She would occasionally slip a little and wobble her way back to her feet. Catra laughed, sound echoing along the corridor as her own feet padded in the same direction. Soon a new sound was echoing back at them, making Yarsha squeal excitedly before a small boy zoomed towards her and the two small children collapsed in a heap on the floor, hugging and kissing each other all over their smiling faces. Catra shook her head at their antics, the little boy barely bigger than his slightly younger friend was always very excited to see them. Before she could reach down and settle kids on their feet, another small figure turned the corner.

"Hey Junior, this one get away from you?" Catra addressed the tiny man who was standing, looking up at her with his wings folded at his back.

The man, formerly known as Imp, smiled a sharp smile up at her, his yellow eyes crinkling with affection. In the Horde he had been nothing but a tool, now he was a brother and a son and it had made him re-evaluate who he had been to the other youths that he had spent his young life spying on. He was still small, barely bigger than the two children on the floor, but he was as old as the woman in front of him. He concentrated, a series of sounds coming from him before he pieced together what he wanted to say.

"He. Is. Very. Excited." His voice was made from a series of other voices, stored and pieced together to make his own. No longer did he record and report those stolen voices. "We. Have. Missed. You. Both. Here."

"Us too. Lots to do in the city though. You could always come into Capital with the others, you know. Everyone would be pleased to see you." It was true, though at the start it had taken longer to build trust in the boy who had been responsible for so much pain

because of his duplicity. But he had been small, isolated by Hordak and his condition as a boy without a voice and they had all too soon taken him in.

"No. Better. Here." It was hard to explain that he felt better in this place that reminded him of home, with people who didn't look at him and think he was the strangest of a very strange group. That, and he liked the quiet. "Mom. Is. In. The. Lab." He quirked an eyebrow, seeing Catra do the same, because of course that was where she was.

"You going with?" Catra gestured down the hall.

"No. I. Will. Take. The. Children. To. Play." There was a large playroom set out in the spire and Catra was more than happy for Yarsha to go there.

"Thanks, Junior. I'll drag Entrapta out of her lab and see you there." She leant down and kissed her kitten on the head before rubbing the little purple head affectionately and throwing a jokey salute to Junior.

Entrapta's lab in the Spire was…something else. There were monitors everywhere showing a dozen conflicting readouts. On work benches scattered around the large space were bots in various stages of manufacture, soil tilling machines being improved and sections of irrigation purification units being fixed. It was just as chaotic as her lab had always been, but much tidier. Catra still understood none of it. In all the white and chrome there was no sign of the equally chaotic owner of the space. But Emily sat in the corner.

"Hi Emily, where's Entrapta?" The machine whirred merrily, beeping a discordant sound and the swivelling to lift and point a leg towards a wheeled vehicle some description. Catra still couldn't see the woman, but thanked Emily with a pat on the dome before walking to that part of the room.

As she got closer she saw that the wheeled rotavator sat over a pit cut into the floor with Entrapta distinctive humming coming from it. Catra laid herself out on the ground and poked her head over the hole, watching Entrapta be caught up in something she was fiddling with in her hands. She was solely focused on the task that she never noticed Catra's presence, it was a rare turn about as Entrapta was most likely to startle an intruder rather than vice versa.

"Hey, 'Trapta, what you got there?" Catra raised her voice and sniggered as a squark came from the purple haired woman and she toppled off the perch of her hair and the metallic object clattered to the floor.

"Catra!" The woman's oddly modulated voice was bright and cheerful as she realised who had spied her. There was no sign of anger as she climbed out of the pit using her hair. Catra pounced to her feet and her purple haired friend patted her on the head with a thick purple lock of hair. "Is it time for your visit already?"

"Apparently so." Entrapta was a nice constant in a world that was often in flux.

"Stanley has been counting down the minutes, I should have realised." Then she was moving briskly out of the room and all Catra could do was follow her in the same bemused way she always did.

"Where's big and creepy?" It was unusual to not see the tall man in the halls when they arrived.

"Hordak is in town. We were all there this morning for supplies, he stayed because he had business at t he council hall." Entrapta could be shockingly vague when she wanted.

Catra was pleased. It wasn't that she feared or hated the big man, when he had surrendered himself in the Fright Zone she had realised that he had been just of weary of it all as the rest of them. He had understood that he couldn't just be one of the

people and until the spire had been kept in a cell but Entrapta had been his biggest advocate and that they had chosen to live together away from the city had been a relief to everyone. Oasis was a place for second chances and it seemed that Hordak was just as keen as the rest of them for that opportunity. For all of the it was hard to look at the man, even minus the armour that he didn't need anymore, and not see somebody who had used her, tortured her and sent her out on a fools errand to die. But look at him she could, for all his faults he was not the one who had shattered her. She was long gone even before Catra's desertion.

The two women entered the playroom and the small boy rushed at Entrapta, wrapping himself around the small woman. Watching, Catra thought that sometimes Hordak must feel like a giant in this place where everyone else was so small and delicate. The child burbled up at Entrapta with the same cadence as his mother but with words that were inarticulate and hard to understand. He was bright and funny and imperfect, and his parents loved him.

"Stanley! Have you shown Catra the schematic you made?" Entrapta's eyes danced as she spoke to her child. He was up and out of her arms, running towards his little art area almost before she stop speaking, grabbing a sheet of paper and runny back to thrust it at Catra. He looked up at her expectantly as she looked at his drawing of a building. It was very well rendered for a four year old.

"This is great Stan-my-man!" His little face looked confused for a moment before breaking into a huge grin and running off to babble at Yarsha who babbled right back.

Junior came over with a glass for each woman, Entrapta wrapping a lock of hair around his shoulders as the three adults went to sit in the sun streaming through the large windows of the playroom. Catra had been bemused by the fact that none of the other Princesses had sought out Entrapta, they saw her fleetingly but never looked for her. They were curious like that, the Alliance, so quick to talk of unity and friendship while keeping their distance from anyone who was too different.

Glimmer paced the courtyard like a caged tiger. Bow watched her, knowing that she wouldn't appreciate the comparison, his dark eyes tracking her every movement. It was distressing to see her so pent up and agitated. The carefree times from the past seemed to get further and further away the older they became. Bow wasn't naive, he knew that eventually Glimmer would take responsibility for part of the kingdom. He had been one of her biggest cheerleaders when it came to tearing down the Fright Zone and building it anew, but as years passed and it became more and more clear how much the earth had been poisoned and how much of a slog it would be to turn the industrialised complex into a habitable village, Glimmer had become more and more angry. Her frustration displaced into snappishness.

Bow felt lost in Brightmoon these days. He could no more leave Glimmer than slip off his own skin, but he knew that he was being left behind. She no longer talked to him about her hopes for the future or her plans. She would disappear at night. He knew she thought he didn't know. He had followed her a time or two but had lost her in the maze of hallways as though she was trying to hide. He didn't know what it meant but it couldn't be good.

He had considered an intervention, but the idea of going to the king and queen with this seemed like a betrayal of her. They were a team and they would get through this together. He just knew it. He just needed to be calm and patient. It was hard to do when she looked so agitated.

When she had received the message on the tracker pad from Oasis, the fairly cryptic message had sent her into a frenzy of activity. All Adora had said was that they had found something troubling but that had been enough. Glimmer had called up the other princesses, demanding their presence but swearing them to secrecy. Her rationale for not sharing this with Queen Angella was that she didn't want to bother her if it was nothing, but if it was something then they would be ready to stroke at once. Bow

wasn’t comfortable with the aggressive language. It was as though she had already made up her mind.

Soon enough the whole of the former rebellion were gathered in the secluded, seldom used garden that had been handed over to Shadow Weaver many years ago to keep her out of trouble. The witch was nowhere to be seen but her presence could be felt in the place.

“We should really go and speak to the queen.” Perfuma’s eyes were darting around the garden. She felt the hairs stand up on her arms, something out here making her skin crawl, though for all she could see it was just the younger members of the Princess Alliance.

Glimmer had intercepted them as they came through the castle gates, hustling them through the courtyard and into the garden with its host of colourful and exotic plants. Some so rare that even the Princess of Plumeria couldn’t identify them. It should have been her favourite place in the palace, so full of nature and vibrancy, but every time the tall woman came here her blood ran cold and she couldn’t wait to leave. Today the garden was not empty when they got there. As Mermista, Perfuma and Adora walked through the trellis at the entrance, they found themselves surrounded by Frosta, Netossa and Spinerella.

“Speak to her about what? You said you had found something troubling?” This was the Glimmer he knew, her voice was calculating but calm. She was excited without him feeling the more recent mania seep from her.

The three women looked between each other. None of them wanted to be the one to drop the bombshell and fracture the peace. Glimmer almost demanded the information, the silence deafening, when Adora sighed as though the world was weighing her down and spoke.

“We were waiting to meet the council, to ask them if we could finally see the Halfmoon. There was a man there, I noticed him

because he was so tall…and there was a little purple haired boy…" her face, just for a moment, broke into a soft smile that shattered as soon as it appeared. "The man was loud, he got our attention…"

"It was Hordak." Mermista couldn't bare listening to Adora stumble over her words.

The gasp that went around the group was one of shock and horror. They had just assumed that the leader of the Horde had been killed in the uprising or executed later. It seemed a silly thing to have thought now, after being in Oasis. Everyone had been given a place. Why not the greatest enemy Etheria had ever known?

"Off course Hordak is there! I told you all. Catra is running the place. I thought she was running it alone, hiding behind the councils skirts, but clearly its the same as it ever was. Hordak and Catra deceiving us all until they can strike!" Where the others looked shocked and disturbed, Glimmer's expression was nothing short of glee at being vindicated in her zealous disbelief.

Bow was unsurprised that she had a plan that she revealed to them all then and there. For six long months she had plotted and planned. Her fixed interest on the crashed space craft had not been assuaged. Perfuma was the only one who had fixedly demanded that they tell the queen, but Glimmer could be persuasive. Very persuasive and even he could see her point. Queen Angella had hidden from the war when they were children, who was to say that she wouldn't do the same this time and leave them exposed?

Glimmer gave them no time to think. She gathered the princesses and headed straight back to the hidden kingdom. She left Bow behind.

Perfuma and Adora had both been gifted with keys to the shield, meaning they could pass in and out of Oasis without needing to be met there. It had been a sign of trust. A sign that they had both been accepted as members of the community. Adora, all but living there, it had just made sense that she would have access whenever she wanted. As for Perfuma, nobody was blind to her love for Scorpia. Now, all of the princesses stood at the border created by the shield, magic buzzing. All but Perfuma. She had refused to be a part of their plans.

Adora respected that the other woman had taken a stand. Her words to go to the council about Hordak had fallen on deaf ears, but she would not bow down to Glimmers grim insistence. No matter how incensed the pink haired girl became. Her only concession had been not going to Angella and not to contact Scorpia. It had been clear in her eyes that the latter had broken her heart. In fact, after the confrontation in the garden, Perfuma had packed her things and gone straight home to Plumeria, disgust clear on her face. It was not an expression any of them had seen there before and it was jarring.

Holding the small device in her hand, Adora felt sick. She had fought countless battles and even looked death in the eye, but she had never felt sick before going into the fray. Sweat was slick on her palm. She knew that this was wrong, but Glimmer was and had always been the leader of the rebellion in her mind. Glimmer the head, Bow the heart and her the hand. She squeezed with a trembling hand and the shield shimmered away. Nothing was on the other side but an empty wagon that was always waiting and the distant silhouette of Capital.

“The Halfmoon is a couple of hours that way.” Mermista was the one to volunteer the information, pointing to the West. Of course, after her first visit she had known where the ship was. The border wall of the fissure forming one edge. It hadn’t been hard to find a map in the city showing the crater. She had looked more out of curiosity when Catra had told them how big it must be, than any malice. But now she found herself weaponising that information.

Glimmer's plan was three pronged; find out what they had to hide on the Halfmoon, take that information and the revelation that they were harbouring Hordak to Angella, then take the city with the full force of the Alliance. Oasis would be taken completely off guard and a war would be averted before it could even begin. Mermista wasn't entirely sold on why that was the plan, but Adora had nodded sullenly in agreement with Glimmer's words and that seemed to be good enough for everyone. After all, if there was nothing to hide in the ship, then why hadn't they shown them? If Hordak got his hands on weapons as advanced as everything that had been used to build this place, then they were all doomed.

Adora was careful to drive the wagon away from where they knew people were posted at the fissure, taking a wide detour until they were at the edge of the crater. It felt wrong to be here without Catra. Very, very wrong. But she had a duty to protect the pace that had taken her in so she led them down into the crater. They were in luck that there were no teams here today. She knew that usually there were groups based here.

It wasn't hard to find the entry tunnel. The cavern was illuminated by a series of lamps and it was easy to follow the path of lights to the opening in the ship. Rope ladders and pulley systems hung down the deep hole. Glimmer led the way down, commanding them to stay together in case they were to encounter somebody there. The further they descended the more eerily quiet it seemed.

Lights burst to life as they passed each level. Glimmer's curiosity was piqued just a little ways down by a corridor that clearly saw a lot of use. There were tables and equipment that had clearly been recently used so they left the climb and walked the long wide halls. At the end, a giant door stood open. Netossa and Spinerella stationed themselves at the entrance when the others walked in. It was hard not to gasp at the huge screen that covered the wall in front of them and the array of equipment that they didn't understand.

While running her hand over one of the dead consoles, Glimmer thought of how fascinated Bow would be by all of this. She had left him behind in case it was too dangerous, or that was what she told herself. If she were being honest with herself, which she was less and less these days, she had left him behind so that he could not tell her no. she was caught up in her awe and fear of the place, as were the others, that she failed to notice the small red light under her hand begin to pulse menacingly.

They would need to come back with Bow to know for sure if any of this was weapons systems but in a ship this size, there was little chance that it wasn't armed. The size and complexity of the bridge was intimidating to them all and as one they agreed to go deeper into the belly of the beast.

Tapping out a bored rhythm on her desk as she drew out another sheet of data from the farmlands, Catra yawned hugely. Yarsha had slept poorly the night before, waking crying from a nightmare about being chased by faceless black figures. Catra had lifted her into her arms and settled them both into her large bed as she crooned softly to her. She sang softly until the little girl was once again in a deep sleep. Catra had been unable to follow her into slumber for some time, her little girl's description of the nightmare far too reminiscent of her own childhood fears.

Her black, faceless demons had been real though. When she closed her eyes and dreamed of being chased and locked away, it was her mind working through the pain of the reality of those situations. She had also lain awake, troubled by the sudden departure of the three princesses. She had hoped that once she returned from the Spire she would be able to invite the whole group to eat at the orphanage. Entrapta had had some of her frank and incisive words to share about her mixed feelings about connecting with Adora again. She had decided to take it.

When she had got back and gone to the hotel, she had found that they, and Mermista's family were gone. Adora's room was still full

of her things so she hadn’t been too concerned. They were princesses, after all, it was entirely possible that business in their own kingdoms had called them away. The chances of Selineas and Plumeria both having a crisis at the same time seemed slim but not impossible. Even so, something struck her as wrong.

Scorpia had also been noticeably absent, locked in her bedroom and not answering when Catra knocked softly on her door after putting the kitten to bed. She had also been gone when they got up this morning. It ruined Catra’s whole routine not to tease Scorpia before dropping Yarsha at the bar. She could call Scorpia, but if the woman needed some time to deal with Perfuma being gone she didn’t want to interrupt.

Stretching to go along with the yawn, she was just picking up a pen when a siren sounded through the room and her gut dropped out from under her. Somebody was on the Halfmoon who shouldn’t be. Somebody had breached the ship and the princesses had disappeared.

Rage boiled through her. She stood, almost flipping the table in her haste to get out of the room. Around her every magicat was puffed up and growling. Everyone could hear the signal but for them it was like nails on a chalkboard, a warning impossible to ignore.

Without words they were moving fast, heading towards the Halfmoon. Men and women spilling from shops and offices, children streaming out of school as the siren called them to protect the place that they had come from.

The place that had been betrayed.

Pure rage filled Catra, pulling a roar from her chest when she entered the pod room that echoed and amplified as it moved around the room. Her teeth were bared, claws extended and the

fur on her shoulders puffed up making her look more dangerous and terrifying than she ever had been as a skinny teen in the war. The other magicats growled, their rage joining with hers as they too took up a battle stance fanning out behind her, and behind them, blocking the door to the death chamber and filling the corridors were men and women representing every specie that lived in Oasis.

Catra advanced on Glimmer, who pulled up her glitter bombs, ready to fire at the enemy. Her heart was pounding in her chest as she stood in the room full of death. She had made a massive tactical error, but there was nothing to say that she could't pull it back to her advantage. Take out the obvious leader of the army and then call in back up. Either way it would force her mother to take a stand! She was unwilling to think about what that stand would actually mean.

She fired, magical blows that show have pushed the advancing feline back hit her in the chest and dissolved like so much confetti. Around her, she was vaguely aware of the same happening. Mermista had no water to conjure with and stood, impotent, Frosta the same. Netossa threw an energy net that covered two magicats who had surrounded her only to dissolved as one swiped at it with an errant claw. Spinerella threw out a gust of wind that raged around her and was a gentle breeze by the time it his the line of predators. And Adora, sword held aloft, the cry of 'For the honour of Greyskull' on her lips, felt nothing and she too was surrounded.

Then there was no more room for projectiles, Catra was on her. She pounced from a few feet away, body colliding solidly with Glimmer's own, throwing her against the wall with enough fall to make the cracking of her rib audible as all of the air was pushed out of her lungs. There was no time for a breath as agony lanced through her, two hands were placed around her throat and squeezed. No claws, just all force. Spots began to dance in front of her eyes as Catra's face pressed close to hers. Close enough to kiss. Close enough to bite. Luminous eyes bored into hers as the hands held firm, just short of choking. Glimmer ineffectually

brought her hands up to scrabble weakly at the furred arms, desperate to be able to take a deep breath. As darkness began to cloud the edges of her vision and consciousness started to slip away aa voice cried out.

“Catra! Stop!” It was a voice familiar to both when locked in the deadly embrace.

Catra’s hands loosened imperceptibly as she whipped her head to glare with fire filled eyes at Adora who still held her sword limply in her hand. Magic denied her she couldn’t bring herself to raise it against the righteously indignant crowd. They had come into this place. They had desecrated a sacred place. They had made an error in judgement. The only people to blame here were themselves. Adora saw Mermista’s head bowed in shame, clearly feeling the same. The others simply looked lost, standing among the coffins of thousands of lost souls.

“You don’t get to tell me to do anything!” That roar was back, raw and laced with more venom than she had heard from the younger woman since Brightmoon. Adora flinched as it was directed at her.

“Think about what will happen if you kill her. The Alliance will attack you.” Her voice felt thick, like the words were stuck and she was having to force them out.

“What is this is not an attack on us?” Relief flooded Adora as she saw Catra’s hands move away from Glimmers throat as she let her fall in a heap at her feet, head lulling but still breathing. Catra stalked towards her and Adora shrank back, genuinely afraid of the other woman as she had never been before. When they fought as teens she may have felt betrayed, now she really had been.

Looking into mismatched eyes that glowed with rage, she spoke quietly the only justification that they had. “We saw Hordak.” Said aloud in this place, it seemed like a petty provocation indeed.

She hadn’t expected laughter. She probably should have. Catra’s maniacal laugh had been one of the worst things about fighting with her during the war, it wasn’t a sound she had ever heard before but it had seeped into her and coloured every memory of every laugh that they ever shared together. It was bitter and cruel. She was so close to Adora that she could feel the furnace like heat radiating off her fur in the dimly lit room, eyes glowing like coals. Adora could easily have run her through but she was paralysed by shame.

“You saw Hordak?” Her head was shaking in utter disbelief. The other magicats in the room were watching her, taking their lead as they stayed guarding their catches. “You saw Hordak, and thought, what? That was what you’d been waiting for to destroy us? We let you in, share our home with you and all that time you were just biding your time? Waiting for a reason to come in here and take us out?”

Adora wanted to deny it. It wasn’t true! She, Mermista and Perfuma had loved their time in the city. It was them who had broken the trust. Even in her own head it was no excuse at all. Catra was right, Glimmer had just been waiting all along and they had all been so blinded by the sins of the past that they had let her guide them into a disaster.

“Did you even think to ask?” Her voice was softer now, broken in a way that Adora had heard before and hated that she knew.

Her mouth opened and closed. Nothing came out. It was answer enough. Catra looked over to Mermista who wouldn’t make eye contact, eyes downcast to the floor. She said no more, instead making a sub-vocal sound that galvanised the rest of the magicats in the room. The princesses found themselves roughly grabbed and marched out of the pod chamber. Adora noted that a few stayed, clearly about to inventory the dead and make sure that they hadn’t desecrated them. Her skin crawled.

It took far less time that she imagined it would to get them all out of the ship and up into the crater. When they emerged into the

bright midday light, the crater was full of magicats, more emerging from the ship entrance. It was as though, somehow, they were all here, waiting. All the young survivors of the Horde genocide, down to the children that she had seen surrounded them in a wide circle. Above, on the rim of the crater, a motley collection of representatives of the rest of Oasis looked down with scowls on their faces.

The princesses were released in the large circle made by the magicats, only Catra among them. Adora could see that Frosta wanted to say something, anything, that could absolve them, but there was nothing to say. Glimmer, at least, was able to stand now holding her ribs with one hand and rubbing at her rapidly reddening throat with the other. Her eyes were focused on Catra and still burned with an unnaturally feverish fury.

Adora, and the others, were so focused on Glimmer and Catra, that she failed to notice a figure approach her until a crack rang out around the crater and her head snapped back from the ferocity of the slap. Instinctively bringing her hand up to her cheek she met the eyes of the grey striped cat she had spent a night with. Her eyes were not laughing now. Instead tears streamed down from anguished depths. Her arm pulled back to strike agains when arms wrapped around her from behind and Catra pulled the sobbing woman away.

“Don’t, Nar. Don’t.” The words were soft, contrasting sharply with what had gone before.

The grey magicat, Nar, sagged in Catra’s grasp and turned in her arms to bury her face in her neck. If the whole assembly hadn’t been so eerily quiet her next words would have been lost. Except it was quiet. Quiet as the graves they had disturbed.

“Did they hurt them?” The words were broken and the meaning clear.

“No.” Soft at first, Catra lifted her voice to make sure everyone could hear. “No, they did not touch the bodies of our parents and

grandparents, uncles and aunts…" their was a palpable breath out as young men and women turned to clutch each other in relief.

Catra passed the young woman into the arms of a vaguely familiar male magicat. Adora felt tears rolling down her face. The reality of the fact that every magicat here, even Catra, was an orphan left behind by the death of the people in the room struck at her chest. Catra was standing in front of Glimmer, hands clasped behind her back this time, eyes locked with equally angry ones.

"So where's mommy?" It was a clear taunt, a poke into an old wound that everyone had been able to see when they were younger. A wound that Glimmer had never treated.

"I…She…". Before Glimmer could form a lie, another voice was speaking out.

"We can without royal permission or decree. The Alliance doesn't know. This was our mistake, don't let it take us to war." It was Frosta, taking control and seeing the situation for the egregious mistake it had been.

"Wow." Catra looked genuinely bemused. "Just that desperate to go back to fighting and killing, for what? To say you won? We ended the war without more bloodshed, that not enough for you?"

"Hordak…". Glimmer tried again. Catra was no longer listening.

"Tell Queen Angella what you have done. Tell her that we are only reason you are going home and not being thrown in our jail is courtesy. We will speak only to her. You are banned from entry to Oasis. We expect to hear from her within three day." She was walking away before any of them could speak.

"Or what?" Glimmers voice was rough, but it was like she couldn't stop.

"Let's not have to find out." It was thrown over her shoulder as she led the magicats up the sides of the deep impression. They climbed up the sheer sides like liquid and from moment to the

next they were alone in the crater. As though they had imagined the scene.

Nobody spoke as they made their way back to the wagon that they had been left. Nobody spoke on the drive to the shield opening where a phalanx of uniformed guards waited, weapons in hand. Adora and the others got out, making their ways to the opening in the barrier. As Adora passed, a hand was thrust into view. She looked up and saw Lonnie looking at her with sad, sad eyes. She placed the entry device gently into her palm. She wanted to say something, apologise for ending the tranquility, but there were no words. She had turned her back on them once, and now she had done it again.

"At least Perfuma didn't come. It would have broken Scorpia's heart." Lonnie's voice was raw as she held back tears. Her words said one thing, but Adora knew she was saying that she had broken all their hearts instead.

The barrier closed behind them and they were once again in the middle of the desert. They began a desolate trudge away, their trackers jammed until they were far enough away that the signal from Oasis was lost. With one call, their would be transporters coming from the closest villages, ready take them back to Brightmoon.

Adora couldn't bare to stay with the others. With a thought Swift Wind was in the sky above them. His usual cheer dampened by what he could feel seeping out of her through their bond. Glimmer reached out, as though to stop her and she roughly threw off her hand as she climbed aboard the winged horse and into the sky. She couldn't face heading back to Brightmoon, facing Queen Angella, so like a coward she ran away towards the woods.

Chapter End Notes

Next time:
The best dads in Etheria.
What do you mean magic doesn't work on magicats?

Angella is not best pleased.
Things are very far from over!

Chapter 14 - 72 Hours in Brightmoon

Chapter Summary

Two chapter 14s - all events are happening concurrently in the two places.
Let's see how Glimmer's plans have affected them.

(I would read the Brightmoon section first though).

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

People thought that Swift Wind didn't know much about silence. He knew they saw him as loud and obnoxious, he may be an alicorn but he wasn't oblivious. In fact, it would probably surprise them to know how much of his life away from them was spent in silence. His idealistic idea to free all of his brethren when he had first been transformed, had petered out after the war. The other horses were happy to follow him over the horizon, but a domestic horse cannot care for itself. Their needs were more than he could deal with. He had tried to talk to them, but his words had fallen on deaf ears, he was not truly one of them anymore. The horses had drifted away, back to the villages and towns that they had come from. Warm stables and plentiful grain were the luxuries of the simple life they required.

So, Swift Wind was too chatty because much of his world was silence. But he knew when to keep quiet. Adora's call had been unexpected. She'd only sparingly used their bond during the worst of the war and less and less with the passage of years. His ears had pricked and he had been dashing through the air at once. Broad wing strokes eating up the miles to the Crimson Waste. The pain and self loathing he felt even from so far hastening his journey.

Hitting sand, wings sending up a plume of sand on the downstroke, he watched the others shielded their eyes. They all

looked dour, broken. None more than Adora, though. Her eyes were dull, her posture slumped as she wordlessly, and gracelessly, clambered aboard him. Through the bond he could almost feel her scream her need to get away. So he got them away. Wings wide, beating hard they were airborne in a wave of sand, and gone.

Adora clung to his neck, burying her face in his mane. He could feel her shaking against him. It was an unfamiliar feeling, but he knew it was bad. As he flew faster and faster towards the Whispering Wood, he felt the coolness of drying moisture in his hair and knew she must be crying. He could ask what, but he didn't think that he would get an answer. Instead, he redoubled his efforts. If Adora needed them to be lost, then there was no better place to get lost in than the woods.

Setting down in a small, tree shaded clearing, his wings hit the branches, causing brittle leaves to shower down around them. He expected Adora to climb down once his hooves touched the mossy floor. Instead, she held tighter to him, hands clutching convulsively in his mane. He stood, stock still, waiting. And waiting. When it became clear that she was going nowhere, Swift Wind lowered his body to the ground, folding his wings to shield his broken cargo.

It was morning before Adora pulled herself away from the comfort of the fur and feather cocoon. She had slept fitfully, lulled by the warmth of his body and the thrum of his heart. Her eyes were sore and gritty , red rimmed and swollen from hours of grief that she knew she had no right to feel. She had done it again. In trying to do the right thing she had got everything wrong. Catra's words echoed around her head… 'Why didn't you ask?' Why hadn't she? Had she become so hardened that there was no longer any trust in her heart?

Slipping down the equine's flank, her boots hit the ground with a dull thud. Swift Wind's head swung slowly towards her, fixing her with large, concerned eyes. She had thought he was still sleeping, hoping to slip away unseen before he woke.

“You doing alright there, Adora?” His deep, melodious voice held none of its usual playfulness.

She opened her mouth only to close it again. She could only shake her head, eyes darting to the dark depths of the forest. Swift Wind started to speak again, but Adora felt her blood rushing in her ears. Her heart was pounding and her skin prickled. His words were lost to her and she bolted into the woods. Running full tilt down a track too narrow for the horse to follow.

“Adora!” His shouts made her legs turn faster, stumbling over roots and fallen branches. Her vision was blurred but she pushed herself to move faster and faster.

“Adora!”

“ADOOORAAA!” The alicorn’s voice was almost imperceptible now, as the forest closed around her. The Whispering Woods took care of its own and Adora belonged here. So she ran.
Thirst was what kept her moving even when her legs became leaden and she could feel the blisters forming on her feet. She wasn’t sure how long she’d run or how far she had walked. When it wanted to be the Whispering Woods was a constantly shifting maze of dense trees and vines. It usually gave her an easier time but apparently it too had decided that she had crossed a line.

Staggering tiredly over yet another exposed root, throat burning, she hadn’t eaten or drunk anything in over twenty-four hours, she found herself spat out of the threes and into a clearing she knew well. She look up and up at the intimidating building that towered over her.

Her eyes look up at the stairs, her feet seeming to make a decision for her and taking her up them until she was standing, slumped, against the doorframe. Her eyes closed as she just let herself rest. She wasn’t sure how long she stood like that before her treacherous hand raised and rang the bell. She balled her first and drove it into the stood beside the door, feeling her knuckles split and pain shoot up her wrist. She hissed in pain, but did

nothing to staunch the blood that began to lazily ran over her hand and drip to the floor.

It didn't take long before she hears the sound of feet on marble. A big part of her wanted to turn tail and run again but she just couldn't. Her body needed to stop. She knew she could turn into She-ra, but what if she didn't come when she called? She hadn't in the magicat ship. It was as though the primal power that dwelt inside her had judged her wanting. It was how she was judging herself.

The door opened, the heavy wood moving slowly on its hinges, revealing the smiling face of Lance. He peered out, obviously hoping to see one of his plethora of sons standing on his doorstep. His gaze land on the slumped and rumpled form of the young woman who was friends with his son and his smile fell as he took in the state of her. He reached out, calling her name, she turned vacant eyes up to him and started to tilt. Before her vision turned black, large hands grasped her arms and stopped her from falling face first to the floor.

Lance tamped down his shock, swinging the woman into his arms and quickly moving back inside. He kicked the door closed with his heel and moved through the cavernous vestibule and towards the study. George would be there, hunched over his drafting table and hard at work.

Using his shoulder to push open the study door, he winced behind his glasses as the wood banged against the wall. George's head shot up at the sound, words of censure on his lips until he noticed the limp form cradled in his arms and rushed to his husband's side. George reached out, freeing Lance from her weight and moving to place her softly on the chaise.

The taller man, now unencumbered, rushed to the kitchen to get supplies. Not sure what was wrong with the young woman he threw all manner of items onto a tray. He tucked a towel under his arm and bustled back. He saw that George had straightened Adora's limbs and was, in the way of all parents, resting the back

of his hand against her forehead checking for any sign of a fever. He looked up at the man he had married over two decades ago and smiled sadly as he stood up and moved away. He too Lance's tray and placed it to one side before grabbing the blanket that was folded on the back of the couch and laid it over their guest.

"Should we call someone?" Lance put his arm around the smaller man's shoulders and rested his head against his temple.

"I think if she wanted to be somewhere else she would be. I say we settle her in one of the boys' bedrooms and see what she has to say when she wakes up." George's eyes hadn't left the prone woman as he spoke.

"Are you ok?" Lance punctuated his words with a kiss where their heads met.

"She looks like she's been through something awful. I wish I knew what it was." Even though it had been a long time since he had fought, George still remembered the toll it took on a person. Yet, he had never seen Adora look so worn even during the war.

"We can ask her tomorrow. If she's up to it." He squeezed gently. "We can tell her what we found about her book, maybe that will cheer her up." The taller man moved away to pick up the tray as George stooped to pick up the woman who never stirred as he held her to his chest.

They pair took her up to Bow's old room, it seemed only fitting to put her in her friend's bed. It didn't hurt that Bow's room was the closest to the study, and though both men may be in good shape they were not in the first bloom of youth anymore. By the time Adora was set on the bed, George was sweating lightly and had to take a couple minutes to get his breath back. While he did, Lance gently removed her boots and socks, wincing as he saw the raw flesh on her soles. Moving up her form her managed to slip off her jacket and then took the small bowl of salt water he had brought from the kitchen and a cloth. As carefully as he would touch a baby bird that had fallen from its next, he bathed her feet and

applied a salve before he pulled a sheet over her. George had regained his composure and drawn the curtains closed, shading the room.

Taking a final look at the unconscious form, they left her to sleep, a glass of water and wrapped sandwich beside her on the night stand.

Silence had settled over Brightmoon in the wake of the attack on Oasis. When the princesses had arrived back at the castle with their tales between their legs, Glimmer had tried to cajole them, to convince them to let her handle the queen. Netossa had glowered at her while Frosta had simply pushed her out of the way roughly, much to the shock of the guards, and stormed down the hallway to the queen's study.

Queen Angella and King Micah had been taking tea. Gently flirting and laughing. After Micah had been returned from Beast Island they had needed to get to know each other all over again. In the intervening years they had both changed so much, though at the core they remained the rebellious couple who had fallen in love against the advice of everyone around them. But Micah had been alone for almost fifteen years, the isolation having driven him just a little mad. His temper was shorter and his ability to cope with being around large groups was next to none. It had been difficult for him to get used to being part of a society again, even if it was beside his beautiful wife. That she had changed too had been a lot to get used to.

Angella had looked the same, down to each wave of her hair and arch of her eyebrow. He had aged, putting on muscle and gaining grey in his hair, but she still thought he was the most handsome man that she had ever seen. Micah had felt intimidated, wondering how could she love him again knowing how fragile and transitory his life was compared to her own. Angella, on the other hand, had tried to smother him with too much love and too many expectations too soon and he had almost hit her, once. That had

made him retreat like a wounded animal and run away to hide. She had feared he had disappeared again and search ceaselessly for him. It was these kinds of misunderstandings that had led them to Mysticore.

Castaspella had been all too happy to help them find a counsellor who they had religiously seen for almost five years until they had both slotted back together like the perfect puzzle pieces they are. But the time that they had made for each other, they still kept as a standing date. Just for them, tucked away privately for a few hours where they could be silly or soft. Micah felt almost like the young man he had been when he saw the angelic being for the first time, and knew that he would do anything if only he could be hers. It didn't hurt that Angella continued to look at him as though he hung the moons.

Reconnecting to his daughter had been far more difficult. When he had left, she had been a pudgy little toddler stumbling around behind him and asking to be picked up and thrown in the air. She had been sweet and easy, a tiny version of the woman he loved beyond measure. The young woman he had come back to had been hard to handle. She seemed light and airy, but there was an iron core to the girl that was dangerous. He wasn't sure that anyone else in Brightmoon, or the Alliance could see it. They were all so close, codependently so if you asked him, but even now he still felt as though he wasn't allowed an opinion on these young people that he had missed growing up. Yet, sometimes when he looked at her, he saw something in her eyes that made him afraid. He had seen it before, in the eyes of the woman that haunted the halls of the castle that he refused to enter, eyes now concealed behind a mask. It made him very worried about his progeny.

When the door banged open violently on its hinges, they were both taken aback. Micah leapt to his feet, already standing combat ready while Angella began to pull her magic from the Moonstone. It took a moment to realise that the tall figure in the doorway was Frosta and both began to relax. Not completely though, Frosta's expression was grave and she was almost vibrating with agitation, hands balled into fists at her sides. From

the open door they could hear something of a commotion coming towards them. Frosta shot an irritated glance over her shoulder before firmly shutting the door on the noise and walking purposefully to where the royal pair were now sitting.

"You need to know that we have done something very stupid that could damn us all." Frosta's words were clipped and direct as always. They lacked clarity though.

"What could you have done?" Micah was incredulous.

"Who is we?" The two elders spoke at once and Micah took his wife's hand.

"All of the princesses. Adora, Mermista and Perfuma came back from Oasis early."

"We haven't seen them." Angella was starting to sit up straighter.

"They returned early and told us that they had seen Hordak." Angella and Micah both tensed at the name. "They told Glimmer over the tracker and she gathered us. We met in the garden. Glimmer told us all we should go and find answers before we came to you and we did. Like a bunch of idiots!" Her voice rose in pitch. "It was like old times, the danger and excitement. Glimmer was so passionate, just like she used to be and we… we just went along with it. Only Perfuma said no."

"What did you do?" Angella was standing now, towering over the other woman who cowered a little under the Queen's glare.

"Glimmer had a plan. We were to go and find weapons on the magicat ship, come back with evidence for you and then attack." To her own ears now it seemed mad, irrational. The only outcome the outcome that had happened. Frosta hated that she turned back into a pre-teen when she was around Glimmer. "We broke in with Adora's shield key…" Her voice tapered off as Angella's glare intensified.

The angel was walking passed her now, towards the door and throwing open with another bang. She marched down the hall, legs eating up the distance in long strides until she was stood n front of her daughter who had gone very still. Her angry words as she tried to get to the study only to be retrained by the women around them, all of whom stepped back looking shame faced. Angella peripherally noticed that Adora was missing but her attention was too focused on Glimmer to think too much about it.

"Mom I…"

"Don't you dare 'mom' me!" Without taking her eyes off of her daughter she raised her voice. "Guards! Escort Princess Glimmer to my thrown room. Clear the room of anyone else and wait for me."

The guards looked between each other, not knowing what was going on, but when the queen looked towards them with a frown they sparing into action and flanked the pink haired princess, one grasping the top of her arms and escorting her gently along the way but ensuring she could not escape into thin air without taking one of them along with her. Angella's ire was now focused on the other women who were still standing in the hall.

"All of you have put Etheria's progress back a decade. If war comes from this then it will be on all your heads! I thought you all knew better than this. But clearly you need a reminder." She walked closer to them and hissed her next words. "I am the queen! You bring concerns to me and we work on plans as a team. Glimmer is NOT the queen." She paused, a murmur of assent coming from the small group. "Go back to your kingdoms. You will not return until you are given permission." She turned her back on them and moved quickly towards her thrown room, they were summarily dismissed.

Frosta rejoined them. There were no words. What could they say in the face of the truth. Their little escapade could have plunged them back into war.

Eyes fluttering open, Adora felt disorientated. She was laying on something soft, a comforting scent surrounding her. She moved her hands and a sheet fell away. Blinking owlishly, pieces fell into place as she realised that she was in a bed; in a bedroom. She was certain that it was not her room in Brightmoon, the bed was too soft and the sheets smelled all wrong. Good, but not her own. The room was dark, but a sliver of light glinted at the join where the curtains met. Slowly, she pushed herself up to a sitting position and cast her gaze around the room.

Even in the gloomy room, she could make out a desk with a battered chair down up to it, a tall cupboard next to it with a mirror stretching along both doors, reflecting her dishevelled image back to her. Like watching a ghost, she saw her hand reach up and ruffle her bedhead, settling the short strands into some semblance of order. She drew her knees up to her chest, wincing as her feet dragged along the cool sheets, wrapping her arms around them and resting her forehead there. Hiding her from the reflection. Trying hard to hide from herself.

Turning her head so that now it was her check pressed against her knees, she noticed the glass on the nightstand and remembered just how thirsty she was. It was a tall glass, maybe a pint, and she knew better than to slam the whole thing down at once, that was a sure way to bring it all back again. She uncurled and sat on the edge of the bed, before bringing the glass to her lips and sipping gingerly. She almost started to cry again when she saw the neatly wrapped sandwich. It was an act of care that she wasn't certain she deserved. It didn't stop her from picking it up and taking a bite, almost as hungry as she was thirsty. It was delicious and gone faster than it should have been. Her stomach groaned and turned, but it stayed down.

Refuelled, she felt strong enough to stand and limp over to the desk. She ran her hands over the various books and pencils that

were scattered across it, as though the owner had just stepped out and would be back any moment. Her eyes drifted up to the cork-board, flicking away when she saw picture upon picture of the Best Friend Squad. Her stomach almost rebelled as she saw. Glimmer's image.

Needing to get out, she picked up the empty plate and glass and walked barefoot out of Bow's room and towards the kitchen. She had been here many times over the years. It wasn't a home away from home, but she knew it well enough to navigate her way around. The crockery clinked as it was set on the counter and she thought about washing them up but was distracted by the sound of three voices coming from across the hall. Like she was being called by a siren song, she walked over to the study and knocked softly on the door. It opened almost at once and George reached out and took her hand, smiling as he led her into the room and settled her in an armchair. She saw that Lance was holding a tracker pad and her heart sank.

"Bow would like to say hello, would you be up to that?" Lance was so gentle as he spoke that Adora wondered how bad she must look to other people.

"I…" her voice cracked and she coughed a little, George rushed to a pitcher and poured her some amber liquid which she took gratefully, surprised as she tasted of the iced tea on her tongue. "I can talk to Bow." After all he hadn't been there.

Lance handed over the tracker pad and both older men walked to the other side of the room, pointedly not paying attention to what was being said but not wanting to leave the fragile seeming woman alone. Adora watched them walk away, both men were greyer than they had been when she first met them, and maybe a little less solid but they were still people you could rely on. Bow was lucky to have parents like them. He was lucky to have parents, period. That thought brought her dangerously close to thinking about what Catra had said to the assembled crowd about the bodies of dead parents that she had stormed into and her

hand came up to involuntarily rub the cheek that had been slapped.

Looking down shamefacedly she was met with Bow's understanding brown eyes as he studied her from the pad in silence, waiting for her to speak. She met his eyes, words caught in her throat, and saw how tired he looked. His skin looked ashen and there were obvious bags under his bloodshot eyes. Eyes that usually danced with affection seemed dulled.

"Hi Bow." Her voice was small but carried through the device in her lap.

"How are you doing, Adora? We were all worried about where you disappeared to." His tone was gentle and she loved him just a little more.

"How did you find me?" She knew but there was no harm in conforming it.

"My dads called me. They were worried about you, they weren't prying." Bow raised his hands, to show his transparency.

"I know, they're good men, like you." Her eyes dropped from the screen to her lap again, she didn't think she could look him in the eyes. "Do you know what happened?" It was almost a whisper.

"Yes." A deep sigh punctuated his words. "I'm not going to say I understand what you all did. It was reckless and dangerous…I don't want to go back to fighting for my life, Adora."

Blue eyes shot up to the screen, wide and horrified. Is that what he thought? That she had gone with Glimmer because she wanted to start a new war? To give her life meaning? Though from his perspective, she supposed it looked exactly like that. She had be searching for meaning and then this.

"I don't either Bow." Her voice was choked.

"Then why?"

“I don’t understand what you mean.” She knew her voice was started to sound panicked, she noted Lance and George take a step towards her but stop themselves as they heard Bow’s voice.

“Why wouldn’t you go to the council, ask them about Hordak? You could have spoken to Scorpia. Anything. But you chose to come back to Brightmoon and tell Glimmer! You know she’s been off lately.” He looked guilty. “Who am I kidding, she hasn’t been right for a while and I just let it happen. Why didn’t you go to Queen Angella?”

Why hadn’t they? They always had access to the royal couple, Adora lived in their home and had a good relationship with them. Why had Glimmer’s argument that they should gather information before going to the monarch seemed like a good idea? She wracked her brain but came up empty. It wasn’t like the other’s had gone against her either. Adora should have known better. Chain of command had been ground into her as a child, and the chain of command began and ended with the Queen. Years of fighting under Glimmer’s instruction were hard to ignore though.

So hard to ignore that she had defied protocol.

“I don’t know.” She really didn’t. “What’s happening there?” It had already been close to forty-eight hours since they were ejected from Oasis and they had been given a ticking clock.

“The others had all be sent back to their kingdoms. Glimmer is under house arrest. Queen Angella has confined her to our quarters with twenty-four hour guard. It was King Micah’s idea. She’s been in with advisors, working on some sort of treaty to extend to Oasis to avoid an escalation.” Bow was usually one of the Queen’s advisors, but it sounded like he was being kept out of the loop.

“Aren’t you a part of those conversations?”

“I am being barred from the meetings. I am too close to Glimmer and they are trying to avoid a conflict of interest, as much as they

can given that she is the queen's daughter." A hard edge crept into his voice as he spoke. Bow was a trustworthy man and to be cast aside for free of betrayal grated on him.

"I am so sorry, Bow."

"I know." He didn't say it wasn't her fault or make any excuses for her. "I think you better stay there for now, let Queen Angella focus on the task at hand. I'll keep in touch." He smiled sadly and the screen went black.

Adora leant forward, tracker clasped in her hands, pointing towards the floor. She closed her eyes and tried to keep her breathing under control, head bowed over her knees as she began to rock gently in her seat. She wasn't aware of the motion until a large hand landed softly on her shoulder, stilling her. She didn't look up, but allowed her body to fall sideways, until her head was resting against his hip, taking comfort in the movement of his hand as it moved to stroke her hair. She wondered how many times her friend had taken comfort from such a motion.

With his other hand Lance took the tracker from her limp hands and passed it over to George. They had both heard the conversation, whether they were trying to eves drop or not. Bow had already filled them in on the situation. George had been horrified, but pleased that his son had been left out of it. He had hate that Bow had become involved in the last war but respected his choices. It didn't meant that he wanted to watch it happen again. He moved to his desk, setting down the tracker and picking up a pile of books and papers. He caught Lance's eye and saw his husband smile that charming grim of his as he crouched to say something to Adora.

Not long after they were arranged around the huge kitchen table, its rough hewn surface pitted with the marks of a lifetime together and a bakers dozen of boys. There were holes and gauges, pictures scattered here and there in anything ranging from pencil to paint. They had never had the heart to wipe them off, and once all the boys had been grown, in a fit of nostalgia, Lance had

varnished them into the table, preserving the history of the object in its grain. They were historians after all and every object held value. They each had a cup of tea in front of them and a slice of cake, though none of them had touched either yet. Instead, they were all focused on the array of documents laid out. There weren't many, but what was there was fascinating.

Moving to another space had helped to shake Adora out of her funk a little as had the promise of some answers. She was hoping that it would help her understand why Glimmer, and she, were so suspicious of the magicats. It would vindicate them if it could prove some sort of deception. But, in vindicating them it would indict Catra and her newfound kin.

"So," George was the one to get the ball rolling, taking a sip of his tea and placing the cup back onto the delicate saucer with a clink. "We found some more mentions of the magicat story that was in your book. What was interesting, was that there was no evidence to corroborate any of the stories. It would seem that this book you brought to us," he tapped the battered cover. "Rather than being a factual tome, is actual the detail of a myth." Adora's shoulders deflated a little. Seeing this Lance jumped in.

"Once we knew that these were just stories, the question became where did they come from. We obviously know that magicat's are an extraterrestrial species. We also know, from what you were told in Oasis, that their ship crashed and they remained in suspended animation until the Horde."

"That's definitely true, we saw the bodies when we…" Her voice was quiet as she admitted what she had seen.

"If your Catra," Adora couldn't hide a wince at the use of the other woman's name, "was the first of her kind to walk Etheria then how did these people draw these." Lance opened her book to reveal the picture of the kitten. He and George then opened two other book and unrolled a scroll of parchment.

Adora studied the images. She knew the one from the book she had found in her drawer, it was the other that caught her eye. They were not all of equal quality, a couple were laughably cartoonish, giving the cat people disproportionally large ears and the faces of actual cats. One or two were of a similar quality to the first. On one, she noticed that there appeared to be annotations but before she could pull it towards her, George was holding something out to her.

"As we read around the myth of the magicats, something became very clear," he cleared his throat and began to read.

…"From the sky rained blue flame. Faster and faster it came, filling the sky with its inferno. A second sun falling from the sky, turning the sky black in its wake. A shard of fire split and flew along the horizon, the last shooting star in the sky. The fire blazed, then went out. Every star gone from the sky and the true sun had abandoned the world. Two moons now looked upon us and all that had been known was lost…"

"Whatever happened, it coincided with Etheria being pulled into Despondos. It's no wonder it became attached to a myth. The stars went out and there was fire in the sky." He turned the book towards her, showing a picture of a fireball all painted in shades of blue.

"Exploring the timeline, and using the data you gained from the First Ones ship, it seems clear that whatever technology was used to pull Etheria from one dimension to another caught the Halfmoon and damaged it, sending it barrelling towards Etheria. Why that led to a crash we can't say."

"But," Lance continued, "what we have been able to deduce is that, although the larger ship crashed into the desert, in a hostile uninhabited area, hence why nobody was aware of it, the 'shooting star' landed in a populated area."

He pulled over a large rolled sheet of paper and unfurled it to show a detailed map of Etheria as it would have been a thousand

years ago. Adora noted that the area that would be the Waste, was heavily border in red and clearly held sigils which showed it was to be avoided. What her eyes were drawn to though, was the image of a pale blue sarcophagus. She reached out and carefully traced her finger over it. Her mind just couldn't place where it was. George reached up and overlaid a translucent map of modern Etheria, showing that the 'shooting star' had crashed on the edge of the Whispering Woods, in the area that had been the no-mans land between it and the Fright Zone.

"So what does that tell us?" Her curiosity had temporarily pushed her sadness to the side.

"What it tells us is that the people in the area went and found the 'shooting star' and what they found was obviously not that." George was now holding up another, more batter book. He opened it to a page with a drawing of what looked like a large, smooth peach pit. On the next page was the same object, this time showing the interior which contained five people.

Adora reached out and reverently took the book from him with trembling hands and looked more closely at the second image. All of the figures were drawn with their eyes closed, but none of them were in pods of any kind. She turned to the next page and began to read.

…"The star was glowing red with heat when we found it. It had been two days since the stars went out and we had finally found one of the things that had fallen from the sky. It was a strange sight, etched all over with intricately lined patterns but so smooth to the touch, once it had cooled, that it felt like silk.

When we tapped on the outside, there was a hollow echo that came back and we were shocked to think that it was not a solid object. Curiosity is a seductive mistress, and we came back the next day with cutters and hammers of all types. It took hours and a lot of effort but finally we were through and prising open a chunk.

That was when we found them.

They were curled inside the hollow metal shell, huddled together. Some of us cried. It looked like a family balled up inside. Two adults and three small children. They were all covered in fur, big ears and tails on each one. They looked like nothing we had ever seen. Like cats. All of them were dead.

We pulled them out of the hollow and laid them in on the moss. They did not look peaceful in death. Their faces were etched with fear, even the smallest child (who could have been no older than my own three year old son) had their faced scrunched up apprehensively. We would sketch pictures of them later before we gave them a decent burial in the place that they had landed.

Others had reached inside the now empty chamber. It was a small space, hardly big enough for the small group that we had pulled out. Everything inside had obviously been thrown around. There were all manner of glass looking sheets on one wall. We weren't sure what their purpose were. What we did fine was several small books, some rations and what were obviously personal items to the family. There were three stuffed animals of a sort we had never seen before.

The family was buried with solemnity from those of us who had found them. We dragged the object back to town and broke it up. The metal was melted and we were able to salvage many precious metals from the wreckage. The books were taken to our library. The librarian hopes that they will be able to decipher some of the peculiar writing…"

"So they really did crash land a thousand years ago." Her mind was processing what she had just read.

"It seems so. That was written by a farmer. We think that your book comes from the attempt at translation from the very librarian referenced here and it is likely that the images are from the original book found with the bodies." George tapped the familiar picture of a child.

“The smaller vessel must have been an escape pod. They must have been inside in case of a problem, to ensure that some of the magicats would survive.” Adora’s words sounded more like she was talking to herself.

“If they deployed it too late it wouldn’t have been able to get away and they faced the same fate as all of their people.”

“Can I take these to my room?”

“We thought you might also want to take a look at these,” Lance brought up a box and opened it reverently, showing the young woman the fragments of a book. It had clearly been cut and torn many times. “We think these are fragments of the books they found. They were among many other wax sealed boxes we found at a dig twenty years ago or so.”

“Be gentle with them, try not to handle them too much, they’re fragile.” George smiled encouraging and Lance proffered the box.

Glimmer sat on the floor surrounded by the scattered and shattered remnants of the things that had been on her desk. She had thrown them from her desk in a rage. How dare her mother confine her to her room like she was still a child being grounded! Not even Bow was allowed to come in unless he was bringing her meals. Ever since her mother had her frog marched to the thrown room she had been seething. Could nobody see how convenient it all was? The body’s acted as a perfect smoke screen for anything else. They still didn’t have answers about Hordak but were going to go, tail between their legs to those animals and beg forgiveness for her trespass! When she had been put under house arrest she had laughed in her mothers face which had just made the older woman purse her lips and had her shown to her room.

Glimmer’s room had been sealed with magic from the outside. Guards posted on her balcony and at her door. The seal was warded against her magic. She had found that out the hard way

as she had attempted to transport from her bathroom to her sideboard. Rather than disappearing in a cloud of sparkles, she had felt electricity across her skin that pricked like a thousand bee stings. She hadn't tried again. The ward had her father's signature all over it and she was nowhere close to the caster that he was.

Her confinement was only thirty-six hours old and already she felt stir crazy. After she had trashed the room in a storm of temper, she had attempted to get out. That had been fruitless. Everything was locked and the magic impediment was not worth trying again, the pain had been too intense. She had screamed and shouted, raging at the guards, her mother, Catra. Catra most of all. That Horde scum was the reason for all of this.

And then there was Adora. That traitor had run away rather than facing the music alongside her. She was the one who had brought the news of Hordak. She was the one who had let them inside the shield and driven them to the crater. Where was her house arrest? Where were the repercussions for her? She had fled like a coward on Swift Wind and from what little gossip she could get from Bow had gone to hideout at his fathers' library.

She seethed for a day and a night and another day. Then night came and she was still sitting among the ruins of torn photographs and shattered ornaments. Once all these mementos held so much meaning to her that she treasured them like priceless artefacts, now they were simple truffles. Useless and pointless as her confinement.

That was how Shadow Weaver found her, sat amongst the rubble of her past, simmering with impotent rage. It made the older woman smile beneath her mask as she manifested into the room in a black cloud of shadow-smoke. At first Glimmer didn't notice her. As it should be, the witch melted into the shadows and slipped the mask from her face and tucked it within her robes. Then she glided out of the darkness in a rustle of robes and Glimmer looked up at her, a smile blooming out of the scowl on her face as she saw her confidant.

“Glimmer, my dear girl, I heard what happened.” She bent her tall frame and cupped the younger woman’s cheek. “Are you all right?”

“I’m angry. I’m angry and frustrated with my mother’s lack of understanding. Why are we the only people who can see that this is all just a trap?” Glimmer got to her feet and joined the other woman witting on her bed. They both sat sideways so that they could make eye contact. Shadow Weaver rested a gentle hand on her forearm.

“Sometimes we have to take charge for other people’s own good, Glimmer. They can’t always tell what’s best for them. The worst the medicine the better it is for you, after all.” As she spoke she removed a metal flask from the folds of her robe and proffered the vessel to the woman opposite.

Glimmer reached for the flask and took a long drink of the liquor that burned a little as it travelled down her throat. She didn’t often drink with the old witch, or anyone, she always wanted to be in control of her actions. But in times of high stress, there was nothing wrong with a shot or two. As she took another pull, Shadow Weaver’s smile grew as she watched pink eyes turn red and stay that way for a beat or two. Taking back the flask, she whisked it away without taking her own drink.

“Maybe I am wrong? What if there was nothing there and I have started something, as mother says?” Her head started to hang, but the hand on her arm squeezed and she looked back up.

“Never doubt the courage of your convictions, Glimmer. A good leader sticks to their guns.” Self doubt in her protege was the last thing she needed.

“Tell me, did you discover anything of use?”

“The story they told about the dead was true…”. Glimmer’s pink eyes fixed on her. “Did you have them all killed?”

“Goodness no, it was all Hordak’s orders. I never knew anything about it until they brought that mongrel back with them. Of course they would have a different story, Hordak will have twisted it to suit himself.” She had been afraid this would come up but it was easy to deflect. She had learnt a long time ago that people believe what you want them to believe.

“I knew it! I knew it as soon as they said he was there!” Her face cleared, then clouded again as she thought of something. “Magic didn’t work there. I don’t know if it was the room, although I had been able to use magic in the rest of the ship, or the magicat’s themselves. I shot bombs at Catra and they just seemed to absorb into her skin. It had no affect. It was the same for all of us. Even Adora couldn’t transform once she was surrounded by them.”

That was curious indeed. Shadow Weaver had used magic to twist and turn the young magicat inside out all her life. Magic had always worked on her just fine. Perhaps it was the princess magic, or the chamber itself. If only she had one of them to study at length, she had never really bothered with the thorn in her side, keeping her under control had been hard enough.

“That is very interesting indeed. Maybe there is some mystical reason for their name after all, maybe magicats have powers that we did not suspect. I am sure we will have time to find out very soon, your mother is a bleeding heart like all the others. Mark my words, she will invite a delegation here.” Already a dark plan was forming in her mind.

“How does that help us?”

“Oh Glimmer, you will need to show them and your mother how sorry you are and make your peace. And then we will be able to study them and find their weaknesses.”

On the third day after a night spent tirelessly looking over the history of a woman she wasn't sure would ever speak to her again, Adora's inherent need to always be 'doing' took over and she found herself pulling on her boots after a delicious breakfast with George and Lance, and then heading out for a walk. She promised them that she wouldn't be gone more than a few hours and made her way into the woods.

Today, the dense trees seemed far more inviting. Friendly as they always were to her, whether because they liked Adora or obeyed She-ra, she didn't know, but she was glad of it. She tried to enjoy the flowers and the smell of sap and the greenness around her. Her mind was still whirling from the information she had found. She hoped that maybe she could help make amends with it. It there was any possibility of a way back from what she had done. Starting to slip back into melancholy, she saw Catra's anger at Glimmer, her disappointment with her and Lonnie's sadness. It made her stomach churn. Getting lost in her head, she walked straight into an obstacle and went sprawling into the leaf litter.

Groaning, spitting out a mouthful of dirt, she rolled onto her back and yelped when two giant eyes appeared right over her own. Reacting on instinct, she began to scrabble backwards, heart pounding. It was the cackle that stopped her.

"Mara dear, what are you doing down there? Come, come, you said you would help me clean my cottage today." Even after all these years, Razz still called her Mara from time-to-time. It happened less now than it had, time seemed to have settled down around the old woman.

"Sorry Razz." Adora was on her feet now, dusting off her pants. "Lead the way."

Following the small scarlet figure through the woods, the blond hoped that she would be able to make her way back to the library. She had noticed over the years that the woods seemed to bend for Razz, as though she were one of its roots and it needed to make her path as easy as it could. Her cottage was never far, no

matter where you were. The ancient lady looked exactly as she had when Adora first saw her as a teen, perhaps she always would. Perhaps Razz was a spirit of the woods and would outlast them all.

Once inside the cottage, Razz pushed her into one of the armchairs that faced the fire and set about bustling around to make her a hot drink. It was comforting. Sometimes Adora wondered if this is what it would be like to have a grandmother. She pottered, she doted, she occasionally hit you with a broomstick and made you copious amounts of pie. As though thinking of it made it so, a slice of berry pie was shoved under her nose before Razz sank into her own chair opposite and stared at her with her hugely magnified eyes.

"You are troubled, Adora. Tell Razz what troubles you?" It was hard not to become a little hypnotised by those eyes and the cadence of her voice. Adora found herself telling Razz everything.

Out of words, she set to work eating her pie. Silence settled around the two of them until there were nothing but crumbs on her plate. She set it down on the floor beside her. When she sat back up Razz leant forward and rested a bony hand on her knee.

"You fear that you have cut down the new growth in the garden and that it will never grow back." She was used to riddles now and waited. "The hardiest weeds can be cut, poisoned or burned and grow back through even the smallest crack in the darkest corner. Wild and savage and beautiful in a way that is not perfect, but is perfect all the same." She tapped the knee under her hand. "Sometimes the gardener needs to ask the wildflower, that they called a weed, for forgiveness and cultivate it anew."

Adora mulled over those words. Could she really ask for a second, or would it be third, chance to prove that she would not hurt her former friends? It seemed too cruel to even consider. The two of them picked berries and Adora carried a full bucket back to the cottage for the old woman. As she began to make a crust, Adora prepared to leave when a question popped onto her lips.

“Razz, do you remember a big, blue fireball falling from the sky when Etheria was pulled into Despondos?”

“Visitors waiting to say hello.”

“They’ve said hello now, Razz. The girl I told you about, Catra, she was one of them.”

“Then all the more reason to cultivate them after they have been seeded in the ground.”

Angella sat behind the large monitor, looking into its dead black depths and seeing her own solemn face reflected back at her. She had not intended to take the full three days that they had been given to open communication with Oasis, but planning a satisfactory strategy had been difficult. Glimmer was remorseless and her actions unforgivable. She had not grown up to be the woman that Angella thought she would. In the war she had shown so push purpose and honour but now it was like all she wanted is a return to the ‘good old days’ of the war where she felt needed.
When Glimmer had described the confrontation in the chamber full of the dead, there was no emotion in her voice. Just cold facts and bile about the former Horde second in command. It had chilled her that her child could be so cold about so much death. When Angella had first heard abut the Horde’s attempted genocide on that ship, after their first contact with the new civilisation, she had felt sickened that she had not known and that so many innocent people had died and she had never even met one of the magicat’s, not even Catra, face-to-face. When had Glimmer lost her humanity?

The other princesses, when contacted and interrogated over the trackers, had all been clearly affected by what they had seen in that room. They had detailed the smashed pods and the desiccated bodies, the smaller room with baby sized units and how Catra had come in roaring like an avenging demon. None of

them had a justification for their actions. Adora had still not returned, but Bow had spoken with her and assured the queen that she was more devastated than anyone and safely in the hands of his fathers. Angella would need to have a very serious conversation with the woman who wielded such immense power with apparently such poor judgement, but she had other matters to focus on for now.

It had hurt her heart to ban Bow from the talks. She was aware that he was not sharing her daughter's room during her house arrest, he couldn't, but he still visited her daily. He was a great member of her council and a good politician. It had surprised them all when he had taken to it so well but it had been gratifying to know that her daughter would eventually have a solid sounding board by her side when Angella stepped down as queen, though now she didn't know if she ever would. She knew Bow understood her reasons, but also knew that he felt slighted at his ejection. Her pans needed to work so that everything could get back on an even keel and they could all move forward.

Micah had wanted to be with her when she made the call. Wanted to stand by her shoulder and show his support. She loved him all the more for it but had said no. it was important to show that she was willing to be alone to make contact, to look the representatives of Oasis in the eyes and ask for forgiveness and the start of a journey to a lasting peace. There were still questions, they were not about to allow themselves to be steam roller were Glimmer's suspicions not without grounds, but there were more diplomatic ways to do it and Angella was very adept at diplomacy.

Taking a deep breath to ground herself, she reached forward a long fingered hand and initiated contact.

Chapter End Notes

Now let's see how things played out in Oasis...

Chapter 14 - 72 Hours in Oasis

Chapter Summary

Two chapter 14s - all events are happening concurrently in the two places.
Let's see how Glimmer's plans have affected them.

(I would read the Brightmoon section first though).

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Angry voices flowed through the room, low but constant. Every magicat over the age of sixteen sat, packed into the meeting room. It was hot and the anxiety in the room was palpable. Only a few hours had passed since they were all filling the crater. Blue and yellow eyes studied the throng, flitting from one form to another. She knew them all. Knew their names, their sorrows and their joys. Tace had shown her who they were and it had been her duty to understand them. No, not a duty, a pleasure. To understand them, was to understand herself.

Now was not the time for rashness or vengeance. If they stooped to that then they would show the Alliance that they had been right. She knew that they would have to honour their forebears, but vengeance would just get them killed. Sh let them vent a little longer before she let out a defining roar that broke over all the other noise in the room and left silence in its wake. All eyes were on her now on the small raised platform at the front of the council chamber. Usually this place represented all of Oasis, but today it was just for magicats.

"I know that you are all angry. I am angry. Our land has been violated, our dead have even desecrated and our trust has been broken. All of Oasis has suffered in this but none more than us." There were shouts of agreement from the crowd.

“So what are you going to do about it?” The words were angry, darling out of the male near the back as he glared at her.

“We are going to force Brightmoon to punish those who attacked us and make them ensure peace.” She knew that they would hate it. They wanted blood, not paper.

Shouts filled the room now, louder and more angry. It was hard to make out the words clearly but she knew that many of them were cursing her and her attachment to the Alliance, messy as it was. She let it go on, knowing from bitter experience that it would soon wear itself out and then angry silence would fill the room once more. It took longer than expected but soo they were all watching her again.

“I know you want to go to Brightmoon and show them what they did to us.” Shouts of ‘yeah’ and raised fists greeted her words. “You want to bare your fangs and unsheathe your claws and tear at the people who have hurt us.” More whoops. “You want them to pay for all the wrongs that have been done to our people.” She had to stop as the cheering reached a crescendo.

She was watching them intently as the commotion continued. She saw that it was a small minority of loud and angry young males, all around twenty, who were leading the shouts for violence. Many of the magicat’s just looked sad and sick. It was how she felt.

“But you don’t want that!” Her voice rose above them and then the ‘boos’ that she had anticipated came. She raised her voice over them too, until they were silenced. “You don’t want a war. You are not warriors, or soldiers. It would kill your spirit and break your body.”

“We’re fought war!” Came from one side.

“What do you know?” A scream from elsewhere.

“Outsider!” It was an accusation that had been levelled at her more than once when she had been recognised as the chief of

them all. Her roar had shown that she was without question, the alpha of their group. It didn't mean that they all liked it.

"Then I am an outsider. I am also the only soldier in this room!" Her shout was sharp and the heckles stopped. "Our planet was attacked, and we ran to survive. I have seen the records. When the ships left the enemy wasn't even at the gate. You were all as much children as I was. We fled to survive and we have survived, but that fear you and your parents knew? That is NOTHING compared to the terror you feel everyday on the battlefield!" Her gaze was steely as she moved it around the room to meet as many eyes as she could. It was a lie, of course, she had never felt terror on the battlefield, she'd been all too ready to die by then. But they didn't need to hear that.

"War is like an animal you brought home to feed one day and keeps coming back and demanding more and more of your food until you are starving and it is fat and curled up by your fire. It's not one and done. It lasts for years, kills your body and your spirit. It breaks you and makes you into a monster!" There was passion in her words, no need for equivocation here.

"So you're a monster, Chief." This time the call wasn't a hackle, it was filled with disbelief.

"I am the biggest monster of them all, Midrall. I have done unspeakable things and had them done to me. I was pulled out of my pod and brought to a place where I was a replacement for a dead soldier. I was raised in battle simulations eating grey slabs of engineered algae. I was taught that weakness was something to be beaten for. That individuality was another reason to beat me. I was scorched in the fire of war, tempered on the anvil of fists and switches. I am what happens when wars go on for generations." She noticed the males who had been so loud were now all looking chastened.

"You want your children to live in peace, you don't want them ever to be afraid. I don't want Yarsha to know fear, or any child in this place. All those children we brought from the Horde, those

small boys and girls were already soldiers - just grist to the mill. They still scream in the night. The orphanage sometimes rings with their cries."

She let that sit with them for a few moments, noting tears on some faces.

"Trust that I want what is best for us and all of Oasis. Don't let your hearts be darkened by hate and violence. Living well is the best revenge. We are good, and honest and that is the truth of us. We will make a lasting peace and get our justice the right way. If the time comes that we go to Brightmoon, some of you will be by my side as envoys." It was time to let them go, she hoped her words had broken through.

"Go and be with each other. Feel sad, feel angry but don't feel hate."

The room cleared quickly until Catra was left with only one other magicat. Kesh came and sat beside her at the edge of the stage. She wasn't her sister, didn't really know what her gentle sister had seen in the rough and ready soldier, but she loved her because Tace had loved her.

"You did good, Chief. Tace would be proud." She saw Catra's shoulders finally relax at the words and knew her sister would be proud of her too.

Knocking on Catra's bedroom door took her by surprise as she read to the little girl dozing in her lap. No matter what chaos was going on around them, Yarsha loved to be read to, as she curled up in somebody's lap. She was always listening, could always tell you abou the story she had head, but her eyes would be closed and her little body completely relaxed. Catra enjoyed these times. Nobody had ever read to the Horde children. Nothing outside of military strategy in dingy classrooms. She was discovering the

magic of children's stories. Right along with her kitten. She would not let the princesses ruin things for her and her child.

Rhythmically running her hands through the girls hair until she began to purr as she made the transition from dozing to sleeping, Catra called out for the person outside to come in. It was unusual for anyone in the orphanage to knock, they were all family here and would burst in if they wanted something. It wasn't her favourite aspect of living here, she would rather lock her door and have nobody else in their space, but it was another thing that she had learned from Tace, that being open to people was sometimes as literal as allow people to come in.

The door opened slowly, revealing the tall pallid form of Hordak. He stood rigidly in the opening, hesitating to cross step threshold. Meeting his red eyes, she indicated that he should stay put, as she moved to put the sleeping girl in the centre of the large bed and covered her with a light blanket. Pressing a kiss to a small velvet ear, she walked to her visitor and ushered him back into the corridor before gently closing the door. Hordak opened his mouth to speak, but she shook hers, and he remained silent. Passing Scorpia's room she pushed open the door, happy to see that even under the circumstances it was unlocked today.

She poked her head trough the small gap and saw Scorpia curled up on the bed with a picture cradled gently between her claws that she looked at forlornly, not even looking up at Catra's intrusion. She was loath to interrupt her friend, goodness knows they all needed to grieve and wallow in their own ways, but she thought maybe she could offer something of a distraction to her melancholy friend.

"Hey, Scorp." She kept her voice soothing as she would if she were talking to Yarsha after a nightmare. The white haired woman slowly brought her gaze around to meet hers. "Any chance you could go sit in with fuzzy-butt? She's napping and I need to go have a conversation with Hordak."

Scorpia was on her feet, gently placing the picture face down on her nightstand, before Catra had even finished. She made her was to the door, which Catra held wider for her, and looked at the big man, bigger even than herself, who in that moment seemed very small as he waited on the magicat. She smiled wanly at Catra as she passed on her way to the room down the hall.

"You know I always have time for my favourite kitten." Her words were happy but her tone was heavy as she moved away.

"C'mon ghoul, let's talk somewhere where there aren't kids to hear." She had made her peace with him long ago, but they weren't what could be called friends.

She led him down the back stairs, keeping him away from the children. These stairs led down through the kitchens and out to the street. She knew he would have come in that way. Many of the children who had started their lives in the Horde still found seeing their former dictator traumatising. The first time, after they let him roam free, that a child had run screaming from him on the street Hordak had decided that the less he came to town the better. It was why he and Entrapta lived far away in the Spire. The less people had to look at him the better.

They walked in tense silence. Everything about Catra felt tense for the last twenty-four hours. The only time she didn't feel like a clenched fist was when she was with her daughter. The further she got from her child, the more the frustrated rage bloomed inside her. It was feeling that she had hoped that she had left behind in her teens. It was something else to hate the princesses for. They walk quickly and ended at the bar, at this time of day they would just be setting up and the two of them could go to a table and talk candidly without interruption.

Looking across the table at the man partially responsible for ruining her life, Shadow Weaver still held top spot of her life ruiners but this man had given her the job, she couldn't help but marvel at the change in his appearance. They had taken away his exosuit when they had arrested him and broken it down for parts.

Entrapta had been incensed and it wasn't often you saw that but he had taken it as part of his punishment. She knew that now he saw it as essential to his rehabilitation. Magicat medicine and medical equipment had gone a long way to healing his body and he was now just a very tall man with some very odd physical quirks. He didn't look almost as frightening as he used to.

"Say what you have to say, old man." Her words were curt, she had little time for pleasantries.

"We both know that this is my fault, Catra. They saw me and then we were attacked. They want me." His deep, melodious voice was full of mourning and self hatred. "Hand me over to them. It will keep this place safe. It seems only fitting that I should be your sacrifice."

"When they first got here they were baying for my blood, Hordak. If we hand you over now, they'll just come back in a month or a year and demand me and then somebody else, and somebody else. Nobody is martyring themselves for this place, you old fool. Nobody else dies or gets thrown in a cell to rot." Once she had thought he should but Entrapta would never forgive her and Stanley deserved his father.

"Then how are we to prevent a war? They are easier to start than to finish, Catra. I should know." The shame in his voice was a long way from his superciliousness from years passed.

"For starters, I am pretty certain that what happened on the Halfmoon was done without the orders of the Alliance. That was a fishing expedition. Sparkles is desperate to take me down and saw an opportunity. We wait for them to make contact and then we force them to sign a peace accord with us. We show them good faith they do the same." It stung, that she would have to be the bigger person. She was no politician but as the Chief it was up to her to make sure that the magicat's never suffered what she had suffered.

Hordak and the magicats had a history, or somebody who looked like him at least. When Tace had first seen Hordak when he was arrested she had gone berserk, lashing out at him and if he hadn't still been in the exosuit, she would have gutted him. Catra had been forced to grab her around the waist and pull her off of him. Hordak still sported a faint scar on his chin from her attack. It had taken wheedling to get answers from either of them. Tace had volunteered it freely and later, Hordak had filled in the gaps.

Hordak's maker, or brother? Catra wasn't sure of the mechanics, was the leader of a galactic version of the Horde, that revelation had made her skin crawl. It was that monster that her people had been running from, him and his threat to destroy their world if they did not captivate to them. It was what Hordak had been trying to emulate here. He had found himself stranded in a strange place and endeavoured to make it what he was familiar with. It was an experiment that he could see had failed early on but habit and obsession had been what had kept him going and going until a purple haired variable had shaken him out of his malaise.

Over time, Hordak had shown himself to be an asset to them all. Working tirelessly on converting equipment from the Fright Zone and the Halfmoon to be useful to Oasis. He had been the one to build their solar vehicles. Hordak was a man making amends for himself and the man one he looked like. Catra wasn't going to let him throw that away.

"Look," she leaned towards him, "I'm gonna need you to come with us when we inevitably go to Brightmoon. You are going to be yourself, no going back to that act that we all grew up with. You're going to be the husband, the father and the mechanic that you are NOT the warlord they think you are. Do you understand me."

Hordak looked up at her with his red eyes as soft as she had ever seen them. It wasn't an expression she had ever had directed at her, she was more used to murderous glee as he tried to kill her, but it was a look he directed at his family. She hoped it meant he

understood that she would protect him as she would protect anyone here.

"I understand. You are a good woman Catra. I am sorry I didn't nurture you better when you were a child. Who know what you could have been."

"Good job you didn't, or we'd still be living in a war zone and hating ourselves." He nodded in agreement as Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle came from the back room to join them at the table. It should have seemed odd to her to see this group clustered around the table, Hordak should have looked out of place, but with Rogelio sat at his side, Lonnie at one end of the table and Kyle at the other. They all understood.

Nobody would be taking the fall for somebody else's crimes this time.

Catra hadn't returned home after meeting with Hordak. She had left him talking with the others and made her way back to her own office. She needed to be alone, or as alone as she could be in Oasis. She loved the place and she liked that she was loved, but she was responsible for so much that it was hard sometimes to get a moment to herself. She walked through the bullpen and to her office, nodding greeting to the serious faced men and women she passed. It was usually a jolly place but today it was almost silent. She entered her office and was careful to turn the lock behind her. She was here to take moment, not deal with problems.

She threw herself into her office chair, hearing it whine in protest at the harsh treatment. She let out a little growl. It was hard to be the one staying measured in all of this when all she wanted to do was scream and punch and tear. Glimmer had been lucky to leave this place with her throat in tact. She didn't know where that level of self restraint had come from, or maybe it was just an old sense of self preservation that she was hardwired with. Adora's voice

ringing out in that space telling her to stop had taken her back to a very dark place, or being punished for nothing and being told if only she did better it wouldn't happen again. If she'd just stop and think, be less disrespectful things would change. When she'd try and things would just be the same. Why could Adora never see that it wasn't her fault?

She growled again and banged her fist on the desk hard enough to make one of the drawers open a little. She sighed and pulled the drawer out more, pulling out the small screen that she kept there. It was a book sized tablet that had much of the history of the magicats' uploaded onto it. She had poured over every bit of information she could get about her people over the last decade and it had filled an empty part of her that she hadn't known was there. Meeting with Hordak had forced her mind back to the reason why her people had been hurtling through space when they had been caught in a spacial anomaly and flung to Etheria.

She flicked the device on and watched the screen come to life in front of her. She pressed a few keys and was taken to the logs. She tapped the thumbnail of a portly magicat, a historian she had come to learn, who had been recording all she could about their home-world. In this particular recording, looking harried and dishevelled she told the watcher…

"We have been aware of a force approaching for some time. They started at the edge of our galaxy, we received distress call too late to be of service. Planet after planet went quiet. Old allies were gone. We began to build three arks. Our leaders had always wanted to explore the far flung reaches of the universe, who knew their hubris would be our salvation?

The arks were already half built, languishing in hangers on an abandoned island, victims of budget cuts and a lack of passion. It has been eight months and they are almost complete; the Fullmoon, the Halfmoon and the Quartermoon. They will carry tens of thousands of our people out into the stars to find a new world far from this danger. Many of us will be left behind but at least there will be hope.

We have received transmissions from the Galactic Horde. Threats of destruction if we refuse to capitulate to the will of their leader, a totalitarian dictator known as Prime. In all the data we have been able to gain from other planets in his path, it won't matter if we surrender or not. He will take what he wants from us and wipe us from the face of history. We will be lucky if the planet itself survives his arrival. By all accounts he has a weapon that can blow a planet to smithereens.

Some wish to fight, to use our fleet to preemptively take the fight to Prime. It is a foolish desire. We have limited ships and our armoury is sparse at best. Perhaps we have let ourselves forget our warrior ways too much. Though I do not think even our ancestors would have stood a chance against a creature so avaricious and cruel.

The Horde will be upon us within weeks. The ships are to be filled with as many of us as can fit. Some of our elders wanted them to be filled with only the 'best and brightest' of our kind. Cooler heads prevailed. Who is to say who is the best when talking about magicat life? We performed a lottery based on our census. Thirty-thousand assorted member of our species will shoot into the night. Thirty-thousand chances for our future. Our only hope that they will outrun Prime and disappear into deep space. Found a new home for us.

I am not one of the chosen, though I have been privilege to put together our history for the future generations of you who will be born on alien soil. You ARE the best of us. You are all of us."

…Catra turned off the recording. Prime. It terrified her to think that out there, somewhere, was a creature of such evil that he could turn worlds to dust and erase whole civilisations. From what she had learned from readouts on the bridge they weren't in what the instruments considered space anymore. She hoped it meant they were tucked away safely away from this tyrant.

It was something to thank the First Ones for, it seemed.

The Fullmoon and the Quartermoon hadn't been so lucky as to be pulled out of space, she hoped that they had found a safe place. It was a pretty wish, that out there, a thousand years ago, one of those ships had found a safe haven and called to its sisters in the night, had mourned the loss of the Halfmoon, and then set to work making a home. That a thousand years had passed in sweat and told and that the great, great, great, great…thirty times great grandchildren of those survivors were prolific, free and happy.

Because the alternative? That was unthinkable. Them dying in the cold dark of space, chased down like prey and obliterated, was horrifying. And then, that the lucky one, the Halfmoon, had been unlucky enough to fall victim to another Horde a thousand years later was something like a cosmic joke.

They were all victims here.

"Am I a bad person?" The woman's words were slurred as she lounged across the bar in an inebriated puddle.

The bartender opened his mouth to say something, then quickly shutting it again, lost for words. They were good at listening, sure. When she had run her own bar in a skull in the middle of teh desert, all the reprobates had told her their secrets and bragged about their conquests. Here, where people wanted to talk about things that mattered and get some sort of comfort? She was ill equipped. The horned woman opened her mouth to try again when she saw Lonnie walking towards them from the floor. She caught the bosses eye and tilted her head towards the drunk woman. Lonnie nodded and ushered her away.

Getting closer to Scorpia, Lonnie could smell how much she had drunk already, without needing to smell her breath. The night was still young, the scorpioni must had arrived when they opened and been drinking steadily for the last couple of hours. She reached out and rested a gentle hand on her friends back and moved it in

circles. It told her how drunk the big woman was that she didn't react to being touched.

Kyle's first set was just finishing, and as he said his thank yous to the crowd she caught his eye. He knew at once that she wanted him to get Rogelio. They had been together for almost thirsty years, the three of them knew each others needs without words. She watched him bounce down the stairs of the stage, giving Scorpia a concerned look as he ducked into the kitchen. Rogelio couldn't drop everything straight away, so Lonnie sat down beside the white haired woman whose head was now resting on the bar, cheek smooshed as she looked dopily at Lonnie.

"Hi, Scorpia. How you doing there?" It was a stupid question. She was clearly doing very poorly. They all were, but the princesses betrayal had touched Scorpia more than most. The flower princess may not have come on the raid, but she had obviously known. If they all felt hurt by Adora's actions, she couldn't imagine how Scorpia was feeling about Perfuma.

"Am I bad, Lonnie?" Her voice was shockingly clear for how bloodshot her eyes were. Perhaps that was more from tears than alcohol.

"Oh, Scorpia…You are the very best of us all. You're sweet and kind and you never let anything break your spirit. I only wish I could be as good as you." It was true. During the war, Lonnie hadn't always been kind to the big bug. She'd found her infantile and foolish, and may have had a tiny crush on her, and had lashed out with displaced anger. As a grown woman she appreciated the very parts of Scorpia that used to grate.

"Then why does nobody ever love me back?" There was a quaver in her voice now and those red eyes were getting glazed.

"We all love you." A new voice joined them, Kyle sitting on Scorpia's other side. He looked over her slumped back and mouthed to Lonnie that Rogelio would be a little while.

“Everybody loves me… I’m sooo loveable…” She was clearly entering the loopy part of drunk, sitting up sloppily and waving her giant claws around wildly. Both Lonnie and Kyle found themselves having to dodge a concussion. “But nobody is ever IN love with Scorpia. Nope. No love for me.”

“You know that’s not true…”. Kyle was cut off by a pincer against his lip and a spittle filled ‘shush’.

“Catra didn’t love me. I loved and loved and loved. There were smooches and no love. Then Perfuma…”Now she was sobbing and her words were hard to make out. “Pretty, perfect Perfuma. I love her so much and I thought she loved me. She’d look at me with these eyes and I thought, oh, this is what love is, you know?” She didn’t wait for a response, she was on a roll. “Then she was in my room, telling me she had to end it because she was needed in Plumeria. And she cried. And we were done… And she KNEW.” The end of ‘knew’ choked into sobs.

Scorpia's wounds were fresh. Days ago she had been a woman in love and now she had to deal with betrayal and deception. So Perfuma hadn’t broken into their home to raid their secrets. She had to have known. She could have warned them. Warned Scorpia. Instead she chose to lie. Kyle didn’t think he’d ever be able to forgive the woman for doing this to his friend.

Finally Rogelio was coming out of the kitchen and without preamble he scooped the giant woman into his arms as though she weighed no more than a child and headed straight for their apartment. He had no need to look back, he knew his spouses would follow. The kitchen could live without him tonight, he had more important things to do.

Darkness surrounded her as she curled into a ball in the space where the sleep chamber met the cradle it sat on. Her back was against the wall, her forehead against the cool metal of the pod. Her arms and tail were coiled around herself as she purred

forlornly. It was a mournful sound, reverberating around the room like a dirge. She didn't rock or move at all, just sat still, in the dark, among the dead.

It wasn't the first time that she had come here to mourn. In the wake of Tace's death, she had come here often. It had been important to her not to show too much of her heartbreak to her young daughter. Yarsha had been only a year old when they lost the third point in their family triangle, old enough to miss the black magicat but not old enough to understand that she was gone. Catra had spent sleepless nights rocking a very upset baby. She had missed her Zu's scent, the feel her warmth and the touch of her fur. To a baby magicat, sensation was everything and although she had remained a happy little thing, perhaps crying a little more in the day than usual but mostly fine, the nights had been another matter. The nights had been filled with tears and gut wrenching sobs that left the tiny body gasping and almost inconsolable.

Catra had spent those nights with her daughter wrapped in one of Tace's shirts, cradled in her arms, singing and rocking her. She hadn't slept much in those days. Not because of the inconsolable infant, but because of the dreams that plagued her. Every time she closed her eyes, she saw death. It was easier not to sleep at all.

It was when exhaustion had beaten her that she would retreat to the belly of the ship. Yarsha would be left in Lonnie's capable hands, and she would sneak off to be alone. Only ever in the day, she never left Yarsha alone at night, it was something she promised herself even before Tace's passing, and always able to be contacted. There was a strange kind of comfort in the cool darkness, surrounded by the dead. Tace may not be here, but others were.

It had taken some time for her even to consider the idea of finding her parents in the pod room, let alone look at who they were on the manifest. She had never had parents before. It wasn't a concept that she had ever thought about, even as a child

in the Horde. When other young cadets would dreamily talk about the possible parents that they may have had, who had selflessly given them up for the lie of a 'greater good', Catra had always known it was hog-wash. All adults brought was pain and loathing. If she had been born (Shadow Weaver enjoyed telling her that she was just a cosmic mistake, hatched from the air just to test her) then they had seen what a mistake she was and thrown her away.

Tace had been puzzled by her lack of curiosity, though she had not voiced it at the start. She had known Catra's parents well and hoped eventually the other girl would ask. She had assumed it was trauma keeping her from investigating, or simply how focused she was on resettling the magicats and freeing the Horde. In the weeks after the Horde dissolved and their community tripled, talk of finding families and looking for the survivors of raids from the young men, women and children around them had. It had finally been the thing to make the taller woman push.

She had found Catra napping in the bottom of a set of foundations that she had been digging. When they had discovered the prefabricated buildings that filled almost half of the giant ship, Catra had become almost possessed with the idea of making homes for everyone. Other pitched in, of course, but none with the zeal and tireless dedication that Catra showed. The building site had been deserted when Tace found her, covered in sand and curled in the warm sand, the others having gone on a well deserved break. She had jumped down into the deep pit, crouching beside the frustratingly perfect girl and running her hand through filthy hair. Catra had stirred and looked up at her with big, befuddled eyes. For a moment she had looked just like that toddler Tace used to take out to play and the question had just blurted out.

"Catra, why haven't you found your parents?" All of the other young magicat's had located their parents pods and done their own private mourning, most had also downloaded their family details from the computer. The youngest children would find their parents when they were ready.

Big, confused eyes blinked several times as though she were trying to focus on Tace's face. She had fallen asleep exhausted and been woken up unexpectedly and hit with a question, it was no wonder she was confused. Tace had smiled at her and stroked her ears gently until the other woman got her wits back and sat up, yawning and stretching expansively. It had caused her cropped shirt ride up even higher and showed off all the muscles in her arms, shoulder and abdomen. Tace's blush may be hidden by her dark fur but the frantic swishing of her tail gave her away and caused Catra to let out a throaty little laugh.

"Why haven't I what?" As she spoke her hands had reached out to gently tug Tace's tale.

"I just… I was looking at you all cute and I wondered why you hadn't found your parents." She kept her expression soft, knowing how easily spooked Catra could be.

"I guess it never occurred to me?" Catra's voice was neutral as she spoke in a way it seldom was and Tace tilted her head in bemusement. "I never wondered if I had parents or if somebody loved me, Tace. I spent all my life being told I was garbage and treated accordingly. The only dreams I had, were of a day left alone and taking over the world. It wasn't a healthy environment. I guess I still didn't really think about parents."

"It wasn't all your life, you know, until we left you were loved so, so much. And you are now." Tace leaned forward to press a tender kiss to her lips that was happily returned. "Would you like to find them?"

"I guess, I can't see what difference it will make to me, but if you come with me it can't hurt, right?"

Two days later they had been in the belly of the Halfmoon. Tace had become well versed in the computer system and was quickly able to find Catra's parents. Looking at the pictures of their smiling faces had made her chest tighten, they had been nice, kind people. She looked over at Catra who was staring at the

screen with no recognition on her face and Tace's sadness grew. She reached out and took one of the shorter girls hands and squeezed. Mismatched eyes turned to her.

"Do you recognise them at all?" Tace's voice was almost a whisper in this sacred place.

"No." She ruefully shook her head. "I don't know what I expected. I was really little and there's been a lot of water under this broken bridge." Tace hated it when Catra would call herself broken. It downplayed what she had been through and overcome, but now wasn't the time for an argument about self esteem.

"Would you like me to tell you about them before we find them?" The monitor just showed the facts, floor plan of where their pods were, names, ages and function in the crew.

"Yeah." It was an effort to admit to her desires for a past, but with Tace it was easier. She was starting to learn that she could be soft, vulnerable, and that it wouldn't be thrown in her face. She moved closer, dropping the black cat's hand and instead resting her head on her shoulder as they stood side by side.

That was how she had learnt about her parents, Tzali and Dhi. They had been mated for many years, both males dedicated to their work before they adopted a tiny kitten whose mother had died in birth and whose father was unknown, and then just as dedicated to her. The fact that they had picked her had made Catra's heart swell. Very few people had ever picked her before. It was overwhelming to know that she had been what they had wanted. Their smiling pictures had almost made her cry. Looking at them in their pods, mummified and forever frozen but at least side-by-side, had made her sob into Tace's shoulder.

Years later she would come here after the death of her own mate and allow herself to grieve with the parents that she didn't remember but felt connected to. Now, she grieved for another young woman; grieved for the possibility of reconnecting with somebody who she had once believed would choose her. She

castigated herself, she should have known better. Adora had never really chosen her. She was a convenient, attentive friend for the blond. But she had chosen to obey Shadow Weaver unquestioningly, had chosen the rebellion and now she had chosen to betray not just Catra but an entire group of people who had only treated her with kindness over the last six months. She had hoped, that fickle thing that still lived in her, that maybe she and Adora could grow close again. Not out of an impossible dream of some romantic entanglement (she had been lucky enough to have her great love, after all), but because the blond was so damn likeable.

Purrs stuttering to a stop, she sighed into the darkness as she heard a familiar gait making its way towards her. She didn't move from her spot, just tensed a little. The rhythmic, heavy footfalls and the drag of a tail got closer and closer until the person folded themself down in the space beside her, careful not to touch any of the pods. This was not a place for him. But he knew she shouldn't be left alone.

Rogelio didn't make a sound as he sat in the dark. Catra was grateful. She leaned into him as he began to make a deep humming sound, that she joined with her purr, both lamenting a girl they used to know who had abandoned them again.

Seated around the large table in a semi circle, the council were in clear view of the monitor, the incoming transmission signal beeping ominously. They had been waiting for this call for the three days since the Alliance had been cast out of Oasis. Catra sat in the far corner of the room, still in view of the monitor but pointedly showing that she was involved but not a leader of this place. What she was, however, was the chief of the magicats and as such was representing them.

It was Huntara who opened the connection. Queen Angella's face sprang to life on the screen. Her pale skin and light pink hair almost luminous. Her troubled expression was easy to read, she was as scared of a conflict with them as they were. It was

reassuring to see that she was not carrying the anger and animosity that they had seen in her daughters face each time she had entered their home.

“Queen Angella.” Huntara spoke first, taking charge with her strong, no nonsense tone. “I trust that you have been made aware of the terrible breach of our trust that has happened here?”

“Yes,” Angella’s tone was weary. “I wish to apologise unreservedly for the actions oof my people. I assure you that the incursion was in no way sanctioned by the Alliance. I have spoken at length with the perpetrators of the incident. I believe I have a full picture of events, though I would appreciate hearing your views.”

“That’s all very nice for your, but your people led an invasion into our territory, using an access device we provided in good faith. They breached a sacred area that we had told you we would consider them seeing in time. We have been doing everything we can to build a link with you, opening our home to your people and treating them like our own. What possible provocation could there be to justify these actions?”

Angella sat straighter in her seat, embarrassment and shame on her face. “I agree that their actions were rash. Like you, I do not wish to start another conflict. I am sick of war.” There was a sound of agreement from the Oasis delegation.

“We had no intention of starting a war, Queen Angella. All we have been doing for a decade is building a place where we can all live in peace. But we cannot just stand by while hostile forces come to destroy us.”

“No. You cannot. I would not expect you to. Princess Glimmer is under arrest for her actions. I offer safe passage to Brightmoon for a delegation of Oasis representatives. We will work on a binding peace treaty.” Angella’s voice held the authority of decades of rule, and they believed that the guaranteed safety would be just that. There was no reason to disbelieve it.

“We will consider your proposition and give your our answer.” Huntara did not wait for a further response and ended the transmission, sitting back and looking around the table at her peers. In turn they all turned to meet Catra’s glowering face. She stood and joined them at the table, perching on its surface with one hip.

“So, Wildcat, looks like your plan is what we’re going with.” Scorpia’s tone was sad and contrite.

“They want a delegation of the leaders of this place, I told you that they would. I fought these people for years, I know how they think. I may not be on the council but I am chief of my people.” She worried her lip with a snap tooth. “They’ll want me there anyway, and Hordak. Queen Angella may say she is on our side, but you know she wants to believe her daughter. The only way to clear this up without a fight is if we give them what we know they want. They want to talk, they want to interrogate me and Hordak and they want somebody to blame for all this that isn’t them.”

“How could they possibly turn this around on us?” Double Trouble was a gifted manipulator, but even he found that a stretch.

“If we aren’t there they will. Trust me. We all need saving from the ‘good’ people.” They would let Queen Angella know their answer the following day.

It was time to get their delegation together.

Chapter End Notes

Off to Brightmoon we go?

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

Planning for peace.

Chapter Notes

Sorry it's a bit late this week - had the Covid vaccine and it made me feel like I'd been mauled by a bear.

This is a transitional chapter so a little shorter than usual.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Walking between the two towering guards, Glimmer felt tiny. Like the little girl who used to sneak between the guards and into her mother's office, clambering up into her lap as she read through papers in the wake of her father's disappearance. It brought a pang to her heart as she considered how she had become more and more distant from her mother. It had started during the war when she felt stifled and controlled and only gotten worse as time passed and she had no real role after the end of the conflict. She knew it was stupid to resent her father's return to their lives but that voice inside her head, the saboteur, constantly whispered that her mother would need her more if he wasn't there.

Heels clicking on the floor as they walked, the much shorter woman having to hustle to keep up with the tall, taciturn guards, Glimmer felt ashamed to think of her father as someone standing in her way. As a little girl, she had wanted her daddy back so desperately that for a while she would talk to him, imagining that he was out in the world and could hear her. She would make the staff set a place for him at the table and talk to him, she had been too young then to understand the tears that would fill her mothers eyes. As she had grown older, the memory of her father had faded until he was more an idea than an individual. She had been so young when he vanished, that she had forgotten so much about him. She had been the focus of all her mothers attention for so

long that it had started to feel like a prison, but when it was gone it had left her feeling adrift.

The war had ended, her father had come home and what was left for her? She'd woken that morning feeling strangely clear. She had looked around the wreckage of her room and hated herself just a little. Leaping from the bed, she'd felt compelled to put everything back into its place. She had straightened the crumpled edges of crushed photographs, pinning them back up with the reverence that she once had and not the contempt with which she had torn them down. Her friends smiling faces looked down at her and she had to turn away. She swept up shards of glass and pottery from trinkets broken beyond repair and deposited them into her trashcan with a heavy heart, before placing the scant survivors back in their places.

Standing where mere days ago she had sat among the wreckage of her rage, Glimmer saw a room that was a familiar comfort. Bow's things were beside the bed, his clothes in the wardrobe, a natural metamorphoses of a space that had felt shred with him since they were children when he was would sneak in to play and for giggly sleepovers. Sleepovers that had evolved to include Adora, the lost Horde puppy who had become like a sister to both of them over the years. This room had been a sanctuary and a place where the three of them could relax and ben young, even when things were at their worst. Purloined cakes, silly games and quiet confessions had all happened here. Now it echoed with silence.

Bow had not been allowed to sleep here for the last two weeks of her house arrest and Adora had yet to even return from wherever she had run off to from the desert. The anger that she had felt at the blond's flight seemed distant and hazy now. Of course Adora had gone to be alone. Things had not gone to plan, in fact after some time alone even Glimmer could admit to herself that what they had done had been ill judged. Very ill judged.

Where had that anger gone? When she had sat with Shadow Weaver on her bed, passing her flask back and forth, she had felt

the fire running through her blood as hot as when she had led them all down to that ship. Standing in the room of corpses all she had seen was red. No empathy, or sorrow. They had not been the bodies of the dead to her, just a distraction. Blood had thundered in her ears, almost louder than the roar that had ripped out the magicat when she found them there. Seeing Catra, all she had wanted was to destroy her and the magic that she had thrown at her, if not for whatever had quashed their magic in that room, would have been enough to kill her. There hadn't even been any room inside her for panic when those wickedly clawed hands had tightened around her throat and applied so much pressure that she could barely see.

That rage seemed far away. Hazy and shameful, the reality of what she had seen and done starting to eat away at the edges of her consciousness. Maybe it was all the time alone in her room. After that first visit, she hadn't even seen Shadow Weaver. Perhaps her father had strengthened the spell that he had place on the room or the old witch had just decided she wasn't worth the effort. Bow's brief visits to deliver her meals just made her miss him more.

By the time that the doors to her parents suit came into view, Glimmer felt exhausted. She hadn't seen either of her parents since her mother had put her under house arrest. Now with a clearer head she knew that she wouldn't be able to stand her parents shame. The two guards moved to either side of the door, flanking it and standing to attention with their staffs in their hands, one leaned over and opened the door, Glimmer took a deep breath and walked in.

Her parents rooms were like a little house inside the castle. The room that she walked into was a cozy living room with plush sofas that she had fallen asleep on many times over the years. Micah was sitting on one of the sofas with a book open on his lap, one arm reaching across the back of the leather. Her mom was nowhere to be seen. Micah looked up from the heavy tome, and beckoned his daughter over.

“Come and take a seat, Glimmer. Angie’s working right now but she should be back soon. I thought we could spend a little while together before she gets back.” He smiled at her, it was wide and reached his eyes though she could see the hint of sadness there.

“I’d like that, dad.” She sat down, sinking into the cushions and tucking her feet under her.

Micah watched her, his expression growing fond as he thought of the toddler that used to curl up beside him in that same position as she listened to him tell her stories. They had so few memories together, he cherished every one, from holding her minutes after she was born to teaching her to put on her socks. In a lot of ways he was luckier than her, her memories were hazy as a child’s are, while each moment was engraved on her mind.

“You look sad, sweetheart.”

“I guess I am. I’ve had a lot of time to think about things, and I’ve come to regret what I did.” It was true and she didn’t know why she felt so surprised by that.

“Your mother will be pleased to hear that.” He looked at her appraisingly. “It’s going to take more than words to make things right, though, Glimmer.” His qualms about his daughter were something that he could not shake, no matter what she said. There was something about her that made his senses squirm.

“I know.” The words came out on a sigh, just as the doors opened for a second time and Angella glided in.

“Glimmer. I hope that you haven’t waited long.” Her words and posture were stiff, as though she were talking to a stranger and Glimmer wished she was sat in a more dignified way, especially when her mother did not move to sit.

“We’re just been having a little chat, Angie.” Micah’s voice broke the tension a little, though his wife took a seat in an armchair opposite rather than joining them on the coach.

“Glimmer, I have spoken with the council of Oasis and they will be sending a delegation here in two weeks. It is imperative that we are able to build a treaty with them to ensure the peace that we have enjoyed for a decade continues. They have agreed to bring Hordak here to answer our questions.” It all seemed very reasonable, Glimmer waited for more. “They have requested that you been tried for your actions in their sacred place. You and the other princesses will need to explain yourselves to them and hope that they are willing to forgive you.”

Glimmer’s blood ran cold at the word ‘trial’. Her fists clenched in her lap and she had to purse her lips together to not say something that she knew she would regret. Her mind was whirling, the anger that she thought was gone was suddenly bubbling up from a deep well, how dare they demand that she lose her liberty for trying to protect the all? Those were words that would get her however with her mother and instead she nodded mutely to show she understood.

Angella’s tone softened a little, “Glimmer, I know you have been spending this time thinking about what happened. I don’t want to keep you on house arrest but it won’t be my disunion to make. You need to think about what you are going to say to the delegation, especially the magicat’s. To them what you did may be unforgivable and it is a reality you may have to face.”

A life in a cell made no sense to Glimmer, but no matter. She had been raised in the castle and prepared to be a monarch once day. She understood diplomacy, even though she had little use for it most of the time. She could find a way out of this mess, and when she did she would get the answers she knew were lurking in Oasis. Eventually they would show who they really were and she would be waiting, ready to protect her family.

Bundle of books clutched to her chest, Adora arrived back at Brightmoon weeks after bolting from the desert, once again astride Swift Wind who was back to his usual bombastic self. On the brief journey from the library to the castle she had fought the

desire to turn back. She had to face Queen Angella, her mistakes could have started a war and the older woman deserved an apology and some answers. Bow's fathers had been so kind to her over the two weeks that she had been there, but even that had just made her feel worse.

She slid off of the alicorn's back, resting her head against his neck and patting him gently in thanks. "I'm going to the stables to see my horse brothers and sisters, if you need me Adora I'll be close by." He nudged her with his head before he cantered off toward the stables. Not for the first time, Adora was glad that he was the animal companion that she got to have, even if a dragon would have been cool.

Moving quickly so as not to lose her nerve, Adora rushed to Queen Angella's study, making the attendant guards straighten in surprise. Neither of them tried to stop her though, as she knocked tentatively on the big doors. A feint 'come in' drifted to her from within and she took a deep breath and clutched the books more tightly before walking in.

Angella looked up from the papers spread across the desk in front of her, eyes widening a little as she took in who was standing in front of her. For a moment, softness flittered across her face before it hardened into a look that Adora had seen a lot while growing up, though never directed at her. Disappointment.

"I am glad you have decided to return Adora. I know that you were a part of Glimmer's plan and we need to talk about this." Angella gestured for her to take the seat opposite her at the desk.

"Queen Angella, I am so sorry for what I did. When I saw Hordak I just…I still don't really know what I was thinking. Of course we should have gone straight to the council or spoken to you through the tracker. I suppose the part of me that was raised in the Horde just panicked when I saw him after so long and then it was like we were back in the war, Glimmer was calling the shots and I just went along with it." The words rushed out in a garbled mess.

“I don’t think any of us can ever understand what you went through as a child, Adora. The others may have grown up during the war, but you were Brough up for the war. I’ve seen the affect being close to Shadow Weaver has on you, and I can only imagine that seeing Hordak again was shocking. I understand the choice you made not to go to the council, though I may not agree with it. I can see that seeing him would have made you feel betrayed, I feel betrayed by it. What I don’t understand is not coming to me.” She rose from behind the table and Adora flinched, causing the angelic being to frown at the reaction.

Sometimes it was so easy to forget where Adora had come from. Her kindness and sweet disposition hard to reconcile with the childhood full of training and war and bereft of anything like adult care or genuine affection. Maybe she was at fault, perhaps as her queen and her almost parent she should have pushed her more to talk about what had happened in her childhood, found her the help that she needed. Watching her flinch away as though Angella was going to strike her made her feel sick inside.

Angella tentatively moved closer and rested a soft hand on Adora’s tense shoulder, softly squeezing. “I thought we had a relationship where you knew you could bring things to me and I would listen?”

Adora looked up at the sadly serene face. “We do. Queen Angella, please know it wasn’t because I don’t trust you. Seeing Hordak, I think Mermista and I were just thrown back into the war and it made sense to follow Glimmer. It was what we’d always done. Her plan made sense at the time…though I know it was bad and dangerous.” Her voice choked as she thought about that room. “When we saw all those bodies, there were thousands of them…it stretched further than we could see…I knew we had ruined everything.” The leather-bound cover of the book in her grasp squeaked as she held it tighter and tighter.

“Maybe very badly damaged but not not ruined, not yet. A delegation of people from Oasis are coming here to work on a peace treaty. It is not a given, but I can see the remorse in your

eyes, and hear it in your voice. If I can, then they will." Angella could see a sheen forming in the blond's eyes.

"I know you're right, Queen Angella." Adora held out the book which Angella took with a furrowed brow. "While I was at the library, Bow's fathers showed me these. There is some information about when the Halfmoon crashed. It's not much but it might help us give some context that will help us make peace. There are some notes inside from other texts too…" A tear spilled down her cheek as her voice trailed off. "There were so few magicats left. We saw bodies stretching for miles and then maybe a few hundred were waiting for us…" She wasn't sure what she wanted to say so she stopped.

"It's a tragedy. Let's hope that it is the last." She put the book on the desk and then moved to open the door. "Go and settle back into your room, Adora. We have two weeks to get ready to welcome our guests."

Adora hurried back to her room and closed the door behind her. She slid down the door and sat on the floor. Her head tilted back and her eyes were closed as she inhaled the comforting smell of home. Angella had been far kinder than she deserved, especially after having put her own daughter under house arrest. Why Adora wasn't suffering the same fate, she wasn't really sure, but she was thankful.

Getting to her feet, Adora made her way to her desk. She wasn't sure what she was looking for when she started to shuffle through the nicknacks. Something brightly coloured caught her eye, sitting on top of a pile of pictures waiting to be added to her cork board. She picked up the picture, bright colours jumping out and making her smile. The lines were crude, squiggly and rushed in rainbow hews. A child imagination where a tree could be purple and the sky was pink. When Yarsha had first pressed the picture into her hand, pressing a sloppy child's kiss to her cheek, Adora hadn't been sure what it was. The kitten had patiently explained that this was a tree, and that was a cloud and this was Yarsha (a little dark blob with pointy parts) and this was Adora (a pink and yellow

blob) and that was Ra (a far oranger blob than Catra ever was) and over there a red swirl that she had worked out was Scorpia. Adora had been touched at the time, now as she ran her fingers over the slightly bumpy crayon lines she just felt sad.

She took the sheet of paper and sat on the edge of her bed, just staring down at it. She didn't have any pictures of the kitten or Catra, and she didn't know if she would see them again but at least for a little while she had meant something to them.

Three people in a room shouldn't feel so claustrophobic. Especially not these three people in a room that they had spent countless hours in. Yet, here they were, standing in an awkward triangle, eyes darting between each other. Nobody threw themself onto the bed, or perched on the edge of the desk, they just stood stiffly, an air of wariness between them that hadn't even existed when Adora had been fresh from deserting the Horde.

None of them knew how to break the statement. The tension between them was far to thick for a simple quip, a moment of levity that would usually be shared. A joke, a laugh and everything would be better. They were too old for that, the situation too dire. Each of them knew it but what the solution was they did not know.

Bow looked between the two women in the room. They had both decided to leave him behind. He was sure that for Adora it was simply an act of thoughtlessness - caught up in a mission, a chance to fight for a cause and make the others proud again. He had watched her, taken note ever since they had first fund the desert city, of how Adora had been trying to move forward, finally, but how easy it was to draw her back into old patterns. It was his wife who had made the conscious choice to shut him out. While she had been confined to their shared room, he had spent the intervening weeks considering her actions .

Glimmer had left him behind. She had walked away to commit an act that she knew he would be opposed to so that she would face no resistance. As whipped up as they had all been on their way to the desert, Bow knew that he would have been the first o cool and wonder at their actions. Glimmer knew it to. It chilled him to think of her being so calculated with their relationship. The fact that they knew each there as well as they knew themselves used against him. It made him question how well they knew each other anymore.

Alone, in one of the guest rooms, he had had time to think about Glimmer without Glimmer being around to cloud his thoughts. If distance made the heart grow fonder, it also made it grow more analytical. He finally admitted to himself that she had been pulling away from him and everyone around them for years now. Throwing herself into whatever came along. Spending long hours away from him. Even at night, he would wake up and she would be gone. He knew she thought that he didn't know, but how could he not? Somebody else might have followed her or demanded answers, but Bow had hoped that she would eventually come to him to talk out whatever was othering her. Instead they were left here, now, a chasm between them as they stood only feet apart.

For her part, Adora was nervously toying with the bracer wrapped around her left wrist. Since her friends married, and she had been so happy when they had taken those steps first into romance and then into marriage, she had felt uncomfortable in their space. This wasn't where they had sleepovers anymore, especially after she had been forced to put Glimmer in her place about bursting in. The Best Friend Squad seemed like something far too childish for this moment, and in a lot of ways she felt like a stranger again, except this time she felt like a stranger to herself as well as to these two people who used to know her so well.

How did you start a conversation with somebody when you blamed her as much as yourself for destroying something you hadn't even built yet? Pale blue eyes drifted around the room, not settling on her companions but noticing the abused appearance of the pictures on the chalk board and the strangely empty nature of

the desk and shelves. Her focus was pulled towards the smaller woman when she lifted her hand and motioned awkwardly to the bed and the chair.

"I think we should all take a seat." The pink haired woman's voice was low and lacked any of the bossy authoritarian tone that she used so often these days.

Adora took a seat on the chair, allowing Glimmer and Bow to sit together on the bed. It was uncomfortable to see them sitting so far apart. Glimmer looked down at her hands, body turned towards Bow. She worried at a piece of her skirt, gathering her thoughts while the other two waited. Finally, it was Bow who spoke.

"Why Glimmer?" His voice was beseeching, really wanting to understand what had gone wrong.

"I know I made a mistake. It was wrong to go behind my mother's back and take matters into my own hand. And I know that I took advantage of everyone's trust in me," She reached across the mattress and cautiously hooked her pinky with Bow's, he didn't pull away but neither did he move closer. "So although I still think that there is more going on in Oasis, I can admit that I made a mistake."

It was more than they had expected from her. She sounded a lot more like the idealistic girl they remembered than the bitter woman looking to make a point. It was less reassuring that she still seemed suspicious of the desert dwellers. Small steps, but steps that seemed like they were going in the right direction at least.

"I'm glad to hear you say that, Glim." Bow took her hand fully in his and gave it a squeeze. He hoped that she would see what the rest of them did by the time that the delegates left.

"I spoke to mom and she said that whether I go on trial will be left in the hands of the Oasis envoys. I will be permitted to attend

the meetings and speak with them. I am still on house arrest but you're allowed to stay with me," she looked at Bow though her eyelashes, suddenly shy. "If you want to."

Bow lifted her hand to his lips and pressed a kiss to her knuckles, if she was willing to try to change then he could be there to help her. "Of course I would love to come back to our room. I hate sleeping without you." And if he was going to keep a close eye on her, then it was a win-win situation for him.

"I should take some responsibility too, Glimmer. If I hadn't come barrelling in, telling you about Hordak without finding out any information you would never had had that plan. None of us had to go along with you either. Yes, it was your plan, and maybe we all got caught up in your plan, but we could have said no. We all have a lot answer for." Adora's conversation with the king and queen still rang in her head.

Glimmer reached across the distance between the bed and the chair and rested her hand on the blonds knee. For a moment the three of them were connected, sharing a feeling. They were all willing to work for something that would help them all.

In the corner, where the light couldn't reach, shadows gathered.

None of them had wanted to return to Brightmoon. But return they had had under the orders of Queen Angella. They may not be a fighting force anymore, princesses and queens of their own realms, but when the older woman pulled rank they still came at her call. Much as they had with Glimmer. Old habits died hard, but die they needed to.

Frosta felt ashamed that she had allowed her judgement to be clouded in the haze and furry of Glimmer's ire. She had been a queen in all but name for most of her life, and yet when she was with the others that lonely eleven year old girl came stampeding back to the fore. Eager to please and impress the cool kids,

Glimmer in particular. In her room in Brightmoon, each of the Princesses had one set aside for their use, she sat on the bed and tried to stop her hands from trembling.

She was a queen. She had every right to resist Angella's call to return for what was sure to be a disaster, but here she was. Over the last month she had sat in her ice palace, on her carved throne, and brooded over what had happened. Away from Glimmer's infectious zeal and Mermista and Adora's panic, it was easy to see that they should never have gone to Oasis. Logical showed that they would have been better off going to talk to all of the involved parties and then approaching the Council with their fears. Instead fear had prevailed.

Though fear of what she wasn't sure.

Were they really afraid of the little city in the desert, impressive as it may be? They had taken and destroyed all of the Fright Zone's weapons when it had been deserted. They audited it and found that other than a few skiffs and rations, the full inventory of the place was there, weapons, vehicles, uniforms. Why leave all of that behind it Hordak was simply planning to move his military machine into the desert? And, what for? The Fright Zone was primed and designed for war, Oasis just wasn't. But that was hindsight talking. Of course there was no hidden threat in that ship.

Just the dead… her hands trembled more, as they had ever since she had stood in that room, when she thought of what she had seen before the fury of the magicats had found them. The desiccated bodies in row after row, still sleeping a sleep that they had not thought would be forever filled her nightmares. When the grey furred cat had smacked Adora before breaking down, Catra's words had echoed around in her head. They were the parents and families of all the young magicats that surrounded them. All of them orphans. All of them just like her. She couldn't even imagine how she would react if somebody were to go into her parents tomb.

Sighing, she stood and made her way back to her suitcase, needed to do something to distract herself. As she pulled out her clothes sounds from the room next door caught her attention. The muffled sounds of high pitched laughter and running feet almost made her smile. Mermista and her family had arrived at the same time that she had. They had exchanged tight smiles and made a sedate trip to their neighbouring rooms. At least Sturgio was enjoying his visit.

Mermista watched her soon zoom around the large suit with a soft expression on her face. Sea Hawk was hiding behind a thick curtain, his feet sticking out from underneath but the little boy didn't seem to notice. The child was searching for his father mostly by running back and forth around the room and jumping on and off of the two beds. He would tire of it soon and her husband would leap out and scoop the giggling lad off of his feet and tickle him. It was something they always did when they got here. It was routine and familiar and light. It was something that she could rely on at a time when very little felt as it should.

Since going back to Selineas, things had been strained between she and Sea Hawk as they never had been before. Even when they first met and she had tried to push the overly enthusiastic man away, sometimes almost cruel, he had never looked at her as he had been. His usually merry eyes were clouded, and his words had been measured. His quietness was more almost unbearable. It said more than any words, about how he felt about what they had done.

There hadn't even been a shanty in weeks.

Sea Hawk loved going to Oasis. He and Sturgio had made lots of friends and settled into the place like they belonged. Mermista could admit that she loved it too. She had been making a difference and liked spending time with Lonnie and Catra, the three of them sharing a laughter and parenting woes while they watched Kyle and Sea Hawk sing up on stage while Rogelio hovered and the children all played together. It had been easy to

relax there, she wasn't in charge, just helping put the place together again.

Watching people who had been raised to fight being so soft with their own children, she still didn't know how she could have led the princesses there to take them down. Catra had said it on their first encounter, children weren't pawns and yet Mermista had helped put them all in danger. She couldn't shake the sadness that she felt when she thought other part in it all.

She wished she had listened to Perfuma. Or they hadn't seen Hordak… no that was no excuse, they should have gone to the leaders of the city and asked for answers. Adora would have if she hadn't been backing her up. Mermista wasn't sure how she was going to face the delegates.

She was brought back to the present by Sea Hawk swooping out and pretending to scare their son. They laughed and wrestled as he threw the little boy playfully onto the larger bed and watched him bounce. He caught his wife's eye and they shared an uncertain smile as she joined the playful tussling on the bed. She leaned down and kissed her son's head, before turning to place a kiss on her husbands cheek. He reached up, eyes twinkling just a bit and took her hand, giving it a reassuring squeeze.

Down the hall, past Netossa and Spinerella's rooms which were still waiting for the married princesses and their brood to arrive, Perfuma sat on the balcony that looked out over the garden. Vines and branches reached out towards her and seemed to wilt as they got closer. Her sadness leached into their cells and made them heavy with despair. Perfuma hadn't had any contact with the rest of the Alliance since she walked away from the gardens. If not for Queen Angella's call she would have stayed away.

She may not have helped to attack the Halfmoon but she knew that everything that she had loved in Oasis was gone now. Everyday she wished that she had been brave enough to tell Scorpia the truth, rather than breaking up with her and staying quiet. She had felt torn, her loyalty to the rest of the Alliance, no

matter how much she disagreed with their actions, at war with her feelings for Scorpia and the others who had become part of her life over the last six months. Rather than making a choice, she had taken the cowards way out and picked neither. Now she couldn't even think about the other princesses without feeling an anger inside that no amount of meditation could quench.

As for Scorpia, just thinking about the woman she adored made tears well in her eyes. There was no way that they could ever be together again now. How could she ever expect to be forgiven for betraying everything that they had shared together? Scorpia had opened her heart and her home to Perfuma and she left her crying in her room under a false pretence before people tried to tear their world apart.

When she had arrived back in Plumeria, the plants had wilted all around her and the Heart Blossom had dimmed. Her hands had itched to call the colony and let them know what was heading their way but she hadn't. Instead she had hidden away in a yurt and meditated for days. It had done nothing to lift the pall that covered her and she knew that whatever Glimmer was leading the others to do had been done. There was no going back now.

Now, a month later, waiting for a delegation from Oasis, Perfuma wasn't sure if she wanted Scorpia to be with them or not. She just wanted to look into those eyes once more and say she was sorry. There was a meeting in a few hours where Queen Angella was going to tell them all what she expected from them. They were going to need to build some strong bridges and Perfuma didn't really know how the magicats would ever trust them again.

Perfuma reached out a hand and a vice wrapped around it, a small flower blooming at her fingertips. The bud grew, blossomed and withered in an instant, the petals falling one by one to the floor of the balcony, like pale tears.

Chapter End Notes

Next time... Oasis comes to Brightmoon...what could go wrong?

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

Packing up for Brightmoon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Standing uncomfortably in front of Phibin, Catra tried not to bristle as he ran his hands across her shoulders. Her traitorous tail gave away her discomfort as it puffed up like an angry brush and batted against the portly male who moved it away with a chuckle. Ignoring the low rumble coming out of his client, certain that she wasn't aware that she was growling, he brought his tape measure across the breath of her shoulders. It was lucky that they had so many clothes to choose from, preserved in the sealed rooms of the ship, alterations were far faster than making new garments. More fidgeting made him jab her lightly in the shoulder with a claw.

"Stand still! You're worse than a child, Chief. In fact," he raised his head and looked over her shoulder towards the kitten who was sitting in the corner, humming softly and dressing and undressing her doll. "Yarsha, come over here, will you?"

Hearing her name, the little one bounced to her feet, skipping over and throwing herself into the tailor's legs. She tilted her head back to look up at him with her large, luminous yellow eyes and blinked prettily, waiting to hear why she had been called over. Dropping one end of the tape, the large man rested a white furred hand on her little head and, for a moment, enjoyed the aesthetic of light and dark between them as she chirped quizzically.

"Yarsha, you need to tell your Ra how to behave. She fidgets, she squirms, she grumbles. That's not very helpful is it?" The head under his hand shook comically, those eyes still locked onto him. "So, can you go and explain to her how to be fitted?" She was

always a good girl when he made her dresses and growing so fast that she made frequent visits to his shop to be measured.

"Ok Phibs!" Beaming at being given an important job, she twirled around to be in front of her parent, eyes now fixed on her. Catra looked down at her daughter, a fond smile on her face, and waited. "Ra. You has to stand still!" Stubby fingers waved around as she spoke and the taller cat tried not to laugh. "Phibs might stick you if you move." Her brow was furrowed and she seemed genuinely concerned.

Catra knelt down in front of the kitten and ran a hand over one of her pointy ears. The earnestness in that face was adorable and it made Catra realise that she may not have had any parents, but she seemed to be doing a good job being one. Tenderly she took her daughters hands.

"I'm sorry, Yar-Yar. I'll behave for Phibin, I promise." The beaming, toothy grin that she got in return was infectious. She sent the child back to her toys and straightened up. "Be quicker." She threw over her shoulder in a whisper that she knew the light furred cat would catch.

"You're so impatient!" Phibin tutted as he once again stretched out the tape. He took the measure of her shoulders, arms and waist before kneeling down to measure her inside leg. It was all she could do not to kick him as she felt him touch her. The growl started again, this time with more menace. Blue eyes looked up apologetically as the big man got back to his feet.

"There, all done. No need to get tetchy. Let me go and see if I have anything that is close to these dimensions that's appropriate." He looked her up and down again and made some more mental notes. "Why don't you go and get something to drink and when you two come back I can get you to try some on."

"Can't you just do it and give them to me?" Never had clothes been such a chore. She knew she and all the magicats that were

heading to Brightmoon were going to need to look a particular way, show their culture, but this seemed very time consuming.

"No. If I do that you will look ridiculous and what impression of you as chief does that give?" Catra still wasn't completely sold on the fact that she should be heading to Brightmoon as chief at all, but she had been overruled on all counts. Things had been so much easier when she had wanted to be a young despot. A sigh came out of the chestnut magicat and Phibin knew that the fight had gone out of her. "So come back in twenty and I will have a few garments pinned for you to try on." He shoed the two females out and made his way to his workbench.

Suddenly finding herself on the street outside the fashionista's store, holding Yarsha's hand, Catra had to chuckle. This notion that she was Chief Magicat was laughable. She knew how to lead and had developed a roar and that seemed to be good enough. The notion that any of them followed her orders was just stupid, Phibin treated her like an errant child, Kesh didn't listen to a thing she said, Varga thought she was rash and the rest were either a little wary of her or simply overly fond of the girl that Tace had chosen. The Alliance were going to have questions, the same ones she had asked over the years, and it would be her entourage's job to answer them without making her seem like she had been lying about not being a princess. She wasn't, she wasn't in charge of this place, she just filled a function that the almost dead society needed to feel secure.

"Come on Fuzzy-Butt, let's go get a snack." Yarsha looked up at her with a smile and hand in hand they made their way to one of the small cafe's that lined the centre of Capital.

One snack, and a very sticky kitten, later they were heading back to the tailor's. They let themselves in and Catra took her daughter passed Phibin and into the back room where she washed her clean much to the squirming kittens displeasure. With a now frowning Yarsha in tow, Catra returned to the main room and couldn't help but nod approvingly at the selection of clothes spread out around the male. Yarsha scampered over to him and

decided that she liked a green outfit the most, before running back to her dollies to tell them all about her snack.

"Strip off your outer wear and put this on." There was no preamble in Phibin's words as he thrust the clothes Yarsha had picked into her hands. She sighed and did and she was bid. She had never learned any kind of shame around nakedness, growing up as she had, so soon was standing in just her underwear in full view of the shop window. If some people walking past did a double take as they saw her, she wasn't aware as she pulled on the tunic over her head and drew on the knee length pants.

Stepping up onto the small dais in the centre of the room, Yarsha's hum background music, she let her mind roam, trying to ignore the tugging and prodding going on around her as Phibin cinched in the fabric and put pins into it to hold it in place. These clothes were what her people would wear to more official business. Apparently they had packed enough of their traditional apparel to cloth all of the magicats going to Brightmoon. Tace had worn something in the style when they had declared themselves mated in front of the others, Catra hadn't then, still feeling like it was a heritage that didn't quite belong to her.

She had to admit, standing in them and being made into a furry pin-cushion, the clothes were surprisingly comfortable. They didn't tug on her fur and they would give a range of movement, leaving most of her arms bared from the elbow, the cinched waist felt familiar though she wasn't sure about the short skirt of fabric that hung over the top of the pants. Those were interesting, loose but tight just below the knee, again clearly designed with magicat movement in mind. Though she would not don them today, the knew from the ceremony she shared with Tace that fine leather straps would wind around her feet, like she had used bandages for as a child, and also up her arms from her wrist to her elbow. If nothing else she would look fantastical with her hair and her height.

"Once this one is right I can use it as a template for the others so you only have to stand here for a little while. Are you sure you

don’t want one of the dresses, you know, like Tace wore?” Phibin was one of the few people who would bring up Tace with her, the others walking on egg-shells about it almost two years later. Phibin had little time for artifice, it was why he and Double Trouble had been drawn to each other. Catra appreciated his frankness.

“Thats a fat no. No dresses for me. Could you make a little one like Tace’s for Yarsha though?” It was a bitter sweet idea to see her baby wear something like her mate.

“I can do that.” Phibin smiled as he moved to secure the pants. “Do you want a specific colour scheme?”

Looking down at the outfit she was wearing , she decided the green wasn’t so bad. She looked over at the pile of tunics on the table and made a tactical decision. “Any colours but red and black.” Best to keep Force Captain Catra as far out of mind as possible.

Folding her clothes carefully, Lonnie placed them in the holdall that had been given to her for this expedition. She had never needed to pack her things and go on a trip before. When they were all younger and deserting the Fright Zone on mass, they had simply had the clothes on their backs and whatever they could carry in their hands and boxes. It had been inelegant and now all of that was gone. Lonnie wasn’t a sentimental person, the only part of growing up she wanted to remember were living their lives beside her. The rest was best forgotten and the old uniforms and equipment had been trashed long ago. Kyle had wanted to keep some, but Rogelio had been vehemently against it and it wasn’t something that the smaller man felt strongly enough to fight for.

The motion of folding was almost hypnotic, shirts, pants, underclothes. She was so distracted that she missed the sound of the door opening but the thunder of three sets of feet made her head snap to the entrance just as her three energetic children

hurried in. What kept her attention was how suddenly still and serious they all became as they stood just inside the room. Fernando looked small and hunched, his long arms crossed over his chest as he looked down at the floor where he worried with a clawed toe. Ellia was worrying at her lower lip as she half glared half pouted at her mother while Digby's tail and ears were twitching a mile a minute as he stood still. It was oddly disturbing to see them all acting so uncharacteristically.

"Hi guys…". Her words were drawn out as she placed the shirt in her hands down on the bed and walked over to stand in front of the children, the over sized bed no longer blocking her from them.

What she expected she wasn't sure, it certainly wasn't all three of them to throw themselves at her at once, making her stumble until they all landed in a heap on the wide bed. She could feel Digby's desperate purr rumbling through the three of them, as Fernando's long arms enveloped her and his sister. Ellia had her head buried under Lonnie's chin and Digby was snuggled to her other side, furiously scent marking her cheek. It wasn't often that the kids went into a dog-pile, usually the two men of the house were a part of it, but Lonnie wasn't complaining. She loved her brood like she had never loved anything.

When she had first realised that what she felt for Rogelio and Kyle was more than friendship, she had been confused by the emotions but had leapt onto them with both feet. Their relationship had been young when they had moved to Oasis, but with the freedom they were handed it had grown quickly and they were inseparable. She loved them with a fire, two men so different that together the three of them made something special.

That love though, was very different from the way she loved these children that had been hers for almost five years now. She would do anything for them, live for them or die for them. Every time she held them, or told them a story she felt like she was regaining something she never knew that she had lost. Even when they argued with her about doing their homework.

“What’s all this?” Her voice was low as she spoke.

“We want to go with you.” It was Ellia who spoke up from somewhere below her chin.

“Sweetheart, we’ve talked about this.” Lonnie managed to wriggle her hand from between her body and Fernando’s and cup the back of the little girl’s head.

“Yarsha gets to go.” Fernando’s deep voice was sullen in her ear.

“Yeah, she’s just a baby!” Digby sounded like there were tears in his voice.

Lonnie wriggled until she was sitting and then scooted up to the head of the bed, drawing the children up with her until they were all sitting together and she could look at their faces. A lesser woman would have broken and agreed to anything as she looked at their sadness, but she was not a lesser woman.

“Look, I would love nothing more than to have you three with me always. You know that. But not this time. This isn’t a fun trip. Catra is bringing Yarsha with us to keep her safe and to show that we are moving forward. Hordak is bringing Stanley for the same reason. You three have both your dads to look after for me. Who knows what trouble they’ll get themselves into if no one is here to watch them?” There was a chuckle in her voice and a lump in her throat.

“Dad and Papa can look after themselves.” It was rare that Ellia was the one to be surely, the dark haired human child was usually quite shy and happy to follow her brothers’ lead.

“Who can do what?” Kyle’s voice came through the door, followed by the two men in question. Rogelio rumbled and all the children sagged in relief as the men climbed onto the bed, becoming bookends to the four of them.

“The kids think you two can look after yourselves.” Lonnie looked over Digby’s head at Kyle, barely holding back the tears in her

eyes.

Rogelio made a series of growls and rumbles that made all of the children look at his curiously. "What do you mean you and Dad have never lived without mom?"

"Papa's right you know. We've all always been together. For all we know we'll burn this place down if there's no-one to keep watch on us." When he wanted Kyle could sell sincerity.

Lonnie saw that the children were starting to cave. They sat together on the bed for a long time, talking and hugging, the six of them their own special bubble. Eventually the children got restless, fears averted and promises made about making a trip in the future, and ran out of the room to play. It left Lonnie and her two husbands alone. They gravitated together, filling the gaps left by the children's departure until they were cuddled together, Rogelio holding them both tenderly. Lonnie wasn't sure why she wanted to cry, she never usually did that, but the idea of a goodbye was suddenly overwhelming.

Elsewhere, on the outskirts of Oasis, another family were preparing themselves to leave the safe haven of their Spire and head out into the lion's den of Brightmoon. Hordak was sitting on a stool in Entrapta's lab, watching as the frenetic woman collected together gadgets and tools into a pile before discarding half and starting again. He had watched her do this more than once a day over the last week and he knew it was a sign of her anxiety. Neither of them were very good at talking about their feelings, but they knew each other in a way that he had once thought only Prime could know him. It scared him sometimes that he had once believed himself only to be worth something if he could impress a creature who had made him for war and then thrown him away when he failed. He had believed it for so long that he had torn a world apart for it.

He wondered, in his more introspective moments, what would have happened if he had met a younger Entrapta years before. What if twenty year old Entrapta had stumbled into his life, would

he have been ready to see her or would he have looked through her as he had looked through so many? When he had found her sneaking around his lab, he had been tired of war but to proud and too obsessed, he could admit that now, to stop. She had changed him, or maybe she had just allowed him a chance to change?

Watching locks of purple hair reach for more and more, he stood up and walked over to her. They weren't the most tactile of couples, but today he needed to hold her. Hordak stood his tall form in front of Entrapta and waited to be noticed. It wouldn't do to startle her. Finally she turned and stood motionless, watching him for a moment, reading his expression until with a loud clatter all of the gadgets in her hair were dropped to the floor as she moved forward and wrapped those same tendrils around him. He could barely move, but had just enough space to put his arms around her. They stood together in silence.

There was no need for words. Hordak knew why Entrapta was anxious. Entrapta knew why he was melancholy. It was enough. The embrace didn't last long, before Entrapta was back to moving around the room. Hordak was about to move back to his perch when her voice rang out through the room.

"You should see if Junior has changed his mind…and I think Stanley might need a snack." She sounded certain about the first point and a little confused about the second.

"I fed Stanley his lunch an hour ago, Entrapta. But I shall go and speak with Junior and see what the young one is up to." Hordak had never considered that he would be a father. Had barely had a concept of what it meant. It was why it had been so easy for him to collect children and use them as weapons.

He regretted it now. He looked at Stanley with his purple hair and soft cheeks, struggling through simply growing up and wondered if his Horde would have destroyed his son. It made him feel doubly guilty when he looked at Junior, once his imp, a boy that he had bred in a jar in a quest to emulate Prime. The only one of

his own clones to survive. Over the last few years he had worked hard to make amends, almost sure that he had been forgiven though he didn't think that he would forgive himself.

He found both of his boys in the playroom. Stanley was at a table, all his attention firmly focused on a brightly coloured picture that was taking shape on the paper in front of him. His pink tongue was clenched between his teeth as he concentrated hard. Even from the door Hordak could see the boy was doing a pretty accurate picture of a dragon. What he lacked in verbal communication he made up for with his ability to imagine and be creative. Neither Entrapta or Hordak were sure where he got it from, but they encouraged it non-the-less.

Junior was lounging in a small hammock in a corner reading a book, keeping watch over his little brother even though it wasn't necessary. He waved a lazy hand as he noticed Hordak walk in and went to continue with his book until he realised that the large man was walking over to him. Sitting up, the diminutive man spun till he was perched on the edge of the hammock. His progenitor sat beside him on a chair.

"Junior, are you sure that you won't come with us to Brightmoon?" Hordak kept his deep voice low so that it wouldn't carry to the child at the other side of the room.

Junior thought for a moment. His knee jerk reaction had been to say no. He hated to be gawped at and made to speak. He even avoided going into the Capital where he was known. Things were far better than they had been but he enjoyed his privacy. He imagined it was some sort of irony that after being a spy for Hordak all he wanted was privacy, but that was the way things were. Having given it a few days, he still knew that he would rather watch over Entrapta's experiments than deal with diplomacy.

"I. Want. To. Stay. Here. If. That. Is. Acceptable." Sometimes he wished he could find the right inflections for his words as easily as he could find the words in his catalogue of voices.

"I understand that. Of course it is acceptable for you to stay here. Try not to be alone the whole time though, take it from me that is not good for you." Hordak sat back on the chair, Junior returned to lounging in the hammock and Entrapta's three boys existed together in silence.

It was finally time to leave. Weeks had been spent in preparation, the magicat's deciding on their representatives, led by Catra. There would be seven of them in total plus Yarsha, representing the best of them, or at least those them who had the best memory of their home and culture. Two years ago it would have been Tace leading the group, but Catra would have to do her best to represent her people and herself.

The council had been reticent to lose any of their members, but Scorpia had been adamant that Catra and Yarsha were going nowhere without her, and Catra had been glad that there would be another pair of eyes on the little one. Double Trouble had also petitioned to join them, which had surprised everybody but Catra. Since the day they found all those dead bodies in a silent underground room, the shapeshifter had become very invested in the young magicats. It didn't hurt that they had become particularly invested in a certain stocky white designer who would also be a part of their group.

Huntara had appointed two temporary council members from a pool of proxies that had been drawn up two years before. It was not a perfect system but still meant that the city would be able to run as normal. Most of the inhabitants would not even notice that they were gone, if not for the fact that everyone was waiting for the outcome of what was to come. It was like the whole place was holding it's breath in fear, it gave the place a stiff, terrified air that was all too familiar to those who had grown up in the Horde. It was something that Catra had hoped that her people would never face.

Two of the slow moving solar wagons had been filled with their bags and other assorted sundries. They weren't fast or beautiful but they were reliable and able to get over most terrain, they just had to hope that the Whispering Woods would let them pass through. They meant no malice so they were hopeful. It was decided that the magicat delegates and the Oasis delegates would split themselves into the two wagons, Catra would rather have been with Scorpia and Lonnie, but it was good to consolidate herself with her fellow magicats as often as possible.

Catra sat in the back of the wagon, Yarsha perched on her lap as the wagons pulled away to no fanfare. Kesh was beside them, looking fondly at the little girl that her sister would never see grow up as her eyes hooded quickly and the motion of the wagon lulled her to sleep. Kesh was a wildcard, she spoke her mind and paid little heed to what she was told, but she was Tace's sister and nobody knew more about their cultural history than the sisters. It was also comforting to have her there, with Yarsha, it was like having Tace on the mission too.

Like the little one in her arms, Phibin who was seated further back was already asleep, head lolling back as deep purring snores rolled out of him. It made more than one of the other inhabitants of the van chuckle, breaking the tension that they were all feeling. Soon, the wagon was alive with their chatter and laughter as they were just a group of friends on a trip, rather than a delegation of ambassadors desperate to avert a war but keen for some recompense.

Magnificent. It was the only words to describe the Brightmoon as it came into view as the wagons coasted the hill and caught sight of it over the horizon. It was like something out of a children's story book, its pretty pastel colours and shining gold looming hazily against the clear sky. The Moonstone glowed with an inner light that gave it an etherial quality as it sat aloft in its giant sceptre-like tower. Waterfalls and verdant trees flowed and cascaded around the place. The eyes of all the passengers in the

wagon were transfixed, Catra's included. She could hear the awe in the sounds coming out of the other magicat's, especially the little one in her arms.

She wished that her eyes were seeing it for the first time. She couldn't tear her eyes away because behind them the images of the last time she had seen this place were crashing through her. Standing at the head of tanks and skiffs, commanding legions of soldiers hell bent on taking down the place no matter the cost. She had stood across the battlefield from somebody who she had thought of as essential to her life and unleashed everything she had at her. Launched a barrage of assault on Adora that she had wanted to destroy her. Her skin crawled as she remembered those days, all the hate and jealousy that she had projected out at the world to fill the broken and empty spots inside herself.

Those thoughts were the ones that made her eyes drop to the braided head of the child sitting on her lap. She wondered if Lonnie and Scorpia, in the other wagon, were thinking what she was? After all, they had only been following her orders that day. They had no more stake in the game than any of the other troops. She had risked their lives like nothing more than game pieces, willing to do anything to win somebody else's war that she thought was her own. She had stood, proudly, overlooking the carnage that she was unleashing and for the first time in her life she had felt like she was winning against all the odds stacked against her. Everyone would know that Catra was not a failure. A gusty sigh left the older version of that woman, looking around she saw tat nobody noticed, too caught up in talking about what they were seeing.

When that rainbow of power had rushed over and through her, blowing away all her hopes as easily as it had the tanks, she had been left feeling empty and lost. More lost. She wondered if when she was a teen she had ever been anything but. Now, she had the luxury of age and hindsight, of a life well lived for a decade with real loss under her belt, she see how foolish she had been. Now seeing Brightmoon all she could see was how much she had once

been wiling to hurt anyone that stood in her way, friend or foe, and not care about the consequences.

Part of her would like to know what Hordak was thinking in this moment. Had he even cared when he sent them to take the castle or had he just been going through the motions of conquest that he, like her, had been taught? He had never left his lab, in those days, totally disconnected from a war it seemed like he was just too used to fighting to stop. He had given up easily enough when given an alternative, after all. She could have hated him for that, would have once upon a time, but they were all just broken people trying to change. That Hordak had been the domino that knocked down the rest of them seemed unimportant now. He was making amends, would be for a long time, but surely better that than more pain.

So lost in her own thoughts was she that she almost missed the tickling sensation of small fingers against the underside of her chin. She looked down into yellow eyes and allowed a small smile to blossom on her face as she looked at her daughters dreamy expression. Yarsha clambered onto her feet in her lap and smooshed their cheeks together looking out at the castle.

"S'pretty,Ra." Her voice was breathy and full of awe.

"Yeah it is." She turned and kissed the cheek pushed against her.

"Adora's castle's nice." Catra could correct the child but didn't. It WAS Adora's castle, in its way. "I'm gonna give her and Perfuma cuddles."

That was the dagger to the heart though. Yarsha didn't understand what had happened, those blond's were just more people who doted on her and that she was excited to see. She didn't need to know the hurt that had been caused to them all.

"You can give them a hug, but listen to me Yarsha." She turned the kitten's head so they were looking at her. "I need you to be a big girl and remember what we told you, ok. You stay with one of

us, no going anywhere with Adora or any of the others. You have to be quiet when I tell you and you never leave our room by yourself." The child understood the solemnity in the mismatched eyes that look at her and nodded. Catra smiled proudly and kissed her button nose.

They went back to looking at the castle as finally the spell was broken and the group of magicats began to chatter and point at their destination. As angry as they may be, they were still a group of young twenty-something aliens seeing something quintessentially Etherian for the first time. Catra sat back and remained quiet as she let their voices wash over them as the place she had hoped never to see again grew larger and larger though the window.

Chapter End Notes

All our pieces are on the board now.

No update till Easter weekend FYI work deadlines are kicking my butt this week.

Chapter 17

Chapter Summary

Settling into Brightmoon.

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay with this chapter. Lots of work deadlines and applying to three jobs (and a touch of writers block) stopped this getting out on time.

Angella stood tall at the gates of the palace, Micah standing at her side. It had been a long time since Brightmoon had played host to a delegation of potentially hostile guests. She remembered as a much younger woman, standing with her parents as delegates from other kingdoms came to make trade and political deals before the war with the Horde began. Seeing the different colours and styles of dress and the kitchens preparing the foods of those areas had been something that had been so exciting for the young angelic. Now, all she could think as she watched the squat, ugly vehicles roll their way to a stop before the castle, was that she hoped that war could be averted.

Dark eyes were trained on the opening doors of the two wagons as she watched the passengers disembark. She recognised, from the various reports she had read from the Princesses who had been coming and going from the hidden city over the last few months, several of the people now walking their way. Watching Scorpia walk their way was bitter sweet, bringing back new memories of playing with her parents when they had been children. A shard of guilt lodged in her chest as she thought about how the Scorpioni had been taken by the Horde, who had claimed that they had joined forces, and what life the young princess must have had. She was the first Scorpioni she had seen since and the queen knew that could only mean one thing.

Moving her gaze, she watched the cluster of magicats and her eyes widened as she noticed the small child sleeping in the arms of the one who could only be Catra. She vaguely recognised the woman as the girl who had once attacked Brightmoon, though time had changed her almost beyond recognition. The green robes that she wore were foreign and unusual, mirroring what those around her wore. They all sported bare feet and pants that cut off just below the knee. It was the child that kept her attention though, a toddler if she was seeing correctly, curled up in her arms and sleeping soundly. It gave the angelic hope that everything had been a simple misunderstanding and that they really were as desperate for an extended peace as she was.

The colour drained from her face however when they landed on the towering figure unfolding himself through one of the doors. He may be dressed in loose fitting trousers and shirt but she would recognise him anywhere. For more than half a century he had been the thorn in the side of Etheria, the ghost in the night that continued to haunt them. Now, there he stood, hand extended to somebody still inside the vehicle, looking diminished but still chilling. She felt her heart begin to beat faster as the anger swelled, the man behind her looking at her with a worried expression, even as his own posture had stiffened at the sight. To say that she was shocked when Princess Entrapta was the one to take his hand and be pulled out of the wagon, a child held in her own arms would be an understatement, all of the air suddenly left her lungs as she watched Hordak take the tiny boy from her and hold him close to his chest with a gentleness that seemed impossible for such a monster. He wordlessly followed the purple haired princess as her hair walked her towards the rest of her team before they all advanced towards the welcoming committee.

Angella looked back, noticing the uncomfortable fidgeting of the group of younger women behind her. Adora looked ashen, swaying slightly as though any moment she would fall into a feint. She was not surprised the wielder of the Sword of Protection had wound herself up into such a state, she had long been familiar with how guilt weighed upon the young shoulders. Perfuma beside her kept her eyes downcast and her shoulders were

slumped, doing nothing to diminish the girls height but showing everything about how she felt. As always, Mermista was defiant but her eyes gave her away, that and the fact that Sea Hawk had refused to be at her side for the greeting. They were all dressed in traditional clothes from their kingdoms, Adora wearing something reminiscent of Brightmoon, as they had been instructed. This was to be formal talks and she wanted them all to remember protocol.

Then there was Glimmer. Against her better judgement and Micah's protests, she has allowed her daughter to be there to greet their guests. In the last few days Glimmer had seemed much more like her old self, she had earnestly apologised for her actions and seemed to be attempting to make amends. She had come to her mother two days before and asked to be present to show that she was willing to try to build the peace. Angella had no reason to disbelieve her, though Micah had warned against her presence, and agreed. She had learned to trust her daughter a long time ago and hoped that it would be rewarded.

Oasis stood before her now, represented in all the colours and vibrancy of a nation made of many disparate parts joined in a seamless unity. She met the eyes of each representative, nodding her head respectfully as she raised her voice to be heard by all in the vicinity, princesses, guards and delegates alike.

"I am Queen Angella and I welcome you with open heart to the Kingdom of Brightmoon."

The throne room was cavernous and intimidating. Catra found herself standing taller, noticed that Scorpia and the rest of the team did the same. The only one of them who seemed nonplussed by the ornate room was Double Trouble, who draped themself gracefully over one of the preferred chairs and simply pursed their lips in disinterested appraisal. If you didn't know them you would think that they were bored, Catra knew better, the one-time spy was taking in every detail of the room and its occupants for later analysis. Sitting in her own chair, Yarsha tucked into her chest and still sleeping soundly after her brief

wakeful excitement, she was surprised to note that, other than the array of guards stationed around the room, backs to the walls, only the King and Queen sat before them in their thrones. It was an obvious power play, them sitting in the large elevated chairs, but no more than it would be when they held court with anyone, and Catra admired the confidence to meet with them alone. Their eyes roamed over the rag-tag group of representative and she saw how they lingered on the sleeping children in the room for a moment too long, longing crossing the King's face.

It was Double Trouble who had been assigned leader in this endeavour, and they took to the role with the usual gusto in the role. They levelled their unsettling slit eyes on the royal pair and bared their mouthful of razor sharp teeth in a wide, disarming smile before breaking the silence. It may have been a break in protocol for the guest to speak before the royals, but they hadn't exactly had a lot of experience of that.

"Your Royal Highnesses, thank you for opening the gates of Brightmoon to us. We come in the hope of peace, but also with the expectation of justice." The smooth, honied voice of the consummate actor poured over everyone. Catra knew that her own rough, often squeaky one would not have had half the effect.

"You are welcome in Brightmoon. We too hope that this will be a positive and hopeful period between us and that mistakes that have been made to cause a rift between our two nations can be healed." Queen Angella's voice carried around the room with a steely authority that was both commanding and reassuring. Catra could almost let herself believe that the statuesque woman was truthful in her intent. Almost. Time and terms would tell.

"You'll excuse us if we don't see the incursion into our territory, and the near defiling of an area we had clearly said was off limits, as a 'mistake' and more a declaration of intent." Double Trouble voice was edged like a finely honed blade, there was no way to take offence but that they were equally as tempered as the woman in front of them was clear in word and tone.

“Quite right,”it was the king who spoke this time, his deeper voice almost seeming to resonate around the room. “It was not a mistake but nor was it a declaration. Like you, the last thing that we desire is another war. We lost enough in the last one.” The Oasis delegation noticed the Queen’s eyes turn sad and soft as she looked at the diminutive man at her side as he spoke. “It is time for us all to be building a future and not looking to the past. We hope that you feel the same.”

“That is all we have been doing for a decade, Sir.” It was Catra who gave voice to the feelings of the group this time, showing her hand as a leader of a faction of the group assembled before them.

“You are Catra?” Angella stared at her with her grey eyes and Catra knew that she knew exactly who she was, though the child in her lap may have thrown her a little.

“Yes, ma’am,” she was sure that she was addressing both royals by the wrong titles but she had been raised in the military and these were the honorific that she knew. “I am sure you remember me from the Battle of Brightmoon. That seems like a lifetime ago to me now. I offer my apologise for the destruction I caused but that girl has not been who I am for a long time.” Her words were as sincere as she could make them. Angella nodded, seeming satisfied for the moment though the younger woman was certain that more questions would follow in the eschewing days.

“What capacity are you here in?” The question was obviously addressed to Catra, but before she could speak Double Trouble took control again.

“Let me make the more formal introductions your majesty. I am Double Trouble and this,” they pointed to Scorpia who bashfully waved a claw, “is Scorpia. We represent the five person council of Oasis. We are the elected leaders of the community. Behind Scorpia are several other citizens of Oasis who represent the former Horde and Crimson Waste members of our city. Catra is here in her role as Chief of the Magicats. She is their designated leader and with her are others who represent their species.” Catra

had been watching the monarchs the whole time the lizard spoke and saw them narrow they eyes at the news.

"It was our understanding that Catra was not the leader of Oasis?" There was suspicion in the words now as the king looked fixedly at her.

"And I'm not. I am the leader of my people, who amount to no more than 300 adults and children. We would be happy to talk with you about our culture during our stay to alleviate your concerns." It galled her to talk like this, to seem cowed in some way, but the clear poison that had been spread by the princess was there in their eyes even if the two seated on their thrones were being very measured.

"We will take you up on that." Angella turned her eyes to the final group in the room who had remained, Yarsha began to stir and Catra bent to shush her as her eyes remained fixed on the interaction to come. Honestly, she had been surprised that the Etherian's hadn't addressed this with their first breath.

Entrapta's hair was cradling Stanley where he, like Yarsha, had napped through the entire meeting, while her hand was tucked into Hordak's. It was hard to tell what either of them were thinking on a good day, watching their faces now there was obvious worry on the former princesses face while Hordak's shoulders were drooped in what Catra recognised as shame.

"Hordak, you are in Brightmoon at our request. It is harder for us not to look back at your crimes against Etheria, Brightmoon and ourselves." The immortal's voice had become sharper, her expression pinched as she addressed her oldest enemy. Catra wondered how much self control it took to keep that inside for long enough to graciously welcome the rest of them. Her eyes roamed to the King who was statue still as he glared at the tall man.

"We request," Angella was speaking to Double Trouble now, though her eyes never left the silent pair, "That you allow us to

place Hordak under house arrest until we have had an opportunity to question him."

"What form will this questioning take?" Double Trouble was no fool and wanted to know their intent, Hordak may not be their favourite Oasis resident but without him and his partner, their progress would have been far slower.

"We wish to interrogate him about his past crimes and current intent in order to ascertain what further actions to take." It was a diplomatic way to say that they wanted to interrogate him to decide how long to jail him for, but Catra saw through the diplomatic working and Double Trouble obviously did too. There would be time to discuss this more in commingling days though.

"What say you to these terms, citizen Hordak?" The former spy chose their words carefully for affect.

"I accept the terms of Brightmoon. I would ask only that my family be permitted to share my room with me, able to come and go freely while I am incarcerated." Hordak's words were almost lifeless, though a careful observer would see his hand tighten around Entrapta's as he spoke.

Kings Micah's eyes fell to the small boy nestled in waves of purple hair, them to the clasped hands and looked to his own wife who nodded in silent agreement. "That seems acceptable, for now. We will arrange for a series of meetings with each of you, as well as the other members of the alliance. Each of your rooms is equipped with a tracker pad which we will use to contract you. With the exception of Hordak you are all free to explore the castle, you have been given rooms on the South side and a garden has been set aside for your privacy. If you need anything, please do not hesitate to contact the staff or us directly."

While King Micah spoke, Queen Angella gestured to several of the guards who moved forward to stand with the royal couple. "These guards will escort you to your rooms. Princess Entrapta, Hordak

may share the room you chose, though we will be placing runes around the room and guards at the door to prevent his exit."

"It's just Entrapta, Queen Angella." It was the first time the woman once from Dryl had spoken and her voice was more subdued than anyone had ever heard before.

"Entrapta, it is good to see you well after everything that happened." There was genuine warmth in the words. "Please escort our guests to their rooms and help them with anything they may require. Two guards will be placed on the door to Hordak's but no others." The words were clearly for their benefit but were reassuring non-the-less.

The group from Oasis stood in unison and got ready to follow the silver and white uniformed guards out, when a tiny voice squealed in the loudest whisper imaginable, directly into Catra's ear.

"Ra! She got wings!" It broke the tension just enough to let the older couple let out a laugh.

Shaking her head at her daughters lack of both tact and fear, she pressed her forehead to the smaller one as they walked out. Maybe there was hope for this meeting after all. If the rest of the Alliance could just be as clear as their leader's maybe a lasting peace could be forged.

Staring up at the ceiling, the unfamiliar sounds of the castle filtering in through the window and under the door, Catra tried to even her breaths to follow her bedmates into sleep. The bed beneath her was more vast and luxurious than anything she had ever experienced, and if not for the snuffles and purrs of the two other magicats in the bed she would have thought that she was alone on the pillowy mass. The days events still roiled through her mind like a storm that she could not tame and sleep seemed to get further and further away. After another interminable stretch of time, she couldn't take it any more and rolled off of the bed.

Padding around the room on silent feet, she stooped down and gently shook the shoulder of the black coated magicat until she stirred enough to crack an eye open a slither. Peering over her shoulder, Catra was reassured that the kitten was still curled in a ball and snuffling softly into the back of her aunts head. Kesh grunted in annoyance at having been woken, and Catra smiled affectionately at her, she was as different from her older sister as it was possible to be, but just like Tace, Kesh loved sleep and hated to be roused.

"Hey,"Catra's voice was pitched low, barely audible to anything but cat ears. "I'm going to go stretch my legs. You're in charge of Yarsha." She got a yawn and a grunt in response before Kesh's eyes closed and her breathing almost instantly evened out.

Catra shook her head, taking a last look at her sleeping family, before she walked to the balcony and jumped off, landing in a graceful roll on the grass below in the part of the garden that they had been told was there's to use. Bouncing back onto her feet, she breathed in deeply. Dozens of scents bombarded her from the array of flowers, trees and grasses to the odd hint of ozone that seemed to leech into the air from the Moonstone. It was a far cry from her desert home. A gentle breeze ruffled her fur where it was exposed from her crop top and shorts and she dashed through the shrubbery and up the nearest tree.

There was something to be said for a place that had been lush and growing for generations, the trees in the manicured gardens were tall and strong providing ample challenge in their maze of branches. The agile young woman leapt from branch to branch, moving higher and higher, occasionally leaping from one well groomed tree to another. The higher she moved the slimmer the boughs became, flexing under her weight until she went from leaping to swinging between them, using her not insignificant upper body strength and claw enhanced grip to propel her forward using the branches elasticity like a catapult. Soon she could see over the canopy and look up at the mesmerising Moonstone, perched with her knees drawn up on a branch that gently swayed beneath her.

Catra wasn't sure how long she stayed like that, in the soft highlight of Brightmoon, when the rusting of leaves far below drew her attention. The noise was subtle, barely audible from her vantage point and she was sure that one of her fellow magicats would have written it off as the wind. Catra was not any other magical though, she had grown up with hyper vigilance and suspicion as second nature, so when she heard leaves disturbed her heckles rose and she made a fast and silent descent.

Landing on soft feet, she looked at the back of the person clumsily making their way through the bushes. She took in the short blond hair, a couple of leaves and twigs sticking out here and there from her trust through the undergrowth. Like Catra, the interloper was in the shorts and vest that made up her pyjamas, though her feet had been slid into ugly boots. She seemed blissfully unaware of her tail, the cat keeping step with her for a while, stalking her like they were children until she grew tired of it, wanting to know why she was here in the area that they had been promised was for their use only.

"Hey, Adora." Her voice was pitched low but she knew that it would get the other woman's attention.

Adora spun, clearly startled, body rigidly in combat stance as she reached for the bracer that was usually around her wrist. Her fingers encountered nothing but smooth skin as she remembered that she had left it on her dresser when she went for a walk because she couldn't sleep. She looked over at Catra who was watching her with her brow quirked in something like amusement. It would have seemed comfortably familiar if not for the hardness about the furred jaw.

"Um, hi Catra. Couldn't sleep?" She knew her voice was a little high pitched as she lowered her arms and tried to relax her posture.

"Did the pyjama's give it away?" She couldn't help the sarcastic drawl creeping into her voice. She didn't want to fight with the blond. Seeing her just made her feel betrayed, not a new feeling

around her once best friend, and so weary that she feared her body would refuse to stand much longer.

"Yeah, sorry. That was dumb." The human's hands were still agitatedly fiddling with the skin on her arm.

"I thought this part of the garden was meant to be for us?" It was hard not to be concerned, there needed to be a place where her people could exist without worry of being spied on.

"Oh, I didn't even realise I had come this far." Adora's face lost all colour and she looked embarrassed. "I walk around the gardens when I can't sleep until I'm too tired to go much further and then I go back to bed. I didn't even think about changing my rout. I am so sorry." The blue eyes were cloudy and her voice was so agitated that Catra was worried that she was about to witness the other woman hyperventilate over nothing of real consequence.

"Calm down Adora, I believe you. This isn't normal for any of us." The magicat started to walk into the open area of lawn that she had seen before with its border of brightly coloured flowers when she realised that she was being followed by her unwanted companion. Resigning herself to a conversation she was in no way prepared for, Catra moved to sit on one of the large ornamental boulders that were dotted in clusters here and there. Adora did the same so that they were facing each other.

Nothing was said for a while as Catra looked at anything but Adora, while Adora studied the other woman illuminated by the soft light of the Moonstone as it gently illuminated the night. She had known that her childhood friend had grown a lot since the Horde, but she had never seen so much of her body, even when they worked in the fields or on other projects. Seeing her now with her arms, stomach and legs bared it was impossible to miss the muscles that stood out under the fur even while she was mostly relaxed. The fur curled around the edges of her sleeves and waistband, showing how much thicker it was than when they were children. It had been all Adora could do not to reach out and pet her when they had been in Oasis and their arms had

occasionally touched while they worked side-by-side, now with the distance between them, distance she caused, that urge was more intense than ever. Like touch would reconnect them. In lieu of reaching out her fingers went bak to fidgeting with the fine hair on her naked forearm.

"That wouldn't have worked, you know, even if you had it." Catra's voice made Adora jump again and the old, comforting, squeaky laugh was there for just a moment.

"What?" Adora was confused by the words, she was exhausted and her emotions were a raw nerve screaming at being in the presence of the other woman.

"Your sword. She-ra. It wouldn't have worked on me. Not anymore." There was none of the cockiness that she might have expected at those words.

"Oh. I thought that was the Halfmoon?" Adora regretted her words almost as soon as they left her lips as she watched the other woman's body tense, the fur standing up on her shoulders and her tail lashing.

"It's a logical assumption. It wasn't the ship, it was me, well us." Though there was an edge to her voice now she didn't get up and walk away.

"How? Shadow Weav…" This time the magicat did stand, her ears pressed flat to her head as she began to walk away. Adora was about to call her back when she realised that rather than walking away, Catra was pacing.

"You really know how to put your foot right in your mouth don't you?" She closed her eyes, shuttering those mismatched orbs as she shook her head. A deeper darkness seemed to settle over the garden, making her features shadowed and hollow. "Yes, when I was a child magic could hurt me. Now it can't."

"Catra, I am so sorry about everything. I didn't mean for any of it to happen. I saw Hordak, and then Glimmer had this plan and…

and…I am so sorry. I don't think I ever really believed there was danger in Oasis, I love it there. I love the people. I saw Hordak…" It was like she was caught in a loop, the air seeding to get thinner as the light faded further. Spots started to dance in front of her eyes as she dropped her head into her hands, longing for the long hair that would have covered her face and hidden her from view.

She flinched when a hand settled on her shoulder, but relaxed fractionally when she saw the clawed feet enter her eye line. Her breath was coming in jagged gasps as she tried to pull herself together, when the hand travelled from her shoulder to her head and sharp fingered hands began to gently scratch through the short strands. The movement was practiced, and the blond was able to wonder if she did this for Yarsha when she was upset. It warmed her heart to think that Catra cared at least enough not to abandon her to her panic. As the rhythmic stroking continued, Adora's breaths evened out and her body relaxed. They continued like that in silence until Adora felt her eyelids drooping. When the hand was removed from her head and the feet that had been in front of her moved away she almost mewled in displeasure but bit it back. With effort she lifted her head and saw Catra once again seated on the rock opposite, examining her with an inscrutable expression.

"Thank you." Adora's voice was soft but sincere.

"I wouldn't let you suffer Adora, I thought you knew that wasn't me anymore." This time there was obvious sadness in her words. Adora noticed that the garden had become so dark that she could barely make out her companion's face.

"I… Why doesn't magic affect you anymore?" She couldn't say what she wanted and she didn't want to spiral again, this seemed like the least worst thing to say.

"Ha, yeah I did say that." Catra ran her hands through her own hair, before winding one of the two small braids around her finger. "Magicat's go through something like a second puberty, best I can explain. It happens in our early twenties." She gestured at her

body and Adora almost blushed as her eyes roamed. “We become impervious to magic that would harm us. Magicats aren’t magic, we’re magic proof.”

Was it Adora or was it suddenly brighter as the other woman confided that small part of herself to her? She wanted to ask more, to try to build on the moment they had shared, but it was very late and they both needed to sleep. She looked up at the sky to check that it wasn’t dawn, it seemed so much brighter than before, but there was only inky darkness and the glow of the Moonstone.

“Come on, Adora. You look like you’re about two-seconds away from keeling over.” Catra got to her feet and on instinct reached out a hand to pull her to her feet. She wanted to snatch her hand away, but that would be childish and unnecessarily mean, so she stood her ground as a warm hand wild into hers. She pulled Adora gently to her feet before quickly dropping her hand. “You should go back to your room. I think you’re probably ready by now. I should get back to Yarsha.”

“Yeah, wouldn’t want the cutest kitten in the world to wake up by herself.” Adora smiled as she thought about the little one and almost missed the cloud that passed over Catra’s face.

“I would never leave her alone, Adora.” There was something in those words that she didn’t understand, and Catra didn’t say more as she walked away back into the castle alone.

Adora wasn’t sure exactly how she got back to her room. Her limbs felt heavy and she knew that she wouldn’t last long once her body hit her mattress. She closed the door behind her and triggered the magic lock before kicking off her clunky boots, wiggling her clammy toes in the plush pile of the rug that laid before her bed. Clumsily she staggered forward and fell onto the messy bed, wriggling around until she was buried under the covers with her head burrowed into her pillow.

Her breaths already lengthening as her eyes grew heavier, she thought about what had just happened in the garden. When she had walked out of her room that night she had no intention of going anywhere near the wing housing the Oasis retinue, yet she had found herself drawn there anyway. What were the odds that Catra would also be roaming the night?

Flopping onto her back, Adora thought about the hand that had run through her hair and her heart stuttered a little. She had never expected to feel kindness from the other woman again, not after what she had done. That she had not only been kind, but also patient, had almost been more than she could resist. A part of her, laying there in her bed, wished that she had reached out and touched the other woman to show how much she cared back but she was too much of a coward for that. She still wasn't sure that the magicat didn't hate her. She certainly knew that they weren't ok. Although, tonight had hopefully been a step back towards the burgeoning friendship tat had been growing over the last six months.

With a sigh, she made herself relax, her body having started to tense again. She let herself remember the feel other those strong fingers in her hair, the hypnotic monotony of the gentle scrape of claws on her scalp and soon her eyes were closed and snuffling snorts began to fill the room as she fell into a dream of fur and claws and soft words.

Across the castle, Catra was lying prone beneath the kitten who had clambered on top of her as soon as she climbed back into bed. The still sleeping child had zeroed in on her with shocking speed and was now laying across her torso, effectively pinning her parent to the bed. Catra brought her hand up to gently stroke her daughter, feeling the small purrs that followed the touch, as she let he motion sooth her own mind.

Catra tried not to think about the fact that she had just touched Adora like this. She felt like a traitor, treating somebody who had hurt the heart of her people with the same tenderness she would touch her child, but it had been impossible not to. She had seen

Adora spiral like that too many times as children to just let her suffer. Once she was touching her it had felt too familiar, too intimate to stop. The feel of her hair, her scent, all the only good memories from a bleak past.

Wrapping her arms around the kitten, she rolled them to the side so that Yarsha was tucked into her body, and let herself think about the joys that she had had, not the darkness and finally she was able to succumb to sleep.

Micah knew that he shouldn't be there, the purpose of all of this was defuse the situation, not escalate it, but that reckless part of him that had charged into an unwinnable situation all those years ago was still a part of him. It was the thing that kept him alive on an island deemed to be a death sentence. It was the thing that led him to be standing between the two guards stationed at the unimposing door.

Without raising his hand to knock, he had no need of that, he was king of this place and the man inside was all but a prisoner, he blew the doors open with a violent blast of magic. They boomed as they hit off the frame and the guards to either side twitched at the commotion.

If he were hoping that the man inside would flinch, or show any form of surprise, he was disappointed. Hordak stood at the window, staring down at the scattered villages of Brightmoon. The light shone around him, casting him into shadow, making him seem as dangerous and imposing as he had been thirty years before when he sentenced Micah to a lifetime of solitude without a twitch of emotion. For just a second, Micah was back there, guilt over disobeying Angie and never seeing his family again running through him.

It wasn't the noise, but rather the silence that followed that made Hordak turn and face his visitor. He was well used to the sound and fury of those trying to intimidate, it had been one of his own

more bombastic ways to keep his soldiers in check after all. He took in the stocky figure standing in his threshold with a keen eye. He knew him, of course, the once lost king of Brightmoon. A man he had personally taken the pleasure of exiling to a place of death to show the Princess Alliance who was boss. He fervently believed, both then and now that it had been the loss of the king that had broken the original rebellion. He had been gratified at the time, but years had passed and Hordak was on his third life, more than he deserved for sure, and a better man now. He regretted the destruction he had once revelled in and that he had taken this man from his family.

"Would you join me, your majesty?" Hordak spoke as he moved to take a seat at the small table in the corner of the room, scattered with the scrawls of a child.

Micah was broken from his revelry by the rich, smooth tones of the larger man's voice and moved forward to join him, still silent. Micah sized up his former foe as he took his own seat. Out of the corona of sunlight Micah could easily see the changes in the bat-like man. Hordak was much slighter, almost delicate, his shirt and trousers hanging off of his broad frame. It gave him a fragility, like a willow bow in the wind, revealing what had been hidden under his armour. His face was also softer, jaw just as chiselled but there was a softness around his mouth and his red eyes were far less flinty. Even his hair was casually rumpled. It could have been a ploy to disarm his enemy, to seem more vulnerable, but Micah didn't think that the Hordak that he had met could carry that off.

Micah turned to face him, his arm brushing a piece of paper that was sitting on the table top and causing it to flutter to the floor. Out of habit he reached down to retrieve it, finding a brightly coloured child's picture in his grasp. He couldn't help but examine the image, seeing the childish scrawl of bright colours and wavy lines yet it was easy enough to make out the content. Standing in the centre of the page was a woman with wave after wave of purple hair scribbled all around her, by her side was a small boy

with hair the same shade. What really caught his eye was the tall, almost stickman-like figure in the middle of the sheet of paper. He was scratched out in dark blues and black, towering over the other figures (Micah wondered who the small green figure on the other side of what was obviously Hordak was) Holding the little boys hand.

He looked up from the papers to see the other man silently observing him, expression soft with no hint of malice. “Your son is very good.” It wasn’t what he had intended to say but something about the picture in his hand had derailed him.

“Yes, he enjoys making images. He is also quite gifted at schematics for his age, I am told.” There was obvious pride, and a little confusion in her voice. More and more Micah realised that he did not know this man.

“You took that from me, knowing my child.” There it was, the anger and resentment that had thrown open the doors.

“I am sorry for the things that I have done, King Micah. I cannot regret my actions however, if not for them then Oasis would not exist and the magicats, though all alive, would sleep forever under the earth. My Stanley would not exist.” It was an odd admission, but it gave Micah some insight into the creature before him.

Before Micah could say more, the impromptu meeting was interrupted by the sound of small running feet and the door banging open a second time as the small boy in question ran in, followed closely by Entrapta. The boy ran full tilt towards the table and then threw himself at his father who caught her easily, obviously used to this. Micah watched, not sure what he expected to see. Hordak held the very small boy out in front of him and looked at him critically, as though taking an inventory of him, before he smiled and drew the child close in a stiff but loving hug.

Micah had never expected to see a smile on that pallid face, yet here it was. He took in the boy with his buzzed purple hair and his pale skin the same huge as his fathers, as the child looked up at

the tall man as though he hung the moon. Neither spoke, but it was clear that they were communicating.

Micah stood, this had not been the right thing to do. Something moved in the periphery of his vision, drawings attention for a moment, but there was nothing there. Maybe it had been a bug. He turned back to the little group who he would have thought oblivion to him now, if not for the red eye tracking him over teh boys head. Putting the man on house arrest and then intruding on him while spoiling for a fight had been poor judgement on his part, Angie would certainly not be pleased. It was certainly wrong to be there while he was with his young family. He left the room, offering Entrapta a weak smile as he passed her on his way to the door. He remember her as a socially awkward teen in the war, unwilling to leave the sanctuary of her home. He was strangely pleased that she had found somebody who understood her, even if that person was Hordak.

Closing the door behind him, he had a lot to think about. He was still angry and Hordak had much to atone for, but that was what the interrogation sessions would be for.

Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

Let's get this party started

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Taking a shuddering breath, Perfuma raised a trembling and knocked softly at the door. Her head was bowed as she waited for the person inside to open up. A part of her was hoping that it was empty while another dreaded the silence. It would mean that the person on the other side knew who was there, and did not want to speak with her. Time ticked by agonisingly slowly and she wished that she had not skipped out on her morning meditation to come here before the days scheduled events would begin. Now, her hands trembled and her heart was beating too quickly while her mind whirled with intrusive thoughts.

Eventually the door opened, revealing not the woman that she had expected to see, but a shorter and darker magicat eyeing her with suspicion and distain. Perfuma knew Kesh, had worked with her on the farming projects and knew that she was somehow related to Catra and Yarsha, but being greeted by her was a shock. Had she got it wrong and come to the wrong guest room? She looked blankly at Kesh for a moment, who stood silently appraising her through the crack of the doors, and then darted hers eyes along the corridor before coming back to that judgemental gave.

“Is Catra here?” She was thankful that her voice came out steady, if a little small.

Kesh rolled her eyes, not deigning to talk with the human woman, before turning her head to call over her shoulder, “Catra, there’s a princess here for you.” Then she was walking away, still leaving the door open only a crack.

A bright scream streamed out of the room as tiny feet stampeded their way to the doorway. Though the kitten was obscured by the only partially open door, Perfuma was warmed at her excitement, even if it was just to see a 'princess'. The little feet stopped just before they reached the opening, and from the little giggle that filtered through it Perfuma knew that She had been scooped into Catra's arms in a gesture that she had seen a million times around Oasis and in the comfort of the orphanage. Then it was usually to be spun around or tickled, cradled in her parent's arms because she was too tired. Now Perfuma knew it was to keep her safe and away from whoever was at the door and it made all the pain in her chest sting just a little more.

Finally Catra's head appeared in the opening of the door, her eyes giving away nothing as she pushed it open wider and beckoned the tall woman into her suit. Stepping over the threshold she saw that Yarsha and Kesh were nowhere to be seen and assumed that they were either on the balcony or in the bathroom to keep little ears from hearing what they should not.

"Have you seen her yet?" Perfuma was startled out of her perusal of the room by Catra's voice, curt and to the point as she hadn't been for some time.

"No. Not yet. I thought I should come here first. I owe you an apology, for what it's worth." Perfuma was pleased that her voice didn't break and she hoped that those large twitching ears could hear the sincerity in her voice.

"You don't owe me anything. You owe Scorpia an explanation. I saw that you weren't there that day and for that I'll spare you my anger, but you've lost my respect. You obviously didn't believe in what they were going to do or you would have been there too, but rather than give us a heads up you break Scorpia's heart and run away to hide from the storm." Catra's voice lacked any anger, it was far worse that that, it was filled with disgust.

"I didn't want to hurt her. I couldn't stop the others and I couldn't turn on them. I thought that I was doing the right thing." Catra

laughed at that, not the laugh shared with small children around a table or with the farmers in the field, this was the laugh from the battlefield and it made the plant princess shiver.

"You can lie to yourself all you want, Perfuma. You were too much of a coward to take a stand against something you didn't believe in and you hurt my best friend in the process. Take a hard look at yourself before you speak with her if all you're going to do is peddle this…" She waved a hand, the claws unsheathed menacingly.

"I should go." Perfuma found herself edging back to the door.

"You should be truthful with yourself and go to see her." Catra was holding the edge of the door now, Perfuma surprised to find that she was already standing in the hall. "Go and see her before all of this starts and there is no time for you and her. Oasis is what we're here for."

"Thank you." Perfuma spoke the words and knew that she was grateful for Catra's plain speaking. "I will see you at the talks."

A grunt was all she received in response as the door closed on her. Straightening her shoulders, Perfuma walked with purpose to another door, knocking without a second though this time. Catra was right, she had been a coward and she had lied to herself. She could be brave now and take whatever consequences lay behind that door.

This time the heavy, slightly clumsy footfalls were immediate and the door was opened wide in seconds, Scorpia peering into the hallway with wide, curious eyes. It took her a moment as her eyes zeroed in on her visitor for her mind to catch up, Perfuma watched the big, beautiful smile that had bloomed there slowed morph into a mask of sadness. There was no frown, no scowl, just sorrow written on her soft features. She seemed frozen, one claw clutching too hard at the edge of the open door and Perfuma noted absently the material buckling under the pressure. She so desperately longed to reach out and lay her hand over that tough

shell and get her to relax, but she knew that would be the worse more she could make.

“Hello Scorpia, may I come in? I have some things I need to say to you.” She pushed all the longing and repentance into her voice that she could.

Scorpia, terrifyingly silent, stepped away from the doorway and motioned for her to come in. Her broad shoulders were hunched and she had stopped making eye contact. That act to touch and sooth came back and Perfuma forced herself to walk towards the small table in the corner of the room, when everything she wanted was to perch on the edge of the unmade bed, but instead she sat in a chair and waited expectantly to the one opposite to be filled. Looking at the bigger woman who was now fidgeting her claws together, Perfuma realised that she was still in her sleepwear. She had woken her from slumber only to be faced with somebody who had hurt her.

Eventually the scorpioni took the other seat, leaning forward with her pincers resting on her knees and her head bowed over them. Perfuma wasn’t sure if she should be the one to break the heavy silence but when Scorpia’s shoulders began to gently shake, she knew that she had to.

“Scorpia, please don’t cry.” Finally big black eyes rose to finally look at her, tears shimming in her eyes and along her cheeks. “I am so sorry, for everything I did to you. Please, just let me explain why and then I’ll leave. I won’t bother you again.” She felt her own words become thick and tears shimmer in her eyes but bit them back, feeling like she didn’t have the right to cry.

“I don’t want you to leave.” Scorpia’s voice was as soft as she had ever heard it, almost childlike through the hurt and so plaintiff that Perfuma felt her already broken heart fracture still further. “I just want to know why.”

Perfuma tried to explain in words that even to her own ears sounded cowardly and confused. It made no sense to her now

when it had seemed so coldly logical just a scant few weeks before. Explained that she had tried to talk sense into Adora and Mermista, begged them to go to the council but that they had refused and how she had known that once they got to Brightmoon nothing she would say would dissuade them from taking action, although she tried. The words spilled out of her as she reassured that she had taken no part in the attack on Oasis. But there was one thing she didn't answer, because she was still a coward, and Scorpia gave it voice.

"You could have told me. You could have told me and nobody would have known and we could have done something to stop all this." Scorpia's eyes were dry now, and harder, Perfuma found herself shrinking under that stare. "Why finish things between us and let all this happen? Did you just want to get away from me that much and this was convenient timing?" There was something in those words, like she knew that nobody could want her for long. Like she thought there was an expiration date and Perfuma had reached it.

"No… No, Scorpia." Her words spilled out so passionately that the other woman was visibly taken aback. Perfuma took a chance and reached across the table separating them to put her hand on the forearm that was now laying on the table. She was shocked when Scorpia didn't pull away and pushed on. "I made the wrong choice, chose the wrong side, and I hate myself for it. I didn't tell you about why we were leaving because I was torn between how I feel for you and a lifetime of loyalty to them. I never wanted to hurt you. I never wanted us to end. I thought that you would hate me after everything inevitably fell apart, and I thought that this way it would save us both from a worse heartbreak." She was startled when a large claw settled gently over the hand on the scorpioni's arm.

"You never wanted us to end?" Scorpia's expression was torn but her words were achingly hopeful.

"Of course not, I love you Scorpia." Perfuma thought she had lost her chance to say those words to the other woman. This was far

from how she had imagined telling the gentle giant, bu if this was all they had then at least she had said it.

"I love you too," Perfuma's heart soared before crashing through her feet. "I just don't know where we go from here."

For the second time in as many days Catra found herself in a room with the Queen of Brightmoon and her consort. This time they were in what must have once been their war room, if the large oval table that dominated the space was anything to go by. Catra was flanked by her magicat representatives, along with Double Trouble and Scorpia who refused to let them be in any meeting without them. She had thought about saying no to them, that this meeting was about the magicats, and once upon a time that would have been the hill she died on. She had grown out of that self destructive pride, seeing DT and Scorpia's concern for what it was, a need to bear witness to the proceedings to ensure that nothing would be misrepresented. They were here to support her and not wait for her to fail. The same could not be said for the people fanned out across the other side of the table.

Catra was sat opposite the Queen, with Kesh and Phibin flanking her and the other members of her delegation spread out either side of them, each side ending in one of the two council representatives. The Queen was once again accompanied by her husband to her right, it was the oddly blank face of the younger woman to her left that caught and held Catra and her teams attention. Princess Glimmer looked warn around the edges and her face was almost frozen in a look of disinterest. It was the furthest thing from what the magicat had expected; distain maybe, or outright loathing, but no this blankness. Maybe it was a clever ploy or the woman had begun to move on. The rest of the meeting would tell. Looking at the royal family, Catra was increasingly pleased that Yarsha was with Entrapta and her family, securely behind house arrest and the bulk of Hordak.

Naturally, the others princesses were also arrayed to either side of the central family. Catra looked to the familiar faces first. Perfuma's unease was palpable, she was shifting in her seat and shooting glances as Scorpia before looking away guiltily. The feline had seen her make a beeline for the seat closest to the scorpioni only to catch her self at the last moment and slump into an empty chair further round the table. Catra hadn't had a chance to speak with her friend but hoped that Perfuma had taken her rather caustic advice. Next to her was Mermista, her features schooled in that practiced expression of indifference that she sold to those around her. It Catra hadn't spent so much of the last six months around the older woman she might have bought it too, but she had long ago learned how to read people's smallest expressions, looking for the threat of harm, it was easy to see the strain around the water princesses eyes and how her jaw was clenched as though she was biting back something. Even her posture was just a little too rigid. Catra was pettily gratified to see that she was not dealing with her betrayal any better than they were.

Heterochromatic eyes skittered over Adora to settle on the last three Princesses sat at the table. She recognised Frosta. The youngest of the princesses still wore the same blank, antagonistic expression that she had as a child on a throne high above a party that she would destroy. It was obviously her leadership face, but she was well practised enough at it that Catra could read nothing beneath her expression. It gave her pause, she would have to speak with Double Trouble about keeping an eye of the tall girl. Then there were the two who she didn't really know, neither of the had come to Oasis and had not invaded their space either. Catra had a vague recollection of them from the battlefield, though she would be hard pressed to say what there powers were, if any. Perhaps they were like Entrapta and not magical? She supposed time would tell, though the glare she was receiving from the shorter one didn't give her hope of them being particularly open minded, though the pink haired one seemed softer hearted if she knew people.

Adora hadn't looked up once since they all took their seats. Catra saw the bowed head and the tense shoulders and jaw and knew

that whatever anger she was feeling radiating out of the group of people opposite her, she was directing just as much at herself.

The scraping of a seat brought her attention back to the queen who was now standing, her height would have seemed intimidating if not for the fact that Catra was best friends with a giant scorpion woman and uncomfortable allies with a hulking former warlord. Queen Angella smoothed her hands down the front of her silken robe before opening them in an expansive gesture designed to show she was sincere before opening the meeting.

"Welcome to this meeting between Brightmoon and the nation of magicats. We are before you as the leaders of the Alliance. Who stands before us?" Queen Angella's voice was refined and each words enunciated with a formality that suited the woman. Catra cast her eyes about, spotting somebody hidden away in a shadowed alcove typing furiously and realised that this meeting was being minuted. The queen really was taking things as serious as she claimed. This was not simply for show.

Before Catra could rise to her feet, Double Trouble took the stage. It rankled a little, but she managed to keep her fur from bristling, certain that the once spy and now consulate politician had a reason for stepping in. All eyes were focused on the black clad figure as they rested their hands on the table and the usual smile faded.

"We greet Brightmoon as one nation made of three parts. We were once Horde, Waste and Magicat. We have built a civilisation where we have come together. My magicat siblings are here in the spirit of hope and understanding. What we are not here for is any sort of inquest into their Chief. Catra has atoned a hundred times over for any of her past indiscretions." A snort and a whispered 'crimes' interrupted the shifter, who paused to raise a weary brow at Frosta who wilted in her seat as she saw the queen also look at her with admonishment in her eyes. "You may call them crimes, none-the-less, she has atoned each day that she had helped build a home for all of the lost and abandoned. They are here to share

their culture with you and try to make you understand the line you have crossed."

Double Trouble seemed gratified with their words and Catra was honestly touched that they had spoken on her behalf. She hadn't needed them to, she still hated when others did for her what she could do for herself, but a whisper in the back of her mind reminded her that it was all right. Tace's ghost was always there to remind her of the good things that she had learned from her; patience, acceptance, gratitude. As the green skinned speaker sat, Catra edged forward in her seat, drawing all eyes in the room to her. She would not stand or she would be standing all day, it was not about disrespect but of practicality. She raised her voice and stepped fully into her role as chief of the magicats.

All through the castle there was palpable tension, from the rooms given to the delegates to the royal quarters. Some it was to be expected, the worry of possible trouble with the delegates, the looming chance that things could still end in war. There was another tension running through the halls though, at the close of the meeting Queen Angella had confirmed that that night there would be a ball in honour of the visiting dignitaries. Apparently it was to show them that they were respected and valued as equals and give them an opportunity to mingle with them on an equal footing and outside of the ceremony of a meeting. The staff in particular were very much preoccupied with the preparations, though from the looks of it they had been informed ahead of time.

Mermista had excused herself as soon as she could from the meeting with the magicats. She had felt uncomfortable under the weight of their gaze. She knew more than one of them by name, having worked with them for days on end to plan the irrigation and dig out ditches and tunnels. It was nauseating to thing that she had been able to be so cold as to help lead an invasion into their land because she was afraid. And it had been fear that had driven her. If Hordak was back, then Selineas and Sturgio were in

danger. That was all that had been in her mind, even while Perfuma had tried to make them see sense.

Hearing the young magicats talk about their home planet, beautiful and peaceful with war and violence left behind them generations ago, only to be driven to hide amongst the stars from a threat bent only on destruction. To know that an entire planet, more than one, had been reduced to rubble and blown out of existence was chilling. It made what had happened during the war pale in comparison.

Images of those row after row of bodies laying cold and dead in the belly of ship that had been designed to save them still haunted Mermista. She would wake up in a cold sweat seeing Sea Hawk and Sturgio dead in that room. She never reached out to her husband after those nightmares, feeling like she had lost that right when she ignored his pleas for her to listen to Perfuma. Her silly sea captain may have started to thaw from his anger, but she still felt wary around him.

It was funny, to know somebody for so long and so well and yet to realise that you had never really pushed them away until now. When they were young and she would fein disinterest in her paramour, he would pout and moan but always come back just as buoyant as always. She hadn't even thought that he could be silent and sullen. It was not a look she liked on him but he had every right to it.

Entering their room, she saw both her boys sitting on the floor with a dice game going on between them. They didn't hear the door and she was treated to the sound of a deep and bawdy laugh coming from Sea Hawk as Sturgio heckled his gaming prowess. They were hers and she had hurt one of them. It was more than she deserved that he had forgiven her her trespass when she couldn't forgive herself. She took in their appearance, both in just baggy pants and bare chested, looking every bit a pair of pirates.

"Hi." She made her voice happy as she spoke, and identical smiles were instantly directed at her, making her almost feel lightheaded.

"Welcome back my love." Sea Hawk had risen to his feet and moved to plant a kiss on her cheek as she noticed the concern in his eyes.

"Mommy!" Sturgio surged towards her and wrapped his arms around her waist before resting his head on her stomach. She moved her hand and cupped the back of his head.

"Family, we have a party to get ready for." Sea Hawk's arm had slipped around her shoulders and she sagged into him.

Adora walked into the great hall with a strange sense of deja vu. The logical part of her brain told her that this was nothing like her first 'Princess Prom', no matter who might be here. Logic told her that she had already attended another of the once a decade All Princess Balls just two years before and nothing of note had occurred. That one had been held in Plumeria, Perfuma pulling out all the stops to create something far different from what she had experienced in the Kingdom of Snows. That had been all about the formality that she had found in the scrolls, and it probably could have been fun, but the rigidity had seemed like a bit of a downer even if the Horde hadn't created it. Plumeria was all about laid back attitudes and doing what makes you feel good. People had still been dressed up but it had been less formal and a lot more sensual. Adora was almost certain that more than one group of the guests had gone off, got high and some other more sensual things in the thick tendrils of foliage that surrounded the glade the Ball was held in. Adora hadn't had the nerve to do the same, fresh off her breakup she had simply enjoyed her friends and watched over the children as they played among the flowers in the small creche by the dance floor.

This ball felt much different. The formality was back, everyone wearing their finery and attempting to look respectable and like

the grown ups that they were. The room was, for now, divided between the visiting delegation and the rest of the party goers. It was an obvious and uncomfortable indicator that it was going to take more than just one day of talks and history lessons to solve the fifth that had been built between them.

Adora moved from the doorway and headed straight for her safe place, the buffet. She could lurk around the long tables, hidden behind the tall displays and stuff herself silly with the delicious treats. She could avoid trouble and only talk to people who knew where to look for her. As she moved she felt the long, cobalt blue skirt swish against her bare legs, drawing her attention to the dress that wrapped around her body. The fit was more than flattering on her athletic frame, highlighting her shoulders and collarbones but keeping her modesty. It had caught her eye in the tailors weeks before her last trip to Oasis and she had asked for it on a whim, almost forgetting about it until the announcement that they would be having a celebration.

Nodding and smiling as she passed by a host of friendly faces, never stopping for small talk, she soon had a plate in her hand and began piling small savoury foods onto it in no particular order. She knew that by the time that the night was over she would have sampled absolutely everything and that her stomach would be pushing against the clingy fabric that covered her stomach and she would be more than ok with that. It was early yet, so most of the guests were stilling mingling in their desperate groups, a few brave souls already filtering onto the dance floor but the food was largely untouched.

Deciding to start at the end and work her way down the table as the night went on she retreated to a secluded corner nearby and started to pop tasty morsel after tasty morsel into her mouth. Over the years her table manners had improved but with nobody watching she was soon stuffing nibbles into her mouth far too quickly. It wasn’t long before her cheeks were puffed out and her plate was almost empty when something small and solid colluded with her knees, startling her and making her start to choke on the

food in her mouth. Without thinking she set the plate on the floor and scoped up her assailant into her arms.

Huge yellow eyes blinked at her, momentarily confused from the collision and then from being swept off of her feet, but soon recognition hit and her pupils blew wide as she wrapped short arms around the humans neck and squeezed as hard as she could, purring furiously. Wanting to put the choked feeling in her throat down to the food that had gone down the wrong way, Adora held the kitten just as tightly as she admitted to herself that she was near tears to be able to hold the precious little girl again. It was something that she thought would never happen again, once she had broken Catra's trust. Honestly, it was more than likely that Yarsha had got away from her babysitters and they would both be in trouble when somebody found them. Adora knew that she should really head straight to the magicats and hand her over, but the selfish part of her wanted to enjoy a hug from somebody who didn't hate her…

This was the biggest room she had ever seen! The ceiling stretched way over head and was covered in pretty lights that twinkled like the stars Aunt Kesh told her she and her Zu had seen when they were small. She and Ra and all of the other people from home had come into the big room and there had been strange music and people shouting out their names and where they came from. It was exciting and scary and overwhelming for the tiny kitten who was positively vibrating at her Ra's side. A big hand landed on top of her head and she leaned into the touch, relaxing as she focused on it. Then she was being held to Ra's side and marked. It was comforting in the strange place and she marked the older magicat right back.

Once her little eyes were accustomed to the light and the sound she squirmed out of the hold and ran off to where she could see her Aunt Kesh and Lonnie talking by a table. Yarsha shouted their names, blissfully unaware of the strangers that were all around, wide eyed as they watched a child run and shout. She clambered up onto one of the white chairs and joined in the conversation to the delight of the woman. They both beamed at her and she felt

warm inside. But she was very young, and got bored quickly. Soon she was leaping off of the chair and over the table, only just aware of her aunt calling her name.

The people dancing were the next thing to catch her eye, but there weren't many and the music was boring and nobody was singing. She thought that they should ask Kyle to come next time so that they could have more fun. Thinking about the lanky blond man made her think about Rogelio and her little tummy growled like Ra. Never stopping she skidded on the floor and made her way to where she could smell food. It smelt strange but she was hungry.

She was moving too fast when she got to the buffet table and her claws scrabbled at the floor to try to stop. Instead she was skidding under the table and barrelling into the corner. Even as young as she was, she knew that hitting a wall was going to hurt a lot so she closed her eyes and braced herself. When she hit something soft with a grunt, she kept her eyes shut. She tried to be brave when she felt herself lifted off of her feet and cracked her eyes open. They went wide when she saw who was holding her and she started to purr as she cuddled Adora around her neck and felt the human hug her back.

She pulled back and put her hands on either side for Adora's face, looking at her thoughtfully. She liked the short hair, it made her look like a dandelion, she had told her that the first time she saw it. Today it looked a little sparkly and her lips were very pink.

"You look different." She had her serious voice on.

"Is it a good different or a bad different?" There was a big smile directed at her and Yarsha felt warm all over at how pretty her big human friend looked.

"You look good different. You's pretty and your eyes are super blue. Your hair is all glittery." Her own face was stretched in a wide smile.

"That's very sweet Yarsha. We should go and find Catra though. I'm sure you're not meant to be over here by yourself." Adora's voice sounded weird and Yarsha didn't like it so she pouted and shook her head. She wanted to hug Adora and Adora would get her snacks because she always snuck her snacks.

"No!" She wrapped her tail around a bare forearm and put one arm around the humans neck, a position she knew made her very hard to dislodge. "Want to see you and want snacks." Adora was silent for a moment so the kitten patted her cheek gently and pointed at the table…

The last time Scorpia or Catra had been at a formal event like this had been in the Kingdom of Snows where they hatched a plan to plant bombs, annoy blonds and kidnap annoying best friends of said blonds. A lot had changed between then and now, though certain people had gone from simply annoying to damn right dangerous. Once again Scorpia was decked out in a beautiful dress, this time curtesy of Phibin, while Catra was wearing something far more elaborate and yet equally as practical as a suit that her stylist friend had put together for her with a little flourish from Double Trouble's theatrically inclined hand. It was similar to what all of the other young magicats were wearing but stood out, setting her apart.

Yarsha had demanded that she come with them, and Catra had capitulated more easily than she should have but she would rather she be with her than not at all times. She figured that surrounded by almost every representative from their home, nobody would be bold enough to touch the child here. Never-the-less, her eyes remained fixed on the little one as she set her down and watched her make a bee-line towards Lonnie and Kesh. Able to relax for a moment, she turned her attention to the frighteningly silent woman at her side.

She stood taller next to Scorpia these days, her head coming past the white haired woman's shoulder, but she was still mostly dwarfed by her, and yet like always, she knew that Scorpia was the more breakable one. She reached out and set a clawed hand

around Scorpia's upper arms and gave her a reassuring squeeze. She still wasn't a hugger, but she was much better at being a supportive friend than she used to be.

"Scorpia, you look beautiful and powerful. You are here as a council member, we all love and trust you. You have nothing to be worried about." She felt a little of the tension leave the other woman but saw the faraway look in her eyes and followed her gaze to where Perfuma was talking to a goat-man across the room. "If you want to go over there, you should go. We just want you to be happy."

Scorpia had told her that they talked that morning, that feelings had been admitted and that nothing had been solved, but it was a start for the two of them. Catra wasn't exactly feeling warm thoughts about the Princess, but she was one of the better ones and she made Scorpia happy, well mostly. She saw Scorpia look torn and didn't want to push her. She patted her bare back over the top of the midnight blue dress and turned her attention fully back to her daughter just in time to see her vault over the table and dart across the dance floor with barely a pause before she was barrelling towards the food table.

Sighing and shaking her head in fond exasperation, Catra started to follow her kitten. She didn't run, well able to keep tabs on her whereabouts. She let out a low laugh as she saw her start to skid under the table and could picture her shocked little face. When she didn't hear a thud, she shifted her gaze further into the corner and saw just what Yarsha had hit.

Adora bent and stood back up with a fluffy bundle of fur and satin in her arms and she watched the interaction as she walked closer. It was heartwarming and heartbreaking all at once for the magicat. As she got closer, still not making her presence known, her sensitive ears were able to pick up their voices. She had to stop another small chuckle as she listened to her daughter tell Adora how pretty she looked, and she did. Even in the dim light of the corner the dress made Adora's eyes almost glow and her hair shone under the lights. The dress emphasised all of the other

woman curves and Catra had to admit that she looked more stunning than she had ever seen. It seemed like Yarsha was as smitten by Adora as Catra had been at that age. Like Ra like Yar, it seemed.

She heard the blond tell Yarsha that she had to take her back and watched the pout spread over the small face and knew that the blond had no idea who was in charge. The kitten did her patented vice-grip and pointed at the food table and she knew that's she needed to intervene before the human stressed out about not returning the child.

"Hey, Adora, what'cha got there?" The tiny scream that left the other woman tore a shrill laugh from the magicat that she couldn't hold back that delighted the little girl between them no end. Around the room, curious and suspicious eyes took in the strange interaction…

Like Catra, Kesh kept a careful watch on Yarsha. She was all she had left of her sister and she was as precious to her as her own child. Sharing space with Catra could be difficult, she was nothing like the adult magicats she remembered and as different from her sister as two people could be but they had slotted together like puzzle pieces and Kesh loved her because of that. The more time she spent with the older magicat, the more she appreciated her odd ways. The more she learned about her life before Oasis the more she pitted her. She understood why Catra rationed out what she was willing to share, knew that she had shared everything with Tace but Tace had held those secrets to her chest as closely as a treasure. There relationship had been beautiful and Kesh hoped that one day she would find a mate like that. Well, maybe less spiky and a lot more jolly.

When Yarsha had run off after her little chat with Lonnie, Kesh had tracked her like she would prey. She knew that Catra's eyes, heck the eyes of all of the magicats, would be glued to the kitten, but she couldn't stop herself. Even if she wasn't her niece, Yarsha was the first born magic ton Etheria, the only one so far, and held

a special place as a symbol of hope and belonging. She was all of theirs.

When the kitten disappeared under the table only to reappear in the arms of one of the traitors, she growled low in her throat, thankful that Lonnie had left to speak with another group and left her alone. She was about to move forward when she saw Catra close by, watching the blond hold her daughter with an inscrutable expression on her face.

Kesh wasn't sure what Yarsha found so fascinating about that one, the other blond princess was equally nice, when they weren't invading and sure the kitten liked Perfuma but with Adora it was something else. There was some draw about the blue eyes woman that made Yarsha always make a dash to her. She would attach herself to her like a limpet and stay with her for as long as she stayed around. Kesh couldn't see it, sure she was attractive, for a furless creature, and nice enough, but she was weird and awkward. Aside from the incursion, Kesh still couldn't see why her niece was so smitten.

Watching Catra finally approach the pair, she heard the little stifled scream from the human from across the room and the laugh that followed it. Her eyes narrowed as she watched Catra leave the child in Adora's arms as she took a plate and put food on it. Her posture was relaxed and they were talking back and forth with Yarsha who looked openly ecstatic to be between the two of them. Whatever it was about Adora that had Yarsha smitten, it seemed like Catra felt it too. Kesh's heckles rose further at the thought…

Chapter End Notes

The ball will continue next chapter.

Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

Everybody tries to get along.

Chapter Notes

A bit of a fluffier one for a change (only a bit mind).

I had a lot of thoughts about Scorpia.

Finding herself still holding a plate up, almost obscuring Adora's still stunned face, so that her wily offspring could select another nibble and stuff it into her mouth (there were almost certainly crumbs, if not worse, in Adora's short hair), Catra couldn't find it in her heart to be angry or even annoyed. The three of them were mostly shielded by their place in the corner and the overloaded food table. She was certain that many eyes were on them, her people's certainly were, they seldom left Yarsha. Her daughter was like a rare treasure to them. One day, she would just be a face in a playground, surrounded by other children smaller than her, but for now she was the only one born here so far.

"Yar-Yar, you really need to let go of Adora now. Remember what we talked about?" She had hoped that Yarsha would nod and jump over to her. She was kidding herself.

Yarsha pushed the mostly empty plate away and snuggled in closer, if it was even possible, to Adora's neck. She began to purr low in her little chest and Catra put down the plate on the nearest corner of the table. She knew that sound, Yarsha had toppled face first into a half full plate of food more than once. That was her daughter's 'food coma' purr. Sure enough, as she watched, Yarsha's yellow eyes became shuttered and her hand fisted in the short hair at the back of Adora's neck. She would bide her time and then peel the little one out of the human's arms. She'd have

to time it just right or Yarsha would wake though, so it seemed that they were stuck together in this odd truce.

"Is she sleeping?" Adora's whisper was comical, as was the way that she was trying to look at something sitting just below her jaw without moving her head. It was a stark contrast to the elegant dress that she was wearing. It was sleek and, Catra could admit, sexy as it hugged all of the human's curves. Thankfully, her dopey expression meant she was still herself. Or the person Catra though she knew at any rate.

"Stop trying to look at her, idiot. You'll wake her up and you do not want angry, overtired kitten. Those claws are tiny but sharp. Let her get a little deeper and I can lift her off of you." Catra moved from her place just in front of the pair to stand next to Adora on the side cradling Yarsha. Both women had their backs to the wall and were able to watch the room while they were pretty much isolated, even as the food table gained more and more traffic.

"I can hold her. She doesn't weigh anything really. I don't mind." Adora sounded excited and flustered in equal measure and Catra felt her heckles start to rise. Just because they had spoken once and Yarsha liked the woman did not mean things were as they had been.

"I do mind." She watched those oh-so blue eyes widen in understanding and had to reach out a hand to stop Adora from slumping and dislodging the child. "Watch it. Look, she likes you a lot. You're great with her. But you didn't give her a second thought when you let them into our home. You can hug her, talk to her, but you chose not to protect her so how can I trust you with her?"

Adora hadn't thought of it like that. Never considered that Catra wasn't just angry for herself and all the magicats. She was right, she had never given Yarsha a thought and yet with the child in her arms she couldn't imagine never being able to talk to or hold her again.

“I know. You have every right to feel that way. I meant what I said last night. I will try to show you that I am sorry. I want us to be friends again.” She wasn’t sure if that was the right thing to say, if she even meant it, when she thought of Catra and Yarsha, all of the magicats, her emotions became something that she didn’t quite understand.

“Is that what we were?” There was an inscrutable quality to Catra’s voice, and for a moment they were standing across form each other, a tank at Catra’s back and a flower behind Adora’s ear. Was Catra talking about now or then? Adora’s head thumped lightly against the wall behind her not wanting to consider either option.

Tense silence fell between them. Neither of them looked at the other, eyes fixed ahead as they watched people of all races come and help themselves to plates of for, seemingly oblivious to the trio in the corner. Catra kept her ears focused on Yarsha, to the cadence of her breaths and the hum of her purr. She tried to ignore that she was able to pick out Adora’s heartbeat too, the familiarity of it from hundreds of nights sleeping close to her almost making her body relax by default. But as pleasant as these surroundings were and as civil as the guests were being, they were in enemy territory and she could not allow that.

Instead, she looked further into the ballroom and noticed a cluster of five children of assorted sized standing with the princesses she didn’t really know. The taller one had an arm wrapped around one’s shoulders and was holding the hand of the child that was obviously the youngest while the white haired princess was kneeling between two of the other kids and waving her finger in the air. They had quite the brood. It was good to see that at least some of these people had made a start at living a life. The fifth child broke away and Catra realised she knew that face.

Sturgio was running pell-mell towards them. Catra had spent enough time with Sea Hawk and Mermista’s little boy to know that like his father, where the boy went chaos would follow. It was impressive that in all the expansive room he had managed to not

only see them, but see Yarsha being held by Adora. That was obviously his goal and he sped through the people near the table, making several jump or scream as they were startled. Catra felt her lips quirk in a smile at him. He, at least, seemed wholly unfazed by events.

The next thing she knew he was popping out from under the table beside them with a whoop which caused Adora to scream for the second time and jolt Yarsha awake. Moving fast, Catra snatched Yarsha away from the tender flesh of a human neck before little claws could sink in and before her tail tensed around her arm again. She held her daughter out in front of her, used to the hissing and thrashing of a kitten awakened too soon. It would pass quickly, but she could live without a scratched face.

"Yarsha! Hey Yarsha!" The voice of the boy beside them broke through Yarsha's tantrum and she froze.

Catra knew that the danger was gone and set the kitten on her feet beside her friend. The little pair smiled bashfully at each other before they jumped into the most aggressive hug she though she had ever seen, although a part of her told her that she had jumped Adora like that a lot when they were that age. Then Sturgio was grasping her hand and hurtling back to where he had started with an equally fast and willing accomplice by his side.

Shaking her head Catra pushed off of the wall, stretching her back with a series of pops. She tried to ignore that she knew Adora was watching her. That was something she was not equipped to deal with. She started to move away without a backwards glance.

"Thanks Catra." Adora's voice sounded sad, but she didn't turn around to confirm it.

"You have crumbs in your hair." She threw it over her shoulder and followed her daughter at a more sedate pace.

Bow tucked Glimmer's hand into the crook of his elbow and smiled down at his wife who trued her face up to meet his gaze and positively beamed back. He hadn't seen her look so happy in a long time, and if he was surprised that she could be so carefree when they were about to mix with people she had felt such extreme hostility to just weeks ago, he didn't show it. He hadn't been part of the mornings meeting, busy collating his weeks of research from the documents Adora had borough back from his fathers' to hand over to the queen, but he hoped that this was a sign that it had gone well and that Glimmer had heard something to help put her mind at ease. Still smiling he pressed a kiss to her forehead and watched a pretty pink blush dust her cheeks, making them almost the colour of her hair.

The pair straightened and turned to the ornate doors. The guards, expressions carefully schooled to blankness, pulled them open to admit them. The royal couple were some of the last to arrive, the hall already buzzing with people talking and laughing, the division between Oasis and Brightmoon obvious but not as distant as he might have feared, some were starting tentative conversations with strangers and it warmed him. Glimmer had made them late fussing over which dress to wear. It was an obvious show of weakness, her nervousness obvious and he knew that she would not show that to anyone but him. Patting the hand on his arm reassuringly, they walked down the stairs at the side of the room to the sound of their names being announced loudly by the herald.

All eyes were on them now, absently he noticed that the King and Queen were also yet to arrive and felt relieved that they were not the last and that whatever scrutiny they were under would move to his in-laws sooner rather than later. He wasn't naive enough to believe that was true, even from the distance between the bottom of the stairs and where the delegates were he could see the glowers being directed at them. Well, at his wife. He wanted to step forward and thrust her behind him and absorb all that anger, but he wasn't a boy anymore. It wasn't his place to try to take the weight of her sins, just to be there to help her repent for them.

Rather than entering the fray, Bow guided them to an area of the room where he could see friendlier faces, Glimmer making no word of protest as they moved. Frosta greeted them warmly, though without the usually cheekiness she threw at the older woman. He had seen that she had pulled away since everything happened and wasn't sure whether is was because she blamed Glimmer of herself for everything. With her were two other dignitaries from the Kingdom of Snows that the royal couple knew in passing and soon the group was talking comfortably if a little superficially.

Bow started to laugh at something the lord had said when he was the group of children that had taken over the still sleepy dance floor as a more upbeat song began to play. He recognised a couple of them as some of Netossa and Spinerella's longest standing foster children, while the others were fairly new arrivals that they had not met yet. The older princesses always had a brood these days of children ranging anywhere in age from six to seventeen. As his gaze lingered, and the familiar longing filled him, he watched as Sturgio emerged from the small group and ran to the edge of the room at the breakneck speed of a child, arms flailing and head throw back. It was such an innocent action that it made Bow's resolve to help forge a lasting peace even stronger, none of these children should have to know war in their lifetimes.

He was brought back into the conversation by Glimmer reaching for his hand and tugging on his fingers, but he kept shooting glances at where the little prince had disappeared, curious to see what the rambunctious boy was up to. He was caught up in a story about some escaped livestock, which was admittedly hysterical, when he watched Sturgio round the table hand-in-hand with a smaller child.

A smaller, darkly furred little girl wrapped in a sunny coloured velvet dress with tiny bows hanging at the end of the braids that wound through her mane of hair. Bow couldn't have kept track of the conversation after that if he tried, he didn't think he had ever seen anything so cute in his entire life. He knew he had heart

eyes and the pleased squeak that leaked out of him would have embarrassed him had he noticed the shocked looks on his companions faces. Fortunately he was too busy looking at how the kitten ran jumped to stay with her friend.

"Thats so cute!" It burst out of him before he could hold it back, and now he realised that the others were looking at him like he had lost his mind, while Glimmer's eyes were fixed on the children.

"Oh, yes, we saw that they brought some offspring with them." The snooty tone of the tusked speaker made Bow narrow his eyes and turn to him.

"Of course they have, trying to pretend that they're harmless." Another voice broke in, this time far more familiar and he felt his hopes for change fading.

Glimmer was still watching the kitten as Sturgio introduced her to the group of children that were cared for by Netossa and Spinerella. He studied his wife study the scene, hunting for any of the softness in her eyes that he felt when he looked at the small, energetic bundle. There was none. At least the malice that she had directed that way when they had first seen the girl in Oasis seemed to be absent. He just wished her words were less incendiary. He glanced around, relieved that none of the Oasis people had made it this far yet so that the words had not been overheard.

"I'm sure that her mother just wanted to keep her close, dear." The voice came out of nowhere, casual to the untrained ear but full of censure for those in the know. Glimmer visibly wilted.

Bow wasn't sure how he had missed the arrival of the king and queen, their entrance must have been heralded, yet here they were, just behind the younger group. The people they had been talking to gushed over the monarchs, telling them about themselves and how honoured they were to have been invited. Queen Angella allowed them to chitter away at her for a while

with a smile before asking to be excused to talk with her daughter. The others all but tripped over themselves to do her bidding. Bow would have laughed, if he wasn't watching his wife so intently.

"Glimmer, dear, we're supposed to be finding a common ground tonight. You know, building bridges, not sewing seeds of doubt about our guests." It was always fascinating to watch how these two women interacted. They loved each other beyond reason but there was a weight of expectation on both sides. Bow noticed that Micah was looking at them with an expression similar to what he imagined was on his own.

Bow liked Glimmer's father, he was a fun guy to be around. Fun, until you saw the flintiness that could come into his eyes. He had a power at his fingertips that Bow could hardly comprehend for all his scientific smarts. He knew that Micah would not hesitate to use it against anyone he saw as a threat to his family, to Angella, and sometimes Bow wasn't sure that didn't include the threat that Glimmer could be however unwittingly.

"Sorry mother, it just slipped out. I will try harder for the rest for the night. I promise I am here ready to learn all I can about them all." Bow could hear the truth over her words and relaxed.

"I am glad to hear it." The four of them settled into a brief conversation before Bow was once again looking at the dance floor, watching as Catra picked up her daughter and threw her, screaming with laughter, high into the air before catching her with ease inches from the floor. She did it a second time and Bow saw that Micah was watching too, those wise eyes twinkling.

Bow noticed that Catra's clothes were different to what he had seen the other magicats around the room wearing. The others were all in long tunics or wrapped in swathes of fabric. Each one wearing a bright colour in their loose fitting garments. They were sumptuous and spoke of a world of elegance and comfort. A place lost to them. The kitten was dressed in a dress that Bow might have seen any little girl in Etheria sport and it was very sweet.

Catra's clothes were different. Her top was cut into panels, wrapping her torso and fastened with wide straps at the shoulders. It was tooled from thin leather and a stark, white shirt sat beneath. A kilted skirt made from dozens of leather panels hung to her knees and her feet were wrapped in the same leather. It was impressive in a subdued way.

"That is one adorable little girl." His voice had a soothing timbre when it was laced with mirth.

"Isn't she?" He watched as the other children, of various sizes, surrounded the magicat and tugged on her tunic, their intent clear.

"That one, she doesn't seem like the stories that I have read and heard from the war. Certainly not the villain that Glimmer has described her as." He turned those knowing eyes on his son-in-law, seeing the way he was watching the children with open longing.

"No." Bow watched as she next picked up Sturgio and sent him airborne, catching him easily. "No, she doesn't."

Scorpia had always seen herself as something of an oaf. She was likeable and well meaning, and of course gave great hugs, but she was not poised or delicate. She had grown large and bulky well before her peers and been pushed by a well meaning instructor to become a force captain even though her temperament was not really cut out for it. It was why it had been so easy for her to believe the indoctrination she had received as a child that she would never be accepted as a princess. None of the others were hybrids after all, and if she couldn't even fit in, in the place where she was raised what hope did she have of anything else. When Perfuma had told her they were done, all of that childhood insecurity that she had always hidden behind her bright facade had oozed to the top.

Moving across the ballroom, she felt just as much the sore thumb as always, ironic for somebody with none. She had to fight the desire to say, ‘sorry’ or ‘pardon me’ every time she passed to close to somebody in the room. She knew they were looking at her as a member of Oasis, not gawking at her but she couldn’t shake the feeling. She didn’t want to put on her Horde persona, she enjoyed not waking up and having to push down her insecurities and plaster a smile to her face to survive, but she felt that too-big smile starting to creep across her face despite her best efforts.

It wasn’t a long walk, but the closer she got to where Perfuma stood with her back towards her, the further away she seemed to be. She had been watching her from across the room as the flower princess moved from groups to group, talking animatedly and reaching out in that disarming way she had that drew people to her. Scorpia noticed that she was the first person to approach one of her people, walking to Lonnie and beginning a conversation that, though it looked uncomfortable, did not end in aggression. It was a start. Seeing her break the ice had seemed to spur other people on to approach them and now there was a lighter feel around the place, though naturally the strain remained. With things seeming more relaxed, Scorpia had decided to do as Catra suggested, especially after she had had seen the cat woman talking calmly with Adora. If she could try to reconnect with somebody who had hurt her so badly, Scorpia certainly could.

Then she was standing behind the other tall woman, close enough to touch but hesitant to interrupt the conversation between two goat people, a magicat and several humans. It was why they had come here after all. They were supposed to be integrating. She was on the council, she should be moving around the room and doing the same, not mooning over her ex-maybe-not-ex-girlfriend. Already turning away, she wasn’t prepared to feel the long fingered hand wrap around her upper arm. She stilled instantly, almost frozen to the spot, not turning or breathing. All sound from around the room, the voices, the laughter, the clink of glasses and plates all disappeared to be replaced by the sound of her own breathing.

Then Perfuma was in front of her, a hand now holding either arm. Perfuma had learned quickly that one of the reasons that Scorpia liked hugs so much, other than being the most affectionate person that she had ever met, was that it allowed her to feel the other person. Very few people ever took the time to think about Scorpia's claws, beyond the fact that they looked dangerous and could break through almost anything. Perfuma had thought about them a lot. Life was made more difficult for Scorpia because of them and she overcame that every day with a smile. What she couldn't overcome was the limited feeling in them through the thick barrier of her shell. She hugged to feel more. Perfuma took her by the arms so that she could feel the warmth of her touch, the texture of her skin and the gentleness that she deserved.

"Scorpia, you look beautiful." Perfuma's thumbs rubbed gently at skin that was pebbled with gooseflesh from the touch, feeling her heart bloom. The scorpioni truly did look lovely, the dark blue of the dress made her hair glow while the fabric clung to her body like a river of silk. The straps were an array of braided coils that criss-crossed her chest and wound around her neck to leave her back bare down to her stinger. "Just exquisite." Those words came out breathlessly as she moved forward into Scorpia's space, drawn like a magnet to the blushing woman.

"You look lovely too." Scorpia was pleased when her voice didn't break. A part of her was screaming to step back, that she shouldn't be enjoying the feel and closeness of the woman who had so recently broken her heart in two but she just couldn't. Perfuma was wearing a shift dress, similar in style to the dresses she usually wore but strapless, showing off her lean, broad shoulders and her hair was curled around her face, with tendrils coiling around her face. If Scorpia had hands she would bury them in her hair, wind the hair between her fingers…but she didn't, so she couldn't. Melancholy must have shown on her face, because then Perfuma was touching her face, raising her chin so that their eyes could meet.

"I know that we have a lot to discuss, and maybe things won't be the same again, but I love you and you look wonderful and we're

at a ball and would you like to dance with me?" She didn't know where the words or the resolve came from, but Scorpia was taking a chance. She didn't have to wait for a response as long arms wrapped around her neck and she was holding the other woman in her arms as they hugged each other.

Perfuma broke away and took one of Scorpia's pincers in her hand wand led her to the dance floor. It was a much less formal affair than at the Princess Prom, as she had heard others refer to it during the course of the evening, people were dancing in couples or groups but nothing was choreographed. Yarsha was running around, jumping up and down with some other children, Catra standing to the side of the dance floor keeping watch, throwing a suave salute and a wink to her as she was pulled further to the centre by the Princess of Plumeria. As they two moved into each others arms, Scorpia let herself notice that Adora was standing just a little way from her old friend, trying to look like she was talking to other people even while her eyes were trained on the woman watching her daughter. Scorpia didn't have time to think about that because Perfuma's head was resting on her shoulder and there was warm breath on her neck and hands on her back. There was only room for her to think about that.

Varga had always been a solid sort. His parents used to laugh that he was the most serious kitten in all the world. When the others would run and play he would spend his time carving the fallen boughs of trees into tiny bowls and spoons for his sisters dolls. As he grew up, he became more fun as all youths do, always quick with a quip and his deep laugh, but still he was ever thoughtful. He had been one of the few not crying for revenge when Catra assembled them. He saw her reasoning and agreed wholeheartedly, they were in no way prepared for war and he had been old enough when Prime came not to want to live through the chaos a second time. They may not have seen fighting but they knew distraction all too well.

He stood with Lonnie, his impressive bulk comforting to her as it felt like having Rogelio at her side, and found that these Etherian's weren't so bad. They were a little judgemental and overly effusive, perhaps a little enthusiastic for his taste but he could deal with that. They were nothing like the natives that he lived with. As he continued to listen, ears lazily swivelling to capture snippets of conversations going on around them, his eyes drifted to the dark skinned human beside him.

Lonnie was nothing like these others. She might look like the other humans, but everything else about her was different. Maybe it was that she had been brought up in the Fright Zone? They had all heard enough stories from there to feel ever more protective of the former occupants, especially these young adults who had grown up with their Chief.

Varga had been old enough, like Tace, Phibin, and a handful of others, at eighteen to vividly remember their home-world. They had all grown up surrounded by nature, much like the woods that that they had travelled through to get there, but even more verdant. The air had been warm and damp, keeping the plants lush and the crops plentiful. They had everything they needed to live with the nature around them, far more than these people who built their castle to stand out and overshadow the nature around it. They'd inhabited the trees, living in canopies so large that whole villages existed in only one. It was something that he remembered fondly and longed for often, they were not meant to be confined to the ground. From the stories that he had heard, sparing as they may be, Catra had found her place off the group by traversing the most risky and rickety heights that the Fright Zone had to offer. He wondered how the young humans and lizard-kin had found their instincts satisfied in that lifeless place.

He was just about to chip in some more to the conversation, interest piqued by the idea of eating sea grown vegetables, something that he had no experience with and already his mind was spinning with ideas for trade if things went to plan, when his ears picked up the subtle rustle of Lonnie's clothing. He looked back to her and noticed that her shoulders had tensed and her

expression had lost its light, hardening into a mask. He looked at their companions and they were still chattering away, clearly not noticing the change in her demeanour. Making eye contact with her he tried to communicate a question, they were acquaintances through Catra, Tace and Kesh, but not close friend, but she read his loud and clear. She shot her eyes and he followed the move and caught the sight of the Brightmoon princess and her husband making their way towards them through the crowds having finally taken the courage to break away from their own.

Varga leaned down and whispered in her ear, careful to pitch his voice loud enough for human ears (many times he had whispered to a human only to realise they could not hear him with their inferior hearing) yet low enough to not be overheard. "What do you want to do?" The couple were almost with them now and there was no doubt that they were their intended target.

"We see what they want and mind what we say." Lonnie didn't bother turning into is ear, she breathed it out under her breath while smiling as the rest of their group decided to move on and mingle with others as they too noticed who was approaching.

"Hi, Lonnie isn't it? We met when we first discovered Oasis?" The husband, Bow (Varga had read his dossier, meticulously put together by Scorpia and the Chief), sounded genuinely sincere as he neared and held out his hand in the gesture that meant that he wanted her to take it. It was an odd thing to do, the tall cat always thought, but with their muted senses he imagined their greetings would seem equally strange. After a rather reserved handshake from Lonnie, unperturbed he turned to the magicat. "Hi, I'm Bow. I'm one of the royal advisors. I don't think we met?" His hand was now thrust out towards the magicat. Varga didn't want to cause and incident so took the proffered limb and shook gently, careful to mind his claws, not ignorant to the fact that the princess was watching all this coldly and had yet to say a word.

"A pleasure to meet you, Bow. I am Varga, as you can see I am part of the Magicat group and when we are home, in Oasis, I am a civil engineer." Or something very like it anyway. "And who is

this with you? I don't believe we've met?" He turned the other man's words back, not to be cruel but simply to highlight the woman's silence. Lonnie could not, or would not, engage the woman, her own expression equally glacial. It looked like he would be doing all the heavy lifting here. He wondered where Phibin was when he needed him.

Glimmer had no choice but to step forward, a lifetime of royal protocol being drilled into her not letting her do anything but. It was all she could do not to roll her eyes at the tall, intimidating magicat. Of all of those in the room, this one with his broad barrel chest and clearly exposed muscles in his arms and legs, voice deep in a way that was almost hypnotic, this magicat looked the most dangerous. It was a lie, of course, the must dangerous magicat in the room was currently talking and laughing with her mother as though they were old friends, while her father took the liberty of clapping her on the back. It was chaffing at the pink haired woman but she would not be shown up here, in her own home. She could schmooze and look just as benign as the next despot. She was not here to show her hand.

"I am sure that you know me, Varga is it? I imagine you saw us at the crater and I extend and apology to you and all your people for intruding on your sacred place." It was a scripted admission, one she had crafted and would roll out to all of those she spoke with in this room. It's what they wanted to hear, she was sure if she looked honest enough, and said it with enough feeling they would believe it.

"You are right Princess, I should be more forthright." Varga's ears were pressed close to his head, and if either of the humans before him knew magicat body language they would have known something was not sitting right with him. But they didn't. Before he could speak again, a pair of white hands landed on his and Lonnie's shoulders, easing them apart so that another body could squeeze between them.

"Your apology is welcome, Princess Glimmer, though of course some things are not so easily healed with pretty words." Phibin, as

though called by Varga's thoughts, took change of the interaction, one hand falling away from Varga's shoulder, while the other slid down Lonnie's arm and looped with hers. "I hope that it can be a first step between us." Glimmer and Bow exchanged a look at this poised and eloquent male, decked out in sparkling robes over his husky frame that made him look appear just as regal as they were, it was a far cry from what their actual leader had chosen. Phibin saw and extended his own hand, "Phibin. I oversee magicat affairs in Oasis and am a hell of a tailor." He laughed jovially and Bow and Varga joined him, Glimmer shook the preferred hand and Lonnie excused herself.

As the human woman began to walk off, Varga noticed her be swept into the arms of one of the younger Brightmoon men who were dancing and pulled into some kind of reel. He half expected her to deck him, but was pleased to see her smile at something he said and let herself be shown the steps. They were here to show that they were not who these people thought they were, after all. He turned his full attention back on the interaction at hand only to see that Glimmer, too, was smiling and starting to laugh at one of Phibin's delightfully delivered stories. Soon they were joined by a cluster of people from both worlds. Though the princess never once looked comfortable, maybe it was a start.

Under the cover of darkness hours after the ball had drawn to a close, with the castle sound asleep, far inkier tendrils than the night raced down the corridors. They oozed like living things, flowing and surging in their haste to reach their master. Nothing stood in their way as they breached doors and flew past windows. Surreptitiously placed guards, some heads nodding on their watch, remained oblivious to the hive of activity that swept passed them, disturbing not even the air.

The closer they surged to their destination, the quieter and darker the halls became until the various fingers of shadow were able to converse into an amorphous dark that smashed through the final set of doors at the end of the hall. This time they swung open,

revealing a room as eerily silent as the dark messengers. For days they had been away from the heart of their darkness and now, like an embrace, the wrapped around the woman who had birther them to life, absorbing through her skin until they were once again whole.

Shadow Weaver, maskless in the night, threw her head back in ecstasy as her body embraced the intrusion. All of the secrets stolen by her minions converging in her mind. Everything she could want of desire to know from the last two days there for the taking. It would take ours to order them, work through what was important and what was not but here, in this room, she was not likely to be disturbed. For now her little visitor was more lucid than she had left her in some time and sure to be amply distracted by current events. Shadow Weaver could live up to her name and find out anything she wanted to know.

Come morning she would send out her tendrils again for a new slew of insights but for now, fully restored she sat down before her scrying bowl and began to gracefully draw runes about its surface, making the liquid in the purloined silver vessel roil and churn until the suddenly stilled without a ripple as words images began to play out before her eyes.

Chapter 20

Chapter Summary

A run, an invitation and a revelation.

Yawning so wide that her jaw clicked, Catra gently patted the back of the sleepy little ball resting on her chest. Yarsha had a habit, when she was exhausted, of migrating on top of her and then making herself into a tiny ball and purring like a chainsaw. It was adorable but made it a little hard to breath. The purring by her ear almost drowned out the snuffling snores of the other person in the bed. Kesh was a good friend and sister but made for a pretty annoying bedmate. Yawning again, stretching with one arm while the other held the kitten still, she turned her head to look out of the window that spanned the wall from floor to ceiling, leading out to the balcony. It was clearly still early, the daylight hazy yet, but even though she had been up late at the ball, her body was buzzing.

Delicately she wrapped both arms around her daughter and rolled her back onto the mattress. Rolling back, she got out of bed and walked out onto the balcony to take a deep breath of the moist morning air. It was nothing like waking in their desert home, where the air was warm and dry even after the terraforming, though eventually it would be more like this. Catra pounced up onto the balustrade, legs hanging over into the void and looked out, eyes not settling on any one thing, just enjoying the silence.

Ears twitching, she listened for any sign of life in the rooms around her, but there was nothing but the chirp of birds and the gentle rustle of wind through the trees. Zoning out, her mind drifted to the events of the day before. The initial meeting with the dignitaries had gone well, though she knew that they had a lot more questions for her and her people. Brightmoon had been true to its word and her people, all of them bar Hordak, were free to roam wherever they pleased and the ball had been an

unprecedented success as far as she had seen. There would need to be a debrief though.

The thought made her sigh, it had been late when the party broke up, no-one feeling like they could be the first to leave without causing an incident. Jumping back down onto the balcony floor, she moved back into the room to pull her coms from her bag and took it back outside. She sent a message to Double Trouble, pretty sure that the perennial party person would already be awake and bright eyed, getting a confirmation response that they would convene a meeting. Letting the device sit on the seat that was on the balcony, she retook her seat, this time swinging her feet.

Distantly the gentle rhythm of running footsteps filtered up to her. She turned her head to where it was coming from and found herself looking at Adora, clad in workout clothes, running alongside the edge of the area that had been assigned to them, clearly trying not to trespass as she had the previous day. From her vantage, Adora was small but her hair shone in the early morning light and Catra could see that rather than the serene look she had always worn when they worked out as kids, she looked pensive.

Glancing over her shoulder, back into her room, she saw that Yarsha mad migrated to Kesh's chest and both dark cats were snoring up a storm, with no sign that they would wake anytime soon. Making a decision, she quickly grabbed a shirt and pants from a drawer and threw them on before stepping off of the balcony and performing a controlled fall into the underbrush. She hit the ground running, easily catching up to the woman on the other side of the imagined borderline.

Catra's bare feet were silent on the sod as she paced the other woman. Adora hadn't noticed her, it felt almost as though she was hunting the other woman, and maybe she was. Her mind couldn't help but flash back to their childhood in the Fright Zone, hiding from each other as the other sought them out. Watching the blond's every move and bouncing on her for any kind of touch

that was not a punishment. The thought brought her up short, letting the taller woman pull away.

Why was she following her? That had been a long time ago and she no longer needed that from Adora. She was surrounded by people who loved, respected and honoured her. She had known real love, the kind that you feel for someone and see reflected back. Adora had been an idol, something to worship and lavish her affection on, however rough it may have been, that had never been reciprocated the same way. Sure, they had been friends and she knew that the blond had cared but not as she had wanted. Now they were grown, still possibly enemies, and she found herself falling into patterns that were unhealthy now as they had been then.

Grumbling to herself, blaming the way that Adora had been with the sleeping Yarsha last night on making her emotions so jumbled, she turned on her heel and was about to wonder over to a tall tree when she heard a thud followed by an 'oof' that she would know anywhere. Exasperated she found herself jogging in the direction that the sound had come from.

Sure enough, emerging from the bushes, she could see Adora sitting inelegantly on the floor, legs splayed and a hand pressed to her face, over her eye. Sighing gustily, catching the prone woman's attention at last, she tried to ignore the sheepish smile that was thrown her way. She stormed towards her and harshly pulled the hand away, seeing that the covered eye was red, the skin around it puffy heading quickly towards what was likely to become a hell of a shiner, but thankfully nothing was cut of bleeding."How?" There was no need to elaborate as Adora pointed over her shoulder and Catra followed the finger to see a low branch sticking out of an others well manicured tree and huffed. "You're an idiot."

"I know." Adora's face had fallen into a sullen pout and Catra almost laughed at how much she resembled a seven year old with her short hair rumpled and her face red. She didn't though. Years of parenting had let her develop the iron will you needed not to

laugh at things which were simultaneously naughty but also hysterical.

"C'mon, you should go and ice that." Catra reached down and hauled the other woman to her feet. It felt strange, when she had done this when they were teens Adora had always been significantly heavier than her and a little taller, now it was easy to pull the blond up. Catra was more worried that she would make her stumble from being too forceful, the two of them coming eye to eye as Adora did lose her footing a little and fall into her. Catra's hands shot up to both the other woman's shoulder to steady her but also, obviously, to push her away which made the still lingering pout deepen.

"I'll heal it when I get back to my room. Don't want anyone thinking the Chief magicat decked me." Adora's voice was joking, obviously trying to defuse the weird tension that was forming between them.

It didn't work. Catra's body tensed and she took a big step back from her childhood friend, a deep frown now marring her face, ears down and mouth twisted in a slight sneer. Adora ran through what she had said that could make the woman go from grumpily comfortable to this and froze. Of course Catra would baulk at the idea of her healing wounds using She-ra and her being to blame. If her face hadn't stung so much the blond would have slapped herself for putting her foot in it again. It was easy to forget that her relationship with Catra was no relationship at all.

"I didn't… I down't mean…"

"Save it, Adora. I'll see you around." She was gone in a second, though the hedge and away like a ghost and Adora was left, still. Trying to stumble out an apology, for what exactly she wasn't sure.

Arriving back in her room, this time through the door, Catra started to strip off the shirt that she had thrown on, when a piece of paper on the floor in front it caught her eye. She stooped to pick it up, the thickness and weight of it unfamiliar. This wasn't just a hastily scribbled note by Lonnie or Scorpia, then. Turning the envelope in her hand, she saw the ornate seal holding it closed and knew that it was something far more formal than that.

Quietly grabbing some more fitting clothes, she made her way to the bathroom and closed the door behind her before slicing open the the heavy gauge paper with a claw and pulled out the equally fine paper inside, folding it to find a hand written note, the penmanship beautiful and reminiscent of the statuesque woman who had penned it. It was a simple, brief missive. An invitation to breakfast for herself and Yarsha with the older royals. She turned the paper, making sure that she had not missed anything, but that was all. Would she and her daughter like to breakfast alone with the king and queen?

Her mind whirled as she thought about what the angle could be. Yarsha would be with her so her safety was assured and she had not sensed any hostility from Angella or Micah. If anything, the older members of the Alliance seemed as tired as she felt about events. The previous night, they had moved around the room and spoken to all of the delegates and their own people with equal warmth and friendliness. When they had approached her on the sidelines of the dance-floor, watching her daughter have fun with the other children, she had been surprised by how open and friendly they had been. The king had even made a joke, clapping her on the back as the two women had laughed.

Seeing that the invitation was for in a half hour, she completed her morning routine quickly, pulling on a purple outfit today, before entering the main room far more noisily and seeing Yarsha stir while Kesh simple flopped onto her stomach and started to snore even more vigorously. Walking over, she pulled back the sheets and gathered the now yawning and squirming kitten into her arms, walking them both over to the dresser and then the

bathroom. By the time she placed the little one onto the edge of the vanity, she was blinking owlishly up at her and softly smiling.

"H'llo Ra." She held her little arms up, making gabby hands and Catra laughed softly, leaning down for a hug and a sloppy kiss on her cheek before they rested their foreheads together.

"Morning, Fuzzy-Butt." The little body slumped into hers and she stroked one of her pointed little ears.

It always made her feel happy that Yarsha was so much more like Tace than her. Yarsha was far darker than the chestnut fur that covered most of her own body, even with the patches of it that peppered her body. Her velvety ears were also smaller than Catra's had ever been. Tace had teased her about just how big her ears were, and it used to make her feel shy before Tace would kiss them and tell her they were beautiful. Seeing her mate in their daughter reminded her that Tace was not completely gone.

Not wanting to fall into melancholy she asked Yarsha if she would like to go and have breakfast with the king and queen. She's needn't have worried that the child would say no. Yarsha cheered and flapped her hands in excitement, raising her arms above her head to let Catra pull her sleep shirt off. Laughing at the antics of this little beast, she proceeded to help her clean her teeth and brushed her fur and tidied her hair. Pulling a soft blue t-shirt over her head, watching her ears ping out from the neck as it settled, she pressed another kiss there. Then she slipped the girl into darker blue dungarees that Phibin had made specially for her, popping her tail out through the hole.

Satisfied that the two of them looked appropriately like the head magicat and her daughter, Catra took Yarsha by the hand and made their way to the door, breakfast time fast approaching. She opened the door, letting Yarsha pull her out. Before she left, a cheeky smile covered her face as she looked back at the lump of her sister on the bed.

“Bye Kesh!” She shouted it loudly hearing a growl before slamming the door in time to hear something smack into the other side.

Laughing, to the surprise of the guards stationed at intervals in the corridors, she let Yarsha drag her a little ways before realising that they didn’t know where they were going. Crouching down and whispering in the child’s ear, she watched her run up to the nearest guard and smile winningly up at the tall, helmeted figure. She was proud to see that her girl was not shy even when the guard looked quite menacing.

“Es-scuse me.” Small fingers reached out and tugged the long robe of the guard who looked down, puzzlement clear even under the helmet.

“Yes?” The female voice that emerged was low and confused.

“Ra and me are goin’ to see the fairy queen lady. Do you know where she is?” Catra felt herself laughing again at Yarsha’s description of Queen Angella.

The helmet turned to Catra, and now she could see green eyes narrowed at her through the eye-holes. She nodded to confirm what the child was saying and the guard nodded, turning back to the child though clearly addressing her parent as detailed instructions were given. It seemed that the royal suit was clean across the other side of the castle.

“Fankoo!” Yarsha moved forward quickly, causing the guard to tense and grasp their staff more tightly instinctively, only to instantly relax when small arms wrapped around one of the legs and they were hugged tightly and released just as quickly as the little one skipped back to take her parents hand. Catra saw a small smile sweep across the unconcealed lips and let Yarsha drag them away.

Before long the two of them were facing a pair of the most ornate doors that they had seen in the castle so far. Two more guards

stood on either side, moving their staffs to cross over the entrance as the pair approached. Standing tall before them, Catra thrust out the invitation to the one on the right who passed the eyes over it before nodding. The blocking poles were removed and Catra allowed Yarsha to be the one to pound on the door excitedly. It took no time for the doors to be opened, revealing Queen Angella dressed in more floaty silk robes, wings folded at her back.

Before the woman could greet them, Yarsha rushed towards her, this time foregoing and leg hug and instead doing and impressive leap into the angels wide open arms, throwing her arms around her neck. Angella looked stunned, arms quickly coming around to grasp the child for fear of her falling back to the ground. Catra shook her head ruefully, realising that Yarsha was going to do what Yarsha was going to do, and walked forward into the room herself.

"Good morning, your majesties." She saw that Micah was also standing by the door as he moved to close them. His face was split into a sad smile as he looked at his wife cradling the toddler who was babbling at her excitedly as Angella listened and nodded where appropriate, a soft expression on her face that Catra thought she was probably never intended to see.

"Thank you for accepting our invitation. The queen and I enjoyed talking with you at the ball last night and though that a more informal, low stakes environment might make answering some of our questions a little easier for all sides." Micah warm, perpetually amused sounding voice met her ears as the short man walked around to usher them all into the comfortable dining room off of the main foyer of the suit.

"I was surprised to receive your invitation, but clearly my daughter has decided that you are all right so who am I to argue. I cannot say anything on behalf of Oasis, or the magicats, that may be used against them." Her tone was light, but her tone was serious as they all sat around the beautifully set table in the centre of the room. Yarsha heard her parent's tone and clambered

down from the tall woman's arms and latched onto her leg, looking up with big eyes.

"Of course, of course. Our intent is not to trick you into anything. We are curious about your culture and wanted to talk about it in a place where things do not have to lead back to life and death." Queen Angella's strangely accented voice was completely sincere and Catra found herself relaxing just a little, smiling down at the kitten to reassure her before lifting her onto a seat and taking the one next to her.

"Then I accept your invitation. Yarsha and I will do the best we can to answer any questions you have, though you would probably been better off asking Phibin or Kesh here. They know a lot more than I do." As she spoke she was unsurprised to see Queen Angella take the seat on her daughter's other side while Micah sat opposite the child.

"I won't lie to you, Chief Catra, your daughter may have had a lot to do with this invite." Micah pulled a face that set Yarsha into fits of giggles and Catra appreciated that the man was trying to put them both at ease.

"She has that affect on people, don't you Yar-Yar?" The little one merrily chirped, eyes straying to the food that was in the centre of the table as a pink tongue licked her lips. "The first thing that I can tell you is that you don't need to call me chief, that title only exist between magicats." She could build bridges.

Her eyes widened as she watched Queen Angella take Yarsha's plate and put a little of each of the foods on the table onto it. As she reached for one chafing dish, Catra found herself reaching out and gently staying the other woman hand. "Sorry, no grapes. They don't agree with us." It was warming that all she received was an acknowledging smile rather than that hand puling away.

"Well, that's two things that we have learned about your people already." Queen Angella passed the plate to the kitten and received a head-butt to the arm in thanks.

“You don’t have to call us King and Queen either at least in private, you aren’t a resident of Brightmoon after all and here we can speak as equals.” Micah was reaching for the bowl of scrambled eggs that were in front of her and she passed it to him with a smile. It was odd but she felt like she did when she, Tace and Yarsha would eat with Kesh, like part of a little family.

“Well, as equals, ask away. I only know so much though. I grew up like Adora, without even any idea of the rest of Etheria was really like, let alone a world beyond. Most of what I know, I have learned in a decade of studying old records and listening to much wiser people than me.” She finished and reached out for some fish that had caught her eye on the table. She took two and cut a little off of one, placing it alongside the other food on Yarsha’s plate. The little girl grinned and went to grab it with her fingers. “Fork Yar-Yar.”

“Otay Ra!” The words were a little garbled through the mouthful of potatoes already in her mouth, but table manners were a work in progress so she would take her using cutlery as a win. That she could hear both the other people at the table gently laughing at her daughters antics told her they were more charmed than disgusted.

“I have noticed that she calls you that. Does it have a meaning, or is it a shortening of your name?” Angella’s voice was light, just somebody talking to a new acquaintance.

“I was curious too.” Micah joined his wife in looking expectantly at her while they ate their own food. It made her relax more as she saw that as refined as the queen was, the king was shovelling food into his mouth as though he was afraid it would be taken away. She knew that feeling.

“Ra? No, it isn’t the end of my name, though that would be cute. In my culture we do not have gendered titles for a child’s care givers. Instead of mother and father we have Zu and Ra. Zu is the parent that the child physically resembles the most, usually kittens will take fur colour from one parent and that is the Zu. Ra means

that she just looks a little less like me. The names can be given to either gender.” She took a bite of her fish savouring the smokey flavour, certain that she knew what the newt question would be.

“The young woman sharing your room, is that Yarsha’s Zu then?” Catra almost choked on the food in her mouth as the idea of Kesh being her mate flashed through her mind. It was ludicrous, they would kill each other.

“No, Kesh is not my mate.” She managed to splutter out, but Yarsha had decided to tune in to the conversation and piped up.

“My Zu is dead.” It was very matter of fact and left both Angella and Micah with their mouths hanging open at such a small child blurting that out.

“Yes she is, Yar-Yar. Good girl.” The kitten beamed up at her Ra and turned back to her food.

Catra’s mismatched eyes looked up from her daughter and met the sympathetic gaze of the tall woman. She seemed to recall that there had been no king when they were at war. Something about him dying in the first conflict when she was a child. It clearly hadn’t been true, but the queen had obviously thought that he had been for some time.

“You don’t need to discuss it with us.” Micah was reaching across, hesitantly placing his hand on hers. It was strange to be touched so easily by near strangers, especially strangers who she could end up at war with, but here she was not hissing or anything.

“I am more than happy to tell you about my mate. Truthfully, she was chief in all but name before she passed. I was just there keeping everyone in line.” In her head she could hear Tace tutting at her description of their roles, but it was true. “Tace was her name. She was one of the eldest of the survivors, in fact she and Phibin would have been the nominated leaders in other circumstances.”

“Why is that?" Angella was obviously intrigued.

“Oh, I was only Yarsha’s age when the ships left our planet. If not for the Horde’s intervention with the wreckage, I would still be. Or I’d be thirteen living in the desert.” That thought made her laugh a little, thinking of Digby. “I was taken by the Horde as a sample, I guess, and handed to Shadow Weaver.” She saw how the name made Micah glower, clearly he had no love for the old witch, wherever she was and an odd look pass between the husband and wife that she could not decipher. She filed it away. A shared enemy could bring people together. “That’s how I ended up with Adora.” Why did so much seem to come back to the blond?

“Then, please, tell us about your mate.”

It was cathartic to be able to talk to people who did not know them about the other woman. They had not known her, and every word that she said was new and interesting to them. She explained how Tace had guided her in learning about her heritage and taken care of her when all she wanted to do was atone no matter the cost. Her description of the magicat made Micah and Angella reach for each others hands, hearing the reverence in her voice for her dead partner and understanding her loss. They couldn’t help but grow in respect for the young woman across from them, she had obviously left her past behind. Nobody could talk like that about somebody else and not mean it with every fibre of their being.

Angella noticed how the child had slowed her eating and was also looking at her Ra with adoring eyes as she hung on every word about a woman that she would never really remember beyond stories. It was what she had feared for Glimmer, barely older than this little tot when Micah had been lost them and why she had been so firm with her. Trying to keep her safe but driving her to recklessness.

“She sounds like she was a wonderful young woman.” Micah’ voice sounded choked with emotion. She was touched.

Catra appreciated that that neither of them asked about what had happened to Tace. It was one thing to be able to share the

woman with others, another to have to think about her death. For a while, attention turned to the little girl who basked in the attention and began to babel about her child's life. It was adorable even if Catra had heard it before. That, she had realised, was a big part of being a parent. Angella and Micah cooed and nodded along. It was easy to see what kind of childhood Glimmer must have had. How she had become so bitter when she had obviously had so much love was beyond the magicat. When she saw Micah pretend to sneak a cookie to the little one with a wink, she thought that they would make very good grandparents.

"Catra, could you explain how your role as chief works?" Angella's question felt out of place, but of course she was here for a purpose beyond quality time with the heads of Brightmoon.

"So, from what I know, there were several provinces on my peoples home planet and like here they were each ruled by something like a king. I am not that," she held up her hands to forestall any questions. "There were smaller tribes in each area and they were managed by a chief, an alpha." Angella and Micah look at each other and she knew that would need explaining too. "An alpha is just the most capable member of the tribe. Usually an older member who is stronger and more capable than the others." It made her feel childishly bashful to say that in front of these people.

"You are the eldest magicat left alive?" Micah's voice was soft, the crushing weight of the near genocide of an entire race heavy in the room.

"I shouldn't be but I am. Tace and Phibin were both almost my age when they went into stasis, but even though they had been trained how to take over the ship they had the life experiences of normal teens. War was strange for them, they were living normal lives and then threat came from the sky and things were gone. Not like here. I had been trained my whole life, made hard and led armies…you know that. Who better to take charge of all that was left?" She fidgeted in her seat and turned her attention to

Yarsha who was starting to wiggle in her seat, crumbs clinging to her fur which she dusted away.

"Yarsha," the queen's voice made the little one sit up straight and smile at her. "Would you like to go and play? There might be some toys in the box in the corner?" She had barely finished talking when a sloppy kiss landed on her cheek with a merry 'fankoo' and the child was making a beeline to the small chest of Glimmer's old toys that she had never quite got around to putting away.

"I think," Catra managed to push through her self consciousness. "That once, long ago, the magicats were warriors. They'd fight to see who ruled, it's where the alphas come from. By the time they got here, they were all peaceful and living with nature. Tace used to tell me about these massive trees they lived in, cities made up from treehouses. Made me so jealous." She laughed a little to herself at the memories of Tace laying beside her, running her fingers through the tuft of hair on her sternum as she described their old homes.

"We wish your elders had not been killed as they were, Catra. I again cannot apologise enough for what happened in your ship." Micah's voice was soothing and heart felt.

"I think we all have regrets. Isn't the question whether we can all find forgiveness?" She took a deep breath and brokered the issue that she knew would probably break this camaraderie. "Hordak has done a lot of shitty things, I know that better than most people. Once, he trapped me and sucked all the air out of the room so I would suffocate before sending me into the desert to die because I had disappointed him. Trust me, I know how bad he used to be. I understand why you want to put him on trial. It won't help this peace you're trying to build with us."

Catra looked carefully at each of them, seeing Micah's eyes grow stormy while Angella just looked tired. They all had axes to grind, but sometimes personal vendettas needed to be put behind you before you could move forward. Something else she had learned from her mate.

“Look, he hurt the world, and he hurt you personally. I get that. He has already been tried though. When we dismantled the Fright Zone, he saw the writing was on the wall, and when Entrapta came with us he just gave up. He completely capitulated to us. We took him into custody, tried him for his crimes - he didn’t defend himself once. Entrapta defended him, but he never did. We built a prison just to hold him. Don’t get me wrong, others have come and gone from there over the years, but it was for him. He spent three years there, the only person he saw was Entrapta.”

“He deserved longer.” Micah’s voice had lost its jolly edge.

“He did.” His eyebrows rose, not expecting that response. “But Entrapta didn’t. Oasis didn’t either. He was more use to us repenting out in the world than locked up behind bars. We put electronic monitors on him and he has been making amends ever since. Without him, even with Entrapta, we would not be where we are today. He shouldn’t be put on trial again by you when those of us who felt his touch every day in every part of our life have already judged him.” She paused for a moment, unable to read their faces now. “He’ll let you. He’ll stay here and do penance again, because he really does feel guilty. You won’t be punishing him though, you’ll be punishing his wife and children and all the other people who rely on him.” It felt so odd to be so earnestly defending Hordak.

“We’ll consider your words on this matter but it is not our decision alone.”

“I understand but you must know that we will mount a defence for him.” She saw them nod, for a few moments the only noise in the room Yarsha’s delighted laughter as she found another toy in the box.

The tension broke when the kitten ran over, grasped Angella’s large hand in her tiny one, and pulled the older woman over to play with her. Micah’s expression softened again, love and fondness was hung over him as he saw his elegant and put

together wife lower herself to the floor and pick up a doll. Catra let out a breath she had knot known she was holding. Maybe there was hope for all of them if the others could be as reasonable as the king and queen.

"She really is adorable." She wasn't sure whether he was talking about the child or the woman by her side, but she found herself agreeing either way.

The amount of information accrued by her shadow minions had been vast. They had poured the information back into her, and she in turn had channelled it into her scrying pool. Years before she had been moved from her original not-quite jail cell, to one of the standard rooms given to guests in the castle. She was in one of the furthest corners where few went because it was cold and shadowed constantly due to the mountain. It had become overspill rooms for parties and guests, though she was grateful that it was not in use during this visit. She would rather keep her presence hidden for now. She was still bound, or so they believed, not to leave this area of the castle, but if her powers had abandoned her once, she had spent a lot of years rebuilding them.

That arrogant little monster had shattered her mask and severed her connection with the Black Garnet, certainly impacting her power in the short term. What nobody seemed to remember, save perhaps Micah and his sister, was that she had never NEEDED the jewel in the first place. Oh, she had coveted it and used it to its full potential but her power came from within. The initial shock of the link being destroyed had left her abilities stunned, but after a few months in the relative luxury of Brightmoon being cared for as no prisoner should ever be, she had felt the power returning to her fingertips.

It had been small things at first, the thrumming under her skin and the itch in her mind that craved release. She had spent so long connected to the Scopioni's seat of power that she had

almost forgotten what her innate power felt like. But oh, the rush to know that it had been stunned and not destroyed had made her feel triumphant. Naturally she had told no one. Let them underestimate her until she was ready to show them why you should not treat a prisoner so well.

She had bided her time over months and then years. She put on a facade of weakness and capitulation, thrilled when she was transferred to a room full of darkness for her to feed on. The small waterfall fed pool had been the icing on the cake of the small suit of rooms. Micah had growled at her and reminded her that she was a prisoner still and never to see freedom again for her crimes before and during the war, that she was never to enter the rest of the castle, and made a show of using his magic to cast a binding spell around the wing. She had done her best to seemed cowed, it had taken all of her considerable acting talents to pull that off. Then her plans had started in earnest.

Her first move had been to enchant the pool, pouring magic in it through dark swirling runes. Then she a had broken apart the shadows that filled the room and sent them out as her spies, all over the palace, in every nook and cranny. She could not leave the perimeter of Micah's spells at the beginning but that did not top her reach. It had not taken long for her to find the wet spot in Brightmoon. She had spent many hours watching the Princess fuss and fret about her role and her projects, growing increasingly frustrated after the close of the war. A careful suggestion in a sleeping ear, a dream cast and injected into her head had inevitably led her to seek out the fallen sorceress.

Seducing Glimmer had been harder than her father, she was older and jaded in her own way. It was not enough to stroke her ego. It had taken a connection between two people who's plans had been aborted by a common foe. Catra had been that. Glimmer suspected the cat of everything, from leading the Horde to having something to do with the suddenly empty Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver had not believed for a moment that Catra was that capable, tough now it seemed Glimmer had the measure of the other woman far better than she did. Shadow Weaver blamed the

vile mongrel for many of her problems. She had taken her power, her role and left her here, waiting and now she was back.

That had been an unforeseen boon.

She had altered her end game considerable when the news arrived that the deserters from the Fright Zone had been located and with them Catra. She had not even had to do any convincing to make Glimmer believe the worst, just helped her to head down that path a little more zealously than she might have done. Years of grooming the girl had left her bitter and malicious. The constant steady diet of Shadow Weaver curated dreams, teas that made her open to suggestion and the day to day rig moral of peace made a powerful cocktail that the callow girl was all to ready to get drunk on.

Now looking into the scrying pool, she pulled up more of the information from the previous few days. Much was banal and unhelpful, who was wearing what and what the food would be were no interest to her and yet she could not skip too much for fear of losing something. Dullard after dullard flew passed, maybe she needed to guide her minions more actively next time. She was about to take a break when familiar voices filled the room and she froze, a sneer on her unmasked face.

Adora and Catra sat in the garden, mid conversation. She took the images back to their beginning, a shadow beginning to hang over the women where they sat on a pair of rocks. She pulled over a notebook and sat down on the pools edge, ready to milk everything she could from any and all of their interactions. Her eyes rested on Adora, she had not seen her in the flesh for years. The last time had been in a corridor where the blond girl had shied away from her as though everything she had ever done wasn't to make her strong, make her the best. Ungrateful child. Her eyes scanned the cropped hair and tired look in her eyes, she was not the girl she had raised. She looked weak. It galled her to admit that Catra looked the opposite.

The hair that fell across her shoulder, shaved on one side, the breadth of muscle and the self assured look in her eyes that had replaced the recalcitrance she was used to showed that she was more than she had ever been. Briefly, just for a moment, Shadow Weaver considered that she had favoured the wrong girl. It was not a thought that lasted as her loathing for the cat creature churned to the fore, making her wish that she could reach out and throttle her through the pool. She waved her hand through the surface of the water and the image began to tells its story.

21

Chapter Summary

And then there were none...

Chapter Notes

CW
There will be blood.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Head pounding, Catra groaned as light hit her closed eyelids. Grunting, she brought her arm up and let it flop across her face, shielding her eyes. The blissful relief of the darkness was disturbed by the faint sound of chuckling beside her. Her brow wrinkled under the arm across her face while she cautiously reached out across the bed with her other hand. It didn't get far before she was brushing her fingers against a familiar silkily furred hip. She sighed with relief and rolled onto her side, finally dropping her arm from my eyes and cracking open her blue eye to take in the glorious sight of Tace holding their baby girl in her arms. Yarsha looked impossibly small. Hadn’t she been bigger yesterday? Catra vaguely remembered a hazy idea of a child climbing on her back and talking rapidly to a pale woman. As soon as it had come the doubt faded as she drank in the sight of her wife and her daughter sitting up in their bed. Tace was teasing the kitten with her fingers as Yarsha’s uncoordinated little hands swiped at them ineffectually.

Even though the black furred magicat hadn’t looked down at her, Catra knew that Tace knew she had woken up. The laughter had been at her expense, not the little ones antics. Moving slowly beneath the sheets that seemed to have sucked all the energy from her heavy limbs, the chief magicat rested her forehead against Tace’s hip and purred contentedly when the hand that had been hovering over the kitten moved to wind through her short

hair and massage the scalp beneath, offering relief from her headache. Tace shifted a little, bringing her knees up and placing the kitten on top of them, tiny feet pressed against her stomach as yellow eyes blinked up at her face. Catra moved a little more until her face was close to the sharp little feet and she nipped at them while fingers wound her hair into short locks.

In her wildest dreams young Catra could have never imagined this. Once, when she was ten or eleven, a new batch of babies and toddlers had suddenly appeared in the creche. Usually there was a new one or two, easy to ignore for the older cadets going passed, but this time there had been almost twenty. She had found out later that a village had been taken and all of these children had been left behind, though obviously now she realised that the village had been decimated and the little ones stollen to bolster their ranks. Young Catra had been strangely fascinated by all of the children. They had been small and fragile, crying easily from something as small as a mean face. She would find herself sneaking way to the creche, without even Adora knowing, and watch through the glass walls.

The creche had been one of the few places in the Fright Zone that had been bright and somewhat clean because the infants were so fragile and prone to infection. It had been hard to stay out of sight but years of hiding from angry instructors and Shadow Weaver had left Catra more adept than most as slinking around in the shadows. She would watch them play clumsily, sometimes laughing but mostly just huddled in corners holding each other. She had known that she and Adora must have looked like them once, although her memories of her first months in the military complex were hazy at best.

For a few weeks, she had visited every day, fascinated and filled with a type of longing that she could not understand. The other kids in her unit, even her own squad, had started to hit puberty and become shy and goofy around each other, wanting to touch and being horrified because they hadn’t the understanding to know what was happening to them and the Horde had not been big on ‘unnecessary education’ which included sex ed. It was a

wonder there weren't pregnancies among the soldier's but the kitten had been certain that she had never seen even one pregnant soldier. All of the new recruits came from the outside. Catra wasn't like the other cadets, in more ways than she could count, not even sure if someone like her would go through the same physical changes as the lizard-kin and humans. What she did know was that she was suddenly fascinated by children.

In those weeks she had imagined what it might be like to have a child of her own, a little tubby kitten with blue eyes and pale golden fur. Even as young as she was, she had already been in love with Adora, any fantasies of the future always featuring the older girl in a prominent role. The idea of a kitten, shared by the two of them had filled her young heart with warmth and hope that she seldom felt in the cold, soulless dark. It hadn't lasted long, good things never had for the young girl.

One day, tired and aching from an evening of discipline from the Second in Command, she had limped her way to her hiding spot, rather than heading to training. She had crouched in a corner, hands grasping her ribs as she watched a tiny blond boy crying all by himself. All of the other children had finally started to settle into life here, but she had noticed that this one, the runt of the litter, was always by himself. She had known it was foolish to get closer to the glass wall, even more so to raise her hand and tap softly on the glass with her claw. It was almost worth it to see the little head perk up and a curious smile spread over the little face. But then he had been shouting and pointing and between one moment and the next rough hands had been grabbing her and agony had lanced up her side. Before she knew it she had been back in Shadow Weaver's clutches and developed a new found hatred of small children.

Now, with Yarsha kicking her in the face, life couldn't be better. So many things that she had thought and believed as a child had been wrong, lies and cruelties inflicted on her that meant that she had nothing of her past. Getting to know her own baby daughter had led her to find out more about her own parents. The more she heard stories from Tace about the men that her Ra and Zu

had been, the more she fell in love with them as she was in love with this woman and little girl.

Dizziness passed over her for a moment, the bed felt as though it was shifting and dissolving. Her mind whirled and everything dropped out from under her, she reached desperately for Tace but there was nothing there. The feeling of falling consumed her and then, just, stopped.

Catra blinked her eyes open, head still pounding, light all around her as she staggered, reaching out for something to keep her on her feet. When had she got to her feet? A gust of air burst from her lungs as she roughly hit something rough and tall, but at least the danger of falling seemed to have passed. She blinked until her vision cleared and she found herself on the pristinely manicured lawn of the Palace of Brightmoon. Had she brought Yarsha out to play?

As though thinking about her had made the kitten appear, peels of joyful laughter drifted to her ears, making Catra's ears twitch and swivel until she found the little one. Her eyes followed slower, but soon she was looking at Yarsha, her calico fur fluffed by the breeze as he hair bounced around in its braids. Somebody was chasing the little girl, a blur of red and gold that Catra couldn't focus on.

Soft hands landing on her shoulders made her jump and spin, attempting to bring her claws up to defend herself but it was as though her body and her brain were disconnected. Her actions were slow and ineffectual. The taller figure in front of her slid their hands up to cup her face between them, cradling her as though she were made of fragile porcelain. Catra looked up at the woman in front of her and mewled with such melancholy that she was enveloped in an embrace that she had missed every day for almost two years. An impossible touch.

"Tace, what's going on?" Catra's voice was small and scared, played counterpoint by the sound of childish delight.

“You know, my wonderful girl.” Tace pressed a kiss to her forehead, Catra turning almost liquid at the touch, legs no longer holding her up as Tace brought them both down to sit on the ground, the smaller girl leaning heavily against her as she smoothed her fingers down a striped arm.

Both magicats watched the kitten be chased around the garden by the laughing blond woman. Yarsha whooped and tumbled, carefree and happy. Strong arms reached down and the girl was scooped into the air, taking flight and being caught with ease, both grinning at each other.

Yarsha seemed much bigger than she remembered.

Catra felt so tired.

Adora leaned down to lace up her boots. She had slept later than usual and felt a little heavy, her head still fuzzy even after a shower and pulling on her clothes. If she didn’t know better she would swear that she was suffering the ill effects of a long night drinking. Satisfied that her shoes would do, even as one of the laces trailed longer than the other, insulting her own sense of symmetry, she stood from the edge of her bed, grabbing a jacket from the back of the chair by her desk, and made her way out to the dining hall. She hoped that a big cup of coffee and some food would help clear her head.

Walking down the hallway, she passed people already starting their day. Adora wasn’t sure if she was projecting, but many of them seemed almost as dazed as she felt. The week had passed in a whirl of activity. There had been countless meetings about peace and trade. She had shown her remorse at every turn and it almost seemed as though Catra had taken the first steps to forgiving her.

Thinking about her childhood friend and her little girl brought a smile to Adora’s face and lifted some of the fog from her brain.

The blond was certain that she would never have what she most wanted with the magicats, but she would have as much as she needed. Nothing felt as right as being with the two of them, and she hadn't even put her foot on her mouth for the last forty-eight hours. It was almost a record. She had spoken with the queen, made a request that was both practical and extremely selfish. Somebody would need to be the ambassador to Oasis, and she wanted to be that someone. Nobody needed She-ra anymore, but maybe Catra and Queen Angella needed Adora.

Entering the oddly quiet dining hall, Adora picked up a tray and loaded it with food almost absently as she looked for somebody to sit with. In the corner, tucked away with a book, Frosta was absently picking at a bowl of something that looked like she should have eaten it at least twenty minutes ago. Thanking the server, Adora made a beeline for the younger woman and slide noisily into the seat opposite, tray and cutlery clattering on the table, bringing Frosta's attention from her book to look bak at her.

"Morning." Adora grinned goofily, maybe she had just needed to stretch her legs? She picked up a fork and shovelled scrambled eegs into her mouth.

"You're unbearable in the morning, you know that right?" The book was placed face down on the table top as Frosta looked at her own forgotten food and scrunched up her nose in disgust, pushing it away and reaching over and snatching a piece of Adora's toast.

"People tell me that." Her voice was muffled through the mouthful of food. Some of the best people told her that.

Frosta had been a part of all of the negotiations and Adora had been able to tell how hard she had been working to be fair and listen to what the people of Oasis had to say. It had obviously been wearing on her. She was used to listening to Glimmer and following her lead ever since she was a child. She had worshipped the other woman for as long as they had all known one another, and to accept that her prejudices had led them to almost do

something so terrible was hard to bare. But she was a queen and had opened her mind.

Adora smiled at the other woman, the throbbing starting in the back of her head again as she blinked hastily to clear the fog in her vision and Frosta smile blankly back.

Nostrils quivered as she caught the acrid scent of iron in the air. It floated down the corridors, familiar and alien all at once. It made the fur on her shoulders stand on end and her tail puffed up to double its size. In the pristine sterile halls of the palace the smell dominated everything, completely filling the keen senses of the magicat. Looking around the hall, Kesh could see that there was no-one else around; no guards, no princesses, nobody but her. It was the most empty she had seen the corridors of the palace since her arrival the week before. Something about the situation caused a ripple of fear to move through Kesh, she wasn't sure why but she knew she had to follow the scent, that there was something familiar about it. A part of her said it was foolish to go anywhere alone especially when she had her suspicions however she wasn't going to let that stop her, she was the cat in the adage, one day she would get herself killed from her own curiosity but it hadn't stopped her before and it wouldn't now.

She moved carefully down the corridor, attentive to even the smallest hint of danger, the scent of blood grew stronger and stronger. Whatever trail she was following she was certainly on the right path. It wasn’t long before her ears picked up the sound of people moving around, the swish of long robes and sound of water slopping on the group heightening her curiosity as she noticed the hall taking a sharp bend to the right up ahead. Knowing that the sound, and possibly smell, were coming from there, she fitted her body to the sleek wall and moved on silent feet until she could peek, unseen, around the bend.

What she saw made her eyes widen in dawning horror. There, surrounded by a pool of blood, were two of the palace guards,

mops in hand instead of spears. The heads of the mops and the buckets of water were stained pink, as were the edges of their long robes. Her eyes traced the scene, noticing that the blood was not localised to one area, instead a fat smear disappeared out of sight and into a suspiciously dark hallway. Kesh's heart pounded in her ears. Whatever this was, it was not good. She needed to find Catra, right now.

That was why she was wandering the halls, after all. Catra had missed a meeting with the Alliance, one too important for her to have blown off. Not that her chief would ever do that. Catra may be a lot of things that Kesh didn't understand, but she was the most dedicated person that she had ever known. Tace had told her more than once about how they would go to bed together, falling asleep in each others arms, only to wake hours later, in the dead of the night, to find Catra seated at her desk in the low light, agonising over blueprints or plans with her head in her hands. She gave every part of herself to Oasis and what was left was for Tace and later Yarsha. There was no way she would not attend a meeting that was to finalise the planned treaty to protect everything she had worked for.

No way.

A lump was in her throat, a worse case scenario that she dare not give a name to. Taking one last look at that dark doorway and the fast disappearing blood, Kesh withdrew back along the walkway. She was heading to the guest wing, mind preoccupied with finding her people, when she all but ran into the tall, silver and pastel robed figure of another palace guard. Her eyes widened in fear as she stumbled, long arms reaching out to help steady her.

"Thank you." Kesh muttered, trying not to sound as afraid as she felt.

"You are welcome. You should be more careful." The words were dull, flat and almost robotic in a way that she had not heard anybody's in this place full of light and vibrancy. It was almost as

unsettling as the way that the guard walked away, marching as though on parade though there was nobody there to see but her.

Kesh shivered, fur puffing up even more, her tail must look like a brush by now. Sure that she had to tell somebody what she had seen, Kesh started to run, heedless of how the Brightmoon people would feel about her on hands and feet barrelling down the hallway. Not that there was anyone to see as she careened around a bend, feet skidding out from under her and sending her into a tumble that landed in front of Lonnie's door. Breathless from the run and relief, she started to knock on the closed door. There was no answer so she began to pound more fiercely, still nobody came to the door. Beginning to breath more raggedly, fearful that she would hyperventilate, she moved to the next door, then the next. Each door left a hollow sound and no-one coming to greet her. Even Scorpia's room was empty. She knew that the other magicats were in a meeting with some scientists, but the Oasis people should be around.

Kesh put her hand to her face and tried to calm down. As a last resort she barrelled towards Phibin's room. Like her, he had decided to let the other magicats have their say as delegates. As she got close she could see the older man's door was slightly ajar and her heart stopped. Had he been taken from his room? Without thinking, working on pure fear and adrenaline, she changed through the door and froze in place at what she saw.

There, on the floor, contorted into a position that she had hoped never to see, the portly man was entwined with the bare, pale green skin of Double Trouble, both looking at her with wide eyes, just as stunned as she was. Kesh felt her jaw working, nothing coming out as Phibin and DT disentangled themselves, the larger man moving to grab a blanket to wrap around the shape shifter, before he pulled a kilt over his own hips.

"Kesh, darling, much as we both enjoy your company, some warning would be nice." Double Trouble's voice was like silk concealing a blade. Sharp and smooth all at once.

"I…I'm sorry…no I'm not!" Her world was out of kilter and their attitude was not helping.

"Kesh," Phibin's voice was low and more honeyed with age, burring out of his huge barrel chest. It calmed her. It always reminded her of her lost Ra. "What's wrong?"

"There's something very wrong going on! I can't find anyone!" She saw that she was about to be interrupted but raised a forestalling hand. "Catra didn't show up for a meeting this morning, I was looking for her when I found the guards cleaning up a lot of blood. They didn't see me and I came here. I have knocked on every door and no-one answered. The halls are really quiet and I am getting a bad feeling about this." Phibin had moved over to her, pulling her into his big naked chest as she finished speaking, letting out a deep purr to help her calm down. She sagged in this arms and looked over at the calculating face of their council leader as they sat on the bed, chin cupped in their own palm.

"If you're right, we are in a lot of trouble. This is enemy territory and we are at a supreme disadvantage." They stood, dropping the blanket, heedless of their nudity and pulled on their black bodysuit. "If Catra is missing, I think we can only assume the others have been taken with her."

"Why now? We've been here a week, the treaty is all but signed and we have written up trade and agricultural contracts. Why all the show? Why not do this the night of the banquet when all our guards were down?" Phibin had a point, Kesh pulled away to look at both of their faces.

"No idea. It doesn't matter. Where is Yarsha?" Other people might have found it odd that Double Trouble instantly turned their attention to the kitten, but Phibin knew that ever since DT had found the mostly dead magicats with Catra they had felt responsible for them all. Mostly for the youngest ones.

“Yarsha!” Kesh’s voice was almost a wail, how could she have forgotten her niece, the only part of her sister that she had left?

“Kesh you need to calm down. Catra told me yesterday that Yarsha was going to have a playdate with Stanley today. Maybe whatever is happening, they haven’t bothered with Hordak’s room because he is already under arrest?” It was a slim hope, but hope nonetheless.

“We should get the children out of here. They need to be kept safe. If this is nothing then we lose nothing, but if you’re right then they will be safe.” DT had already formulated a plan, mind always working angles, a habit built over many years of spying and grifting.

“How do we do that?” Kesh had separated herself from Phibin and was standing with her fists balled but her breathing thankfully back to normal.

“You need to go and get Adora.”

Wearing somebody else's skin was sometimes easier than wearing their own, Double Trouble had long since stopped agonising about stealing another's identity. In fact, it was the biggest part of their own. Walking down the hallway in the guise of one of the guards was an easier task than most. Their head was covered and the robes hanging to the floor concealed much of their movements. All they had to do was walk with purpose and give a tacit nod here and there to the scant few people that they passed on their way to Hordak’s room.

It was easy to see what Kesh meant about the halls being eerily quiet, they were busier the further away from their wing that they went but there were still far fewer people and those that they did cross seemed almost hungover. They were dazed and shambling.

Getting close to the place where the strangest family in Oasis were being held, a sense of relief washed through the shifter as

they saw the familiar sight of two guards stationed outside the door. Standing taller, Double Trouble walked with authority over to the two guards. They weren't just any guard, after all, they had been careful to take the form of the guard Captain Juliet. The two soldier's spotted their commander and stood to attention, although they seemed to be moving slowly as though through water.

"At ease. I have come to see the prisoner." It was as easy as that, one of the guards reaching forward to open the door and letting them walk through without question. No wonder these people had never been able to win the war for themselves if this was how they run the place. If the place was under siege it was easy to see why.

Hordak eyed the intruder, while Entrapta stayed sat on the floor reading a strangely technical sounding book to the, thankfully, two children on her lap, thick purple hair holding the book open. DT raised their finger to their lips, getting a subtle nod from Hordak in understanding as the doors were closed behind them. When the sound of the lock being turned sounded DT dropped the facade, morphing back to themself as Entrapta looked up for the first time.

"Are you both all right?" It was the last question they expected and Hordak's posture became even more rigid than it usually was.

"What is going on shape shifter?" Hordak had walked over to his wife and pulled her to her feet, pushing her and the children behind him as though Double Trouble meant them harm.

"Nothing good. Our people have disappeared, no-one can find Catra and Kesh found blood being cleaned up in the halls. Have you heard or seen anything?" The faces of both looked back blankly.

"No. The guards have been unusually quiet in the last twenty-four hours. I have logged no conversations between them." Entrapta's

voice came from over Hordak's shoulder where she had lifted herself up with her hair.

"Kesh said they all seem to be acting strangely. We should get the children out of here." Whatever was happening to the guards it could not bode well for them.

"You will get Entrapta out of here too. I will stay." Hordak's voice showed his worry, a rare glimpse into his cares for his wife and son.

"I thought you would say that. Kesh is getting help. Entrapta, you need to get the children ready and leave with me now, we're meeting them in the garden. I don't think that we have any time to waste." Double Trouble turned away, giving the family some privacy.

Low voices behind them revealed how much the former leader of the war machine that had once ravaged Etheria had changed. They were distracted from the soft words by the feel of tiny claws pricking at their leg. Looking down, Yarsha's huge yellow eyes blinked slowly back. DT knew what that meant and reached down to lift the kitten into their arms. She was getting big, the lizard remembered when she weighed barely more than a large book and now she could curl her arms around their neck. The fuzzy little face tucked into a green neck and pudgy fingers wound in long blond hair.

"Hello Kitten." DT had a voice reserved only for this child though they would never admit it.

"H'lo, DT. Where's Ra?" Where indeed.

"She's busy but she told me to tell you how much she loves you and that she needs you to go an adventure for her." The form in their arms wriggled excitedly.

"You should go now before anything is suspected. If you can send me a sign when you need me I will join you." Hordak's words confirmed something that the former spy had long since

suspected, Hordak was only a prisoner here because he chose to be.

Morphing back into the captain, passing Yarsha to Entrapta, DT led the little group back out of the room and away from the guards. They were headed towards the garden where the next part of their plan would take shape. While they had been retrieving the children and scientist, Kesh had been on a mission of her own.

It had been surprisingly easy to make her way from the delegates wing and into the main part of the castle. She knew where Adora's room was, it would be almost impossible not to, considering how much the human had been trailing the chief magicat around since they had been here. Kesh was still no fan of the older woman, in her eyes she had wheedled her way into the life of her home and then turned traitor, but it seemed like Catra could see beyond that so she had tried.

Kesh still didn't like how Catra was with the human woman, but if she could help them now, if she wasn't part of whatever was happening here, Kesh would forgive all her transgressions. Right now, all that mattered was protecting the children. She reached up to the door and knocked, feeling dread as her knuckles connected with the wood. If Adora was missing too, things would be far more dire than they thought.

Thankfully the door opened after only a brief hesitation. Adora stood there looking strangely rumpled, eyes blearily staring at Kesh with only a glimmer of recognition. She was bare foot and lightly swaying and her shirt was only half buttoned and looked like she had been asleep in it. It was odd, if she had learned nothing else about the woman it was that she was an early riser and perpetually perky at an ungodly hour.

"Adora, you don't look too good." The concern in her voice was genuine as she walked her way into the room, Adora staggering back to give her space. The door closed and the blond swayed.

“Sorry, I’m just feeling a little woozy. I think it’s the flu, I woke up like this. I was just taking a nap.” The unfocused eyes darted too and fro for a moment as though she was working hard to put something together. “Did we have a meeting scheduled? I thought Catra was in meetings with Queen Angella this morning.” Of course she knew Catra’s schedule.

“Adora, I don’t think you have the flu. You need to sit down and listen as hard as you can.” The blond nodded readily and found herself sitting in her desk chair.

Kesh laid out everything that she had seen. The more she said it, the worse it sounded and the more certain she became that the blood on the floor had been Catra’s. Adora was listening with rapt attention, face grim even as she looked dazed. As Kesh started to lay out the plan, a hand raised to stop her. Kesh’s mouth snapped shut as she watched the woman grope across her desk for her sword. Kesh took a step back, fear travelling up her spine. She was no warrior, could never be fast enough to get passed the woman with a sword. She braced herself as Adora stood.

“For the Honour of Greyskull!” Adora’s voice filled the room and then there was light and colour all around, Kesh’s jaw dropping as she saw the transformation from woman to goddess with her own eyes for the first time. It only lasted a minute before she was shrinking back to her normal size, but now Adora’s posture was once again tall and strong, her eyes clear and focused in a way that would be chilling if the magicat hadn’t been certain that she was on their side now. “What do you need me to do?”

Waiting in the garden for DT and the children felt like an eternity. Adora had agreed readily to help, her love for the little magicat kitten obvious in the scent of anxiety that oozed from her. She had thrown on her jack and fixed her sword to her wrist and they had been running down a smaller, more private exit into the gardens, apparently this was how Adora got out for a run each morning. They had made it to the rendezvous spot without detection.

When she finally saw Entrapta and the children following a figure who could only be DT, she was able to take ether first deep breath she had all day, or so it seemed. Adora, by her side, let out a little sob and then there was the sound of large wings beating against the air and her fur was ruffled by the shifting currents as the alicorn that was Adora's companion swooped in from the sky. This was the clever part of their plan, airlift the innocent out, where she had to leave to Adora.

"I hope we can trust you, Adora." DT shifted back to themself as they came to a stop, words pointed.

"I give you my word of honour that I will do anything to protect Yarsha and Catra. I have broken her trust more than once and I will never do it again." The sincerity in her words was undeniable.

"Hell of a time to realise that." Kesh couldn't help the jibe.

"You're right, and if I could go back none of this, whatever this is, would be happening. But I can't." She turned to Entrapta. "Swift Wind is going to take you to a hidden library in the woods. Bow's fathers are there. Tell them everything, they'll know you're from me when they see Swifty. Do not leave until you hear from Hordak." There was an authority to her voice that mirrored Catra's, it was clear to see that they had been raised together.

"A library?" Entrapta's curiosity was piqued was was good for all of them.

The small purple haired woman gathered her son in her arms and, using her tentacle like hair, walked her way over to the alicorn and climbed aboard, placing the boy in front of her. Adora lifted Yarsha up, holding the child close and rubbing her cheek over the top of her head. It looked as though she was trying to mark the kitten, yet another reminder that this was the person that had grown up at the chief's side. Kesh felt uncomfortable and pulled the little girl away, kissing her before passing her up to Entrapta.

"Hey!" The indignant shout came as Kesh was suddenly lifted up and onto the back of the alicorn too.

"You are going with them, Kesh. Catra wouldn't forgive me if anything happened to you or Yarsha. Entrapta and you will be safe and you will be able to tell if anything is amiss." Double Trouble nodded at Adora's words. Kesh huffed but resigned herself to this new turn in the plan.

As the huge beast beneath her bunched his muscles and took to the sky, she hoped that Phibin had managed to make his way to the King and Queen.

Curled into a purring, shivering ball in the dark corner, it would be easy to think that the young woman was just sleeping rather than unconscious, if not for the pool of dark congealing blood that haloed her head and turned her hair to tendrils of tangled gore. The split in her forehead oozed sluggishly even hours after she had been dragged into the room, the edges gaping and the shine of bone visible through the wound. The purring almost covered the sound of teeth chattering together, the body already feeling the effect of shock and trembling all over.

A darker shadow than those that surrounded her fell across the magicat as Shadow Weaver glided over to stand intimidatingly in front of the crippled form of the woman who had been a thorn in her side since she was a child. For a long time the sorcerers had believed the magicat had perished in the desert and it had brought her much joy in her own confinement in the Palace of Brightmoon. A sneer twisted the face beneath the mask, as she took in the pathetic figure. Blood had made its way across the exposed fur, drying into stiff spines. Eyelids fluttered over ever defiant mismatched eyes. Perhaps she should have plucked one out for the girl's insolence when she was young, taught her a lesson she would be unable to forget.

Caught in thoughts of how she could have done more to quash the girl beneath her boot back in the Fright Zone, she almost

missed the whispered sounds that replaced the purrs. The sorceress crouched, watching the flickering eye-lids and hearing the incoherent words falling from her lips. She was dreaming.

Shadow Weaver let out a dark chuckle. This alien invader didn't deserve anything but nightmares. She reached out, spitefully holding the sharp jaw in her hand as she had dozens of times before, forcing the insolent girl to meet her eyes. The last thing she expected was the purr to start up again, louder than before and for the face to weakly nuzzle against her palm. Disgusted, she wrenched her away, provoking a sorrowful mewl from the magicat. Still unconscious, a trembling arm reached out for someone who wasn't there.

"Tace?" The word ghosted out of the blood covered mouth, meaningless gibberish from a fool.

Shadow Weaver was about to walk away, she was busy orchestrating a coup after all, when she was brought up short by the next words that wheezed out of Catra.

"Adora?" It was so plaintive, almost broken hearted and Shadow Weaver felt her blood boil.

No matter how she tried, no matter how the world broke them apart, this creature would always seek out Adora. All of the hopes that she had for the foundling girl, how she would harness her potential and use her to take the world and shape it to her own image. Everything dashed by this animal and all of her defiance. It had seeped into the other girls skin and made her just as defiant.

Wheeling around on the almost lifeless body, she crouched again. This time when she moved it was to pull her arm back and land a vicious slap across the bloodied cheek, sending the head snapping back, making sluggish ripples in the pool of congealing blood. That seemed to break something loose inside the prisoner, heavy eyelids fluttering open to look glassily up at the darkness around her.

“Wh…” It was all that fell from her lips before she was slumping again, back into darkness.

Shadow Weaver let out a dry cackle, holding her sticky hand away from her body. She walked towards one of the guards who stood stock still around the room, eyes staring blankly into space silly waiting, barely breathing. She waved a long fingered hand to the nearest two, who peeled away from the wall and joined her, automaton-like, out into the hallways of the palace. A decades work was finally coming to fruition and, better than she had hoped, she would take down everyone who had stood in her way in one fell swoop with a scapegoat at her fingertips to be destroyed. It was better than she could ever have imagined. Oasis proving to be the one part of her plan that she hadn’t even known was missing.

Chapter End Notes

Next time we'll see how this is unfolding for the others and what after has befallen Scorpia and co.

(also Lance and George get to play with small children - and Entrapta).

Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

Not alone in the dark.

When the portly white cat had rushed into the room the king and queen had known that something was very wrong. Guards should have stopped him, his way should have been barred and there should have been chaos in the hallway outside their chamber at one of these magicats attempting to access their private quarters. There had been nothing but the sound of his running feet, heavy sounds combined with the ticking of his claws on the polished surface. He had burst through the door without knocking, skidding to a stop in front of them, chest heaving and tail lashing frantically as he gathered his breath to speak.

They waited, Angella gripping Micah's hand tightly, braced for anything.

"You're in trouble." The words fell out his mouth with no preamble, his deep voice oozing with fear.

"What do you mean?" Micah, brave and foolish man as he had been during the war. Brave and foolish as he had been when he was taken from her, moved to stand in front of her. It was silly, she towered over him, but the warmth that spread through her chest at his attempt to protect her warmed the queen.

"Look, I'm not the threat here." His arms went up placatingly. "Something is going on out there and we don't know what. The few people I've seen in the halls are walking around like zombies and Catra's gone."

Angella laid her hand on Micah's shoulder and moved him to the side so that she could step closer to the tall magicat. "Catra's gone?" From what she had learned of the chief magicat over the last week, it seemed out of character for the woman to leave her

people. She was smart, loyal and dedicated to building a peace for them and a future for everyone. Angella couldn't help but like and respect her and knew Micah felt the same.

"She left Yarsha behind." Angella felt her blood run cold. Catra would never leave behind that precious little girl. Something very bad was happening indeed.

Before either of the monarchs could ask more, the door was flung open causing all three of them to flinch, two bodies flying in. In a blur of motion the duo were dragging and hauling furniture to barricade the doors. Phibin rushed to help while Angella shared a worried look with her husband, watching as he began to mutter incantations under his breath, hand weaving the air in gestures full of power. She knew without being told that he was building a shield around the room even as the younger people tried to provide simpler barrier.

Walking with long strides, she found herself at Adora's side, grasping her arm and turning her to face them. Here was their golden girl, the one who had fought more tirelessly than any for victory and then for peace, looking frantic. Angella looked into wild blue eyes and knew that whatever trouble was marching down that corridor towards them was big and very, very bad.

"Adora, what do we know?" The Queen kept her voice level, calm, and felt the shoulders under her hands relax a fraction.

"Catra is missing. There is barely anyone moving around the castle and those that are seem to be in a daze. I was in a daze this morning, felt like a hangover. I went to breakfast and I wasn't paying enough attention. Everybody looked how I felt, except maybe Frosta? I don't know. Next thing I knew I was being woken up from a nap by Kesh and she said that all of the Oasis delegation had vanished, except her, Phibin and DT." Her voice was fast, the self recrimination obvious.

"What about the children?" Angella had become unaccountably fond of the kitten in just the few days that they had spent time

together.

“Yarsha was with Entrapta and Hordak, we sent the children with Entrapta and Kesh to Bow’s dads. Then we came here.” As though she couldn’t maintain the weight of the eye contact, Adora bowed her head. Angella didn’t force her to look up, just gently touched the top of her head.

“What about Hordak?” Micah’s voice floated to them, a quick snatch between incantations.

“He stayed in his room. If we call him, he’ll come.” Double Trouble spoke, voice clear and certain. “As much as you hate him, we’re going to need his help. It’s like a ghost town out there.”

As though to make their words a lie, the sound of a dozen marching feet trouped down the hallway outside, almost sounding like the bitter rain of a storm. It was not a reassuring sound when the faces before you look stricken. She didn’t want to utter her next words.

“What about the guards?” Angella had seen and spoken to several of them this morning. Surely she would have noticed something was wrong.

“Kesh saw them cleaning up a lot of blood down one of the side corridors and a blood trail, she couldn’t tell where it was going. We have to assume that whatever is happening, they're compromised too.” Compromised. Someone had come into her castle and was stealing out from under her and she hadn’t even noticed.

Micah gasped, sudden and loud, dropping to one knee and clutching at his chest as the words of magic stuttered out of him. It was as though he had been punched in the chest by a giant fist and all of the air and magic had burst out of him. Angella rushed to his side as the other three turned to face the shuddering door. Micah got back to his feet, face grave. He knew only one person who had possessed the magical capabilities to overpower him.

One woman in all the castle who could stop him dead in his tracks as a boy and, so it would seem, even now. Shadow Weaver had been powerless for years. Where had this come from?

The familiar sound of rockets and tinkling filled the air as the doors shuddered hard. Blast after blast pummelled them, shaking loose the furniture that had been piled in from of them. It wouldn't be long before the barrier was breached by the very last person that Queen Angella ever though that she would need to be afraid of. Whatever was going on here was not new.

The door started to splinter.

"Micah, take Adora and the others and get out of the castle. Put a tracking spell on me, quickly." Her husband followed her instruction without question, long used to his wife's wise leadership. "They'll be here for me. Get out and make a plan, you'll know where I'll be." She pressed a kiss to his cheek before pushing him towards the window.

"Your Majesty…" Adora always fell back on absolute formality when she was most afraid.

The door exploded.

"Run!" Angella didn't watch them throw themselves out of the window, confident that Micah's magic, and She-ra would catch them as they fell.

All her focus was on the hole where her door used to be.

Glimmer stood, flanked by helmeted guards. A vicious smirk covered her face as she stared with eyes only for her mother. Angella didn't recognise her daughter. The person in front of her, staring with utterly black eyes, was not the girl she had cradled in her arms.

"Hello Mother."

Angella looked around the dim room as she was hustled forward, one of the three seldom used banquet halls. As a girl it had always amused her that the castle had been built with so many, as though they would throw party after party, and maybe once upon a time they had. Today the room looked far from festive. The air, rather than being filled with the sounds of revelry, music and laughter, was eerily quiet, occasionally broken by soft groans or stifled crying. The queen had caught sight of dozens of people in the shadows, as though caught in the darkness, nobody had looked back and they all seemed dazed, just as Adora had started to say. She was glad that Micah had got away from their daughter.

The thought of Glimmer, her eyes black and expression blank, sent a shiver up her spine. She was flung to the ground, arms still bound behind her back, inside one of the pools of inky dark. For a moment, she was blinded by the change of light. She lay still, long body crumpled in a heap, waiting for her vision to clear. With her hands bound behind her back her wings were also effectively pinned, meaning that she was vulnerable as a lamb. Finally able to make out shapes in the darkness, she wriggled to her knees and started to shuffle her way over to the few huddled forms she could make out.

It was slow going, her long robes hampering her movements, but gradually she got closer, able to make out the vacant, dazed faces of Mermista and Sea Hawk. The low whimpers coming from the moustachioed man's mouth were so incongruous with the loud boisterousness that she was used to from his that it was almost more frightening then being immobilised. Mermista at least seemed to have awareness enough to hold Sturgio close to her, and Angella's heart clenched at the sight of the little boy staring blindly out into nothing, only moving to blink. She was about to speak, say anything to try to snap them out of it, gain some allies in this room full of zombies, when a rattling gasp came from the darkest corner of her shadow cell.

Even with eyes now accustomed to the dim light, she had to squint to see who was there. She could see that the floor around the figure was darker than anywhere else and her breath stopped.

The rattling breaths, the dark pool, whoever it was, was hurt and possibly dying surrounded by people but utterly alone and helpless. Casting another look at the family of three, she shifted and made her way to the darkest corner as fast as her compromised condition would allow.

She felt the blood before she saw the prone figure's face, the ichor soaking into the silk of her clothing, making her progress even slower through the sticky pool. She shuddered at the sensation but kept moving. Glimmer was somewhere, being puppeted by who knew what, all the bile that she had apparently been keeping pent up inside corrupted and made poison to turn her against her home and her family. Whoever was laying there bleeding could not be the first death on her daughters hands. If that happened then there would be no rescuing her only child.

There was no holding back the gasp that left her lips when she could finally see the damage done to the woman on the floor. Even in the shadowy light she could see the glint of bone shining between the split skin of Catra's forehead before it disappeared into her matted hair. Sluggishly dark blood was dribbling across her face and down to join the rest pooled beneath her. How there could be any blood left in her was beyond the Queens's comprehension.

Angella felt tears starting to fall down her cheeks as the rattling breaths being let out by the young magicat slowed still further. Here was somebody who had worked hard, turned their life around and created a family. Yarsha deserved to have her parent. In that moment Angella decided that Catra would not die. She wouldn't let her. She would save her daughter and she would save this girl. That was all that mattered right now.

Edging closer, fearful of jostling the fragile form, Angella saw that one of Catra's hands was splayed out to her side, palm up and fingers open. Even unconscious her claws were out, wicked and sharp, a stark contrast to how breakable she truly was. Angella contorted her body until her bound hands were close to those wickedly sharp claws, she had heard more than once about how

they could split metal, and used them to cut her bonds. Her wrists sprung free, still circled by the cuffs but no longer held together. It was far easier to move.

Finally able to regain her feet, she moved around the collapsed body and sat down, pulling the icy form onto her lap. She was sure that it was wrong to move somebody who was injured, but it seemed like the time to worry about that was long passed. Uncaring about her clothes, she leaned her back against the wall, thankful that there was one, she rested Catra's broken head against her chest and held her like a child. The chill of Catra's skin, even though her fur, seeped into the immortal and made her shiver. Hurriedly she brought her wings around to wrap the pair of them together, hoping to lend just a little of her body heat to her.

"It'll be all right, Catra. Adora will save us, you know she will." She kissed the younger woman's forehead on the side that wasn't split, hoping that her suspicions about the two women were right. "Hold on just a little longer, for Yarsha." She hoped Micah and Adora came up with a plan fast.

Safely out of the castle and in the gardens, it was easier to hide from the patrolling guards. Adora, Micah, Phibin and DT crouched low in the bushes and began to move towards the castle boundary. Micah had to fight every instinct not to run back in, storm the place and get back his wife. It was those instincts that had made him lose his family for almost twenty years and he wouldn't do that again. Instead he followed Adora's lead as she hustled them through the undergrowth and towards the garden that had been assigned to the magicats. It was the most wild part of the castle grounds and would afford them the most cover to regroup and think of a plan.

Double Trouble felt something score at their cheek as they moved around a rose bush, a tickle on their cheek telling them that it was bleeding but there was no time to stop and check, vanity be damned. They couldn't stop themself from reaching their tail out though, searching as they moved for contact with the male behind

them. Phibin saw the aimless movement, DT was never aimless, and stroked down the length as they keep going, seeing the shoulders ahead of them sag a little. It was scary to see the always self assured person seem tense and afraid. Phibin was afraid too but more used to running away. Last time he had had to run away he had woken up in a world where he had lost everything.

The big cat almost ran straight into his some-time lover, thoughts distracted, when Adora brought them to a sudden halt, fist raised in the air. Micah was peering over her shoulder from where they were crouched and nobody spoke. Sensitive ears strained to make out whatever had caused Adora to stop their forwards momentum, and there it was distant but clear to him. Two voices talking in slurred whispers. Not guards then.

Then they were moving again, still keeping low but heading towards the voices. Adora had caught them on the wind, just a snatch, and recognised them straight away. She changed their course, confident that the others remained at her back, bringing them closer and closer to the two women who were also hidden in the undergrowth. The closer they got, the thicker the thicket of leaves and thorns became. Soon they were stuck, unable to move forward and unwilling to turn back. Adora touched her bracer, sword falling into her hand, something familiar in this dark time, and started to hack away a path for them.

They continued forward until a vine swiped out towards them. It swiped for Adora's sword but was easily sliced away. Any question Micah had about where they were headed was answered. Perfuma was out here with somebody and hopefully still herself enough to help them.

"Perfuma! Frosta! It's me, Adora!" Adora's words were hissed loud enough to travel through the bushes but not enough to leave them.

Like magic, Phibin shook his head and let out a rueful laugh at the thought, of course it was like magic because it was, the plants

parted to reveal what looked like a small, dark cave crafted from leaves. It would be perfectly camouflaged from anyone looking down from the castle and easily overlooked by a patrol. At the centre, the two princesses sat huddled together, slumped and glassy eyed but aware enough to be looking directly at them. He watched as Adora cast her eyes around the small dome, seemingly satisfied with something, before softly muttering something under her breath. The small space was momentarily filled with bright, rainbow light that was almost blinding in its intensity and then the athletic form of the other woman was replaced by a glowing, golden goddess. Phibin was taken aback, in all her time at Oasis Adora had never transformed. It was awe inspiring for sure.

The light that had surrounded the big woman was moving forward, channeling through her and her sword an outward into the two women, wrapping around them and then being absorbed. Phibin couldn't take his eyes off of the sight, not missing as their eyes cleared and they straightened, looking around as though they weren't quite sure where they were or how they got there.

"Adora?" The question in Perfuma's voice was clear.

"How are you feeling?" They needed to know that they could rely on these women now more than ever.

"I feel fine now, before it was like I was under water. Everything felt far away." Frosta spoke up, voice grave as Perfuma nodded from her side.

"Somebody has taken over the palace. We're not sure how or who, but everyone feels like you did. Most people are gone and we don't know where. All we know for sure is that the guards have all been compromised, and Glimmer. Queen Angella has been captured and we are all that is left." Frosta looked grim at Adora's news and Perfuma gasped and covered her face with her hands. Phibin was sure that she was thinking of Scorpia. How could she not.

“What do we do?” Frosta’s eyes darted towards the magicat and the shapeshifter and skittered away to look down. Shame was written on her face. There was no question that Oasis was responsible, not after letting herself meet them with an open mind.

“When did this start?” Perfuma’s voice held an edge that none of them but the other princesses were familiar with.

“We’re not sure. Catra went missing this morning, it’s not even dinnertime and the palace is almost deserted. Months maybe? You can’t get this done without planning.” Adora’s voice dripped with worry, cracking on her old friend's name.

“And Glimmer?” Frosta’s eyes remained downcast, Glimmer had always been her mentor and to think that she had turned traitor was hard to swallow.

“All we know is that she is with the enemy, not how.” Micah was the one who spoke, face grave as he talked about his child.

“Then we need a plan.” Perfuma was not going to let anyone else be hurt in all this.

The plan was simple, childishly so. Micah would use his magic to transport himself and Perfuma right to the Oasis barrier and bring back reinforcements while Adora and Frosta would allow themselves to be captured and Double Trouble would disguise themself as one of the guards and be with them every step, watching the enemy and hopefully getting them out of any cell that they may be put in.

Now they just needed to get captured.

George and Lance shared a bemused look as the whirlwind of a woman flung herself up the highest shelves, using her hair as grappling hooks to hold herself steady in the air, while she pulled out, examined and discarded book after book. In the hours since

the strange little group had arrived, she had barely been still. She had asked after First Ones books and then shimmied her way up to the oldest texts and began to pour over them.

Tugging at his pant leg made Lance look down to see the very small, purple haired boy looking up at him with his strangely knowing eyes. The tall man knelt down to be on the boy's eye level, well used to speaking with children after having more than a dozen of his own. He looked at the pale skin and strangely sharp little face and waited. Big eyes studied him, trailing over his face as small hands lifted up to touch his nose and the edges of his glasses. They blinked slowly and, out of the blue, the child bumped his head into Lance's before giggling softly and running back to the two magicats who were curled together in a corner.

Kesh, the adult, was curled around the kitten forming a large purring ball. The boy clambered on top of them, working his way into the cuddle pile and resting his head against the kittens. He was almost as catlike in his movements as the other two and Lance couldn't help but wonder at that as he straightened up to stand with his husband again as he too took in the strange group.

When they had seen the winged horse fly towards the library they had raced out, expecting Adora and hopefully their son and daughter-in-law. What they hadn't expected was the motley group of women and children. In his rapid fire way Swift Wind had introduced the group and explained that Brightmoon was under attack from within. They had promised to take care of the small group and he powerfully took to the air to monitor the surrounding area.

Neither man had ever seen a magicat in the flesh, and here was not one but two in their home. Even without introduction they would have known that the adult was not Catra. Adora had talked about the other woman a lot, and this short, dark furred woman couldn't look further from her description.

Kesh seemed reserved and very afraid, not letting the kitten get too far from her which was how they had ended up curled in a

ball. The young woman may look peaceful, but her light eyes shone out from her black fur, scanning the room constantly even as the child curled into her asleep. Though, having been parents, George could see that the child was not sleeping peacefully, her little ears and tail in constant motion as her eyes twitted under the lids. Even if she had not seen what was going on she knew something was very wrong.

"Lance," George's voice made his husband turn to him with worried eyes. He knew that tone. "Stay here and look after them."

The smaller man started to walk away, spine rigid, until a large hand landed on his shoulder stopping his progress. He turned to look at the haunted look in Lance's eyes, he'd seen it there before and hated to put it there again. He reached up and took the hand from his shoulder, holding it in his own and bringing it up to place a tender kiss against trembling knuckles.

"You don't have to." But they both know that the old soldier did.

"I'll just get my weapons. We should be prepared. I promise that I won't run into the fray this time, but if it comes here, we should be ready." Lance couldn't stop himself from pulling the smaller man close, closing his eyes as he rested their heads together.

Finally everything had fallen into place. All those years under Hordak, watching as his ineptitude let opportunity after opportunity pass them by all in some futile quest to impress a man a universe away. Seen his distraction and lack of focus push him into his lab and further from their goal of harnessing the magic of Etheria to make it better and take it away from the immature hands of the princesses.

He had failed. He had held the power of an entire army at his fingertips and had failed to win a war that he had started. Yet she, from a prison cell, magic-less and alone had done what he never could. All of the princesses were under her thrall now, Glimmer her tame second in command. They were caged and cowed and

all it had taken was meticulous planning, unbound patients and a catalyst. She had waited and waited for the right moment and then Catra had provided it.

Today was a very good day. With Glimmer at her side, Shadow Weaver flowed through the room, magic once again flowing through her from her connection with the younger woman. She ignored the cowering figures in her shadow cells, her eyes fixed on one and one alone. Behind them guards followed. She may have won, but she would not grow complacent. There would be others coming for them and her plans were too important. Etheria deserved more than these privileged fools could offer it. Only she had the vision to control the magic and direct it to its full potential.

Standing outside the furthest cell she looked at Queen Angella, that filthy beast settled across her lap and scoffed. Of course the foolish woman would try to help the lost cause. It was why she was so weak. She lacked vision. She should be trying to work out a way to save her people, not trying to wake the dead.

"Queen Angella, I see you have replaced one child with another." It was a well aimed barb that made the small woman at her side flinch, even as deeply under her thrall as she was. It didn't hurt to keep working at the wedge that she had been sliding between them over the years and, if she were honest, it amused her.

"You won't get away with this, you witch!" Queen Angella kept her voice calm and level as she glared daggers at her captor.

"Foolish woman! I have already 'got away with it'. I have been getting away with this for years, right under your nose. It was you who let me wander the palace, who looked away when you thought my magic was gone. You who couldn't see your daughter was lost. She came to me." The smugness in her voice filled Angella with rage.

"You liar!" This was louder, less controlled.

“You’re the liar.” It was Glimmer’s flat voice that replied, “You promised me that I would get more responsibility after the war but all I was good for was throw away projects and digging in the dirt. I let battles. Now I am nothing but your secretary.” Shadow Weaver grinned with pride under her mask, she hadn’t even had to plant that hate just feed it.

“Enjoy your cell, Your Majesty. I’ll come back to put out the trash.” In a swirl of crimson robes she was moving away, there was still a lot to do.

“You won’t get away with this!” It was called after her and she let out a laugh.

“You think Adora and Micah will come and rescue you? You’re a bigger fool than I thought. I taught them both. There is nothing they can do that I will not anticipate. I will capture them both and you will all rot together.”

Catra held Yarsha close, running her hand up and down the girl’s back as she trembled with fear. She whispered soft words to her, comfort and reassurance, that things would be all right. That she would be fine. That it was all right to leave the protective circle of her arms. The girl’s head just shook more as she buried it further into the fur of her Ra’s neck. At least the tears seemed to have stopped.

Another hand joined hers on the child’s back and rubbed in soft circles over the smooth fabric of her uniform. The stuttering breaths began to calm al last, the gentle touch of the two women calming the kitten’s rapid breathing. She pulled her shaggy head away from her Ra and turned to look at her other parent with a big smile painted across her face. Things were different now, they had always been good but now they were better. There was double the love.

“There she is!” The bright voice only made her smile widen as she threw herself from one pair of arms to the other. This time she didn’t burrow in though, she just gave a tight squeeze that was happily returned before squirming and jumping down to the floor.

Catra looked between her mate and her daughter and felt dizzy, everything fuzzy for a moment. Dark and cold replaced the bright warmth of the day before everything snapped back into brilliant colour. She smiled down at the little girl with her hand upraised, expectantly looking to her. She grasped one hand while the woman at her side took the other and together the three of them walked towards the school gates. Every four steps they swung the little one off of her feet between them, hearing her delighted laughter.

Finally it was time. They joined the small group of other parents bringing their children to school for the first time. Catra still thought that six seemed too small to leave her daughter all day with strangers, but the smiling faces looking at her told her how ridiculous she was being without words. Yarsha finished hugging her other parent before turning to Catra and smiling her bright eyed smile.

Catra crouched down low, Yarsha had grown but not much, and the child threw her arms around her neck again as she folded her into her arms and held her tightly to her chest. They stayed that way until the shrill whine of a siren began to wail. Catra’s ears twitched at the painful sound before it settled down into the sound of a school bell.

It was time to let go.

Running her fingers through the sticky, clumped hair, trying to separate strands in a futile attempt to give the young woman some comfort as her life slowly ebbed away Angella felt helpless. The woman was cold to the touch, Angella’s own body help long since passed helping. She could feel the breaths growing more

laboured and knew that she would not last much longer. That she had held on for hours as it was showed her strength.

Just about ready to let the younger woman go, the scream of a siren filled the air. It was a sound that was so discordant that it made even the vacant eyes of the other people in the room shift to look up for some sign of danger. The sound didn't last long, but it was a welcome distraction from the thought of the girl dying in her arms.

The siren cut and was replaced with the sound of a scuffle and somebody, more than one somebody, being dragged against their will into the room. Angella looked towards the sound and saw Frosta and Adora fighting against the grasping hands of a half dozen guards. There was no sign of Shadow Weaver or Glimmer and for that she was thankful. There was no way that Adora and Frosta had been taken so quickly or so easily. In the kerfuffle Frosta met her eye and nodded.

A plan then, and not a moment too soon. Angella bowed her head close to a limp and lifeless ear and spoke as softly as butterfly wings. "The cavalry is here, Catra, hold on just a little longer."

Chapter 23

Chapter Summary

It might not be nine lives but it's something.

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the wait - this chapter has killed me and I am still unhappy with it but it's time to release it to the wild. I am halfway through the next chapter already though so there's that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Being searched and shackled had been humiliating for Adora, but necessary to sell the ruse that DT was a guard who had captured them. Even in their strangely glazed state, the brisk hands had ghosted all over her body, looking for any hint of the transformed sword. They had started by looking for her bracer, everybody knew that was where she carried her sword but when they found her wrist bare, they moved to frisk the rest of her. Thankfully she had thought carefully and they had missed the curved metal that was sitting in her cleavage and cupping around her bra. It was a small victory but a victory nonetheless to be armed and fully able to access her powers.

The whole ordeal had been wordless, DT having to bite their tongue more than once, that theatrical nature of their's bursting to get out but they had succeeded and been guided to one of the large rooms that filled the castle. Inside the lights were dim and dotting the floor were large circular voids that contained dozens of still figures. Nobody made a move to turn towards them as the doors were noisily pushed aside. This was not the whole of the castle, there must be other rooms filled with these isolated cells, Adora just hoped that it was the right one. They had to be able to search, there was no point being placed in one if it was the wrong one.

As planned, Frosta and Adora begun to cause a fracas, pulling against their shackles and shouting, hoping that Angella would hear them and be able to respond. It was quick, but Frosta caught a glimpse of pale skin and paler purple fabric in the back corner, sharing a look with the queen and kicking out at DT to get their attention. Phibin had been wrestling with one of the taller guards, finding himself in a headlock and, seeing that they were now been hustled in a particular direction, let him body go completely limp and boneless in that way that cats can. His huge bulk, suddenly made almost liquid, pulled the guard down with him until he could wriggle free and join the small group as they were pushed through the shadowy forcefield that surrounded a familiar group.

Phibin recoiled as the scent of blood filled his nostrils. It was strong and smelt stagnant, as though it had been spilled some time ago. They had been directed to the cell-like area of the room that contained Angella and a dozen others, including Mermista and Scorpia. It had been shockingly easy for Double Trouble to insert themself into a group of soldiers, their zombie like state meaning that didn't question another in their ranks. They had easily been able to direct Adora's group to where they needed to be and get them thrown inside without raising any suspicions. There was no need for DT to stay with the guards, She-ra's powers would be able to break them out of the cell when the time came, so they melted into the darkness and simply waited for the guards to leave, no doubt on their way to gather Shadow Weaver to survey her newest prisoners.

Once the guards were gone, the room seemed empty of life. All they could hear around them was even, uniform breaths as though everybody was a puppet being animated by the same strings. Phibin had no time to contemplate that though, he was too fixed on the darker corner where Catra's body lay across Queen Angella's lap looking like a child in the tall woman's arms. He rushed to her side, Adora beside him. He saw her reach for her hidden sword, pulling it free with a muted shimmer as it changed shape and wrapped around her wrist again. Uncaring about the feel of the congealing blood against his knees, he reached out to take Catra from the queen and drew her head up to his shoulder,

cradling her like a child. She felt ridiculously small in his arms in a way he had never thought of her.

From the corner of his eye he watched as Adora began to glow, reaching out an open hand towards the dying woman. He pulled her away, shielding her with his body and shaking his head at the blond whose brows drew angrily as she made to grab his shoulder and force him back to her.

"Don't waste your time." His hiss was low but cut through the darkness, he knew they were all watching him then. "Your magic is no good here, for this. Go and revive the others in here, like you did for Frosta and Perfuma. I can fix her." She looked sullen but followed his instructions. He wondered what part of him had ever wanted to lead and thanked all that was sacred that he had long outgrown that.

Taking a deep breath, he dredged up all of the knowledge that had been bestowed on him as a boy and all of his courage. He placed a kiss on the wounded forehead and then sealed their lips together in a grim parody of a kiss, pouring his energy into her through their sealed lips. As his life flowed out of him and into her, his body began to tremble and he felt a reassuring presence at his back, holding him steady and didn't need to look to know it was Double Trouble.

Through the connection he could feel his heart begin to slow as hers restarted again and warmth seeped into her skin. He wasn't sure how much he could give her, but knew that she had been almost dead when he touched her. He gave and gave, the sounds around him growing fainter and further away. As his vision began to fade and his fingers grew slack, he tried desperately to keep a hold on his friend. Just a little more.

There had been only blackness for so long, the feeling of floating all consuming. First Tace had drifted away, a wane smile on her face as Catra felt pulled away reaching for her only to clutch at nothing. She had watched as the other girl grew more distant but

never really disappeared, just grew too far away to see. Next was Yarsha, her small but not small enough hand slipping out of her own with a giggle as she drifted in another direction away from her. That was when tears started to make their way down her cheeks in the dark place. Until the feeling of her own body was gone and all there was, was self.

Still Adora was there in the distance, golden light softly glowing in the nothingness. She had moved in and out of this time, sometimes with Catra and Yarsha and others gone. Always there in any version of a now and what was to come. Tace had been in the now and the then. Tace with her gentle green eyes and infinite patients and wisdom. Approving of forgiveness.

Then she was moving, slowly at first and then faster and faster until she was gasping in the blackness, disoriented and panicked. She was going somewhere but the dark was warm and somewhere Tace and Adora were both there. But the blackness was fading to grey and then white. White everywhere, surrounding her and touching her. There was sensation, touch and smell and sound and it was overwhelming. She couldn't move even as her eyes fluttered open as the arms holding her up became slack and useless.

Catra fell the short distance to the floor when Phibin blacked out. It was enough of a jolt to make her gasp, eyes looking around in confusion at the scared faces all around her. Adora was there, he sweet, honest face smiling at her as though she had just remade the world and everything was spinning. Where was Tace if Adora was here? Was she touching her.

Dragging her aching body to her knees, mind slowly clearing even as almost blinding pain filled her head, she was able to finally take in the world around her. Phibin was laying in a pool of blood, Queen Angella and DT tending to him, while Lonnie and Scorpia stood with Adora and a few others in a place that seemed tiny even as the room spread out around them. She reached up a hand and felt the stickiness of old blood on her fingers, touching it to her slick forehead and knew.

Phibin had made a sacrifice for her and they were in a lot of trouble.

The sense of urgency burned under her skin. The need to rip and tear, to turn tail and storm the castle until she had her hands bathed in the blood of her enemy pounded under her skin. If it could, her fur would be standing on end, only the blood caked so thickly all over her prevented it staining her ruddy and hiding her stripes. If she let it, she would gag at the stench of her own putridity, but there was no time for any thought but survival. Turning back would satisfy for only a moment before she was torn down and that would serve nobody but a foolish need for revenge. If she were younger, unencumbered by attachments and soft things like love, she would have. What care had she to live? She wasn't that girl anymore though, she had a whole world of people looking out for her and looking to her, and Yarsha most of all.

Catra had pushed out ahead of the others, leaving a gap between herself and those who had saved her. Even after the breathless explanation of what had happened during their escape, everything seemed unreal. One minute she had been walking back from delivering Yarsha to have a playdate with Stanley before heading to a meeting and the next she was coming to smothered in her own blood and cradled in the queen's arms while Phibin collapsed in front of her. Nothing made much sense after that, least of all that Shadow Weaver had been in the castle all along and was responsible for all this. She knew she needed to know more, but all she could do right now was survive and keep the others alive alongside her until they reached this safe haven hidden in the woods.

As they moved through the woods, the group was deathly quiet, each lost in their own tumultuous thoughts. Even Sturgio, usually as loud and obnoxious as his father, simply hid his face in his father's collar and kept quiet and hidden. Whatever turmoil had been going through his mind when he was locked away by

Shadow Weavers magic had left him very afraid. Or maybe it was the blood. The giant pool on the floor that had painted Phibin's light fur dark red. That would be enough to steal the words of any child.

After hours of walking, darkness was falling rapidly, the Whispering Woods the perfect cover for an escape though not easy to traverse even for those who it favoured at night. The library was a full days journey from the castle, and they had not made their escape until the day moon was already cresting. It only made sense to find a place to camp. Catra's nerves were buzzing, what Phibin had done for her had infused her with more than just life-force, but a feeling of near boundless energy that she knew would not allow her to sleep, but the others were flagging. Scorpia had begun to stumble, crashing a large claw through the bark of a tree, the sound echoing in the silence and making the white haired woman cringe in a way she hadn't seen in years. Holding up her arm, fist clenched, she called a halt to the group. The small batch of her people who had been released with her, along with Adora recognised the sign for what it was and the others stopped as they did.

"We need to bed down for the night. Everybody is tired and it does us no good to get captured because we're too exhausted to fight back." Catra's voice was flat even to her own ears, it was that or scream. She looked to Adora who was biting her lip and trying hard not to shoot glances at her.

"Catra is right, I'm afraid I may fall down if we go much further." Queen Angella's voice maintained that air of quiet authority that seemed to calm the nerves. All eyes turned to her and Catra felt something sag with relief inside her at not being the one that they were looking to. "Does anyone recognise where we are?"

"There's a glen about ten minutes that way," Adora pointed a hand that trembled slightly. "We're close to where I usually see Razz," she saw the people from Oasis look at her strangely, not know what or who Razz was but pushed on. "I recognise that gnarly

tree over there. There's a canopy that covers the entrance. We should be shielded."

The others agreed mutely, and followed as she led the way. Catra had dropped to the back and, as they finally reached the hideaway, had peeled off and disappeared completely. Adora tried not to panic. The sight of the other woman laying, barely alive, across the queen's lap was etched into the back of her eyelids and now she was gone. For a terrible moment, the world blurred around the edges. They'd been too late to save the magicat, She-ra had been impotent and she wasn't with them at all. She started to sway on her feet, only a strong hand wrapping around her bicep keeping her on her feet.

Blinking away the panic, she found Lonnie's eyes looking at her sadly, clearly able to tell some of what she was thinking. They stood together in silence as they both turned their attention to the makeshift camp being cobbled together out of moss and leaves. There would be no chance of a fire, so people were getting into small groups to keep warm over night. It was at least a blessing that it was spring and not winter for their escape. Along with Lonnie and Scorpia there were a handful of other Oasis citizens along for the rides none of them magicats who were obviously former Horde fro the way that they organised the clearing.

Adora felt hesitant to move forward, every part of her screaming that Catra should not be left alone but very aware of the fact that whenever they were alone together things started to turn sour. Lonnie squeezed the arm that she was still holding and Adora was again captured by eyes that seemed much wiser than she remembered.

"Sea Hawk!" Lonnie"s sudden shout started everyone, and she smiled a sheepish apology. "Give me your shirt, will ya."

"Fair Lonnie, I fear it is not your style." The man could bounce back, she could give him that. His mirthful voice quivered at the edges but it soothed his wife and son to hear him sound himself.

Lonnie was glad that she had got to see the man behind the clown while they had been working together in Oasis.

“Catra’s going to need new clothes, pretty sure she smelt water and went off to wash.” She didn’t need to mention the blood, they’d all seen it.

Wordlessly Sea Hawk set down his child and removed his coat before pulling the white shirt over his head and balling it up to throw at her. She caught it easily and then noticed that somebody else was lightly disrobing. The stocky woman turned to see that Queen Angella had removed her cape and was also handing it out.

“She’ll need to change out of her pants too.” It was such a simple thing, but seemed so unbearably kind in the moment that Lonnie wanted to reach out and give the older woman a hug, she didn’t but saw that Scorpia was fiddling over to her with her big soft eyes and smiled to herself. The queen was about to get a really great hug.

Lonnie pushed the small pile fabric into Adora’s arms. “Do you know where she would have gone for water?” Adora fumbled with her now full arms and nodded. “Then you can take these to her and maybe talk. I think you need to.” It was unusual to see Adora so quiet, she had so easily slotted into the day to day life of Capital that it was sometimes easy to forget that she had never really been one of them, even though she could have been.

The small pool with its fast running waterfall wasn’t far, and as she walked closer she could make out the rush of the water. It was probably that which had pulled Catra away. The closer she walked, the more she felt like she could breath again. Catra would be there and safe.

As she rounded the corner, darkens having fully fallen, she saw the woman in her thoughts standing under the rush of the waterfall. It was barely taller than she was, but enough that the water was making her figure a blur in the phosphorescent glow of the moss that dotted the place. It was beautiful. She had only

ever been here in the day and had no idea of how the place would transform. Careful not to startle the woman under the stream, she moved to where the stiff and blood soaked clothes had been discarded. She sat on a lightly glowing rock, the bundle of clothes on her lap and tried not to watch the naked figure distorted by the water.

She had seen Catra shower a million times as they grew up, but they had been different people then. All she wanted now was to reassure herself that the magicat was in one piece, but she wasn't sure that her care would be welcomed.

It was too dark to tell, but she was certain that the water that ran away from the fall was darkened with the blood of the woman who was scrabbling at her hair. Even with her movements distorted by the water, Adora could tell that she was growing frustrated as she pulled at the longer locks. A growl, louder even than the rushing water, met her ears and Catra stormed out from the water, fur plastered to her body. She stalked purposely towards Adora.

"Give me your sword." Catra's eyes were burning and her hand was stretched out, there was no question that she would hand it over to the dripping woman.

Catra wrapped her hand around the hilt, cold fingers brushing against bare flesh. "Can you make it a dagger?" Adora thought and the sword shrank until Catra lifted from her hands and walked away. Adora didn't follow her, but even her human hearing could make out the sound of a blade slicing through hair, and the grunt of frustration that she knew from growing up.

Adora put the clothes down and cautiously made her way to the other woman, finding her hacking away at the longer hair that was still matted with blood. Approaching as though she would scare Catra away, she gently rested her hand on a rapidly cooling shoulder. She needed to get Catra to put some clothes on before she got hyperthermia. The shoulder under her hand tensed but she didn't pull away.

“I can do it.” Adora pitched her voice low, as soft as she could, and was shocked when the tagged was passed over Catra’s shoulder without resistance.

Catra sank onto a tall rock that was close by, making it much easier for Adora to reach her head. With a thought, the dagger in her hand became scissors and she started to cut away at the already butchered hair. The shorter hair of her undercut was darker than the rest of her fur but no longer. There was no way that Adora was willing to get that close, she snorted through her nose as she realised she was about to give Catra a very poor, very spiky mohawk.

“What?” Catra’s voice was rough but not unkind as she commented on the snort.

“Just thinking about what you’re going to look like once I’m done.” There was a non committal hum from below her. Adora noticed that the thin braid of hair that usually fell in front of Catra’s left ear, cuffed with gold, had already been removed.

They fell silent, save for the sound of the water and the scissors. Adora had done this once before, when they had been eight. Catra had never told her what happened, but one day she had returned to the bunks with glue caked in one side of her hair and tufts of it singed away. Little Adora had grabbed her hand and pulled her to the showers, but even with the two of them the glue stayed firm. With big, sad eyes, Catra had asked her to get rid of it and Adora had managed to sneak into a storage closet and get some scissors that were mostly blunt and run haphazardly back to the other girl who was curled up in the corner of the locker room, shivering on a bench. Adora had hacked at the hair, leaving it looking mangled but burn and glue free. It hadn’t been as short as it was about to be, but Catra had been more subdued that usual for a long time afterward.

Her hair had always been something that Catra had used as a shield when they were younger, before she found the mask that would later be the thing she hid behind. Whoever had hurt that

day had known that and used it against her. It had taken almost six months for Catra's hair to grow back to normal and in that time she had started to be even more prickly than before.

"Doesn't matter." Catra's tension was clear through her shoulders and jaw, that Adora wanted to reach down and cup but resisted.

"Do you remember when we were kids?" The deep sigh showed that Catra knew exactly what she was thinking about.

"It was Octavia and a couple of her toadies. They jumped me and set fire to my hair, one of them must have thought that was too dangerous though and then they found the industrial glue." She hadn't wanted Adora to know back then, she had some pride after all. It didn't matter now though.

"Oh." Adora wasn't sure what she had expected. "Not Shadow Weaver."

Catra spun at that, luckily Adora had cut away the last of the matted hair just in time not to take an ear, her eyes were boring into Adora who fought the urge to step back. This close, the jagged indentation in her forehead was still visible even in the dim light. It seemed that whatever magic Phibin had wrought had not wiped away the injury that she had suffered, simply speeded up the process.

"How could you not tell me she was there?" Adora might have expected the words to be angry, to rip through her with rage, maybe be followed with a punch, but they were just broken and exhausted. The fell between them like iron, hot and heavy. They weighed on Adora, who wasn't sure she had a good answer.

Catra growled, shaking her head and pushing passed Adora, back to where she had abandoned her filthy clothes, head feeling too light and too cool. She could hear the human following her but ignored her, fixed on trying to clean the blood from her shirt when she noticed the small piled of fabric on the neighbouring rock. Her

growl turned to a sigh as she slumped down, pushing her magicat garb onto the mossy ground and holding her head in her hands.

Adora chose that moment to sit down beside her, shoulder lightly touching her own and just looking out to the waterfall. The silence between them was tense and laced with far more that the presence of Shadow Weaver that had always stood between them, even as children. It was Catra who broke the silence.

“Do you hate me that much?” She didn’t need to look up to know that those guileless blue eyes were staring at the top of her cropped head and wished that she hadn’t let the soft words out.

“I’ve never hated you, how can you even think that.” Adora shivered in the night and blamed the cold.

“Then why would you let me bring my people, my daughter, into a place where that monster was?” She was looking at the blond now, eyes hard.

“I forgot she was there!” It was almost a shout. “I told them from the start not to let her stay in the castle. The king and I wanted her gone years ago but the others made her a bigger prison and put her out of sight in the castle. I’ve been avoiding her for years! Then there you were and all I could think of!” She slapped a hand over her mouth, shame and guilt at war inside her.

“Stars! Why are you like this?” There was fond exasperation there and when Adora met her eyes again the anger seemed to have gone back to a simmer.

“Sorry?” She wasn’t sure what she was apologising for in that moment.

“I know you are Adora.” Catra reached out, suddenly very aware of her nudity, and snagged the blousy white shirt, pulling it over her head and letting it fall until she was at least covered. She pulled the other sheath of fabric and considered what to do with it.

“I wanted to heal you, back there.” Fabric tearing filled the quiet between them.

“Wouldn’t have worked.” Catra was fashioning a sarong out of some of Angella’s cape and seemed satisfied that it would last until the library.

“Phibin stopped me and then did…What was that?” The sight of the oddly intimate moment between the two magicats had been playing in her mind ever since.

“He gave me his life-force. Magicats are immune to other magic but that is the one piece of our own. We can offer almost all of our life-force to another to keep them alive. I’m still injured and he is weakened but he didn’t take on the injuries.” Catra’s claws were scratching at the stone, leaving deep scores as she spoke.

“It was different to any magic I have ever seen, primal.” Frightening.

“Yeah. We can all do it, you know. Just have to open ourselves up and,” she clicked her fingers and the anger was back but not directed at Adora this time, “just like that you’re fine.”

“Have you done it?” It was either exactly the right thing to say or very, very wrong.

“No. I didn’t know…” It was the saddest Adora had ever heard her, and she had been sad for what seemed like their whole life.

“We should go back.” Adora held out her hand surprised when Catra took it, still wordless. She would tell Adora who she hadn’t saved in her own time.

The throne room was dark, the once bright pastel colours as muted as the woman who now sat upon it. Shadow Weaver lounged in the impressive seat and admired all that she had achieved. Years of preparation and the good luck to find a new potential enemy had made possible what had, for a while, seemed

an idle daydream. She looked to her side where Glimmer sat blankly on the smaller throne intended for her father.

When the younger woman had first started to come to her, all her pent up rage had been directed at the old sorcerer. She had been a convenient outlet for a young woman who felt like her lives work had been stolen out from under her. There were no battles left to win, no enemies to fight and she was left to rebuild. She was not a builder, she was a destroyer just like Shadow Weaver and she had seen the potential there even as she had been railed against.

What a woman in a glass jar has is time. Glimmer had come daily in the aftermath of the aborted war, threatening and blaming, Shadow Weaver had simply waited in silence. She had health with spoilt brats before. If she could control a force as wild and untameable as Catra for a lifetime, she could certainly win her way into this spoilt little princesses head.

Her patience had paid off when she had been moved to the all but abandoned wing of the castle and been left to fester away. Glimmer had still come looking for her but the anger had shifted, the malice directed far more inwards than before and it was then that she had pounced. Not with a punch or an attack, but with practiced kindness. Glimmer was far more like her father than she imagined, a well placed word, a gentle hand and a grandmotherly cup of tea and she opened up like a flower parched in the desert. It was almost too easy. She had cultivated her like one of the dark blooms in her green house over the passage of years. Little-by-little filling her with potions that would allow her to take control. Now she was a pretty, powerful little puppet.

Adora was in her clutches, the castle was subdued and it was only a matter of time before the fools who followed Catra attacked to save her. That would be all she would need to bring the controlled Princesses together with their kingdoms to fight back. They would win easily and she would control them all. She had tried being good, in Mysticore, had attempted to be the loyal underlying of a

despot only to find him wanting but now she was in control and Etheria would know true order and magic.

Thinking of the magicat, she waved her hand and a wave of shadow formed in front of her. She waved her hand and was able to look at the small huddle of magicats. They were in one of the smaller rooms, guards all around them as she did not trust the forcefield to hold them. She had heard what Catra had revealed in the garden, it was a small spanner in her plans but not all force needed to be magical. Catra had succumbed easily enough to brute force. The dark shadow in the main holding area was before her now and she watched as the queen petted futilely at the dank fur. The dark and bloodied form was completely still. Finally the garbage was finally gone.

"Guard." Four faces lining the walls turned to face her, one under her power. "Throw out the trash would you." She waved her hand towards the image in front of her and they were away to dispose of the corpse. No need to let Angella or the princess from Selineas sick from being stuck with that rot.

The soldiers marched out and she stood from the throne, moving to stand in front of the black eyed princess. She reached out for her and found her hand taken in the smaller woman's papery one and she took got to her feet. They had more work to do.

"Come, Glimmer dear, you were going to show me the Moonstone up close." The Black Garnet may be gone, but it paled when compared to the power of Brightmoon's rune.

"I was?" The voice seemed momentarily confused, Shadow Weaver tucked that away and assured herself that's she would dose her again later. "I was." There was the certainty.

"Thank you. Perhaps your husband will be able to join us for dinner." There was something to be said to knowing all of your minion's weaknesses. Glimmer's eyes glowed at the mention of her husband, even bedazzled as she was. Control could come in many forms.

Sitting in the cold, slimy blood, the weight of the shallowly breathing Phibin across their lap, Double Trouble wondered how they had got to this moment. Ten years ago the only person they had cared about was themself and where the next infusion of cash would come from. There had been no-one that they cared about and nobody cared about them. Then there had been Catra and her snarky, angry hurt that Double Trouble felt drawn to first taunt and then sooth. The day the pair had found the Halfmoon had changed them though, far more than anything else.

Double Trouble may have been morally grey their whole life, but death on that scale was something that they had always managed to avoid, staying well clear of the war. Seeing it had altered something inside them; watching Catra discover the children and where she had come from had been something that had changed them both. Little had they known that Phibin would become somebody who would matter so much to them.

Stroking a pale, elegant hand through fur that was crisp and disgusting, DT wished that it was their own green hand and not the guise of the queen. Phibin had been such a brash young man, fighting for position against both Tace and Catra. He had been square jawed and built like a warrior, though it had been easy to see that his muscle was all for show. His initial hostility and attempt at something like a coup had ended quickly though. He was just a young man who had lost everything and wasn't sure who he should be. It hadn't taken him long to find his place though. Without the expectation of parents or his people on his shoulders he had become soft, physically and mentally.

That was when Double Trouble had first noticed him. As he became a tubby, affable man and not the roughly hewn boy who had woken up, Double Trouble had felt drawn to him and they had shared their time with each other ever since. He was not the shape shifter's only paramour, but he was their favourite and

sitting with him near dead, DT wondered if it was time to consider settling down. They tilted their head down, touching foreheads with the slowly warming one in their lap. It was as good as a kiss among the magicats. Still bowed over the vulnerable form, it took a moment for the small ears that they were currently sporting to catch the sound of guards coming.

The shape shifter straightened, watching as a new group of guards entered the main doors and made straight for their cone of shadows. This was to be their chance to escape then. The lizard withdrew from under Phibin, placing his head gently onto the ground before hiding in the shadows and dissolving back into the form of one of the guards. They brought their hand up to check that the communicator was still sitting in their ear after transforming, they would need it soon. As the shield went down and the group entered, eye only fixed on the still form on the ground, it was easy to join them without question.

Double Trouble had to bite their lip when two of them roughly grabbed the magicat under the arms and began to drag him away. A thick trail of gore painting the ground behind his feet. Wherever they were taking the man they thought was Catra, it couldn't be allowed. Thankful that their body was stronger than it looked under the disguise, DT moved forward with purpose and reached for the limp man, managing with only a little effort to throw him over his shoulder. Nobody moved, empty masked faces directed to them.

"The blood will bring pestilence that Shadow Weaver will not want. I will take this to the incinerator," it was as good a guess as any and based on the terrible things that Catra had let slip over the years. It seemed to quell any suspicion, the other guards fanning out to clean oblivious to the now empty cell or disappearing imposters.

It took effort but they were in the quietest part of the garden before Double Trouble let their shape transform back to its normal self and checked the pulse of the bloodied figure that was yet to

stir. Sighing in relief, Double Trouble touched the communicator and waited.

“DT?” Catra’s voice trickled tinnily though the connection and it was a relief to hear it.

“Kitten, you need to get Adora to send her magic horse now. We’re in the same place he picked up Yarsha.” There was no answer on the other line, but the lizard waited, watching the sky.

It was a long fifteen minutes, no alarm yet blaring, before a speck in the sky circled down to join them. The alicorn landed lightly and lowered his body to help DT get the limp man onto his back. It wasn’t graceful, but Phibin was slung across him like a sack and DT clambered up behind, ready to hold him steady. No words were spoken as the alicorn beat his wings back into the sky, taking them far from the darkness that was spreading.

Chapter End Notes

Next time - we're coming together!

Chapter 24

Chapter Summary

Let's get to the library!

The night had been long and Catra had not slept. She had allowed Adora to lead her back to the impromptu camp and turned her hand to helping set up a perimeter and as much comfort as they could. She had brought down bushels of leaves and even helped Mermista to build something like a nest for Sturgio to sleep in. As they worked side by side, Mermista kept casting looks at her though her eyelashes. Catra didn't have the capacity to deal with the older woman's guilt, so kept tight lipped, walking away when the job was done without a word.

It was, of course, impossible to be alone in this small place of hiding, and as fast as she distanced herself from Mermista and her family, she was joined by Queen Angella. Part of her, young and hateful and bubbling to the top with the revelation that her childhood tormentor had been embraced by the Alliance all these years, longed to lash out at the woman who had shown her nothing but kindness and understanding in the passing week. The other part, the part that had been tempered by age and responsibility could only look at her with disappointment but didn't pull away when the older woman reached out to cautiously touch her newly butchered hair.

"Catra, I know that there is nothing I can say." Catra stepped back at her words, eyes wary, disengaging from the caring touch. Her eyes darted around, glad that Adora was working with her people to fortify the camp as best they can with Scorpia using her claws and Adora her sword, to fashion crude weapons. If she walked away now, perhaps nobody would follow.

Angella's eyes were soft, glassy in a way that she had never seen, and she looked away, whirling around to walk back into the trees. Perhaps she could patrol, protect the others while they slept.

There was no way that she could sleep, with Shadow Weaver out for her blood and her child stars know where. Footsteps followed her and she knew it was the queen. It seemed that these people didn't become less persistent with age. Catra rested her head against a tree and flexed out her claws, piercing the bark and sinking them deep into the wood beneath.

"This is our fault, my fault. Mika has told me for years that my hubris about Shadow Weaver would hurt us and I didn't listen. I think I had some noble idea that she would change or maybe I hoped she would just disappear. I know that she was cruel to you children, I've seen how Adora shies away from her. I'm sorry. And now you have been pulled into a coup by somebody with a vendetta against you." Angella's voice was genuine but Catra found her hands gripping hard and felt the wood splintering.

"Cruel? She tortured me for years!" Catra's voice hissed with low menace, all of the pain and self loathing beaten into her as a child bubbling up, the stress of the day breaking her defences. "She would tie me up, electrocute me, starve me all for being a kitten or being Adora's friend. She is more of a monster than Hordak ever was and you wanted him to face consequences." She could feel the blood thundering in his ears and tried to keep her breathing even. "You should go back to the others now."

Angella opened her mouth to say something, what she wasn't sure. To hear even a little of what Shadow Weaver had inflicted on this woman as a child made her feel sick and intensified the self indulgent guilt that she was allowing herself to feel. Taking the younger woman's advice she walked back to help finish setting up camp, passing Scorpia and Lonnie on her way. Adora stood a little way away, looking after the other women with want in her eyes, but on seeing the queen smiled wanly and started to gather large leaves for them to sleep on.

Scorpia had tenderly wrapped Catra in her arms, loosely enough that she could escape the hold easily should she need to while Lonnie cupped her hands, gently massaging the backs until they unclenched and withdrew from the tree, droplets of blood oozing

from small cuts and a few splinters poking out. There were no words needed for the three of them, Lonnie simply pulled out the shards of wood while Scorpia pressed a kiss to Catra's temple. It had been grounding.

She had ushered them all back to the clearing soon after, duty and worry driving her to ensure that everyone was together. She had watched as Sturgio was placed on the little nest made for him, with Mermista and Sea Hawk bracketing him on either side, their arms over him, resting on each others shoulders. It filled her with longing. The Oasis group were already hunkered down and Scorpia and Lonnie moved to join them, but Catra grasped Lonnie's wrist to forestall her movements. She jerked her head towards Adora and Queen Angella who were laying away from the others and each other.

"Get them to be closer together, stay with them. They'll get cold like that and I need everyone to be able to hustle in the morning." She whispered her instructions to her old friend.

"You could tell them that yourself." Lonnie's green eyes were sympathetic as she looked into the mismatched ones that refused to settle on the two prone women.

"Not tonight Lonnie, all right. No bossing me around today. Just go and do as I ask. I'll keep watch."

"You almost died today, Wildcat. YOU need sleep." Scorpia's very loud version of a whisper joined the discussion and Catra watched as Adora tried to pretend she wasn't eavesdropping, she couldn't even lie with body language. Catra shook her head, she didn't want to feel affection for the older woman just now.

"The energy transfer won't let me sleep. I feel like i'll never need to sleep again. Just get some rest so we can get to the library first thing." She was grateful when they didn't argue more and watched as they rearranged the women and themselves. Satisfied that they were all close enough, Catra took to the tallest tree overlooking the clearing and prepared to protect these people.

Now, dawn was breaking, her palms itched to shake the blond awake and demand she take her to her daughter. Once it had been clear that they were not being followed she had found her eyes resting on the blond's sprawled out form more and more in the moonlight. She could see her face clearly enough and had let her eyes move over contours that looked just as they had when they were children, relaxed and young in sleep. Catra stretched from the couch she had been in most of the night and lightly jumped to the ground. It was time to get moving.

After Micah had used his magic to teleport himself to Mysticore, Perfuma had been left alone at the barrier. On the outside of the barrier to be precise. She stood, a single pillar of colour in the muted sand and tried not to weep. Tears glistened in her eyes and she blinks rapidly, she was on a mission and everyone was counting in her. It was the first moment since coming to in the garden, that she had a moment to process, though, and a single tear managed to burn its way down her cheek as she reached into the folds of her dress and pulled out the key to the barrier, hoping beyond hope that the frequency had not been changed.

The slim black box felt fragile in her hand, like if she closed her fist too quickly it would shatter and all hope would be lost. She would never see Scorpia again, Yarsha would never see Catra. Before she pressed the keys, she wished that she had some way to make contact with the others, but the only coms they'd had had needed to be split with DT for their plans to work. She hoped that they were all out and safe.

The barrier partnered as it always had, no fanfare or excitement, just the facade of the desert melting away to show a portal into a world that she had helped to make green even to the edges. She stepped through and that was when she saw that some thing had changed. As her foot crossed the threshold into Oasis the mechanical click of a gun filled her ears and she turned her head to see a small squad of five guards standing to the side of the opening. Weapons levelled at her. There were only three access

points along the barrier to Oasis, clearly recent events had led them to post permanent guards ay each one.

Perfuma raised her hands, holding out the key and flinching when it was snatched out of her hand by one of the burly soldiers. She didn't recognise him, the scarf wrapped around his face obscuring it, but a second figure stepped forward to take his place and this person she knew.

Rogelio pulled the scarf from his face, revealing his scaled muzzle. Perfuma had spent a lot of time with the lizard-kin and could read the question written in his eyes. He really was a very expressive man, once you took the time to get to know him. Perfuma walked closer to him, knowing that they were all watching. It was time to be brave.

"Brightmoon has been taken, we don't know what has happened to Catra, everyone seems to have been taken prisoner and we need your help." She hadn't meant to blurt it like that, but the words had just spilled out, she would be more eloquent when she got to the council chamber.

Rogelio stared at the princess with his cool, dark eyes and appraised her. The last time he had seen her was just before she left Scorpia broken and crying in his home. Now she was here claiming that Lonnie was possibly a prisoner and Catra was gone. He grunted an order to the rest of the group and watched in satisfaction as they followed his order. They didn't have to, here he was just a restaurant owner and cook, but these men and women were all ex Horde and they knew what he had to lose. He reached out and gently grasped Perfuma's shoulder, guiding her towards the small transport that sat a small distance away.

He was only out here because he had been worried and agitated by the absence of so much of his family. And that was what Scorpia and Catra were, as much as Lonnie and Kyle. There was nobody that that he would trust more than that group of people and now they were in trouble. Rogelio had put aside fighting. He had left protecting Oasis to the others, he and Kyle taking part in

the rejuvenation of the place. Kyle would laugh that they were the heart and soul while Lonnie and the others were the hand and the head. He might be right.

After the rebellion Rogelio had vowed never to raise his hand in violence again. He had helped distribute food, and when the stockpile of ration bars had been depleted, braved the belly of the Halfmoon looking for anything that had been preserved. It had been hard times in the desert with the doubling of a population, but thankfully the food stores in the birdied ship had been held in the same stasis technology that had kept the children alive. After that it had been an all day task to keep everyone fed until real homes and business had been created. It had only been logical for him to open a restaurant after he realised that he had an aptitude for cooking. He had never wanted to do anything else ever again, except be part of a family.

With Lonnie gone, he had felt compelled to volunteer to patrol though. Some part of him knowing that his family would be endangered if he didn't and now, here was Perfuma telling him that one of his spouses was possibly in danger, or worse. He knew that he would escort her to the council chambers, he needed to know exactly what she knew.

The journey back to the city was quiet, Perfuma's face grim in a way that he had never seen on the woman. It made her look older, harder, and the lizard-kin wondered how much steel there was behind the zen facade that she showed the world. Vaguely he recalled fighting her during the war, but he had never met her one-on-one. Something inside him Tod him that it was a good job.

Then they were walking into the council hall, the leaders having been hurriedly called from the transport. Huntara sat in her centre seat, looking down on the new arrival with speculation in her eyes. Perfuma had started to explain what she knew, which wasn't much Rogelio realised. Adora and her people had stayed back to find out more, the children with them were safe and it seemed Shadow Weaver was behind whatever mind control was happening there. She had no details about the fate of his spouse

or his friends but it seemed certain that whatever had happened to them was nothing good.

"Where were they heading?" Huntara's voice was sober, her eyes fire.

"Bow's fathers live in a library in the heart of the woods, it's impossible to find if you don't know it's there. We should be able to contact them with your tech." Huntara rose from her seat and made her way to the back room, gesturing for them to follow as the other council members moved to call together their people.

Rogelio's palms itched as he wondered how he would tell Kyle and their children if anything had happened to Lonnie and hoped that he would not have to.

Shuffling down the corridor, flanked on either side by bodies that were almost as tall as his own, Hordak steeled himself for whatever vile manipulation his former second in command was about to attempt on him. He was well used to powerful people using words to control him, but Shadow Weaver was no Prime. He had been born suckled to the tit of a universally despotic creature who had crafted himself into a god, and it had taken time, distance and eventual forgiveness from the very people he had become the monster to, to help him see that was not what he had to become. But Shadow Weaver didn't know that.

Pulling himself up, straightening his spine and stiffening his shoulders as he walked, he wished he was wearing something more like his old exosuit, it would have made donning the mask of his old self that much easier. At least he wasn't dressed in the overalls that had become his peacetime uniform, practical and comfortable, still able to hide his imperfections even when Entrapta told him that they made him beautiful. His treacherous mind couldn't always believe those words but he was getting better. For his trip to Brightmoon he had donned a series of collarless suits in a muted colours that squared his body, and he

walked through the doors of the throne room wearing steel grey and black.

The sight of Shadow Weaver splayed on the throne, legs crossed under her long red gown and arms clutching the armrests told him all he needed to know about her current state of mind. Hubris was a powerful weapon if you could wield it correctly, he would simply need stoke her ego and then bide his time. He put on his best snake smile, it felt foreign on his lips after years of sincerity pointed at his family, pulling at his cheeks and dulling his red eyes to embers and looked fixedly at the masked woman, waiting.

Shadow Weaver uncoiled like a snake from the throne she had usurped and stalked towards him, every inch of her telegraphing menace and intimidation. He never flinched. His red eyes followed her movements as he allowed a grim smile to curve his lips, the hint of a red fang peeking out. It was an old expression, recognisable to this woman who had been at his side for the better part of twenty years. He wondered why he had never seen his own evil reflected back to him before. Maybe if he had, many lives would have been saved. The chasm he often felt in his chest, when he looked at the citizens of Oasis who had once been his tools, cracked open a little more and without Entrapta there he felt it bleed. He wondered if it would ever really stop. Finding a conscious had been the making of him, he knew, but it was a harsh master.

"Hordak. Look at you, they had made you small. I barely recognise you." There was a sneer in her voice as it poured out laced with condescension.

"Shadow Weaver, I see that being a pet in a cage has done nothing to limit your ambitions." He could sneer too though he feared it lacked bite.

"Oh, you have no idea. These Brightmoon fools with their simpering and their forgiveness, I've been plotting for years." He wished he could see her eyes, sure now that she was closer that

she was appraising him and fearing that she was finding him wanting.

“Impressive.” He let the word falls from his lips with grim amusement.

“Well, hardly. It wasn’t even a challenge, what with that,” she waved her hand and his attention was momentarily diverted from her and towards the young couple that he now noticed crumpled in the corner like broken marionettes, “silly girl there. It was almost too easy, really.” In as braggadocios as she was, she gave no quarter in revealing her plans.

If Hordak had any hope of helping his people, and perhaps proving himself to the Alliance, he needed to know what she had done. The princess and her husband were still, unmoving, but their eyes were open. He wasn’t close enough to be certain, but the princesses seemed to be staring directly at him lifelessly. There was no doubt in his mind that whatever was at play here, she was as much a pawn as the guards though she may not think it.

“What do you want from me?” He made his voice dark, molten and sinister.

Shadow Weaver didn’t answer straight away, turning and leading him back to the throne that she had stood from. Settling herself, she rested her chin on her fist and looked up at him with that unreadable mask. He had always hated that he couldn’t see her face, but it was not so different from the mask of indifference that his old master had worn.

“You and I are the same, Hordak. We were meant for more than we were born into. Your problem has always been a lack of vision.” He knew that tone, had heard her turn it on the cadets more than once. It burrowed under the skin and made you weak.

“I was always rather single minded I suppose.” It was true, conquest had been a means to an ends for him. A way to impress

a man who had turned his back on him. Sometimes that desire still burned in him, the disconnect from the hive mind leaving a gaping hole inside him that even his family could not fill, but his life was his own for what felt like the first time and he was able to fight the still seductive allure of power.

“Single minded? Small minded. You never saw what we could really achieve. Without more than a few drops of blood I have taken over this kingdom and have the resources to take the others just as easily.” She was so smug that Hordak almost missed the mention of bloodshed.

“Not a bloodless coup then?” He kept his voice flat but worry gnawed at him. He might not be embraced at the heart of his new home, but they had given him a second chance and were friends of a sort.

“Ha!” The bark of laughter was derisive and he almost shivered at the coldness. “Can there even be such a thing? It’s of no consequence, simply putting down a mongrel that I should have let perish years ago.” It was so dismissive, as though the death of another were nothing.

“If you have everything you need to take all of Etheria, why bring me here then?” He crossed his arms over his chest to hide the slight tremor there as he considered Catra dead and her daughter orphaned.

It left a bitter taste in his mouth as he thought about all of the children who had passed through the grinder of his war machine. How many of those had parents killed without a thought and been drafted to do just the same under his rule? He had never even seen them as people. Maybe he could blame it on his own origins, bred in a tube and birthed full grown he had no concept of childhood fragility only of his need for fodder for his war machine. He had left the raising and indoctrination to others, like the woman before him. It had been a mistake he had realised as soon as Stanley had been place in his arms.

"Hordak, we both know that you can't be happy being a lapdog to these people. They obviously have you on a leash in that rat hole in the desert and here they were going to make you pay. You could be my second in command this time, I'll even let you keep your purple haired princess. Now I have the Moonstone my magic will be more powerful than ever, along with your skills, everything will be controlled. Work with me and I will give you one of the kingdoms to run with your little paramour and her whelp."

It was all he could do not to growl as she spoke about Entrapta and their son. It did seem clear that she had not realised that Stanley was also his son, which gave him hope that as far reaching as her magic may have seemed, she had not seen and heard everything about them. He was familiar with her shadow spies, they had been used to his advantage many times, but it would seem that they had not been everywhere.

"A tempting offer to be certain, I have been so bored biding my time in Oasis. I had hoped that I would be able to get these princesses to trust me. It seems we were of the same mind. Where would you like me to start?" He hoped that he sounded convincing.

He needed to get his hands on a communicator and fast.

Angella watched as Catra rushed passed the rest of the group, barrelling though the door of the library heedless of what was going on around her. It wasn't a surprise when Adora followed close on her heels, biting her lip, clearly torn but unable to stop herself. Scorpia too started to lurch forward but Lonnie put her hand on a spiked shoulder and halted her progress, shaking her head mutely and getting an understanding smile in response. For her part, Angella felt her heart lurch as she walked through the door and saw Catra, kneeling on the floor and waiting as the little girl who had just noticed her threw herself into her parent's waiting arms.

Angella felt like weeping as Catra wrapped the small child in her arms and hugged like a woman taking a breath after too long under water. She buried her face in the girl's hair and breathed her in before pulling back and running her hands and eyes over the little one, checking that she was ok. Angella knew that Glimmer was on the wrong side of all of this, but she felt tears forming in her eyes as she thought about how far away she was from her own daughter. Though, really, how close had they really been recently. Was she such a bad mother not to see all of this?

Adora worried at her lip, hands fidgeting at her side as she hovered behind the reunited pair. She felt the need to know that Yarsha was all right burn through her and when Catra stood, tucking Yarsha into her arms and the child reached up to pull on her hair, examining it and moving the older woman's face around with her small hands, she felt choked. Catra only had eyes for her daughter, letting her roughly run her fingers over the deep, still tender scar that now split her forehead.

"Ra?" Giant yellow eyes looked at her parent and Adora could tell that there were tears forming there, the eyes shining, as she took in the wound.

"Yar-Yar, have you been a good girl for Aunt Kesh?" Catra's voice was gravelly but she smiled softly at her baby and Adora felt her heart crack and knew she should step away but her feet felt rooted to the spot.

"Yep! We done reading, this is a book place," pinchy hands had her ear and were pulling it towards the child. "Did you know this was a library Ra?"

"I didn't. Do you like it?" The child's head nodded enthusiastically.

"Me an Stanley broke an old pot!" There was an enormous smile on her face and Adora couldn't hold in the coo that escaped her lips. Catra turned and seemed to notice she was there for the first time, but she couldn't read the expression in those mismatched eyes.

“ADORA!” The kitten was suddenly airborne, fidgeting out of Catra’s arms and into Adora’s. Startled, Adora was barely ready when the weight hit her and staggered, arms coming up convulsively to hold the child whose face was now startlingly close. Vaguely she was away of Catra’s hand resting on the girl’s back.

“Hello Yarsha.” Was that her voice?

“You sound funny! Have you and Ra been on an adventure?” A sharp little finger was tapping her forehead and it felt so familiar that she thought she might break down and cry.

“Yeah. We had an adventure. We both missed you though.” Yarsha preened and then started to rub her head on Adora’s jaw.

Adora looked up, meeting Catra’s eyes as she watched her. She sent her a watery smile, and watched as the other woman’s face grew stormy. Catra didn’t return the expression, just moved to rest her forehead above her hand on Yarsha’s back and her shoulders shook a little. Adora’s fingers itched to reach out the arm not supporting the kitten and rest it just behind a drooping ear but she didn’t dare.

Angella had pulled her attention away from the trio who were clearly groping their way towards something, instead moving to join the others who had been greeted by Entrapta and the young magicat woman. George and Lance were not far behind, she noticed that George was carrying the small purple haired child that she had seen but not really met in the last week. This was Hordak’s son and as she found herself staring at his sharp little face as it rested against the old soldier’s shoulder. Even with his mother’s hair, his face was all Hordak and yet he was soft and fragile as any child and for a fleeting moment she found herself hoping that the former despot was unharmed, if simply to save the child any harm.

The low buzz of frantic talk, none of it focused enough to be useful but all of it screen relief, as George passed the dozing boy

into his mothers cradle of hair, stopped when two more people slowly walked into the room. Phibin rested his not inconsiderable weight onto Double Trouble who was only too happy to lend a shoulder. He looked around and breathed a sigh when he saw Catra with Yarsha. He couldn't stand for long and was manoeuvred to a conveniently placed couch in the foyer.

The big magicat was still weak as a kitten, but by the time that Swift Wind had deposited them at the library in the dead of night, he had regained consciousness. They were greeted by two men who looked wary, one with a crossbow trained on the newcomers. Kesh had appeared at their side, and DT had watched as she placed her hand on the taller man's shoulder and say something that had his smaller companion lowering his weapon. They had helped carry Phibin into the building and up to a bathroom. Double Trouble had run warm water into the bath and stripped the filthy clothes from the man, kicking them out into the hall. With effort they had managed to get the magicat into the tub, not wanting others to see him like this, and washed the blood out of his snowy fur with more care than they may have ever shown anyone. When this was all over, the shapeshifter was going to have to have a long talk with themself.

Catra turned, slowly as though she was afraid that if she looked at him he would disappear. A little whimper left her as she met his pale eyes and he held out trembling arms to her. She looked torn between going to him and staying with her daughter, Adora held the kitten tighter and nodded to the short haired woman trying to show her that Yarsha was all right with her. Then she was moving away, crouching in front of her fellow magicat and raising a hand to wrap around the back of his neck feeling him do the same to her as they brought their foreheads together and closed their eyes, chuffing at each other in a way that not even Adora had heard before. Soon Kesh joined them and everyone felt like they were witnessing something that they shouldn't.

Adora's attention was taken off of the four people by the couch as Queen Angella walked to her and Yarsha. She reached out and stroked a hand down the child's back, making her giggle and purr.

Her little face lit up as she looked at the older woman, looking around her for her husband no doubt. Angella felt that pang that was becoming all too familiar as she realised that after all this she may never see a grandchild of her own.

The calm that had fallen over the room was shattered when an insistent beeping sound started to ring out. Catra's ears twitched, as did Kesh's, and the two of them straightened from Phibin and trend their attention to George who was pulling out a communication pad. It was clearly one of Bow's but modified for his fathers. The moustachioed man swiped a finger across the screen and it first to life with a grave purple face. Huntara's voice filled the room.

Chapter 25

Chapter Summary

> We spend a little time at the library and Hordak does a very bad thing.

Yarsha's little body quivered as she hid behind the curtain. Her tail waved and her ears twitched as she listened for her Ra to come into the room. She had jumped out of the bath shrieking with excitement and run down the hallway, leaving the older magicat saturated in water from thew small tidal wave that she had sent up from the bathtub. The naked ball of dripping fluff had careened down the unfamiliar hallway, almost bumping into several adults, all of whom gave her a soft look as she smiled and kept running.

When she had reached the room that the two nice men had shown to her and Aunt Kesh, she skidded around the corner and ducked behind the long curtain that covered the window. She was a little cold, but the fun of the chase and the capture were running through her tiny body and she barely noticed the damp on her fur. She waited, and waited, and waited until finally her ears caught the sound of feet. She tried not to giggle even as her teeth began to chatter from the cold.

Adora had been walking down the long hallway, socked feet moving softly down the long corridor as she returned from fetching herself a snack from the kitchen. Everyone was heading to bed for an early night, there was nothing that they could do till morning when reinforcements would arrive. It seemed, from what they could glean from Entrapta's quick and messy hack into the communication systems at Brightmoon, that Shadow Weaver was none the wiser about their escape. The woman's ego blinding her to what's going on under her nose was at least giving them some breathing space. Adora knew that Entrapta was trying to patch into Hordak's room, but it was a process that needed to be done with finesse so as not to alert anyone beyond the former war lord.

A large yawn tore out of the blond as she raised a hand to scratch through her short hair, making it stick up in ruffled spikes. All the stress of the situation was catching up with her and the adrenaline had bled out hours before. She passed a room, the door standing open and couldn't help but poke her head around the doorjamb, looking for the inhabitant. George and Lance had taken them all up to the hallway that held their sons' rooms and let them take a room each, before disappearing to retrieve some of the boys old clothes for them to change into. Adora had slipped into the room she knew was Bow's, taking comfort in the space that had become something of a bolt hole over the years and where she had escaped to after the disaster at The Halfmoon, not seeing which rooms the others had picked.

This room was sparsely decorated, the walls a deep blue that mirrored the night sky and a long work table spanned one wall while an easel sat in a corner. There was only a single bed, which meant that there was a lot of floor space for the big soft rug that hugged the floor and drapes that touched the floor. If the easel was anything to go by, this must be Bow's second oldest brother Halberd's room. Realising that she was intruding and not wanting to be caught in someone else's room, Adora made to leave when there was a sudden, ear piercing scream and a small weight collided with her upper back, tiny claws digging into her shirt. Adora tensed on impact, instinctively reaching back to throw the attacker over her shoulder, only managing to pull back at the last moment when she realised that she was now grasping Yarsha by the scruff over her own shoulder.

"I got you 'Dora!" Yarsha's voice was happy and excited, but as she loosened her grip and manoeuvred the child into her arms Adora could feel the shivers running through her damp body.

"Why are you naked, Kitten?" The human walked them to the small en suit that was attached to each room. It contained a toilet, sink and small shower and there were towels hanging on the wall. She took one of the fluffy linens and bundled the small child into it, rubbing it vigorously to warm the child up. She

remembered Catra getting sick when they were children if her fur wasn't dried well enough.

"Ra gave me a bath and I ran away!" She was full of glee, even while little fangs chattered together.

"Were you waiting for your Ra when I came in?" Adora took Yarsha back to the main room and sat on the bed with the girl in her lap, keeping her wrapped up like a little burrito to share her body heat with her.

"Yep-yep!" Big yellow eyes blinked up at her, excitement written all over her face. "There was a big tub. I had a splashy splash and now I is all clean! Then I splashed Ra and ran away so I could pounce on her." The words spilled out fast, almost too fast to follow but she was so pleased with herself that it didn't matter. Adora couldn't help but beam down at her.

"Well, I'm sorry I ruined your pounce." She affected a pout to look as contrite as possible.

"Who was pouncing?" Catra's voice filtered through the door and Adora involuntarily tensed, feeling as though she was doing something wrong.

Catra walked through the door backwards, obviously pretending to look for something so that she wouldn't see the girl on the bed. She was carrying a small collection of clothes in her hands and looked almost as wet as the little girl had been, newly short hair plastered against her head. She'd obviously changed into the clothes that George and Lance had managed to fish out for them all, a simple white shirt loosely buttoned and what looked like yoga pants that were a little too long and bunched around her ankles. She looked so far from the girl who dominated Adora's best moments as a child. Giggling in her arms drew Adora's attention back to the kitten snuggled up in her arms.

"I'm a big hunter, Ra! I go away and then I was hiding and then I was all 'grrrrr' and then I jumped and got 'Dora and she didn't

know I was there.” Yarsha was wiggling so excitedly that she almost wriggled her way off of the blond’s lap.

Mismatched eyes finally turned to the bed and saw the kitten cocoon sitting proudly on the human’s lap. Adora shot her a sheepish smile, showing that she felt as uncomfortable to be there as Catra did to be looking at her holding her child on the bed that was to be hers. It seemed both very wrong and too right all at once and for a moment she felt dizzy, blinking rapidly to dispel the feint image of Tace she swore she saw sitting beside the human on the bed, smiling. When she opened her eyes again it was just Yarsha and Adora.

“I bet she was really surprised!” She plastered a smile to her face and walked towards the bed. The two older human men had passed her in the hall and given her the clothes she was wearing, along with some adorable children’s clothes they had left laying around from their apparently enormous brood of sons.

She knelt on the floor and reached up to peel the towel off of the very fuzzy kitten, trying to ignore as her hand brushed Adora’s aside. The human woman seemed paralysed, just looking down at the kitten’s head, Catra didn’t know what to say, so wordlessly pulled a little purple shirt over the braided head and then popped the kitten up and into a pair of flannel shorts the same colour. Yarsha tumbled forward into her arms and began to gently nuzzle and purr. A sure sign that she was ready for sleep, all her energy suddenly and familiarly gone.

“I should go.” Adora’s voice was so soft it was like she was afraid that something might break if she spoke louder. She was just getting to her feet when a little tail wrapped around her wrist and held tight.

“You stay with us, Dora. Peas.” Big yellow eyes blinked as she looked between the two women, a crease between her two tiny brows. “We be together and keep safe.”

Catra had to choke back a sob that wanted to get out as she realised that Yarsha had picked up more of what was wrong than any of them had thought. Her kitten was so clever, but she had already lost too much to be suffering through anything like this. She had only ever wanted her child to have the childhood that she hadn't. She looked at Adora over the child's head and saw a tear tracking its way down her cheek at the words.

"Ok, Yar-Yar. Adora can stay if she wants to. But this bed is extra little." Looking at it, it was bigger than they had as children but nowhere near big enough for the three of them to lay side by side.

"Of course I'll stay." Adora's voice sounded choked, so Catra kept Yarsha focused on her as she tickled at a round little belly and got a series of giggles.

"Can we get Aunt Kesh too?" Yarsha blinked those giant eyes up at Catra, and got a laugh out of her.

"I don't think Kesh would appreciate us waking her up for a sleepover, Fuzzy-Butt." She hustled the child up the bed and nestled her under the sheets, where she curled into the foetal position. "Wanna know what Adora and I used to do when we were little?" A little head nodded furiously. "When I was worried I would crawl into Adora's bunk and sleep at the end. That's what I'm going to do now. Adora," she looked at the blond, making sure she understood. "Is going to sleep next to you and I am going to curl up at the end."

She watched as Adora cautiously got into bed beside the little girl, laying stiffly until the child snuggled up to her. She had little choice but to rearrange herself until she was laying on her side, cuddling the already purring kitten close. Satisfied that they were settled, Catra curled into a ball at the end of the bed, letting her tail be grasped by her child as she started to purr loudly. It had the intended affect of lulling both the other occupants in the bed to sleep. Soon there were little snores and bigger snorts filling the air while Catra struggled to get to sleep.

Thoughts ricocheted around inside her head like a pin ball, unable rest as they clashed against each other. Her head ached with it, or perhaps it was the exhaustion that had crashed on her like a falling tree a few hours ago. Catra laid curled once more at Adora's feet as she had countless nights as a child. Back then it had been the safest place to be, the place that felt most like home in a world that was always a threat to her. She had started to curl up at the human girl's feet almost as soon as she had been taken to the Fright Zone. Something about her had always madder feel safe, she had never known why but now she understood that she had been looking for a connection after being ripped away fro her parents.

Everything about laying there tonight felt strange, the images that she had seen as she had slipped away into oblivion were becoming hazy, but one thing that she was sure of was that Tace had been there and so had Adora. It made her brain itch. If not for Yarsha's grip on her tail keeping her grounded she would have bolted out of the window and out into the woods to progress her thoughts. She could no more tear herself away from her daughter than she could forgive Shadow Weaver.

Thoughts of Shadow Weaver began to spin into her head. She may not have seen the old woman in Brightmoon but she had certainly made her presence known. The magicat reached up and rubbed futilely at the brand new scar that spanned her forehead and up into her hairline. It seemed that she would never be rid of that ghost of her past. A shudder moved through her, too many memories of pain and violence shifting through her minds eye to be contained. It was all she had of her childhood, painful memories of 'discipline', laced with soft moments with Adora. It rankled that she had nothing left of her Ra or Zu, all wiped away by the childhood trauma inflicted on her.

And Shadow Weaver had almost caused her own kitten to be left orphaned and parentless!

She could feel the rage that had been simmering since she woke up and they had gone on the run started to come to the fore. Laying there in the dark, her body started to tremble. Her anger wasn't at the violence that had been done to her, it was all she could expect from the old witch. It wasn't even at the hubris of the Alliance for their ability to forgive and want to rehabilitate somebody like Shadow Weaver, while pointing their ire at her and Hordak. No. All her rage was for her daughter.

Thinking about Yarsha being left alone, orphaned at the same age she had been torn from her pod made her blood boil, her hands fist in the sheets. From the moment that she had first held the tiny bundle of fluff when she had been extracted from the artificial womb, Catra had felt everything click into place in her heart and vowed that this little girl would never know the pain she had. She had been so small and defenceless that Catra had been terrified to even touch her, but Tace had laid a hand over hers where it rested on the tiny back and she had known that she would give anything for her. She had already failed her once, letting Tace slip through her fingers, she was damned if she would let Shadow Weaver make her an orphan.

Unable to lay there any more, she slid her tail out of Yarsha's loose grip, laying still while she waited for the child to settle, which she did by grasping her own tail and snuggling deeper into Adora's arms, who buried her nose into the coil of braids. A pang went through her as she watched these two be so comfortable together when she felt so ambivalent around the blond. It was the constant push and pull of being around Adora, and it wasn't even new. Even as children Adora had been equal parts safety and danger, taking Shadow Weaver's words as truth and never seeing how much she was being bullied by the older woman for nothing. Binding her wounds when she came back from being punished while rebuking her for being punished in the first place. Now, the semantics were different but things were much the same. Adora clearly wanted to be close again, to become friends…or clearly more than friends, the human wasn't the best at hiding her feelings and yet had turned against her as easily as ice turned to water in the sun. She so wanted to trust her, this person full of so

much hope and, despite everything that they had been through, naiveté but how could she?

Satisfied that they wouldn't miss her and that Yarsha was protected, Catra caste a longing look at the window, but instead made her way out of the door. She padded down the hallway of the sprawling, mazrlike library. She didn't care where she ended up, she just needed to work out the anger. What had started as a walk turned into a run as she made her way passed the bedrooms. The place was enormous, she could easily lose herself I the stacks that filled the place.

For more than an hour she ran, climbed and lashed out at imaginary opponents. She was breathless and her muscles ached but the anger was still there. She was trudging back to the bedroom when she heard a voices coming from down the hall. They were unfamiliar but soothing. She recognised them as the men who had welcomed them into their home. Her tired feet carried her in the direction of the sound and before she knew it she was walking into a dimly lit kitchen where the men were seated with their heads together, sipping at steaming mugs. They didn't notice her at first. She took a moment to study them, they had kind faces but looked weary to the bone. She wondered why they had not slipped off to their own beds?

A noise from behind her caught her attention and she turned to see Phibin and Kesh trudging down the hallway she had just walked along. Both looked tired but their faces broke into smiles when they saw her. She couldn't help but smile back, noticing from the corner of her eye that the two humans had noticed their approach. They seemed a little startled to see her there, but a chair was pushed out and she walked to the table, muttering a thank you.

"I'll make us all some tea." The taller man, Lance she thought he had said his name was, stood as he saw Phibin and Kesh walk into the kitchen. They looked small and uncertain as they hadn't since their pods had been opened and Catra knew that they needed the kindness of these people.

"We'd really like that. Thank you." She beckoned the pair closer and they took their own seats. She looked at George and smiled softly. "You two are librarians, right? Maybe we can answer some questions?"

Lance and George had not gone to bed when all of their unexpected guests had. As the group had started to flag, the librarians had rushed from room to room ensuring that the bedrooms that belonged to their brood were ready for visitors. They always kept them dusted and the beds made, always happy when one of their boys came to visit on a whim. It didn't happen as much as they would like but all the beds always had clean linen and there was always towels in the bathrooms. The pair of them had shown the others to the bedrooms and then rushed around to dig up old clothes from their children. There had been enough in various shapes and sizes to accommodate everyone, Scorpia had been given one of Lance's old outfits which bulged at the seams but would do.

Now the pair of them sat, slumped and exhausted at their kitchen table, both cradling a cup of steaming tea as they tried to process what the day had brought them. They had thought all of this had ended when the Fright Zone had collapsed, that they wound't have to worry about Bow's safety anymore (well anymore than on a normal day). Now it seemed that their youngest son was in more danger than ever and all they could do was provide a safe harbour for the people who might be able to save him.

George reached over and put his hand over Lance's larger one, brown eyes came up to meet his through the lenses of his glasses which only seemed to magnify Lance's distress. He had done a good job at keeping it under wraps all day, but George had known and loved his husband for far to long to be fooled by his facade. He laced their fingers together and through their hands up to press a gentle kiss against the back of Lance's hand and saw the tears that had been threatening finally fall. He reached up with his

other hand and cupped the chiselled jaw he loved so, wiping the tear away with his thumb.

"He'll be ok. He's a survivor and everyone here is going to do all they can to rescue our Bow." He kept his voice as level as he could. He had always made it a point to be strong for Lance; Lance who had worked so hard to rebuild him after he had come back from the first war, broken and traumatised. It was his way to show his husband how much he loved him.

"I know you're right, George, but how could this happen? How could nobody see what was happening to Glimmer? Why didn't we or Bow see it?" It was jarring to hear the frustration and sadness creep into anger in his usually affable and bright voice.

"We often overlook the worst parts of the people we love, Darling. I mean, you don't even complain about my tickle moustache anymore." It was a weak and silly joke but it got a small smile so he considered it a win. "Nobody is to blame in all of this but Shadow Weaver. We'll help Bow deal with Glimmer when he needs us."

"I know you're right."

Quiet fell between them for a moment as they sipped at their tea, feeling their eyes start to droop, the day starting to catch up with them. When Swift Wind had brought the two magicat's, Entrapta and her boy, they had been surprised. When they had seen him come back hours later with a blood soaked magicat and a shapeshifter they hadn't known what to think. Lance had hurried them inside while George had taken it upon himself to get a bucket and wipe the blood off of Swift Wind while he filled him in on what more was happening in a frighteningly subdued voice.

"When this is all over, we'll get all our boys here with their families and get them to stay for a while." Lance squeezed George's hand and he knew that he would move the moons themselves for this gentle man.

They began to talk about their sons, little memories of them as children, warming their hearts. Bow was always the smallest, and would trail after his bigger brothers picking up on their hobbies and interests. Trying desperately to be just like them. All of them. It meant that, at times, their youngest boy seemed like he was an actor playing a hundred parts. He had tried painting with Halberd, who was perhaps their most patient child, but Bow lacked any real talent for it. But Halberd had been adamant that he would teach him something and wanted his little brother to succeed so had tried everything until he discovered Bow's skill at technical drawing. That had led to Bow's love for design and technology. Something he shared with his fifth oldest brother Mace. They had tinkered for hours making little pretend robots.

A shuffling sound in the hallway stopped their conversation as they both turned away from each other, startled to see Catra standing in the doorway. Her arrival at the library had been unexpected and after days spent with Adora in her grief over betraying her old friend. They couldn't help but study the two women together. Had been witness to how the kitten, who had started to wheedle her way into her heart in just a few hours, had clung to both of them and how Adora blushed and Catra looked away.

"I'll make us all some tea." Lance broke the sudden tenseness, as he always did, with kindness. Lance put his foot out and moved out a chair to welcome Catra to the table. She was soon joined by the other two magicats, they all looked like children in that moment.

"We'd really like that. Thank you." Catra reassured her friends who joined her at the table. George watched as she chewed her lip, before seeming to decide on what to say. "You two are librarians, right? Maybe we can answer some questions?" It was just the distraction that they needed.

Shadow Weaver had smiled as she said it. He couldn't see her face through the mask, but he could tell after working with the

woman for more than twenty years, she was smiling. It was smug and cruel. How else he had expected her to test his loyalty, he wasn't sure, but this seemed inevitable. She had sat opposite him at the table, food spread between them which neither of them touched, simply acting as one more extravagant demonstration of her power and control over Brightmoon. Princess Glimmer had been seated to her left, blank eyed and still like a doll and her husband was still slumped in the far corner in a well of shadow. Hordak couldn't tell if he was tied down, but he was certain that it didn't matter.

Over uneaten delicacies, Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers and welcomed him to the fold. He wasn't entirely certain why she had not simply taken control of him as she seemed to have for all of the other inhabitants of the castle, but whatever she really needed from him obviously required that he be in his right mind, something that he was more than grateful for. He was long passed wanting to subsume himself into a collective consciousness. He enjoyed his individuality and all that came with it far too much.

"Of course, you'll understand if I don't accept this change of sides, if that is indeed what it is, at face value. I will need you to prove your loyalty to me. A test, of sorts to show that you will follow my orders and that these people really are meaningless to you." Her confidence was almost laughable. He knew that the queen and Catra had got out, Entrapta had managed to send him a small blast of encoded data on his com, undetectable to anyone but him, and yet here Shadow Weaver sat blissfully ignorant. Her self confidence would be her downfall.

"I wouldn't expect anything else." His voice had taken on the pitch and timbre that he had used to control the Fight Zone, it was sliding on an old coat, worn and comfortable but a little too tight.

"Good, then this should be easy." She had risen from her chair, beckoning for he and Glimmer to follow as she glided from the table and out of the room.

Shadow Weaver moved like a ghost, or a wraith, all sinuous movements and uninterrupted grace. Rather than beauty it telegraphed menace. Like her shadow spies she could creep up on you in an instant. Though he had no affinity with magic, it was clear in every line of her body as she moved that she was full of power, it must be being siphoned from the Moonstone and meant that she was as dangerous as she had ever been, perhaps more so.

The trio, along with the group of guards that they had collected along the way, entered a room that was heavily guarded. It was small, obviously a meeting room from the bare look of the place. Any furniture that may have been there was long gone, replaced by the huddled group of magicats who were shackled in the centre of the room. Hordak was familiar with magicat biology, he knew that Shadow Weaver couldn't hold them with her magic or manipulate them, so she had fashioned a more old fashioned prison.

Hordak could feel the pocket-knife hidden in his pocket burn into him, along with the little shards of wire and electronics he had been toying with. Things were silent for several beats. The magicats were proud and brave, they didn't whimper of cry out for mercy but simply glared at the newcomers. Hordak met Varga's eyes, they had worked together more than once, he was one of the few outside of Hordak's small circle who knew the reclusive man, and they shared a look of morbid understanding. Even before they had got here Hordak had suspected what his test would be. This was the best possible option.

"You will kill one of these animals. That is how you show me where your loyalties lie. These alien interlopers have no place here." Her grim satisfaction was palpable.

Hordak nodded mutely, reaching one hand deep into his cluttered pocket and trying to think how much he could pass off to the big magicat without being noticed. There was no reaction from the group on the floor to Shadow Weaver's words and he knew she

must be seething at their lack of fear. She had always so enjoyed the fear of the cadets and her enemies.

"As you wish." His words were directed at the sorceress, but his eyes never left Varga as he tried to push every bit of trust into his red gaze as he could.

A guard stepped forward, pressing a large, thin bladed dagger into his hand which he took without flinching. Even in his worst days as a warlord he had managed to largely keep his hands clean of the blood of his enemies. His large hand clenched around the grip and he made his way towards the small group. Four sets of eyes locked on him, one head tilting almost imperceptibly in resignation. That would be his sacrificial lamb then.

He moved between the cuffed bodies, hearing them start to growl and curse for affect. He still had his other hand deep in his pocket, and as he crouched, he pulled it out, sure to keep it hidden behind the back of one of the magicats and made it seem as though he was resting it on the ground to provide leverage, rather than pressing a mess of wires and a pocket knife into Varga's hand. Then he was moving, lightning quick, like pulling off a bandaid.

He lunged forward, plunging the thin blade in and up, straight into the heart of the slight male magicat. It pierced his heart almost at once, a clean wound. A startled puff of air and a gasp left the young man's mouth and he flailed weakly. The warm stickiness of blood trickled onto Hordak's hand and he pulled away in disgust, taking the knife with him and seeing the wound spurt, the blood bubbling out. He needed to get them out of there fast. He surged to his feet, passing the blade back to the soldier who had given it to him and walked towards Shadow Weaver with a smile. He heard rather than saw the body of the boy slump to the floor and the anguished sounds of the other.

"Good enough?" He affected a smirk as he spoke, keen to clear the room as fast as he could.

“Good enough.” Then they were filing out of the room, leaving the magicats to grieve for their fallen comrade.

Hordak had to stifle the sigh of relief when the last guard exited the room and the door closed behind them. No need to alert then to anything untoward. He needed to know the rest of her plan, and if his luck kept up he soon would.

The door clanged shut behind the brainwashed group and the magicat’s sprang into action. Varga had already used the small strip of wire to pick open his cuffs and fell upon the wounded boy, pressing his lips over ones that were fast turning blue as he poured his life-force into him. He was vaguely aware of the other two picking open their own shackles and pocketing the knife, his focus on directing his energy to repair the punctures and keep the heart beating.

He pulled away when he started to feel his fingers tremble. He needed to be able to run. One of the other took his place, rejuvenating rather than repairing their friend until the four of them were all unshackled and standing in the room. It was a small space, a window barely broader than his shoulders looked out over the moat of the castle. It was a single, solid pane of glass with nothing to open out into the world. It was perfect.

The snick of claws unsheathing filled the room and then the sound of glass being deeply scored followed. These people truly had no idea what magicats were capable of, even after knowing Catra. It was pathetic but they weren’t about to look a gift horse in the mouth. With speed and precision a hole big enough for all of them was scored and then Varga used his strength to pop it out, there was no sound of shattering, the pane plummeting to the water below with a muted splash.

“Can you climb?” There was a nod and the four of them were moving.

They didn’t know where they were going, but being out of this place was better than the alternative.

Chapter 26

Chapter Summary

And so we gather our forces.

People packed the library. Warriors of every shape, size and affiliation crowded into the quiet halls, standing between the stacks and milling around the artefacts in a way that made Lance's heart flutter with concern any time one wobbled on its stand. He knew that it was silly, that human lives were at stake and that his research was largely meaningless at this moment, but it was the life's work that he had invested so much in with George. It was hard to quell his worry.

The first batch of these people had arrived late in the night after he, George and their magicat guests had finally retired for the night. There had been the rumbling of vehicles, vibrating the windows of the building and wholly unfamiliar in their quiet, secluded home. It had been followed by pounding on the doors that had echoed through the building, drawing them from their slumber. Lance and George had leapt out of their bed and run, pyjama clad, out into the hallway only to see their visitors piling down the stairs, weapons and claws drawn and ready. With nothing more than a few nods and swipes of her arm, Catra had deployed her people around the foyer, ready for a possible attack. Though what attacker would be knocking Lance wasn't sure, but at his side George visibly relaxed as they ducked behind a large amphora so Lance was able to take solace in that.

Catra had walked to the door, Adora and Scorpia moving to flank her, and thrown the door open. The laugh that had rung through the doorway had been warm and booming, then Catra had been pulled into a big purple embrace. Dozens of people had then piled in through the doors, greeted warmly by the Oasis group. The woman called Lonnie rushed into the arms of a large lizard-kin and buried herself in his arms as soon as he appeared in the doorway.

That had been an hour ago, and now Lance's quiet home was filled with voices. Some people just happy to be together while others were huddled in a corner, already hatching plans. The night was still dark and some people had begun to drift upstairs to pack into his guests rooms to get some sleep to be refreshed by the morning. It seemed as though they now had an army. Old fears from watching George walk away to join an army crept up Lance's spine and only grasping his husbands hand made them abate. He knew that George would not run off this time and thanked the First Ones for it.

An hour had passed and finally it seemed like everyone was ready for a few hours sleep before putting their plan in motion when commotion at the still open doors caused everyone inside to freeze, ready for an attack. When a small group of four magicats had stumbled in, looking tired and dishevelled a cheer had erupted causing all of those who had gone to bed, even the children, to come and see what was going on. There was a brief exchange of words before the non-magicats were all moving away, while the furred bodies of these alien guests poured down the stairs and leapt down over bannisters to envelope their brethren.

Lance and George made their way over to the heavy doors, noting the ad-hoc tents that were also housing yet more people outside among the tanks and trucks, before pushing them closed. The older men then made their way back to the kitchen, still too full of adrenaline to sleep, and began to prepare food for these newest new arrivals who must surely be famished.

Kesh watched as the small group of escapee's were enfolded into the arms of the magicat's who had newly arrived from Oasis. She would join them soon herself, her skin itched to be a part of the group. To feel muscle and fur surround her and reassure herself that there was hope against the insanity that seemed to plague her people. Yet she held back, even as she saw Phibin's large bulk join the pile. This small group of magicats had been left behind by

her and by Catra, it was hard to not let guilt eat up at her. She was alive when so many were dead, even her sister, and she has almost allowed more of her people to die.

The young magicat knew that it was silly to beat herself up for running, she was no warrior. She was a small, bookish youth who would have simply been caught herself. She knew she had done the right thing, that gathering the others and getting them out had been the best thing that's he could have done, but looking at the four of them so dishevelled and exhausted she wished she could have done more.

Worrying at her lip, fangs coming close to slicing through the tender flesh, her eyes darted around every face in the crowd. When a hand landed on her shoulder she let out a yelp and jumped, not having heard the person behind her approach. A soft cackle came to her ears and she turned her head to see Catra looking at the big group of magicats with an expression that mirrored her own. The hand gripping her flexed gently and Kesh found herself relaxing. She and Catra did not always share the easiest relationship but this was the bond of kinship that her sisters love of this woman had forged between them.

"You know you did the right thing, you couldn't have got everybody out yourself. You raised the alarm, you saved my life. You protected Yarsha. They survived and got here too. You're a hero in all this Kesh, not a coward." It was creepy sometimes how Catra could seem to read her so well.

"Don't pretend you don't feel the same." She spoke low, for her companion's ears only.

"Of course I do. I blame myself for letting us go to Brightmoon in the first place but its just as ridiculous. Queen Angella isn't to blame, we were forging peace. The only blame for any of this is Shadow Weaver."

Their conversation was cut short when Phibin called to them in his loud, boisterous voice, arm extended and they both moved

forward to be enfolded into the group. The sounds changed, the heavy, humming trill that had greeted Phibin's arrival now came out of more than twenty chests, louder and richer than any sound that Catra had ever heard before. The relief she felt at the return of these people was so intense that for a moment, held up by the arms of her family, she sagged almost bonelessly. It lasted for only a second but she felt bolstered. The small arms wrapped around her leg and by instinct she pulled Yarsha up to her where the child wrapped herself around her torso.

Yarsha, like the rest of the building, had been woken by the loud cheer that had gone up and it had been impossible to send her back to bed. This was a ritual, a rite, that the kitten was just as much a part of as her Ra. Now though, with the night fast fading, it was important that her people get some rest. She pulled herself away, putting Yarsha into Kesh's arms and drew herself up to her full height before chuffing loudly which pulled all eyes to her.

"You're return is just the sign we all needed that our plans will be successful. Now you all need to go to sleep, Kesh will take you upstairs and put you into rooms. I can smell that our hosts have made food for you four, grab some and head to bed. When we head out in the morning you will be staying here to guard the library." She was expecting some resistance, but none came as solemn heads nodded and the group dispersed.

Kesh walked passed Catra, allowing Yarsha to butt her head against her parent's and get a soft kiss. Soon all that was left in the large entrance hall was Catra, Phibin and Varga. Slowly the three of them made their way to the kitchen, already deserted as food had been taken and beds sought. They sat at the table and Varga stuffed some meats into his mouth from the already plundered plate. They gave him a few moments, unsurprised when an eerily silent Entrapta joined them at the table.

"Hordak gave me this," Varga broke the silence to place a flat microchip on the table. It was gone almost as soon as it appeared, into Entrapta's gloved hand.

“How did he get this to you?” Phibin was the one to ask, he was all too aware that the four magicats had been held separately to the other prisoners and that Hordak had been separated too.

Varga looked grimly around the table, his eyes finally settling on Entrapta as he took a deep breath to tell his tale. When Entrapta heard that Hordak had been forced to ‘kill’ one of the magicats she let out an uncharacteristic gasp, flipping her visor down to cover her pale face.

“He knew we could save each other, it was when he went in to stab that he passed me the chip. I don’t know what it’s for but I’d guess it’ll get us into the castle.”

Holding the stiff leather harness out in front of her, the magicat let out a heavy breath as she examined the criss-crossed straps that made up the armoured carapace. The finely woven material that already rested on her shoulders seemed to hum, making her fur feel alive. It was metallic and something like chainmail but nothing she had ever experienced before. Fisting her hands, she heard the leather creak in her grasp, before pulling it over her head and settling it across her torso. It seemed to mould itself to the shiny film while she pulled on the clasps until it fit like a second skin.

Catra rolled her shoulders. She had expected the war-wear to feel hard and unyielding, a far cry from her Horde uniform. Instead it moulded so seamlessly to her body that as she moved it felt like a second skin. She had always suspected that her people were once warriors, but assumed it was something that they had left behind them. Huntara arriving with an entourage of Horde soldiers and a chest full of magicat weapons and armour had been a welcome break from the gnawing fear for the people left in Brightmoon and the fate of Oasis if Shadow Weaver cast her eye west. It had also proved beyond a doubt that her people had known how to fight.

Reaching down to the bed she lifted the wickedly curved blade that was waiting there, and held it up to the light. It had a broad, smooth handle and the blade was as long as her forearm and hooked sharply at the end. She gave it a couple of swipes though the air, impressed with how comfortably it sat in her hand, feeling almost as natural as moving her unsheathed claws. Light from the window caught the blade and glinted on the wicked edge and she shuddered as she thought about drawing the edge across flesh and how it would cleave so easily.

Large ears twitched, one swivelling to the door as a new sound stood out from the white noise of voices gathering outside the window. The patter of small feet slapping on tile and the accompanying tinkle of claws got closer and closer, Catra quickly sheathed the dagger and placed it into the loop of her belt before turning to face the door in a crouch. Soon Yarsha ricocheted around the doorframe and threw herself into her parents arms. Catra was ready and drew the fragile body into her chest, very aware of the barrier of armour between her and the kitten. It was jarring not to be able to feel the beating of her daughters heart against her chest.

Yarsha grasped her cheeks between oddly gentle hands and looked seriously into her Ra's mismatched eyes. It was hard not to squirm under the toddlers appraising look, so much like Tace's even though the eyes so close to her were yellow and not green. Nothing was said between the two magicats for a stretch of time that was uncommon for the child, but Catra didn't break the silence, waiting for what her daughter would do. Soft tapping on her shoulder told her that the girl wanted her to turn, so she did, finding herself facing the long mirror in the room. The mirror that she had avoided looking into while getting ready to don the mantle of captain once again.

Facing her reflection, she couldn't quite believe what she was seeing. She had been afraid to look as she dressed in the unfamiliar warriors garb, afraid that she would be swept back to windowless rooms and screaming pipes, to pain and vengeance and misplaced violence. Instead she saw a woman looking back at

her who was a protector, the child perched on her hip did not diminish the intimidating and beautiful cut of the armour but exemplified what it was for. Her roughly shorn hair, thanks to Adora, meant that her ears stuck out more than usual and gave her a much more feline look than ever. She almost didn't recognise herself. Was this who Tace had seen when she looked at her?

Falling fast into a Tace shaped hole, she was jolted back to the moment by small fingers reaching up to rub her ear. Yarsha's small purr at the velvety feel brought her back to the room, and she looked at her child, their child, through the mirror. Today she was dressed in dungarees and maroon shirt, all thanks to the two gentle men whose home they had invaded and their brood of boys. Knowing that she was being watched, Yarsha met her gaze in the mirror, a near-pout on her lips.

"Ra, you a hero?" The words were serious and she could only shake her head softly.

"No, Yar-Yar. Not a hero. I was a soldier though, a long time ago." She kept her words soft, but had long ago vowed never to lie to her child, too many lies had been spread through her life.

"But you're a hero now, Ra. You look like a story." Yarsha poked at the carapace that must have been uncomfortable to rest against. Looking at herself again, Catra realised that she did look like the crude drawings that she had seen in the children's books that had been rescued from the Halfmoon. If she put on the bullet shaped helmet, she would be unrecognisable to even herself.

"I'm trying to be a good leader Yarsha, not a hero. The world has enough of them." She would never be She-Ra, and would not want to be. Heroism was for people who hadn't been steam roller by the world, but leadership? That she understood after so many years in Oasis.

"My hero, Ra." Yarsha's words were soft, breathed into the fur of her parent's neck, as she looked into the mirror, her yellow eyes

far away.

“You’re my brave girl, Yar-Yar. You know I have to go away for a little while and you have to make sure that Aunt Kesh knows that she is doing an important job, staying here with you.” Because Kesh was more like her than she was her sister, she was hot headed and certain that being left behind would mean she was weak.

Except.

Catra couldn’t let Yarsha be the only part of Tace that was left in the world.

Passing the doorway, Perfuma drew up short as she saw the large silhouette of the woman who held her heart and whose own heart she had almost decimated. The flower princess was heading to join the others in the staging area that Huntara had put together in front of the library. The big purple woman had exchanged what felt like a scant few words with Catra before being able to put together a clearly military operation. It was all too easy to forget sometimes that the Horde and all those that had been in it were part of a well oiled army.

Perfuma detoured into the small room, coming up behind Scorpia and laying a gentle hand on her back. She felt a sigh come from the bigger woman and then she was turning to look at the slight princess with a far away look in her eyes. Perfuma reached out and cupped Scorpia’s face, getting a wane smile as dark eyes closed and she pressed her cheek deeper into the gentle touch.

“You don’t need to come back to Brightmoon with us, you could stay here and protect the library.” Perfuma spoke softly, moving until her body was flush with her love’s and wrapping her other hand around her waist.

“I never wanted to fight in the first place, you know? I was never very good at anything except the brute force though, so I got to

be a force captain.” Scorpia moved until her head was resting in the crook of Perfuma’s neck, breathing in her fresh, floral scent. “Was the best day of my life when Catra and I walked out into the Waste.”

“Then stay here.” She dropped a kiss into short white hair.

“I can’t.” She raised her head, forestalling the words that were about to fall from Perfuma’s lips. “I’d never forgive myself if I let Catra go without me and she died. Again. We’re a team, you know? They’re all my family out there.” She moved them so that they were both looking out of the window, down at the gathered forces.

“Mine too.” Perfuma was looking at the woman at her side.

She was a brave warrior. She had faced down countless foes and entered forbidden places with barely a thought, but as she stood in the grand entrance hall of the library, the sound of the others outside, already gathered and waiting to advance on Brightmoon, she felt her heart stutter in her chest. Brightmoon was a place that she had spent almost half her life protecting, and here she was about to lead troops to plunder it. Ready to fight toe-to-toe with Glimmer who had been more than a friend, almost a sister in the time that had passed. Her own footsteps, echoing too loudly in the large vestibule, were all that she could focus on as she paced.

Adora felt like a child, or maybe a coward, so worried about taking up arms after almost a decade of not needing to. She-Ra shimmered at the edges of her consciousness, ready to be deployed once more in the defence of Etheria, but she was more afraid of the goddess on the inside than her before. Even that first time when she had found the sword. Her fingers, unbidden, moved to fidget with the bracer that she had yet to allow to morph back into the sword. Movement from the right caused her to quickly yank her hand away as she watched Angella make her

way down the long staircase, she looked as serene and put together as always and yet there was a tigress around her eyes that let Adora know that she was as torn about what was to come as she was.

Micah had yet to return. It was all that was keeping them in this holding pattern as they waited for Mysticore to join their ranks. Angella said nothing as she passed, only reaching out to rest a fine boned hand on her shoulder in a fleeting touch of comfort as she made her way to join the people who were about to save her home.

Bolstered by the taller woman's resolve, Adora ran her hands through her short, shaggy hair, pushing it away from her face. Sometimes, like this, she missed her trusty old ponytail. She would have been able to slip off the band, reorder the strands through her fingers and then cinch it back up again. It would have helped to settle her. Now her fingers moved through the short hair, tousling it but it did nothing to centre her. Becoming frustrated with herself, she balled her hands into fists and let them hit into her thighs. Taking a deep breath, she decided she may as well head outside and try to distract herself with preparing the vehicles and forces.

As Adora turned to the door, clicking footfalls descended the stairs, drawing her back into the shaded room. She turned, still very much her Adora-self, and her blue eyes widened at the sight of Catra. For a moment she was too stunned to speak at the sight of the armoured warrior in fronton her wearing antique armour and looking every part the general that she would be today. This was not the young cadet she had known or the force captain she had fought, this wasn't even the magicat chief she had worked alongside. This was somebody from an ancient story ready to defend the existence of her people.

She must had gasped, because Catra was suddenly looking at her with a cool, level stare from beneath the shadow of the helmet that she had donned. Adora looked back at her, feeling shy and more than a little embarrassed. Here was Catra looking just as

imposing as She-Ra and all under her own power without needing a magical sword. Not for the first time, Adora wondered how things might have been different if Catra had been the one to take custody of the sword.

Adora opened her mouth to say something encouraging. Except what came out was patronising bossy. One minuet they were passing each other on the way to the door and the next they were shouting at each other. Old wounds seem to have torn open in an instant, a flash over that brought up grievances that were better left in the past. It wasn't the time or the place but neither woman could seem to stop themselves. Adora stalked towards Catra, intending to grab her by the arm as she walked away, make her face her.

Neither woman was sure how it happened, one minute they were arguing and then Catra was pining the blond to the wall, forearm braced across her throat as books showered down around them. Catra felt some of the heavy tomes hit her shoulder but adrenaline and armour meant she could ignore it. She glared into Adora's wide, oh so blue, eyes and wished that the blond was not here. Logically she knew that having She-Ra with them would give them a definite strategic advantage. But not everything was about logic.

"You need to back off Adora! This isn't about you or me. This is about taking down Shadow Weaver once and for all." She could feel the girl quivering beneath her arm and moved away, putting distance between the two of them. "If we live through today we'll have plenty of time for this."

Catra didn't wait for Adora to collect her thoughts and respond, she was marching out of the door. Adora was left alone, back still pressed uncomfortably against the spines of old tomes.

Catra walked tall, out of the library and into the midst of an army awaiting her orders. For a moment, images overlayed themselves in her mind, a bigger, dirtier army poised to attack the very place

they were to storm today. A younger her, full of a far more corrosive rage, basking in the power and letting it fuel her. She blinked and that girl was gone. Now her anger came from a far more noble place; no less honest than her old loathing, but now there to protect and defend others. There were people to be freed and maniacs to be taken out. This was not lashing out at the nearest soft belly anymore. Her people had been hurt and she would stop that happening again.

Her own near death had played very little part in her ire. She was so used to being hurt, tortured and underestimated by Shadow Weaver that it perversely felt almost like home. A twisted kind of nostalgia. She may yet die today, too far from the hope of resurrection. If she dies, it would be a worthy death, valiant in a way that she had never imaged herself. Adora was the hero of their story, even from their infancy, yet now Catra was bravely bedecked as a knight and leading an army. If she died, and she had no doubt that once she was seen on the field of battle Shadow Weavers fury would be all consuming, her people would be safe and thrive. Yarsha would never be alone, all the magicats of Oasis would cradle her daughter, the first born of a generation. When she faded from the kitten's memory, the child would know that she had been loved. It was a gift that Tace had given her, an heirloom to pass to their child.

Pulling herself out of her brief melancholy (these were thoughts that she could not share with the others, Phibs and Kesh and Scorpia would all be aghast and Adora would… she didn't need to think about Adora), there was no time of that in a general, she squared her shoulders and lifted her hands above her head to call for silence. It was hard not to feel a part of adrenaline at the power of bringing so many under her control just by a gesture. Silence took hold as all eyes turned to her, old enemies turned new allies shoulder-to-shoulder with old soldiers. All of them had hoped never to fight again. Those that had been Horde had worked so hard to make it never happen, yet here they were. The world had found them in their seclusion, and now that had to save the world. There was a bitter irony to it, but also a strange sort of symmetry to being the ones to save the day.

She opened her mouth to speak, but before any words could escape there was a shimmering, rippling sensation to the air and the scent of ozone filled her nostrils. Bodies unused to magic tensed, people hefting weapons that were unfamiliar in some hands and old friends to others, but Catra remained relaxed, lending courage to her people. As the sensation intensified, bodies began to step out of the air. People in long robes which sent an involuntary shiver up Catra's spine, were ow among them. She vaguely recognised Castaspella who was one of the last to emerge at the side of her much more diminutive brother, Micah. The faces of all the new arrivals were set in hard lines as Catra watched them all begin to weave their hands in unison, terrifyingly familiar shapes etching themselves into the air before, with a muted pop, disappearing.

"Sorry to be so late, we wanted to get the cloaking spell just right." Micah's voice was more flat than the young general had ever heard. She raised her eyebrow and he went on. "The spell we just cast will mean that Shadow Weaver's shadow spies can neither see nor hear us. We are invisible to her magic." A muted cheer went around the group, rising like a wave before crashing back to silence.

Micah found Angella in the crowd and moved to her side, linking his hand with hers as they looked to Catra for orders. Of all of them, Catra was the most capable of leading them into battle. His opinion didn't change as he saw the towering, glowing figure of She-ra emerge from the building to hover behind the chief magicat. Adora looked nervous, her eyes flitting left and right and her hand fidgeting on the hilt of her sword. It was jarring behind Catra's composed stillness as she surveyed all of these people who were now hers to command, making sure and certain eye contact with the crowd. She oozed with confidence and self assurance that, if manufactured, was extremely convincing. Micah had missed most of the war, relegated as he had been to Beast Island, but in this moment he could understand how this woman, as nothing more than a slip of girl, could lead an army that almost took Brightmoon. His dark eyes once again travelled to Adora's

alter ego, so lorded among his people, and wondered what had changed to make her seem so uncertain in this moment.

Catra knew the exact moment that Adora walked out behind her. She saw the expressions of the people watching change, the moonstruck expression of the Brightmooner's and the clenched jaws of her own. It was quick to pass, all eyes on her again, expectant. Even if she hadn't seen the audience change, the fur on the back of her neck had prickled as Adora walked out. Their altercation was still fresh in her mind, but she always knew when her childhood friend was around. It gave her a sense of gratification that the people quickly focused back on her, looking beyond the flashy glow of the goddess and to the person who had worked to lead them.

"Today we will be advancing on Brightmoon." There was no cheer, no hooray for invasions, instead there was only the sound of shuffling feet and discomfort. "I know that this is something that none of us had ever imagined. To my Oasis brothers and sisters," human, hybrid and magicat eyes looked at her with so much faith and trust that she almost lost her breath, "I thank you for taking up arms to fight when you had hoped never to again."

She was surprised when a rhythmic sound started up and realised it was her people beating their chests with closed fists in answer to her. It was nothing like when she had led the invasion of Brightmoon, when people had only listened to her out of fear of her superiors and not respect for her skills. She let her eyes sweep over Huntara, Scorpia, Double Trouble, Lonnie and Rogelio, settling on the lizard man. He had never wanted to raise arms again, she knew, and a sliver of guilt settled in her heart.

"Brightmoon, Queen Angella, you have been ripped from your home by the same darkness that plagued many of us in the past. You have given me command of these troops and I will lead you as wisely as I can. It has been a long time since I was a soldier, but some lessons are hard learned and never forgotten." Behind her she heard a murmured agreement from Adora.

She spoke a few more words before directing people to their places. She and Huntara had divided the forces, mixing sides together and now with the Mysticore sorcerers among them they had layers of protection. With the vehicles in place it should take only a few hours to het back to the palace, hopefully catching Shadow Weaver unawares. They had escaped less than 24 hours ago, they needed Shadow Weaver's hubris to be stronger than her sense of self preservation. Catra was almost certain that after her 'body' had been disposed of that the old crone would not have checked her prisoners yet, would have left them to stew.

Catra jogged down the stairs, She-ra at her heels, turning to look up at the high windows and send a jolly wave to Yarsha who was held in Kesh's arms. The younger magicat was looking down with sad eyes as she clutched her niece, and surrounded by the other escapees who had returned to them. Catra had refused to allow them to put themselves at risk again, especially after the non-murder Hordak had been forced to commit. Instead they would watch over the library and the children. She-ra peeled of from her, joining to forced she was to lead, climbing on board Swift Wind who had been blissfully silent in all this. He was more a war stead than she had ever imagined.

Catra climbed onto her cycle, engine purring to life under her as the last of the forces prepared to move out. Today there was only one possible outcome. She couldn't let it end any other way than with their success.

Darkness dominated the once bright, bejewelled castle. Daylight streamed outside but the windows were barred against it. Everywhere there was nothing more than the quiet thrum of power and fear. Whimpers from those held captive and numbed by her spells drifted down the corridors whenever the doors were opened by patrolling guards. Soon she would go and haunt the holding cells.

The princesses that she had taken hostage and plunged into catatonia would need to be moulded and crafted into Glimmer's image. She had plans for them all. In the euphoria of Catra's dispatch, a thorn finally out of her side forever, she had not felt the need to push further. She had them all, a collection of pretty little things bursting with power at her disposal. All of their power her's to harvest and use at her leisure and nobody left to stand against her. With Hordak firmly on board, his murder of that filthy animal proof that he, like her, had been simply biding his time inside a guided cage, they would handily succeed where the Horde had failed. Who could stand against them now?

It had been a very successful forty-eight hours. All those years of watching and waiting, poisoning minds and relationships had all paid off better than she could ever have imagined. Glimmer discovering Oasis and channelling all the venom that Shadow Weaver had spilled into her, for years, into attacking Catra had simply been a delightful boon. Glimmer could turn her attention back to destroying her mother as had always been the real plan, though the sorceress would be delighted to tear down Oasis and leave nothing behind but dust.

Standing from the throne that she had commandeered, lights flickering around her as shadows seemed to be sucked from every corner to wrap and writhe around her, cloak-like. In the depths of the room, the silently gasping form of Bow was revealed, cheeks sunken and hollow in his sallow face. His clothes were rumpled and his pants stained. Through her mask, Shadow Weaver sneered disdainfully and waved a hand, a guard appearing at her side as though conjured from the air.

"Take that," she flung a careless hand in the fallen man's direction, "and hose it down."

The silent guard, more robot than human, moved mechanically towards the dark skinned man and roughly grabbed him under his arm, jerking him to his feet. He flailed to his feet and slumped into the vice like grip, easily allowing himself to be dragged out of the room on stumbling feet and away down another dark hallway.

Glimmer was busy with the Moonstone, charging herself and preparing it, along with Hordak whose technical prowess would be invaluable, for Shadow Weaver to harness, and seemed to have forgotten about Bow when she was not within a direct line of sight of him.

Strolling down the hall, a phalanx of guards falling in behind her like the train of an elaborate gown, she decided to visit her most high profile prisoners. Surely after a day coated in the dried blood of the animal the queen would be ready to bend to her wishes. Then there was Adora, she smiled below the mask, it was more than time for the young woman to come back into the fold.

Flicking her wrist, the doors burst open with a push from her shadows and she was walking between the dimly lit bubbles that acted as cells within the large ballroom. The guards in her wake spread out around the room, each one looming over the dead eyed people cowering within. Finally she was standing before the last, darkest of the cells, the floor still stained with drying blood. She scanned the area, eyes moving all around, and then taking it in a second time. She muttered an incantation and the lights in the whole room became almost blindingly bright, causing even the enchanted guards to stumble and blink rapidly at the change.

Shadow Weaver walked forward, arm slicing through the force field and leaving it in magical tatters. Dried blood and empty space was all that greeted her.

Darkness fell all over the castle, only Shadow Weaver pulsed red like the enraged, burning core of the world.

Chapter 27

Chapter Summary

Infiltration and subterfuge.

Hordak knew the second that Shadow Weaver discovered her prisoners were gone. Perched high overhead on the gantry beneath the moonstone, he had a birds eye view as the castle went dark. The life seemingly leached out of it, almost colourless under the morning light. Then, a flurry of darkness shot from windows and balconies, the old witches minions cast out to search for her prey. It was faster than he hoped and meant moving things up faster than he wanted. He had to hope that the chip had got to Entrapta.

To his right, the princess looked out blankly over what had been her kingdom. Hordak doubted it would ever be again. No matter how deeply Shadow Weaver had got her hooks into the woman she had clearly made some poor decisions all on her own. If her mother ever trusted her again she would be quite foolish. Even so, it would be a long way back, he was sure. Right now she was a fly in the ointment. He needed to send a signal and not be stopped.

Taking his moment, her back turned to him as she dazedly followed the spectres trajectory into the trees, he rose silently and brought a spanner down hard on the back of her head. She crumpled like paper at his feet. He scooped her up, throwing her over his shoulder, I small compartment of his brain recognises that she was unhealthily light, but there were other considerations.

He raced towards the machine that he had been shocked to see sitting beside the Moonstone. Glimmer must had plundered Dryl, using her powers to zap in and out with technology Entrapta had left to rot. There was no doubt it was his wife’s technology, he would know her hand in every nut and bolt. If had been adulterated, by who he wasn’t sure. Shadow Weaver had thrust

him up here with the princess with orders to hook the machine up and allow her to siphon its power as she had the black garnet so long ago. He had spent the last several hours with the pretence of hooking it up, while instead making a crude communications device. He slapped his hand against a button and found himself hoping to something bigger than himself that Entrapta would get the message.

Feeling his shoulder starting to ache at the added weight, he grabbed the woman tighter and ran for the doorway. He wouldn't be able to get them out, he was no fool, but if he could tie the woman up and stop her using her magic it would help his people. He snorted out something like a laugh as his lungs began to burn from the unexpected exercise. He had never been much of a soldier himself, more suited to end he had told himself. In Prime's glorious army of clones he had believed himself sublime, second only to his brother. How wrong he had been then, weak and deformed and thrown away. His life only made bearable chance and even then he had wasted it on trying to get back to, what he now realised, was a false prophet. Noone good, no true light, could do to others what his progenitor had done to the magicats and countless others. It seemed that light and shadow could both harbour evil just as easily. He was physically much weaker than he appeared, but his determination was almost legend.

He made it down a hall and into a side room that turned out to be some kind of janitorial closet before he all but dropped the young woman onto the ground. He did his best to break her fall, but it was likely that she would have some rather uncomfortable bruises on some tender parts of her anatomy come morning. Standing back up to his full height, the slender man rolled his shoulders and felt a pop followed by some relief in the joint. His red eyes scanned the small space, it was barely bigger than the breath of his arms, but it was filled with shelves covered in some very useful items. The little bit of Entrapta that he always had with him, the quirky voice in the back of his mind, was delighted.

It wasn't long before he had located rope and tape, quickly sealing up the pink haired woman's mouth and then tying her

hands behind her back and her ankles together. Knowing exactly what her powers were after studying her during the war he was certain that would not be enough, and with no way to keep her unconscious save for knocking her out again which was not on the cards, he rummaged around until he located an unopened box of foil. He crouched down beside his captive and rolled over onto her stomach. He wound the foil around her hands over and over until the roll was empty and her bound hands looked like a ball of silver. Picking up the tap by his knees he used it to cover every inch of the foil until that too was gone. He hoped that this would act as some sort of faraday cage to hold in her explosive powers. It was a long shot but all he had.

Sitting the woman upright in the corner, propping her up in a seated position, he hoped that this would be enough to hold her until he returned. He couldn't help the large group of people held in the big rooms downstairs , but he could try to find Bow. He knew from their brief interaction that Shadow Weaver kept the young man separated from the other prisoners as both a reward and a threat to Glimmer. If he could find him and snap him out of his haze, he could be invaluable.

Overjoyed at finding a key hung on a hook just inside the door, he left, relieved to find that it fit the closet door. If it proved to be a master key it was indeed his lucky day. Moving quickly, he was down the nearest staircase and on the hunt.

What should have been an almost impenetrable wall of trees and vines, was a breeze to traverse for the assorted assault vehicles and soldiers on foot. The Whispering Woods, as was their want, had moved aside to allow Brightmoon to be saved. Maybe it was their connection with She-Ra, maybe it was the determination of all of the princesses, whatever it was Catra was relieved that they had a fast and efficient rout to therein goal. It had been more than a day since her escape and the chances that Shadow Weaver was still unaware were slim to none. The woman was a narcissistic old hag but she was a shrewd one.

There had been no word from the castle except for the hastily compiled chip that Hordak had managed to get smuggled out for them. He had given them an idea of the number of troops that Shadow Weaver had in her thralls, his best guess at the amount of captives remaining in the stupor. He had mentioned something about a device he was to hook up to the Moonstone and Entrapta had seemed to understand that, almost giddy with knowledge that they didn't get.

It had been a definite boon. That along with the inside knowledge of the palace's layout from the people who lived there and they had a workable plan with parts for many people to play. Even if Shadow Weaver knew they were gone, the chance that she would expect a frontal assault of any kind so soon was low. That was what Catra was banking on.

Sitting astride her cycle, she raised herself up on the crest of a hill and let her eyes scan the picture perfect image of Brightmoon. Already the place was showing signs of decay. The gleam had gone the colours seemed dimmed and in every window there was only darkness. In fact the darkness seemed to be seeping out of the building, very clear shadows flying away from the towers and fanning out like hunting dogs in search of a particular prey.

Catra hoped that Cataspella was right and that the spell that the sorcerers had performed really would hide them from view of Shadow Weaver's minions. It was their only chance. Just about to swing her arm forward in a clear sign to move out, she was stopped by a shrill beeping signal coming through her earpiece. She looked around her and saw the various drivers all looking just as puzzled as she felt.

A loud hooting laugh filtered out of a window and she knew without knowing that the signal was from Hordak. Entrapta was exactly that happy about four things; tech, Stanley, Hordak and Junior. Dismounting, Catra made her way to the car carrying the scientist and pulled open the doors to see her furious typing at a keyboard, the people packed inside with her all staring at her expectantly.

“Hordak says it’s now or never. He’s subdued Glimmer.” Entrapta’s face was covered by a smile but her eyes were hard. It was almost scary to see that much focus directed at something that wasn’t an inanimate object.

Mermista had been the one to volunteer the idea of a water assault. It was genius really, if Shadow Weaver spotted them, or had caught wind of their approach they would attack her on every front that they could. They had land covered and with the mysticore contingent, along with Adora on Swift Wind and Queen Angella they could also go in by air. The moat was possibly the last place that anyone would think to look. Especially if you were looking for the person leading the breach. Especially if that person was Catra and you knew how much she feared water.

Shadow Weaver knew exactly how intense that fear was, she was the one who had instilled it in the young kitten after all. When crimson electricity and cripple rigour had not been enough she would throw a bucket of water over the child and then shoot those vaults through her. Catra could still smell the singed fur and the copper taste in her mouth from biting down on her own tongue as her body spasmed. That had started when she was six. By the time she was nine the witch had tired of the electrocution, starvation and imprisonment, that had been when the drownings had started. As the others were learning to swim, preparing them for water assaults, Catra was facing her own water assault.

As she watched Mermista walk out into the water, legs transforming into a glistening fin as she passed her waist, Catra felt a lurch in the pit of her stomach. On the outside she made sure to keep her composure, she knew how important it was that your leader have an air of quiet authority at all times, but inside there was a terrified kitten scratching at the walls of her mind and tearing razor thin scratches over old scars. Mermista was using her magic to make a bubble with the intention of the ten of them getting inside and walking their way into the castle through one of the sewage ducts.

What Catra was seeing, was a large tank being wheeled into a dirty room covered in rust and mould, not Shadow Weaver's precious Black Garnet chamber for fear of hurting the jury rig around it that gave her its power. This had been an unused storage room. The smell of dust and mildew had hung in the chill air. Soldiers would bring the tank, water sloshing lazily as it was wheeled in, and turn tail and leave without a second look for the child pinned in the corner of the room by ropes of energy. They all knew that this one was the second in commands favourite whipping boy, and if her ire was fixed on this one it kept everyone else out the crosshairs, for the most part. She was a sacrifice that they were willing to make.

Clenching her jaw, Catra was the first to walk forward as Mermista beckoned them into the close quarters of her bubble. She warned them to stay close as they move so that the membrane would not break and flood them with water. The water lapping at her ankles was cold as she waded out to the bubble, thankful that she didn't wear shoes that would be waterlogged. Passing through the skin of the bubble she felt a pop and then she was completely dry, able to see the water sitting at its level outside where she was. The others hurried to join her and she was jostled from all around.

They moved as one, as though practiced. Most of her group were other magicats. Though not trained in warfare, their reflexes and agility meant that they should be able to move through the castle quickly and quietly. They only human with them was Sea Hawk who had insisted on sticking with Mermista and joining the fray.

The walk was barely more than ten minutes across the wide cast of the moat. Catra's mind could not escape memories of the tank as the sound of the water slapping against the sides echoed with every step.

Shadow Weaver was never one to sully her hands on her little mongrel. There would be the occasional punch or slap, and the even rarer gentle touch that the affection starved child would lap up in spite of everything. Writhing electricity would pick up her

tiny, malnourished body and drop her into the icy water. Going from the heat of electricity to the cold water would make her gasp, her body able to do little else at the extremes. Immediately water would fill her lungs and she would begin to thrash and gasp. In an already weakened state her ability to stay at the surface of the six foot deep tank didn't last long and she would start to be pulled down. Fur and clothes waterlogged and heavy pulling her to the bottom.

Shadow Weaver was always there, clearly visible through the water churned to bubbles by her panic, arms folded and masked face intent upon her. It was the same every time, no matter how many times, there was no getting used to the water torture. It never took long for her body to tire, arms and legs become heavy as lead as her lungs burned in her chest. That was when she would sink lifelessly to the bottom of the water.

Being inside Mermista's bubble was too much like that. The water wrapping around her on every side and Catra had to fight with every scrap of her resolve not to hyperventilate in panic. She used to sit on the bottom of that tank, hair waving into her face, and see black spots begin to dance in her vision, obscuring her tormentor. It wouldn't be long after that, that she would lose consciousness before coming to on the cold metal floor of the room. Soaked and freezing, shuddering shivers making her teeth audibly chatter. The whole ordeal would last less than ten minutes and yet these were some of the most debilitating memories of that time.

When they got close to the wide mouth of the water outlet for the castle she fell such intense relief wash through her that she let out a gusty sigh. It was so loud that several pair of eyes turned to look at her and she gave them a forced, roguish smile. Those looks she was used to. She would be dragged to her feet and have to stumble her way back to the bunks before the others arrived from their water training. By the time Adora, Lonnie and the boys would fall back into the room, damp haired and laughing (swimming was apparently a lot more fun than their other training) Catra would be lounging on the top bunk. She would be

dry and in a clean uniform, looking as relaxed as can be. They would rib and tease her about skipping the practice. It was easier to let them think that she was afraid of the water because she was a cat than to try to tell them the truth.

Mermista was able to hold the integrity of the bubble even after Catra stepped out into the mouth of the pipe. The bottom was covered in a few inches of water by it was mostly dry. As soon as the last member of the team had stepped out a torrent of water fell down and covered the entrance while the water princess stepped in and produced a new film of water to seal them in. The tunnel was big but they all had to stoop to make it through. Thankfully Mermista had apparently snuck into the castle a time or two using these means and was able to confidently lead them up and through the labyrinth of tunnels until they emerged through the kitchens.

The vast space was completely absent of life. The lights and equipment were off and there wasn't so much as a pot clanking. With their incredible vision the magicats were able to see that there were no guards. In the darkness eight pairs of eyes glowed.

Silently the group began to move out. It was o quiet that when her earpiece sprang to life, it was all Catra could do not to squeak in shock.

Adora's team were in.

She sent back an affirmative signal and was rewarded by hearing that the other two teams were in place surrounding the perimeter of the castle with their weapons trained.

It was go time.

The place was eery. Angella had never known her home so quiet and still in all her extremely long life here. The usual hubbub of daily life in a palace was absent. The corridors were dark, a smattering of lit sconces making wild patterns on the walls in

small patches. There was no sign of any guards, not even a footfall. Having flown in through the window of one of the towers with her small team, they had taken to the shadows and made themselves as still as possible to avoid detection. It seemed as though there were no need. It couldn't possibly be that easy to break in. Angella knew one thing for certain, she had underestimated Shadow Weaver for a very long time and like somebody who takes a rabid dog taken into her home had been bitten. She would not make the mistake twice about the wily woman.

Looking to her left, she caught She-Ra's eye, was to make out in the depths of the shadows as they glowed like twin blue beacons. They exchanged a grim look. Nothing about this was making things seem good. Angella let She-Ra take the lead, watching her deploy everyone with an economy of words and motion that she had seldom seen from the younger woman. She had never shared the battlefield with Adora in either of her forms, was simply used to the clumsy slightly lost young woman who had been rolling around her castle for so long. It was humbling to see her so easily slip back into soldiery. A reminder of how ingrained in her war really was. And by whom.

They broke into groups, Angella sticking with She-Ra, joined by a young magicat and a mage. The other two groups were a similar mix of a couple of Oasis people, a magicat and a mage. Aodra had quickly sent the message that they had arrived to Catra who likewise had told them it was time to head out. So far everything was going according to their hastily drawn up plans. By it was early yet.

Angella had sketched out a hastily made map, copied by Lance and George, for all of them. They left the unused room, each group grasping their weapons and peeling off down another branching hallway. Unless absolutely necessary they would stay in radio silence. Angella's group was led by She-Ra whose faint golden glow made her easy to follow further and further into the darkness, though it would surely give them away should anyone come close to them.

And that was the thing. They wee well into the heart of the castle now. Each of their own squad, plus Catra's were walking through the dead corridors and there was no-one. Not a single guard or servant at all. The castle was usually alive with them, the immortal had been certain that there would be a zombie-guard around every corner. That there were none began to send gnawing worry through her. Was it possible Shadow Weaver knew their plan somehow? Had Hordak's signal that he had incapacitated Glimmer been a ruse?

Was this a trap?

Entrapta's fingers moved over keys rapidly as she used the access that Hordak had given her to tap into Bow's computer system in the palace. From here she could connect with the smattering of cameras that were inside the building and shut down power if need be.

The scientist part of her was fascinated by Bow's innovations, they had talked a little while the delegates had been in Brightmoon and the younger man had been almost as excited about technology as she was. It was always pleasurable for the geeky former princess to meet somebody who was as enthusiastic about tech as her. It was one of the reasons why she loved Hordak as she did, he was just as socially awkward as her and almost as much of a scientist. Although, she had noticed, that as they built their home together the tall alien had become more interested in making their home. It didn't change how she felt about him, in fact she had realised that it meant that they complimented each other all the more, like the two sides of a magnet being drawn closer and closer together.

Bow was a very creative thinker she realised as she followed programming down path after path, shutting down automatic door locks and various systems. Her eyes flittered from camera view to camera view as she hunted for the position of the guards that were a part of daily life in the palace. Though not every inch of the castle was covered by cameras she should have been able to

spot some of them. Looking at the monitors was like looking at a view of Dryl when she had dwelt there alone. It seemed so wrong to her now when back them it had seemed like the most perfect thing in the world.

Cycling through the cameras in a rapid succession, she drew up short when a flash of movement caught her eye. She zoomed the camera in when she caught a glimpse of bone white. She couldn't hold in the maniacal laughter when she got a grainy glimpse of Hordak's face, brows drawn down and lips pursed with purpose. He was hugging the wall and trying to stay in the deepest shadows, obviously on his way to do something. If only he had an earpiece then she would be able to help direct him in the unfamiliar environment.

Catching sight of Catra and her crew on another corner of her screen, she kept half her attention on Hordak as she gave them instructions about how to access the next level, her own past experiences of Brightmoon coming in more than handy. That's when she had an epiphany.

Hordak may not wear his mech suit anymore, finally something like confident with his uniquely formed body, but he still had some integrated tech that could not be taken away without crippling him. Much of it had been put there by his creator years before, tacit control of his puppets. It was horrible to think about how her husband had once been enslaved, so brainwashed that he had thought that it was the ultimate freedom, but for today she was grateful. There was enough hardware inside Hordak's head that she should be able to hack in and communicate with him.

Her fingers flew over keys, even while she still took her responsibilities for surveillance serious, still hunting for guards. Finally she thought she was in to Hordak's system, using a flurry of keys to send a pulsing message like the one he had sent to her.

On the screen she saw him flinch and look around, before making eye contact with the camera he spotted in a corner and smiling widely. With his hands he made the sign for Bow. They had all

long ago learned sign language to be able to talk with Rogelio and to make life easier for Junior. Knowing that he was looking for the friendly man, she cycled back through the camera's, delving deeper to get into Bow's personal computer system.

With a stroke of a key she was inside the computer in his room, and with another she had access his camera, now being able to see inside the room he shared with Glimmer much more clearly than the footage from the security cameras. At first she thought that the room was empty, but as she saw through the dark she spotted Bow huddled on the bed. She was about to signal Hordak again, when a slight movement caught her eye, she couldn't adjust the camera angle, but she strained to see what had caused it. The tell-tale shimmer of guard robes caught light from the window.

Signalling her husband again, she sent the sequence of pulses that would tell him where to go and that a guard was inside the room. She wanted to watch him to make sure he was safe, but she couldn't let their people down as she had let them down as a much younger woman. Seeing one guard had made her certain that there were others hidden away.

It took some effort but she got into the last camera's, the ones that had been holding out on her. Through a film of dust there they were. Her eyes widened at what she saw through the dusty lens.

There were all the prisoners, now gathered together and hogtied in a single room. Surrounding them a wall of guards, each with their pike or halberd brandished. All prepared. All waiting.

Shadow Weaver knew they were coming, that much was obvious. Entrapta shared the news with a grim Catra and Adora.

They were in the castle. She could feel it. How they had got back in without being detected by her shadow minions she wasn't sure;

she had sent them from the castle in all directions but they had reported back nothing. It must be Micah, performing some spell that he had picked up in the last ten years and of which she was unaware. Cowards hiding under magic cover and sneaking in like rats. It seemed about right for people who had followed Catra.

Even as she considered the possibility that Brightmoon had been breached she had already distributed her guards and prisoners. The rest of the guards she had hidden with her own cloaking spell. It was rough and painful, burning across the guards skin like a coarse tunic but in their puppet state they did not bat an eye. They would be undetectable to any and all comers until it was too late, they were not invisible exactly, it was more that she had made them something your eye would skip over until it was right on top of you.

They would have the jump on any attacker before they even realised they were there. Shadow Weaver smiled grimly from beneath her mask. If these fools wanted to try to free their friends, or more ridiculous still, take back their home they would not stand a chance. Adora may be She-Ra but she was too tender hearted to kill people that she saw as friends and colleagues. These women under her thrall would have no such compunction. Adora would die and so would all of those stupid enough to follow her.

Groaning filled the small room. There was no-one to hear but the bottles of cleaning fluid, mops and buckets. Glimmer's head bobbed on her chest as she came to. Her head was throbbing and her thoughts clouded as she raised her blurred eyes to flit around the room, trying to get her bearings.

It felt like the first time in days that she could think clearly, she wasn't sure even how she got here. The last thing she remembered clearly was being in the ballroom while they entertained the Oasis delegates and Bow looked at her with those sad, disappointed eyes that had become all too familiar over the

last few years. Then it was as though everything had happened through a haze, dreamlike and unreal. People in lighted halos, Hordak at the Moonstone and blood…so much blood.

Head throbbing, she tried to reach up to rub her forehead, only to finally realise that her hands were bound behind her. Panic began to filter in, clearing her head with adrenaline. There was no chance of getting to her feet, those too were tied up. Unable to feel fingers that were numb from where they were sealed in something behind her, she concentrated hard and felt her magic explode from her fingertips. Except, rather than burning off the bonds, she just felt heat surge through her hands like her magic was back-firing back into her.

Glimmer craned her head, spotting brown and silver wrapped around her hands from the corner of her eye. Had Hordak done this to her? He was the last thing she had anything like a clear memory of, and it would be just like the fiend to have betrayed them all as she knew he would. Shadow Weaver had been right, Oasis was nothing more than a staging area for an invasion after all. Glimmer knew that trusting her instincts when she first found the desert dwellers was the right thing to do, thank the First Ones that at least Shadow Weaver had agreed. She needed to free herself and get to her mother, warn her.

Shuffling across the floor like a caterpillar, she jarred her shoulder against a set of shelves causing bottles to crash to the floor around her and roll away to rest by the walls. She was a princess, and as much as she may think that she was down to Etheria and one of the people, she had never been in this janitors closet before. She would have to rummage around as best she could until she found something that could get her out. At least she was able to hook the corner of the tape on her mouth on the edge of a shelf and tear it off, making her swear as the skin was pulled roughly.

It felt like ages in the cramped space, but eventually she dislodged a box full or screwdrivers. She managed to wedge one in a tight gap with there teeth and turned, digging at her bonds

with the blunt tip until she felt it give around her fingers. It was all the opening that she needed to twist her legs back and shoot out sparks towards her legs, frying her bonds and setting her feet free. Straining she tried to pull her hands apart but that seemed futile. She would have to get out and call a guard.

Glimmer was able to turn her back to the door and send out enough of a jolt to dislodge the door and get ip open wide enough to get out. In the equally dim hallway, she struggled to get her bearings in the place she had lived all her life. It was as though she were seeing it all for the first time after years of watching it from a distance. She couldn't explain the feeling, just that everything felt very wrong.

She thought hard about her mother and tried to transport herself to her. The magic still mostly contained around her hands spurted and she felt a pop as her body dematerialised only to appear again in exactly the same space. Not wanting to waste any more time, she started to run down the hallway. It was awkward with her hands still behind her back, but she managed to make it to a flight of stairs that finally seemed familiar and make her way down.

She kept running, eyes peeled for any sign of a guard. She would have to talk to General Juliet about shift rotations. Her mind was starting to drift, feeling cloudy and distant, the hallway seemed to be narrowing in a way that she had never noticed before. She stumbled over her own feet and would have fallen if she hadn't been caught by familiar hands. Glimmer looked up, oping to see Bow or Adora in front of her.

Shielded eyes met hers. Shadow Weaver, surrounded by a strange ripple of magic that fanned out behind her was holding her up. She waved her free hand and something seemed to move around her, brushing against her arm but she couldn't make it out and then the shell around her hands was sliced through and she was free. She straightened herself up and looked at Shadow Weaver again. Her fuzzy brain trying to solve some sort of puzzle. Why

was Shadow Weaver out in the halls? Had mother finally seen sense and set the rehabilitated woman free?

"We need to find my mother, I think Hordak is planning an attack he hit me and tied me up." Glimmer was about to run passed the red robed figure when a hand shot out and tapped her in the forehead.

Glimmer was crumbling to the floor before she even registered the touch, her head smashing into the marble floor. If she hadn't been unconscious before she certainly wouldn't have been after that. Shadow Weaver spent a moment looking down at the girl who was supposed to be her weapon. It would seem her magical hold on her had weakened, how she wasn't sure, but there was no time for that. Better to put her out of commission than risk a betrayal.

Without a word, two of her hidden guards scooped up the unconscious woman and took her to join her husband in their room, guarded under lock and key. Better no weapon than one that could be turned on you.

Not sparing another thought for Glimmer, Shadow Weaver continued her purposeful march to the throne room.

It was too easy. They had breached the castle at two points, deployed forces at the perimeter and already knew the location of the guards and hostages. All without a single piece of resistance or obstacle. It had to be a trap. Shadow Weaver was surely playing them somehow. She hated to imagine that Hordak would have betrayed them, set them up like lambs to the slaughter, but how else would the witch have known of their arrival?

These thoughts were playing through both Catra and Adora's minds as they led their teams. At this rate they would rendezvous without having seen another living soul. Adora had sent one of her groups to search for Bow after receiving intel from Entrapta

about his location as well as Hordak's. She really hoped that the faith Entrapta had in her husband, that they all had in him, was justified.

Knowing that all the hostages were together and well guarded they were to converge there and take them out. Catra wasn't one to put all her eggs in one basket though, she had been burned enough before. One team from each of their groups was situated around the castle, ready to call in the reinforcements at a moments notice. Huntara was also on standby at the gates, ready to breach.

Catra looked at her team, Mermista and Sea Hawk poised on the other side of the doors, others were at Catra's back. She knew that on the far side of this large room Adora would be doing the same with her forces. Sometimes it was a comfort to know the other woman so well even after so long.

"Ready?" Her words were whispered but heads nodded all around and on the other end of the coms Adora whispered an affirmative, Huntara's deep voice not far behind and Scorpia's following them all.

Catra pulled back and kicked down the door.

Chapter 28

Chapter Summary

Magical kisses (not quite what you think).

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Blood pumped sluggishly out of the gash on her leg, vaguely she realised it was pulsating along with the beating of her heart. Even in the dim light the pool beneath her was glossy. Dazedly she remembered the sword, if she could just get to it she could transform back into She-Ra. Her thoughts were hazy, the shouts of people all around the room and the clash of weapons and gunfire compounding with a blood loss making it increasingly hard to focus. She reached for her vambrace, fingers that were already becoming numb sliding over the naked skin of her forearm. Her breath began to get more laboured from pain and gathering panic, she threw her hand out, groping blindly through the cooling sticky liquid.

The more she searched, the more panic grew as she discover the sword was nowhere to be found. How it got away from her? She'd fought hundreds of times, only Catra had ever disarmed be her before. Adora's breath was coming faster now, fingers and toes numbing rapidly.

Hands landed on her shoulders and she gasped loudly, thankful that the sound of conflict masked her exclamation. Before she could react any more than that, she was being roughly dragged backwards. The hands on her shoulders were gripping painfully tightly — and almost welcome distraction from her useless leg. She absently noticed the thick smear of shiny dark blood that was following her. She knew she should be afraid of the hands on her but it was just a relief to be out of the melee.

Finally, after a handful of heartbeats, she felt the person at her back deposit or against a wall into a darker shadow, shielding them. Momentarily her head cleared enough for her to register that the sounds of fighting were growing more distant even as the person beside her grunted as they tried to move some fallen debris in front of them as a barrier.

Pale blue eyes slowly swung sideways taking in her saviour. Or perhaps captor? When hazy vision cleared, it was Catra… of course it was. Their role reversal seemed almost complete now. Darkness began to creep into the corners of her vision and her head felt far too heavy to hold up as she let it lower towards her chest.

Catra noticed Adora's head start to bob as she began to lose consciousness. She'd been fighting in the hallway; pinned down by four or five unseen assailants when she heard the other woman cry out. It wasn't Adora's scream that had been any louder than the battle around them, it was that she screamed all. In all their interactions in training simulators, and later on the field of battle, she had never heard the blonde scream. Her sharp ears could still pick out that voice from a crowd, and before she thought more about it she'd been fighting through her enemies and skidding through the doors of the War Room and into chaos.

The room was dark, emergency lighting flickering feebly given a place a red pall through the darkness. It took a moment, through the throng of people fighting around the claustrophobic space to even catch a glimpse of blonde hair. She had been looking for She-Ra's golden glow, she only saw blonde. Her blood froze, why was Adora not in her warrior form? Lashing out with her claws at an oncoming guard, thankfully visible this time, careful not to slit the woman's throat but vicious enough to put them down for now, she vaulted over an upturned portion of the table, getting closer to a target. Only days before she and her people sat around that same table negotiating peace and now, much like the treaty, the table was in ruins. Split apart and flipped.

Expecting her bare feet to hit cold, possibly jagged ground, the sticky wetness she encountered seeping between her toes made her shudder. She knew without looking what it was. Moving without a plan she grabbed for Adora's collapsed form and began to haul her back, away from the fray. Mismatched eyes darted around, searching for somewhere to take her comrade for safety. Soon she was moving towards a small corner alcove, probably somewhere where refreshments would be set out for meets. Once Adora was braced against the wall, it was just a matter of pulling a large chunk of the broken table in front of them to shield them from the fighting that was retreating into other parts of the castle.

She saw Adora's head nodding, a clear sign that she was holding onto awareness by a thread, and with one ear on the room in case any of those hidden guards came towards them, she met bleary blue eyes with her own. Catra reached out a hand and slapped at Adora's face, making her head snap back and her eyes blink, clearing with more understanding.

"Where's your sword?" Catra's hissed words reminded Adora of what she was missing and she began to feebly search around herself for the missing weapon.

"I don't know. I can't find it. Will you find it for me Catra?" Adora's voice had taken on a childish cast as her eyes filled with helpless tears.

Huffing, Catra peeked her head back over the table edge, looking over to where she had found Adora. Other than the pool of blood and several unconscious bodies there was no sign of her sword. She ducked back down, finally having the wherewithal to take in the real state of the older woman. If the pool of blood out there was anything to go by, she was in a bad way.

Scooting forward, Catra realised the blood was still oozing, slower than it must've been, out of Adora's right thigh. The fact that she was till alive and mostly conscious meant that it hadn't nicked her femoral artery which was something, but as she peeled away the pant leg with her claws, she hissed through her teeth as she got a

good look at the deep wound that was almost cutting halfway through the leg. Thankfully there was no sign of bone, but the angry red muscle seemed to be peeling open and a puddle of blood sat in the well.

Her first instinct was to reached down for her belt and fashion a tourniquet to staunch the blood. Her fingers itched as she looked at the paler and sweat over Adora's face, knowing that wouldn't be enough to get her out of the room, let alone the castle. A face flashed in her mind and she took a deep, shuddering breath as she knew what to do. Without the sword it was the only option to get the human out of here alive.

"Adora." The blue eyes were looking vaguely into the middle distance and she wasn't certain that the woman had registered her words. She reached out a clawed hand and cupped Adora's chin, turning her head so that they were looking eye to eye. The coolness of the waxy skin under her hand was disturbing and made her want to pull away. "Adora, I need you to focus right now. Can you hear me?"

Adora didn't have the strength for words, but she nodded weakly.

"I don't know if this is going to work. I am going to do to you what you saw Phibin do to me. I have no idea if this will work, but without your sword this is all we have." Catra leaned forward, holding Adora's head still. She knew how the blond woman felt about her, it was laughable how bad she was at hiding it, she just hoped that she wouldn't read more into this after she recovered.

"Don't make this weird." Catra muttered before she sealed her lips to Adora's and began to push her life force into the dying woman.

Even though she was the chief of her people on Etheria, she had never performed the transfer of life-force, hadn't even known it was a thing until it was too late. In those dark days after Tace's death she had poured over as many documents as she could get about it. She had spoken to everyone who had experienced it and now she was hoping that the surging, pulling sensation through

her body was right. She had to be careful not to give Adora too much, they still needed to find Hordak and clear the castle.

Blue and yellow eyes closed as the power flowed, she wasn't in the Brightmoon War Room, she was in the middle of the desert following Tace up a steep incline…

… Hiking for pleasure seemed like the most redundant thing in the world to Catra. She could understand forced marches, survival training, but doing that for fun was just strange. If Tace hadn't enjoyed the long, slow scenic walks so much she would have mocked them. But Tace really did. Even though their home was a desert, somewhere that should have been voice of life, Tace was able to find all of the most interesting things about it to love.

Oasis was a patch of spreading green in what had once been called the Crimson Waste, but it still had a long way to go. Today Tace wanted to go and look at a cliff that was close to the Halfmoon's crash sight. It was going to be a picnic date apparently. Catra smiled at the idea, it was something that she had come to enjoy a lot over the last few years.

Since Yarsha had arrived in their lives there hadn't been much time for dates, not that there had been before that, what with putting together a whole new civilisation but they had tried. Now they were married old ladies with a kid and she loved every moment of it. Phibin had offered to have Yarsha for the day, promising that he would not simply dress her up like a doll the whole time, though both her parents were pretty sure that was exactly what he would do. It had given them the free time to just be with each other for the first time in several months.

Catra tugged on the warm hand clasped in hers and drew Tace to a halt on the golden sand. The darker furred woman turned to face her, a curious smile curving her lips, revealing those pearly teeth that shone from her dark face. Catra found herself smiling back like a dope. This was happiness. She reached up her other hand and held Tace's cheek, feeling a purr start to travel through her wife. They leaned forward at the same time, lips meeting in a

kiss that felt as welcome as taking a deep breath after being under water.

Then Tace was shoving her away playfully, causing her to lose her footing and stumble back into a soft dune. Tace laughed, it was rich and warm, full of playful joy as she broke into a run on all fours, eating up the distance and widening the gap between them. Catra twisted to her feet, cinching the backpack tighter to her before she joined the chase.

"I'm carrying the picnic you know!" Catra's shout was answered by more laughter and she smiled and pushed herself to move faster.

They ran for a long time, laughing and pouncing on each other. It felt light and free, almost what she imagined feeling like a real child would. Tace had just slipped out of her grasp, not before exchanging another kiss, and headed towards the horizon. Catra took a moment to catch her breath and just admire her wife's beauty.

Suddenly there was a terrifying scream echoing across the plain and Catra's heart slammed in her chest. She was running before the scream stopped. It was Tace's voice, Tace's pain. How had they gone from playful laughter to fearful screams in less than the blink of an eye? They were meant to be safe here, it was all of their second chances.

Catra caught herself a split second before she too would have found herself falling into the bottom of the hidden ravine. Tace was crumpled on the ground below, pinned by rocky rubble. The edge where Catra found herself was jagged and it was plain to the warrior what had happened as she began to scramble down to her silent partner. Tace had hit that edge and it had collapsed without warning, sending her tumbling down and landing on top of her at the bottom. Her silence after that scream was more frightening than anything she could remember.

At the bottom without knowing how she had got there, hands torn up from recklessly climbing down the rocks, she threw the bag

from her back and collapsed to her knees beside Tace's body. The dark haired woman was pinned by a single chunk of rock bigger than Catra's whole body, from her sternum to her feet. Without even trying Catra knew that even with her new strength it would be impossible to free the other woman. It didn't stop her trying though.

First she reached down with tentative fingers and felt for a pulse, almost sobbing when she found one. There was hope then, but the blood on Tace's lips said that it would be fleeting and that she would need to move fast.

Riffling through their pack, she sent a distress beacon to Oasis and then she was on the stone, hands grasping the jagged stone and heaving with all her might. She felt the stone start to give a little and continued to hail even as she felt her hands being shredded and her muscles screaming as tendons and muscles began to tear but she would not give up. Her ears were trained on only one thing, Tace's breathing which had become rough and jagged, coming out irregularly.

Eventually Catra managed to raise the rock enough to turn and get her back underneath it and used her legs as a fulcrum to finally flip the boulder off of Tace to crash on her other side. She didn't see it, her eyes were fixed on the devastation of her wife's body where it lay crushed, blood oozing from more than a dozen places. She could see bone projecting from her black, blood matted fur. She move to her head, holding both of her cheeks and begging her to open those gorgeous green eyes and look at her.

Her pleas were answered as Tace opened her green eyes, it seemed as though it took all of her energy to do this one last thing. The usually shining eyes were dim. She locked eyes with the mismatched ones looking down at her, tears running down her face. Her lips moved but nothing came out, there was so little air left in her lungs. Catra didn't need to hear the words to know what they were.

“I love you too, Tace.” There was a wheeze and then nothing. Tace’s eyes had drifted closed and she was gone.

Catra shattered, body collapsing over Tace’s and sobs wracking her body. That was when she had heard the grinding sound of the rescue vehicle drive and she had started to laugh hysterically, life was one terrible irony after another for her.

The rescuers had been the ones to tell her about the kiss. They had charged down and demanded to know why she had let Tace die rather than administer it. The two magicats with the group had been angry, the loss of another of them too much for tact. Catra had looked up at them blindly, no idea what they were talking about. The pair had exchanged a look of such profound horror that she had known that whatever had happened it was certainly her fault…

… She came back to herself as she roughly pushed Adora away, she fell a little light headed but otherwise pretty good. She looked down at the leg wound, not wanting to make eye contact with the blond and saw that the gash was mostly closed and no longer bleeding. Adora should be able to walk.

“Come on, we need to get to Hordak.” Her voice was gruff and she still hadn’t met Adora’s eye.

“Catra…” there was a pleading note to Adora’s voice that she didn’t want to hear. The sounds of fighting in the castle were dying down and she focused n that.

“Come with me or leave. We don’t have time for this.” She was moving before she got an answer, crouching down and grabbing a fallen soldier’s spear and throwing it to Adora who she knew would be following.

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Adora led the way down the hallway towards Bow and Glimmer’s room. From what they had been able to get from Entrapta it seemed that was where Hordak had headed to attempt to free the

younger man. Up in the higher levels of the castle they had only had to duck into an open door a couple of times to avoid oncoming guards running back down to the first floor. The castle was home to more than a two hundred guards, and it seemed that they had overpowered most of them.

Adora limped her way towards Glimmer's room, Catra prowling the hall behind her. There were no lights left up here, everything was dark, the windows had been shuttered and every sconce was snuffed. It was mostly a decade of walking this rout day in and day out that let her navigate so easily.

"How much further?" Catra's low hiss was impatient.

"Next left." It seemed that an economy of words was best, Shadow Weaver could have minions anywhere in this darkness. It also meant that she didn't give in to the need to talk about what happened in the War Room.

Standing before the door, Adora hefted the spear that she had taken from a felled guard and had been using like a cane. Now she levelled the point at the doorway. Behind her she heard Catra's claws come out with the unmistakable snick. Taking a breath and squaring her shoulders Adora used the point of the spear to tap a specific sequence on the door. If Hordak was in there then he would answer the same (it was apparently something he did with Stanley, according to Entrapta) and if a guard emerged she was ready.

Both she and Catra sighed with relief when the sequence of taps was answered, they then heard the door unlock from the inside and Catra moved forward to much it open. They walked into the most well lit room they had encountered so far. Adora found herself blinking back tears as she eyes adjusted to the brightness. It stung but she was grateful to be able to see both of her friends out cold on the bed. Hordak was stood close by, his face showing a large bruise under his eye and his lip was split. On the floor, there was the collapsed form of a palace guard.

“Where is She-Ra?” Hordak’s voice was low and he sounded as worn down as he looked. Adora was unused to thinking of him as just a man and it was a jarring realisation.

“Adora’s sword is gone. It’s just us for now.” Catra had walked closer to the bed and was looking down at Bow and Glimmer speculatively.

“Then how are we going to free these two of the enchantment?” It was clear that Hordak simply wanted to be out of here.

“I’m going to give something a shot.” She leaned down, hands on either side of Bow’s head, but before she gave the kiss she turned to look at Adora. “They keep any snacks in here? I’ll need an energy boost.”

Adora limped over to the wardrobe, opening it and pulling out a discrete drawer revealing a plethora of snack treats. She pulled out several containing meat jerky and sweets. Turning, she saw that Catra was already kissing Bow. It was just like watching Phibin transfer life-force into Catra, yet it still made her feel uncomfortable.

Her thoughts were broken as Bow let out a whimper and Catra pulled back. It had only taken a few minutes for the power to work. The magicat was walking around the other side of the bed and looking grimly down at Glimmer with her arms folded across her chest. Thinking quickly, Adora reached back into the drawer and pulled out an apple juice and chocolate bar, rushing to Bow’s side and thrusting them into his hands.

Bow looked up at her, his eyes were clear and there was a sad smile playing on his lips as he lifted the juice to his lips and rank the whole ting in one. He grimaced as he moved it away. He turned his dark eyes to look at Catra standing over Glimmer and sighed.

Catra turned her eyes to him and seeing his broken appearance knew what she had to do. She leaned down and gave Glimmer

the kiss. A twisting viper of rage building in her stomach at the fact that she could use it on this selfish, vindictive woman and couldn't on Tace.

The effects had been swift on Bow and they worked just as fast on Glimmer. The moment that Catra felt her start to stir she stepped back, unwilling to get hit with a bolt of confetti powered anger. There was no doubt in her mind that Shadow Weaver was only half the story for the princess,

Glimmer groaned loudly before opening her eyes and seeing Bow, she smiled and stretched on their bed. For a few second she just enjoyed being in her room with her husband before her brain kicked in and she remembered waking tied up, she leapt unsteadily to her feet, hands raised as she saw Hordak, Catra and the felled guard.

"Adora, what are you waiting for? Help me!" Glimmer's voice was shrill.

"Glimmer, you need to calm down. It isn't what you think. The Oasis people are helping us save the castle. Your mom's just outside; Shadow Weaver has been manipulating you." Adora was moving towards her friend as though she were a cornered wild animal.

"Of course you'd buy that rot! These monster's are trying to keep going where they left off and you're letting them win!" Glimmer had directed her hands towards Hordak now, the magic beginning to converge there.

"Glimmer, please listen to Adora. I don't remember anything clearly for a long time. They don't have the power to do that, Shadow Weaver does." Bow's pleading voice broke her concentration for just long enough for Catra to stride up behind her and tap her on the shoulder. Glimmer whirled around, hands not in position.

Catra pulled back and swung with a closed fist, connecting with Glimmer's jaw with a sickening crunch before the pink haired woman could say another word. She collapsed to the floor as her knees gave way and her head cracked the stone. The princess was out cold with Catra standing over her, allowing herself a moment to gloat before they moved on.

"I've been wanting to do that for months." Adora and Bow shot her scathing looks but she didn't care, they had a witch to find.

"Can you two get her out of here?" She was looking at Hordak now, face expectant.

"How many forces are still within the castle?" Hordak's voice was rough and she could see the tiredness around his red eyes.

Touching her hand to her earpiece, she stood motionless for a moment. It was then that Adora realised that's he had lost her own earpiece somewhere in the chaos. "Huntara and Mermista just reported that the lower floors have been cleared. Scorpia is holding the captured guards and all of the hostages are out."

"We should all leave." Adora's voice was still pained, the wound in her leg was mostly closed but the ache and bruising were making her walk with a limp and sapping her energy.

"Adora is right Catra. There is no benefit for us in confronting Shadow Weaver now. We can trap her here and strike again after we regroup." The magicat looked between her former commander and her former best friend and snorted.

"Shadow Weaver doesn't deserve another second of freedom. I can go after her myself. If she has Adora's sword who knows what she'll be up to." She turned towards the door, no longer willing to waste time on an argument she was not going to have.

Adora looked between Bow and Hordak and made her decision. She helped them pick up Glimmer from the ground and hook her arms over their shoulder's before she made a loping jog towards the empty doorway and towards the disappearing form of Catra.

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The throne room was dark, the guards hidden in the shadows as still as chess pieces. They were all the pawns she had left. Shadow Weaver sat on the throne and brooded. All her grand plans torn asunder by Catra and her rag-tag band of scum. Of course Queen Angella would join forces with them and give all her authority to the mongrel.

There was no chance that she could succeed now. The palace was surrounded by hostile forces, the hostages were gone and all but this last small group of guards had been taken down. All her years wasted. If only Glimmer had never found Oasis she would be sitting pretty right now with a half dozen puppet princesses, taking. Her rightful place as the most powerful entity in Etheria.

She didn't flinch when the door to the door was violently kicked open, slamming against the walls. She had expected these two to be the ones that would arrive. They would see it as closing some sort or circle, as a closure for all their perceived injustices. She was the one who had raised the pair of them, shaped them and made them strong and yet all she received from them was hatred. They would be nothing without them.

"You've lost, Shadow Weaver. Come quietly and you won't be hurt!" It was Catra's voice that filled the room and she was almost impressed with the pretence that she would be taken prisoner.

"We both know you want me dead you piece filth. Why pretend, only Adora is here to see it and she would cover for you with the others." The sneer in her voice was plain as day. Still arrogant right till the end.

Catra and Adora were edging into the room, Adora with a spear held out in from of her and Catra was welding a strongly curved blade as well as her teeth and claws. At least her death would be swift by the cat's hand. She would not be prisoner again, she knew that this time it would be far less pleasant than it had been before.

She motioned with her hand and the last of the cloaked guards rushed the pair. She never moved from her seat, simply watching her soldier’s battle with the Brightmoon guards. She sound’t help but feel momentarily proud that these women were so accomplished, it was all her doing of course. Absently she wondered why Adora was doing not to use the sword, perhaps it was because she wanted to enjoy the violent act that they were here to perform.

It wasn’t long before the guards were dispatched, Catra sported a jagged cut down the side of her face that was bleeding down her face and was breathing heavily while Adora seemed largely unscathed even if she was still limping. They turned grim eyes on her and made for the throne.

Chapter End Notes

Happy New Year's Eve! Last part up tomorrow!

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

So it ends.

Chapter Notes

I couldn't hold this back - I promised myself I would finish this in the year it started and I am sticking to it.

Thank you all for sticking with this fic.

Happy New Year!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Saucer sized yellow eyes glistened with tears. A small lip jutted out dramatically as a single, fat tear rolled down through the dark fur of her cheek to pop with a plop on the sandy floor. Her shoulders were hunched, making her appear far smaller than her admittedly diminutive height. Mismatched eyes looked down at the pitiful creature in front of her and smiled affectionately, reaching out to rest atop her braided hair. She felt the struggle inside the child as she fought to keep up the tears when a purr was desperate to escape.

Catra crouched to the ground, moving her hand to her kitten's shoulder and ducking her head to catch shining yellow eyes. The young girl moved her head, trying to avoid eye contact but Catra kept trying, pulling funny faces at her daughter, uncaring that throngs of other people were moving passed them. Eventually Yarsha couldn't hold in her giggles anymore and she started to laugh at her Ra's antics.

"There's my Yar-Yar." Catra placed a kiss on her cheek. "Why are you so upset? You've been talking about coming to school with Digby and the others for months."

“I do want to go to school.” Yarsha was wiping her wet face on her sleeve, Catra knew she should stop her but didn’t have the heart. “I didn’t realise I wouldn’t see you all day.”

Catra felt her heart warm even more, since she had turned five Yarsha had been showing a streak of independence that really hammered home that her little girl was growing up fast. It was nice to hear that she was still very young after all. In her neat school clothes, specially put together by Phibin, she looked absolutely adorable.

“That’s true. What you need to remember is that I will be here every morning and I will get you every afternoon. Think about how many new things you’ll have to tell me about and show me?” Yarsha started to smile at that idea. “I never went to school like this so you can tell me how awesome it is, does that sound like a good idea?”

“Oh Ra, I will learn everything and then I can tell you all about it.” The child lurched forward to kiss her parent, barely missing head butting her in her enthusiasm.

A series of hellos distracted the crouched pair and Digby suddenly appeared at their side. His brother and sister had already walked in but he had promised that he would walk Yarsha to her classroom. Lonnie and Kyle waited a little way away, their growing children not wanting to be seen with them at drop off. Catra gave them a little wave that they returned sheepishly as she got to her feet. She watched as Digby took Yarsha’s smaller hand in his and knew that she would be more than ok once her day started.

“Seems like Yarsha already has a little crew.” Lonnie nudged her with her shoulder as they walked away, “Like mother like daughter.”

“Yes, because I was always the one with lots of friends when we were kids.” Catra rolled her eyes and Kyle laughed. It was true, Catra had always been too prickly to pick up friends unless they were thrust into her space.

“You’ve got me there. Look at you now though, you’re positively popular.” Catra swatted at the snarky woman who easily dodged out of the way.

Yarsha had walked through the gates with Digby and almost immediately dropped Digby’s hand, making a beeline towards a group of children her age. Her tail had be flicking to and fro excitedly and Catra was certain that her eyes would have been like saucers. By the time the bell had rung, there had not even been a backwards glance for her Ra. It made her proud that her child was so confident and friendly. Tace’s daughter, through and through. Thoughts of Tace were never far from her mind, every day Yarsha looked more like her.

She walked to the restaurant with her friends, being greeted with a big hug from Rogelio who had been a lot more demonstrative since the whole Brightmoon fiasco. It was as though he was reaffirming every day his promise never to pick up arms again. Catra hugged him back just as tightly. She had every intention of heading to work after this but was press ganged into staying for a lavish breakfast that left her feeling sleepy and bloated.

Catra made an executive decision as she left the tented building, teasing goodbye’s ringing out from the trio. Rather than taking the path to her office, where she should be running through paperwork, she headed down a narrower rout and out into the fields that were bursting with summer as summer moved into spring. Crops and flowers were everywhere, as far as the eye could see now as life consumed more and more of the dead sand. She let her hand run through the tall grasses, feeling them tickle her palm as she moved.

The walk was nice, the crops made everything smell clean. Soon enough she was at the marker, looking up at its warm surface. She reached out and rested a hand on the surface, it was so warm that it almost felt alive. Her forehead followed and she let herself just stand there thinking about her daughter and her wife.

Stepping back, she lowered herself to the ground, still looking at the marker.

"I dropped Yarsha off this morning. You would have cried so much, I on the other hand was the picture of stoicism…"

Adora rolled out of bed, glancing at the clock to see that it was a little passed seven. Something that she had learned since moving to Oasis was that the day was long and that there was no need to rush. It seemed to be the mantra of the magicats and lizard-kin that all of the residents had adopted. Adora's new job also meant that there was plenty of time to work out and drill in her day.

It had been a relief to be given a job description in writing and a contract that tied her to both Brightmoon and Oasis. It had set out very clearly her role and responsibilities. If was the first time she had seen anything like that since she was a child in the Horde. It did make her realise that some things from her old home had been worth keeping. She had been the logical choice for emissary, she liked the sound of that better than ambassador, she was familiar with the people who made up Oasis and had penance to make for her previous actions. She hadn't failed to notice that Queen Angella had pointedly told her that she needed to find herself while she was here.

Rubbing her hands over her face, she stood up and headed to the bathroom, idly scratching her stomach as she went. In the pristine white room, she began to run a shower, moving over to the mirror to clean her teeth while the water reached the desired temperature. As she moved the brush around her mouth she examined the woman looking back at her. She wasn't the girl who ran from the Horde to play hero, or the woman asleep at the wheel in Brightmoon, she wasn't even the Adora from a year ago who had decided she needed a change. She had a role and a purpose. Every day when she left her apartment she had friends to speak to and targets to hit. This place was alive, growing month by month. The shield had been taken down and now there

was a bustling trade in goods as well as many dispossessed people coming to join this home of the left behind. Adora fit here.

Throwing off her clothes she stepped into the shower and let the tepid water cascade over her body. It had taken her a while to get used to that but in the hot desert conditions it was far healthier than hot water running over you. Her muscles had become a little less prominent since she moved here, she was no long justifying her existence by them after all. Considering her muscles made her think about She-Ra. The goddess she had been and lost. Queen Angella had had the palace staff search every nook and cranny of the castle looking for the Sword of Protection and it was still nowhere to be found. It was as though it had simply disappeared during the skirmish. Adora had fretted about it for a few months, now it simply seemed like a relief that it was gone.

Running her hands through her hair, lathering it up, she enjoyed the shoulder length locks moving through her fingers. She had let it grow out of the short cut, but like to leave it down. Unlike when she had forced herself to make a change, this felt more like the real her, a natural progression.

Finally clean and dressed for the day in an outfit that was a happy medium between her old Horde uniform and the fashion of this new world, as provided by the delightful Phibin, she was ready to head to the council building. She worked out of a poky little room with a very small window. It was perfect.

She strode out of the apartment and made a bee line to Rogelio's restaurant. She found herself there at least once a day. Part of it was to see her old friends who were now just her friends, and a big part of it was how terrible she remained at cooking. Rogelio had tried for months to teach her to cook. She could manage the very basics like boiling an egg of pasta if she was given it pre made but everything else came out as charcoal. The big man had given up one day, throwing his arms in the air and roaring so loud that his whole family had emerged from upstairs. That was when Kyle had suggested that Adora could eat for free. It may have

saved all their sanity. She had also grown fond of their three children who were all very loud and boisterous.

That was only a part of her weekly routine, and as she looked down at her watch she realised that she needed to pick up the pace if she intended to eat some of Rogelio's delicious breakfast soufflés and get to the meeting that she had with the council first thing.

Bow walked down the hall with a tray in his hand. As he passed the sparsely arrayed guards they nodded to him, some still looked sheepish when they saw him but he didn't hold a grudge. He moved down a fork in the corridors, the opposite way to where his room was. As he walked, the decor began to change. In the mostly unused east wing things had changed in the last year or so. Here guards were positioned far closer, armed and alert. Everything that could be used as a weapon removed, sconces replaced with wall lights sunken into the walls and carpets removed.

Getting closer to a desk with a familiar woman sat behind it, he smiled broadly and carefully balancing the tray on one hand, waved. The white haired woman beamed back at him, waving a big red claw. He sided up to the table and lifted one of the small plates off of the surface, placing it down in front of Scorpia who squealed with delight and clicked her exoskeleton happily.

"I saw these when I was down in the kitchen's picking up dinner and I remembered how much you enjoyed them last time." Bow's voice was full of life again. It had taken months for him to get that part of himself back after the coup.

He had been depressed for weeks, his body had been injured but for a man like him it was the psychological harm that had lingered. His ability to trust had been almost irreparably damaged, not broken, though he was certainly slower to warm up to people these days. It had been easy to fall into a friendship with Scorpia. She had arrived at the castle eight months ago to act as both a

jailer and ambassador. The peace treaty had miraculously managed to survive Shadow Weaver's machinations and the two cities were working together well.

"Bow, you're the best!" She positively had stars in her eyes as she looked between him and the doughnut that he had given her. It was glazed with pink icing and sprinkles and filled with custard. It was exactly the opposite of what she would have grown up eating.

"Well, you're the best ambassador I've ever met so it's fair." His words were kind but they were also true. The woman may sometimes appear bumbling on the outside but she was shrewd and efficient at her job and always well prepared. She was also exceedingly calm and patient which made her exceptionally good at acting as prison warden. Not to mention that being based here meant that she and Perfuma were able to spend a lot more time here as the Princess came and went.

"You can go on through, let me just hit the switch and I'll walk you through so you can keep holding the tray." She hit two switches on her desk and made her way around to join him. It was always a little humbling to realise just how big the woman was.

The two of them walked through the first of the magnetised doors that Scorpia had disengaged. When they reached the second she removed the keys from around her neck and opened the series of locks on the door. She grasped the large hand and pulled it open. There was a whooshing down as the locks disengaged and she drew the thick slab towards herself. Bow thanked her with another smile and walked into the suit of rooms that were now a prison cell.

He heard the door close and be relocked behind him, but he had eyes only for the woman who was walking across the room towards him with a smile on her own face. She took the tray from him as they exchanged a quick kiss. As usual he did a visual inventory of the room, noticing that she had moved the sofa and

the bookcases into a spot looking out of the window. Everything else seemed to be in place. He scanned each of the windows visible from his spot and saw that the glass was in tact and the bars that covered them were undisturbed. With the wards that Castaspella and Micah had put in place over the room the chances of four foot nothing Glimmer getting out were slim.

Bow was permitted to visit his wife three times a week. The days were never the same, nor were the times. It wasn't intended to torture the imprisonment but simple to try to keep her a little more on her toes.

Glimmer walked over to him and grasped his hands, pulling him towards her new seating area where they sat down together. She snuggled into his arms, basking in his presence as they both looked out at the beautiful view of the woods. He settled his arm across her shoulders and grasped her arm with his hand. He wondered how had missed her falling weight and preoccupation before everything had gone wrong. He had known that she had a thirst for revenge against Catra but he had failed to see how bad things really were.

Glimmer was still in a bad place about all of that. Even though she was willing to accept that Shadow Weaver had been stringing her along and was, in fact, the one who had attacked them, her inability to recognise that Catra and Hordak had played no part in it was frustrating. When Queen Angella had asked that they be permitted to incarcerate her daughter, there had been strict parameters placed on it. One was that she be guarded by an outsider, hence Scorpia's presence, another was that they actually create a prison with bolts on the doors, bars at the windows and wards against Glimmer's magic. The most important criteria and one that was entirely negotiable, was that Glimmer needed to see a therapist. They had give Brightmoon one year to get the young woman to accept it or she would be taken back to Oasis. Queen Angella had all too readily agreed. Entrapta had devised a device that would shield the Moonstone from Glimmer's use as a secondary protective measure.

It had taken almost nine months to convince the woman in his arms to agree to talk to the councillor that they had found in Mysticore. They would come down from the clouds three times a week and meet privately in the cell. She did seem a lot more relaxed since. Whether she would ever be permitted to leave this room was a different story but one to think about way further down the line.

Bow turned and placed a kiss on pink hair as he began to tell Glimmer about his last few days, filling in the gaps that she missed.

In another cell, hundred of miles away, another woman languished in a prison cell. This room was a simple round space with a ten metre circumference. There were no corners for secret shadows to dwell in. The walls were sheer and seamless affording no chance of contraband being stowed away and the bed, sink, toilet and desk were all equally seamless extensions of the wall. It was almost as though the entire room had been forged in one giant piece and set in place.

Shadow Weaver paced her cell like a caged animal, her clothes were in the one drawer she was afforded, she needed no more than that as all she wore here were plain brown overalls. There was no patten or artifice. Her face was bared, her mask had been confiscated along with her robes. They had literally stripped her of everything. There were always two guards on her room, one of them always a magicat. One quarter of the circular room was glass, with the door set into it. It was far to thick to crack, that much had been obvious when she had been walked in here. The guards stood on either side of this area with their backs to her. It felt more insulting than if they had been scrutinising her every move.

Further out there was a desk with another prison guard. None of the three guards in this section changed their shift at the same time, they were staggered to ensure that she was always as trapped as could be. She may have hated the foolish ninnies who ran around Brightmoon, but they had known how to treat her with

respect. Here she was viewed as nothing. She had already spent almost a year in this cage and was yet to even be let outside. It gave her some solace to. Realise that she was feared.

As she did every day, she focused her energy and tried to make any magic jump to her fingertips. And, just like every day she felt absolutely nothing. She looked through the glass and saw the clock out there proclaiming that it was lunch time. She knew that she was not the only person in this prison, she had overheard enough to know that minor misdemeanours were punished by community service but any violence or breach of the peace resulted in a brief period of incarceration. It meant that there was a kitchen in the building and that the food was passably good. It also meant that were she to ever get a whiff of her power back she would have a group of people ready to brainwash.

Creaking signalled that the heavy door around the corner had been opened. The squeaking of the trolley that brought the food getting closer and closer. She hated to admit that her mouth began to water. There was so little to look forward to here that food had started to become that one bright spot. They let her have books, pen and paper and occasionally there was music piped in but mostly there was just waiting for her next meal.

She went to sit at her desk on the chair that was also growing out of the floor and waited. She knew the drill by now. While making sure that her desk was free of anything else she absently noticed that the guards, a large ginger magicat and an equally heft lizard, drew themselves up taller. That was unusual.

“At ease you two.” The sound of that voice grated through her nerves and her hunger evaporated in an instant replaced with the taste of bile on her tongue.

Catra handed the food tray to Deban and watched as she punched a series of keys on the wall, causing an unnoticeable hatch in the glass to open revealing a small drawer that she slid the tray into before moving her red furred hand back over the buttons sealing it again. Without meaning to Shadow Weaver stood up and

walked to the drawer, pulling open the lid and removing the food. Not want to seem weak, she placed the tray on the table and began to eat as though the other magicat were not there. She would not acknowledge her even if she had to choke on her food to do it.

"How are you enjoying your stay Shadow Weaver?" Catra's voice had that smug cast to it that she would use as a child when she was trying to prove that she was worth something. It irked her then and it irked her now. She refused to respond.

Every now and again Catra would come by, it had only happened a handful of times in the preceding year and she never gave her the pleasure of hearing her speak. She wasn't even sure if the girl was here for anything more than to revel in her victory. Well, let her revel for now. This was simply another set back and if there was one thing that Shadow Weaver knew about herself, it was that she could always start again.

What a week! Catra lowered herself down onto the wide step of the council building, grateful to be off of her feel and have something at her back to lean on. The week had started with Yarsha's first day of school and become more chaotic from there. Visiting Shadow Weaver had been a double edged idea; seeing the older woman in a cage always brought a sense of relief to her, knowing that she was being treated as she should be. On the other hand was the fact that the woman seemed hardly broken by her incarceration. The room was pristine, she ate the food and there was no attempt to keep track of the days.

Then, as though there were some rule that things could not be peaceful for too long, there had been a small brawl this morning between a group of younger magicats. Thankfully she had gone through this enough to know that this was just a part of puberty where they became more aggressive as they grew into themselves. It was simply an issue that so many were hitting that age all at once. It would pass almost as soon as it arrived but in

the mean time it made for a lot of paperwork and a few overnight stays in the cells at the prison until peoples blood stopped boiling.

She leaned back with her elbows on the step behind and tilted her head up to the sun with her eyes closed as she enjoyed the touch of it on her face. Tace used to tease her that she was the only person in the desert who liked to feel hotter. She would say something lewd back and they would usually end up entwined together, but her wife had been right. She had spent so long cold and wet as she grew up that she was just happy to be warm.

As her mind was drifting, a shadow fell over her blocking the sun and she opened her eyes, smiling up at the person that was standing there. Adora smiled back as she held out a brown bag. Catra nodded approvingly and gestured to the stair next to her. Adora lowered herself and reached in to the bag to pull out her own lunch before handing the sack over to Catra for her own.

They ate in silence for a while, both just savouring the food. This had become something of a routine for the two of them. They would meet on the stairs of the council chamber a couple of times a week and just chew the fat. They weren't close like they had been as kids, that would take longer, but they were definitely friends again. Catra was thankful that Adora had never brought up the kiss of life after that day. The blond hadn't moved on from her crush but it at least made her more bearable.

"Hey, I haven't seen you since Yarsha started school. How is the cutest kitten on Etheria?" And that was another thing, Yarsha was no longer the only kitten on Etheria. In the last year half a dozen adorable balls of fur had been born. Each one had been celebrated like the miracles that they were.

"First day was a bit rocky, there were tears." She saw Adora smirk and push her hair behind her ear, the new hair style suited her. "No, I did not cry. I am the magicat chief and I do not cry because my child has to go to school. I did go to see Tace though." That was something else that had changed between them, Catra talked about her wife a lot more freely and Adora felt like she almost

knew the woman. She wished she had met her, she sounded liked an amazing person.

They talked back and forth about work, Yarsha and their friends. Adora gave her an update from Brightmoon that she had received that morning and she filled the human in on her trip to see Shadow Weaver. It was nice. It was comfortable.

One day Adora might even get up the courage to ask Catra on a date. Not today. Today they were just two women who had grown apart learning how to be friends again. One day they might be more.

Chapter End Notes

> This started life as a 10 chapter catradora fic and somewhere it evolved into this. I, and I think a lot of you, fell in love with Tace and I just couldn't end it with Adora and Catra riding off into the sunset.
>
> Thank you all for reading. I have a lot more new stuff lined up for 2022!
>
> HAPPY NEW YEAR!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!